Learning to Lens

An Introduction to General Relativity and Strong Gravitational Lensing

with Mathematica

Based on the published works of

P. Schneider, J. Ehlers & E. E. Falco, *Gravitational Lenses* (1992)
R. Narayan & M. Bartelmann, *Lectures on Gravitational Lensing* (1997)
A. O. Petters, H. Levine & J. Wambsganss, *Singularity Theory and Gravitational Lensing* (2001)
S. Carroll, *Spacetime and Geometry* (2004)
A. B. Congdon & C. R. Keeton, *Principles of Gravitational Lensing* (2018)
M. Meneghetti, *Introduction to Gravitational Lensing* (2021)
P. Saha, D. Sluse, J. Wagner & L. L. R. Williams, *Essentials of Strong Gravitational Lensing* (2024)
P. Schneider, C. S. Kochanek & J. Wambsganss, *Gravitational Lensing: Strong, Weak and Micro* (2006)

Rodrigo Córdova Rosado
Harvard-Smithsonian Center for Astrophysics
rodrigo.cordova_rosado@cfa.harvard.edu

with

Claude (Anthropic)
via Claude Code

October 22, 2026

About This Document

This tutorial suite was produced by **Rodrigo Córdova Rosado** (Harvard–Smithsonian Center for Astrophysics) with the assistance of **Claude** (Anthropic), an AI language model, via **Claude Code** — Anthropic's command-line tool for collaborative software engineering and technical writing.

The physics content in these notes draws from the following published textbooks and review articles:

- S. Carroll, *Spacetime and Geometry: An Introduction to General Relativity* (Addison Wesley, 2004)
- A. B. Congdon & C. R. Keeton, *Principles of Gravitational Lensing* (Springer, 2018)
- R. Narayan & M. Bartelmann, *Lectures on Gravitational Lensing* (1997; arXiv:astro-ph/9606001)
- P. Saha, D. Sluse, J. Wagner & L. L. R. Williams, *Essentials of Strong Gravitational Lensing*, Space Science Reviews **220**, 12 (2024)
- M. Meneghetti, *Introduction to Gravitational Lensing: With Python Examples* (Springer, 2021)
- P. Schneider, J. Ehlers & E. E. Falco, *Gravitational Lenses* (Springer, 1992)
- A. O. Petters, H. Levine & J. Wambsganss, *Singularity Theory and Gravitational Lensing* (Birkhäuser, 2001)
- P. Schneider, C. S. Kochanek & J. Wambsganss, *Gravitational Lensing: Strong, Weak and Micro*, Saas-Fee Advanced Course 33 (Springer, 2006)

Full bibliographic details for these and all works cited in the text appear in the **References** at the end of this document.

The workflow was as follows: the author directed Claude to co-write the LaTeX lecture notes, Wolfram Mathematica scripts, and interactive notebooks, drawing on the reference texts above. Claude drafted the text and code; the author reviewed, revised, and approved all content.

Importantly, all mathematical derivations and symbolic results in these notes have been verified deterministically using Wolfram Mathematica's computer algebra system — not generated probabilistically by an LLM. Every equation, identity, and worked solution was checked by running the companion `.wl` scripts (via `wolframscript`), which perform exact symbolic computation. The Mathematica verification outputs are reproducible and accompany each module in the repository.

The AI assistant was used for:

- Drafting expository prose and pedagogical explanations
- Structuring the curriculum and organizing modules
- Writing Mathematica code (subsequently executed and verified)
- Formatting LaTeX and managing cross-references

The AI assistant was **not** used as a source of mathematical truth. All physics content derives from the published works listed above, and all symbolic computations are verified by Mathematica.

This is a **living document**. Additional details, examples, and lessons will be added over time as the author continues to learn and teach this material. The most current version is always available at: https://github.com/rodelcr/Learning_to_Lens

Contents

Notation Guide **27**

I General Relativity Foundations 29

1 Special Relativity and Tensor Basics 30
1.1 From Newton to Einstein . . . 30
1.2 Spacetime and the Invariant Interval . . . 31
1.3 Index Notation and the Minkowski Metric . . . 32
1.4 Lorentz Transformations . . . 32
1.4.1 Rotations . . . 33
1.4.2 Boosts . . . 33
1.4.3 Physical Consequences . . . 34
1.5 Four-Vectors . . . 35
1.6 Dual Vectors (One-Forms) . . . 36
1.7 Tensors . . . 36
1.7.1 Important Operations . . . 36
1.7.2 Key Tensors in Minkowski Space . . . 36
1.8 The Metric as the Central Object . . . 37
1.9 Energy and Momentum in SR . . . 37
1.10 Summary . . . 37
1.11 Problems . . . 37

2 Differential Geometry and the Metric Tensor 39
2.1 Manifolds and Coordinate Charts . . . 39
2.2 The General Metric Tensor . . . 40
2.3 Vectors and Tensors on Manifolds . . . 40
2.4 The Covariant Derivative . . . 41
2.5 Christoffel Symbols . . . 41
2.6 Parallel Transport . . . 41
2.7 The Geodesic Equation . . . 42
2.8 Curvature Tensors . . . 43
2.9 The Metric Determines Everything . . . 44
2.10 Computation Cookbook: A Step-by-Step Guide . . . 44
2.10.1 Algorithm: Christoffel Symbols from a Metric . . . 45

2.10.2 Algorithm: The Riemann Tensor from Christoffel Symbols 45
2.10.3 Algorithm: Ricci Tensor and Ricci Scalar 46
2.10.4 Worked Example: The 2-Sphere 46
2.10.5 Tips and Tricks 48
2.11 Standard Computational Tools 48
2.12 Summary 49
2.13 Problems 49

3 The Schwarzschild Solution **51**
3.1 The Equivalence Principle 51
3.1.1 The Weak Equivalence Principle 51
3.1.2 Einstein's Elevator 52
3.1.3 The Strong Equivalence Principle 52
3.1.4 From the Equivalence Principle to Geodesics 53
3.2 The Most General Spherically Symmetric Metric 53
3.3 Deriving the Schwarzschild Metric 53
3.4 Birkhoff's Theorem 55
3.5 Gravitational Time Dilation 55
3.6 Gravitational Redshift 56
3.7 The Event Horizon and Singularities 56
3.8 Inside the Event Horizon: The Coordinate Swap 57
3.8.1 The Signature Flip 57
3.8.2 Physical Meaning: The Singularity Is a Moment in Time 57
3.8.3 Why Nothing Escapes: Tilting Light Cones 58
3.8.4 Eddington–Finkelstein Coordinates 58
3.8.5 Relevance to Gravitational Lensing 58
3.9 The Weak-Field Limit 59
3.10 Isotropic Coordinates 59
3.10.1 The Isotropic Radial Coordinate 59
3.10.2 The Schwarzschild Metric in Isotropic Form 59
3.10.3 Weak-Field Expansion 60
3.10.4 Connection to the Linearized Gravity Formalism 60
3.11 Schwarzschild Radius for Astrophysical Objects 60
3.12 Embedding Diagram: Flamm's Paraboloid 61
3.13 Summary 61
3.14 Problems 62

4 Geodesics and Orbits in Schwarzschild Spacetime **63**
4.1 Killing Vectors and Conservation Laws 63
4.2 The Effective Potential 64
4.3 Circular Orbits and the ISCO 65
4.4 The Photon Sphere 66
4.5 Effective Potential: Newtonian vs. GR 66
4.6 Perihelion Precession 66
4.7 Null Geodesics and the Deflection of Light (Preview) 67

4.8 Brief Overview: The Kerr Metric . . . 68
4.9 Summary . . . 69
4.10 Problems . . . 69

5 Linearized Gravity and the Weak-Field Metric 71
5.1 Introduction: Why Linearize? . . . 72
5.2 The Weak-Field Expansion . . . 72
5.3 The Newtonian Limit . . . 72
5.3.1 Assumptions . . . 73
5.3.2 Derivation . . . 73
5.3.3 Identification with Newtonian Gravity . . . 73
5.4 The Weak-Field Metric . . . 74
5.5 Null Geodesics in the Weak-Field Metric . . . 75
5.5.1 Setup . . . 75
5.5.2 The Null Condition . . . 75
5.5.3 Deflection Angle . . . 75
5.5.4 Point Mass Deflection . . . 76
5.5.5 The Factor of Two . . . 76
5.6 The Effective Refractive Index . . . 77
5.7 Superposition in Linearized Gravity . . . 79
5.8 Preview: From Deflection to the Lens Equation . . . 79
5.9 Summary . . . 80
5.10 Problems . . . 81

II Gravitational Lensing Theory 82

6 Light Deflection in Curved Spacetime 83
6.1 Introduction: Null Geodesics and the Deflection Problem . . . 83
6.2 Soldner's Newtonian Calculation (1801) . . . 84
6.3 The GR Deflection Angle — Full Derivation . . . 85
6.3.1 The Impact Parameter . . . 85
6.3.2 Distance of Closest Approach . . . 85
6.3.3 The Total Azimuthal Change . . . 85
6.3.4 Change of Variables . . . 86
6.3.5 Weak-Field Expansion . . . 86
6.3.6 Evaluating the Integrals . . . 86
6.3.7 The Deflection Angle . . . 87
6.4 The Shapiro Time Delay . . . 88
6.4.1 Coordinate Travel Time . . . 88
6.4.2 The Two Components of Time Delay . . . 88
6.5 Deflection by the Sun . . . 89
6.6 Deflection by Galaxies . . . 90
6.7 Exact vs. Weak-Field Deflection . . . 91
6.8 Summary . . . 92

6.9 Problems . . . 92

7 Cosmological Distances **94**
Part A: The FRW Metric and Friedmann Equations . . . 95
7.1 The Cosmological Principle . . . 95
7.2 The Robertson–Walker Metric . . . 95
7.3 Christoffel Symbols for the FRW Metric . . . 96
7.4 Ricci Tensor and Ricci Scalar . . . 97
7.5 Einstein's Equations with a Perfect Fluid . . . 98
7.6 The Friedmann Equations . . . 98
7.6.1 The First Friedmann Equation . . . 98
7.6.2 The Second Friedmann Equation . . . 99
7.6.3 The Fluid Conservation Equation . . . 99
7.7 The Hubble Parameter and Density Parameters . . . 100
7.7.1 The Hubble Parameter . . . 100
7.7.2 Density Parameters . . . 100
7.8 Equations of State and Scale Factor Solutions . . . 101
7.8.1 Matter, Radiation, and Dark Energy . . . 101
7.8.2 Scale Factor Solutions . . . 101
7.9 Redshift and the Scale Factor . . . 102
Part B: Distance Measures for Lensing . . . 102
7.10 Comoving Distance . . . 102
7.11 Angular Diameter Distance . . . 103
7.12 The Angular Diameter Distance Is Not Monotonic . . . 103
7.13 Luminosity Distance . . . 104
7.14 The Lens–Source Angular Diameter Distance . . . 104
7.15 The Distance Ratio for Lensing . . . 106
7.16 Lensing Efficiency . . . 106
7.17 Summary . . . 106
7.18 Problems . . . 107

8 The Gravitational Lens Equation **109**
8.1 Introduction: From Deflection to Imaging . . . 109
8.2 The Thin-Screen Approximation . . . 110
8.3 Lensing Geometry . . . 110
8.4 The Lens Equation . . . 111
8.5 Surface Mass Density and the Deflection Integral . . . 111
8.6 Critical Surface Mass Density . . . 112
8.7 The Einstein Radius . . . 113
8.7.1 The Point Mass Lens Equation . . . 113
8.7.2 The Einstein Ring . . . 114
8.7.3 Numerical Examples . . . 114
8.8 Image Positions for a Point Mass Lens . . . 115
8.8.1 Properties of the Images . . . 115
8.8.2 Limiting Cases . . . 115

8.9 Magnification of a Point Mass Lens . . . 116
8.10 Summary . . . 116
8.11 Problems . . . 117

9 Magnification, Convergence, and Shear **122**
9.1 Introduction: From Image Positions to Image Properties . . . 122
9.2 The Effective Lensing Potential . . . 123
9.2.1 Key Properties of the Lensing Potential . . . 123
9.3 Convergence . . . 124
9.3.1 Physical Meaning . . . 124
9.3.2 Convergence from the Lensing Potential . . . 125
9.4 Shear . . . 125
9.4.1 Physical Meaning . . . 126
9.5 The Jacobian Matrix (Inverse Magnification Tensor) . . . 126
9.5.1 Decomposition of the Jacobian . . . 126
9.5.2 Eigenvalues of the Jacobian . . . 127
9.6 Magnification . . . 127
9.6.1 Properties of the Magnification . . . 127
9.6.2 Magnification in Terms of Eigenvalues . . . 128
9.7 Convergence vs. Shear: Physical Effects . . . 128
9.7.1 Pure Convergence ($\kappa > 0$, $\gamma = 0$) . . . 128
9.7.2 Pure Shear ($\kappa = 0$, $\gamma > 0$) . . . 128
9.7.3 Both Convergence and Shear . . . 129
9.8 Example: Point Mass Lens . . . 129
9.8.1 Lensing Potential for a Point Mass . . . 129
9.8.2 Shear for a Point Mass . . . 130
9.8.3 Convergence for a Point Mass (away from origin) . . . 130
9.8.4 Magnification for a Point Mass . . . 130
9.9 Example: Singular Isothermal Sphere (Preview) . . . 131
9.9.1 Convergence and Shear of the SIS . . . 131
9.9.2 Magnification of the SIS . . . 131
9.10 Critical Curves and Caustics (Preview) . . . 132
9.11 Summary . . . 132
9.12 Problems . . . 133

10 Fermat's Principle and Time Delays **135**
10.1 Introduction: From Geometry to a Variational Principle . . . 135
10.2 The Time Delay Function . . . 136
10.3 Fermat's Principle and the Lens Equation . . . 137
10.4 Classification of Images: Morse Theory . . . 137
10.5 The Arrival-Time Surface . . . 139
10.5.1 Point Mass Lens . . . 139
10.5.2 The Einstein Ring as a Degenerate Minimum . . . 139
10.6 Observable Time Delays . . . 140
10.7 Time Delay and the Hubble Constant . . . 141

10.7.1 Observational Milestones . . . 142
10.8 Example: Point Mass Time Delay . . . 142
10.8.1 Fermat Potential for the Point Mass . . . 142
10.8.2 Time Delay Computation . . . 143
10.9 Example: SIS Time Delay . . . 144
10.10Summary . . . 145
10.11Problems . . . 145

III Lens Models and Applications 147

11 Axisymmetric Lens Models 148
11.1 Introduction: From Formalism to Models . . . 148
11.2 General Formalism for Circularly Symmetric Lenses . . . 149
11.2.1 Deflection Angle from Enclosed Mass . . . 149
11.2.2 Mean Convergence . . . 149
11.2.3 Shear for Circular Symmetry . . . 150
11.2.4 Magnification for Circular Symmetry . . . 150
11.3 Point Mass Lens (Recap) . . . 150
11.4 Singular Isothermal Sphere (SIS) . . . 151
11.4.1 Three-Dimensional Density Profile . . . 151
11.4.2 Surface Mass Density . . . 151
11.4.3 Einstein Radius of the SIS . . . 151
11.4.4 Convergence and Shear of the SIS . . . 152
11.4.5 SIS Lens Equation and Images . . . 153
11.4.6 SIS Magnification . . . 153
11.4.7 Critical Curves and Caustics of the SIS . . . 153
11.5 Nonsingular Isothermal Sphere (NIS) . . . 154
11.5.1 Surface Mass Density . . . 154
11.5.2 Convergence of the NIS . . . 154
11.5.3 Deflection Angle of the NIS . . . 155
11.5.4 Effect of the Core Radius on Image Multiplicity . . . 155
11.6 NFW Profile . . . 156
11.6.1 Three-Dimensional Density Profile . . . 156
11.6.2 NFW Parameters: Concentration and Virial Mass . . . 156
11.6.3 Surface Mass Density of the NFW . . . 157
11.6.4 Convergence of the NFW . . . 158
11.6.5 Deflection Angle and Shear of the NFW . . . 159
11.6.6 Role of Concentration in NFW Lensing . . . 160
11.7 Comparison of Models . . . 160
11.8 Summary . . . 161
11.9 Problems . . . 161

12 Non-Axisymmetric Models and Critical Curves **164**
12.1 Introduction: Why Non-Axisymmetric Models Matter . . . 165
12.2 SIS + External Shear . . . 165
12.2.1 Lensing Potential . . . 165
12.2.2 Deflection Angle . . . 165
12.2.3 Convergence and Shear . . . 166
12.2.4 Critical Curves . . . 166
12.2.5 Caustics: The Diamond (Astroid) . . . 166
12.2.6 Image Configurations . . . 167
12.3 The Singular Isothermal Ellipsoid (SIE) . . . 167
12.3.1 Surface Mass Density . . . 168
12.3.2 Deflection Angle . . . 168
12.3.3 Critical Curves and Caustics of the SIE . . . 170
12.4 The Angular Structure of Lenses: Multipole Expansion . . . 171
12.4.1 The Multipole Series . . . 171
12.4.2 Internal vs. External Multipoles . . . 171
12.4.3 Which Multipoles Matter . . . 172
12.5 Critical Curves . . . 172
12.5.1 Two Families of Critical Curves . . . 172
12.5.2 Critical Curves for Axisymmetric vs. Elliptical Lenses . . . 173
12.5.3 Physical Meaning . . . 173
12.6 Caustics . . . 173
12.6.1 Types of Caustics . . . 173
12.6.2 Caustics for Specific Models . . . 173
12.7 Image Topology . . . 174
12.7.1 Critical Curves as Parity Boundaries . . . 174
12.7.2 Caustic Crossings and Image Creation/Destruction . . . 174
12.7.3 Walking a Source Across Caustics: A Worked Example . . . 175
12.7.4 The Fold and Cusp Catastrophes . . . 176
12.7.5 Image Configuration Taxonomy . . . 178
12.7.6 Why Giant Arcs Form . . . 179
12.8 Image Configurations: Doubles, Quads, and Einstein Crosses . . . 180
12.8.1 Double Configuration . . . 180
12.8.2 Quad / Einstein Cross Configuration . . . 180
12.8.3 Cusp Configuration . . . 181
12.9 Summary . . . 181
12.10Problems . . . 182

13 Strong Lensing by Galaxies: Applications **184**
13.1 Lens Modeling Overview . . . 184
13.1.1 Parametric Models: SIE + External Shear . . . 185
13.1.2 What Data Constrain the Model . . . 185
13.1.3 Degrees of Freedom . . . 185
13.1.4 Free-Form Models . . . 185
13.2 The Einstein Radius as a Mass Estimator . . . 186

13.2.1 The Model-Independent Mass Measurement . . . 186
13.2.2 The SIE Einstein Radius and Velocity Dispersion . . . 186
13.2.3 Numerical Examples with Real Systems . . . 187
13.3 The Mass-Sheet Degeneracy . . . 188
13.3.1 The Mass-Sheet Transform . . . 188
13.3.2 Image Positions Are Invariant . . . 188
13.3.3 What the MST Changes . . . 188
13.3.4 Physical Interpretation . . . 190
13.3.5 How to Break the MSD . . . 190
13.4 The Source Position Transformation . . . 191
13.4.1 Definition . . . 191
13.4.2 Implications . . . 191
13.5 Strong Lensing and Stellar Kinematics . . . 191
13.5.1 What Each Technique Measures . . . 191
13.5.2 The Power-Law Mass Profile . . . 192
13.5.3 Breaking the Degeneracy . . . 193
13.5.4 The Bulge-Halo Conspiracy . . . 193
13.6 Time-Delay Cosmography . . . 194
13.6.1 Recap: Time Delays and H_0 . . . 194
13.6.2 The H0LiCOW / TDCOSMO Program . . . 194
13.6.3 The Role of the Mass-Sheet Degeneracy . . . 195
13.6.4 Current State and Future Prospects . . . 196
13.7 Real Lens Systems: Case Studies . . . 196
13.7.1 Q0957+561: The First Gravitational Lens . . . 196
13.7.2 Q2237+0305: The Einstein Cross . . . 196
13.7.3 B1608+656: Time-Delay Cosmography . . . 196
13.8 Substructure and Flux-Ratio Anomalies . . . 197
13.8.1 The Flux-Ratio Anomaly . . . 197
13.8.2 Why Flux Ratios Probe Low-Mass Substructure . . . 197
13.9 Extended Sources and Einstein-Ring Reconstruction . . . 197
13.9.1 The Einstein Ring as a Pattern . . . 198
13.9.2 Source Reconstruction . . . 198
13.10 External Convergence and Lens Environments . . . 198
13.10.1 Dust and the Interstellar Medium of the Lens . . . 199
13.11 Summary . . . 199
13.12 Problems . . . 199

14 Strong Lensing by Galaxy Clusters 202
14.1 Introduction: Why Cluster Lensing Is Special . . . 202
14.2 NFW Model for Cluster Lensing . . . 203
14.2.1 Cluster-Scale NFW Parameters . . . 203
14.2.2 Lensing Quantities at Cluster Scale . . . 203
14.2.3 Critical Curves and Caustics for Cluster NFW . . . 204
14.2.4 Einstein Radius Scaling with Cluster Mass . . . 205
14.3 Giant Arcs . . . 205

14.3.1 Formation Mechanism . . . 205
14.3.2 Ray-Tracing Through a Cluster Potential . . . 206
14.3.3 Length-to-Width Ratio . . . 206
14.3.4 Arc Statistics . . . 206
14.4 Multiple Image Systems in Clusters . . . 207
14.4.1 Image Families . . . 207
14.4.2 Spectroscopic Confirmation . . . 207
14.4.3 Famous Cluster Lenses . . . 207
14.5 Cluster Mass Estimation . . . 207
14.5.1 Strong Lensing Mass Estimates . . . 208
14.5.2 Weak Lensing Mass Estimates (Preview) . . . 208
14.5.3 Combining Strong and Weak Lensing . . . 208
14.5.4 Comparison with Other Mass Estimators . . . 208
14.6 Magnification and the Cosmic Telescope . . . 209
14.6.1 Magnification by Clusters . . . 209
14.6.2 Magnification Bias . . . 209
14.6.3 The Hubble Frontier Fields . . . 209
14.6.4 JWST and the New Era of Cluster Lensing . . . 210
14.7 Brief Introduction to Weak Lensing . . . 210
14.7.1 The Weak Lensing Regime . . . 211
14.7.2 The Reduced Shear . . . 211
14.7.3 Tangential Shear Profile Around Clusters . . . 211
14.7.4 From Clusters to Cosmic Shear . . . 212
14.8 The State of the Field and Future Directions . . . 212
14.8.1 Current Observational Facilities . . . 212
14.8.2 Future Facilities . . . 212
14.8.3 Open Questions . . . 213
14.8.4 Connection to the AGEL Project . . . 213
14.9 Summary . . . 213
14.10Problems . . . 214

IV Statistical, Weak, and Micro Lensing 218

15 Lensing Statistics and Cross-Sections 219
15.1 Lensing Cross-Sections . . . 219
15.1.1 The Point-Mass Lens . . . 220
15.1.2 The Singular Isothermal Sphere . . . 220
15.2 Optical Depth . . . 221
15.3 Magnification Bias . . . 221
15.4 Summary . . . 222
15.5 Problems . . . 222

16 Weak Gravitational Lensing and Cosmic Shear **224**
16.1 Introduction: The Weak Regime . . . 225
16.2 Galaxy Shapes and the Shear Estimator . . . 225
16.2.1 Complex Ellipticity . . . 225
16.2.2 From Source to Image, and the Estimator . . . 226
16.3 Tangential and Cross Shear . . . 227
16.3.1 Definitions . . . 227
16.3.2 Mean Tangential Shear and the Projected Mass . . . 227
16.4 Reduced Shear and the Mass-Sheet Degeneracy . . . 228
16.5 Cluster Mass Reconstruction . . . 228
16.5.1 The Kaiser–Squires Inversion . . . 228
16.5.2 Aperture Mass . . . 229
16.6 Cosmic Shear: Lensing by the Large-Scale Structure . . . 230
16.6.1 The Effective Convergence . . . 230
16.6.2 The Convergence Power Spectrum . . . 231
16.6.3 Two-Point Statistics . . . 231
16.7 Galaxy–Galaxy Lensing . . . 232
16.8 Summary . . . 232
16.9 Problems . . . 233

17 Gravitational Microlensing **235**
17.1 The Microlensing Regime . . . 236
17.2 Point-Lens Magnification . . . 236
17.2.1 Magnification of Each Image . . . 236
17.2.2 Total Magnification . . . 237
17.3 The Light Curve and the Einstein Timescale . . . 237
17.3.1 The Paczyński Curve . . . 238
17.4 Optical Depth to Microlensing . . . 239
17.4.1 The Dark-Matter Test Toward the Magellanic Clouds . . . 239
17.4.2 Toward the Galactic Bulge . . . 240
17.5 Binary and Planetary Microlensing . . . 240
17.5.1 Caustic Crossings . . . 240
17.5.2 Detecting Planets . . . 241
17.6 Astrometric Microlensing . . . 241
17.7 Quasar Microlensing . . . 242
17.8 Summary . . . 243
17.9 Problems . . . 243

V Compound Lenses, Degeneracies, and Cosmography **246**

18 The Multi-Plane Lens Equation and Double-Source-Plane Lenses **247**
18.1 Why a Double Source Plane Is a Cosmological Ruler . . . 247
18.2 Recap: The Single-Plane Lens Equation and Its Distances . . . 248
18.3 The Multi-Plane Lens Equation . . . 249

18.3.1 Statement . . . 249
18.3.2 Derivation from straight-line propagation . . . 249
18.3.3 The Congdon–Keeton form and the factors β_{ij} . . . 249
18.3.4 Lens–lens coupling . . . 250
18.3.5 Two limits every implementation should pass . . . 250
18.4 One Deflector, Two Source Planes . . . 250
18.5 When the Near Source Has Mass: Coupling in a DSPL . . . 251
18.6 From Deflections to Einstein Radii: $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$ . . . 252
18.7 The Cosmological Content of $\mathcal{B}$ . . . 252
18.7.1 $\mathcal{B}$ is independent of H_0 . . . 252
18.7.2 Sensitivity to w and $\Omega_{\rm m}$ . . . 253
18.8 The Isothermal Ellipsoid . . . 253
18.9 What a DSPL Fit Samples . . . 255
18.10The $\mathcal{B}$–γ' Degeneracy . . . 256
18.11The Circularity Trap . . . 257
18.12Summary . . . 257
18.13Problems . . . 258

19 Power-Law Lenses with a Central Point Mass 260
19.1 The Circular Toolbox, Revisited . . . 261
19.2 The Power-Law Lens . . . 262
19.2.1 Convergence and deflection . . . 262
19.2.2 Critical curves of the power law . . . 263
19.2.3 Reading the source-plane map . . . 263
19.3 The Point Mass . . . 263
19.4 Power Law plus Point Mass . . . 264
19.4.1 Where the point mass acts . . . 264
19.4.2 The stationary point and the critical mass fraction . . . 265
19.4.3 Caustics and image counts . . . 266
19.4.4 The tangential critical curve . . . 266
19.5 The Singular Isothermal Sphere plus a Point Mass . . . 266
19.6 Broken Power Laws . . . 267
19.6.1 Definition and slope convention . . . 267
19.6.2 Deflection in closed form . . . 268
19.6.3 The point mass as the corner $t_1 \to 2$ . . . 268
19.6.4 Outside the break: a power law plus an effective point mass . . . 268
19.6.5 Inside the break: a resolved break is necessary, not sufficient . . . 269
19.7 Summary . . . 270
19.8 Problems . . . 271

20 Odd Images, Central Images, and Their Suppression 273
20.1 The Arrival-Time Surface, Revisited . . . 274
20.1.1 Where can a maximum sit? . . . 274
20.1.2 The one-dimensional cut . . . 274
20.2 Counting Images with the Index Theorem . . . 275

20.2.1 What the hypotheses exclude . . . 276
20.3 The Central Image of a Cored Lens . . . 277
20.3.1 Three images, at most . . . 277
20.3.2 How faint is the central image? . . . 278
20.4 Steep Cusps Suppress the Central Image . . . 280
20.5 A Central Point Mass Punctures the Surface . . . 280
20.5.1 The bare point mass: exactly two images . . . 280
20.5.2 A point mass inside a cored lens . . . 281
20.5.3 The critical black-hole mass . . . 282
20.6 A Degeneracy: Inner Slope versus Central Mass . . . 283
20.7 Summary . . . 283
20.8 Problems . . . 284

21 How an Unmodelled Central Mass Biases a Compound Lens 286
21.1 A Power Law with a Central Point Mass, Seen from Two Source Planes . . . 287
21.2 What "the Einstein Radius" Means When a Central Mass Is Present . . . 288
21.3 The Central Mass Is a Different Perturbation on Each Plane . . . 289
21.4 Two Channels for the Bias in $\mathcal{B}$ . . . 290
21.4.1 A fixed-slope, on-ring estimate . . . 290
21.5 Linear Response: the Bias of a Fit That Cannot Represent the Truth . . . 291
21.5.1 Worked example: exact fit versus linear response . . . 292
21.6 When the Central Mass Destroys the Radial Image . . . 292
21.7 Hidden and Detected Central Masses . . . 295
21.8 From a Bias in $\mathcal{B}$ to a Bias in w . . . 296
21.9 Summary . . . 297
21.10Problems . . . 297

22 The Mass-Sheet Degeneracy in Multi-Plane Lenses and Kinematic Breaking 299
22.1 The Mass-Sheet Transformation in Three Lines . . . 299
22.1.1 Two explicit examples . . . 300
22.2 What the Sheet Is: External, Internal, and the SPT . . . 300
22.3 One Deflector, Two Source Planes . . . 301
22.3.1 Known distances: the second plane breaks the MST . . . 302
22.3.2 Free distance ratio: the second plane does not . . . 302
22.3.3 How the MST reaches a power-law distance ratio . . . 303
22.3.4 When the nearer source has mass: two lens planes . . . 303
22.4 The Power-Law Slope as a Local MST . . . 304
22.5 Breaking the MST with Stellar Kinematics . . . 304
22.5.1 The isothermal case, exactly . . . 305
22.5.2 Power-law mass, power-law tracer: the spherical Jeans equation . . . 305
22.5.3 The systematics that come with σ . . . 306
22.5.4 Two internal directions: a core and a central point mass . . . 307
22.6 Summary . . . 307
22.7 Problems . . . 307

23 Azimuthal Multipoles and the Central-Mass Confusion **309**
23.1 Notation and Set-up . . . 310
23.2 The Multipole Expansion of the Convergence . . . 310
23.2.1 The power-law base . . . 310
23.2.2 A single multipole on the power-law base . . . 310
23.3 Potential and Deflection in Closed Form . . . 311
23.3.1 Solving the Poisson equation mode by mode . . . 311
23.3.2 The isothermal limit and Chapter 12 . . . 311
23.3.3 A radius-independent perturbation . . . 312
23.4 Amplitude Bookkeeping . . . 312
23.4.1 The convention trap: k_m is not a_m . . . 312
23.4.2 From fractional amplitude to isophotal deviation . . . 312
23.5 The Structural Fact: a Multipole Encloses No Mass . . . 313
23.6 Degenerate in the Likelihood, not in κ . . . 314
23.7 Response of the Tangential Critical Curve . . . 314
23.8 The Residual Diagnostic: Inner versus Outer . . . 315
23.8.1 The central point mass . . . 316
23.8.2 The multipole . . . 316
23.8.3 A worked comparison . . . 316
23.9 The Dipole Resonance . . . 318
23.10Summary . . . 318
23.11Problems . . . 319

24 Cosmological Sensitivity of Compound-Lens Ratios **320**
24.1 Why a Scalar Is Not Enough . . . 321
24.2 The Ratio $\mathcal{B}$ in a Dark-Energy Cosmology . . . 321
24.2.1 The CPL equation of state . . . 321
24.2.2 $\mathcal{B}$ is a ratio of comoving distances . . . 322
24.3 The Sensitivity Jacobian . . . 322
24.3.1 Definition . . . 322
24.3.2 Two ways to compute it . . . 323
24.3.3 An illustrative geometry . . . 323
24.4 From a Model Error to a Parameter Displacement . . . 323
24.5 One Source-Plane Pair: The Answer Is a Direction . . . 324
24.5.1 Rank and the blind direction . . . 324
24.5.2 The bias ray . . . 325
24.5.3 Is the fixed-$\Omega_{\rm m}$ number a bound? . . . 325
24.5.4 Linear is only linear . . . 326
24.5.5 Raising the rank . . . 326
24.6 Many Planes: Coherence, Not Averaging . . . 327
24.6.1 The rows of J are nearly parallel . . . 327
24.6.2 The model error is one error . . . 328
24.6.3 Why coherent errors do not average as $1/\sqrt{n}$ . . . 328
24.7 Degeneracy Versus Bias . . . 329
24.7.1 Three things an analyst can do with the radial image . . . 329

24.7.2 Masking surrenders a constraint . . . 329
24.7.3 The model manifold is thin . . . 330
24.8 A Practical Recipe . . . 330
24.9 Summary . . . 331
24.10Problems . . . 331

25 First-Order Estimators and Multi-Plane Coherence 333
25.1 The General Idea: Bias as Linear Response . . . 334
25.2 Worked Example: A Power Law with a Hidden Central Mass . . . 334
25.2.1 The lens . . . 334
25.2.2 Image configuration . . . 335
25.2.3 First-order image positions . . . 335
25.3 Residuals and the Least-Squares Fit . . . 336
25.3.1 The first-order residual . . . 336
25.3.2 Which χ^2? Source plane versus image plane . . . 336
25.3.3 The normal equations and the response coefficient . . . 336
25.4 The Radial Image's Leverage . . . 337
25.4.1 The tangential pair alone measures enclosed mass . . . 337
25.4.2 Why the radial image dominates . . . 337
25.4.3 The exact closed form for the canonical triple . . . 338
25.4.4 How good is the asymptote? . . . 338
25.4.5 Beyond the canonical triple . . . 340
25.5 Freeing the Slope: Where the Leverage Goes . . . 341
25.6 Two Source Planes: Bias of the Distance Ratio . . . 341
25.6.1 Setup . . . 341
25.6.2 The bias . . . 342
25.6.3 The sign change . . . 342
25.7 Multi-Plane Coherence . . . 343
25.8 The Consequence: Significance, Not Amplitude . . . 343
25.9 When the Linear Estimate Fails . . . 344
25.10Summary . . . 344
25.11Problems . . . 345

References 347

List of Figures

1.1 Spacetime diagram in 1+1 dimensions showing the light cone structure. The shaded (blue) region is timelike; the dashed orange lines are the light cone (null); the unshaded region is spacelike. The blue arrow is the worldline of a stationary particle; the red arrow is a particle moving at $v = 0.6c$. (cf. Carroll Fig. 1.5) 31

1.2 A Lorentz boost with $v = 0.5c$ tilts both the time axis (t', red) and the space axis (x', dark red) toward the light cone. The light cone itself (orange dashed) is invariant under boosts. (cf. Carroll Fig. 1.7) 34

1.3 The Lorentz factor $\gamma = (1 - v^2/c^2)^{-1/2}$ as a function of velocity. Time dilation and length contraction both scale with γ. Note the dramatic increase as $v \to c$. 35

2.1 Parallel transport on the 2-sphere. A vector (blue) initially pointing east at the equator is transported north to the pole along $\phi = 0$, then south along $\phi = 60$ back to the equator. The final vector (green) has rotated by $\alpha = 60$ — equal to the solid angle enclosed by the path. This rotation is a direct manifestation of curvature. (cf. Carroll Fig. 3.2) 42

2.2 Geodesics on the 2-sphere are great circles. Three orthogonal great circles are shown, illustrating that the shortest path between any two points on a sphere follows a great circle arc. 43

3.1 Gravitational time dilation factor $d\tau/dt = \sqrt{1 - R_S/r}$ as a function of r/R_S. Clocks near the horizon ($r \to R_S$) are dramatically slowed. Far from the mass ($r \gg R_S$), the factor approaches unity (flat spacetime). 55

3.2 Gravitational redshift z_{grav} as a function of emission radius r/R_S. The redshift diverges at the horizon. The black dot marks a typical neutron star ($r/R_S \approx 2.4$, $z \approx 0.3$). For the Sun, $z \approx 2.1 \times 10^{-6}$. 56

3.3 Flamm's paraboloid: the equatorial spatial geometry of the Schwarzschild spacetime embedded in 3D Euclidean space. The throat at $r = R_S$ represents the event horizon. The surface curves more steeply near the throat, visualizing the spatial curvature caused by gravity. An interactive version is in `gravitational_redshift.nb`. 61

4.1 Comparison of Newtonian (dashed) and GR (solid) effective potentials for a massive particle with $L = 4\,GM/c$. The GR correction term $\propto 1/r^3$ pulls the potential down at small r, allowing particles to plunge past the centrifugal barrier. (cf. Carroll Figs. 5.4 and 5.5) 65

4.2 GR effective potentials for several values of angular momentum L (in GM/c units). **Left:** For massive particles, the red dashed curve shows $L = L_{\rm ISCO} = 2\sqrt{3}\,GM/c$, where the stable and unstable circular orbits merge. **Right:** For photons, the potential always has a maximum at $r = 3GM/c^2$ (the photon sphere). Interactive versions in `effective_potential.nb`. 67

4.3 A precessing orbit in Schwarzschild spacetime, computed by numerically integrating the orbit equation for $L = 4.2\,GM/c$ with perihelion at $r \approx 13.6\,GM/c^2$. This is a strong-field orbit: the perihelion advances by ≈ 2.07 rad (119°) per radial period, almost twice the weak-field estimate $6\pi GM/(c^2 p) \approx 1.07$ rad for the same semi-latus rectum $p = L^2/GM$, which is why the rosette opens so quickly. (Earlier printings of this caption called the advance "small"; it is not, for this orbit — see Exercise 5(b). cf. Carroll Fig. 5.6.) 68

5.1 Comparison of the exact Schwarzschild deflection angle (solid blue) with the weak-field approximation $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$ (dashed red) as a function of impact parameter b/R_S. The weak-field value falls short of the exact one by a fraction $\approx (15\pi/32)\,R_S/b$ (the second-order term): about 15% at $b = 10\,R_S$, 5% at $30\,R_S$ and 1.5% at $100\,R_S$. The orange dashed line marks the capture impact parameter $b = (3\sqrt{3}/2)\,R_S$. For the Sun, $R_S \approx 3$ km and the closest approach is $R_\odot \approx 7 \times 10^5$ km, so $b/R_S \approx 2.4 \times 10^5$ — deep in the weak-field regime. Interactive version: `deflection_comparison.nb`. (cf. Congdon & Keeton Fig. 3.7) 77

5.2 Effective refractive index $n = 1 + 2|\Phi|/c^2$ as a function of distance from a point mass, plotted for a solar-mass object. The refractive index is largest (light is slowest) at the surface of the mass and approaches unity far away. 78

5.3 Fractional error $|\hat{\alpha}_{\rm exact} - \hat{\alpha}_{\rm weak}|/\hat{\alpha}_{\rm exact}$ of the weak-field approximation as a function of b/R_S. The error is $\approx (15\pi/32)\,R_S/b$: below 1% for $b/R_S \gtrsim 150$ and below 0.1% for $b/R_S \gtrsim 1500$. For typical astrophysical lenses ($b/R_S > 10^4$), the weak-field approximation is essentially exact. 80

6.1 Geometry of gravitational light deflection by a point mass M. A photon approaches from the right with impact parameter b, reaches closest approach at $r_0 \approx b$, and is deflected by $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$. The dashed line shows the undeflected path. Generated by `deflection_angle.wl`. 87

6.2 Deflection angle $\hat{\alpha}$ as a function of impact parameter b for a solar-mass lens, shown in arcseconds. The deflection falls as $1/b$. The vertical dashed line marks the solar radius ($b = R_\odot$) where $\hat{\alpha} = 1.75''$. Generated by `deflection_angle.wl`. 90

6.3 Comparison of the exact deflection angle (solid blue, from numerical integration) and the weak-field approximations $\hat{\alpha} = 4m/b$ (dashed red, first order) and including the second-order correction (dot-dashed green), as a function of $b/R_{\rm S}$. The lower panel shows the relative error. The first-order approximation has $\sim 15\%$ error at $b = 10\,R_{\rm S}$ and reaches 1% accuracy only for $b \gtrsim 150\,R_{\rm S}$. At the photon sphere $b = 3\sqrt{3}\,R_{\rm S}/2$, the exact deflection diverges (the photon orbits the mass). Generated by `deflection_angle.wl`. 91

7.1 Angular diameter distance $D_A(z)$ for the concordance cosmology ($\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.7$, $H_0 = 70$ km s^{-1} Mpc^{-1}). D_A reaches a maximum of approximately 1748 Mpc at $z \approx 1.6$ and then decreases. This turnover is a key consequence of the expanding universe and has no analogue in Euclidean geometry. Generated by `friedmann_equations.wl`. 104

7.2 Comoving distance $\chi(z)$ (blue), angular diameter distance $D_A(z)$ (red), and luminosity distance $D_L(z)$ (green) for the concordance cosmology. At low redshift ($z \ll 1$) all three converge: $\chi \approx D_A \approx D_L \approx cz/H_0$. At high redshift they diverge dramatically. The turnover of D_A is clearly visible, while D_L grows monotonically. Generated by `friedmann_equations.wl`. 105

7.3 Lensing efficiency $D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}$ as a function of lens redshift z_d for several source redshifts $z_s = 1, 2, 3$ in the concordance cosmology. For $z_s = 1$, lensing is most efficient at $z_d \approx 0.35$; for $z_s = 2$, at $z_d \approx 0.5$. The peak lies somewhat closer to the observer than the comoving midpoint ($\chi_d \approx 0.42\,\chi_s$ for $z_s = 1$). Generated by `friedmann_equations.wl`. 107

8.1 Geometry of gravitational lensing. A light ray from a source at angular position $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ in the source plane is deflected by the angle $\hat{\alpha}$ as it passes through the lens plane, and is observed at angular position $\boldsymbol{\theta}$. The angular diameter distances $D_{\rm d}$, $D_{\rm s}$, and $D_{\rm ds}$ connect angular separations to physical separations. The reduced deflection angle $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = (D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s})\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$ gives the apparent angular shift. Generated by `lens_equation.wl`. 119

8.2 The Einstein ring. When a source (star symbol at center) lies exactly behind a point mass lens (filled circle at center), the image is a complete ring of angular radius $\theta_{\rm E}$. For a slightly offset source ($\beta \neq 0$), the ring breaks into two images at positions θ_+ and θ_-. Generated by `lens_equation.wl`. 120

8.3 Image positions θ_+ and θ_- as functions of the source position β for a point mass lens, in units of the Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$. The primary image θ_+ (blue) is always outside $\theta_{\rm E}$ and approaches the unlensed position (gray dashed line) for $\beta \gg \theta_{\rm E}$. The secondary image θ_- (red) is always inside $\theta_{\rm E}$ (in absolute value) and approaches the lens for $\beta \gg \theta_{\rm E}$. At $\beta = 0$, both images are at $\pm\theta_{\rm E}$ (Einstein ring). Generated by `lens_equation.wl`. 121

9.1 Effect of convergence and shear on a circular source. **Left:** Pure convergence ($\kappa = 0.3$, $\gamma = 0$) produces a larger circle (isotropic magnification). **Center:** Pure shear ($\kappa = 0$, $|\gamma| = 0.3$) produces an ellipse (anisotropic distortion; the magnification $\mu = 1/(1 - |\gamma|^2) \approx 1.10$ differs from unity only at second order in $|\gamma|$). **Right:** Both ($\kappa = 0.3$, $|\gamma| = 0.3$) produces a larger ellipse. The dashed circle shows the original source in each panel. Generated by `lensing_potential.wl`. 129

10.1 The arrival-time surface $\tau(\theta_1, \theta_2)$ for a point mass lens with source at $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.5, 0)\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$. The surface shows a minimum (Type I image, blue dot) and a saddle point (Type II image, red dot). The minimum has the smaller arrival time and corresponds to the image that is observed first. The difference in τ between the two stationary points gives the dimensionless time delay. Generated by `time_delay_function.wl`. 140

10.2 Contour plot of the Fermat potential $\tau(\theta_1, \theta_2)$ for a point mass lens with $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.5, 0)\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$. The two stationary points (minimum and saddle) are marked. The critical curve (Einstein ring, dashed circle) is overlaid. Generated by `time_delay_function.wl`. 141

10.3 Dimensionless time delay $\Delta\tau$ between the two images of a point mass lens as a function of the source position $y = \beta/\theta_\mathrm{E}$. The time delay increases with the source offset. For $y \to 0$ (Einstein ring limit), $\Delta\tau \to 0$ because the two images become symmetric. Generated by `time_delay_function.wl`. 144

11.1 Effect of the core radius on the NIS convergence and shear, shown for three regimes that control the critical-curve topology. **Left:** for $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_\mathrm{E} < \theta_\mathrm{E}/2$, the central convergence $\kappa(0) > 1$, so both tangential and radial critical curves exist and three images can form. **Center:** at the critical value $\theta_c = 0.5\,\theta_\mathrm{E} = \theta_\mathrm{E}/2$, $\kappa(0) = 1$ exactly and the radial critical curve collapses to a point. **Right:** for $\theta_c = 1.0\,\theta_\mathrm{E} > \theta_\mathrm{E}/2$, $\kappa(0) < 1$ everywhere; no critical curves exist and only one image forms. Generated by `axisymmetric_models.wl`. 156

11.2 NFW convergence $\kappa(x)/\kappa_s = f(x)$ (solid) and shear $|\gamma(x)|/\kappa_s = \bar{\kappa}(x)/\kappa_s - f(x)$ (dashed) as functions of the dimensionless radius $x = \theta/\theta_s$. Both curves are normalized to κ_s and are universal functions of x (independent of concentration); the horizontal grey line marks $f(1) = 1/3$. The concentration c enters only through the overall scale κ_s and the angular scale θ_s, both of which absorb the dependence on c and on the cosmological distances. Generated by `axisymmetric_models.wl`. 160

11.3 Comparison of convergence profiles (left) and deflection angles (right) for the four axisymmetric models. All curves use the SIS Einstein radius θ_E as the unit of length on the horizontal axis; the SIS, NIS and NFW amplitudes are set so that the profiles can be compared on the same panel (specifically NIS with $\theta_c = 0.2\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$ and NFW with $\theta_s = 0.3\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$, $\kappa_s = 0.5$). Only the SIS and NIS are normalized to reproduce $\bar{\kappa}(\theta_\mathrm{E}) = 1$; the NFW deflection therefore does not pass through $\alpha = \theta_\mathrm{E}$ at $\theta = \theta_\mathrm{E}$ on this plot. The point mass convergence is a delta function and is not shown. Generated by `axisymmetric_models.wl`. . 162

12.1 Critical curves (left, image plane) and caustics (right, source plane) for the SIS + external shear model with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$ and $\gamma_{\rm ext} = 0.1$. The critical curve is an oval (approximately elliptical for small shear); the caustic is a diamond (astroid) with four cusps. The shear axis is horizontal. Generated by `critical_curves_caustics.wl`. 167

12.2 Critical curves (left) and caustics (right) for the SIE model with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$ and axis ratios $q = 0.5$, 0.7, and 0.9. As q decreases (more elliptical), the diamond caustic grows larger, increasing the cross-section for quad imaging. Generated by `critical_curves_caustics.wl`. 170

12.3 A source walks across the caustic of an SIE lens ($q = 0.7$). **Top row:** Source positions (red star) in the source plane, with the diamond caustic shown. **Bottom row:** Corresponding image configurations in the image plane, with the critical curve shown. Blue dots = Type I images (positive parity); red dots = Type II images (negative parity). As the source crosses the caustic, images appear/disappear in pairs. Generated by `critical_curves_caustics.wl`. . 177

12.4 Magnification behavior near fold and cusp caustics. **Left:** Near a fold, two images straddle the critical curve with magnifications scaling as $|\mu| \propto 1/\sqrt{d_\perp}$. **Right:** Near a cusp, three images merge, with stronger divergence. The cusp relation $\mu_A + \mu_B + \mu_C \approx 0$ holds for the signed magnifications. Generated by `critical_curves_caustics.wl`. 178

12.5 Image configurations for an SIE lens with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$ and $q = 0.7$. **Left:** Double (source outside caustic). **Center:** Quad / Einstein cross (source inside caustic). **Right:** Cusp configuration (source near a cusp). Blue = Type I (positive parity); red = Type II (negative parity). The critical curve and caustic are shown as gray curves. Generated by `critical_curves_caustics.wl`. 181

13.1 Enclosed Einstein mass $M_{\rm E}$ as a function of Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$ for three lens–source redshift configurations (flat ΛCDM, $H_0 = 70$ km/s/Mpc, $\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$). Higher redshift lenses enclose more mass for the same angular Einstein radius. Generated by `galaxy_lensing.wl`. 187

13.2 The mass-sheet degeneracy. **Left:** Convergence profiles for an SIS lens ($\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$) under the MST with different λ values. The solid curve is the original profile ($\lambda = 1$); dashed curves show the transformed profiles. Curves with $\lambda > 1$ correspond to a negative sheet, e.g. an underdense line of sight ($\kappa_{\rm ext} < 0$ in $\lambda = 1 - \kappa_{\rm ext}$). **Right:** Magnification scaling $\mu_\lambda = \mu/\lambda^2$ for three different original magnifications. Generated by `galaxy_lensing.wl`. 190

13.3 Power-law density profiles $\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$. **Left:** Convergence profiles for different slopes (the solid curve is the isothermal case $\gamma' = 2$). **Right:** Enclosed 3D mass $M(\leq r) \propto r^{3-\gamma'}$ for the same slopes. Generated by `galaxy_lensing.wl`. 192

13.4 Predicted σ_v^2 (normalized to the isothermal value) as a function of the density slope γ', for fixed Einstein mass. The green band shows the range found by the SLACS survey ($\gamma' \approx 2.0 \pm 0.2$). Measuring σ_v constrains γ' and breaks the mass-sheet degeneracy. Generated by `galaxy_lensing.wl`. 194

13.5 Time-delay cosmography and the mass-sheet degeneracy. **Left:** Inferred H_0 as a function of the MST parameter λ, showing the H0LiCOW measurement (red point) and the Planck and SH0ES bands. **Right:** Time delay vs. H_0 for $\lambda = 1$ (solid) and $\lambda = 0.95$ (dashed). Generated by `galaxy_lensing.wl`. . . 195

14.1 Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$ as a function of cluster mass M_{200} for an NFW profile with $c = 5$, $z_d = 0.3$, and $z_s = 2$. The dashed line shows the approximate $M^{1/3}$ scaling. Clusters below $M_{200} \sim 10^{14}\,M_\odot$ have Einstein radii comparable to galaxy-scale lenses. Generated by `cluster_lensing.wl`. 205

14.2 Giant arc formation by an NFW cluster ($M_{200} = 10^{15}\,M_\odot$, $c = 5$, $z_d = 0.3$, $z_s = 2$). A circular source of radius $0.5''$ is placed at three positions: $\beta = 0$ (Einstein ring, left), $\beta = 0.5\,\theta_{\rm E}$ (giant arc, center), and $\beta = \theta_{\rm E}$ (near the critical curve, right). The critical curve is shown as a dashed circle. Generated by `cluster_lensing.wl`. 217

15.1 The point-mass magnification cross-section $\sigma(\mu_p)/(\pi\theta_{\rm E}^2) = y^2(\mu_p)$ of Eq. (15.1), as a function of the magnification threshold μ_p. At high magnification the cross-section falls as $\sigma \propto \mu_p^{-2}$ (dashed), the universal scaling that produces $p(\mu) \propto \mu^{-3}$ and drives the magnification bias. Generated by `lensing_statistics.wl`. 220

16.1 Tangential-shear profiles $\gamma_{\rm t}(\theta)$ for two axisymmetric lenses, illustrating eq. (16.10). **Solid:** the singular isothermal sphere, $\gamma_{\rm t} = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta)$ (eq. 16.12), with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1$. **Dashed:** an NFW halo (Chapter 11, eq. 11.54) with $\kappa_s = 0.2$ and scale $\theta_s = 1$. The NFW tangential shear decreases monotonically: it tends to the finite value $\kappa_s/2$ at the centre, is nearly flat inside θ_s, and steepens outside it, whereas the SIS is a single power law. The measurable $\gamma_{\rm t}$ maps directly to the excess surface mass density $\Delta\Sigma$ (eq. 16.11). Generated by `weak_lensing.wl`. . . . 230

17.1 The point-lens total magnification $A(u)$ (eq. 17.5, red) as a function of the source–lens separation $u = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$. The high-magnification asymptote $A \to 1/u$ (blue dashed) and the unlensed limit $A \to 1$ (grey dotted) are shown for reference; the marked point is $A(1) = 3/\sqrt{5} \approx 1.34$. Generated by `microlensing.wl`. 238

17.2 Paczyński microlensing light curves (eq. 17.8 substituted into eq. 17.5) for minimum impact parameters $u_0 = 0.1, 0.3, 0.5, 0.7, 1.0$ (top to bottom). Time is in units of the Einstein timescale $t_{\rm E}$; every curve is symmetric about the peak at $(t - t_0)/t_{\rm E} = 0$, and the smaller the impact parameter the higher and narrower the peak ($A_{\max} \approx 1/u_0$). Generated by `microlensing.wl`. 239

18.1 The DSPL distance ratio $\mathcal{B}$ as a function of the far source redshift z_{s2} for $z_l = 0.5$, $z_{s1} = 1.0$, in a flat cosmology with $\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$, for $w = -1$ (solid) and $w = -0.7$ (dashed). Lower panel: the fractional difference. $\mathcal{B}$ falls monotonically with z_{s2} towards a finite floor; the w signal grows with the separation of the two source planes, reaching -1.75% at $z_{s2} = 4$ ($\mathcal{B} = 0.5815 \to 0.5714$). Generated by `multiplane_dspl.wl`. 254

19.1 Annihilation of the radial critical curve by a central point mass. **(a)** Radial eigenvalue $\lambda_r(\theta)$, eq. (19.17), for a $\gamma' = 1.5$ power law with point masses $m = 0$, $m_{\rm crit}/2$, $m_{\rm crit}$, and $2m_{\rm crit}$ ($m_{\rm crit} = 27/4096$). The dashed line marks the radial critical radius $\theta_r = \theta_{\rm E}/4$ of the bare power law. For $0 < m < m_{\rm crit}$ the curve crosses zero twice (two radial critical curves); at $m_{\rm crit}$ it touches zero; above it $\lambda_r > 0$ everywhere. **(b)** The threshold $m_{\rm crit}(\gamma')$ of eq. (19.19). Below the curve the lens has radial critical curves; above it, none. Generated by `power_law_point_mass.wl`. 265

19.2 Deflection of a broken power law versus a single power law. All three solid curves have outer slope $t_2 = 0.5$ ($\gamma' = 1.5$) and Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E} = 1$ (vertical dotted line at 1); the broken models have $\theta_B = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$ (dotted line at 0.1) and inner slope $t_1 = 1.5$ (a steep cusp, red) or $t_1 = 0$ (a flat core, blue). The dashed curves are eq. (19.32): the continued outer power law plus $\theta_{\rm eff}^2/\theta$. Outside the break they lie exactly on the broken-power-law curves; inside, they separate. For the core, $\theta_{\rm eff}^2 < 0$ and the dashed curve plunges to zero. Generated by `broken_power_law.wl`. 270

20.1 Contours of the arrival-time surface $\tau(\theta_1, \theta_2)$ for an NIS with $\theta_c = 0.2\,\theta_{\rm E}$ and a source at $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.2, 0)\,\theta_{\rm E}$ (black cross); top row full view, bottom row zoom on the centre; axes in units of $\theta_{\rm E}$. **Left:** NIS alone — minimum (blue), saddle (red), central maximum (green). **Centre:** NIS plus a central point mass with $\theta_\bullet^2 = 0.3\,\theta_{\bullet,\rm crit}^2$ — the summit is punctured (black dot) and a second saddle appears next to the puncture; four images. **Right:** $\theta_\bullet^2 = 1.2\,\theta_{\bullet,\rm crit}^2$ — the maximum and the inner saddle are gone; two images. Generated by `odd_images.wl`. 278

20.2 Magnification of the central image of an NIS as a function of core radius. Solid: the on-axis closed form, eq. (20.14); dashed: its small-core limit $4\theta_c^2/\theta_{\rm E}^2$; points: numerical roots of the lens equation for $y = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$, which lie within 6% of the closed form for $\theta_c \le 0.05\,\theta_{\rm E}$. The divergence as $\theta_c \to \theta_{\rm E}/2$ is the radial critical circle shrinking onto the centre. Generated by `odd_images.wl`. 279

20.3 Where a central image can exist, for an NIS with a central point mass. For each black-hole Einstein radius $\theta_\bullet$ the central image exists only for sources between the inner caustic (solid; eq. 20.20 at small $\theta_\bullet$) and the radial caustic (dashed). The two curves meet and end at $\theta_{\bullet,\rm crit}$, eq. (20.21); above it no source has a central image. Blue: $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$; red: $\theta_c = 0.2\,\theta_{\rm E}$. Generated by `odd_images.wl`. 282

21.1 Bias in $\mathcal{B}$ from a power-law-only fit to five image positions generated with a central point mass, for $\mathcal{B} = 0.8$ and two slopes. Points: exact fit (zero residual). Dashed: linear response, eq. (21.15). The far source is at 0.9 times the radius of the power law's radial caustic ($y_2 = 0.293\,\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}$ for $\gamma' = 1.6$ and $0.481\,\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}$ for $\gamma' = 1.8$), giving linear coefficients -4.66 and -1.77. The points run from 2% of the annihilation value $m_{1,\rm crit}$ (§21.6) to 0.35 ($\gamma' = 1.6$) and 0.25 ($\gamma' = 1.8$) of it, just below the masses at which this source loses its radial image (0.38 and $0.29\,m_{1,\rm crit}$). At the last $\gamma' = 1.6$ point the exact bias exceeds the linear one by 50%; at the last $\gamma' = 1.8$ point, by 24%. Generated by `central_mass_bias.wl`. 293

21.2 Annihilation boundary of the radial image in the (γ', m) plane. Solid: $m_{\rm crit}(\gamma')$, eq. (21.21), the fraction on the radial-image plane. Dashed: the near-plane fraction $m_{1,\rm crit}$ for $\mathcal{B} = 0.8$, eq. (21.22); above it (shaded) the far plane has no radial critical curve. The dot marks the illustrative lens of §21.4.1 ($\gamma' = 1.9$, $m_1 = 0.01$). Generated by `central_mass_bias.wl`. 295

22.1 The MST of a power law with $\gamma' = 2.2$. **Left:** convergence for $\lambda = 0.8$ (positive sheet), 1, and 1.2 (negative sheet; this profile crosses $\kappa = 0$ near $2\,\theta_{\rm E}$). All three profiles cross where $\kappa = 1$ (the fixed point of $\kappa \to \lambda\kappa + 1 - \lambda$), not at $\theta_{\rm E}$. The dashed verticals mark the two images A and B of a source at $\beta = 0.2\,\theta_{\rm E}$; they are the same for all three profiles. **Right:** the lens map $\theta - \alpha_\lambda(\theta)$. Each curve meets its own source line $\lambda\beta$ (horizontal dashes) at the same two image positions. Generated by `msd_multiplane.wl`. 301

23.1 **Left:** the $m = 4$ convergence multipole κ_4 of Eq. (23.4) on a $\gamma' = 1.5$ power-law base, with an exaggerated $a_4 = 0.05$ for visibility (the colour scale is clipped near the centre, where $\kappa_4 \propto \theta^{-1/2}$). The dashed circle is the unperturbed Einstein ring. Red regions gain mass and blue regions lose the same amount: the pattern averages to zero on every circle. **Right:** contours of the total convergence (grey) and the first-order tangential critical curve, Eq. (23.20) (red), compared with the unperturbed ring (dashed). Generated by `multipoles_power_law.wl`. 315

23.2 Deflection perturbation $|\delta\alpha|/\theta_{\rm E}$ versus radius on a $\gamma' = 1.5$ power-law base. Dotted: central point mass with $f_\bullet = 0.01$, base renormalised to keep the Einstein ring fixed (Eq. (23.21)). Solid red: the same after the slope is also re-fitted (Eq. (23.22)); the residual is now second order at $\theta_{\rm E}$ and concentrated inside. Dashed blue: an $m = 4$ multipole with $a_4 = 0.01$, peak over φ (Eq. (23.11)), rising outward as $\theta^{1/2}$. Vertical lines mark the radial critical curve θ_r of the base and the Einstein radius. Generated by `multipoles_power_law.wl`. 317

24.1 Contours of $100\,(\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}_0 - 1)$, the percentage change of $\mathcal{B}$ relative to its value at $(\Omega_{\rm m}, w_0) = (0.3, -1)$ (black dot), for the illustrative geometry $z_d = 0.5$, $z_1 = 1$, $z_2 = 2$ with $w_a = 0$. The thick contour is $\mathcal{B} = \mathcal{B}_0$: every cosmology on it reproduces the same ratio. Note the small dynamic range (a few per cent over the whole panel) and the curvature of the contours, which makes $\mathcal{B}$ non-monotonic in w_0 (§24.7). Generated by `cosmological_sensitivity.wl`. 324

24.2 The bias as a direction. Solid: the contour $\mathcal{B} = \mathcal{B}_0$ through the reference cosmology (dot) at the illustrative geometry ($w_a = 0$). Dashed: $\mathcal{B} = 1.005\,\mathcal{B}_0$, the locus to which a +0.5% ratio error moves the fit. Dotted: the blind direction $(c_\star, 1)$, tangent to the solid curve. Arrows: the linear bias vectors of eq. (24.18) for external degeneracies $c = 0$ (fixed Ω_m, blue), $c = +\frac{1}{2}$ (green) and $c = -\frac{1}{2}$ (red). Open circles: the exact solutions on the first two rays. The red ray never reaches the dashed curve. Generated by `cosmological_sensitivity.wl`. 327

25.1 Response coefficient c of a fixed-slope, source-plane (unit-weight) power-law fit to a lens with an omitted central point mass, as a function of the density slope γ', for the canonical configuration: tangential pair only (dashed; the floor $1/(\gamma' - 1)$ of Eq. (25.11)) and with a radial image at $\rho = 0.2$, 0.05 and 0.01 (Eq. (25.15)). The radial image raises c above the floor, the more so the deeper it sits. This depth dependence is a property of the unit weights; an image-plane fit behaves differently (§25.4.5). From `response_coefficient.wl`. 339

25.2 The exact correction factor c/c_asym of Eq. (25.17) against the radial-image position ρ. For $\gamma' < 5/3$ the asymptote is approached from above and can be badly low at moderate ρ; for $\gamma' > 5/3$ the curve dips below unity before converging. All curves reach 3 at $\rho = 1$, where c has returned to the floor while c_asym has not. From `response_coefficient.wl`. 340

Notation Guide

Symbol	Meaning	Units / Notes
Coordinates and Angles		
$\boldsymbol{\theta}$	Image position (angular)	radians or arcsec
$\boldsymbol{\beta}$	Source position (angular)	radians or arcsec
$\boldsymbol{\alpha}$	Reduced deflection angle	radians
$\hat{\alpha}$	Physical deflection angle	radians
$\boldsymbol{\xi}$	Position in lens plane	physical (kpc, Mpc)
Distances		
$D_{\rm d}$	Observer–lens angular diameter distance	Mpc
$D_{\rm s}$	Observer–source angular diameter distance	Mpc
$D_{\rm ds}$	Lens–source angular diameter distance	Mpc
Lensing Quantities		
$\theta_{\rm E}$	Einstein radius	arcsec
$\Sigma_{\rm cr}$	Critical surface mass density	$\mathrm{g\,cm^{-2}}$ or $M_\odot\,\mathrm{pc^{-2}}$
κ	Convergence $= \Sigma/\Sigma_{\rm cr}$	dimensionless
γ	Shear magnitude	dimensionless
ψ	Effective lensing potential	dimensionless
μ	Magnification	dimensionless
$\mathcal{A}$	Jacobian (inverse magnification) matrix	2×2
Cosmology		
H_0	Hubble constant	$\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$
$\Omega_{\rm m}$	Matter density parameter	dimensionless
Ω_Λ	Dark energy density parameter	dimensionless
GR / Metric		
$g_{\mu\nu}$	Metric tensor	
$\Gamma^{\alpha}_{\ \mu\nu}$	Christoffel symbols	
$R^{\alpha}_{\ \beta\mu\nu}$	Riemann curvature tensor	
$R_{\mu\nu}$	Ricci tensor	
R	Ricci scalar	

Mathematica files are cross-linked throughout these notes. Links formatted as `filename.nb` or `filename.wl` point to companion Mathematica notebooks and scripts in the `Mathematica/`

directory of this repository.

Part I

General Relativity Foundations

Chapter 1

Special Relativity and Tensor Basics

> *General relativity (GR) is Einstein's theory of space, time, and gravitation. At heart it is a very simple subject ... The essential idea is perfectly straightforward: while most forces of nature are represented by fields defined on spacetime, gravity is inherent in spacetime itself.* — Sean Carroll, *Spacetime and Geometry*

Before we can describe how gravity bends light we need the language of special relativity and tensors. This chapter reviews the foundations: Minkowski spacetime, Lorentz transformations, four-vectors, and the index notation that will carry us through the rest of these notes. The emphasis is on fluency with the notation and with the physical ideas (time dilation, length contraction, the invariant interval) that the transition to curved spacetime in later chapters will build on.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `lorentz_transforms.wl`: symbolic construction and verification of Lorentz boost matrices
- `four_vectors.nb`: interactive visualizations of worldlines, light cones, and time dilation

1.1 From Newton to Einstein

In Newtonian mechanics, space and time are independent. The gravitational force between two masses M and m separated by a distance r is (cf. Carroll eq. 1.1)

$$\mathbf{F} = -\frac{GMm}{r^2}\,\hat{\mathbf{r}}\,, \tag{1.1}$$

and the gravitational potential Φ satisfies Poisson's equation,

$$\nabla^2\Phi = 4\pi G\rho\,. \tag{1.2}$$

In GR, both of these are replaced by statements about the curvature of spacetime. The equation we will eventually arrive at is Einstein's field equation (Carroll eq. 1.5, in units with $c = 1$):

$$R_{\mu\nu} - \tfrac{1}{2}R\,g_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G\,T_{\mu\nu}\,. \tag{1.3}$$

That is for later. For now we restrict attention to *flat* spacetime, the arena of special relativity, and develop the tensor language needed to write down equations like (1.3).

1.2 Spacetime and the Invariant Interval

Special relativity (SR) unifies space and time into a single four-dimensional continuum called *Minkowski space*. An individual point in spacetime is an *event*, and the path of a particle through spacetime is its *worldline*.

Unlike Newtonian mechanics, SR has no absolute notion of simultaneity. Instead, the fundamental invariant is the *spacetime interval* between two events (Carroll eq. 1.10):

$$\boxed{(\Delta s)^2 = -(\Delta t)^2 + (\Delta x)^2 + (\Delta y)^2 + (\Delta z)^2} \tag{1.4}$$

where we work in *natural units* with $c = 1$ throughout this chapter (we will restore factors of c when needed for astrophysical applications).

Remark 1.2.1. We adopt the *mostly-plus* sign convention $(-,+,+,+)$, following Carroll. Some references (especially in particle physics) use the opposite convention $(+,-,-,-)$, and the sign of every term in an equation must be checked when comparing across textbooks.

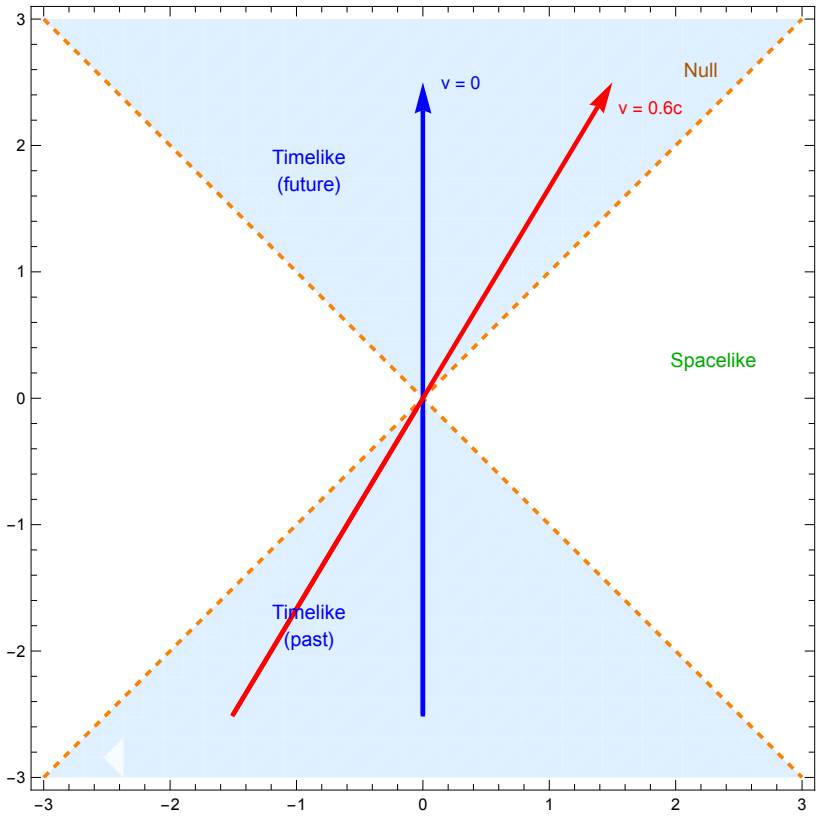


Figure 1.1: Spacetime diagram in 1+1 dimensions showing the light cone structure. The shaded (blue) region is timelike; the dashed orange lines are the light cone (null); the unshaded region is spacelike. The blue arrow is the worldline of a stationary particle; the red arrow is a particle moving at $v = 0.6c$. (cf. Carroll Fig. 1.5)

The sign of the interval classifies the separation between two events. If $(\Delta s)^2 < 0$ the separation is *timelike* and the events can be causally connected; if $(\Delta s)^2 = 0$ it is *null* (or

lightlike), the events being connected by a light ray; and if $(\Delta s)^2 > 0$ it is *spacelike*, and no causal connection between the events is possible.

The *proper time* $\Delta\tau$ along a timelike path is defined as (Carroll eq. 1.17)

$$(\Delta\tau)^2 = -(\Delta s)^2 = (\Delta t)^2 - (\Delta x)^2 - (\Delta y)^2 - (\Delta z)^2 \,. \tag{1.5}$$

This is the time measured by a clock traveling along the worldline. For an infinitesimal displacement, we write the *line element* (Carroll eq. 1.20):

$$ds^2 = \eta_{\mu\nu}\, dx^\mu\, dx^\nu \,, \tag{1.6}$$

where we have introduced the Minkowski metric and the *Einstein summation convention* (repeated indices are summed over).

1.3 Index Notation and the Minkowski Metric

Spacetime coordinates are labeled by Greek letters $(\mu, \nu, \rho, \sigma, \ldots)$ running from 0 to 3 (Carroll eq. 1.12):

$$x^\mu : \quad x^0 = t, \quad x^1 = x, \quad x^2 = y, \quad x^3 = z \,. \tag{1.7}$$

Latin indices $i, j, k, \ldots$ run over the spatial components $1, 2, 3$ only.

The *Minkowski metric* is the 4×4 matrix (Carroll eq. 1.15):

$$\eta_{\mu\nu} = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} . \tag{1.8}$$

Its inverse, $\eta^{\mu\nu}$, has the same components. The metric is used to *raise and lower indices*:

$$V_\mu = \eta_{\mu\nu}\, V^\nu, \qquad \omega^\mu = \eta^{\mu\nu}\, \omega_\nu \,. \tag{1.9}$$

In Minkowski space this flips the sign of the time component and leaves the spatial components unchanged: $V_0 = -V^0$, while $V_i = V^i$.

1.4 Lorentz Transformations

The coordinate transformations that leave the interval (1.6) invariant are called *Lorentz transformations*. They act on the coordinates as (Carroll eq. 1.25)

$$x^{\mu'} = \Lambda^{\mu'}{}_{\nu}\, x^\nu \,, \tag{1.10}$$

where the matrix Λ satisfies the defining condition (Carroll eq. 1.28):

$$\boxed{\eta = \Lambda^{\mathrm{T}}\, \eta\, \Lambda} \tag{1.11}$$

or equivalently $\eta_{\rho\sigma} = \Lambda^{\mu'}{}_{\rho}\, \Lambda^{\nu'}{}_{\sigma}\, \eta_{\mu'\nu'}$.

1.4.1 Rotations

A spatial rotation in the x–y plane by angle θ is (Carroll eq. 1.31):

$$\Lambda^{\mu'}{}_{\nu} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & \cos\theta & \sin\theta & 0 \\ 0 & -\sin\theta & \cos\theta & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} . \tag{1.12}$$

1.4.2 Boosts

Rotations mix two spatial directions using sin and cos, the circular functions that preserve the positive-definite sum $x^2 + y^2$. A *Lorentz boost* mixes a space and a time direction, and must preserve the *indefinite* form $-t^2 + x^2$ of the Minkowski interval. The functions that do this are the hyperbolic functions sinh and cosh, whose identity $\cosh^2\phi - \sinh^2\phi = 1$ has the same relative sign as the Minkowski signature (Carroll Sec. 1.3, pp. 12–14).

The boost along the x-axis with *rapidity* parameter ϕ is therefore (Carroll eq. 1.32):

$$\Lambda^{\mu'}{}_{\nu} = \begin{pmatrix} \cosh\phi & -\sinh\phi & 0 & 0 \\ -\sinh\phi & \cosh\phi & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} . \tag{1.13}$$

The rapidity ϕ parameterizes the boost in a way that is analogous to the rotation angle θ: just as two successive rotations by θ_1 and θ_2 give a rotation by $\theta_1 + \theta_2$, two successive boosts with rapidities ϕ_1 and ϕ_2 compose to a single boost with rapidity $\phi_1 + \phi_2$ (Exercise 1.11.2).

To connect the rapidity to the more familiar velocity v of the boosted frame (Carroll eqs. 1.33–1.35), consider a particle at rest in S', for which $x' = 0$. The boost matrix then gives $0 = -\sinh\phi \cdot t + \cosh\phi \cdot x$, so that $x/t = \tanh\phi$. Since x/t is the velocity v of the S' frame as seen from S, we identify

$$v = \tanh\phi\,. \tag{1.14}$$

The Lorentz factor γ then follows from the hyperbolic identity $\cosh^2\phi - \sinh^2\phi = 1$:

$$\gamma \equiv \frac{1}{\sqrt{1-v^2}} = \cosh\phi\,, \qquad \gamma v = \sinh\phi\,. \tag{1.15}$$

Substituting into the boost matrix, we recover the familiar form (Carroll eq. 1.35):

$$\begin{aligned} t' &= \gamma(t - vx)\,, \\ x' &= \gamma(x - vt)\,. \end{aligned} \tag{1.16}$$

Exercise 1.4.1. Verify that the boost matrix (1.13) satisfies the Lorentz condition (1.11) by explicit matrix multiplication. Then confirm this symbolically using `lorentz_transforms.wl`.

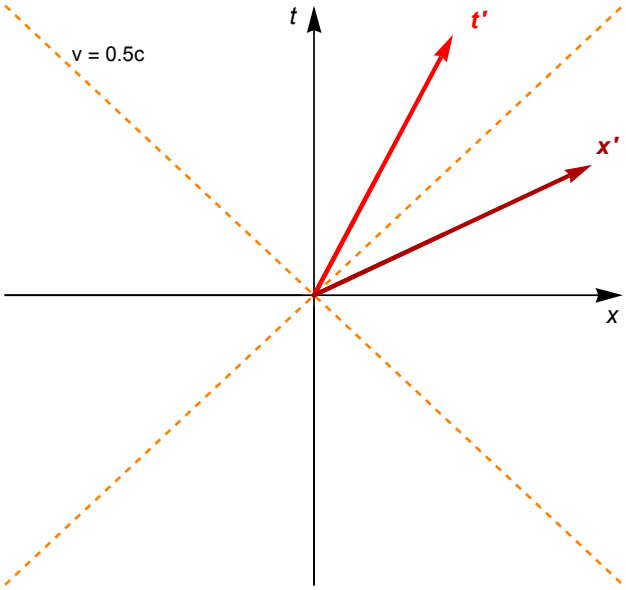


Figure 1.2: A Lorentz boost with $v = 0.5c$ tilts both the time axis (t', red) and the space axis (x', dark red) toward the light cone. The light cone itself (orange dashed) is invariant under boosts. (cf. Carroll Fig. 1.7)

1.4.3 Physical Consequences

The boost equations (1.16) lead directly to the classic relativistic effects (Carroll Sec. 1.3; Congdon & Keeton Sec. 3.1.2); in each case the derivation is a single substitution. Consider first a clock at rest in S', for which $\Delta x' = 0$. The inverse boost gives $\Delta t = \gamma(\Delta t' + v \cdot 0) = \gamma\,\Delta t'$, so the moving clock runs *slow* by a factor $\gamma > 1$; this is *time dilation*. Next consider a rod at rest in S', with proper length $L_0 = \Delta x'$. We measure it in S by recording the positions of both ends *simultaneously* ($\Delta t = 0$). From $\Delta x' = \gamma(\Delta x - v \cdot 0)$ we obtain $L_0 = \gamma\,\Delta x$, hence $L = \Delta x = L_0/\gamma$: the rod is shorter in the frame in which it moves, which is *length contraction*. Finally, events simultaneous in S' ($\Delta t' = 0$) satisfy $0 = \gamma(\Delta t - v\,\Delta x)$, so that $\Delta t = v\,\Delta x$; events separated in space are therefore *not* simultaneous in S, and simultaneity is relative to the frame.

Exercise 1.4.2. (Twin paradox.) An observer travels from event $A = (0, 0)$ to $B' = (\Delta t/2,\, v\Delta t/2)$ and back to $C = (\Delta t, 0)$ at constant speed v, while a stationary twin travels from A directly to C. Show that the traveling twin ages by $\Delta\tau_{AB'C} = \sqrt{1 - v^2}\,\Delta t$ while the stationary twin ages by $\Delta\tau_{ABC} = \Delta t$. (cf. Carroll eqs. 1.18–1.19. Visualize with `four_vectors.nb`.)

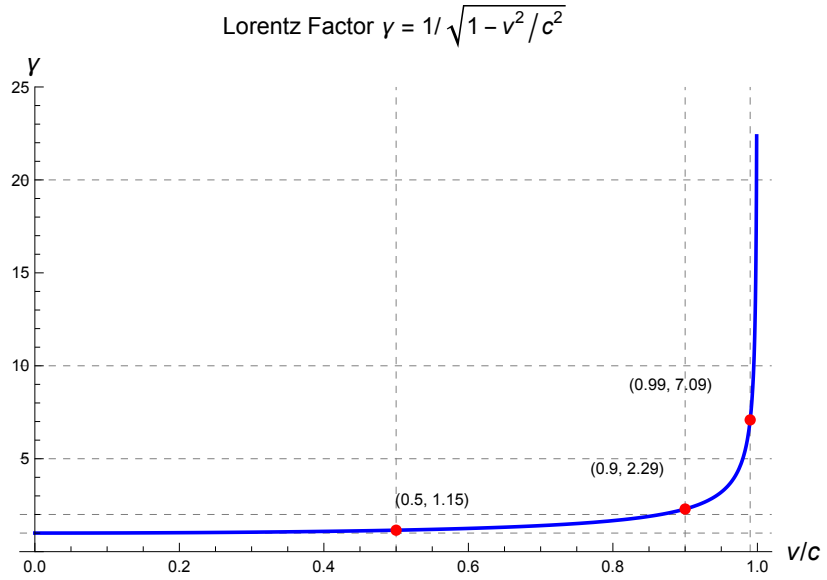


Figure 1.3: The Lorentz factor $\gamma = (1 - v^2/c^2)^{-1/2}$ as a function of velocity. Time dilation and length contraction both scale with γ. Note the dramatic increase as $v \to c$.

1.5 Four-Vectors

A *four-vector* V^μ is a set of four components that transforms under Lorentz transformations as (Carroll eq. 1.39):

$$V^{\mu'} = \Lambda^{\mu'}{}_{\nu} V^\nu \,. \tag{1.17}$$

The examples we shall use most are the following.

Four-position: $x^\mu = (t, x, y, z)$.

Four-velocity: For a massive particle with worldline $x^\mu(\tau)$, the four-velocity is defined as the derivative of the position with respect to proper time τ (the time measured by a clock traveling with the particle):

$$U^\mu = \frac{dx^\mu}{d\tau} \,. \tag{1.18}$$

To express this in terms of coordinate time t we use $d\tau = dt/\gamma$ (from time dilation, eq. (1.5); see also Carroll eq. 1.17), which gives $U^\mu = \gamma\, dx^\mu/dt = \gamma(1, v^x, v^y, v^z)$, where $v^i = dx^i/dt$ is the ordinary three-velocity.

The norm of the four-velocity is always $\eta_{\mu\nu} U^\mu U^\nu = -1$ (in units with $c = 1$; Carroll eq. 1.100). This follows from the definition, since $U^\mu U_\mu = (dx^\mu/d\tau)(dx_\mu/d\tau) = ds^2/d\tau^2 = -d\tau^2/d\tau^2 = -1$, where we have used $ds^2 = -d\tau^2$ along a timelike worldline.

Four-momentum: The four-momentum is defined as $p^\mu = m\, U^\mu$, where m is the rest mass (Carroll eq. 1.101). Written out, $p^\mu = m\gamma(1, v^x, v^y, v^z) = (E, p^x, p^y, p^z)$, where $E = \gamma m$ is the relativistic energy (which reduces to m at rest, i.e., $E = mc^2$ in conventional units) and

$\mathbf{p} = \gamma m\,\mathbf{v}$ is the relativistic three-momentum (which reduces to $m\mathbf{v}$ for $v \ll c$; Congdon & Keeton eqs. 3.18–3.23). The invariant norm gives the *energy–momentum relation*:

$$\boxed{\eta_{\mu\nu}\,p^\mu p^\nu = -E^2 + |\mathbf{p}|^2 = -m^2} \tag{1.19}$$

or, restoring c: $E^2 = (pc)^2 + (mc^2)^2$.

For a photon ($m = 0$), $E = |\mathbf{p}|$ and the four-momentum is null: $p^\mu p_\mu = 0$. This is the property we shall use when we trace light rays through curved spacetime in later chapters.

1.6 Dual Vectors (One-Forms)

Associated with every vector space is a *dual vector space* (or cotangent space T_p^*). A dual vector (or *one-form*) ω_μ transforms under the *inverse* Lorentz transformation (Carroll eq. 1.50):

$$\omega_{\mu'} = \Lambda^{\nu}{}_{\mu'}\,\omega_\nu\,. \tag{1.20}$$

The prototypical one-form is the *gradient* of a scalar field ϕ (Carroll eq. 1.54):

$$(\mathrm{d}\phi)_\mu = \partial_\mu\phi \equiv \frac{\partial\phi}{\partial x^\mu}\,. \tag{1.21}$$

The contraction of a vector with a dual vector is a Lorentz scalar: $\omega_\mu V^\mu \in \mathbf{R}$.

1.7 Tensors

A *tensor* of type (k, l) is a multilinear map that takes k one-forms and l vectors and produces a real number (Carroll eq. 1.56). In components, the transformation law is (Carroll eq. 1.63):

$$T^{\mu'_1\cdots\mu'_k}{}_{\nu'_1\cdots\nu'_l} = \Lambda^{\mu'_1}{}_{\alpha_1}\cdots\Lambda^{\mu'_k}{}_{\alpha_k}\,\Lambda^{\beta_1}{}_{\nu'_1}\cdots\Lambda^{\beta_l}{}_{\nu'_l}\,T^{\alpha_1\cdots\alpha_k}{}_{\beta_1\cdots\beta_l}\,. \tag{1.22}$$

1.7.1 Important Operations

Three operations on tensors recur throughout these notes. *Contraction*, the sum over one upper and one lower index, reduces the rank by $(1, 1)$ (Carroll eq. 1.70), as in $S^{\mu\rho}{}_\sigma = T^{\mu\nu\rho}{}_{\sigma\nu}$. *Raising and lowering* uses the metric to move an index up or down (Carroll eq. 1.72), as in $T^{\alpha\beta\mu}{}_\delta = \eta^{\mu\gamma}\,T^{\alpha\beta}{}_{\gamma\delta}$. *Symmetrization* and *antisymmetrization* over a set of indices are denoted by round and square brackets respectively (Carroll eqs. 1.79–1.80).

1.7.2 Key Tensors in Minkowski Space

Four tensors in Minkowski space will be used repeatedly. The metric $\eta_{\mu\nu}$ is a symmetric $(0, 2)$ tensor. The Kronecker delta $\delta^\mu{}_\nu$ is the identity map. The Levi-Civita symbol $\tilde{\epsilon}_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}$ (Carroll eq. 1.68) is totally antisymmetric, with $\tilde{\epsilon}_{0123} = +1$. The electromagnetic field strength $F_{\mu\nu} = -F_{\nu\mu}$ (Carroll eq. 1.69) is a $(0, 2)$ antisymmetric tensor whose components are $\mathbf{E}$ and $\mathbf{B}$.

1.8 The Metric as the Central Object

What connects SR to GR is that the metric is the fundamental object describing the geometry of spacetime. In SR, the metric is the constant $\eta_{\mu\nu}$. In GR, the metric becomes a field $g_{\mu\nu}(x)$ that varies from point to point and encodes the curvature of spacetime produced by matter and energy.

Everything we need for gravitational lensing (the bending of light, the distortion of images, the time delays between multiple images) follows from how the metric determines the paths of light rays. That account begins in the next chapter, where we introduce curved spacetime and the geodesic equation.

1.9 Energy and Momentum in SR

The *stress-energy tensor* $T^{\mu\nu}$ encodes the energy and momentum content of matter and fields. For a perfect fluid with energy density ρ, pressure p, and four-velocity U^μ it is

$$T^{\mu\nu} = (\rho + p)\, U^\mu U^\nu + p\, \eta^{\mu\nu}\,. \tag{1.23}$$

Conservation of energy and momentum is expressed as

$$\partial_\mu T^{\mu\nu} = 0\,. \tag{1.24}$$

This will generalize to $\nabla_\mu T^{\mu\nu} = 0$ in curved spacetime, and the stress-energy tensor will appear as the source term on the right-hand side of Einstein's field equation (1.3).

1.10 Summary

Spacetime is a four-dimensional continuum whose invariant quantity is the interval $ds^2 = \eta_{\mu\nu}\, dx^\mu dx^\nu$. Lorentz transformations ($x^{\mu'} = \Lambda^{\mu'}{}_\nu x^\nu$) leave the interval invariant; boosts mix space and time. Four-vectors and tensors are classified by how they transform under Lorentz transformations. The metric $\eta_{\mu\nu}$ is the central object: it defines distances, raises and lowers indices, and generalizes to $g_{\mu\nu}$ in GR. Photons travel on null paths ($ds^2 = 0$), which is the starting point for the treatment of gravitational lensing.

1.11 Problems

Exercise 1.11.1. Classify the following pairs of events as timelike, spacelike, or null separated:

(a) $A = (0, 0, 0, 0)$, $B = (2, 1, 1, 0)$

(b) $A = (0, 0, 0, 0)$, $B = (1, 1, 0, 0)$

(c) $A = (0, 0, 0, 0)$, $B = (3, 1, 2, 2)$

Check your answers with Mathematica.

Exercise 1.11.2. Show that two successive boosts along the x-axis with rapidities ϕ_1 and ϕ_2 are equivalent to a single boost with rapidity $\phi = \phi_1 + \phi_2$. Relate this to the velocity addition formula $v = (v_1 + v_2)/(1 + v_1 v_2)$.

Exercise 1.11.3. Prove that the four-velocity of any massive particle satisfies $U^\mu U_\mu = -1$ (in units with $c = 1$).

Exercise 1.11.4. A photon with energy E in frame S is observed in frame S' moving with velocity v along the x-axis.

(a) Show that the photon energy in S' is $E' = \gamma E(1 - v\cos\theta)$, where θ is the angle between the photon's direction and the x-axis in frame S.

(b) Specialize to $\theta = 0$ (head-on) and $\theta = \pi/2$ (transverse) and interpret physically.

Exercise 1.11.5. The electromagnetic field strength tensor has components (Carroll eq. 1.69):

$$F_{\mu\nu} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & -E_1 & -E_2 & -E_3 \\ E_1 & 0 & B_3 & -B_2 \\ E_2 & -B_3 & 0 & B_1 \\ E_3 & B_2 & -B_1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

(a) Show that $F_{\mu\nu}$ is antisymmetric.

(b) Compute $F^{\mu\nu} = \eta^{\mu\alpha}\eta^{\nu\beta}F_{\alpha\beta}$ and verify that the signs of the electric field components change.

(c) Compute the Lorentz scalar $F_{\mu\nu}F^{\mu\nu}$ and express it in terms of $\mathbf{E}$ and $\mathbf{B}$.

Chapter 2

Differential Geometry and the Metric Tensor

> *The appropriate mathematical structure used to describe curvature is that of a differentiable manifold: essentially, a kind of set that looks locally like flat space, but might have a very different global geometry.* — Sean Carroll, *Spacetime and Geometry*

In Chapter 1 we worked exclusively in flat Minkowski spacetime. To describe gravity, we must allow spacetime to be *curved*. This chapter introduces the mathematical machinery of differential geometry (manifolds, the general metric tensor, the covariant derivative, Christoffel symbols, and the curvature tensors) on which general relativity and, ultimately, gravitational lensing are built.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `christoffel_symbols.wl`: general-purpose symbolic computation of Christoffel symbols and curvature tensors from any input metric
- `curved_surfaces.nb`: interactive visualizations of parallel transport, geodesics, and curvature on 2D surfaces

2.1 Manifolds and Coordinate Charts

A *manifold* is a space that may be curved globally but looks like $\mathbb{R}^n$ in every sufficiently small neighborhood. More precisely, an n-dimensional manifold M is a topological space equipped with a collection of *coordinate charts*, invertible maps $\phi : U \to \mathbb{R}^n$ from open subsets $U \subset M$, that cover all of M and are smoothly compatible on overlaps (Carroll Sec. 2.2). Examples are $\mathbb{R}^n$ itself, the 2-sphere S^2 (the surface of a ball), the 2-torus T^2 (the surface of a doughnut), and spacetime, a 4-dimensional Lorentzian manifold.

In general *no single coordinate system can cover an entire manifold.* The sphere S^2, for instance, requires at least two charts (e.g., stereographic projections from the north and south poles; Carroll eqs. 2.9–2.10). We will always work locally in a single chart, keeping in mind that our results are coordinate-independent.

2.2 The General Metric Tensor

On a manifold we need a way to measure distances and angles. This is provided by the *metric tensor* $g_{\mu\nu}(x)$, a symmetric, nondegenerate $(0,2)$ tensor field. The line element is (cf. Carroll eq. 1.20, now generalized)

$$\boxed{ds^2 = g_{\mu\nu}(x)\, dx^\mu\, dx^\nu} \tag{2.1}$$

In flat Minkowski space, $g_{\mu\nu} = \eta_{\mu\nu}$ everywhere. In curved spacetime, $g_{\mu\nu}$ varies from point to point and encodes the gravitational field.

The *inverse metric* $g^{\mu\nu}$ is defined by

$$g^{\mu\lambda} g_{\lambda\nu} = \delta^\mu{}_\nu \,. \tag{2.2}$$

As before, the metric raises and lowers indices: $V_\mu = g_{\mu\nu} V^\nu$, $V^\mu = g^{\mu\nu} V_\nu$.

Example 2.2.1. The metric on the 2-sphere of radius R in spherical coordinates (θ, ϕ) is

$$ds^2 = R^2\big(d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta\, d\phi^2\big)\,, \tag{2.3}$$

so $g_{\theta\theta} = R^2$, $g_{\phi\phi} = R^2 \sin^2\theta$, and all other components vanish.

Example 2.2.2. The flat plane in polar coordinates (r, ϕ) has metric

$$ds^2 = dr^2 + r^2\, d\phi^2 \,. \tag{2.4}$$

Despite the coordinate-dependent appearance, this space is flat: the curvature tensors vanish. We will verify this in Mathematica.

2.3 Vectors and Tensors on Manifolds

On a general manifold, vectors live in the *tangent space* T_p at each point p. A vector V at p is identified with a directional derivative operator along a curve $x^\mu(\lambda)$ through p (Carroll Sec. 2.3):

$$V = V^\mu \partial_\mu \,, \tag{2.5}$$

where $\partial_\mu \equiv \partial/\partial x^\mu$ form a *coordinate basis* for T_p.

Under a coordinate transformation $x^\mu \to x^{\mu'}$, vector components transform as (Carroll eq. 2.19):

$$V^{\mu'} = \frac{\partial x^{\mu'}}{\partial x^\nu}\, V^\nu \,. \tag{2.6}$$

This generalizes the Lorentz transformation law from Chapter 1 to arbitrary coordinate changes.

Dual vectors (one-forms) and general tensors transform analogously, with one factor of $\partial x^{\mu'}/\partial x^\nu$ for each upper index and $\partial x^\nu/\partial x^{\mu'}$ for each lower index.

2.4 The Covariant Derivative

Ordinary partial derivatives of tensors are *not* tensors on a curved manifold: the transformation of $\partial_\mu V^\nu$ picks up an extra, non-tensorial term from the coordinate dependence of the basis vectors (Carroll Sec. 3.2).

To repair this we introduce the *covariant derivative* ∇_μ, which adds a correction term involving the *connection coefficients* $\Gamma^\rho{}_{\mu\sigma}$ (Carroll eq. 3.5):

$$\boxed{\nabla_\mu V^\nu = \partial_\mu V^\nu + \Gamma^\nu{}_{\mu\lambda} V^\lambda} \tag{2.7}$$

For a one-form (Carroll eq. 3.16):

$$\nabla_\mu \omega_\nu = \partial_\mu \omega_\nu - \Gamma^\lambda{}_{\mu\nu}\, \omega_\lambda \,. \tag{2.8}$$

For a tensor of arbitrary rank the rule is one term $+\Gamma$ for each upper index and one term $-\Gamma$ for each lower index (Carroll eq. 3.17).

The connection coefficients are *not* tensors, since they transform inhomogeneously (Carroll eq. 3.10), but the covariant derivative $\nabla_\mu V^\nu$ *is* a tensor.

2.5 Christoffel Symbols

In GR we demand two additional properties of the connection: that it be *torsion-free*, $\Gamma^\lambda{}_{\mu\nu} = \Gamma^\lambda{}_{\nu\mu}$, and *metric compatible*, $\nabla_\rho g_{\mu\nu} = 0$. These two conditions uniquely determine the *Christoffel symbols* (also called the Levi-Civita connection; Carroll eq. 3.27):

$$\boxed{\Gamma^\sigma{}_{\mu\nu} = \frac{1}{2}\, g^{\sigma\rho}\big(\partial_\mu g_{\nu\rho} + \partial_\nu g_{\rho\mu} - \partial_\rho g_{\mu\nu}\big)} \tag{2.9}$$

This is one of the central formulas of GR: given any metric, we can compute the Christoffel symbols and from them all of the geometry.

Example 2.5.1. For the plane in polar coordinates, $ds^2 = dr^2 + r^2 d\phi^2$ (Example 2.2.2), the only nonvanishing Christoffel symbols are (Carroll eqs. 3.29–3.31):

$$\Gamma^r{}_{\phi\phi} = -r \,, \qquad \Gamma^\phi{}_{r\phi} = \Gamma^\phi{}_{\phi r} = \frac{1}{r} \,. \tag{2.10}$$

We derive these and more general cases in `christoffel_symbols.wl`.

2.6 Parallel Transport

In flat space we can freely slide a vector from one point to another while keeping it "constant." On a curved manifold this is no longer unambiguous, because the result depends on the path taken.

The notion of keeping a vector constant along a curve $x^\mu(\lambda)$ is formalized as *parallel transport*: a vector V^μ is parallel-transported if (Carroll eq. 3.40)

$$\frac{dV^\mu}{d\lambda} + \Gamma^\mu{}_{\rho\sigma}\frac{dx^\rho}{d\lambda}V^\sigma = 0\,. \tag{2.11}$$

A consequence of metric compatibility is that parallel transport preserves the inner product: if V^μ and W^μ are both parallel-transported along a curve, then $g_{\mu\nu}V^\mu W^\nu = \text{const}$ (Carroll eq. 3.42).

On the 2-sphere, parallel transporting a vector around a closed loop rotates the vector, by an angle proportional to the enclosed area and the curvature (Figure 2.1).

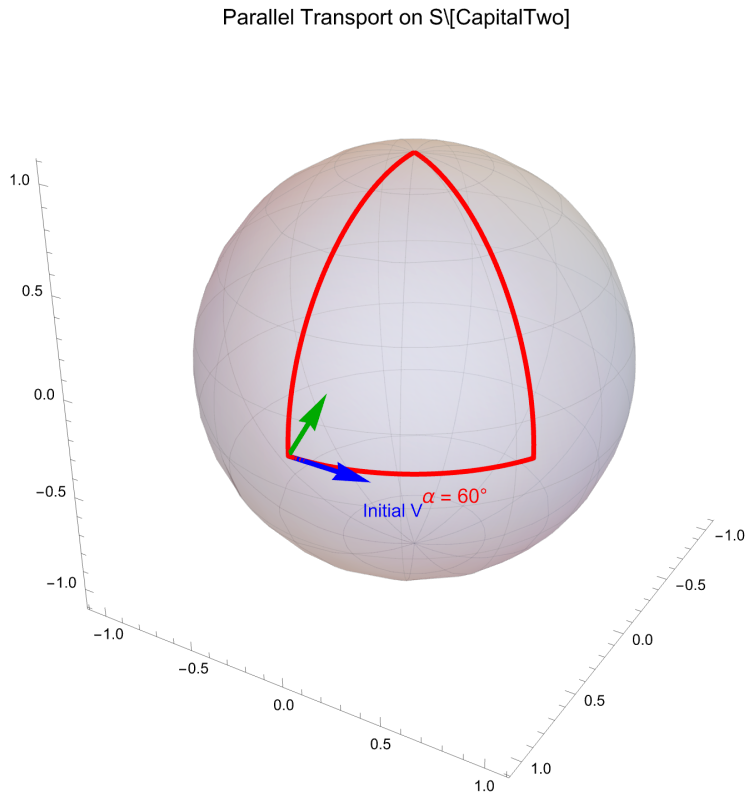


Figure 2.1: Parallel transport on the 2-sphere. A vector (blue) initially pointing east at the equator is transported north to the pole along $\phi = 0$, then south along $\phi = 60$ back to the equator. The final vector (green) has rotated by $\alpha = 60$ — equal to the solid angle enclosed by the path. This rotation is a direct manifestation of curvature. (cf. Carroll Fig. 3.2)

This is also visualized interactively in `curved_surfaces.nb`.

2.7 The Geodesic Equation

A *geodesic* is the curved-space generalization of a straight line: it is the path that parallel-transports its own tangent vector. Setting $V^\mu = dx^\mu/d\lambda$ in (2.11), we obtain the *geodesic*

equation (Carroll eq. 3.44):

$$\boxed{\frac{d^2x^\mu}{d\lambda^2} + \Gamma^\mu{}_{\rho\sigma}\frac{dx^\rho}{d\lambda}\frac{dx^\sigma}{d\lambda} = 0} \tag{2.12}$$

This can equivalently be derived by extremizing the proper time/interval functional (Carroll Sec. 3.3, eqs. 3.45–3.55; Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.60).

Geodesics inherit the classification of the interval. *Timelike geodesics* ($ds^2 < 0$) are the paths of freely falling massive particles and are parameterized by proper time τ; *null geodesics* ($ds^2 = 0$) are the paths of light rays, parameterized by an affine parameter λ; and *spacelike geodesics* ($ds^2 > 0$) are curves of shortest spatial distance. The character (timelike, null or spacelike) is preserved along the geodesic (Carroll Sec. 3.4).

In flat space with Cartesian coordinates, $\Gamma^\mu{}_{\rho\sigma} = 0$, so the geodesic equation reduces to $d^2x^\mu/d\lambda^2 = 0$, a straight line, as expected.

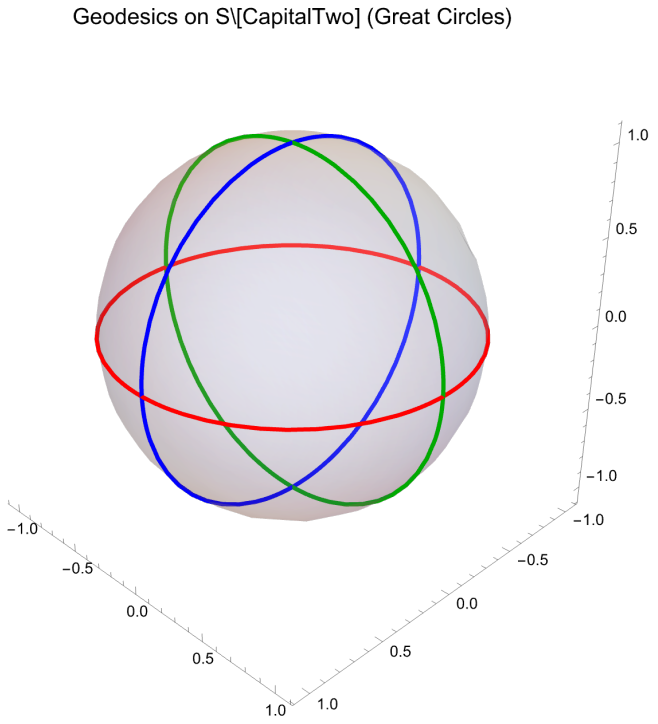


Figure 2.2: Geodesics on the 2-sphere are great circles. Three orthogonal great circles are shown, illustrating that the shortest path between any two points on a sphere follows a great circle arc.

2.8 Curvature Tensors

The *Riemann curvature tensor* $R^\rho{}_{\sigma\mu\nu}$ measures how much parallel transport around a closed loop rotates a vector. It is defined by (Carroll eq. 3.4)

$$\boxed{R^\rho{}_{\sigma\mu\nu} = \partial_\mu\Gamma^\rho{}_{\nu\sigma} - \partial_\nu\Gamma^\rho{}_{\mu\sigma} + \Gamma^\rho{}_{\mu\lambda}\Gamma^\lambda{}_{\nu\sigma} - \Gamma^\rho{}_{\nu\lambda}\Gamma^\lambda{}_{\mu\sigma}} \tag{2.13}$$

A manifold is flat if and only if $R^{\rho}{}_{\sigma\mu\nu} = 0$ everywhere; curvature is characterized entirely by the Riemann tensor.

From the Riemann tensor we construct the *Ricci tensor* by contracting the 1st and 3rd indices,

$$R_{\mu\nu} = R^{\lambda}{}_{\mu\lambda\nu} \tag{2.14}$$

and the *Ricci scalar* as its trace,

$$R = g^{\mu\nu} R_{\mu\nu} \tag{2.15}$$

These are the quantities that appear in Einstein's field equation

$$R_{\mu\nu} - \frac{1}{2} R\, g_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G\, T_{\mu\nu}\,, \tag{2.16}$$

relating the curvature of spacetime (left side) to its matter and energy content (right side). Here $c = 1$; with factors of c restored the right-hand side reads $8\pi G\, T_{\mu\nu}/c^4$, the form used from Chapter 3 on.

Remark 2.8.1. The Riemann tensor in n dimensions has $n^2(n^2-1)/12$ independent components. In 4D spacetime, that is 20. In 2D, there is only 1, and the Gaussian curvature determines everything.

2.9 The Metric Determines Everything

We collect the chain of dependence established in this chapter:

Metric $g_{\mu\nu}$
↓ eq. (2.9)
Christoffel symbols $\Gamma^{\sigma}{}_{\mu\nu}$
↓ eq. (2.12) ↓ eq. (2.13)
Geodesics (particle paths) **Curvature** $R^{\rho}{}_{\sigma\mu\nu}$

The metric is thus the fundamental object in GR. Once $g_{\mu\nu}$ is known, everything else follows from it: how particles move, how light bends, and how spacetime curves.

For gravitational lensing the application is as follows: given the metric around a massive object (e.g., the Schwarzschild metric for a point mass), one solves the null geodesic equation to trace light rays and determine how images are formed.

2.10 Computation Cookbook: A Step-by-Step Guide

Computing the geometric quantities of GR by hand is a necessary part of learning the subject. This section gives explicit, algorithmic recipes for going from a metric to Christoffel symbols, to the Riemann tensor, to the Ricci tensor and scalar. The 2-sphere example is carried through in full, and `christoffel_symbols.wl` checks every result.

2.10.1 Algorithm: Christoffel Symbols from a Metric

Given a metric $g_{\mu\nu}$ in coordinates $\{x^\mu\}$, compute all Christoffel symbols $\Gamma^\sigma{}_{\mu\nu}$ as follows.

1. Write down the metric components: list every nonvanishing $g_{\mu\nu}$ and note which coordinates each component depends on. For a diagonal metric, the only nonvanishing components are $g_{11}, g_{22}, \ldots$

2. Compute the inverse metric $g^{\mu\nu}$. For a diagonal metric this is immediate: $g^{\mu\mu} = 1/g_{\mu\mu}$ (no sum), and all off-diagonal components vanish.

3. Compute the required partial derivatives. For each target symbol $\Gamma^\sigma{}_{\mu\nu}$ one needs the three derivatives
$$\partial_\mu g_{\nu\rho}, \quad \partial_\nu g_{\rho\mu}, \quad \partial_\rho g_{\mu\nu}$$
appearing in the Christoffel formula (2.9). Most of these vanish for diagonal metrics with few coordinate-dependent components.

4. Apply the formula
$$\Gamma^\sigma{}_{\mu\nu} = \frac{1}{2}\, g^{\sigma\rho}\big(\partial_\mu g_{\nu\rho} + \partial_\nu g_{\rho\mu} - \partial_\rho g_{\mu\nu}\big)$$
For a diagonal metric, the sum over ρ collapses to the single term $\rho = \sigma$ (since $g^{\sigma\rho} = 0$ for $\rho \neq \sigma$).

5. Use the symmetry $\Gamma^\sigma{}_{\mu\nu} = \Gamma^\sigma{}_{\nu\mu}$, so that only symbols with $\mu \leq \nu$ need be computed.

Remark 2.10.1 (Diagonal metric shortcut). For a diagonal metric $g_{\mu\nu} = \mathrm{diag}(g_{11}, g_{22}, \ldots)$, the nonvanishing Christoffel symbols come in only three types (no sum on repeated indices here):

$$\Gamma^\mu{}_{\mu\mu} = \frac{1}{2g_{\mu\mu}}\,\frac{\partial g_{\mu\mu}}{\partial x^\mu}\,, \tag{2.17}$$

$$\Gamma^\mu{}_{\mu\nu} = \Gamma^\mu{}_{\nu\mu} = \frac{1}{2g_{\mu\mu}}\,\frac{\partial g_{\mu\mu}}{\partial x^\nu} \qquad (\mu \neq \nu)\,, \tag{2.18}$$

$$\Gamma^\mu{}_{\nu\nu} = -\frac{1}{2g_{\mu\mu}}\,\frac{\partial g_{\nu\nu}}{\partial x^\mu} \qquad (\mu \neq \nu)\,. \tag{2.19}$$

All other components vanish. These formulas reduce the work considerably.

2.10.2 Algorithm: The Riemann Tensor from Christoffel Symbols

Given the Christoffel symbols, compute each component of $R^\rho{}_{\sigma\mu\nu}$ using (2.13):

$$R^\rho{}_{\sigma\mu\nu} = \partial_\mu \Gamma^\rho{}_{\nu\sigma} - \partial_\nu \Gamma^\rho{}_{\mu\sigma} + \Gamma^\rho{}_{\mu\lambda}\,\Gamma^\lambda{}_{\nu\sigma} - \Gamma^\rho{}_{\nu\lambda}\,\Gamma^\lambda{}_{\mu\sigma}$$

1. Use the index structure. The Riemann tensor is antisymmetric in its last two indices, $R^\rho{}_{\sigma\mu\nu} = -R^\rho{}_{\sigma\nu\mu}$, so only components with $\mu < \nu$ need be computed.

2. Take the partial derivatives of the Christoffel symbols. For each component, differentiate the relevant Christoffel symbols with respect to the coordinates x^μ and x^ν.

3. Evaluate the quadratic terms. For each component, sum over the dummy index λ in the two $\Gamma\Gamma$ products. Only terms in which *both* Christoffel symbols in the product are nonzero contribute.

4. Count the independent components. In n dimensions, the Riemann tensor has $n^2(n^2-1)/12$ independent components: 1 in 2D, 6 in 3D, 20 in 4D. In 2D, the single independent component determines everything.

2.10.3 Algorithm: Ricci Tensor and Ricci Scalar

1. For the Ricci tensor, contract the first and third indices of the Riemann tensor:

$$R_{\sigma\nu} = R^{\lambda}{}_{\sigma\lambda\nu} = \sum_{\lambda} R^{\lambda}{}_{\sigma\lambda\nu}\,.$$

   In 2D this is a single sum; in 4D it is a sum of four terms.

2. For the Ricci scalar, trace with the inverse metric:

$$R = g^{\sigma\nu} R_{\sigma\nu} = \sum_{\sigma} g^{\sigma\sigma} R_{\sigma\sigma}$$

   (the last equality holding for a diagonal metric).

2.10.4 Worked Example: The 2-Sphere

We carry out the *complete* calculation for the 2-sphere metric

$$ds^2 = R^2\,d\theta^2 + R^2\sin^2\theta\,d\phi^2\,, \tag{2.20}$$

with coordinates $x^1 = \theta$, $x^2 = \phi$.

Step 1: Metric components.

$$g_{\theta\theta} = R^2\,, \qquad g_{\phi\phi} = R^2\sin^2\theta\,, \qquad g_{\theta\phi} = g_{\phi\theta} = 0\,.$$

Only $g_{\phi\phi}$ depends on a coordinate (θ).

Step 2: Inverse metric.

$$g^{\theta\theta} = \frac{1}{R^2}\,, \qquad g^{\phi\phi} = \frac{1}{R^2\sin^2\theta}\,.$$

Step 3: Partial derivatives of the metric. The only nonvanishing derivative is

$$\partial_\theta g_{\phi\phi} = R^2 \cdot 2\sin\theta\cos\theta = R^2\sin 2\theta\,.$$

All other $\partial_\mu g_{\nu\rho} = 0$.

Step 4: Christoffel symbols. We use the diagonal shortcut formulas (2.17)–(2.19) type by type. For type (2.17) ($\Gamma^{\mu}{}_{\mu\mu}$), both $\partial_\theta g_{\theta\theta} = 0$ and $\partial_\phi g_{\phi\phi} = 0$, so $\Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\theta\theta} = 0$ and $\Gamma^{\phi}{}_{\phi\phi} = 0$. For type (2.18) ($\Gamma^{\mu}{}_{\mu\nu}$ with $\mu \neq \nu$),

$$\Gamma^{\phi}{}_{\phi\theta} = \Gamma^{\phi}{}_{\theta\phi} = \frac{1}{2g_{\phi\phi}}\,\partial_\theta g_{\phi\phi} = \frac{R^2 \sin 2\theta}{2R^2 \sin^2\theta} = \frac{\cos\theta}{\sin\theta} = \cot\theta\,.$$

Also $\Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\theta\phi} = \frac{1}{2g_{\theta\theta}}\partial_\phi g_{\theta\theta} = 0$. For type (2.19) ($\Gamma^{\mu}{}_{\nu\nu}$ with $\mu \neq \nu$),

$$\Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\phi\phi} = -\frac{1}{2g_{\theta\theta}}\,\partial_\theta g_{\phi\phi} = -\frac{R^2 \sin 2\theta}{2R^2} = -\sin\theta\cos\theta\,.$$

Also $\Gamma^{\phi}{}_{\theta\theta} = -\frac{1}{2g_{\phi\phi}}\partial_\phi g_{\theta\theta} = 0$. The nonvanishing Christoffel symbols are therefore

$$\boxed{\Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\phi\phi} = -\sin\theta\cos\theta\,, \qquad \Gamma^{\phi}{}_{\theta\phi} = \Gamma^{\phi}{}_{\phi\theta} = \cot\theta} \tag{2.21}$$

Verify this with `christoffel_symbols.wl`.

Step 5: Riemann tensor. In 2D there is only one independent component. We compute $R^{\theta}{}_{\phi\theta\phi}$ (i.e., $\rho = \theta$, $\sigma = \phi$, $\mu = \theta$, $\nu = \phi$):

$$\begin{aligned}
R^{\theta}{}_{\phi\theta\phi} &= \partial_\theta \Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\phi\phi} - \partial_\phi \Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\theta\phi} + \Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\theta\lambda}\,\Gamma^{\lambda}{}_{\phi\phi} - \Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\phi\lambda}\,\Gamma^{\lambda}{}_{\theta\phi} \\
&= \partial_\theta(-\sin\theta\cos\theta) - 0 + \Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\theta\theta}\,\Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\phi\phi} + \Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\theta\phi}\,\Gamma^{\phi}{}_{\phi\phi} \\
&\quad - \Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\phi\theta}\,\Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\theta\phi} - \Gamma^{\theta}{}_{\phi\phi}\,\Gamma^{\phi}{}_{\theta\phi} \\
&= (-\cos^2\theta + \sin^2\theta) + 0 + 0 - 0 - (-\sin\theta\cos\theta)(\cot\theta) \\
&= -\cos^2\theta + \sin^2\theta + \cos^2\theta \\
&= \sin^2\theta\,.
\end{aligned} \tag{2.22}$$

Step 6: Ricci tensor.

$$R_{\phi\phi} = R^{\lambda}{}_{\phi\lambda\phi} = R^{\theta}{}_{\phi\theta\phi} + R^{\phi}{}_{\phi\phi\phi} = \sin^2\theta + 0 = \sin^2\theta\,. \tag{2.23}$$

For $R_{\theta\theta}$, we need $R^{\phi}{}_{\theta\phi\theta}$. Lower the index and use the antisymmetry of the fully lowered tensor in each index pair, $R_{\phi\theta\phi\theta} = -R_{\theta\phi\phi\theta} = +R_{\theta\phi\theta\phi}$:

$$R^{\phi}{}_{\theta\phi\theta} = g^{\phi\phi}\,R_{\phi\theta\phi\theta} = g^{\phi\phi}\,R_{\theta\phi\theta\phi} = g^{\phi\phi}\,g_{\theta\theta}\,R^{\theta}{}_{\phi\theta\phi} = \frac{R^2\sin^2\theta}{R^2\sin^2\theta} = 1\,,$$

so

$$R_{\theta\theta} = R^{\lambda}{}_{\theta\lambda\theta} = R^{\theta}{}_{\theta\theta\theta} + R^{\phi}{}_{\theta\phi\theta} = 0 + 1 = 1\,. \tag{2.24}$$

Step 7: Ricci scalar.

$$R = g^{\theta\theta}R_{\theta\theta} + g^{\phi\phi}R_{\phi\phi} = \frac{1}{R^2}\cdot 1 + \frac{1}{R^2\sin^2\theta}\cdot\sin^2\theta = \frac{1}{R^2} + \frac{1}{R^2} = \boxed{\frac{2}{R^2}}\,. \tag{2.25}$$

This is the standard result: a sphere of radius R has constant positive Gaussian curvature $K = 1/R^2$, and in 2D the Ricci scalar equals $2K$.

2.10.5 Tips and Tricks

Most metrics encountered in GR courses are diagonal, and for these eqs. (2.17)–(2.19) are quicker than the full Christoffel formula. A Christoffel symbol $\Gamma^{\sigma}{}_{\mu\nu}$ vanishes whenever the relevant partial derivatives of the metric are all zero, so before computing it one asks whether $g_{\mu\nu}$ depends on x^{σ} and whether $g_{\sigma\mu}$ depends on x^{ν}; if neither does, the symbol is likely zero. It helps to count before computing: in n dimensions there are $n^2(n+1)/2$ potentially independent Christoffel symbols (accounting for the $\mu\nu$ symmetry), 6 in 2D and 40 in 4D, and most of them are zero for typical metrics, so the nonvanishing ones should be identified first. If the metric is independent of a coordinate x^{α} (a Killing symmetry), many Christoffel symbols simplify or vanish; in the 2-sphere example, the metric is ϕ-independent, which removes several terms at once. Finally, hand calculations should always be checked with `christoffel_symbols.wl`, since sign and index errors in these computations are common at every level of experience.

2.11 Standard Computational Tools

The hand-rolled functions defined in `christoffel_symbols.wl` are pedagogically valuable, since they make the connection between the textbook formula and the computation explicit. Mathematica also provides built-in tools for GR calculations, which we describe here for reference.

Wolfram Function Repository. The `ResourceFunction` interface provides one-liner access to several GR computations:

- `ResourceFunction["ChristoffelSymbol"][g, coords]` returns the Christoffel symbols as a plain $n \times n \times n$ array, identical in format to our custom function. We have verified that this matches our code exactly for both the 2-sphere and Schwarzschild metrics (see `verify_against_textbooks.wl`).
- `ResourceFunction["RicciScalar"][g, coords]` returns the Ricci scalar. It works for simple metrics (e.g., the 2-sphere) but may not fully evaluate for more complex ones.
- `ResourceFunction["RiemannTensor"]` and `ResourceFunction["RicciTensor"]` exist but return opaque tensor objects rather than plain arrays, which makes them difficult to use for further computation.

Remark 2.11.1. For this reason, we use `ResourceFunction["ChristoffelSymbol"]` as a cross-check throughout the tutorial, but maintain our custom functions for the full Christoffel $\to$ Riemann $\to$ Ricci $\to$ scalar pipeline, since the built-in ResourceFunction versions of the higher-order tensors do not return plain arrays. All results have been cross-validated against textbook equations; see `Mathematica/verify_against_textbooks.wl` for the complete test suite.

The xAct Package. For research-level tensor algebra in Mathematica, the `xAct` suite (available at `http://www.xact.es/`) is the standard tool. Its component packages include `xTensor` for abstract tensor algebra (index manipulation, symmetry, canonicalization), `xCoba`

for component computations in coordinate bases, and `xPert` for perturbation theory (useful for linearized gravity, Chapter 5). xAct is strongest at abstract manipulations: proving tensor identities, computing perturbation expansions, and working with complicated index symmetries. It is less convenient for the "plug in a metric, get numbers out" workflow used in this tutorial, which is why we do not use it as our primary tool. For research involving heavy tensor algebra (higher-order perturbation theory, non-trivial spacetimes, or abstract index calculations), xAct is the appropriate tool.

Installation:

```
(* Download from http://www.xact.es/download.html *)
(* Unpack into ~/Library/Wolfram/Applications/ (macOS) *)
(* Then: *)
Needs["xAct`xTensor`"]
Needs["xAct`xCoba`"]
```

2.12 Summary

A manifold is locally flat but may have global curvature, and the metric $g_{\mu\nu}(x)$ encodes the geometry. The covariant derivative ∇_μ generalizes the partial derivative to curved spacetime, using the connection $\Gamma^\sigma{}_{\mu\nu}$. The Christoffel symbols are uniquely determined by the metric via (2.9) once the connection is required to be torsion-free and metric-compatible. Parallel transport depends on the path, and this path-dependence is measured by the Riemann curvature tensor. Geodesics, the paths that parallel-transport their own tangent vector, are the trajectories of freely falling particles and light rays. Einstein's equation relates curvature ($R_{\mu\nu}$) to matter content ($T_{\mu\nu}$).

2.13 Problems

Exercise 2.13.1. Compute all nonvanishing Christoffel symbols for the 2-sphere metric $ds^2 = R^2(d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta\, d\phi^2)$ by hand, then verify with `christoffel_symbols.wl`.

Exercise 2.13.2. For the flat plane in polar coordinates, $ds^2 = dr^2 + r^2 d\phi^2$:

(a) Compute the Christoffel symbols.

(b) Compute the Riemann tensor and verify that the space is flat ($R^\rho{}_{\sigma\mu\nu} = 0$).

(c) Write down the geodesic equations and show that straight lines in Cartesian coordinates ($x = a + b\lambda$, $y = c + d\lambda$) satisfy them.

Exercise 2.13.3. For the 2-sphere metric, compute:

(a) The Riemann tensor $R^\theta{}_{\phi\theta\phi}$.

(b) The Ricci tensor $R_{\theta\theta}$ and $R_{\phi\phi}$.

(c) The Ricci scalar R. Show that $R = 2/R^2$ (constant positive curvature, as expected for a sphere of radius R).

Exercise 2.13.4. A vector initially pointing east is parallel-transported from the equator of a unit sphere ($R = 1$) along the following path: north along the meridian $\phi = 0$ to the pole, then south along $\phi = \alpha$ back to the equator. Show that the vector has rotated by angle α. (Hint: solve the parallel transport equation (2.11) along each segment, or use the geometric argument that the rotation equals the solid angle enclosed.)

Exercise 2.13.5. Show that great circles are geodesics of the 2-sphere. Specifically, show that the equator $\theta = \pi/2$, $\phi = \lambda$ satisfies the geodesic equation (2.12) with the Christoffel symbols from Exercise 2.13.1.

Chapter 3

The Schwarzschild Solution

> *In GR, the unique spherically symmetric vacuum solution is the Schwarzschild metric; it is second only to Minkowski space in the list of important spacetimes.* — Sean Carroll, *Spacetime and Geometry*

Having developed the general machinery of differential geometry in Chapter 2, we now apply it to the most important exact solution in GR, the *Schwarzschild metric*, which describes the spacetime geometry outside any spherically symmetric, non-rotating mass. This metric governs the gravitational field of stars, planets, and non-rotating black holes, and is the starting point for the treatment of gravitational lensing.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `schwarzschild_metric.wl`: derive and verify the Schwarzschild metric: compute Christoffel symbols, Riemann tensor, verify $R_{\mu\nu} = 0$, and compute the Kretschmann scalar
- `gravitational_redshift.nb`: interactive plots of gravitational redshift, time dilation, and Flamm's paraboloid embedding diagram

3.1 The Equivalence Principle

Before deriving the Schwarzschild solution we address a prior question: why should gravity be described by the geometry of spacetime at all? The answer lies in the *equivalence principle*, the physical principle on which general relativity is founded.

3.1.1 The Weak Equivalence Principle

The oldest form of the equivalence principle dates back to Galileo: all objects fall at the same rate, regardless of their composition or internal structure. More precisely, the *weak equivalence principle* (WEP) states that the *inertial mass* m_i (which appears in Newton's second law, $F = m_i\, a$) is equal to the *gravitational mass* m_g (which appears in Newton's law of gravitation, $F = m_g\, g$):

$$m_i = m_g\,. \tag{3.1}$$

This equality has no explanation within Newtonian mechanics, where it is an empirical fact. It has been tested to high precision: Eötvös-type torsion-balance experiments (Dicke, Braginsky, and the Eöt-Wash group) verified it to better than one part in 10^{13}, and the MICROSCOPE satellite mission (2022) extended the limit by two orders of magnitude:

$$\frac{|m_i - m_g|}{m_g} < 10^{-15}\,. \tag{3.2}$$

Einstein took the universality of free fall to be no accident and elevated it to a principle.

3.1.2 Einstein's Elevator

Einstein's step was to treat the WEP as a fundamental principle rather than an empirical coincidence. He expressed this through the *elevator thought experiment*:

> *An observer in a closed, windowless elevator cannot distinguish between the following two situations:*
>
> (a) *The elevator is at rest on the surface of the Earth, where the gravitational acceleration is g.*
> (b) *The elevator is in empty space, accelerating upward at g.*

Conversely, an observer in free fall in a gravitational field (the "falling elevator") experiences the same conditions as an observer floating in empty space, far from any gravitating body. Dropped objects float alongside the observer, and no local experiment can detect the gravitational field.

This equivalence between gravity and acceleration is *local*: it holds in a sufficiently small region of spacetime, in which tidal effects (variations of the gravitational field across the elevator) can be neglected.

3.1.3 The Strong Equivalence Principle

Einstein extended the elevator argument to its fullest form as the *strong equivalence principle* (SEP):

> *The results of any local experiment (gravitational or not) in a freely falling reference frame are indistinguishable from those of the same experiment in special relativity.*

If a freely falling observer experiences special relativity locally, then gravity cannot be a "force" acting in Minkowski spacetime; it must instead be encoded in the geometry of spacetime itself. Different freely falling observers at different locations each see flat (Minkowski) spacetime locally, but the global structure connecting these local frames is curved. Gravity is the curvature of spacetime.

3.1.4 From the Equivalence Principle to Geodesics

The equivalence principle connects directly to the mathematical framework developed in Chapter 2. A freely falling object experiences no forces in its local (freely falling) frame, and so follows a "straight line" through its local Minkowski patch of spacetime. A straight line in a curved manifold is a geodesic (Chapter 2, Section 2.7).

Therefore the equivalence principle implies that *freely falling particles follow geodesics of the spacetime metric*. This is the physical content of the geodesic equation:

$$\frac{d^2x^\mu}{d\tau^2} + \Gamma^\mu{}_{\alpha\beta}\frac{dx^\alpha}{d\tau}\frac{dx^\beta}{d\tau} = 0\,. \tag{3.3}$$

In Newtonian language, the Christoffel symbols $\Gamma^\mu{}_{\alpha\beta}$ play the role of gravitational "forces," but in GR they are geometric quantities which describe how the coordinate system (not the particle) is "accelerating."

Remark 3.1.1. The equivalence principle tells us that gravity curves spacetime, but it does not tell us how the curvature is related to the matter content. That information requires Einstein's field equations $G_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G\,T_{\mu\nu}/c^4$, which were stated in Chapter 2 and whose simplest vacuum solution ($T_{\mu\nu} = 0$) we derive in this chapter. The field equations will be used throughout the remaining chapters as the foundation for gravitational lensing.

3.2 The Most General Spherically Symmetric Metric

We seek the metric outside a static, spherically symmetric mass distribution. The most general line element consistent with these symmetries can be written (Carroll eq. 5.11; cf. Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.64):

$$ds^2 = -e^{2\alpha(r)}dt^2 + e^{2\beta(r)}dr^2 + r^2\,d\Omega^2\,, \tag{3.4}$$

where $d\Omega^2 = d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta\,d\phi^2$ is the metric on the unit 2-sphere, and $\alpha(r)$ and $\beta(r)$ are functions to be determined from Einstein's equation.

Remark 3.2.1. The "static" assumption means the metric is independent of t and has no $dt\,dr$ cross terms. "Spherically symmetric" means the angular part takes the form $r^2d\Omega^2$, with r chosen so that spheres at constant r have area $4\pi r^2$.

3.3 Deriving the Schwarzschild Metric

We solve Einstein's vacuum equation $R_{\mu\nu} = 0$ for the metric (3.4). The strategy follows Carroll Sec. 5.1.

Step 1: Christoffel symbols. The nonvanishing Christoffel symbols for (3.4) are (Carroll eq. 5.12):

$$\begin{aligned}
&\Gamma^t{}_{tr} = \alpha' \,, \quad \Gamma^r{}_{tt} = e^{2(\alpha-\beta)}\alpha' \,, \quad \Gamma^r{}_{rr} = \beta' \,, \\
&\Gamma^r{}_{\theta\theta} = -r\, e^{-2\beta} \,, \quad \Gamma^r{}_{\phi\phi} = -r\, e^{-2\beta}\sin^2\theta \,, \\
&\Gamma^\theta{}_{r\theta} = \Gamma^\phi{}_{r\phi} = \frac{1}{r} \,, \quad \Gamma^\theta{}_{\phi\phi} = -\sin\theta\cos\theta \,, \quad \Gamma^\phi{}_{\theta\phi} = \cot\theta \,,
\end{aligned} \tag{3.5}$$

where primes denote d/dr.

Step 2: Ricci tensor. The Ricci tensor components are (Carroll eq. 5.14)

$$R_{tt} = e^{2(\alpha-\beta)}\left[\alpha'' + (\alpha')^2 - \alpha'\beta' + \frac{2}{r}\alpha'\right] , \tag{3.6}$$

$$R_{rr} = -\alpha'' - (\alpha')^2 + \alpha'\beta' + \frac{2}{r}\beta' \,, \tag{3.7}$$

$$R_{\theta\theta} = e^{-2\beta}\big[r(\beta' - \alpha') - 1\big] + 1 \,, \tag{3.8}$$

$$R_{\phi\phi} = R_{\theta\theta}\sin^2\theta \,. \tag{3.9}$$

Step 3: Solve $R_{\mu\nu} = 0$. From $e^{-2(\alpha-\beta)}R_{tt} + R_{rr} = 0$ we obtain $\frac{2}{r}(\alpha' + \beta') = 0$, hence (Carroll eq. 5.17)

$$\alpha = -\beta + \text{const} \,. \tag{3.10}$$

By rescaling the time coordinate we set the constant to zero, so that $\alpha = -\beta$.

Setting $R_{\theta\theta} = 0$ then gives (Carroll eq. 5.18)

$$e^{2\alpha}(1 + 2r\alpha') = 1 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \partial_r(r\, e^{2\alpha}) = 1 \,. \tag{3.11}$$

Integrating,

$$e^{2\alpha} = 1 - \frac{R_S}{r} \,, \tag{3.12}$$

where R_S is an integration constant.

Step 4: Identify R_S. In the weak-field limit ($r \to \infty$), the metric must reduce to $g_{tt} \approx -(1 + 2\Phi/c^2)$ with $\Phi = -GM/r$. Comparing with $g_{tt} = -(1 - R_S/r)$, we identify the *Schwarzschild radius* (Carroll eq. 5.23):

$$\boxed{R_S = \frac{2GM}{c^2}} \tag{3.13}$$

Result: The Schwarzschild Metric.

$$\boxed{ds^2 = -\left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right)c^2\, dt^2 + \left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right)^{-1} dr^2 + r^2\, d\Omega^2} \tag{3.14}$$

This is the unique vacuum solution with spherical symmetry (Birkhoff's theorem; Carroll Sec. 5.2). We verify $R_{\mu\nu} = 0$ symbolically in `schwarzschild_metric.wl`.

3.4 Birkhoff's Theorem

Birkhoff's theorem states that the Schwarzschild metric is the *unique* spherically symmetric vacuum solution to Einstein's equation. Consequently even a time-dependent spherically symmetric source (e.g., a pulsating star) produces a static exterior metric (Carroll Sec. 5.2).

This is the GR analogue of Newton's shell theorem: the gravitational field outside a spherically symmetric mass depends only on the total enclosed mass M, not on how the mass is distributed.

3.5 Gravitational Time Dilation

A clock at radial coordinate r in the Schwarzschild spacetime runs at a rate different from a clock at infinity. For a stationary clock ($dr = d\theta = d\phi = 0$), the proper time is related to coordinate time by (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.65):

$$d\tau = \sqrt{1 - \frac{R_S}{r}}\, dt\,. \tag{3.15}$$

Since $\sqrt{1 - R_S/r} < 1$ for $r > R_S$, clocks closer to the mass run slower than clocks farther away. At $r = R_S$ the time dilation becomes infinite; this surface is the event horizon.

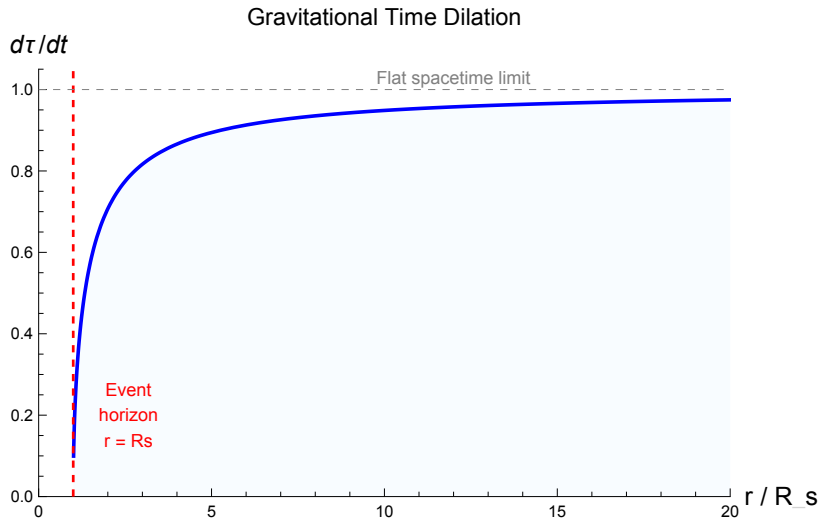


Figure 3.1: Gravitational time dilation factor $d\tau/dt = \sqrt{1 - R_S/r}$ as a function of r/R_S. Clocks near the horizon ($r \to R_S$) are dramatically slowed. Far from the mass ($r \gg R_S$), the factor approaches unity (flat spacetime).

3.6 Gravitational Redshift

A photon emitted at radius $r_{\rm em}$ with frequency $\nu_{\rm em}$ is observed at $r_{\rm obs} \to \infty$ with frequency

$$\frac{\nu_{\rm obs}}{\nu_{\rm em}} = \frac{\sqrt{1 - R_S/r_{\rm em}}}{\sqrt{1 - R_S/r_{\rm obs}}} \xrightarrow{r_{\rm obs}\to\infty} \sqrt{1 - \frac{R_S}{r_{\rm em}}}\,. \tag{3.16}$$

Since $\nu_{\rm obs} < \nu_{\rm em}$, the photon is *redshifted* as it climbs out of the gravitational potential well. The gravitational redshift parameter is

$$z_{\rm grav} = \frac{\nu_{\rm em}}{\nu_{\rm obs}} - 1 = \left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r_{\rm em}}\right)^{-1/2} - 1\,. \tag{3.17}$$

In the weak-field limit ($R_S/r \ll 1$) this reduces to $z_{\rm grav} \approx GM/(rc^2)$ (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.63).

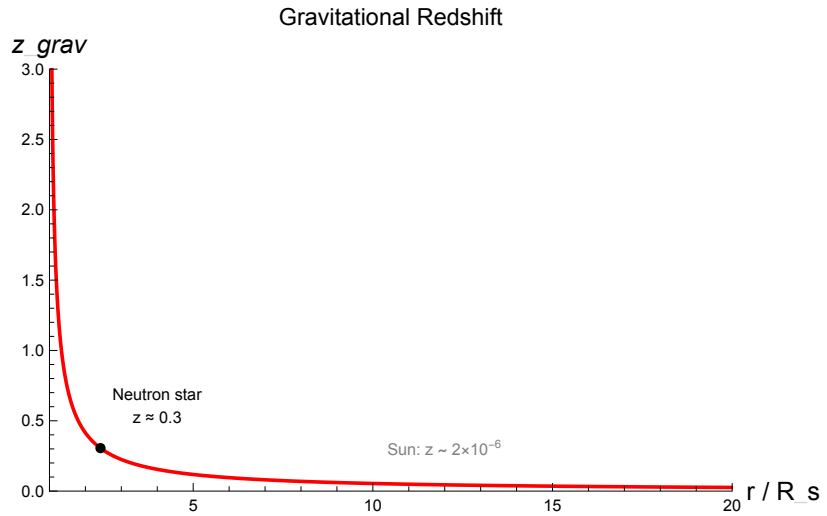


Figure 3.2: Gravitational redshift $z_{\rm grav}$ as a function of emission radius r/R_S. The redshift diverges at the horizon. The black dot marks a typical neutron star ($r/R_S \approx 2.4$, $z \approx 0.3$). For the Sun, $z \approx 2.1 \times 10^{-6}$.

Remark 3.6.1. The gravitational redshift was one of the three classical tests of GR proposed by Einstein, along with the perihelion precession of Mercury and the bending of light. It has been measured to high precision using atomic clocks at different altitudes (e.g., Pound–Rebka experiment, 1959; GPS satellite corrections).

3.7 The Event Horizon and Singularities

The Schwarzschild metric has two apparent singularities, at $r = 0$ and at $r = R_S$, and their nature is quite different (Carroll Sec. 5.3).

$r = R_S$ **(coordinate singularity).** The metric components diverge, but this is a coordinate artifact. The curvature remains finite, and the geometry is smooth. In appropriate coordinates (e.g., Eddington–Finkelstein or Kruskal–Szekeres), the metric is regular at $r = R_S$. Nevertheless $r = R_S$ is the *event horizon*: once a particle crosses it, it can never return.

$r = 0$ **(true singularity).** This is a genuine physical singularity at which the curvature becomes infinite. This can be confirmed with a curvature invariant, the *Kretschmann scalar*

$$K = R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}\, R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma} = \frac{12\, R_S^2}{r^6} = \frac{48\, G^2 M^2}{c^4\, r^6}\,. \tag{3.18}$$

which diverges as $r \to 0$ but is finite at $r = R_S$, so that only $r = 0$ is a true singularity. We verify eq. (3.18) in `schwarzschild_metric.wl`.

3.8 Inside the Event Horizon: The Coordinate Swap

The Schwarzschild metric (3.14) describes spacetime outside a spherical mass, but it also describes the region $r < R_S$. A brief look at this interior clarifies what the Schwarzschild radius means physically.

3.8.1 The Signature Flip

The Schwarzschild line element is

$$ds^2 = -\left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right) c^2\, dt^2 + \left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right)^{-1} dr^2 + r^2\, d\Omega^2\,.$$

Outside the horizon ($r > R_S$), the factor $f(r) \equiv 1 - R_S/r$ is positive, so $g_{tt} < 0$ (timelike) and $g_{rr} > 0$ (spacelike).

Inside the horizon ($r < R_S$), this factor becomes *negative*, $f(r) < 0$. Consequently $g_{tt} = -f(r)\, c^2 > 0$, so the t direction is now spacelike, while $g_{rr} = f(r)^{-1} < 0$, so the r direction is now timelike. The roles of r and t have swapped: inside the horizon, r is a time coordinate and t is a space coordinate.

3.8.2 Physical Meaning: The Singularity Is a Moment in Time

Since r is timelike inside the horizon, decreasing r is the *future direction*. Every future-directed worldline must have $dr < 0$; the singularity at $r = 0$ is not a place that can be steered away from but a *moment in time* that all interior observers inevitably reach.

Remark 3.8.1. An observer inside the horizon can no more avoid the singularity at $r = 0$ than avoid next Tuesday. This is the precise sense in which a black hole traps everything: the singularity does not pull the observer toward a point in space; rather, the future itself points toward $r = 0$.

3.8.3 Why Nothing Escapes: Tilting Light Cones

For radial null rays ($ds^2 = 0$, $d\Omega = 0$) in Schwarzschild coordinates,

$$\frac{dr}{dt} = \pm\, c\left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right). \tag{3.19}$$

Outside the horizon, the two signs give outgoing (+) and ingoing (−) light rays. At $r = R_S$, both solutions give $dr/dt = 0$: light "stands still" in these coordinates (a coordinate effect, not a physical one).

For $r < R_S$, the factor $(1 - R_S/r)$ is negative, so dr/dt has the *same sign* for both solutions: both "outgoing" and "ingoing" light rays have $dr < 0$ when $dt > 0$. All future-directed light cones therefore point toward smaller r, and no signal, not even light, can move to larger r inside the horizon.

3.8.4 Eddington–Finkelstein Coordinates

The pathological behavior at $r = R_S$ in Schwarzschild coordinates is a coordinate artifact. We can remove it by switching to *ingoing Eddington–Finkelstein coordinates*. We define the advanced time coordinate

$$v = t + \frac{r_*}{c}, \qquad r_* = r + R_S \ln\left|\frac{r}{R_S} - 1\right|, \tag{3.20}$$

where r_* (units of length) is the *tortoise coordinate* (Carroll eq. 5.108), and dividing by c makes r_*/c a time shift so that v is a well-defined time coordinate in SI units. In terms of (v, r, θ, ϕ), the Schwarzschild line element becomes (Carroll eq. 5.111)

$$\boxed{ds^2 = -\left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right) c^2\, dv^2 + 2c\, dv\, dr + r^2\, d\Omega^2} \tag{3.21}$$

This metric is manifestly regular at $r = R_S$: every component is finite and the determinant is nonzero. The horizon is the surface on which outgoing light rays have $dr/dv = 0$; ingoing rays cross it smoothly.

Remark 3.8.2. In the Eddington–Finkelstein form it is evident that the event horizon is a *one-way membrane*: ingoing light ($dv > 0$, $dr < 0$) crosses the horizon without incident, while outgoing light at $r = R_S$ remains at $r = R_S$ forever.

3.8.5 Relevance to Gravitational Lensing

Remark 3.8.3. For gravitational lensing we work exclusively in the region $r \gg R_S$, far outside the event horizon. Galaxy-mass lenses have $R_S \sim 0.1$ pc, while lensing occurs at scales of kiloparsecs. The black hole interior is therefore not directly relevant to lensing calculations. Nevertheless, the interior clarifies why the Schwarzschild radius is special (it is where light cones tip over) and what the boundary conditions of the exterior solution mean.

3.9 The Weak-Field Limit

For $r \gg R_S$, the Schwarzschild metric reduces to the *weak-field* form (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.71)

$$ds^2 \approx -\left(1 + \frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\right) c^2 dt^2 + \left(1 - \frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\right) \left[dr^2 + r^2\, d\Omega^2\right], \tag{3.22}$$

where $\Phi = -GM/r$ is the Newtonian gravitational potential. This form is valid for *any* weak gravitational field, not only the Schwarzschild case, and will be the starting point for deriving the deflection angle of light in Chapter 6.

Remark 3.9.1. In the weak-field metric (3.22) the spatial part is modified by a factor $(1-2\Phi/c^2)$ as well as the time part. Gravity therefore affects both the rate of clocks (time dilation) and the curvature of space. Both effects contribute equally to the bending of light, which is why GR gives twice the Newtonian deflection angle.

3.10 Isotropic Coordinates

The standard Schwarzschild coordinates (t, r, θ, ϕ) have an asymmetry: the radial and angular parts of the spatial metric carry different factors. In eq. (3.14), the dr^2 term is multiplied by $(1 - R_S/r)^{-1}$ while the angular part $r^2\, d\Omega^2$ has no such factor. The spatial part of the Schwarzschild metric is therefore *not* conformally flat, i.e. not proportional to the flat-space metric $dr^2 + r^2\, d\Omega^2$.

This can be remedied by introducing *isotropic coordinates*, in which the spatial metric *is* conformally flat.

3.10.1 The Isotropic Radial Coordinate

We define a new radial coordinate ρ by

$$r = \rho \left(1 + \frac{R_S}{4\rho}\right)^2. \tag{3.23}$$

This transformation is invertible for $r > R_S$ (i.e., outside the event horizon), with the inverse $\rho = \frac{1}{2}(r - R_S/2 + \sqrt{r^2 - r\,R_S})$.

3.10.2 The Schwarzschild Metric in Isotropic Form

In the coordinates (t, ρ, θ, ϕ), the Schwarzschild metric becomes

$$\boxed{ds^2 = -\left(\frac{1 - R_S/(4\rho)}{1 + R_S/(4\rho)}\right)^2 c^2\, dt^2 + \left(1 + \frac{R_S}{4\rho}\right)^4 \left(d\rho^2 + \rho^2\, d\Omega^2\right)} \tag{3.24}$$

The spatial part is now proportional to the flat-space metric $d\rho^2 + \rho^2\, d\Omega^2$, so the spatial geometry is *conformally flat*. The single conformal factor $(1 + R_S/(4\rho))^4$ multiplies all three spatial directions equally, hence the name "isotropic."

3.10.3 Weak-Field Expansion

To first order in R_S/ρ (the weak-field regime $\rho \gg R_S$), the isotropic metric reduces to

$$ds^2 \approx -\left(1 - \frac{R_S}{\rho}\right) c^2\, dt^2 + \left(1 + \frac{R_S}{\rho}\right) \left(d\rho^2 + \rho^2\, d\Omega^2\right). \tag{3.25}$$

Since $R_S = 2GM/c^2$, we have $R_S/\rho = 2GM/(\rho\, c^2) = -2\Phi/c^2$ where $\Phi = -GM/\rho$ is the Newtonian potential. Equation (3.25) is therefore

$$ds^2 \approx -\left(1 + \frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\right) c^2\, dt^2 + \left(1 - \frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\right) \left(d\rho^2 + \rho^2\, d\Omega^2\right), \tag{3.26}$$

which is the weak-field metric (3.22) with r replaced by ρ. (In the weak-field regime, r and ρ agree to leading order.)

3.10.4 Connection to the Linearized Gravity Formalism

This result connects the exact Schwarzschild solution (this chapter) to the linearized gravity approach (Chapter 5). In Chapter 5, the weak-field metric is derived from first principles as a perturbation of flat spacetime, $g_{\mu\nu} = \eta_{\mu\nu} + h_{\mu\nu}$ with $h_{00} = -2\Phi/c^2$ and $h_{ij} = -2\Phi/c^2\, \delta_{ij}$. The isotropic form (3.26) shows that the Schwarzschild solution, when expanded to first order, reproduces this linearized metric. The two descriptions, the exact solution in curved coordinates and perturbation theory in nearly flat coordinates, describe the same physics in different coordinate systems.

Remark 3.10.1. The isotropic form also exhibits the connection to the parameterized post-Newtonian (PPN) formalism and the factor of 2 in light deflection. In eq. (3.26), both $h_{00} = -2\Phi/c^2$ (time perturbation) and $h_{ij} = -2\Phi/c^2\, \delta_{ij}$ (space perturbation) are proportional to R_S/ρ, so the time and space perturbations are equal. In the PPN formalism, this equality corresponds to $\gamma_{\text{PPN}} = 1$, which is the GR prediction. As noted in the weak-field limit discussion, this equal contribution of time and space curvature is why GR predicts twice the Newtonian deflection angle for light.

3.11 Schwarzschild Radius for Astrophysical Objects

Object	**Mass**	R_S	**Actual Radius**
Earth	5.97×10^{24} kg	8.9 mm	6371 km
Sun	2×10^{30} kg	3.0 km	7×10^5 km
Neutron star	$1.4\, M_\odot$	4.1 km	~ 10 km
SgrA*	$4 \times 10^6\, M_\odot$	1.2×10^7 km	— (black hole)
Galaxy ($10^{12}\, M_\odot$)	$10^{12}\, M_\odot$	3×10^{12} km	—

For a galaxy-mass lens ($M \sim 10^{12}\, M_\odot$), $R_S \sim 0.1$ pc, far smaller than the galaxy itself. The weak-field limit is therefore appropriate for gravitational lensing by galaxies.

3.12 Embedding Diagram: Flamm's Paraboloid

To visualize the spatial curvature of the Schwarzschild geometry, we can embed the equatorial ($\theta = \pi/2$) spatial slice in 3D Euclidean space. At constant time t, the spatial metric on the equatorial plane is

$$dl^2 = \left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right)^{-1} dr^2 + r^2\, d\phi^2 \,. \tag{3.27}$$

Embedding this as a surface of revolution $z(r)$ in cylindrical coordinates (r, ϕ, z), for which $dl^2 = (1 + z'^2)dr^2 + r^2 d\phi^2$, we find

$$z(r) = 2\sqrt{R_S}\,\sqrt{r - R_S}\,, \tag{3.28}$$

which is *Flamm's paraboloid* (Figure 3.3).

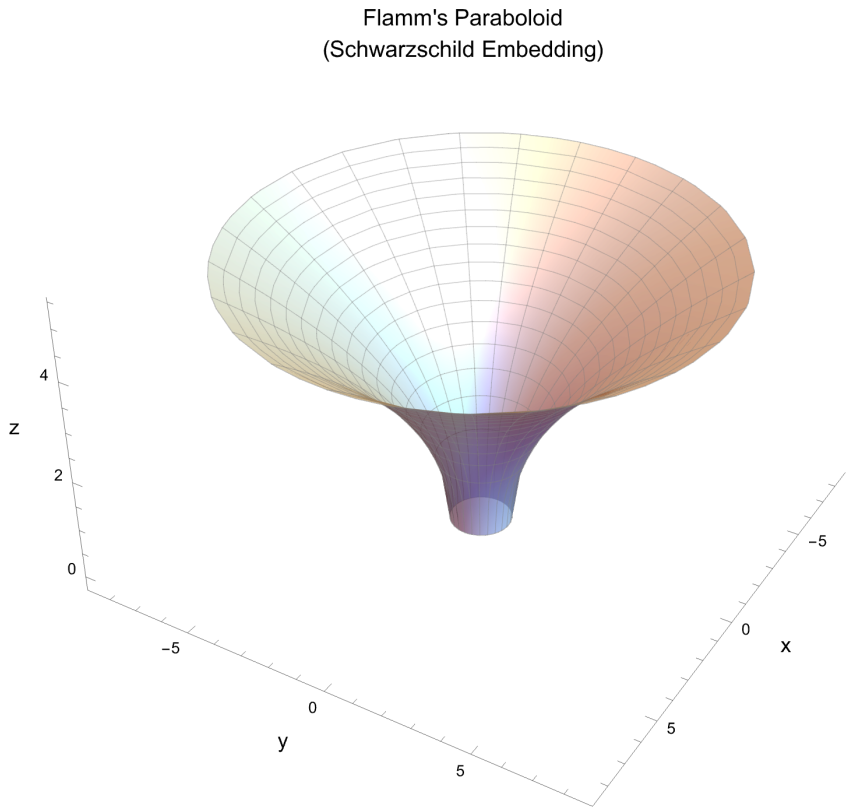


Figure 3.3: Flamm's paraboloid: the equatorial spatial geometry of the Schwarzschild spacetime embedded in 3D Euclidean space. The throat at $r = R_S$ represents the event horizon. The surface curves more steeply near the throat, visualizing the spatial curvature caused by gravity. An interactive version is in `gravitational_redshift.nb`.

3.13 Summary

The Schwarzschild metric is the unique spherically symmetric vacuum solution (Birkhoff's theorem), and it is parameterized by a single quantity, the mass M (or equivalently the

Schwarzschild radius $R_S = 2GM/c^2$). Clocks run slower in stronger gravitational fields, $d\tau = \sqrt{1 - R_S/r}\, dt$, and photons lose energy climbing out of a potential well; these are gravitational time dilation and gravitational redshift. The surface $r = R_S$ is a coordinate singularity (the event horizon), whereas $r = 0$ is a true curvature singularity. The weak-field limit ($ds^2 \approx -(1 + 2\Phi/c^2)c^2dt^2 + (1 - 2\Phi/c^2)d\ell^2$) will be the foundation for light deflection in Chapter 6.

3.14 Problems

Exercise 3.14.1. Using the reusable functions from Chapter 2 (`christoffel_symbols.wl`), verify that the Schwarzschild metric (3.14) satisfies $R_{\mu\nu} = 0$.

Exercise 3.14.2. Compute the Kretschmann scalar $K = R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}$ for the Schwarzschild metric and show that $K = 12\, R_S^2/r^6$. Verify that K is finite at $r = R_S$ but diverges at $r = 0$.

Exercise 3.14.3. Compute the Schwarzschild radius for:

(a) The Earth ($M = 5.97 \times 10^{24}$ kg)

(b) The Sun ($M = 1.99 \times 10^{30}$ kg)

(c) A typical galaxy lens ($M = 10^{12}\, M_\odot$)

In each case, compare R_S to the physical size of the object.

Exercise 3.14.4. A photon is emitted from the surface of a neutron star ($M = 1.4\, M_\odot$, $R = 10$ km).

(a) Compute the gravitational redshift z_{grav}.

(b) By what fraction is the photon's wavelength increased by the time it reaches a distant observer?

(c) Compare to the redshift from the surface of the Sun.

Exercise 3.14.5. Derive the Flamm's paraboloid embedding (3.28) by embedding the equatorial spatial slice of the Schwarzschild geometry in 3D Euclidean space with cylindrical coordinates (r, ϕ, z).

Chapter 4

Geodesics and Orbits in Schwarzschild Spacetime

> *Together the conserved quantities E and L provide a convenient way to understand the orbits of particles in the Schwarzschild geometry.* — Sean Carroll, *Spacetime and Geometry*

In Chapter 3 we derived the Schwarzschild metric. We now ask how particles and light move in this spacetime. The answer comes from the geodesic equation, which we reduce to a one-dimensional effective potential problem using Killing vectors and conservation laws. This chapter derives the effective potential for massive and massless particles, identifies its characteristic features (the ISCO and the photon sphere), and ends with Mercury's perihelion precession, one of the three classical tests of GR.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `geodesic_equation.wl`: symbolic derivation of the geodesic equations, conserved quantities, effective potential, ISCO, photon sphere, and perihelion precession formula
- `effective_potential.nb`: interactive plots of effective potential with sliders for L and ϵ; orbit integration; precessing ellipses

4.1 Killing Vectors and Conservation Laws

The Schwarzschild metric is independent of both t and ϕ, and therefore possesses two *Killing vectors* (Carroll Sec. 5.4):

$$K^\mu = (\partial_t)^\mu = (1, 0, 0, 0) \quad \text{(time translation)}, \tag{4.1}$$

$$R^\mu = (\partial_\phi)^\mu = (0, 0, 0, 1) \quad \text{(axial rotation)}. \tag{4.2}$$

For any geodesic $x^\mu(\lambda)$, the quantity $K_\mu \, dx^\mu/d\lambda$ is conserved along the path (Carroll eq. 5.54). Lowering the index with the metric gives the two conserved quantities (Carroll eqs. 5.61–5.62, with c restored as in Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.76a):

$$\boxed{E = \left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right) c^2 \, \frac{dt}{d\lambda}} \tag{4.3}$$

$$\boxed{L = r^2 \frac{d\phi}{d\lambda}} \tag{4.4}$$

For massive particles ($\lambda = \tau$), E and L are the conserved energy (including rest energy, so $E = c^2$ for a particle at rest at infinity) and angular momentum *per unit mass*.[1] For photons, they are the energy and angular momentum of the photon (up to normalization of the affine parameter).

Spherical symmetry also allows us to restrict all orbits to the equatorial plane $\theta = \pi/2$ without loss of generality (Carroll eq. 5.56).

4.2 The Effective Potential

The normalization condition for the four-velocity gives (Carroll eq. 5.63, with c restored):

$$-\left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right) c^2 \left(\frac{dt}{d\lambda}\right)^2 + \left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right)^{-1} \left(\frac{dr}{d\lambda}\right)^2 + r^2 \left(\frac{d\phi}{d\lambda}\right)^2 = -\epsilon c^2 \,, \tag{4.5}$$

where $\epsilon = 1$ for massive particles (timelike geodesics) and $\epsilon = 0$ for photons (null geodesics).

Substituting the conserved quantities (4.3) and (4.4), we obtain a radial equation (Carroll eq. 5.65):

$$\frac{1}{2}\left(\frac{dr}{d\lambda}\right)^2 + V_{\text{eff}}(r) = \mathcal{E} \,, \tag{4.6}$$

where the *effective potential* is (Carroll eq. 5.66, with additive constant $+\frac{1}{2}\epsilon$ absorbed into $\mathcal{E}$; Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.80):

$$\boxed{V_{\text{eff}}(r) = -\epsilon \frac{GM}{r} + \frac{L^2}{2r^2} - \frac{GML^2}{c^2 r^3}} \tag{4.7}$$

and $\mathcal{E} = \frac{1}{2}(E^2/c^2 - \epsilon c^2)$ is the effective "energy."

Remark 4.2.1. The three terms in V_{eff} each have a physical interpretation:

1. $-\epsilon\, GM/r$ is the Newtonian gravitational potential (absent for photons since $\epsilon = 0$);
2. $L^2/(2r^2)$ is the centrifugal barrier (identical to Newtonian mechanics);
3. $-GML^2/(c^2 r^3)$ is the GR correction, a term which has no Newtonian analogue and is responsible for all the distinctive features of relativistic orbits.

The GR term is attractive at small r, so the centrifugal barrier can be overcome; this is why particles can spiral into black holes, which is impossible in Newtonian gravity.

[1] Carroll sets $c = 1$ and writes $E = (1 - R_S/r)\, dt/d\lambda$. Earlier versions of this chapter used that $c = 1$ form in eqs. (4.3) and (4.5) while keeping explicit factors of c in eqs. (4.7) and (4.16), so the two did not match. The factor c^2 follows Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.76a; with it, one E serves every equation of this chapter.

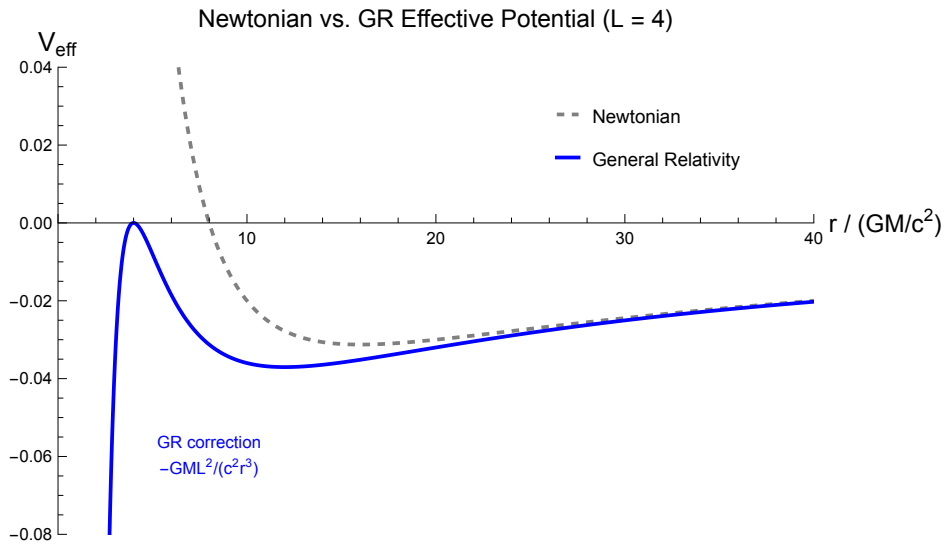


Figure 4.1: Comparison of Newtonian (dashed) and GR (solid) effective potentials for a massive particle with $L = 4\,GM/c$. The GR correction term $\propto 1/r^3$ pulls the potential down at small r, allowing particles to plunge past the centrifugal barrier. (cf. Carroll Figs. 5.4 and 5.5)

4.3 Circular Orbits and the ISCO

Circular orbits occur at extrema of the effective potential: $dV_{\text{eff}}/dr = 0$. For massive particles ($\epsilon = 1$), this gives (Carroll eq. 5.68):

$$GMr_c^2 - L^2 r_c + 3GML^2/c^2 = 0\,. \tag{4.8}$$

The two solutions are (Carroll eq. 5.71):

$$r_\pm = \frac{L^2}{2GM}\left(1 \pm \sqrt{1 - \frac{12G^2M^2}{L^2c^2}}\right)\,. \tag{4.9}$$

The outer solution r_+ is a *stable* circular orbit (a minimum of V_{eff}) and the inner solution r_- an *unstable* one (a maximum of V_{eff}). Real solutions require $L^2 \geq 12\,G^2M^2/c^2$, i.e., $L \geq 2\sqrt{3}\,GM/c$ (Carroll eq. 5.73). The minimum stable circular orbit occurs when $r_+ = r_-$, giving the *innermost stable circular orbit* (ISCO) (Carroll eq. 5.74; Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.84):

$$\boxed{r_{\text{ISCO}} = \frac{6GM}{c^2} = 3\,R_S} \tag{4.10}$$

Remark 4.3.1. The ISCO is a fundamental scale in black hole astrophysics. Accreting matter in a thin disk spirals inward until it reaches the ISCO, then plunges into the black hole. The ISCO radius determines the efficiency of energy extraction from accretion and the inner edge of accretion disks observed in X-ray binaries and active galactic nuclei.

4.4 The Photon Sphere

For photons ($\epsilon = 0$), the effective potential simplifies to (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.86):

$$V_{\text{eff}}^{\text{photon}}(r) = \frac{L^2}{2r^2} - \frac{GML^2}{c^2 r^3}\,. \tag{4.11}$$

Setting $dV_{\text{eff}}/dr = 0$ gives a single circular orbit (Carroll eq. 5.70; Congdon & Keeton Sec. 3.3.3, prose after eq. 3.86):

$$\boxed{r_{\text{photon}} = \frac{3GM}{c^2} = \frac{3}{2}\,R_S} \tag{4.12}$$

This is an *unstable* circular orbit: any perturbation causes the photon either to escape to infinity or to spiral into the black hole. Nevertheless, the photon sphere governs strong gravitational lensing near black holes and is directly related to the "photon ring" observed by the Event Horizon Telescope.

4.5 Effective Potential: Newtonian vs. GR

The qualitative differences between the Newtonian and GR effective potentials are collected in the following table.

Feature	**Newtonian**	**GR**
Centrifugal barrier	Diverges as $r \to 0$	Overcome at small r
ISCO	None (stable at any r)	$r = 3R_S$
Photon orbits	None	Unstable at $r = 3R_S/2$
Plunge orbits	Impossible	Possible for $r < r_{\text{ISCO}}$

4.6 Perihelion Precession

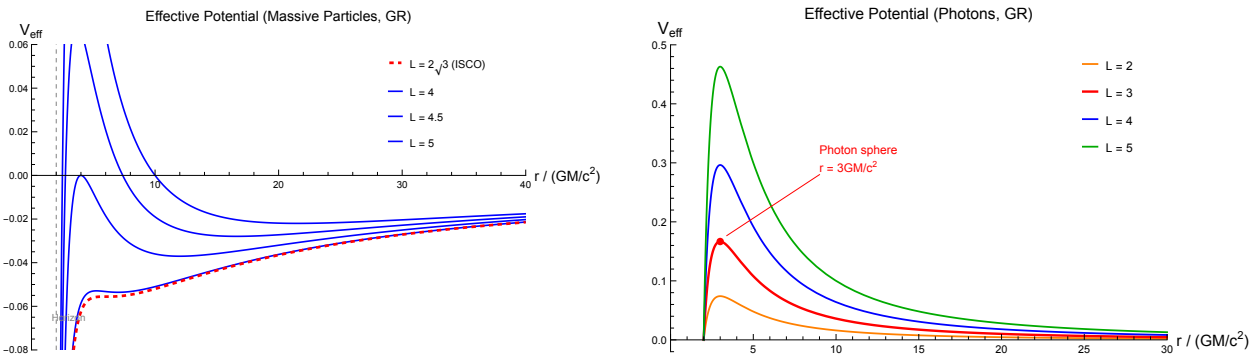
In Newtonian gravity, bound orbits are perfect ellipses that close on themselves. In GR, the extra $-GML^2/(c^2r^3)$ term in the effective potential causes the orbit to *precess*: the perihelion (point of closest approach) advances by a small angle each orbit.

Following Carroll Sec. 5.5 and using the substitution $x = L^2/(GMr)$, the orbit equation becomes (Carroll eq. 5.79):

$$\frac{d^2x}{d\phi^2} + x = 1 + \frac{3G^2M^2}{L^2c^2}\,x^2\,. \tag{4.13}$$

The last term is the GR correction. Treating it as a perturbation ($x = x_0 + x_1$, with $x_0 = 1 + e\cos\phi$ the Keplerian solution), one finds the accumulated precession per orbit (Carroll eq. 5.92):

$$\boxed{\Delta\phi = \frac{6\pi GM}{c^2 a(1-e^2)} = \frac{6\pi G^2M^2}{c^2L^2}} \tag{4.14}$$



(a) Massive particles ($\epsilon = 1$) (b) Photons ($\epsilon = 0$)

Figure 4.2: GR effective potentials for several values of angular momentum L (in GM/c units). **Left:** For massive particles, the red dashed curve shows $L = L_{\text{ISCO}} = 2\sqrt{3}\,GM/c$, where the stable and unstable circular orbits merge. **Right:** For photons, the potential always has a maximum at $r = 3GM/c^2$ (the photon sphere). Interactive versions in `effective_potential.nb`.

where a is the semi-major axis and e the eccentricity.

For Mercury (Carroll eq. 5.96) this gives

$$\Delta\phi_{\text{Mercury}} = 5.02 \times 10^{-7}\ \text{rad/orbit} = 0.104''/\text{orbit} = 43.0''/\text{century}\,. \tag{4.15}$$

This matched the previously unexplained 43 arcseconds/century discrepancy in Mercury's orbit and was one of Einstein's first confirmations of GR.

4.7 Null Geodesics and the Deflection of Light (Preview)

For photons, the orbit equation (using $u = 1/r$) becomes (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.87):

$$\frac{d\phi}{dr} = \pm\frac{L}{r^2}\left[\frac{E^2}{c^2} - \frac{L^2}{r^2}\left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right)\right]^{-1/2}. \tag{4.16}$$

A photon approaching a mass M with impact parameter $b = cL/E$ (the perpendicular distance from the mass in the absence of deflection) will be deflected by an angle (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.96):

$$\hat{\alpha} = \frac{4GM}{c^2 b}\,, \tag{4.17}$$

in the weak-field limit ($b \gg R_S$). This is *twice* the Newtonian prediction and was confirmed by Eddington's 1919 solar eclipse observations.

The full derivation of the deflection angle is the subject of Chapter 6. We mention it here because the effective potential framework shows why light bends: photons follow null geodesics of the curved Schwarzschild spacetime, and the GR correction term in the effective potential deflects them more strongly than Newtonian gravity would predict.

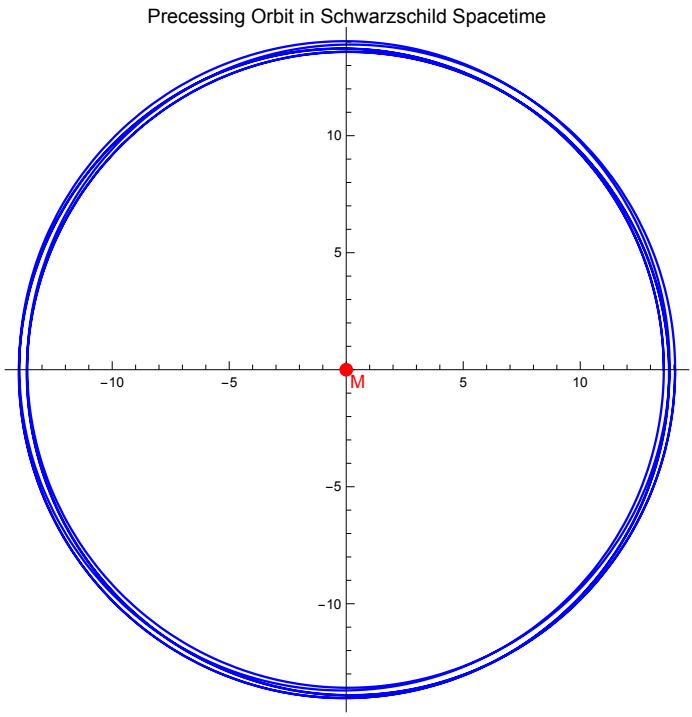


Figure 4.3: A precessing orbit in Schwarzschild spacetime, computed by numerically integrating the orbit equation for $L = 4.2\,GM/c$ with perihelion at $r \approx 13.6\,GM/c^2$. This is a strong-field orbit: the perihelion advances by ≈ 2.07 rad (119°) per radial period, almost twice the weak-field estimate $6\pi GM/(c^2 p) \approx 1.07$ rad for the same semi-latus rectum $p = L^2/GM$, which is why the rosette opens so quickly. (Earlier printings of this caption called the advance "small"; it is not, for this orbit — see Exercise 5(b). cf. Carroll Fig. 5.6.)

4.8 Brief Overview: The Kerr Metric

Real astrophysical black holes are not described exactly by the Schwarzschild solution because they rotate. The metric for a rotating, axially symmetric black hole is the *Kerr metric*, discovered by Roy Kerr in 1963. In Boyer–Lindquist coordinates it takes the form

$$ds^2 = -\left(1 - \frac{R_S r}{\Sigma}\right) c^2 dt^2 - \frac{2R_S r a \sin^2\theta}{\Sigma}\, c\, dt\, d\phi + \frac{\Sigma}{\Delta}\, dr^2 + \Sigma\, d\theta^2 + \frac{A \sin^2\theta}{\Sigma}\, d\phi^2 , \qquad (4.18)$$

where

$$\Sigma = r^2 + a^2 \cos^2\theta , \qquad \Delta = r^2 - R_S r + a^2 , \qquad A = (r^2 + a^2)^2 - a^2 \Delta \sin^2\theta , \qquad (4.19)$$

and $a = J/(Mc)$ is the *spin parameter* (angular momentum per unit mass, with dimensions of length). For a physical black hole, $0 \le a \le GM/c^2$.

Four features distinguish the Kerr geometry from Schwarzschild. The first is *frame dragging*: the $dt\,d\phi$ cross-term forces particles near the black hole to co-rotate, an effect absent in Schwarzschild. The second is the *ergosphere*, the region $r_+ < r < (R_S + \sqrt{R_S^2 - 4a^2\cos^2\theta})/2$, where $r_+ = (R_S + \sqrt{R_S^2 - 4a^2})/2$ is the outer event horizon, in which even stationary

observers must co-rotate with the black hole. (At $a = 0$, $r_+ = R_S$, not $R_S/2$, and the ergosphere collapses onto the Schwarzschild horizon; only at maximum spin $a = GM/c^2$ does $r_+ = R_S/2$.) The third is a spin-dependent ISCO: the ISCO radius depends on the spin parameter and on the direction of the orbit (prograde or retrograde). For a maximally spinning black hole ($a = GM/c^2$), $r_{\rm ISCO} = GM/c^2$ (prograde) and $r_{\rm ISCO} = 9GM/c^2$ (retrograde), compared with $6GM/c^2$ for Schwarzschild. The fourth is that there are two horizons, $r_\pm = GM/c^2 \pm \sqrt{(GM/c^2)^2 - a^2}$.

Remark 4.8.1. For gravitational lensing by galaxies and clusters, the Kerr metric is not needed: the lensing effect is dominated by the total enclosed mass, and the weak-field/thin-lens approximation (Chapter 5 and beyond) washes out spin effects at the angular scales of interest. Kerr lensing is, however, an active research topic for strong lensing near individual black holes, for instance the "photon ring" structure observed by the Event Horizon Telescope, where frame-dragging produces asymmetric brightness patterns.

4.9 Summary

The Killing vectors ∂_t and ∂_ϕ yield a conserved energy E and angular momentum L along geodesics, and the radial motion reduces to a 1D effective potential problem with $V_{\rm eff} = -\epsilon GM/r + L^2/(2r^2) - GML^2/(c^2r^3)$. The GR correction term $\propto 1/r^3$ is responsible for the ISCO at $r = 3R_S$, the photon sphere at $r = 3R_S/2$, perihelion precession, and enhanced light deflection. Mercury's perihelion precesses by 43 arcsec/century, which is confirmed by observation and was one of the first tests of GR. The Kerr metric generalizes Schwarzschild to rotating black holes (frame dragging, ergosphere, spin-dependent ISCO), but is not needed for galaxy- or cluster-scale lensing.

4.10 Problems

Exercise 4.10.1. Starting from the normalization condition (4.5) and the conserved quantities E and L, derive the effective potential (4.7) for massive particles ($\epsilon = 1$). Show that in the Newtonian limit ($c \to \infty$, $R_S \to 0$), it reduces to $V_{\rm eff}^{\rm Newton} = -GM/r + L^2/(2r^2)$.

Exercise 4.10.2. Derive the ISCO radius by finding the value of L for which the two circular orbit solutions (4.9) coincide (i.e., the discriminant vanishes). Verify $r_{\rm ISCO} = 6GM/c^2 = 3R_S$.

Exercise 4.10.3. Show that the only circular photon orbit in the Schwarzschild spacetime is at $r = 3GM/c^2 = 3R_S/2$, and that it is unstable (a maximum of $V_{\rm eff}^{\rm photon}$).

Exercise 4.10.4. Compute the perihelion precession of Mercury using eq. (4.14) with: $M = M_\odot$, $a = 5.79 \times 10^{10}$ m, $e = 0.2056$. Verify $\Delta\phi \approx 43''$/century (Mercury's orbital period is 87.97 days).

Exercise 4.10.5. Using the effective potential for massive particles with $L = 4GM/c$:

(a) Plot $V_{\rm eff}(r)$ and identify the stable circular orbit radius, the unstable circular orbit radius, and the ISCO.

(b) For a particle with $\mathcal{E}$ slightly above $V_{\text{eff}}(r_+)$, describe qualitatively the type of orbit (bound precessing ellipse, scatter orbit, or plunge orbit).

Chapter 5

Linearized Gravity and the Weak-Field Metric

> *The weak-field limit described in this chapter is less restrictive, assuming that the field is still weak but it can vary with time, and without any restrictions on the motion of test particles. This will allow us to discuss phenomena that are absent or ambiguous in the Newtonian theory, such as gravitational radiation (where the field varies with time) and the deflection of light (which involves fast-moving particles).* — Sean Carroll, *Spacetime and Geometry*, Sect. 7.1

In Chapters 1–4 we developed the full machinery of general relativity and applied it to the exact Schwarzschild solution. That framework is necessary for black holes and strong-field orbits, but most gravitational lensing (by galaxies, galaxy clusters, and large-scale structure) operates in a regime where gravity is weak: the Newtonian potential satisfies $|\Phi|/c^2 \ll 1$ and peculiar velocities are small compared to c. In this regime the metric can be treated as a small perturbation of flat Minkowski spacetime, and the resulting *linearized gravity* formalism is both simpler and more directly connected to the lens equation that we will develop in Chapter 8.

This chapter derives the weak-field metric from first principles, recovers Newtonian gravity as a limiting case, computes the deflection of light (reproducing the factor of two over the Newtonian prediction), and introduces the effective refractive index interpretation on which Fermat's principle for lensing rests. The linearity of the perturbation equations also guarantees that deflection angles from multiple masses superpose, which is the foundation for treating extended mass distributions in later chapters.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `weak_field_metric.wl`: symbolic verification of the Newtonian limit, weak-field deflection angle, factor-of-2, and figure generation
- `deflection_comparison.nb`: interactive comparison of exact Schwarzschild deflection vs. weak-field approximation; effective refractive index visualization

5.1 Introduction: Why Linearize?

Consider a photon passing the Sun at the solar limb. The relevant dimensionless quantity characterizing the strength of gravity is (Carroll eq. 4.21):

$$\frac{|\Phi|}{c^2} = \left.\frac{GM}{rc^2}\right|_{r=R_\odot} \approx \frac{6.674\times10^{-11}\times1.989\times10^{30}}{6.96\times10^{8}\times(3\times10^{8})^2} \approx 2.1\times10^{-6}\,. \tag{5.1}$$

For a typical galaxy lens ($M\sim10^{12}\,M_\odot$, $r\sim10$ kpc), the ratio is $|\Phi|/c^2\approx5\times10^{-6}$. Even for galaxy clusters ($M\sim10^{15}\,M_\odot$, $r\sim1$ Mpc), one finds $|\Phi|/c^2\sim5\times10^{-5}$; values of $\sim10^{-4}$ are reached only in the inner few hundred kpc of a massive cluster.

In all of these astrophysical settings gravity is very weak. This justifies expanding the metric perturbatively around flat spacetime and keeping only first-order terms, which is the linearized gravity approximation.

Remark 5.1.1. The only astrophysical setting in which linearized gravity is insufficient for lensing is near black holes and neutron stars, where $|\Phi|/c^2$ approaches unity. Strong lensing by black holes (e.g., the photon ring observed by the Event Horizon Telescope) requires the full Schwarzschild or Kerr solution developed in Chapters 3 and 4.

5.2 The Weak-Field Expansion

We write the full spacetime metric as a perturbation of the Minkowski metric (Carroll eq. 7.1; Congdon & Keeton Sec. 3.3.2):

$$\boxed{g_{\mu\nu} = \eta_{\mu\nu} + h_{\mu\nu}\,, \qquad |h_{\mu\nu}| \ll 1} \tag{5.2}$$

where $\eta_{\mu\nu}=\mathrm{diag}(-1,+1,+1,+1)$ is the flat Minkowski metric and $h_{\mu\nu}$ is the *metric perturbation*. The condition $|h_{\mu\nu}|\ll1$ means that spacetime is "almost flat": deviations from Minkowski geometry are small.

The inverse metric to first order in h is (Carroll eq. 7.2):

$$g^{\mu\nu} = \eta^{\mu\nu} - h^{\mu\nu} + \mathcal{O}\big(h^2\big)\,, \tag{5.3}$$

where indices on $h_{\mu\nu}$ are raised and lowered with η.

The Christoffel symbols to first order are (Carroll eq. 7.4):

$$\Gamma^{\alpha}{}_{\mu\nu} = \tfrac{1}{2}\eta^{\alpha\beta}\big(\partial_\mu h_{\nu\beta} + \partial_\nu h_{\mu\beta} - \partial_\beta h_{\mu\nu}\big) + \mathcal{O}\big(h^2\big)\,. \tag{5.4}$$

Remark 5.2.1. In linearized gravity we systematically discard all terms of order h^2 and higher. The Christoffel symbols are then first order in h, the Riemann tensor is first order, and the Einstein equations become *linear* in $h_{\mu\nu}$. Linearity is the simplification that allows superposition of gravitational effects.

5.3 The Newtonian Limit

We now show that the geodesic equation in the weak-field, slow-motion limit reduces to Newton's second law, thereby identifying the metric perturbation h_{00} with the Newtonian potential Φ.

5.3.1 Assumptions

The *Newtonian limit* requires three conditions (Carroll Sec. 4.1):

1. a weak field, $|h_{\mu\nu}| \ll 1$;
2. slow motion, $v \ll c$, so that $dx^i/d\tau \ll dx^0/d\tau = c\,dt/d\tau$;
3. a static field, $\partial_0 h_{\mu\nu} = 0$ (the gravitational field is not changing with time).

5.3.2 Derivation

The geodesic equation for a massive particle is (Carroll eq. 3.44)

$$\frac{d^2x^\mu}{d\tau^2} + \Gamma^\mu{}_{\alpha\beta}\frac{dx^\alpha}{d\tau}\frac{dx^\beta}{d\tau} = 0\,. \tag{5.5}$$

In the slow-motion limit, $dx^i/d\tau$ is negligible compared to $dx^0/d\tau = c\,dt/d\tau$, so the double sum over α, β is dominated by the $\alpha = \beta = 0$ term:

$$\frac{d^2x^\mu}{d\tau^2} + \Gamma^\mu{}_{00}\left(\frac{dx^0}{d\tau}\right)^2 \approx 0\,. \tag{5.6}$$

From eq. (5.4), using the static-field condition ($\partial_0 h_{\mu\nu} = 0$):

$$\Gamma^\mu{}_{00} = \tfrac{1}{2}\eta^{\mu\alpha}\big(\partial_0 h_{0\alpha} + \partial_0 h_{0\alpha} - \partial_\alpha h_{00}\big) = -\tfrac{1}{2}\eta^{\mu\alpha}\,\partial_\alpha h_{00}\,. \tag{5.7}$$

For the spatial components ($\mu = i$), this gives $\Gamma^i{}_{00} = -\tfrac{1}{2}\partial_i h_{00}$.

The spatial part of the geodesic equation then becomes

$$\frac{d^2x^i}{d\tau^2} = \tfrac{1}{2}\partial_i h_{00}\left(\frac{dx^0}{d\tau}\right)^2 = \tfrac{1}{2}c^2\partial_i h_{00}\left(\frac{dt}{d\tau}\right)^2. \tag{5.8}$$

Using $d\tau \approx dt$ (valid for slow motion, since $\gamma \approx 1$), we obtain

$$\frac{d^2x^i}{dt^2} = \tfrac{1}{2}c^2\,\partial_i h_{00}\,. \tag{5.9}$$

5.3.3 Identification with Newtonian Gravity

Newton's second law in a gravitational field is

$$\frac{d^2x^i}{dt^2} = -\partial_i\Phi\,. \tag{5.10}$$

Comparing with eq. (5.9), we identify (Carroll eq. 4.19):

$$\boxed{h_{00} = -\frac{2\Phi}{c^2}} \tag{5.11}$$

The time-time component of the metric perturbation is determined by the Newtonian potential. For a point mass M, $\Phi = -GM/r$, so

$$h_{00} = \frac{2GM}{c^2 r} = \frac{R_S}{r}\,, \tag{5.12}$$

where $R_S = 2GM/c^2$ is the Schwarzschild radius.

Exercise 5.3.1. Starting from the geodesic equation (5.5) with the perturbed metric $g_{\mu\nu} = \eta_{\mu\nu} + h_{\mu\nu}$, carry out the Newtonian limit derivation in full detail. Show that for slow-moving particles in a static, weak gravitational field:

(a) The only relevant Christoffel symbol is $\Gamma^i{}_{00} = -\frac{1}{2}\partial_i h_{00}$.

(b) The geodesic equation reduces to $d^2x^i/dt^2 = \frac{1}{2}c^2\,\partial_i h_{00}$.

(c) Comparing with Newton's law identifies $h_{00} = -2\Phi/c^2$.

Verify each step using `weak_field_metric.wl`.

5.4 The Weak-Field Metric

The Newtonian limit only determined h_{00}. To obtain the full weak-field metric, including the spatial components needed for light bending, we must go beyond the slow-motion assumption and use the linearized Einstein equations.

For a static, spherically symmetric source, the solution to the linearized Einstein equations in isotropic coordinates gives (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.71; Carroll eq. 7.59):

$$\boxed{ds^2 = -\left(1 + \frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\right) c^2\,dt^2 + \left(1 - \frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\right)\left(dx^2 + dy^2 + dz^2\right)} \tag{5.13}$$

where $\Phi(\mathbf{x})$ is the Newtonian gravitational potential (with $\Phi < 0$ for attractive gravity). Equivalently,

$$h_{00} = -\frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\,, \qquad h_{ij} = -\frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\,\delta_{ij}\,. \tag{5.14}$$

Remark 5.4.1. Both the time and space components of the metric are perturbed, and by equal amounts. The Newtonian limit (which assumes slow motion) only probes h_{00}, because the spatial components of the four-velocity are negligible. Photons, however, travel at c, so all components of the metric contribute equally to the propagation of light. This is why light bending in GR is *twice* the Newtonian prediction.

Exercise 5.4.1. The Schwarzschild metric in standard coordinates is:

$$ds^2 = -\left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right) c^2 dt^2 + \left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right)^{-1} dr^2 + r^2\,d\Omega^2\,.$$

(a) Expand $(1 - R_S/r)^{-1} \approx 1 + R_S/r + \mathcal{O}((R_S/r)^2)$ and show that the metric becomes:

$$ds^2 \approx -\left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right) c^2 dt^2 + \left(1 + \frac{R_S}{r}\right) dr^2 + r^2\,d\Omega^2\,.$$

(b) Transform to Cartesian-like coordinates and show that this matches the weak-field metric (5.13) with $\Phi = -GM/r$ to first order in R_S/r.

Verify with `weak_field_metric.wl`.

5.5 Null Geodesics in the Weak-Field Metric

We now derive the deflection of light in the weak-field metric. This is the central result of this chapter and the starting point for the entire gravitational lensing formalism.

5.5.1 Setup

Consider a photon propagating through the weak-field metric (5.13) generated by a point mass M at the origin, with $\Phi = -GM/r$. The photon travels along a null geodesic: $ds^2 = 0$.

For a photon moving primarily in the x-direction, passing the mass at impact parameter b (the closest approach distance in the absence of deflection), we can use the *Born approximation*: we compute the deflection along the unperturbed (straight-line) path. This is valid when the deflection angle is small, which is guaranteed by the weak-field condition.

5.5.2 The Null Condition

Setting $ds^2 = 0$ in eq. (5.13) gives

$$\left(1 + \frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\right) c^2 dt^2 = \left(1 - \frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\right) \left(dx^2 + dy^2 + dz^2\right). \tag{5.15}$$

The coordinate speed of light is therefore

$$\frac{|\mathbf{dx}|}{dt} = c\sqrt{\frac{1 + 2\Phi/c^2}{1 - 2\Phi/c^2}} \approx c\left(1 + \frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\right) \tag{5.16}$$

to first order in Φ/c^2. Since $\Phi < 0$, the coordinate speed is less than c near a mass: gravity slows light.

5.5.3 Deflection Angle

The deflection due to the temporal perturbation h_{00} alone is computed by integrating the transverse gradient of $|\Phi|$ along the unperturbed (straight-line) path (Congdon & Keeton Sec. 3.4.1):

$$\hat{\alpha}_{\text{time}} = \frac{1}{c^2} \int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} \nabla_\perp |\Phi| \, dl \,, \tag{5.17}$$

where $\nabla_\perp$ denotes the gradient of $|\Phi|$ perpendicular to the photon's path and dl is the path length along the unperturbed trajectory. This gives the "Newtonian" contribution to the deflection.

The spatial perturbation h_{ij} contributes an *equal* amount, doubling the result. In the PPN (parametrized post-Newtonian) formalism, the full deflection angle is written as (Will 1993)

$$\boxed{\hat{\alpha} = \frac{1+\gamma_{\rm PPN}}{c^2}\int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} \nabla_\perp |\Phi|\, dl} \tag{5.18}$$

where $\gamma_{\rm PPN} = 1$ in GR. The Parametrized Post-Newtonian (PPN) formalism describes deviations from Newtonian gravity using a set of dimensionless parameters; $\gamma_{\rm PPN}$ measures how much spatial curvature is produced per unit rest mass. In GR, $\gamma_{\rm PPN} = 1$ (equal time and space perturbations to the metric, as derived in Section 5.4); in Brans–Dicke theory, $\gamma_{\rm PPN} = (1+\omega)/(2+\omega)$ where ω is the coupling constant. Solar system tests, most precisely the Cassini spacecraft's measurement of the Shapiro delay [5], give $\gamma_{\rm PPN} - 1 = (2.1 \pm 2.3) \times 10^{-5}$, in agreement with GR [49].[1] The Newtonian prediction corresponds to $\gamma_{\rm PPN} = 0$ (no spatial curvature contribution), giving half the GR value.

5.5.4 Point Mass Deflection

For a point mass with $|\Phi| = GM/r$, the photon travels along the x-axis at perpendicular distance b (so $r = \sqrt{x^2+b^2}$ and $\nabla_\perp|\Phi| = (GM\,b)/(x^2+b^2)^{3/2}$). The line-of-sight integral evaluates to

$$\int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} \nabla_\perp|\Phi|\, dl = GM\int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} \frac{b\,dx}{(x^2+b^2)^{3/2}} = GM\cdot\frac{2}{b} = \frac{2GM}{b}\,, \tag{5.19}$$

using the standard integral $\int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} b\,dx/(x^2+b^2)^{3/2} = 2/b$. With $\gamma_{\rm PPN} = 1$ (GR), the deflection angle is

$$\boxed{\hat{\alpha} = \frac{4GM}{c^2 b}} \tag{5.20}$$

This is the *Einstein deflection angle* for a point mass, the central equation of gravitational lensing. We derived it here via the Born approximation in the weak-field metric; in Chapter 6 we will re-derive it from the exact null geodesic orbit equation in the full Schwarzschild metric, and the two approaches agree.

5.5.5 The Factor of Two

The factor of 4 in eq. (5.20) (rather than 2) is one of the best-known results of GR, and its origin is as follows. The temporal perturbation $h_{00} = -2\Phi/c^2$ contributes a deflection of $2GM/(c^2 b)$. This is the "Newtonian" part, which can also be derived by treating the photon as a Newtonian particle moving at speed c. The spatial perturbation $h_{ij} = -2\Phi/c^2\,\delta_{ij}$ contributes an *equal* additional deflection of $2GM/(c^2 b)$, because photons, unlike massive particles, are equally sensitive to the spatial curvature. The total is $4GM/(c^2 b) = 2\times(2GM/(c^2 b))$, i.e., twice the Newtonian prediction. This factor of 2 was confirmed by Eddington's 1919 solar eclipse expedition and is one of the classical tests of general relativity.

[1] Earlier versions of this chapter quoted $|\gamma_{\rm PPN} - 1| < 2.3 \times 10^{-5}$, the number listed as the $\gamma - 1$ limit in Table 4 of Will [49]. The measurement itself is a central value of 2.1×10^{-5} with a 1σ uncertainty of 2.3×10^{-5}, as quoted in the text of Will [49] and of Bertotti et al. [5].

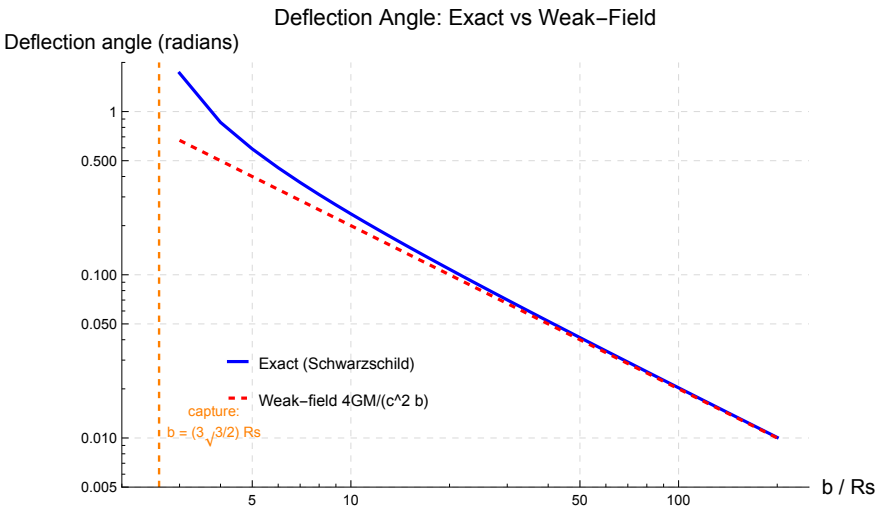


Figure 5.1: Comparison of the exact Schwarzschild deflection angle (solid blue) with the weak-field approximation $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$ (dashed red) as a function of impact parameter b/R_S. The weak-field value falls short of the exact one by a fraction $\approx (15\pi/32)\, R_S/b$ (the second-order term): about 15% at $b = 10\, R_S$, 5% at $30\, R_S$ and 1.5% at $100\, R_S$. The orange dashed line marks the capture impact parameter $b = (3\sqrt{3}/2)\, R_S$. For the Sun, $R_S \approx 3$ km and the closest approach is $R_\odot \approx 7 \times 10^5$ km, so $b/R_S \approx 2.4 \times 10^5$ — deep in the weak-field regime. Interactive version: `deflection_comparison.nb`. (cf. Congdon & Keeton Fig. 3.7)

Remark 5.5.1. Historically, Einstein himself initially published the "Newtonian" value $2GM/(c^2 b)$ in 1911, before he had completed general relativity. The correct value $4GM/(c^2 b)$ appeared in 1915, after Einstein accounted for the spatial curvature. The Eddington expedition confirmed the GR value, not the 1911 prediction.

Exercise 5.5.1. Derive the Einstein deflection angle $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$ for a point mass by evaluating the integral (5.18) with $|\Phi| = GM/r$ along the unperturbed photon path $\mathbf{x}(l) = (l, b, 0)$.

(a) Show that $\nabla_\perp |\Phi| = (GM\, b)/(l^2 + b^2)^{3/2}$.

(b) Evaluate $\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} b\, dl/(l^2 + b^2)^{3/2} = 2/b$.

(c) Combine with $\gamma_{\rm PPN} = 1$ to obtain $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$.

(d) Compute $\hat{\alpha}$ for the Sun at the solar limb ($b = R_\odot = 6.96 \times 10^8$ m) and verify $\hat{\alpha} \approx 1.75''$.

Check with `weak_field_metric.wl`.

5.6 The Effective Refractive Index

The weak-field metric leads to an analogy between gravitational lensing and optics. From eq. (5.16), the coordinate speed of light near a mass is

$$v_{\rm coord} = c\left(1 + \frac{2\Phi}{c^2}\right). \tag{5.21}$$

We can define an *effective refractive index* by analogy with optics, where $v = c/n$:

$$\boxed{n(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{c}{v_{\text{coord}}} \approx 1 - \frac{2\Phi}{c^2} = 1 + \frac{2|\Phi|}{c^2}} \tag{5.22}$$

Since $\Phi < 0$ near a mass, $n > 1$: gravity acts as a medium with refractive index greater than unity, slowing light (in coordinate time) and bending it toward the mass.

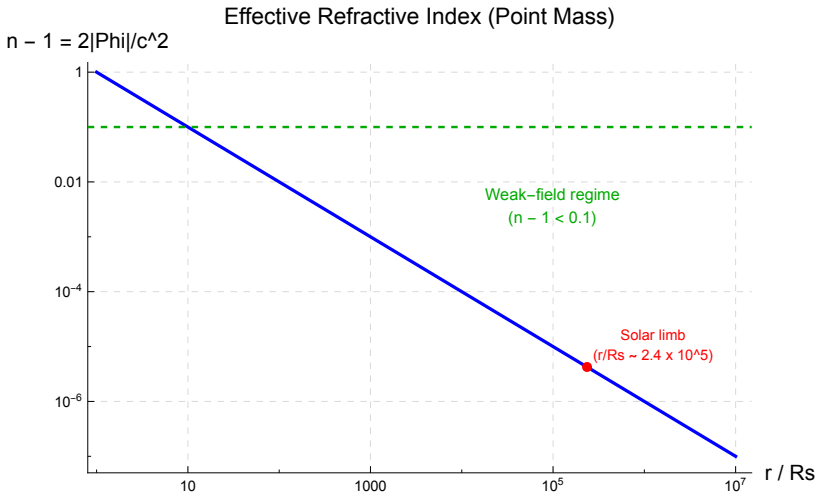


Figure 5.2: Effective refractive index $n = 1 + 2|\Phi|/c^2$ as a function of distance from a point mass, plotted for a solar-mass object. The refractive index is largest (light is slowest) at the surface of the mass and approaches unity far away.

This refractive index interpretation has two consequences.

Fermat's Principle. In optics, light follows the path that extremizes the optical path length $\int n\, dl$. The same principle applies in gravitational lensing: photons follow paths that extremize the *time delay functional* (Carroll eq. 7.85; Congdon & Keeton eq. 4.25):

$$t[\mathbf{x}(l)] = \frac{1}{c}\int n\, dl = \frac{1}{c}\int \left(1 + \frac{2|\Phi|}{c^2}\right) dl\,. \tag{5.23}$$

This will be the foundation for the time delay formalism in Chapter 10.

Shapiro Time Delay. Light passing near a mass arrives later than it would in flat spacetime, by an amount proportional to $\int 2|\Phi|/c^2\, dl$ along the path. This *Shapiro delay* has been measured to high precision using radar signals bouncing off Mercury and Venus.

Exercise 5.6.1. Compute the effective refractive index n at the following distances from the Sun ($M = M_\odot$):

(a) The solar surface ($r = R_\odot = 6.96 \times 10^8$ m)

(b) The Earth's orbit ($r = 1$ AU $= 1.496 \times 10^{11}$ m)

(c) The orbit of Pluto ($r = 39.5$ AU)

For each, compute $n - 1 = 2GM/(c^2 r)$ and comment on the magnitude.

5.7 Superposition in Linearized Gravity

Because the metric perturbation $h_{\mu\nu}$ satisfies *linear* equations in the weak-field limit, we can superpose solutions. If we have two masses M_1 and M_2 at positions $\mathbf{x}_1$ and $\mathbf{x}_2$, the total Newtonian potential is

$$\Phi(\mathbf{x}) = -\frac{GM_1}{|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}_1|} - \frac{GM_2}{|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}_2|}\,, \tag{5.24}$$

and the total deflection angle is the vector sum of the individual deflections:

$$\boxed{\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}} = \sum_i \frac{4GM_i}{c^2}\,\frac{\boldsymbol{\xi}-\boldsymbol{\xi}_i}{|\boldsymbol{\xi}-\boldsymbol{\xi}_i|^2}} \tag{5.25}$$

where $\boldsymbol{\xi}$ is the position in the lens plane and $\boldsymbol{\xi}_i$ is the projected position of mass M_i.

For a continuous mass distribution with surface mass density $\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\xi})$, this becomes (Congdon & Keeton eq. 4.9):

$$\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(\boldsymbol{\xi}) = \frac{4G}{c^2}\int \frac{(\boldsymbol{\xi}-\boldsymbol{\xi}')\,\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\xi}')}{|\boldsymbol{\xi}-\boldsymbol{\xi}'|^2}\,d^2\xi'\,. \tag{5.26}$$

This integral is the starting point for all lens models in Chapters 11–14.

Remark 5.7.1. Superposition of deflection angles does *not* hold in the exact (nonlinear) theory. It is a consequence of linearization and is valid only when all masses satisfy $|\Phi|/c^2 \ll 1$. This condition is satisfied for nearly all astrophysical lensing systems.

Exercise 5.7.1. Two point masses $M_1 = M_2 = M$ are located at $\mathbf{x}_1 = (-d/2, 0)$ and $\mathbf{x}_2 = (+d/2, 0)$ in the lens plane. A photon passes through the midpoint at $\boldsymbol{\xi} = (0, b)$.

(a) Write down the deflection angle vector from each mass.

(b) Show that the x-components cancel by symmetry and that the total deflection is:

$$\hat{\alpha}_y = \frac{8GMb}{c^2(d^2/4 + b^2)}\,.$$

(c) Verify that in the limit $d \to 0$ (masses merge) this reduces to $\hat{\alpha} = 8GM/(c^2 b) = 4G(2M)/(c^2 b)$, i.e., the deflection by a single mass of $2M$.

Check with `problems_01e.wl`.

5.8 Preview: From Deflection to the Lens Equation

The deflection angle (5.20) is a *physical* angle, measured in the frame of the lens. To connect it to observed image positions on the sky, we need the *lens equation*, which relates the true source position $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ to the observed image position $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ through the deflection angle (Congdon & Keeton eq. 4.26):

$$\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})\,, \tag{5.27}$$

where $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = (D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s})\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$ is the *reduced deflection angle* and $D_{\rm d}$, $D_{\rm s}$, $D_{\rm ds}$ are the angular diameter distances from observer to lens, observer to source, and lens to source.[2]

The full derivation of this equation, along with the thin-lens approximation and the definition of angular diameter distances, will be developed in Chapters 7 and 8. For now, the weak-field deflection angle computed in this chapter is the input to the lens equation.

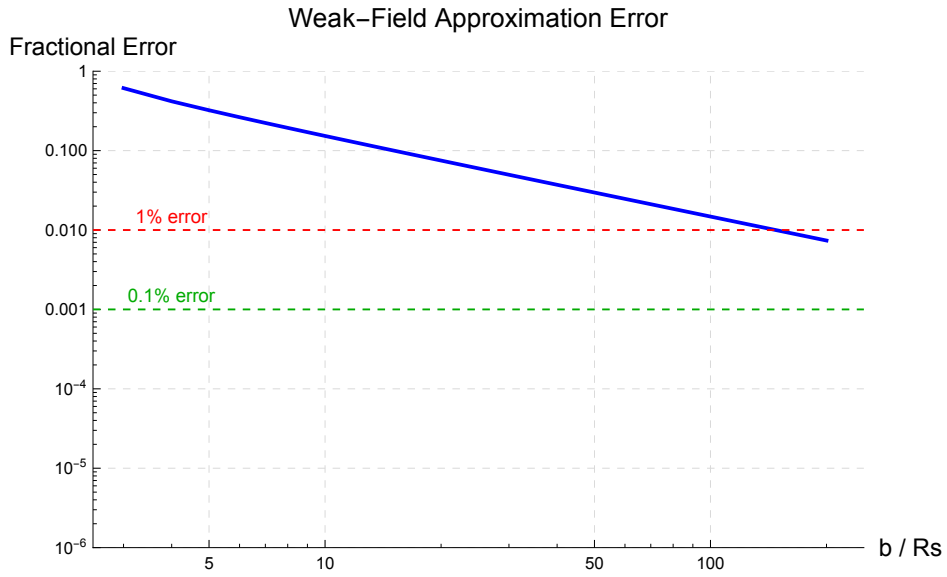


Figure 5.3: Fractional error $|\hat{\alpha}_{\rm exact} - \hat{\alpha}_{\rm weak}|/\hat{\alpha}_{\rm exact}$ of the weak-field approximation as a function of b/R_S. The error is $\approx (15\pi/32)\,R_S/b$: below 1% for $b/R_S \gtrsim 150$ and below 0.1% for $b/R_S \gtrsim 1500$. For typical astrophysical lenses ($b/R_S > 10^4$), the weak-field approximation is essentially exact.

5.9 Summary

In the weak-field limit, the metric is $g_{\mu\nu} = \eta_{\mu\nu} + h_{\mu\nu}$ with $|h_{\mu\nu}| \ll 1$. The Newtonian limit of the geodesic equation identifies $h_{00} = -2\Phi/c^2$, where Φ is the Newtonian gravitational potential, and the full weak-field metric has equal perturbations in time and space, $ds^2 = -(1 + 2\Phi/c^2)\,c^2dt^2 + (1 - 2\Phi/c^2)\,d\mathbf{x}^2$. Null geodesics in this metric yield the Einstein deflection angle $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$, twice the Newtonian value; the factor of 2 arises from the spatial curvature contribution. The weak-field metric defines an effective refractive index $n = 1 + 2|\Phi|/c^2 > 1$, which connects gravitational lensing to Fermat's principle and the Shapiro time delay. Linearized gravity allows superposition: deflection angles from multiple masses add vectorially, which is the foundation for treating galaxies, clusters, and continuous mass distributions as gravitational lenses. The deflection angle is the input to the lens equation (Chapter 8), which maps source positions to image positions.

[2]Earlier versions of this preview wrote $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - (D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s})\,\boldsymbol{\alpha}$ with $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = (D_{\rm d}/D_{\rm s})\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$, which combine to the wrong factor $D_{\rm d}D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}^2$ in front of $\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$. The small-angle geometry gives $D_{\rm s}\boldsymbol{\beta} = D_{\rm s}\boldsymbol{\theta} - D_{\rm ds}\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$, i.e. the form above, which is Congdon & Keeton eq. 4.26 and eqs. (8.8) and (8.9) of Chapter 8.

5.10 Problems

Exercise 5.10.1. (Newtonian limit from the geodesic equation.) Carry out the full Newtonian limit derivation described in Section 5.3. Starting from the geodesic equation with $g_{\mu\nu} = \eta_{\mu\nu} + h_{\mu\nu}$:

(a) Compute the Christoffel symbol $\Gamma^{i}{}_{00}$ to first order in h.

(b) Apply the slow-motion and static-field approximations.

(c) Show that $d^2x^i/dt^2 = -\partial_i\Phi$ implies $h_{00} = -2\Phi/c^2$.

Exercise 5.10.2. (Weak-field Schwarzschild.) Expand the Schwarzschild metric to first order in R_S/r and verify that it matches the weak-field metric (5.13) with $\Phi = -GM/r$. Specifically:

(a) Expand $(1 - R_S/r)^{-1} \approx 1 + R_S/r$.

(b) Write the result in isotropic Cartesian coordinates.

(c) Identify $h_{00} = R_S/r$ and $h_{ij} = (R_S/r)\,\delta_{ij}$ and confirm that the time and spatial diagonal perturbations are equal (i.e., $h_{00} = h_{xx} = h_{yy} = h_{zz}$).

Exercise 5.10.3. (Effective refractive index.) Compute the effective refractive index $n = 1 + 2|\Phi|/c^2$ for a point mass $M = M_\odot$ at distances: (a) $r = R_\odot$, (b) $r = 1$ AU, (c) $r = 1$ kpc. Comment on whether the weak-field approximation is valid in each case.

Exercise 5.10.4. (Deflection angle from null geodesics.) Derive $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$ by evaluating the integral (5.18) with $\gamma_{\rm PPN} = 1$ for a point mass along the unperturbed path. Compute the deflection angle for: (a) the Sun at the solar limb, (b) a $10^{12}\,M_\odot$ galaxy at $b = 10$ kpc. Express results in arcseconds.

Exercise 5.10.5. (Superposition of deflection angles.) Two equal point masses M are separated by distance d in the lens plane.

(a) Derive the total deflection angle for a photon passing at perpendicular distance b from the midpoint (along the symmetry axis perpendicular to the line joining the masses).

(b) Show that for $b \gg d$, the result approaches $\hat{\alpha} \to 4G(2M)/(c^2 b)$: at large distances the two masses act as a single mass $2M$.

(c) Plot $\hat{\alpha}(b)$ for $d = 1$ kpc and $M = 10^{11}\,M_\odot$ using Mathematica.

Part II

Gravitational Lensing Theory

Chapter 6

Light Deflection in Curved Spacetime

> *The great attraction of the theory is its logical consistency. If any deduction from it should prove untenable, it must be given up. A modification of it seems impossible without destruction of the whole.* — Albert Einstein, *The Times* (London), 28 November 1919
> (reprinted in *Science* **51**, 8, 1920)

In Chapter 4 we derived the effective potential for geodesic motion in Schwarzschild spacetime, and in Chapter 5 we obtained the deflection angle $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$ via the weak-field / Born approximation, showing how the factor of 2 over Newtonian gravity arises from the equal contributions of temporal and spatial curvature. We now derive the same result from the exact null geodesic orbit equation in the full Schwarzschild metric. Every lens equation, magnification formula, and time-delay expression in the chapters that follow rests on it.

We also derive the Shapiro time delay, which provides the second observable consequence of light propagation through a gravitational field, and compute the deflection for several astrophysically relevant systems: the Sun (Eddington's 1919 test), Jupiter, and a typical galaxy lens.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `deflection_angle.wl`: symbolic derivation of the deflection angle integral, weak-field expansion, numerical evaluation for Sun/Jupiter/galaxy, Shapiro delay, exact vs. approximate comparison, and figure generation
- `deflection_geometry.nb`: interactive notebook: ray-bending geometry, sliders for M and b, exact vs. weak-field comparison with error percentage

6.1 Introduction: Null Geodesics and the Deflection Problem

Light follows *null geodesics* in curved spacetime: paths for which $ds^2 = 0$ at every point. In Chapter 4 we showed that for a photon in the equatorial plane of the Schwarzschild metric, the conserved energy E and angular momentum L reduce the equations of motion to a single

radial equation (cf. eqs. 4.3–4.4 and the null geodesic orbit equation (4.16) from Chapter 4):

$$\frac{d\phi}{dr} = \pm\frac{L}{r^2}\left[\frac{E^2}{c^2} - \frac{L^2}{r^2}\left(1 - \frac{R_S}{r}\right)\right]^{-1/2}, \tag{6.1}$$

where $R_S = 2GM/c^2$ is the Schwarzschild radius (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.87).

The physical setup is as follows. A photon approaches a mass M from infinity, reaches a distance of closest approach r_0, and then escapes back to infinity. The total change in the azimuthal angle ϕ is $\Delta\phi$; in flat spacetime this would be π (a straight line), so the *deflection angle* is

$$\hat{\alpha} = \Delta\phi - \pi\,. \tag{6.2}$$

Our goal in this chapter is to evaluate $\Delta\phi$ and show that, in the weak-field limit,

$$\boxed{\hat{\alpha} = \frac{4GM}{c^2\,b}} \tag{6.3}$$

where b is the impact parameter. This is the fundamental result of gravitational lensing.

6.2 Soldner's Newtonian Calculation (1801)

Before Einstein, Johann Georg von Soldner (1801) computed the deflection of light using Newtonian gravity, treating a photon as a corpuscle of mass m traveling at speed c.

Remark 6.2.1. Soldner's calculation predates general relativity by over a century. It gives exactly half the GR value, and the origin of the missing half is the contribution of spatial curvature, which the Newtonian calculation omits.

Consider a particle approaching a mass M on a hyperbolic trajectory with velocity $v_\infty = c$ at infinity. The Newtonian equations of motion in polar coordinates yield the orbit equation

$$r(\phi) = \frac{p}{1 + e\cos\phi}\,, \tag{6.4}$$

where $p = L^2/(GM)$ and $e = \sqrt{1 + 2\mathcal{E}L^2/(G^2M^2)}$ is the eccentricity (with $\mathcal{E} = \frac{1}{2}c^2$ for an unbound particle at speed c).

The asymptotic directions correspond to $r \to \infty$, i.e., $\cos\phi = -1/e$. The total angle swept is $\Delta\phi = \pi + 2\delta$, where $\sin\delta = 1/e$. For large impact parameter ($b \gg R_S$), the eccentricity is large and $\delta \approx 1/e \ll 1$, giving

$$\hat{\alpha}_{\text{Newton}} = 2\delta \approx \frac{2}{e} = \frac{2GM}{c^2\,b}\,. \tag{6.5}$$

Exercise 6.2.1. Derive eq. (6.5) in detail. Start from the Newtonian orbit equation for a massless particle with $v_\infty = c$ and impact parameter b.

(a) Show that the semi-latus rectum is $p = b^2c^2/(GM)$ and the eccentricity is $e = \sqrt{1 + b^2c^4/(GM)^2}$.

(b) For $b \gg GM/c^2$, show that $\hat{\alpha}_{\text{Newton}} = 2GM/(c^2 b)$.

Hint: The angular momentum is $L = bc$ and the energy is $\mathcal{E} = \frac{1}{2}c^2$.

6.3 The GR Deflection Angle — Full Derivation

We now follow Congdon & Keeton Sec. 3.4.1 (eqs. 3.87–3.96) to derive the deflection angle in general relativity. The result is $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$, exactly twice the Newtonian prediction.

6.3.1 The Impact Parameter

The *impact parameter* b is defined as the perpendicular distance between the undeflected ray (the asymptotic straight line at $r \to \infty$) and the mass M. From the conserved quantities, it is related to E and L by (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.90):

$$b = \frac{c\,L}{E}\,. \tag{6.6}$$

6.3.2 Distance of Closest Approach

At the turning point $r = r_0$, the radial velocity vanishes: $dr/d\lambda = 0$. From the radial equation of motion, this gives (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.89):

$$\frac{E^2}{c^2} - \frac{L^2}{r_0^2}\left(1 - \frac{R_{\rm S}}{r_0}\right) = 0\,. \tag{6.7}$$

Substituting $b = cL/E$ and defining $m \equiv GM/c^2 = R_{\rm S}/2$, we obtain

$$\frac{r_0^2}{b^2} = 1 - \frac{2m}{r_0}\,. \tag{6.8}$$

In the weak-field limit $m/r_0 \ll 1$, we can solve perturbatively: $r_0 \approx b\,(1 - m/b + \cdots)$, so to leading order $r_0 \approx b$.

6.3.3 The Total Azimuthal Change

By symmetry, the total angle swept from $r = \infty$ (incoming) to $r = \infty$ (outgoing) is twice the angle from r_0 to infinity:

$$\Delta\phi = 2\int_{r_0}^{\infty} \frac{L}{r^2}\left[\frac{E^2}{c^2} - \frac{L^2}{r^2}\left(1 - \frac{R_{\rm S}}{r}\right)\right]^{-1/2} dr\,. \tag{6.9}$$

Substituting $b = cL/E$ and simplifying (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.92):

$$\Delta\phi = 2\int_{r_0}^{\infty} \frac{dr}{r^2}\left[\frac{1}{b^2} - \frac{1}{r^2}\left(1 - \frac{2m}{r}\right)\right]^{-1/2}. \tag{6.10}$$

6.3.4 Change of Variables

Following Congdon & Keeton, we introduce the substitution $u = r_0/r$ (so $u = 0$ at $r = \infty$ and $u = 1$ at $r = r_0$):

$$\Delta\phi = 2\int_0^1 \frac{du}{\sqrt{\dfrac{r_0^2}{b^2} - u^2 + 2m\,\dfrac{u^3}{r_0}}}\,. \tag{6.11}$$

Using eq. (6.8) to replace $r_0^2/b^2 = 1 - 2m/r_0$ (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.93):

$$\Delta\phi = 2\int_0^1 \frac{du}{\sqrt{(1-u^2) - \dfrac{2m}{r_0}(1-u^3)}}\,. \tag{6.12}$$

6.3.5 Weak-Field Expansion

We define the small parameter $\varepsilon \equiv m/r_0 \ll 1$ and expand the integrand to first order in ε. Writing $f(u) = (1-u^2) - 2\varepsilon(1-u^3)$, we use

$$\frac{1}{\sqrt{f}} \approx \frac{1}{\sqrt{1-u^2}} + \frac{\varepsilon(1-u^3)}{(1-u^2)^{3/2}} + \mathcal{O}\big(\varepsilon^2\big)\,. \tag{6.13}$$

Therefore (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.94):

$$\Delta\phi \approx 2\int_0^1 \frac{du}{\sqrt{1-u^2}} + 2\varepsilon\int_0^1 \frac{1-u^3}{(1-u^2)^{3/2}}\,du + \mathcal{O}\big(\varepsilon^2\big)\,. \tag{6.14}$$

6.3.6 Evaluating the Integrals

The zeroth-order integral is evaluated with the substitution $u = \sin\theta$:

$$I_0 = 2\int_0^1 \frac{du}{\sqrt{1-u^2}} = 2\,[\arcsin u]_0^1 = 2\cdot\frac{\pi}{2} = \pi\,. \tag{6.15}$$

This is the flat-spacetime result: no deflection.

The first-order integral is the coefficient of m/r_0 in Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.94:

$$I_1 = 2\int_0^1 \frac{1-u^3}{(1-u^2)^{3/2}}\,du\,. \tag{6.16}$$

Factor the numerator: $1-u^3 = (1-u)(1+u+u^2)$ and $1-u^2 = (1-u)(1+u)$, so

$$\frac{1-u^3}{(1-u^2)^{3/2}} = \frac{(1-u)(1+u+u^2)}{(1-u)^{3/2}(1+u)^{3/2}} = \frac{1+u+u^2}{(1-u)^{1/2}(1+u)^{3/2}}\,. \tag{6.17}$$

The bare integral $\int_0^1 (1-u^3)(1-u^2)^{-3/2}\,du$ evaluates to 2 (verified in `deflection_angle.wl`), so

$$I_1 = 2\times 2 = 4\,. \tag{6.18}$$

Remark 6.3.1. The evaluation of $\int_0^1 (1-u^3)(1-u^2)^{-3/2}\,du = 2$ is a useful exercise in integration. One approach is to split $1+u+u^2 = (1+u)^2 - u$ and to evaluate each piece separately by a trigonometric or hyperbolic substitution. The Mathematica script verifies this symbolically.

6.3.7 The Deflection Angle

Assembling the result (Congdon & Keeton eqs. 3.95–3.96): using $\Delta\phi = I_0 + \varepsilon\, I_1 + \mathcal{O}(\varepsilon^2)$,

$$\Delta\phi = \pi + 4\varepsilon + \mathcal{O}\big(\varepsilon^2\big) = \pi + \frac{4m}{r_0} + \mathcal{O}(m/r_0)^2 \ . \tag{6.19}$$

Since $r_0 \approx b$ to leading order and $m = GM/c^2$:

$$\boxed{\hat{\alpha} = \Delta\phi - \pi = \frac{4GM}{c^2\, b} + \mathcal{O}\big(GM/(c^2 b)\big)^2} \tag{6.20}$$

This is the *Einstein deflection angle* for a point mass in the weak-field limit.

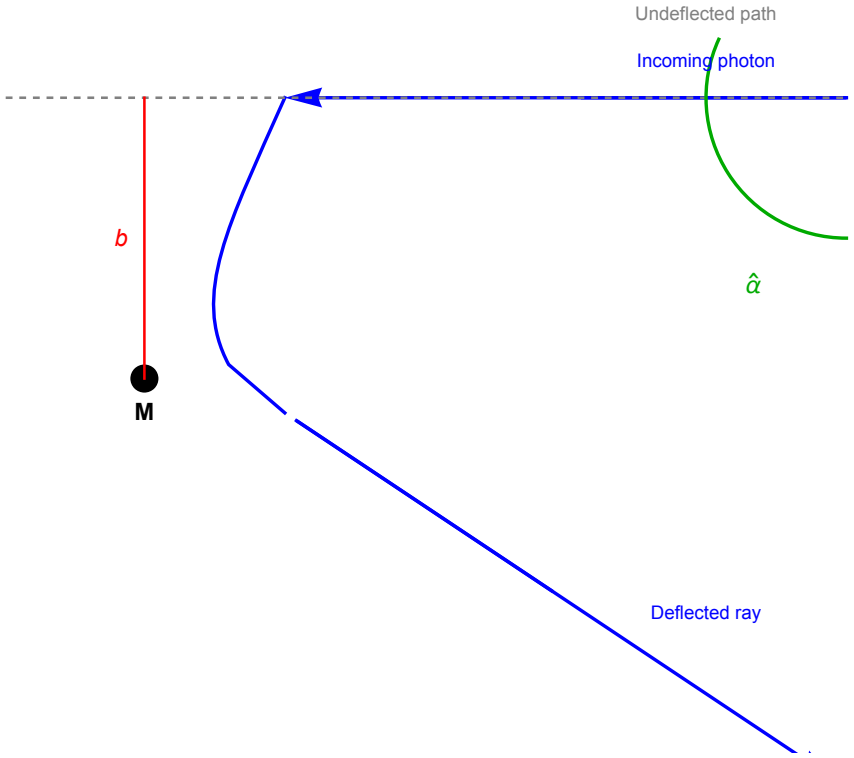


Figure 6.1: Geometry of gravitational light deflection by a point mass M. A photon approaches from the right with impact parameter b, reaches closest approach at $r_0 \approx b$, and is deflected by $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$. The dashed line shows the undeflected path. Generated by `deflection_angle.wl`.

Exercise 6.3.1. Show that the GR deflection angle (6.20) is exactly twice the Newtonian prediction (6.5). Explain physically why:

(a) The Newtonian calculation accounts for the deflection due to the gravitational potential (temporal curvature of the metric, g_{tt}), but ignores spatial curvature (g_{rr}).

(b) In GR, both g_{tt} and g_{rr} deviate from flat space by the same amount (to leading order in m/r), so the spatial curvature doubles the deflection.

Hint: Expand the Schwarzschild line element in isotropic coordinates and identify the contributions from the time–time and space–space components of the metric.

6.4 The Shapiro Time Delay

In addition to deflecting light, a gravitational field causes an excess travel time relative to the flat-spacetime path, as though the light were slowed. This effect was predicted by Irwin Shapiro in 1964 and first measured using radar echoes from Mercury and Venus.

Following Congdon & Keeton Sec. 3.4.2 (eqs. 3.97–3.110), we derive the time delay for a photon passing near a point mass.

6.4.1 Coordinate Travel Time

For a photon on a null geodesic, we can write dt/dr using the conserved quantities (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.97):

$$\frac{dt}{dr} = \frac{E/c^2}{(1 - R_{\rm S}/r)} \left[\frac{E^2}{c^2} - \frac{L^2}{r^2}\left(1 - \frac{R_{\rm S}}{r}\right) \right]^{-1/2} . \tag{6.21}$$

The coordinate time for the photon to travel from closest approach r_0 to a radial distance R is (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.97):

$$T(R) = \int_{r_0}^{R} \frac{dt}{dr}\, dr \,. \tag{6.22}$$

In the weak-field limit ($m/r \ll 1$), expanding to first order gives (Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.100, second line; its expansion in r_0/R is their eq. 3.102):

$$T(R) \approx \frac{1}{c}\sqrt{R^2 - r_0^2} + \frac{2m}{c} \ln\!\left(\frac{R + \sqrt{R^2 - r_0^2}}{r_0} \right) + \frac{m}{c}\sqrt{\frac{R - r_0}{R + r_0}} \,. \tag{6.23}$$

6.4.2 The Two Components of Time Delay

The total time delay ΔT for a lensed photon (relative to the unlensed path) has two contributions (Congdon & Keeton eqs. 3.107–3.110):

$$\boxed{\Delta T = \underbrace{\frac{D_{\rm d} D_{\rm s}}{2c\, D_{\rm ds}} (\theta - \beta)^2}_{\text{geometric delay}} + \underbrace{\frac{4GM}{c^3} \ln \frac{\theta_{\rm ref}}{|\theta|}}_{\text{Shapiro (gravitational) delay}}} \tag{6.24}$$

where $D_{\rm d}$, $D_{\rm s}$, $D_{\rm ds}$ are the angular diameter distances from observer to lens, observer to source, and lens to source respectively; θ is the image position and β the (unlensed) source position; and $\theta_{\rm ref}$ is an arbitrary reference angle. Changing $\theta_{\rm ref}$ adds the same constant to ΔT for every image, so it drops out of the measurable delay *differences* between images.

Remark 6.4.1. The geometric delay arises because the lensed ray follows a longer path through space than the direct (unlensed) ray; it is a purely geometric effect and is always positive. The Shapiro delay arises because the gravitational potential lowers the effective speed of light near the lens: clocks near a mass run slower (gravitational redshift), so the signal takes longer to traverse the potential well.

Remark 6.4.2. The total time delay (6.24) is closely related to the *Fermat potential*, which we will study in detail in Chapter 10. The Fermat potential $\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ encodes both the geometric and gravitational delays, and its gradient gives the lens equation. Images form at stationary points of the Fermat potential (Fermat's principle applied to gravitational lensing).

Exercise 6.4.1. Derive the Shapiro time delay for a radar signal passing near the Sun and bouncing off a planet at distance R from the Sun.

(a) Show that the excess round-trip travel time is approximately

$$\Delta T \approx \frac{4GM_\odot}{c^3} \ln\!\left(\frac{4R_\oplus R}{r_0^2}\right)$$

where $R_\oplus$ is the Earth–Sun distance and r_0 the closest approach distance.

(b) For a signal grazing the Sun ($r_0 = R_\odot$) bouncing off Mercury at superior conjunction (Mercury behind the Sun as seen from Earth), compute ΔT numerically. You should find $\Delta T \approx 220$ μs (240 μs once the non-logarithmic $+1$ of Exercise 6.9.4 is kept).

6.5 Deflection by the Sun

The first and most famous test of the GR deflection formula was Eddington's 1919 solar eclipse expedition. During a total eclipse, stars near the Sun become visible, and their apparent positions are shifted outward by the gravitational deflection.

For light grazing the limb of the Sun ($b = R_\odot$):

$$\hat{\alpha}_\odot = \frac{4GM_\odot}{c^2\, R_\odot} = \frac{4 \times 6.674 \times 10^{-11} \times 1.989 \times 10^{30}}{(2.998 \times 10^8)^2 \times 6.957 \times 10^8} \approx 8.49 \times 10^{-6} \text{ rad}\,. \tag{6.25}$$

Converting to arcseconds:

$$\boxed{\hat{\alpha}_\odot = 1.75''} \tag{6.26}$$

This is the Newtonian value $0.876''$ doubled by general relativity. Eddington's measurements confirmed the GR prediction (within the substantial error bars of the time), making Einstein a global celebrity.

Example 6.5.1. Deflection by Jupiter. Jupiter has $M_J = 1.898 \times 10^{27}$ kg and $R_J = 7.149 \times 10^7$ m. The deflection for light grazing Jupiter's limb is:

$$\hat{\alpha}_J = \frac{4GM_J}{c^2\, R_J} \approx 0.016'' = 16 \text{ mas}\,. \tag{6.27}$$

This is small but measurable with modern astrometry (e.g., the Gaia satellite, which achieves ~ 10 μas precision).

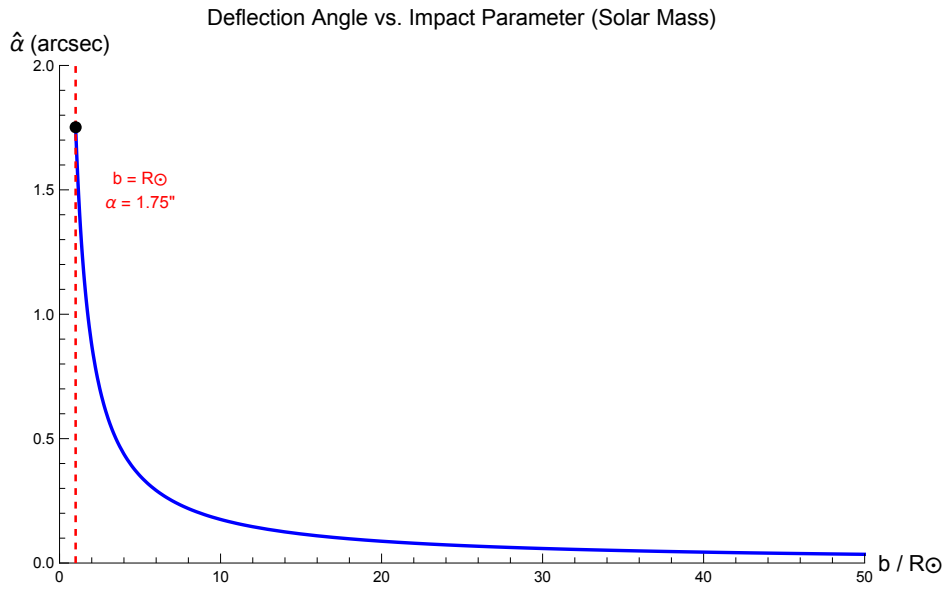


Figure 6.2: Deflection angle $\hat{\alpha}$ as a function of impact parameter b for a solar-mass lens, shown in arcseconds. The deflection falls as $1/b$. The vertical dashed line marks the solar radius ($b = R_\odot$) where $\hat{\alpha} = 1.75''$. Generated by `deflection_angle.wl`.

Exercise 6.5.1. Compute the deflection angle for light grazing the surface of:

(a) The Sun ($M = 1.989 \times 10^{30}$ kg, $R = 6.957 \times 10^{8}$ m): verify $\hat{\alpha} = 1.75''$.

(b) Jupiter ($M = 1.898 \times 10^{27}$ kg, $R = 7.149 \times 10^{7}$ m).

(c) A $10^{12}\,M_\odot$ galaxy with effective radius $R_e = 10$ kpc, using $b = R_e$. Express the result in arcseconds.

6.6 Deflection by Galaxies

Gravitational lensing is astrophysically useful because the deflection angles produced by galaxies are of order arcseconds, large enough to produce multiple images, arcs, and rings that are observable with ground-based and space-based telescopes.

For a galaxy of mass $M = 10^{12}\,M_\odot$ with a typical scale of $b \sim 10$ kpc $\approx 3.09 \times 10^{20}$ m:

$$\hat{\alpha} \sim \frac{4GM}{c^2\, b} = \frac{4 \times 6.674 \times 10^{-11} \times 10^{12} \times 1.989 \times 10^{30}}{(2.998 \times 10^{8})^2 \times 3.09 \times 10^{20}} \approx 3.9'' \tag{6.28}$$

The corresponding Einstein radius (which we will derive properly in Chapter 8) is a few arcseconds, depending on the distance configuration.

Remark 6.6.1. The Einstein radius θ_{E} for a point mass lens at cosmological distances is:

$$\theta_{\mathrm{E}} = \sqrt{\frac{4GM}{c^2}\,\frac{D_{\mathrm{ds}}}{D_{\mathrm{d}}\, D_{\mathrm{s}}}}\,. \tag{6.29}$$

For a $10^{12}\,M_\odot$ galaxy at $z_d \sim 0.3$ with a source at $z_s \sim 1$, this gives $\theta_{\rm E} \approx 2.4''$ (Exercise 7.18.5).[1] Multiple images form whenever the source lies within $\sim \theta_{\rm E}$ of the optical axis; this is the regime of *strong gravitational lensing*. We develop this quantitatively in Chapters 8–9.

6.7 Exact vs. Weak-Field Deflection

The weak-field formula $\hat\alpha = 4m/b$ is a first-order approximation valid when $b \gg R_{\rm S}$. For photons passing closer to the mass, higher-order corrections become important. The *exact* deflection angle is obtained by evaluating the integral (6.12) numerically (or using elliptic integrals), without the weak-field expansion.

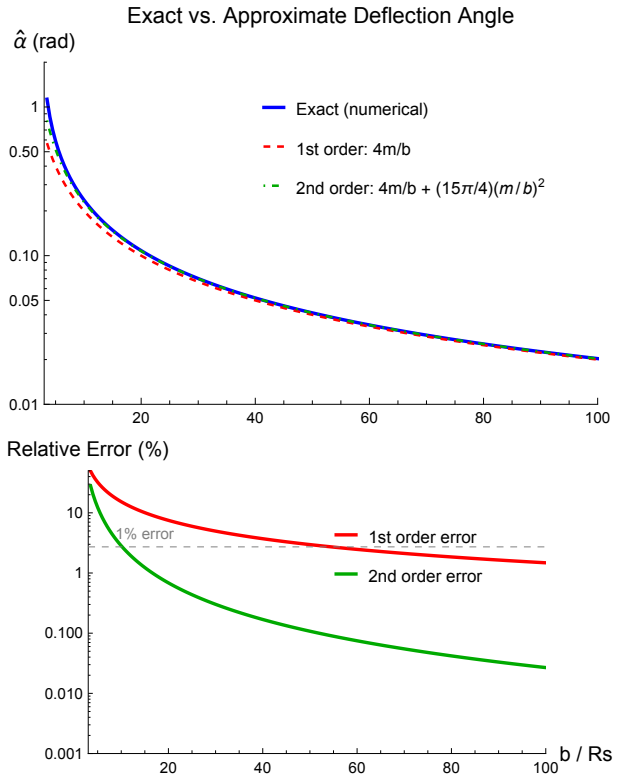


Figure 6.3: Comparison of the exact deflection angle (solid blue, from numerical integration) and the weak-field approximations $\hat\alpha = 4m/b$ (dashed red, first order) and including the second-order correction (dot-dashed green), as a function of $b/R_{\rm S}$. The lower panel shows the relative error. The first-order approximation has $\sim 15\%$ error at $b = 10\,R_{\rm S}$ and reaches 1% accuracy only for $b \gtrsim 150\,R_{\rm S}$. At the photon sphere $b = 3\sqrt{3}\,R_{\rm S}/2$, the exact deflection diverges (the photon orbits the mass). Generated by `deflection_angle.wl`.

The second-order correction has been computed by several authors; the result is (see, e.g., Keeton & Petters 2005):

$$\hat\alpha = \frac{4m}{b} + \frac{15\pi}{4}\left(\frac{m}{b}\right)^2 + \mathcal{O}(m/b)^3\ . \tag{6.30}$$

[1] Earlier versions of this remark quoted $\theta_{\rm E} \sim 1''$; with the concordance distances of Chapter 7 ($D_d = 919$, $D_s = 1652$, $D_{ds} = 1055$ Mpc) the value is $2.38''$.

The critical impact parameter below which the photon is captured (i.e., spirals into the mass) is $b_{\rm crit} = 3\sqrt{3}\,m = 3\sqrt{3}\,R_{\rm S}/2$. This corresponds to the photon sphere derived in Chapter 4.

Exercise 6.7.1. For a photon passing a Schwarzschild black hole at impact parameter $b = 10\,R_{\rm S}$:

(a) Evaluate the deflection integral (6.12) numerically to obtain the exact deflection angle.

(b) Compare with the weak-field approximation $\hat{\alpha} = 4m/b = 0.2$ rad. What is the relative error?

(c) Repeat for several values of $b/R_{\rm S}$ from 5 to 100. At what $b/R_{\rm S}$ does the weak-field approximation first achieve 1% accuracy?

Use the Mathematica script `deflection_angle.wl` *to verify your results.*

6.8 Summary

Light follows null geodesics in Schwarzschild spacetime, and the orbit equation (6.1) reduces to an integral for the total azimuthal angle change $\Delta\phi$. The Newtonian prediction (Soldner, 1801) is $\hat{\alpha}_{\rm Newton} = 2GM/(c^2 b)$; it accounts for only the temporal curvature of spacetime. The GR prediction (Einstein, 1915) is $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$; the factor of 2 enhancement comes from spatial curvature, which contributes equally to the deflection. For the Sun, $\hat{\alpha}_\odot = 1.75''$, confirmed by Eddington (1919) and by modern measurements to $< 0.01\%$; for $\sim 10^{12}\,M_\odot$ galaxies at $b \sim 10$ kpc, $\hat{\alpha} \sim 1''$–$4''$, large enough to produce multiple images, arcs, and Einstein rings.

A gravitational field also causes an excess travel time ΔT, the Shapiro delay, with geometric and gravitational components; it is connected to the Fermat potential of Chapter 10. The weak-field approximation $\hat{\alpha} = 4m/b$ converges slowly: the error is $\sim 15\%$ at $b = 10\,R_{\rm S}$ and drops below 1% only for $b \gtrsim 150\,R_{\rm S}$. The exact deflection diverges at the photon sphere ($b_{\rm crit} = 3\sqrt{3}\,R_{\rm S}/2$).

6.9 Problems

Exercise 6.9.1. (Soldner's Newtonian deflection.) Derive the Newtonian deflection angle for a "corpuscle of light" traveling at speed c past a mass M at impact parameter b.

(a) Write the Newtonian orbit equation and identify the semi-latus rectum p and eccentricity e in terms of b, M, G, and c.

(b) Show that the deflection angle is $\hat{\alpha}_{\rm Newton} = 2GM/(c^2 b)$ in the weak-field limit.

(c) Compute the Newtonian prediction for the solar deflection. You should get $0.876''$.

Exercise 6.9.2. (The factor of 2: GR vs. Newton.)

(a) Starting from the result $\Delta\phi = \pi + 4m/r_0$, show that the GR deflection angle is $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$.

(b) The Newtonian result uses only $g_{tt} \approx -(1 - 2\Phi/c^2)$ where $\Phi = -GM/r$. In GR, the spatial part of the Schwarzschild metric also curves: $g_{rr} \approx 1 + 2GM/(c^2 r)$. Argue qualitatively (or using the isotropic form of the metric) that the spatial curvature contributes an *equal* amount of deflection, doubling the Newtonian result.

Exercise 6.9.3. (Deflection for Sun, Jupiter, and galaxy.) Compute $\hat{\alpha}$ for:

(a) Light grazing the Sun: $M = 1.989 \times 10^{30}$ kg, $b = R_\odot = 6.957 \times 10^8$ m.

(b) Light grazing Jupiter: $M = 1.898 \times 10^{27}$ kg, $b = R_J = 7.149 \times 10^7$ m.

(c) A $10^{12}\, M_\odot$ galaxy at $b = 10$ kpc.

Express all answers in arcseconds. Verify with `problems_02.wl`.

Exercise 6.9.4. (Shapiro time delay for radar echoes.) A radar signal is sent from Earth, passes near the Sun at closest approach r_0, bounces off Mercury, and returns.

(a) Using eq. (6.23), show that the excess round-trip time is

$$\Delta T \approx \frac{4GM_\odot}{c^3}\left[\ln\left(\frac{4\, R_\oplus\, R_{\rm Merc}}{r_0^2}\right) + 1\right]$$

where $R_\oplus = 1.496 \times 10^{11}$ m and $R_{\rm Merc} = 5.79 \times 10^{10}$ m are the Earth–Sun and Mercury–Sun distances.

(b) For $r_0 = R_\odot$, compute ΔT in microseconds.

(c) The first radar measurement of the effect [45] gave $\Delta T = 200 \pm 20$ μs; the prediction is Shapiro [44]. By how many standard deviations does it differ from your result, and what could account for the difference?

Exercise 6.9.5. (Exact vs. weak-field deflection.) For a photon passing a Schwarzschild mass at impact parameter $b = 10\, R_{\rm S}$:

(a) Evaluate the exact deflection angle by numerically integrating eq. (6.12).

(b) Compare with the first-order approximation $\hat{\alpha}_1 = 4m/b$ and the second-order approximation $\hat{\alpha}_2 = 4m/b + (15\pi/4)(m/b)^2$.

(c) Tabulate the relative error of $\hat{\alpha}_1$ and $\hat{\alpha}_2$ for $b/R_{\rm S} = 5, 10, 20, 50, 100$.

(d) At what value of $b/R_{\rm S}$ does the first-order approximation first achieve 1% accuracy?

Use `deflection_angle.wl` *to generate and verify your results.*

Chapter 7

Cosmological Distances

> *Not only does God definitely play dice, but He sometimes confuses us by throwing them where they can't be seen.* — Stephen Hawking, *Does God Play Dice?* (public lecture, 1999)

Gravitational lensing is inherently a cosmological phenomenon: the lens and source are typically at redshifts $z \sim 0.1$–3, separated by distances of order gigaparsecs. To connect the physical deflection angle $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$ derived in Chapters 5 and 6 to observable image positions on the sky, we need a precise definition of "distance" in an expanding universe. Unlike in Euclidean space, there is no single notion of distance in cosmology: the *angular diameter distance* (relevant for angles), the *luminosity distance* (relevant for fluxes), and the *comoving distance* (relevant for volumes) are all distinct.

This chapter develops the full framework of cosmological distances from first principles. In Part A we derive the Friedmann–Lemaître–Robertson–Walker (FLRW) metric from the cosmological principle, compute the Christoffel symbols and curvature tensors for this metric using the tools from Chapter 2, and plug into Einstein's equations with a perfect-fluid stress-energy tensor to obtain the Friedmann equations, the dynamical equations governing the expansion of the universe. In Part B we define the various distance measures, derive the distance ratios that enter the lens equation, and show that the angular diameter distance is not monotonic in redshift: it turns over at $z \sim 1.6$ for the concordance cosmology.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `friedmann_equations.wl`: symbolic computation of Christoffel symbols and curvature tensors for the FRW metric, derivation of the Friedmann equations, scale factor solutions, cosmological distance calculations, and figure generation
- `cosmological_distances.nb`: interactive notebook with sliders for Ω_m, Ω_Λ, H_0 showing how distance–redshift relations change; lensing geometry calculator

Part A: The FRW Metric and Friedmann Equations

7.1 The Cosmological Principle

Modern cosmology rests on the *cosmological principle*: on sufficiently large scales ($\gtrsim 100$ Mpc), the universe is *spatially homogeneous* (the same at every point) and *spatially isotropic* (the same in every direction). Both symmetry assumptions are supported by observation: the cosmic microwave background (CMB) is isotropic to one part in 10^5 across the sky, and the large-scale distribution of galaxies becomes statistically uniform on scales $\gtrsim 100$ Mpc, as shown by surveys such as SDSS, 2dFGRS, and DESI.

Remark 7.1.1. Homogeneity and isotropy constrain only the *spatial* geometry of the universe at each instant. The universe is manifestly *not* homogeneous in time: it was denser and hotter in the past. The metric is therefore allowed to have time-dependent coefficients (the scale factor), and it is this time dependence that encodes the expansion history.

The cosmological principle has a strong mathematical consequence: the spatial part of the metric must be a maximally symmetric 3-dimensional Riemannian manifold. By a classic theorem in differential geometry (see Carroll Secs. 3.9 and 8.2), maximally symmetric n-dimensional spaces have $n(n+1)/2$ Killing vectors, and there are exactly three possibilities for $n = 3$: positive curvature (the 3-sphere S^3), zero curvature (flat $\mathbb{R}^3$), or negative curvature (the 3-hyperboloid H^3). These are characterized by a single parameter, the *spatial curvature constant* k:

$$k = \begin{cases} +1 & \text{positive curvature (closed, finite volume)} \\ 0 & \text{zero curvature (flat, infinite volume)} \\ -1 & \text{negative curvature (open, infinite volume)} \end{cases} \tag{7.1}$$

7.2 The Robertson–Walker Metric

Combining the cosmological principle with the requirement that spacetime be described by a Lorentzian 4-metric, the most general metric takes the *Robertson–Walker (RW)* form (Carroll eq. 8.43; Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.123a):

$$\boxed{ds^2 = -c^2\,dt^2 + a^2(t)\left[\frac{dr^2}{1-kr^2} + r^2\big(d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta\,d\phi^2\big)\right]} \tag{7.2}$$

where t is the *cosmic time*, the proper time measured by comoving observers (those at rest with respect to the Hubble flow); $a(t)$ is the *scale factor*, a dimensionless function of time that encodes how distances between comoving observers change, normalised so that $a(t_0) = 1$ at the present epoch; r, θ, ϕ are *comoving coordinates*, the coordinate labels assigned to comoving observers, which do not change as the universe expands; and $k = -1, 0, +1$ is the spatial curvature parameter. The physical distance between two comoving observers separated by coordinate distance Δr is $a(t)\,\Delta r$, which grows with time if the universe is expanding ($\dot{a} > 0$).

Remark 7.2.1. The metric (7.2) is purely *kinematical*: it is the most general metric consistent with homogeneity and isotropy, but it tells us nothing about how $a(t)$ evolves. The dynamics of $a(t)$ come from plugging this metric into Einstein's field equations, which we do in the next sections to derive the Friedmann equations.

It is often useful to write the spatial part of the metric using the *comoving distance* χ defined by

$$d\chi = \frac{dr}{\sqrt{1-kr^2}}\,, \tag{7.3}$$

so that

$$ds^2 = -c^2\,dt^2 + a^2(t)\left[d\chi^2 + S_k^2(\chi)\,d\Omega^2\right], \tag{7.4}$$

where $d\Omega^2 = d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta\,d\phi^2$ and the *transverse comoving distance* $S_k(\chi)$ is

$$S_k(\chi) = \begin{cases} \sin\chi & k=+1 \\ \chi & k=0 \\ \sinh\chi & k=-1 \end{cases} \tag{7.5}$$

7.3 Christoffel Symbols for the FRW Metric

To derive the Friedmann equations, we need the Christoffel symbols, Ricci tensor, and Ricci scalar for the RW metric (7.2). We use the general functions developed in Chapter 2 (`christoffel_symbols.wl`) and verified symbolically in `friedmann_equations.wl`.

The coordinates are $x^\mu = (t, r, \theta, \phi)$, and the nonvanishing metric components are (reading off from eq. (7.2)):

$$\begin{aligned} g_{00} &= -c^2\,, & g_{11} &= \frac{a^2(t)}{1-kr^2}\,, \\ g_{22} &= a^2(t)\,r^2\,, & g_{33} &= a^2(t)\,r^2\sin^2\theta\,. \end{aligned} \tag{7.6}$$

Since this is a diagonal metric, we use the formulas from Chapter 2 (Remark 2.10.1): for a diagonal metric with components g_{aa} (no sum),

$$\begin{aligned} \Gamma^a{}_{bb} &= -\frac{1}{2g_{aa}}\,\partial_a g_{bb} \qquad (a \neq b)\,, \\ \Gamma^a{}_{ab} &= \frac{1}{2g_{aa}}\,\partial_b g_{aa} \qquad (\text{no sum on } a)\,. \end{aligned} \tag{7.7}$$

The nonvanishing Christoffel symbols of the RW metric are (Carroll eq. 8.44; verified in `friedmann_equations.wl`). The mixed time–space symbols are

$$\Gamma^0{}_{11} = \frac{a\dot{a}}{c^2(1-kr^2)}\,, \quad \Gamma^0{}_{22} = \frac{a\dot{a}\,r^2}{c^2}\,, \quad \Gamma^0{}_{33} = \frac{a\dot{a}\,r^2\sin^2\theta}{c^2} \tag{7.8}$$

and their counterparts (mixed time–space, related by the symmetry $\Gamma^\rho{}_{\mu\nu} = \Gamma^\rho{}_{\nu\mu}$):

$$\Gamma^1{}_{01} = \Gamma^2{}_{02} = \Gamma^3{}_{03} = \frac{\dot{a}}{a} \tag{7.9}$$

where the dot denotes d/dt. The purely spatial symbols are

$$\Gamma^1{}_{11} = \frac{kr}{1-kr^2}\,, \qquad \Gamma^1{}_{22} = -r(1-kr^2)\,,$$
$$\Gamma^1{}_{33} = -r(1-kr^2)\sin^2\theta\,, \qquad \Gamma^2{}_{12} = \frac{1}{r}\,,$$
$$\Gamma^2{}_{33} = -\sin\theta\cos\theta\,, \qquad \Gamma^3{}_{13} = \frac{1}{r}\,,$$
$$\Gamma^3{}_{23} = \frac{\cos\theta}{\sin\theta}\,. \tag{7.10}$$

Exercise 7.3.1. Compute all nonvanishing Christoffel symbols of the RW metric by hand using the diagonal metric formulas (7.7). Verify your results with `friedmann_equations.wl`, which uses the general `computeChristoffel` function from Chapter 2.

7.4 Ricci Tensor and Ricci Scalar

From the Christoffel symbols, we compute the Riemann tensor $R^\rho{}_{\sigma\mu\nu}$, contract to obtain the Ricci tensor $R_{\mu\nu} = R^\lambda{}_{\mu\lambda\nu}$, and then contract again with the inverse metric to get the Ricci scalar $R = g^{\mu\nu}R_{\mu\nu}$. The computation is lengthy but straightforward; we quote the results here and verify them symbolically in `friedmann_equations.wl`.

The nonvanishing independent components of the Ricci tensor are (Carroll eq. 8.45, restoring c with $x^0 = t$, so that $g_{00} = -c^2$):[1]

$$R_{00} = -\frac{3\ddot{a}}{a}\,, \tag{7.11}$$

$$R_{11} = \frac{1}{c^2(1-kr^2)}\left(a\ddot{a} + 2\dot{a}^2 + 2kc^2\right), \tag{7.12}$$

$$R_{22} = \frac{r^2}{c^2}\left(a\ddot{a} + 2\dot{a}^2 + 2kc^2\right), \tag{7.13}$$

$$R_{33} = \frac{r^2\sin^2\theta}{c^2}\left(a\ddot{a} + 2\dot{a}^2 + 2kc^2\right). \tag{7.14}$$

R_{11}, R_{22}, and R_{33} share the same combination $a\ddot{a} + 2\dot{a}^2 + 2kc^2$, which is a consequence of spatial isotropy. We can write the spatial components compactly as:

$$R_{ij} = \frac{g_{ij}}{c^2\,a^2}\left(a\ddot{a} + 2\dot{a}^2 + 2kc^2\right). \tag{7.15}$$

The Ricci scalar is:

$$\boxed{R = g^{\mu\nu}R_{\mu\nu} = \frac{6}{c^2}\left(\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} + \frac{\dot{a}^2}{a^2} + \frac{kc^2}{a^2}\right)} \tag{7.16}$$

[1] Earlier versions printed $R_{00} = -3\ddot{a}/(c^2 a)$, which is the component with respect to $x^0 = ct$, and combined it with $g_{00} = -c^2$ and $T_{00} = \rho c^4$ (the $x^0 = t$ values). The mixed bookkeeping put a spurious $1/c^2$ into eq. (7.21); the spatial components and R do not depend on the choice of x^0.

7.5 Einstein's Equations with a Perfect Fluid

Einstein's field equations relate the geometry of spacetime (the Einstein tensor $G_{\mu\nu}$) to the matter content (the stress-energy tensor $T_{\mu\nu}$):

$$G_{\mu\nu} + \Lambda g_{\mu\nu} = R_{\mu\nu} - \tfrac{1}{2}R\, g_{\mu\nu} + \Lambda g_{\mu\nu} = \frac{8\pi G}{c^4}\, T_{\mu\nu} \tag{7.17}$$

where Λ is the *cosmological constant*.

For a *perfect fluid* at rest in the comoving frame (the natural choice for a homogeneous, isotropic universe), the stress-energy tensor is (Carroll eq. 8.48):

$$T^{\mu\nu} = \left(\rho + \frac{p}{c^2}\right) U^\mu U^\nu + p\, g^{\mu\nu} \tag{7.18}$$

where ρ is the *mass-energy density* (energy density $/c^2$), p is the *pressure*, and $U^\mu = (1, 0, 0, 0)$ is the four-velocity of comoving observers [with $g_{00} = -c^2$, the standard normalisation $g_{\mu\nu}U^\mu U^\nu = -c^2$ gives $g_{00}(U^0)^2 = -c^2$, so $U^0 = 1$]. The components in the comoving frame are:

$$T^{00} = \rho\,, \qquad T^{ij} = p\, g^{ij}\,, \qquad T^{0i} = 0\,. \tag{7.19}$$

With indices lowered using $T_{\mu\nu} = g_{\mu\alpha}g_{\nu\beta}T^{\alpha\beta}$: $T_{00} = (g_{00})^2\, T^{00} = c^4\rho$ and $T_{ij} = p\, g_{ij}$.

Remark 7.5.1. In cosmology, the "fluid" is not a literal gas: ρ and p represent the averaged energy density and pressure of *all* matter and radiation in the universe, smoothed over scales $\gg 100$ Mpc. The cosmological principle guarantees that ρ and p depend only on time: $\rho = \rho(t)$, $p = p(t)$.

7.6 The Friedmann Equations

We now substitute the Ricci tensor (7.11)–(7.15) and the Ricci scalar (7.16) into Einstein's equations (7.17) with the perfect-fluid stress-energy tensor (7.19).

7.6.1 The First Friedmann Equation

The $(0, 0)$ component of Einstein's equations gives:

$$R_{00} - \tfrac{1}{2}R\, g_{00} + \Lambda g_{00} = \frac{8\pi G}{c^4}\, T_{00}\,. \tag{7.20}$$

Substituting $R_{00} = -3\ddot{a}/a$, $g_{00} = -c^2$, $R = 6(\ddot{a}/a + \dot{a}^2/a^2 + kc^2/a^2)/c^2$, and $T_{00} = \rho c^4$:
Left side:

$$\begin{aligned} R_{00} - \tfrac{1}{2}R\, g_{00} + \Lambda g_{00} &= -\frac{3\ddot{a}}{a} + 3\left(\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} + \frac{\dot{a}^2}{a^2} + \frac{kc^2}{a^2}\right) - \Lambda c^2 \\ &= 3\left(\frac{\dot{a}^2}{a^2} + \frac{kc^2}{a^2}\right) - \Lambda c^2\,. \end{aligned} \tag{7.21}$$

Right side:

$$\frac{8\pi G}{c^4}\,\rho c^4 = 8\pi G\rho\,. \tag{7.22}$$

Setting these equal and rearranging:

$$\boxed{\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 = \frac{8\pi G\rho}{3} - \frac{kc^2}{a^2} + \frac{\Lambda c^2}{3}} \tag{7.23}$$

This is the *first Friedmann equation*. It relates the expansion rate $\dot{a}/a$ to the energy density ρ, spatial curvature k, and cosmological constant Λ.

7.6.2 The Second Friedmann Equation

The spatial (i,j) components of Einstein's equations, using the compact form (7.15) and $T_{ij} = p\,g_{ij}$, give (after dividing both sides by $g_{ij}/(c^2a^2)$):

$$\boxed{\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} = -\frac{4\pi G}{3}\left(\rho + \frac{3p}{c^2}\right) + \frac{\Lambda c^2}{3}} \tag{7.24}$$

This is the *second Friedmann equation* (or *acceleration equation*). It shows that matter and radiation ($\rho > 0$, $p \geq 0$) cause the expansion to decelerate ($\ddot{a} < 0$), while a positive cosmological constant $\Lambda > 0$ causes acceleration ($\ddot{a} > 0$).

Remark 7.6.1. The combination $\rho + 3p/c^2$ in the second Friedmann equation is what governs cosmic acceleration. Pressure contributes to gravity in GR (unlike in Newtonian gravity), and the factor of 3 comes from the three spatial dimensions. For a cosmological constant (with equation of state $p = -\rho c^2$), this combination is $\rho + 3(-\rho) = -2\rho < 0$, leading to acceleration.

7.6.3 The Fluid Conservation Equation

The Friedmann equations (7.23) and (7.24) are not independent: differentiating the first and substituting the second yields the *fluid conservation equation* (equivalently, this follows from $\nabla_\mu T^{\mu\nu} = 0$):

$$\boxed{\dot{\rho} + 3\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\left(\rho + \frac{p}{c^2}\right) = 0} \tag{7.25}$$

This is the relativistic analogue of the first law of thermodynamics: the energy density decreases as the universe expands, with the rate depending on both ρ and p. The $3\dot{a}/a$ factor reflects the three-dimensional expansion.

Exercise 7.6.1. Derive the Friedmann equations (7.23) and (7.24) from the Einstein equations (7.17) with the FRW Ricci tensor and the perfect-fluid stress-energy tensor. Verify each step with `friedmann_equations.wl`.

7.7 The Hubble Parameter and Density Parameters

7.7.1 The Hubble Parameter

The *Hubble parameter* is defined as the fractional expansion rate:

$$H(t) \equiv \frac{\dot{a}(t)}{a(t)} \,. \tag{7.26}$$

Its present-day value is the *Hubble constant*:

$$H_0 \equiv H(t_0) \approx 70 \ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}} \,. \tag{7.27}$$

The associated timescale is $t_H \equiv 1/H_0 \approx 14$ Gyr, and the associated length scale is the *Hubble distance*:

$$d_H \equiv \frac{c}{H_0} \approx 4.28 \ \mathrm{Gpc} \approx 1.32 \times 10^{26} \ \mathrm{m} \,. \tag{7.28}$$

7.7.2 Density Parameters

The first Friedmann equation (7.23) can be rewritten in terms of dimensionless *density parameters*. Define the *critical density* as the density required for a spatially flat ($k = 0$), $\Lambda = 0$ universe:

$$\rho_{\rm cr}(t) \equiv \frac{3H^2(t)}{8\pi G} \,, \qquad \rho_{\rm cr,0} = \frac{3H_0^2}{8\pi G} \approx 9.2 \times 10^{-27} \ \mathrm{kg\,m^{-3}} \,. \tag{7.29}$$

The density parameters are:

$$\begin{aligned}
\Omega_{\rm m} &\equiv \frac{\rho_{m,0}}{\rho_{\rm cr,0}} \,, && \text{(matter: non-relativistic)} \\
\Omega_r &\equiv \frac{\rho_{r,0}}{\rho_{\rm cr,0}} \,, && \text{(radiation: relativistic)} \\
\Omega_\Lambda &\equiv \frac{\Lambda c^2}{3H_0^2} \,, && \text{(dark energy / cosmological constant)} \\
\Omega_k &\equiv -\frac{kc^2}{H_0^2} \,. && \text{(spatial curvature)}
\end{aligned} \tag{7.30}$$

With these definitions, the first Friedmann equation at the present epoch reduces to the *cosmic sum rule*:

$$\boxed{\Omega_{\rm m} + \Omega_r + \Omega_\Lambda + \Omega_k = 1} \tag{7.31}$$

Current observations (Planck 2018) give $\Omega_{\rm m} \approx 0.31$, $\Omega_\Lambda \approx 0.69$, $\Omega_r \approx 9 \times 10^{-5}$, and $|\Omega_k| < 0.01$, consistent with a spatially flat ($k = 0$) universe. For most lensing calculations, we work with the *concordance cosmology*: $\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.7$, $H_0 = 70 \ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$.

7.8 Equations of State and Scale Factor Solutions

To solve the Friedmann equations, we need a relationship between p and ρ: the *equation of state*

$$p = w\rho c^2 \,, \tag{7.32}$$

where w is a dimensionless constant for each component.

7.8.1 Matter, Radiation, and Dark Energy

The three primary components of the universe are:

Component	w	$\rho \propto$	$a(t) \propto$
Non-relativistic matter (dust)	0	a^{-3}	$t^{2/3}$
Radiation (photons, neutrinos)	1/3	a^{-4}	$t^{1/2}$
Cosmological constant (Λ)	-1	a^0 (constant)	e^{Ht}

These follow from the fluid conservation equation (7.25). With $p = w\rho c^2$:

$$\dot{\rho} + 3\frac{\dot{a}}{a}(1+w)\rho = 0 \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad \rho \propto a^{-3(1+w)} \,. \tag{7.33}$$

For matter ($w = 0$): $\rho_m \propto a^{-3}$ (dilution by volume expansion). For radiation ($w = 1/3$): $\rho_r \propto a^{-4}$ (volume dilution plus cosmological redshift of each photon's energy). For Λ ($w = -1$): $\rho_\Lambda =$ constant.

7.8.2 Scale Factor Solutions

In a single-component universe with $k = 0$ (flat) and $\Lambda = 0$:

Matter-dominated: $H^2 = H_0^2\,\Omega_{\rm m}\,a^{-3}$ gives

$$a(t) = \left(\frac{3}{2}H_0\sqrt{\Omega_{\rm m}}\,t\right)^{2/3} \propto t^{2/3} \,. \tag{7.34}$$

Radiation-dominated: $H^2 = H_0^2\,\Omega_r\,a^{-4}$ gives

$$a(t) = \left(2H_0\sqrt{\Omega_r}\,t\right)^{1/2} \propto t^{1/2} \,. \tag{7.35}$$

Λ-dominated: $H^2 = H_0^2\,\Omega_\Lambda$ (constant) gives de Sitter expansion:

$$a(t) \propto e^{H_\Lambda t} \,, \qquad H_\Lambda = H_0\sqrt{\Omega_\Lambda} \,. \tag{7.36}$$

7.9 Redshift and the Scale Factor

As light propagates through the expanding universe, its wavelength stretches with the scale factor. A photon emitted at time $t_{\rm em}$ with wavelength $\lambda_{\rm em}$ is observed at t_0 with wavelength $\lambda_{\rm obs} = \lambda_{\rm em} \cdot a(t_0)/a(t_{\rm em})$. The *cosmological redshift* is therefore:

$$\boxed{1 + z = \frac{a(t_0)}{a(t_{\rm em})} = \frac{1}{a(t_{\rm em})}} \tag{7.37}$$

where we used $a(t_0) = 1$. High-redshift objects emitted their light when the universe was smaller: at $z = 1$, $a = 1/2$; at $z = 2$, $a = 1/3$; and so on.

Using eq. (7.37), the Friedmann equation can be rewritten entirely in terms of redshift. From the first Friedmann equation (7.23), $H^2 = 8\pi G\rho/3 - kc^2/a^2 + \Lambda c^2/3$. Each component's density scales as $\rho_i = \rho_{i,0}\, a^{-3(1+w_i)}$ (eq. 7.33), and $a = 1/(1+z)$ (eq. 7.37), so $\rho_m = \rho_{m,0}(1+z)^3$, $\rho_r = \rho_{r,0}(1+z)^4$, and $\rho_\Lambda = \rho_{\Lambda,0}$. Dividing through by H_0^2 and using the density parameter definitions (7.30): $H^2/H_0^2 = \Omega_{\rm m}(1+z)^3 + \Omega_r(1+z)^4 + \Omega_\Lambda + \Omega_k(1+z)^2$. Taking the square root (cf. Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.143, which omits Ω_r; verified in `friedmann_equations.wl`):

$$\boxed{H(z) = H_0\sqrt{\Omega_{\rm m}(1+z)^3 + \Omega_r(1+z)^4 + \Omega_\Lambda + \Omega_k(1+z)^2}} \tag{7.38}$$

For the concordance cosmology ($\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.7$, $\Omega_r \approx 0$, $\Omega_k = 0$), this simplifies to:

$$H(z) = H_0\sqrt{0.3\,(1+z)^3 + 0.7}\,. \tag{7.39}$$

Part B: Distance Measures for Lensing

7.10 Comoving Distance

A photon traveling radially ($d\theta = d\phi = 0$) through the RW metric satisfies $ds^2 = 0$, which gives $c\,dt = -a(t)\,d\chi$ (choosing the sign for incoming photons). The comoving distance to an object at redshift z is therefore:

$$\chi(z) = \int_0^z \frac{c\,dz'}{H(z')}\,. \tag{7.40}$$

This integral must in general be evaluated numerically, using $H(z)$ from eq. (7.38). The comoving distance is the "distance at the present epoch", the distance that would be measured by a chain of rulers laid end-to-end at time t_0.

For the concordance cosmology, some representative values:

z	$\chi(z)$ (Mpc)
0.1	420
0.5	1880
1.0	3300
2.0	5200
5.0	7775

7.11 Angular Diameter Distance

The *angular diameter distance* is defined so that an object of physical (proper) size ℓ at redshift z, subtending an angle $\delta\theta$ on the sky, satisfies the Euclidean-looking relation:

$$\delta\theta = \frac{\ell}{D_A(z)}\,. \tag{7.41}$$

From the RW metric (7.4), a physical transverse distance at redshift z (when $a = 1/(1+z)$) subtending angle $\delta\theta$ is $\ell = a(t)\, S_k(\chi)\, \delta\theta$, so

$$\boxed{D_A(z) = \frac{S_k(\chi(z))}{1+z}} \tag{7.42}$$

For a flat universe ($k = 0$), $S_k(\chi) = \chi$, and this simplifies to:

$$D_A(z) = \frac{\chi(z)}{1+z} = \frac{1}{1+z}\int_0^z \frac{c\,dz'}{H(z')}\,. \tag{7.43}$$

The angular diameter distance is the distance measure that enters the lens equation. The angular diameter distances $D_\mathrm{d} = D_A(z_d)$, $D_\mathrm{s} = D_A(z_s)$, and D_ds (defined below) determine the mapping from physical deflection angles to angular positions on the sky.

7.12 The Angular Diameter Distance Is Not Monotonic

One of the most counterintuitive results in cosmology is that the angular diameter distance $D_A(z)$ is not a monotonically increasing function of redshift. For the concordance cosmology, D_A reaches a maximum at $z \approx 1.6$ and then decreases at higher redshifts.

Objects at very high redshifts therefore appear larger on the sky than a Euclidean estimate would suggest. The turnover arises from two competing effects. For nearby objects, increasing redshift means greater comoving distance χ, so $D_A = \chi/(1+z)$ grows. But at high z, the factor $1/(1+z)$ dominates: the universe was much smaller when the light was emitted ($a = 1/(1+z) \ll 1$), so the physical transverse size of the object at emission, which determines the angle it subtends, was correspondingly smaller. A smaller physical size at fixed comoving size subtends a larger angle, making D_A decrease. The turnover at $z \approx 1.6$ (for the concordance cosmology) occurs where these two effects balance: $d\chi/dz = \chi/(1+z)$, i.e., where the fractional growth of comoving distance equals the fractional growth of the redshift factor (for D_A see Carroll Sec. 8.5, eq. 8.125; the turnover is computed numerically in `friedmann_equations.wl`).

Remark 7.12.1. The turnover of $D_A(z)$ has practical consequences for lensing: a lens at $z_d \sim 0.5$ and a source at $z_s \sim 2$ can have a larger distance ratio $D_\mathrm{ds}/D_\mathrm{s}$ than one might expect, and the "sweet spot" for lensing efficiency is typically $z_d \sim 0.2$–0.5 for sources at $z_s \sim 1$–3.

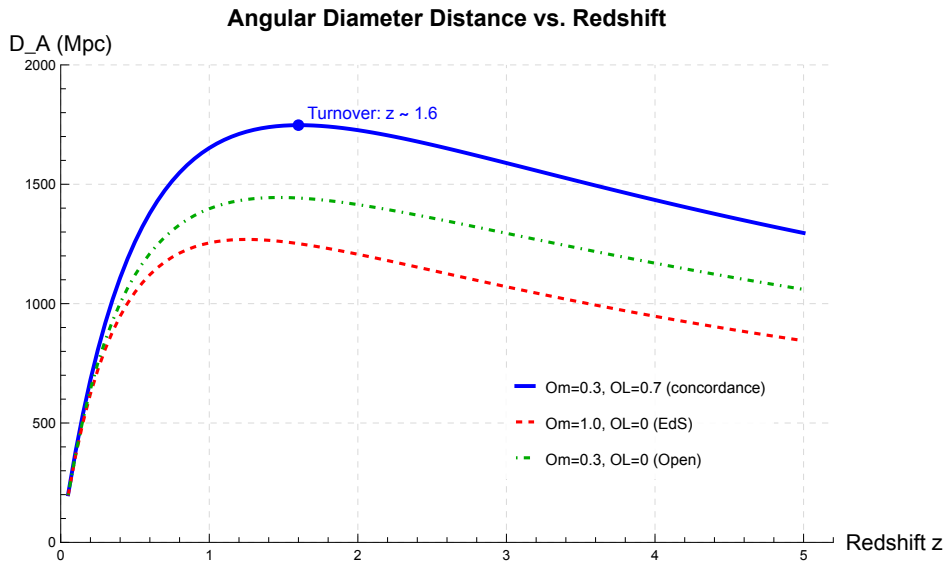


Figure 7.1: Angular diameter distance $D_A(z)$ for the concordance cosmology ($\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.7$, $H_0 = 70\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$). D_A reaches a maximum of approximately 1748 Mpc at $z \approx 1.6$ and then decreases. This turnover is a key consequence of the expanding universe and has no analogue in Euclidean geometry. Generated by `friedmann_equations.wl`.

7.13 Luminosity Distance

The *luminosity distance* D_L is defined so that the observed flux F from a source of luminosity L satisfies the Euclidean inverse-square law:

$$F = \frac{L}{4\pi D_L^2}\,. \tag{7.44}$$

In an expanding universe, two effects reduce the observed flux beyond the $1/r^2$ geometric dilution: (1) photon energies are redshifted by a factor $(1+z)$, and (2) photon arrival rates are reduced by another factor $(1+z)$. This gives:

$$D_L(z) = (1+z)\,S_k(\chi(z)) = (1+z)^2\,D_A(z)\,. \tag{7.45}$$

The relation $D_L = (1+z)^2 D_A$ is the *Etherington reciprocity theorem* (or *distance-duality relation*). It holds for any metric theory of gravity in which photons travel on null geodesics and photon number is conserved.

7.14 The Lens–Source Angular Diameter Distance

For gravitational lensing, we need not only $D_{\rm d} = D_A(z_d)$ and $D_{\rm s} = D_A(z_s)$, but also $D_{\rm ds}$: the angular diameter distance from the *lens* to the *source*. This is not $D_A(z_s) - D_A(z_d)$, because angular diameter distances do not add linearly.

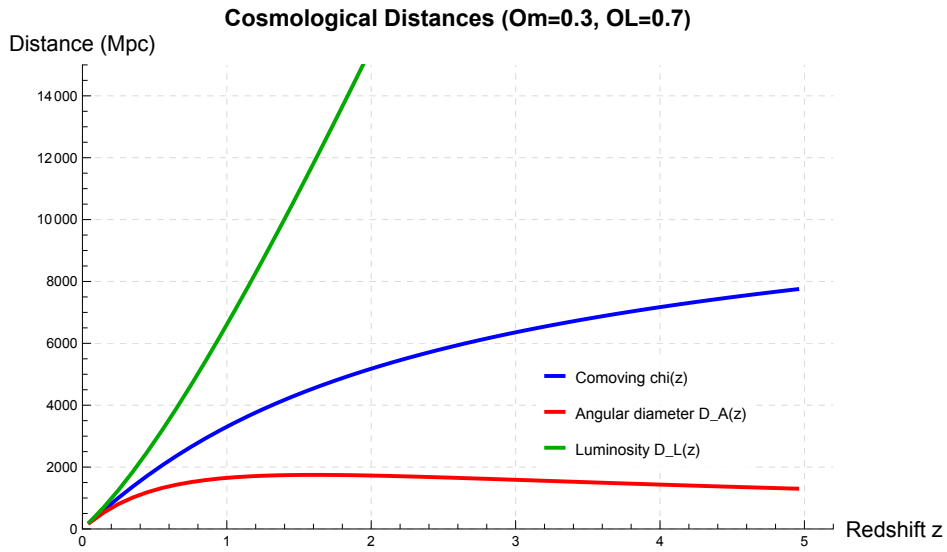


Figure 7.2: Comoving distance $\chi(z)$ (blue), angular diameter distance $D_A(z)$ (red), and luminosity distance $D_L(z)$ (green) for the concordance cosmology. At low redshift ($z \ll 1$) all three converge: $\chi \approx D_A \approx D_L \approx cz/H_0$. At high redshift they diverge dramatically. The turnover of D_A is clearly visible, while D_L grows monotonically. Generated by `friedmann_equations.wl`.

In a flat universe ($k = 0$), the comoving distances add: $\chi_{ds} = \chi_s - \chi_d$, and the lens–source angular diameter distance is:

$$\boxed{D_{\rm ds} = \frac{\chi_s - \chi_d}{1+z_s} = \frac{1}{1+z_s}\int_{z_d}^{z_s} \frac{c\,dz'}{H(z')}} \tag{7.46}$$

For a general (non-flat) universe one uses the Hogg (1999) form (eq. 19; equivalently Congdon & Keeton eq. 3.155):

$$D_{\rm ds} = \frac{1}{1+z_s}\left[D_M(z_s)\sqrt{1+\Omega_k\,D_M^2(z_d)/D_H^2} - D_M(z_d)\sqrt{1+\Omega_k\,D_M^2(z_s)/D_H^2}\right], \tag{7.47}$$

where $D_M(z) = (1+z)\,D_A(z)$ is the transverse comoving distance, $D_H = c/H_0$ is the Hubble distance, and $\Omega_k = -k\,(c/(H_0 R_0))^2$ is the curvature density parameter. For the spatially flat case ($\Omega_k = 0$), eq. (7.47) reduces to eq. (7.46), which is exact and sufficient for the rest of these notes.

Remark 7.14.1. A common mistake is to write $D_{\rm ds} = D_{\rm s} - D_{\rm d}$. This is wrong in general. Even in a flat universe, $D_{\rm ds} \neq D_{\rm s} - D_{\rm d}$ because the factors of $(1+z)$ are different. One must always compute $D_{\rm ds}$ using eq. (7.46) (or its curved-space generalization). To illustrate: for $z_d = 0.5$ and $z_s = 2.0$ in the concordance cosmology, $D_{\rm d} \approx 1259$ Mpc, $D_{\rm s} \approx 1727$ Mpc, but $D_{\rm ds} \approx 1097$ Mpc $\neq D_{\rm s} - D_{\rm d} \approx 468$ Mpc.

7.15 The Distance Ratio for Lensing

The lens equation (Chapter 8) and the Einstein radius both depend on a specific combination of distances. The Einstein radius of a point mass M is (Congdon & Keeton eq. 2.25):

$$\theta_{\rm E} = \sqrt{\frac{4GM}{c^2}\frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}}} \tag{7.48}$$

and the critical surface mass density is:

$$\Sigma_{\rm cr} = \frac{c^2}{4\pi G}\frac{D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm ds}}\,. \tag{7.49}$$

The relevant combination is the *distance ratio*:

$$\mathcal{D} \equiv \frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}}\,, \tag{7.50}$$

which determines the "lensing strength" of a given observer–lens–source configuration.

$\mathcal{D}$ is not $1/D_{\rm d}$, because $D_{\rm ds}$ depends on both z_d and z_s in a non-trivial way. At fixed z_s, $\mathcal{D}$ decreases monotonically with z_d ($\theta_{\rm E}$ is largest for the nearest lenses).[2] The physical Einstein radius, through the efficiency $D_{\rm d}D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}$ of the next section, peaks at intermediate z_d, a little short of the comoving midpoint ($\chi_d \approx 0.42\,\chi_s$ for $z_s = 1$).

7.16 Lensing Efficiency

For a fixed source redshift z_s, the lens redshift z_d at which lensing is most efficient is determined by the *lensing efficiency function*:

$$\mathcal{E}(z_d; z_s) \equiv \frac{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}} \tag{7.51}$$

which is proportional to the square of the physical Einstein radius $R_E = D_{\rm d}\theta_{\rm E}$ (at fixed mass). Here $\theta_{\rm E}^2 \propto D_{\rm ds}/(D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}) = \mathcal{D}$, while the physical Einstein ring area scales as $D_{\rm d}^2\theta_{\rm E}^2 \propto D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s} = \mathcal{E}$.

7.17 Summary

The cosmological principle (homogeneity and isotropy) constrains the spacetime metric to the Robertson–Walker form $ds^2 = -c^2dt^2 + a^2(t)\,[dr^2/(1-kr^2) + r^2 d\Omega^2]$. Inserting the RW metric into Einstein's equations with a perfect-fluid stress-energy tensor yields the Friedmann equations:

$$H^2 = \frac{8\pi G\rho}{3} - \frac{kc^2}{a^2} + \frac{\Lambda c^2}{3}\,,$$
$$\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} = -\frac{4\pi G}{3}\left(\rho + \frac{3p}{c^2}\right) + \frac{\Lambda c^2}{3}\,.$$

[2] Earlier versions stated that $\mathcal{D}$ is maximized for a lens roughly halfway to the source; that statement applies to the efficiency $D_{\rm d}D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}$ of Section 7.16, not to $\mathcal{D}$.

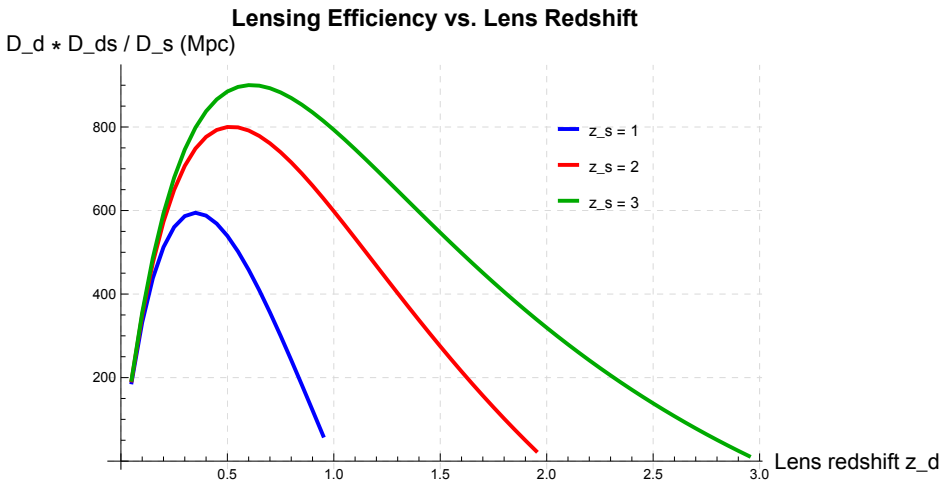


Figure 7.3: Lensing efficiency $D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}$ as a function of lens redshift z_d for several source redshifts $z_s = 1, 2, 3$ in the concordance cosmology. For $z_s = 1$, lensing is most efficient at $z_d \approx 0.35$; for $z_s = 2$, at $z_d \approx 0.5$. The peak lies somewhat closer to the observer than the comoving midpoint ($\chi_d \approx 0.42\,\chi_s$ for $z_s = 1$). Generated by `friedmann_equations.wl`.

The density parameters $\Omega_{\rm m}$, Ω_Λ, Ω_k satisfy $\Omega_{\rm m} + \Omega_\Lambda + \Omega_k = 1$ (ignoring radiation at late times).

The angular diameter distance $D_A(z) = \chi(z)/(1+z)$ is not monotonic: it turns over at $z \approx 1.6$ in the concordance cosmology. The luminosity distance is $D_L = (1+z)^2 D_A$ (Etherington reciprocity). The lens–source distance $D_{\rm ds} \neq D_{\rm s} - D_{\rm d}$; it must be computed as $D_{\rm ds} = (\chi_s - \chi_d)/(1+z_s)$ for a flat universe. The Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E} \propto \sqrt{D_{\rm ds}/(D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s})}$ depends on the distance configuration; the efficiency $D_{\rm d} D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}$ (physical Einstein radius) peaks a little short of the comoving midpoint ($\chi_d \approx 0.42\,\chi_s$ for $z_s = 1$).

7.18 Problems

Exercise 7.18.1. (Deriving the Friedmann equations from the RW metric.) Starting from the Robertson–Walker metric (7.2):

(a) Compute the Christoffel symbols for the FRW metric.

(b) Compute the Ricci tensor $R_{\mu\nu}$ and Ricci scalar R.

(c) Use Einstein's equations with the perfect-fluid stress-energy tensor to derive the first and second Friedmann equations.

(d) Show that differentiating the first Friedmann equation and using the second gives the fluid conservation equation.

Verify all steps with `friedmann_equations.wl`.

Exercise 7.18.2. (Age of the universe for different cosmologies.) The age of the universe is $t_0 = \int_0^\infty dz/[(1+z)\,H(z)]$.

(a) For an Einstein–de Sitter universe ($\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 1$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0$, $k = 0$), show analytically that $t_0 = 2/(3H_0)$.

(b) Compute t_0 numerically for the concordance cosmology ($\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.7$). You should find $t_0 \approx 13.5$ Gyr for $H_0 = 70\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$.

(c) Compare with an open universe ($\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0$, $\Omega_k = 0.7$).

Exercise 7.18.3. (Angular diameter distance turnover.)

(a) Plot $D_A(z)$ for the following cosmologies and identify the turnover redshift in each: (i) $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.7$ (concordance); (ii) $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 1.0$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0$ (Einstein–de Sitter); (iii) $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0$ (open).

(b) Explain physically why D_A turns over: why do high-redshift objects appear *larger* than intermediate-redshift objects?

(c) For the concordance cosmology, find the redshift z_max at which D_A is maximum by numerically solving $dD_A/dz = 0$.

Exercise 7.18.4. (Distances for a real lens system: Q0957+561.) The first gravitational lens discovered (Walsh, Carswell & Weymann 1979) has lens redshift $z_d = 0.36$ and source redshift $z_s = 1.41$. Using the concordance cosmology:

(a) Compute D_d, D_s, and D_ds in Mpc.

(b) Verify that $D_\mathrm{ds} \neq D_\mathrm{s} - D_\mathrm{d}$.

(c) Compute the critical surface mass density Σ_cr in $M_\odot\,\mathrm{kpc}^{-2}$.

(d) Compute the Einstein radius θ_E for a lens mass $M = 10^{12}\,M_\odot$.

Exercise 7.18.5. (Einstein radius for a typical galaxy lens.) For a flat ΛCDM universe with $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.7$, $H_0 = 70\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$:

(a) Compute D_d, D_s, D_ds for $z_d = 0.3$, $z_s = 1.0$.

(b) Compute the Einstein radius θ_E for a lens mass $M = 10^{12}\,M_\odot$. You should find $\theta_\mathrm{E} \approx 2.4''$.

(c) How does θ_E scale with M? What mass gives $\theta_\mathrm{E} = 10''$?

(d) Plot θ_E as a function of z_d (with $z_s = 1$ and $M = 10^{12}\,M_\odot$ fixed). Does θ_E have a maximum? At what z_d is the physical Einstein radius $R_\mathrm{E} = D_\mathrm{d}\theta_\mathrm{E}$ largest?

Verify with `problems_03.wl`.

Chapter 8

The Gravitational Lens Equation

> *Equation (14) is called the lens equation, or ray-tracing equation. It is nonlinear in the general case, and so it is possible to have multiple images $\vec{\theta}$ corresponding to a single source position $\vec{\beta}$.* — Narayan & Bartelmann (1997), Sect. 2.1.3

In Chapter 6 we derived the deflection angle $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$ for a point mass, and in Chapter 5 we showed that deflection angles from multiple masses superpose in the weak-field limit. In Chapter 7 we introduced the angular diameter distances D_d, D_s, and D_ds that describe the geometry of the observer–lens–source system at cosmological separations.

We now assemble these ingredients into the *lens equation*, the mapping from source positions to image positions. This single equation is the starting point for everything that follows: image multiplicity, magnification, time delays, and lens modeling.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `lens_equation.wl`: symbolic derivation of the lens equation, Einstein radius, point mass image positions, magnification preview, critical surface mass density, and publication-quality figure generation
- `einstein_ring.nb`: interactive notebook: Manipulate for source position and image positions, Einstein ring visualization, interactive θ_E calculator

8.1 Introduction: From Deflection to Imaging

Two ingredients are needed to build the gravitational lens equation. The first is the deflection angle (Chapters 5 and 6), $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$ for a point mass, together with the superposition principle (5.25) for multiple masses and continuous distributions. The second is the set of cosmological distances (Chapter 7): the angular diameter distances D_d, D_s, D_ds relating angular separations on the sky to physical separations at the lens and source. The task of this chapter is to combine these into a single equation that maps source positions $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ to image positions $\boldsymbol{\theta}$. This equation can have multiple solutions, multiple images of a single source, which is the defining phenomenon of strong gravitational lensing.

8.2 The Thin-Screen Approximation

The physical extent of a gravitational lens along the line of sight is typically much smaller than the distances between observer, lens, and source. For a galaxy lens, the stellar and dark matter distribution extends over ~ 100 kpc, while $D_\mathrm{d} \sim 1$ Gpc. For a galaxy cluster, the virial radius is ~ 2 Mpc, compared to distances of several Gpc. In both cases the ratio

$$\frac{\text{lens extent}}{\text{cosmological distance}} \sim \frac{100\ \text{kpc}}{1\ \text{Gpc}} = 10^{-4} \tag{8.1}$$

is exceedingly small.

Remark 8.2.1. The thin-screen approximation is the gravitational analog of the thin-lens approximation in classical optics. Just as a glass lens can be treated as imparting a phase shift at a single plane (when its thickness is much less than the focal length), a gravitational lens can be treated as deflecting light at a single lens plane perpendicular to the line of sight at distance D_d.

This justifies the following idealization: all the mass of the lens is projected onto a single plane (the *lens plane*) at angular diameter distance D_d from the observer. The deflection of a light ray occurs instantaneously as it crosses this plane. The three-dimensional mass distribution $\rho(\mathbf{r})$ is replaced by a two-dimensional *surface mass density* $\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\xi})$, obtained by integrating ρ along the line of sight:

$$\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\xi}) = \int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} \rho(\boldsymbol{\xi}, z)\, dz\,, \tag{8.2}$$

where $\boldsymbol{\xi}$ is the two-dimensional position in the lens plane and z is the coordinate along the line of sight.

8.3 Lensing Geometry

Figure 8.1 shows the geometry of a typical gravitational lensing configuration. The observer (O) is located at the bottom of the diagram. The lens plane is a plane perpendicular to the optical axis at angular diameter distance D_d from the observer, onto which the lens (galaxy, cluster, etc.) is projected; the *source plane* is a plane perpendicular to the optical axis at angular diameter distance D_s from the observer, in which the background source (galaxy, quasar, etc.) lies. The *optical axis* is the line from the observer through the center of the lens, and it defines the origin of the angular coordinate system.

All angles are measured from the optical axis: $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ is the observed image position on the sky, $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ the true source position (where the source would appear without lensing), $\hat{\alpha}$ the physical deflection angle at the lens plane, and $\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ the reduced deflection angle, defined below.

The physical positions in the lens and source planes are related to the angular positions by:

$$\boldsymbol{\xi} = D_\mathrm{d}\, \boldsymbol{\theta}\,, \tag{8.3}$$

$$\boldsymbol{\eta} = D_\mathrm{s}\, \boldsymbol{\beta}\,, \tag{8.4}$$

where $\boldsymbol{\xi}$ is the position in the lens plane and $\boldsymbol{\eta}$ is the position in the source plane (Narayan & Bartelmann eq. 15; Congdon & Keeton Sec. 2.2.2).

8.4 The Lens Equation

From the geometry of Figure 8.1, we can read off the fundamental relationship between source and image positions. A light ray that is observed at angle $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ from the optical axis was emitted from the source at position $\boldsymbol{\eta}$ in the source plane. Following the deflected ray from the lens plane to the source plane, the physical displacement in the source plane is (Narayan & Bartelmann Sec. 2.1.3; Congdon & Keeton eq. 2.16):

$$\boldsymbol{\eta} = \frac{D_\mathrm{s}}{D_\mathrm{d}}\,\boldsymbol{\xi} - D_\mathrm{ds}\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(\boldsymbol{\xi})\,. \tag{8.5}$$

Substituting $\boldsymbol{\xi} = D_\mathrm{d}\,\boldsymbol{\theta}$ and $\boldsymbol{\eta} = D_\mathrm{s}\,\boldsymbol{\beta}$:

$$D_\mathrm{s}\,\boldsymbol{\beta} = D_\mathrm{s}\,\boldsymbol{\theta} - D_\mathrm{ds}\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(D_\mathrm{d}\,\boldsymbol{\theta})\,, \tag{8.6}$$

and dividing by D_s:

$$\boxed{\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \frac{D_\mathrm{ds}}{D_\mathrm{s}}\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(D_\mathrm{d}\,\boldsymbol{\theta})} \tag{8.7}$$

This is the *gravitational lens equation* in terms of the physical deflection angle $\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$. It is convenient to define the *reduced deflection angle*:

$$\boxed{\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \equiv \frac{D_\mathrm{ds}}{D_\mathrm{s}}\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(D_\mathrm{d}\,\boldsymbol{\theta})} \tag{8.8}$$

so that the lens equation takes the form:

$$\boxed{\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})} \tag{8.9}$$

Remark 8.4.1. Equation (8.9) is the fundamental equation of gravitational lensing. Every result in strong lensing theory (image positions, magnifications, time delays, critical curves, caustics) derives from this single equation. The nonlinearity of the deflection angle $\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ is what allows multiple solutions (multiple images) for a given source position $\boldsymbol{\beta}$.

Remark 8.4.2. The lens equation is a mapping from the image plane to the source plane: given an image position $\boldsymbol{\theta}$, it determines the corresponding source position $\boldsymbol{\beta}$. The inverse problem, finding all image positions $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ for a given source position $\boldsymbol{\beta}$, is generally much harder, because the equation can have multiple solutions. For a point mass lens the inverse problem can be solved analytically (Section 8.7); for more complex lens models it typically requires numerical root-finding.

8.5 Surface Mass Density and the Deflection Integral

For a continuous mass distribution described by the surface mass density $\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\xi})$ (eq. 8.2), the physical deflection angle at position $\boldsymbol{\xi}$ in the lens plane is obtained by superposing the deflections from all mass elements (Congdon & Keeton eq. 4.9; cf. Chapter 5 eq. 5.26):

$$\boxed{\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(\boldsymbol{\xi}) = \frac{4G}{c^2}\int \frac{(\boldsymbol{\xi} - \boldsymbol{\xi}')\,\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\xi}')}{|\boldsymbol{\xi} - \boldsymbol{\xi}'|^2}\,d^2\xi'} \tag{8.10}$$

This is the two-dimensional analog of the Newtonian gravitational field of a surface mass distribution. The integral extends over the entire lens plane. In terms of the angular position $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ and using $\boldsymbol{\xi} = D_{\rm d}\,\boldsymbol{\theta}$, the reduced deflection angle becomes:

$$\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}}\,\frac{4G}{c^2}\,D_{\rm d}\int \frac{(\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}')\,\Sigma(D_{\rm d}\,\boldsymbol{\theta}')}{|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}'|^2}\,d^2\theta'\,. \tag{8.11}$$

Remark 8.5.1. The deflection integral (8.10) follows directly from the superposition principle derived in Chapter 5 (eq. 5.25). Each infinitesimal mass element $\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\xi}')\,d^2\xi'$ acts as a point mass, deflecting the light ray by $4G\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\xi}')\,d^2\xi'/(c^2\,|\boldsymbol{\xi}-\boldsymbol{\xi}'|)$ in the direction of $(\boldsymbol{\xi}-\boldsymbol{\xi}')/|\boldsymbol{\xi}-\boldsymbol{\xi}'|$. Superposition (valid because we are in the weak-field regime) gives the total deflection as the integral over the lens plane.

8.6 Critical Surface Mass Density

There is a natural surface mass density at which the lens is just strong enough to bend a ray from the source back to the optical axis. Consider a uniform disk of constant surface mass density Σ, and ask what Σ is required for the disk to act as a perfect focusing lens for a source at infinity, i.e., $\alpha(\theta) = \theta$ for every θ inside the disk.

For a uniform disk the two-dimensional enclosed mass within $\xi = D_{\rm d}\theta$ is $M_{\rm 2D}(\xi) = \pi\xi^2\Sigma$, so the physical deflection $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM_{\rm 2D}/(c^2\xi) = 4\pi G\Sigma\,\xi/c^2$. Converting to the reduced deflection via $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = (D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s})\,\hat{\alpha}$ and $\xi = D_{\rm d}\theta$:

$$\alpha(\theta) \;=\; \frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}}\cdot\frac{4\pi G\Sigma\,D_{\rm d}\,\theta}{c^2}.$$

The focusing condition $\alpha(\theta) = \theta$ removes the factor of θ and gives $\Sigma = \Sigma_{\rm cr}$ with (Narayan & Bartelmann eq. 17; Congdon & Keeton eq. 2.68):

$$\boxed{\Sigma_{\rm cr} = \frac{c^2}{4\pi G}\,\frac{D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm ds}}\,.} \tag{8.12}$$

Remark 8.6.1. The factor of 4π traces to the 2D Poisson equation $\nabla^2\psi = 2\kappa$ (Chapter 9): the 4π in eq. (8.12) is the product of $4G/c^2$ (from the deflection formula) and the π that converts the uniform-disk enclosed mass to the line-averaged surface density.

The *convergence* is then the dimensionless ratio of the actual surface mass density to the critical value:

$$\boxed{\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{\Sigma(D_{\rm d}\,\boldsymbol{\theta})}{\Sigma_{\rm cr}}} \tag{8.13}$$

The critical surface mass density sets the boundary between weak and strong lensing. If $\kappa < 1$ everywhere ($\Sigma < \Sigma_{\rm cr}$), an axisymmetric lens is *subcritical*: it can still deflect light, but it cannot produce multiple images. (For a non-axisymmetric lens, shear can produce multiple images even with $\kappa < 1$ everywhere; Congdon & Keeton Sec. 2.5.) If $\kappa \geq 1$ somewhere ($\Sigma \geq \Sigma_{\rm cr}$), the lens is *supercritical*: it can produce multiple images, arcs, and Einstein rings, the regime of strong gravitational lensing.

Example 8.6.1. Numerical value of $\Sigma_{\rm cr}$. For a typical galaxy lens at $z_d = 0.3$ with a source at $z_s = 1$ in a flat ΛCDM cosmology ($H_0 = 70\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$, $\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.7$), the angular diameter distances are $D_{\rm d} \approx 919$ Mpc, $D_{\rm s} \approx 1652$ Mpc, $D_{\rm ds} \approx 1055$ Mpc (computed in `friedmann_equations.wl`). Substituting into eq. (8.12):

$$\Sigma_{\rm cr} \approx \frac{(3\times 10^8)^2}{4\pi \times 6.674 \times 10^{-11}} \times \frac{1652}{919 \times 1055}\ \mathrm{Mpc}^{-1} \approx 0.59\ \mathrm{g\,cm^{-2}} \approx 2840\ M_\odot\,\mathrm{pc}^{-2}\,. \tag{8.14}$$

This is a low surface mass density, only about $5.9\ \mathrm{kg\,m^{-2}}$. Nevertheless, typical galaxy and cluster lenses can achieve $\Sigma \geq \Sigma_{\rm cr}$ in their central regions, making strong lensing possible. The exact value is computed and verified in `lens_equation.wl`.

Exercise 8.6.1. Show that $\Sigma_{\rm cr}$ as defined in eq. (8.12) has units of mass per area. *Hint:* G has units of $\mathrm{m^3\,kg^{-1}\,s^{-2}}$, c has units of $\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, and the distances have units of length.

8.7 The Einstein Radius

The lens equation simplifies considerably for a point mass lens. For a mass M at the origin of the lens plane, the physical deflection angle is (from Chapter 6):

$$\hat{\alpha}(\xi) = \frac{4GM}{c^2\,\xi}\,, \tag{8.15}$$

where $\xi = |\boldsymbol{\xi}| = D_{\rm d}\,\theta$ is the physical distance from the mass in the lens plane. The reduced deflection angle is:

$$\alpha(\theta) = \frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}}\,\frac{4GM}{c^2\,D_{\rm d}\,\theta} = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\theta}\,, \tag{8.16}$$

where we have defined the *Einstein radius*:

$$\boxed{\theta_{\rm E} = \sqrt{\frac{4GM}{c^2}\,\frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}}}} \tag{8.17}$$

This is the characteristic angular scale of gravitational lensing. For a circularly symmetric lens, the Einstein radius is the angular radius of the ring that forms when the source lies exactly behind the lens ($\beta = 0$). The corresponding physical radius in the lens plane is:

$$R_{\rm E} = D_{\rm d}\,\theta_{\rm E} = \sqrt{\frac{4GM}{c^2}\,\frac{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}}}\,. \tag{8.18}$$

8.7.1 The Point Mass Lens Equation

Substituting eq. (8.16) into the lens equation (8.9) (restricting to one angular dimension by the circular symmetry of the point mass):

$$\boxed{\beta = \theta - \frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\theta}} \tag{8.19}$$

This is a quadratic equation in θ. Multiplying through by θ:

$$\theta^2 - \beta\,\theta - \theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2 = 0\,. \tag{8.20}$$

The two solutions are:

$$\boxed{\theta_\pm = \frac{1}{2}\left(\beta \pm \sqrt{\beta^2 + 4\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2}\right)} \tag{8.21}$$

Since $\beta^2 + 4\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2 > \beta^2$ for $\theta_{\mathrm{E}} > 0$, both solutions are always real. A point mass lens always produces two images, regardless of the source position.

8.7.2 The Einstein Ring

When the source is exactly on the optical axis ($\beta = 0$), the two image positions merge:

$$\theta_\pm = \pm\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}\,. \tag{8.22}$$

By the circular symmetry of the lens, this corresponds to a complete ring of images at angular radius θ_{E}, the *Einstein ring*, which has been observed in numerous galaxy-scale and cluster-scale lens systems.

8.7.3 Numerical Examples

Example 8.7.1. Einstein radii for typical lensing systems.

(a) Stellar microlensing ($M = 1\,M_\odot$, $D_{\mathrm{d}} \approx D_{\mathrm{s}}/2 \approx 5$ kpc, $D_{\mathrm{ds}} \approx 5$ kpc):

$$\theta_{\mathrm{E}} = \sqrt{\frac{4 \times 6.674 \times 10^{-11} \times 1.989 \times 10^{30}}{(3 \times 10^8)^2} \times \frac{1}{10 \times 3.086 \times 10^{19}}} \approx 0.9\ \text{mas}\,. \tag{8.23}$$

The Einstein radius for stellar microlensing is of order milliarcseconds, far too small to resolve the individual images, but the magnification is detectable photometrically.

(b) Galaxy-scale lensing ($M = 10^{12}\,M_\odot$, $z_d = 0.3$, $z_s = 1$): With $D_{\mathrm{d}} \approx 919$ Mpc, $D_{\mathrm{s}} \approx 1652$ Mpc, $D_{\mathrm{ds}} \approx 1055$ Mpc:

$$\theta_{\mathrm{E}} \approx 2.4''\,. \tag{8.24}$$

Galaxy-scale Einstein radii are of order arcseconds, easily resolved with ground-based telescopes. This is the regime of strong lensing that produces multiple images and arcs.

(c) Cluster-scale lensing ($M_{\mathrm{E}} \sim 2 \times 10^{14}\,M_\odot$ inside the Einstein radius, $z_d = 0.3$, $z_s = 2$): With $D_{\mathrm{d}} \approx 919$ Mpc, $D_{\mathrm{s}} \approx 1727$ Mpc, $D_{\mathrm{ds}} \approx 1328$ Mpc, the point-mass formula gives:

$$\theta_{\mathrm{E}} \approx 37''\,. \tag{8.25}$$

Cluster-scale Einstein radii are of order tens of arcseconds, producing the giant arcs observed in massive galaxy clusters. For an extended cluster only the mass *within* the Einstein radius enters the point-mass-equivalent estimate above; the total virial mass $M_{200} \sim 10^{15}\,M_\odot$ of a typical massive cluster is much larger, but most of it lies outside θ_{E}. An NFW treatment (Chapter 14) yields the same answer self-consistently.

These values are computed and verified in `lens_equation.wl`. Interactive exploration is available in `einstein_ring.nb`.

8.8 Image Positions for a Point Mass Lens

The two image positions $\theta_\pm$ from eq. (8.21) have several important properties. It is convenient to work with the dimensionless variable $u \equiv \beta/\theta_\mathrm{E}$ (source position in units of the Einstein radius). Then:

$$\theta_\pm = \frac{\theta_\mathrm{E}}{2}\left(u \pm \sqrt{u^2+4}\right). \tag{8.26}$$

8.8.1 Properties of the Images

1. θ_+ is always positive (on the same side of the lens as the source) and satisfies $\theta_+ > \theta_\mathrm{E}$. This is the *primary image*, which is always located outside the Einstein radius.

2. θ_- is always negative (on the opposite side of the lens from the source) and satisfies $|\theta_-| < \theta_\mathrm{E}$. This is the *secondary image*, located inside the Einstein radius. Its negative sign indicates opposite parity (the image is mirror-reflected).

3. Vieta's formulas applied to the quadratic (8.20) give

$$\theta_+ + \theta_- = \beta\,, \qquad \theta_+\,\theta_- = -\theta_\mathrm{E}^2\,. \tag{8.27}$$

   The product relation shows that the images always straddle the Einstein ring: one inside, one outside.

4. The image separation is

$$\Delta\theta = \theta_+ - \theta_- = \sqrt{\beta^2 + 4\,\theta_\mathrm{E}^2}\,. \tag{8.28}$$

   The minimum separation occurs at $\beta = 0$ (Einstein ring configuration), where $\Delta\theta = 2\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$.

8.8.2 Limiting Cases

Source on the optical axis ($\beta \to 0$, $u \to 0$): Both images approach the Einstein radius: $\theta_+ \to +\theta_\mathrm{E}$, $\theta_- \to -\theta_\mathrm{E}$. The two images merge into the Einstein ring.

Source far from the lens ($\beta \gg \theta_\mathrm{E}$, $u \gg 1$):

$$\theta_+ \approx \beta + \frac{\theta_\mathrm{E}^2}{\beta} \to \beta \quad \text{(approaches the unlensed position)}\,, \tag{8.29}$$

$$\theta_- \approx -\frac{\theta_\mathrm{E}^2}{\beta} \to 0 \quad \text{(approaches the lens, becomes infinitely demagnified)}\,. \tag{8.30}$$

In this limit the primary image lies close to the unlensed source position (negligible lensing), and the secondary image is extremely close to the lens and too faint to observe.

8.9 Magnification of a Point Mass Lens

Gravitational lensing conserves surface brightness (a consequence of Liouville's theorem applied to the photon phase space), but it changes the *solid angle* subtended by the image compared to the source. The ratio of image area to source area is the *magnification* μ. The magnification formalism is derived in Chapter 9; here we preview the results for the point mass lens.

For a circularly symmetric lens, the magnification is (Narayan & Bartelmann eq. 26):

$$\mu = \frac{\theta}{\beta}\frac{d\theta}{d\beta}\,. \tag{8.31}$$

The first factor accounts for the tangential stretching of the image (the image is at a different angular radius than the source), and the second factor accounts for the radial stretching.

For the point mass lens equation $\beta = \theta - \theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta$, we have $d\beta/d\theta = 1 + \theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta^2$, and the magnification of each image is:

$$\mu_\pm = \frac{\theta_\pm}{\beta}\,\frac{1}{1+\theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta_\pm^2} = \frac{\theta_\pm^4}{\theta_\pm^4 - \theta_{\rm E}^4}\,. \tag{8.32}$$

Using the dimensionless variable $u = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$, the magnifications simplify to (Narayan & Bartelmann eq. 27):

$$\boxed{\mu_\pm = \frac{u^2+2}{2u\sqrt{u^2+4}} \pm \frac{1}{2}} \tag{8.33}$$

Several properties follow. $\mu_+ > 0$ always (same parity as the source), and $\mu_- < 0$ always (opposite parity: the image is mirror-reflected), because $|\theta_-| < \theta_{\rm E}$ makes the denominator of eq. (8.32) negative. As in Narayan & Bartelmann eq. 27, the lower sign in eq. (8.33) gives the absolute magnification $|\mu_-|$; the signed value is $\mu_- = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{u^2+2}{2u\sqrt{u^2+4}}$. The total magnification (sum of absolute values) is

$$|\mu_+| + |\mu_-| = \frac{u^2+2}{u\sqrt{u^2+4}} > 1 \quad \text{for all } u > 0\,. \tag{8.34}$$

so gravitational lensing always increases the total observed flux. As $u \to 0$ (source on the optical axis), both $|\mu_\pm| \to \infty$: the Einstein ring is infinitely magnified (in the geometric optics approximation). As $u \to \infty$, $\mu_+ \to 1$ (unlensed) and $|\mu_-| \to 0$ (the secondary image disappears).

8.10 Summary

The thin-screen approximation projects the three-dimensional mass distribution onto a single lens plane, justified by the small ratio of lens extent to cosmological distance ($\sim 10^{-4}$). The lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ maps image positions to source positions; the reduced deflection angle $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = (D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s})\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$ absorbs the distance factors. The surface mass density $\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\xi})$ and the deflection integral (8.10) allow the treatment of arbitrary continuous mass distributions, and

the critical surface mass density $\Sigma_{\rm cr} = (c^2/4\pi G)\,(D_{\rm s}/D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm ds})$ separates weak lensing ($\kappa < 1$) from strong lensing ($\kappa \geq 1$).

The Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E} = \sqrt{4GM/c^2 \cdot D_{\rm ds}/(D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s})}$ is the characteristic angular scale of lensing. Typical values are ~ 1 mas for stellar microlensing, $\sim 1''$–$3''$ for galaxy lensing ($M \sim 10^{11}$–$10^{12}\,M_\odot$), and $\sim 30''$–$40''$ for cluster lensing. A point mass lens always produces two images, $\theta_\pm = (\beta \pm \sqrt{\beta^2 + 4\theta_{\rm E}^2})/2$; the primary image ($\theta_+$) is outside $\theta_{\rm E}$ with the same parity, and the secondary (θ_-) is inside $\theta_{\rm E}$ with opposite parity. When the source is exactly behind the lens ($\beta = 0$), the images merge into an Einstein ring at angular radius $\theta_{\rm E}$. The magnification of the point mass lens is $\mu_\pm = (u^2+2)/(2u\sqrt{u^2+4}) \pm 1/2$, where $u = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$, and the total magnification always exceeds unity.

8.11 Problems

Exercise 8.11.1. (Derivation of the lens equation.) Starting from the lensing geometry (Figure 8.1), derive the lens equation (8.7).

(a) Using the small-angle approximation, show that the physical position in the source plane is $\boldsymbol{\eta} = (D_{\rm s}/D_{\rm d})\,\boldsymbol{\xi} - D_{\rm ds}\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(\boldsymbol{\xi})$.

(b) Substitute $\boldsymbol{\xi} = D_{\rm d}\,\boldsymbol{\theta}$ and $\boldsymbol{\eta} = D_{\rm s}\,\boldsymbol{\beta}$ to obtain the lens equation in angular coordinates.

(c) Define the reduced deflection angle and write the lens equation in the compact form $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$.

Exercise 8.11.2. (Point mass lens equation.) For a point mass lens with Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$:

(a) Derive the lens equation $\beta = \theta - \theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta$ from the deflection angle $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2\xi)$.

(b) Solve the resulting quadratic to obtain the image positions $\theta_\pm$.

(c) Show that two images always form (i.e., the discriminant is always positive).

(d) Verify the Vieta relations: $\theta_+ + \theta_- = \beta$ and $\theta_+\,\theta_- = -\theta_{\rm E}^2$.

(e) Show that $\theta_+ > \theta_{\rm E} > 0 > \theta_- > -\theta_{\rm E}$ for $\beta > 0$.

Verify with `problems_04.wl`.

Exercise 8.11.3. (Einstein radius for various systems.) Compute the Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$ for:

(a) **Stellar microlensing:** $M = 1\,M_\odot$, lens at distance $D_{\rm d} = 5$ kpc, source at $D_{\rm s} = 10$ kpc (so $D_{\rm ds} = 5$ kpc). Express the result in milliarcseconds.

(b) **Galaxy lensing:** $M = 10^{12}\,M_\odot$, $z_d = 0.3$, $z_s = 1$. Use the angular diameter distances from Chapter 7 (or the Mathematica script): $D_{\rm d} \approx 919$ Mpc, $D_{\rm s} \approx 1652$ Mpc, $D_{\rm ds} \approx 1055$ Mpc. Express the result in arcseconds.

(c) **Cluster lensing:** mass $M_{\rm E} \approx 2 \times 10^{14}\, M_\odot$ inside the Einstein radius (total $M_{200} \sim 10^{15}\, M_\odot$), $z_d = 0.3$, $z_s = 2$. Use $D_{\rm d} \approx 919$ Mpc, $D_{\rm s} \approx 1727$ Mpc, $D_{\rm ds} \approx 1328$ Mpc. Express the result in arcseconds.

For each case, also compute the physical Einstein radius $R_{\rm E} = D_{\rm d}\,\theta_{\rm E}$ in kpc. Verify with `problems_04.wl`.

Exercise 8.11.4. (Critical surface mass density.)

(a) Starting from the definition (8.12), verify that $\Sigma_{\rm cr}$ has units of mass per area by performing a dimensional analysis.

(b) Compute $\Sigma_{\rm cr}$ (in $\mathrm{g\,cm^{-2}}$ and $M_\odot\,\mathrm{pc^{-2}}$) for the galaxy lens configuration of Exercise 8.11.3(b).

(c) Compute $\Sigma_{\rm cr}$ for the cluster lens configuration of Exercise 8.11.3(c).

(d) A typical elliptical galaxy has a central surface mass density of $\Sigma_0 \approx 5000\, M_\odot\,\mathrm{pc^{-2}}$. Is it a strong lens? Compare Σ_0 with your result from (b).

Verify with `problems_04.wl`.

Exercise 8.11.5. (Image positions for a point mass lens.) Consider a point mass lens with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$.

(a) For source positions $\beta = 0.1'', 0.5'', 1'', 2'', 5''$, compute both image positions θ_+ and θ_-. Tabulate your results.

(b) Plot θ_+ and θ_- as functions of β for $0 \le \beta \le 5''$. On your plot, also show the Einstein radius and the line $\theta = \beta$ (unlensed position).

(c) Compute the image separation $\Delta\theta = \theta_+ - \theta_-$ for each value of β and plot it. What is the minimum image separation?

(d) Compute the magnification of each image using eq. (8.33) and plot the total magnification $|\mu_+| + |\mu_-|$ as a function of β.

Use Mathematica to generate the plots and verify the numerical values. See `lens_equation.wl` and `problems_04.wl`.

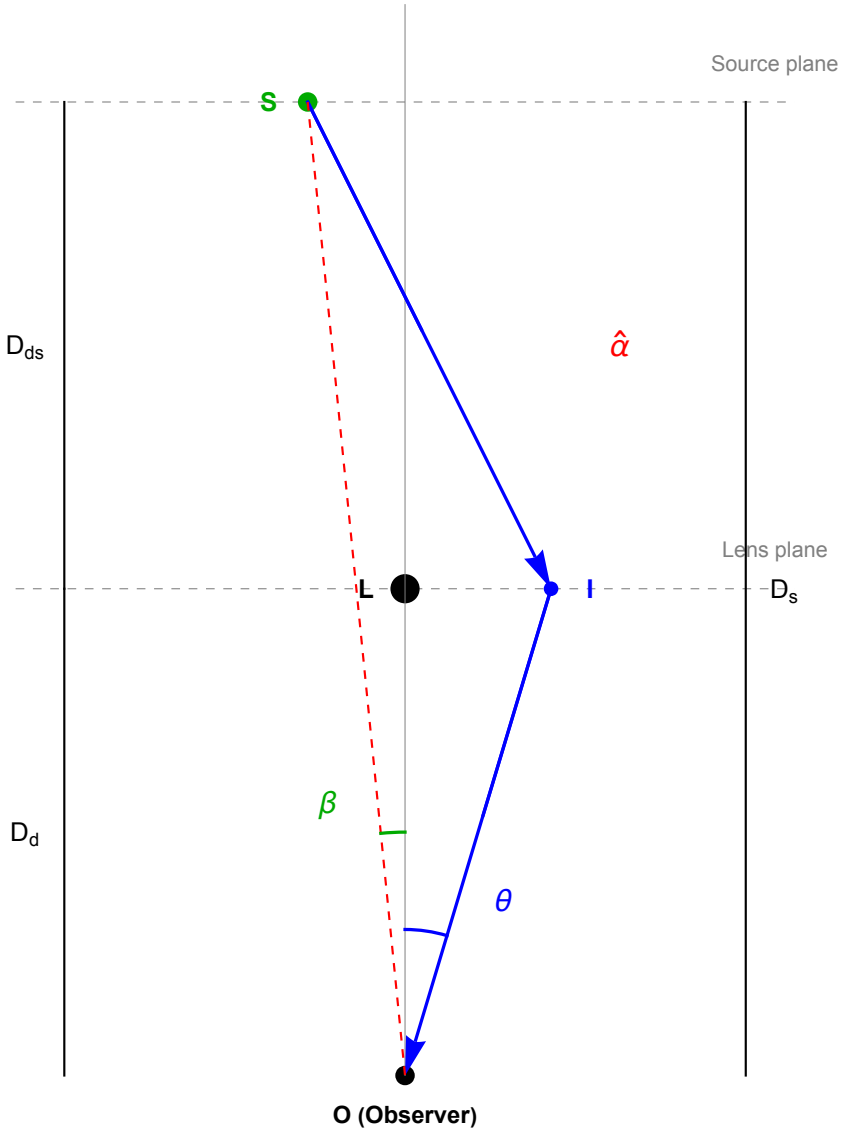


Figure 8.1: Geometry of gravitational lensing. A light ray from a source at angular position $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ in the source plane is deflected by the angle $\hat{\alpha}$ as it passes through the lens plane, and is observed at angular position $\boldsymbol{\theta}$. The angular diameter distances $D_{\rm d}$, $D_{\rm s}$, and $D_{\rm ds}$ connect angular separations to physical separations. The reduced deflection angle $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = (D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s})\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$ gives the apparent angular shift. Generated by `lens_equation.wl`.

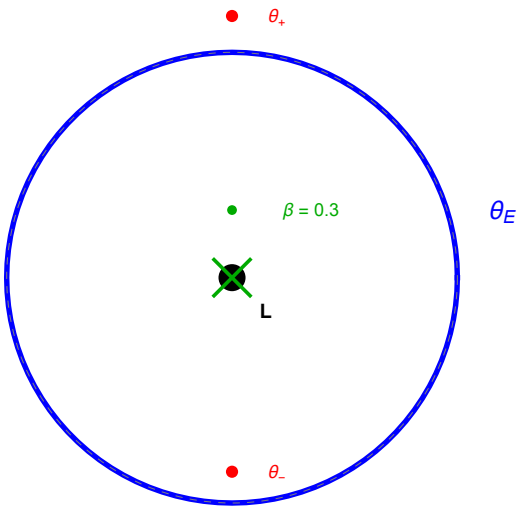


Figure 8.2: The Einstein ring. When a source (star symbol at center) lies exactly behind a point mass lens (filled circle at center), the image is a complete ring of angular radius $\theta_{\rm E}$. For a slightly offset source ($\beta \neq 0$), the ring breaks into two images at positions θ_+ and θ_-. Generated by `lens_equation.wl`.

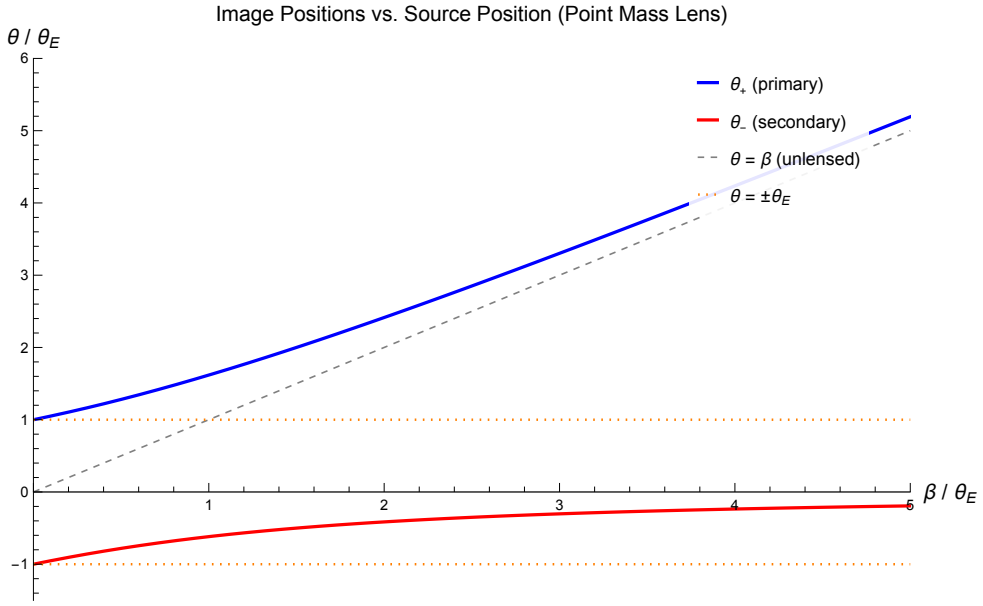


Figure 8.3: Image positions θ_+ and θ_- as functions of the source position β for a point mass lens, in units of the Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$. The primary image θ_+ (blue) is always outside $\theta_{\rm E}$ and approaches the unlensed position (gray dashed line) for $\beta \gg \theta_{\rm E}$. The secondary image θ_- (red) is always inside $\theta_{\rm E}$ (in absolute value) and approaches the lens for $\beta \gg \theta_{\rm E}$. At $\beta = 0$, both images are at $\pm\theta_{\rm E}$ (Einstein ring). Generated by `lens_equation.wl`.

Chapter 9

Magnification, Convergence, and Shear

> *Convergence acting alone causes an isotropic focusing of light rays, leading to an isotropic magnification of a source. The source is mapped onto an image with the same shape but larger size. Shear introduces anisotropy (or astigmatism) into the lens mapping [. . .]* — Narayan & Bartelmann (1997), Sect. 3.2

In Chapter 8 we derived the lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ and used it to find image positions for a point mass lens. We also previewed the magnification formula for the point mass case. We now develop the general formalism that describes how lensing distorts images: their size, shape, and brightness relative to the unlensed source.

The objects of the chapter are the lensing potential $\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, from which the deflection angle derives as a gradient; the convergence $\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, the dimensionless surface mass density, which causes isotropic focusing; the shear $\gamma(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, a spin-2 field that causes anisotropic stretching; the Jacobian matrix $\mathcal{A}$, which encodes all local lensing distortions; and the magnification μ, the ratio of image area to source area.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `lensing_potential.wl`: symbolic derivation of ψ, convergence, shear, Jacobian, and magnification for the point mass lens; verification of the 2D Poisson equation; publication-quality figure generation
- `convergence_shear_demo.nb`: interactive notebook: Manipulate for convergence and shear effects on circular sources, magnification map for point mass lens

9.1 Introduction: From Image Positions to Image Properties

The lens equation gives the positions of the images. Observations reveal more than positions: lensed images are stretched, magnified, and sometimes mirror-reflected relative to the unlensed source. Giant arcs in galaxy clusters, background galaxies stretched into elongated curves by the cluster's gravity, are the most conspicuous example.

To describe these distortions quantitatively, we need the local properties of the lens mapping $\boldsymbol{\beta}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$. Since the lens mapping is a smooth function (except at isolated singularities),

its local behavior is captured by its Jacobian matrix, the matrix of first partial derivatives. This matrix encodes all information about magnification, stretching, and parity of each image.

We begin by introducing the effective lensing potential $\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, a scalar field from which the deflection angle can be derived as a gradient. This potential provides a unified framework: its first derivatives give the deflection, and its second derivatives give the convergence and shear.

9.2 The Effective Lensing Potential

In Chapter 8 (eq. 8.11) we expressed the reduced deflection angle as an integral over the convergence. This deflection can be written as the gradient of a scalar potential.

Definition 9.2.1. The *effective lensing potential* (or lensing potential) is defined as (Narayan & Bartelmann eq. 51; Congdon & Keeton eq. 4.14):

$$\boxed{\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{1}{\pi}\int \kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}')\,\ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}'|\,d^2\theta'} \tag{9.1}$$

where $\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}') = \Sigma(D_{\rm d}\,\boldsymbol{\theta}')/\Sigma_{\rm cr}$ is the convergence (eq. 8.13) and the integral extends over the entire lens plane.

This is the two-dimensional analog of the Newtonian gravitational potential: just as the three-dimensional gravitational potential $\Phi(\mathbf{r}) = -G\int \rho(\mathbf{r}')/|\mathbf{r}-\mathbf{r}'|\,d^3r'$ satisfies Poisson's equation $\nabla^2\Phi = 4\pi G\rho$, the lensing potential satisfies the two-dimensional Poisson equation.

Remark 9.2.1. The lensing potential ψ is dimensionless when $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ is measured in radians. It is related to the physical (Shapiro) time delay through the Fermat potential, which we will encounter in Chapter 10.

9.2.1 Key Properties of the Lensing Potential

The lensing potential has two basic properties:

(1) Its gradient gives the deflection angle. Taking the gradient of eq. (9.1):

$$\boxed{\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \nabla_\theta\,\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})} \tag{9.2}$$

where $\nabla_\theta = (\partial/\partial\theta_1,\,\partial/\partial\theta_2)$ is the two-dimensional gradient with respect to the angular coordinates. This can be verified by differentiating eq. (9.1) under the integral sign and using $\nabla_\theta \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}'| = (\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}')/|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}'|^2$.

(2) Its Laplacian gives twice the convergence (2D Poisson equation).

$$\boxed{\nabla^2_\theta\,\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = 2\,\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta})} \tag{9.3}$$

The identity rests on the Green's function of the two-dimensional Laplacian,

$$\nabla^2_\theta \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}'| \;=\; 2\pi\,\delta^{(2)}(\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}')\,, \tag{9.4}$$

which we prove in two steps.

Step 1: $\nabla^2 \ln r = 0$ *for* $r \neq 0$. In polar coordinates centered at $\boldsymbol{\theta}'$, let $r = |\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\theta}'|$ and write $\nabla^2 = (1/r)\partial_r(r\,\partial_r) + (1/r^2)\partial_\phi^2$. Then $\partial_r(\ln r) = 1/r$ and $\nabla^2(\ln r) = (1/r)\partial_r(r \cdot 1/r) = (1/r)\partial_r(1) = 0$ for $r > 0$.

Step 2: the integrated strength is 2π. For any disk D_a of radius a centered at $\boldsymbol{\theta}'$, the divergence theorem gives

$$\int_{D_a} \nabla^2 \ln r \, d^2\theta \;=\; \oint_{\partial D_a} \nabla(\ln r) \cdot \hat{n}\, d\ell \;=\; \oint_{r=a} \frac{1}{r}\bigg|_{r=a} a\, d\phi \;=\; 2\pi.$$

Combined with step 1, $\nabla^2(\ln r)$ is a distribution supported at the origin with total weight 2π, i.e. eq. (9.4).

Differentiating eq. (9.1) under the integral sign and substituting eq. (9.4):

$$\nabla^2_\theta \psi \;=\; \frac{1}{\pi}\int \kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}')\, 2\pi\, \delta^{(2)}(\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\theta}')\, d^2\theta' \;=\; 2\,\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta})\,. \tag{9.5}$$

Equivalently, one can bypass eq. (9.4) entirely using $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \nabla\psi$ (eq. 9.2) and $\kappa = \frac{1}{2}\nabla \cdot \boldsymbol{\alpha}$ (Narayan & Bartelmann eq. 56; Congdon & Keeton eq. 4.22): $\frac{1}{2}\nabla^2\psi = \frac{1}{2}\nabla\cdot(\nabla\psi) = \frac{1}{2}\nabla\cdot\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \kappa$. Both routes are verified symbolically in `lensing_potential.wl` (direct convolution for the point-mass and uniform-disk convergence).

9.3 Convergence

The convergence was already introduced in Chapter 8 (eq. 8.13):

$$\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{\Sigma(D_\mathrm{d}\,\boldsymbol{\theta})}{\Sigma_\mathrm{cr}} \tag{9.6}$$

It is the dimensionless surface mass density, the ratio of the actual surface mass density to the critical value. We now examine its role in image distortion.

9.3.1 Physical Meaning

The convergence measures the isotropic focusing caused by the lens. A region with $\kappa > 0$ acts as a converging lens, focusing light rays and magnifying images isotropically (without changing their shape). The value $\kappa = 1$ means $\Sigma = \Sigma_\mathrm{cr}$, the threshold for strong lensing; regions where $\kappa \geq 1$ are supercritical and can produce multiple images. For an axisymmetric lens, $\kappa < 1$ everywhere means the lens is subcritical: it can still distort images (via shear), but it cannot produce multiple images. (For a non-axisymmetric lens, $\kappa > 1$ somewhere is sufficient but not necessary: shear can produce multiple images even with $\kappa < 1$ everywhere; Congdon & Keeton Sec. 2.5.)

9.3.2 Convergence from the Lensing Potential

From the 2D Poisson equation (9.3):

$$\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{1}{2}\,\nabla_\theta^2\,\psi = \frac{1}{2}\left(\frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_1^2} + \frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_2^2}\right). \tag{9.7}$$

Thus the convergence is the trace of the Hessian of the lensing potential (up to a factor of 1/2).

9.4 Shear

The shear describes the anisotropic distortion of images, the stretching in one direction and compression in the perpendicular direction.

The specific combinations that define γ_1 and γ_2 are fixed by a geometric argument. The Hessian of the lensing potential,

$$H_{ij} \;\equiv\; \frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_i\,\partial\theta_j}\,,$$

is a 2×2 real symmetric matrix with three independent components. Every such matrix decomposes uniquely into a trace piece (proportional to the identity) plus a traceless symmetric piece:

$$H \;=\; \frac{\operatorname{tr} H}{2}\,\mathbb{I} + H^{\mathrm{TF}}, \qquad H^{\mathrm{TF}} = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{1}{2}(H_{11}-H_{22}) & H_{12} \\ H_{12} & -\frac{1}{2}(H_{11}-H_{22}) \end{pmatrix}. \tag{9.8}$$

The trace part is the isotropic convergence $\frac{1}{2}\operatorname{tr} H = \kappa$ (eq. 9.7); the traceless part is the shear. Its two independent entries are named

$$\boxed{\gamma_1(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{1}{2}\left(\frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_1^2} - \frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_2^2}\right), \qquad \gamma_2(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_1\,\partial\theta_2}\,,} \tag{9.9}$$

so that the Hessian itself reads $H = \big((\kappa+\gamma_1)\;\;\gamma_2;\;\gamma_2\;\;(\kappa-\gamma_1)\big)$. Under a rotation of the $\boldsymbol{\theta}$-axes by angle ϕ, H^{TF} transforms as a rank-2 symmetric tensor whose traceless part carries *two* powers of $e^{\pm i\phi}$. Forming the complex shear $\gamma \equiv \gamma_1 + i\gamma_2$,

$$\gamma \;\longrightarrow\; e^{-2i\phi}\,\gamma\,, \tag{9.10}$$

which is the spin-2 transformation law, the reason the shear has a 180° (not 360°) rotational symmetry. The decomposition (9.8) and the transformation law (9.10) are verified symbolically in `lensing_potential.wl`.

The shear magnitude and the complex shear are:

$$|\gamma| = \sqrt{\gamma_1^2+\gamma_2^2}\,, \qquad \gamma = \gamma_1 + i\,\gamma_2 = |\gamma|\,e^{2i\phi_\gamma} \tag{9.11}$$

where ϕ_γ is the orientation angle of the shear.

9.4.1 Physical Meaning

The shear is a spin-2 field: it is invariant under rotations by 180 (not 360), reflecting the fact that an ellipse looks the same after a half-turn. The two components have specific geometric meanings. For $\gamma_1 > 0$ the image is stretched along the θ_1-axis and compressed along θ_2; for $\gamma_1 < 0$ it is stretched along the θ_2-axis and compressed along θ_1. For $\gamma_2 > 0$ the stretching is along the direction at 45 to the θ_1-axis, and for $\gamma_2 < 0$ along the direction at 135 to the θ_1-axis.

Remark 9.4.1. The convergence and shear together account for all four independent second derivatives of the lensing potential (the Hessian is a symmetric 2×2 matrix with three independent components; κ captures the trace, and γ_1, γ_2 capture the traceless part):

$$\frac{\partial^2 \psi}{\partial \theta_i \, \partial \theta_j} = \begin{pmatrix} \kappa + \gamma_1 & \gamma_2 \\ \gamma_2 & \kappa - \gamma_1 \end{pmatrix}. \tag{9.12}$$

9.5 The Jacobian Matrix (Inverse Magnification Tensor)

The lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ defines a mapping from the image plane to the source plane. The local properties of this mapping are encoded in its *Jacobian matrix*:

$$\mathcal{A}_{ij} = \frac{\partial \beta_i}{\partial \theta_j} = \delta_{ij} - \frac{\partial \alpha_i}{\partial \theta_j} = \delta_{ij} - \frac{\partial^2 \psi}{\partial \theta_i \, \partial \theta_j} \tag{9.13}$$

where in the last step we used $\alpha_i = \partial \psi / \partial \theta_i$ (eq. 9.2).

Using the decomposition of the Hessian into convergence and shear (eq. 9.12), the Jacobian takes the form (Narayan & Bartelmann eq. 58; Congdon & Keeton eq. 4.51):

$$\boxed{\mathcal{A} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 - \kappa - \gamma_1 & -\gamma_2 \\ -\gamma_2 & 1 - \kappa + \gamma_1 \end{pmatrix}} \tag{9.14}$$

Remark 9.5.1. The matrix $\mathcal{A}$ is sometimes called the *inverse magnification tensor* because its inverse $\mathcal{A}^{-1}$ gives the magnification tensor $\mathcal{M}$:

$$\mathcal{M} = \mathcal{A}^{-1} = \frac{\partial \boldsymbol{\theta}}{\partial \boldsymbol{\beta}}. \tag{9.15}$$

$\mathcal{M}$ maps source-plane displacements to image-plane displacements.

9.5.1 Decomposition of the Jacobian

The Jacobian can be decomposed into a convergence (isotropic) part and a shear (anisotropic) part:

$$\mathcal{A} = (1 - \kappa) \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} - \begin{pmatrix} \gamma_1 & \gamma_2 \\ \gamma_2 & -\gamma_1 \end{pmatrix} \tag{9.16}$$

The first term is proportional to the identity matrix and represents isotropic focusing (convergence). The second term is a traceless, symmetric matrix (the shear matrix) that represents anisotropic distortion.

9.5.2 Eigenvalues of the Jacobian

The eigenvalues of $\mathcal{A}$ are (Congdon & Keeton eq. 4.54):

$$\lambda_\pm = 1 - \kappa \pm |\gamma| = (1-\kappa) \pm \sqrt{\gamma_1^2 + \gamma_2^2}\,. \tag{9.17}$$

These eigenvalues give the inverse magnification along the two principal axes of the distortion. The corresponding eigenvectors define the directions of maximum and minimum stretching.

9.6 Magnification

Gravitational lensing conserves surface brightness (a consequence of Liouville's theorem: the photon phase space density is preserved along geodesics). Therefore the magnification is the ratio of the solid angle of the image to that of the source:

$$\mu = \frac{(\text{image area})}{(\text{source area})} = \frac{1}{\det \mathcal{A}}\,. \tag{9.18}$$

Computing the determinant of eq. (9.14):

$$\det \mathcal{A} = (1-\kappa-\gamma_1)(1-\kappa+\gamma_1) - \gamma_2^2 = (1-\kappa)^2 - (\gamma_1^2+\gamma_2^2) \tag{9.19}$$

and therefore:

$$\boxed{\mu = \frac{1}{\det \mathcal{A}} = \frac{1}{(1-\kappa)^2 - |\gamma|^2}} \tag{9.20}$$

This is the general magnification formula for gravitational lensing; μ depends on position through $\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ and $\gamma(\boldsymbol{\theta})$.

9.6.1 Properties of the Magnification

1. Positive parity ($\mu > 0$): the image has the same orientation (handedness) as the source. This occurs when $\det \mathcal{A} > 0$.

2. Negative parity ($\mu < 0$): the image is mirror-reflected relative to the source. This occurs when $\det \mathcal{A} < 0$. The absolute magnification is $|\mu|$.

3. Magnified images ($|\mu| > 1$): the image subtends a larger solid angle than the source. The condition is $|\det \mathcal{A}| < 1$, i.e. $-1 < (1-\kappa)^2 - |\gamma|^2 < 1$.

4. Demagnified images ($|\mu| < 1$): the image is smaller than the source.

5. Critical curves ($\det \mathcal{A} = 0$, $\mu \to \infty$): points where the magnification formally diverges. In practice, images near critical curves are very highly magnified (factors of 10–100), but finite source sizes prevent true divergences. These curves are the subject of Chapter 12.

9.6.2 Magnification in Terms of Eigenvalues

Using the eigenvalues of $\mathcal{A}$ (eq. 9.17):

$$\mu = \frac{1}{\lambda_+ \, \lambda_-} = \frac{1}{(1-\kappa-|\gamma|)(1-\kappa+|\gamma|)} \, . \tag{9.21}$$

The magnification diverges when either eigenvalue vanishes, i.e., when $1-\kappa = \pm|\gamma|$. These conditions define the two families of critical curves: the *tangential critical curve*, $\lambda_- = 0$ $(1-\kappa = |\gamma|)$, where images are stretched tangentially, and the *radial critical curve*, $\lambda_+ = 0$ $(1-\kappa = -|\gamma|)$, where images are stretched radially.

9.7 Convergence vs. Shear: Physical Effects

To build intuition for the roles of convergence and shear, consider how a small circular source is distorted in three limiting cases.

9.7.1 Pure Convergence ($\kappa > 0$, $\gamma = 0$)

The Jacobian reduces to $\mathcal{A} = (1-\kappa)\,\mathbf{I}$, a uniform scaling. A circular source remains circular, but its angular size is scaled by $1/(1-\kappa)$. The magnification is:

$$\mu = \frac{1}{(1-\kappa)^2} \, . \tag{9.22}$$

For $\kappa < 1$, the image is magnified and has positive parity. For $1 < \kappa < 2$ the image is still magnified (for $\kappa > 2$ it is demagnified, e.g. $\mu = 1/4$ at $\kappa = 3$), and for every $\kappa > 1$ it retains positive parity: $\det \mathcal{A} = (1-\kappa)^2 > 0$ for all $\kappa \neq 1$. Although both eigenvalues $(1-\kappa)$ are negative when $\kappa > 1$, their product is positive: a uniform negative scaling is equivalent to a 180° rotation, which preserves handedness. A genuine parity flip ($\det \mathcal{A} < 0$, $\mu < 0$) requires shear, so that the eigenvalues $\lambda_\pm = (1-\kappa) \pm |\gamma|$ have opposite signs.

9.7.2 Pure Shear ($\kappa = 0$, $\gamma > 0$)

The Jacobian becomes:

$$\mathcal{A} = \begin{pmatrix} 1-\gamma_1 & -\gamma_2 \\ -\gamma_2 & 1+\gamma_1 \end{pmatrix} . \tag{9.23}$$

A circular source is distorted into an ellipse. The magnification is:

$$\mu = \frac{1}{1-|\gamma|^2} \, . \tag{9.24}$$

The semi-axes of the elliptical image are proportional to $1/(1-|\gamma|)$ and $1/(1+|\gamma|)$, so the axis ratio is:

$$\frac{b}{a} = \frac{1-|\gamma|}{1+|\gamma|} \, . \tag{9.25}$$

The orientation of the ellipse is determined by the shear angle $\phi_\gamma = \frac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{atan2}(\gamma_2, \gamma_1)$, the two-argument arctangent (equivalently, $\gamma_1 = |\gamma| \cos 2\phi_\gamma$, $\gamma_2 = |\gamma| \sin 2\phi_\gamma$). The one-argument form $\frac{1}{2}\arctan(\gamma_2/\gamma_1)$ of earlier printings is off by 90° whenever $\gamma_1 < 0$.

9.7.3 Both Convergence and Shear

In general, both κ and γ are nonzero. A circular source is mapped to a larger ellipse: the convergence sets the overall magnification (size change) and the shear sets the ellipticity (shape change). The semi-axes of the image are $\delta/(1-\kappa-|\gamma|)$ and $\delta/(1-\kappa+|\gamma|)$ for a circular source of angular radius δ.

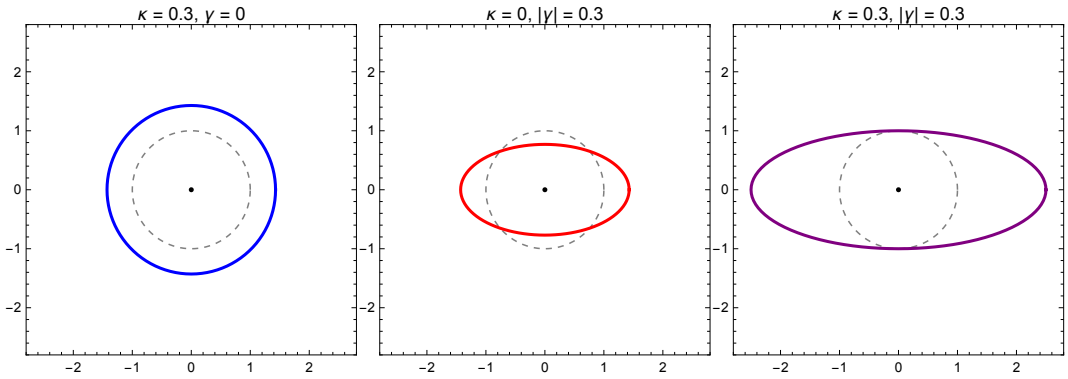


Figure 9.1: Effect of convergence and shear on a circular source. **Left:** Pure convergence ($\kappa = 0.3$, $\gamma = 0$) produces a larger circle (isotropic magnification). **Center:** Pure shear ($\kappa = 0$, $|\gamma| = 0.3$) produces an ellipse (anisotropic distortion; the magnification $\mu = 1/(1-|\gamma|^2) \approx 1.10$ differs from unity only at second order in $|\gamma|$). **Right:** Both ($\kappa = 0.3$, $|\gamma| = 0.3$) produces a larger ellipse. The dashed circle shows the original source in each panel. Generated by `lensing_potential.wl`.

9.8 Example: Point Mass Lens

We now compute κ, γ, and μ for the point mass lens, verifying consistency with the results of Chapter 8.

9.8.1 Lensing Potential for a Point Mass

For a point mass M at the origin, the convergence is a Dirac delta function:

$$\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{\Sigma(D_{\rm d}\boldsymbol{\theta})}{\Sigma_{\rm cr}} = \frac{M\,\delta^{(2)}(D_{\rm d}\boldsymbol{\theta})}{\Sigma_{\rm cr}} = \pi\theta_{\rm E}^2\,\delta^{(2)}(\boldsymbol{\theta})\,. \tag{9.26}$$

The mass is concentrated entirely at the origin; away from the origin, $\kappa = 0$.

Substituting into eq. (9.1), the lensing potential is:

$$\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \theta_{\rm E}^2 \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}| \tag{9.27}$$

which satisfies $\nabla\psi = \theta_{\rm E}^2\,\boldsymbol{\theta}/|\boldsymbol{\theta}|^2$, giving the deflection $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \theta_{\rm E}^2\,\boldsymbol{\theta}/|\boldsymbol{\theta}|^2$ as expected.

9.8.2 Shear for a Point Mass

Using polar coordinates on the lens plane, we can write $\theta_1 = \theta\cos\phi$ and $\theta_2 = \theta\sin\phi$, where $\theta = |\boldsymbol{\theta}|$. Computing the second derivatives of $\psi = \theta_{\rm E}^2 \ln\theta$:

$$\frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_1^2} = \theta_{\rm E}^2\,\frac{\theta_2^2-\theta_1^2}{\theta^4}\,,$$
$$\frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_2^2} = \theta_{\rm E}^2\,\frac{\theta_1^2-\theta_2^2}{\theta^4}\,,$$
$$\frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_1\,\partial\theta_2} = -\theta_{\rm E}^2\,\frac{2\theta_1\theta_2}{\theta^4}\,. \tag{9.28}$$

The shear components are (for $\theta \neq 0$):

$$\gamma_1 = \frac{1}{2}\left(\frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_1^2} - \frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_2^2}\right) = -\frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2(\theta_1^2-\theta_2^2)}{\theta^4} = -\frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\theta^2}\cos 2\phi\,, \tag{9.29}$$

$$\gamma_2 = \frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_1\,\partial\theta_2} = -\frac{2\theta_{\rm E}^2\,\theta_1\theta_2}{\theta^4} = -\frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\theta^2}\sin 2\phi\,. \tag{9.30}$$

The shear magnitude is:

$$\boxed{|\gamma| = \sqrt{\gamma_1^2+\gamma_2^2} = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\theta^2}} \tag{9.31}$$

The shear falls off as θ^{-2} and is aligned tangentially (the factor $e^{2i\phi}$ in the complex shear).

9.8.3 Convergence for a Point Mass (away from origin)

To compute the convergence correctly, we must be careful with the form of ψ. Writing $\psi = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{2}\ln(\theta_1^2+\theta_2^2)$ in Cartesian coordinates:

$$\frac{\partial\psi}{\partial\theta_1} = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2\,\theta_1}{\theta^2}\,, \qquad \frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_1^2} = \theta_{\rm E}^2\,\frac{\theta^2-2\theta_1^2}{\theta^4}\,. \tag{9.32}$$

Similarly, $\partial^2\psi/\partial\theta_2^2 = \theta_{\rm E}^2\,(\theta^2-2\theta_2^2)/\theta^4$. Summing:

$$\nabla^2\psi = \theta_{\rm E}^2\,\frac{2\theta^2-2(\theta_1^2+\theta_2^2)}{\theta^4} = 0 \qquad (\theta\neq 0)\,. \tag{9.33}$$

Therefore $\kappa = 0$ for $\theta \neq 0$, confirming that the convergence of a point mass is indeed a delta function concentrated entirely at the origin. In the distributional sense, $\nabla^2\ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}| = 2\pi\,\delta^{(2)}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, which recovers $\kappa = \pi\theta_{\rm E}^2\,\delta^{(2)}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ via the Poisson equation.

9.8.4 Magnification for a Point Mass

With $\kappa = 0$ and $|\gamma| = \theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta^2$ (for $\theta \neq 0$), the magnification formula (9.20) gives:

$$\mu = \frac{1}{1-\theta_{\rm E}^4/\theta^4} = \frac{\theta^4}{\theta^4-\theta_{\rm E}^4}\,. \tag{9.34}$$

This is eq. (8.32) of Chapter 8. Evaluating at the image positions $\theta_\pm$:

$$|\mu_\pm| = \frac{u^2+2}{2u\sqrt{u^2+4}} \pm \frac{1}{2}\,, \qquad \mu_+ > 0\,, \quad \mu_- < 0\,, \tag{9.35}$$

where $u = \beta/\theta_\mathrm{E}$, recovering eq. (8.33) exactly. (The inner image has $|\theta_-| < \theta_\mathrm{E}$, so $\theta_-^4 - \theta_\mathrm{E}^4 < 0$ and its signed magnification is negative.) The consistency is verified symbolically in `lensing_potential.wl`.

9.9 Example: Singular Isothermal Sphere (Preview)

The singular isothermal sphere (SIS) is the simplest realistic model for a galaxy lens. Its surface mass density profile is (Congdon & Keeton Sec. 2.3.2):

$$\Sigma(\xi) = \frac{\sigma_v^2}{2G\,\xi} \tag{9.36}$$

where σ_v is the one-dimensional velocity dispersion and $\xi = |\boldsymbol{\xi}|$ is the physical radius in the lens plane.

9.9.1 Convergence and Shear of the SIS

The convergence is:

$$\kappa(\theta) = \frac{\Sigma(D_\mathrm{d}\theta)}{\Sigma_\mathrm{cr}} = \frac{\theta_\mathrm{E}}{2\theta} \tag{9.37}$$

where $\theta_\mathrm{E} = 4\pi\sigma_v^2 D_\mathrm{ds}/(c^2 D_\mathrm{s})$ is the Einstein radius of the SIS. Here κ diverges at $\theta = 0$ (the "singular" in the name), and $\kappa(\theta_\mathrm{E}) = 1/2$.

The shear magnitude for the SIS is:

$$|\gamma(\theta)| = \frac{\theta_\mathrm{E}}{2\theta} = \kappa(\theta)\,. \tag{9.38}$$

Thus $|\gamma| = \kappa$ at every point for the SIS. This equality does not hold for general lens models; it is a special property of the isothermal profile.

9.9.2 Magnification of the SIS

The magnification is:

$$\mu = \frac{1}{(1-\kappa)^2 - |\gamma|^2} = \frac{1}{1-2\kappa} = \frac{1}{1-\theta_\mathrm{E}/\theta} = \frac{\theta}{\theta-\theta_\mathrm{E}}\,. \tag{9.39}$$

The magnification diverges at $\theta = \theta_\mathrm{E}$, the (tangential) critical curve of the SIS. The SIS model is treated in full in Chapter 11.

9.10 Critical Curves and Caustics (Preview)

Definition 9.10.1. The *critical curves* are the loci in the image plane where the magnification diverges:

$$\det \mathcal{A}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = 0 \qquad \Longleftrightarrow \qquad (1-\kappa)^2 = |\gamma|^2 \,. \tag{9.40}$$

The *caustics* are the images of the critical curves under the lens mapping, i.e., the corresponding curves in the source plane:

$$\boldsymbol{\beta}_{\rm caustic} = \boldsymbol{\theta}_{\rm crit} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}_{\rm crit}) \,. \tag{9.41}$$

Critical curves and caustics play a central role in strong lensing. When a source crosses a caustic, the number of images changes by two (a pair of highly magnified images appears or disappears); sources near caustics are very highly magnified, which is exploited in studies of distant, faint galaxies; and the topology of critical curves and caustics determines the image configuration (doubly, quadruply, or multiply imaged sources).

Remark 9.10.1 (Physical intuition for critical curves). When $\det(\mathcal{A}) = 0$, the magnification is formally infinite. Images near a critical curve are therefore highly stretched and magnified. A small source near a *caustic* (the mapping of the critical curve to the source plane) produces two images straddling the critical curve, one with positive parity (unreflected) and one with negative parity (mirror-reflected). These images appear/disappear in pairs as the source crosses a caustic, which is why the total number of images always changes by ± 2, preserving the odd-number theorem (Chapter 10). The full topological picture is developed in Chapter 12.

For the point mass lens, the critical curve is the Einstein ring ($\theta = \theta_{\rm E}$), and the caustic degenerates to a single point ($\beta = 0$). For more complex lens models, both critical curves and caustics have richer structure; the full theory is developed in Chapter 12.

9.11 Summary

The lensing potential $\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = (1/\pi)\int \kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}')\,\ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}'|\,d^2\theta'$ is a scalar field whose gradient gives the deflection angle ($\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \nabla\psi$) and whose Laplacian gives twice the convergence ($\nabla^2\psi = 2\kappa$). The convergence $\kappa = \Sigma/\Sigma_{\rm cr}$ causes isotropic focusing: a circular source remains circular but changes size. The shear $\gamma = \gamma_1 + i\gamma_2$ causes anisotropic distortion: a circular source is stretched into an ellipse.

The Jacobian matrix $\mathcal{A} = \begin{pmatrix} 1-\kappa-\gamma_1 & -\gamma_2 \\ -\gamma_2 & 1-\kappa+\gamma_1 \end{pmatrix}$ encodes all local lensing properties. Its eigenvalues $\lambda_\pm = 1-\kappa\pm|\gamma|$ give the inverse magnifications along the principal axes, and the magnification is $\mu = 1/\det\mathcal{A} = 1/[(1-\kappa)^2 - |\gamma|^2]$. The sign of μ determines the image parity. For a point mass lens, $\kappa = 0$ (away from the origin), $|\gamma| = \theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta^2$, and the general magnification formula recovers the result $|\mu_\pm| = (u^2+2)/(2u\sqrt{u^2+4}) \pm 1/2$ from Chapter 8, with $\mu_- < 0$. Critical curves ($\det\mathcal{A} = 0$) and their mappings, caustics, govern the image multiplicity and are the sites of maximum magnification.

9.12 Problems

Exercise 9.12.1. (Derivation of the Jacobian matrix.) Starting from the lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ with $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \nabla\psi$:

(a) Compute $\mathcal{A}_{ij} = \partial\beta_i/\partial\theta_j$ and express it in terms of second derivatives of ψ.

(b) Decompose the Hessian matrix $\partial^2\psi/\partial\theta_i\partial\theta_j$ into a trace part (proportional to δ_{ij}) and a traceless part. Identify the trace part with κ and the traceless part with the shear.

(c) Write $\mathcal{A}$ in the form $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1-\kappa-\gamma_1 & -\gamma_2 \\ -\gamma_2 & 1-\kappa+\gamma_1 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$.

Verify with `problems_05.wl`.

Exercise 9.12.2. (The 2D Poisson equation.)

(a) Show that the two-dimensional Green's function of the Laplacian is $(1/2\pi)\ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}|$, i.e., $\nabla^2 \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}| = 2\pi\,\delta^{(2)}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$. *Hint:* Use the fact that $\ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}|$ is harmonic for $\boldsymbol{\theta} \neq 0$ and apply Gauss's theorem to a small circle around the origin.

(b) Starting from the definition of ψ (eq. 9.1), apply the Laplacian to derive $\nabla^2\psi = 2\kappa$.

(c) Verify the 2D Poisson equation for the point mass lens: $\psi = \theta_{\rm E}^2 \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}|$ and $\kappa = \pi\theta_{\rm E}^2\,\delta^{(2)}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$.

Verify with `problems_05.wl`.

Exercise 9.12.3. (Shear of a point mass lens.) For the point mass lensing potential $\psi = \theta_{\rm E}^2 \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}|$:

(a) Compute γ_1 and γ_2 as functions of θ_1, θ_2.

(b) Show that $|\gamma| = \theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta^2$.

(c) Express γ_1 and γ_2 in polar coordinates (θ, ϕ) and show that the complex shear is $\gamma = -(\theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta^2)\,e^{2i\phi}$ (tangential shear).

(d) Compute the ratio $|\gamma|/\kappa$ at the image positions $\theta_\pm$ of the point mass lens. What happens for sources far from the Einstein radius?

Verify with `problems_05.wl`.

Exercise 9.12.4. (Magnification consistency check.)

(a) Using $\kappa = 0$ and $|\gamma| = \theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta^2$ for the point mass lens, show that $\mu = \theta^4/(\theta^4 - \theta_{\rm E}^4)$.

(b) Evaluate μ at the image positions $\theta_\pm = (\beta \pm \sqrt{\beta^2 + 4\theta_{\rm E}^2})/2$. Using $u = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$, show that the result reduces to $\mu_+ = (u^2+2)/(2u\sqrt{u^2+4}) + 1/2$ and $\mu_- = 1/2 - (u^2+2)/(2u\sqrt{u^2+4})$, i.e., $|\mu_\pm| = (u^2+2)/(2u\sqrt{u^2+4}) \pm 1/2$.

(c) Verify that $\mu_+ > 0$ (positive parity) and $\mu_- < 0$ (negative parity) for all $u > 0$.

(d) Show that $|\mu_+| + |\mu_-| > 1$ for all $u > 0$ (gravitational lensing always increases the total flux).

Verify with `problems_05.wl`.

Exercise 9.12.5. (Elliptical image from constant κ and γ.) A small circular source of angular radius δ is lensed by a region with constant convergence κ and constant shear $\gamma = |\gamma|\, e^{2i\phi_\gamma}$ (with $\gamma_1 = |\gamma| \cos 2\phi_\gamma$ and $\gamma_2 = |\gamma| \sin 2\phi_\gamma$).

(a) Write the Jacobian matrix $\mathcal{A}$ for constant κ, γ_1, γ_2.

(b) Find the eigenvalues $\lambda_\pm$ of $\mathcal{A}$ and show that the image is an ellipse with semi-axes $a = \delta/|\lambda_-|$ and $b = \delta/|\lambda_+|$ (assuming $|\lambda_-| < |\lambda_+|$).

(c) Compute the axis ratio b/a and the magnification μ in terms of κ and $|\gamma|$.

(d) The orientation of the ellipse is along the eigenvector corresponding to λ_-. For $\gamma_2 = 0$ (shear aligned with the coordinate axes), what is the orientation of the major axis?

(e) Evaluate the axis ratio and magnification for $\kappa = 0.3$, $|\gamma| = 0.2$.

Verify with `problems_05.wl`.

Chapter 10

Fermat's Principle and Time Delays

> *The lensing properties of model gravitational lenses are especially easy to visualize by application of Fermat's principle of geometrical optics [...]* — Narayan & Bartelmann (1997), Sect. 3.3.1

In Chapter 8 we derived the lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ as a geometric consequence of light deflection. In Chapter 6 we computed the Shapiro time delay experienced by photons passing through a gravitational potential, and in Chapter 5 we introduced the effective refractive index of a weak gravitational field.

In this chapter we show that the lens equation itself emerges from a variational principle: images form at stationary points of the *arrival-time surface*. This reformulation, Fermat's principle for gravitational lensing, accounts for image formation and also yields observable time delays between multiple images. These time delays are proportional to H_0^{-1}, so that multiply-imaged variable sources (such as quasars) provide an independent measurement of the Hubble constant.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `time_delay_function.wl`: symbolic computation of the Fermat potential, verification that $\nabla\tau = 0$ recovers the lens equation, time delay formulas for point mass and SIS lenses, numerical H_0 estimation, and publication-quality figure generation
- `arrival_time_surface.nb`: interactive notebook: 3D arrival-time surface with slider for source position, contour plots with critical curves, time delay visualization

10.1 Introduction: From Geometry to a Variational Principle

The lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ was derived in Chapter 8 by tracing light rays through the lensing geometry. That approach is direct, but it does not explain why light follows particular paths through the lens plane, nor does it give the relative arrival times of multiple images.

A more general perspective comes from *Fermat's principle*: among all possible paths from source to observer, light follows those for which the travel time is stationary (a minimum, maximum, or saddle point of the arrival time). In classical optics, Fermat's principle explains Snell's law and the focusing properties of lenses. In gravitational lensing it derives the lens

equation as the stationarity condition $\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}\, t = 0$; it classifies multiple images by the nature of the stationary point (minimum, saddle, or maximum), which determines their parity and arrival order; and it produces observable time delays between multiple images, from which the Hubble constant can be measured.

The central quantity is the *time delay function* (or arrival-time surface) $t(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, which gives the arrival time of a photon traveling from a source at $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ via the lens plane at $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ to the observer. Images form at the stationary points of $t(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, and the differences in t between stationary points give the time delays.

10.2 The Time Delay Function

Consider a photon emitted by a source at angular position $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ in the source plane. The photon passes through the lens plane at angular position $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ and arrives at the observer. The total travel time relative to the unperturbed (unlensed, straight-line) path consists of two contributions:

- *Geometric delay* (extra path length): the deflected ray travels a longer geometric path than the straight-line ray. In the small-angle, thin-lens approximation, the extra path length corresponds to an angular excess of $\frac{1}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\beta}|^2$ (see Chapter 8, Section 8.3).
- *Shapiro (gravitational) delay*: the photon passes through the gravitational potential of the lens, experiencing the time delay derived in Chapter 6. In the thin-lens formalism, this delay is encoded in the lensing potential $\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ (Chapter 9).

Combining these contributions, the total arrival time is (Narayan & Bartelmann eq. 63; Congdon & Keeton eqs. 4.23–4.25):

$$\boxed{t(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{(1+z_d)}{c}\,\frac{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm ds}}\,\left[\tfrac{1}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\beta}|^2 - \psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})\right] + \text{const}} \tag{10.1}$$

where z_d is the redshift of the lens, the angular diameter distances $D_{\rm d}$, $D_{\rm s}$, $D_{\rm ds}$ are defined in Chapter 7, and the constant is an irrelevant additive term that depends on the unperturbed travel time.

The factor $(1+z_d)$ arises from *cosmological time dilation*: the geometric and Shapiro delays are computed in the rest frame of the lens (at redshift z_d), but the time delay is observed in the observer's frame. A time interval $\Delta t_{\rm lens}$ at the lens is stretched to $\Delta t_{\rm obs} = (1+z_d)\,\Delta t_{\rm lens}$ in the observer's frame, just as photon wavelengths are redshifted by the same factor (eq. 7.37 from Chapter 7; cf. Schneider, Ehlers & Falco 1992, Sec. 4.6, eqs. 4.65–4.67). The combination $D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}/D_{\rm ds}$ is the *effective lensing distance*, which encodes the geometry of the observer–lens–source system.

Definition 10.2.1 (Fermat potential)**.** The dimensionless quantity

$$\boxed{\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta},\boldsymbol{\beta}) = \tfrac{1}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\beta}|^2 - \psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})} \tag{10.2}$$

is called the *Fermat potential* (or *time delay potential*). The arrival time is proportional to τ:

$$t(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{(1+z_d)}{c}\,\frac{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm ds}}\,\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta},\boldsymbol{\beta}) + \text{const}\,. \tag{10.3}$$

Remark 10.2.1. The Fermat potential has a simple physical interpretation. The first term $\frac{1}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\beta}|^2$ is the geometric delay: it penalizes paths where the ray in the lens plane ($\boldsymbol{\theta}$) is far from the straight-line direction ($\boldsymbol{\beta}$). The second term $-\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ is the gravitational (Shapiro) delay. Because ψ is defined only up to an additive constant, its sign carries no physical meaning; its shape does. For any attractive axisymmetric lens $d\psi/d\theta = \alpha > 0$, so $-\psi$ is largest at the lens centre: photons passing through a deeper part of the potential are delayed more, as for the Shapiro delay of Chapter 6.[1] For a point mass, $\psi = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2 \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}|$ and $-\psi \to +\infty$ at the origin, so the arrival-time surface has an infinite peak there instead of a smooth maximum. The competition between geometric and gravitational delay determines the structure of the arrival-time surface and hence the number and types of images.

10.3 Fermat's Principle and the Lens Equation

Fermat's principle states that images form at stationary points of the arrival time $t(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, or equivalently, at stationary points of the Fermat potential $\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta},\boldsymbol{\beta})$:

$$\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}\, t(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = 0 \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad \nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}\, \tau(\boldsymbol{\theta},\boldsymbol{\beta}) = 0\,. \tag{10.4}$$

Computing the gradient of τ:

$$\begin{aligned}\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}\,\tau &= \nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}\left[\tfrac{1}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\beta}|^2 - \psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})\right] \\ &= (\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\beta}) - \nabla\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})\,.\end{aligned} \tag{10.5}$$

Setting this to zero:

$$\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\beta}-\nabla\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = 0 \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad \boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \nabla\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})\,. \tag{10.6}$$

Since the reduced deflection angle is $\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \nabla\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ (from Chapter 9), this is precisely the lens equation:

$$\boxed{\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})} \tag{10.7}$$

Remark 10.3.1. The lens equation, which we previously derived from ray-tracing geometry, thus follows from the stationarity of the arrival time. Fermat's principle provides a variational derivation of the fundamental equation of gravitational lensing. The connection between the gradient of the lensing potential and the deflection angle, $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \nabla\psi$, was established in Chapter 9 from the Poisson equation $\nabla^2\psi = 2\kappa$.

10.4 Classification of Images: Morse Theory

At each stationary point $\boldsymbol{\theta}_i$ of the Fermat potential (i.e., at each image position), we can characterize the nature of the stationary point by the *Hessian matrix* of τ:

$$T_{ab} = \frac{\partial^2\tau}{\partial\theta_a\,\partial\theta_b} = \delta_{ab} - \frac{\partial^2\psi}{\partial\theta_a\,\partial\theta_b} = \mathcal{A}_{ab}\,, \tag{10.8}$$

[1] An earlier version of this remark said that $\psi > 0$ makes the Shapiro term *reduce* the arrival time. That has the sign backwards: the Shapiro delay $(2/c^3)\int|\Phi|\,dl$ is positive and grows with $|\Phi|$ [30, eq. 3].

where $\mathcal{A}_{ab}$ is the Jacobian matrix of the lens mapping (the inverse magnification matrix, from Chapter 9).

The eigenvalues of T_{ab} at a stationary point determine the *type* of the image. There are exactly three possibilities, classified by *Morse theory*:

1. *Type I image (minimum of τ).* Both eigenvalues of T are positive. Equivalently, $\det(\mathcal{A}) > 0$ and $\operatorname{tr}(\mathcal{A}) > 0$. The magnification $\mu = 1/\det(\mathcal{A}) > 0$ (positive parity: the image is not mirror-reflected). This image corresponds to the minimum of the arrival-time surface and therefore arrives first.

2. *Type II image (saddle point of τ).* One eigenvalue is positive and one is negative. Equivalently, $\det(\mathcal{A}) < 0$. The magnification $\mu = 1/\det(\mathcal{A}) < 0$ (negative parity: the image is mirror-reflected).

3. *Type III image (maximum of τ).* Both eigenvalues of T are negative. Equivalently, $\det(\mathcal{A}) > 0$ and $\operatorname{tr}(\mathcal{A}) < 0$. The magnification $\mu = 1/\det(\mathcal{A}) > 0$ (positive parity). This image corresponds to the maximum of the arrival-time surface and therefore arrives last.

Table 10.1: Classification of images by Morse type. The Hessian of the Fermat potential at each image determines its type and parity. The global minimum of τ is a Type I image and arrives first; a saddle always arrives after it, but its order relative to other images is not fixed (for a point-mass or SIS lens, which has no Type III image, the saddle arrives last).

Type	**Stationary point**	**Eigenvalues**	$\det(\mathcal{A})$	**Parity**	**Arrival**
I	Minimum	$+, +$	> 0	$+$ (same)	First
II	Saddle	$+, -$	< 0	$-$ (flipped)	After I
III	Maximum	$-, -$	> 0	$+$ (same)	Last

Remark 10.4.1 (The arrival-time surface determines image topology). The topology of the arrival-time surface $\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ completely determines the image structure. Each minimum, saddle, and maximum of τ corresponds to an image. When a source crosses a caustic, two stationary points of τ merge and annihilate (or are created from nothing), always one saddle and one extremum, preserving the constraint $N_{\min} + N_{\max} - N_{\text{saddle}} = 1$ (a consequence of Morse theory on the plane). This topological constraint is why images always appear and disappear in pairs with opposite parity, as explored in detail in Chapter 12.

Theorem 10.4.1 (Burke's Odd-Number Theorem)**.** *For a* transparent *lens (i.e., a lens with a smooth, bounded surface mass density $\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ that falls off sufficiently rapidly at large $|\boldsymbol{\theta}|$), the total number of images is always odd. Specifically, if we denote by $n_{\min}$, n_{sad}, and $n_{\max}$ the numbers of minima, saddle points, and maxima of τ, then:*

$$n_{\min} - n_{\text{sad}} + n_{\max} = 1\,. \tag{10.9}$$

This is a topological result from Morse theory.

Remark 10.4.2. The smoothness hypothesis is essential. Burke's theorem does *not* apply to a point mass lens: Σ is a Dirac delta function and $\psi = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2 \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}|$ diverges at the origin, so the origin is a singularity of τ rather than a true stationary point. A point mass therefore produces exactly two images ($\theta_\pm$ from Chapter 8), not three. For an extended lens with a smooth core (such as a non-singular isothermal sphere, Chapter 11), the central singularity is replaced by a genuine maximum of τ and a corresponding third image appears, typically highly demagnified. The singular isothermal sphere itself is intermediate: $\Sigma \propto 1/\theta$ is finite at every $\theta > 0$ but diverges at the origin, again removing the central image while keeping the two outer images.

10.5 The Arrival-Time Surface

The arrival-time surface is the three-dimensional plot of $\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ as a function of the two-dimensional image-plane position $\boldsymbol{\theta} = (\theta_1, \theta_2)$ for a fixed source position $\boldsymbol{\beta}$. It is the standard visualization of Fermat's principle in gravitational lensing.

10.5.1 Point Mass Lens

For a point mass lens with Einstein radius θ_{E}, the lensing potential is (from Chapter 9):

$$\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2 \, \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}| \, . \tag{10.10}$$

The Fermat potential becomes:

$$\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = \tfrac{1}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\beta}|^2 - \theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2 \, \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}| \, . \tag{10.11}$$

For a source at $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (\beta, 0)$ with $\beta > 0$ (placing the source along the θ_1-axis without loss of generality by the azimuthal symmetry of the lens), the arrival-time surface $\tau(\theta_1, \theta_2)$ has exactly two stationary points in the region $|\boldsymbol{\theta}| > 0$: a minimum (Type I) at $\boldsymbol{\theta} = (\theta_+, 0)$, where $\theta_+ = (\beta + \sqrt{\beta^2 + 4\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2})/2$ is the primary image from eq. (8.21), which arrives first; and a saddle point (Type II) at $\boldsymbol{\theta} = (\theta_-, 0)$, where $\theta_- = (\beta - \sqrt{\beta^2 + 4\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2})/2$ is the secondary image, which arrives second.

The point $\boldsymbol{\theta} = \mathbf{0}$ is a *singularity* of ψ, not a true stationary point of τ, so the point-mass lens has only the two images $\theta_\pm$ above. A softened mass profile (Chapter 11) replaces this singularity with a smooth maximum and produces a corresponding (highly demagnified) third image.

10.5.2 The Einstein Ring as a Degenerate Minimum

When the source is exactly behind the lens ($\boldsymbol{\beta} = 0$), the Fermat potential becomes circularly symmetric:

$$\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta}, \mathbf{0}) = \tfrac{1}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta}|^2 - \theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2 \, \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}| \, . \tag{10.12}$$

The stationarity condition $d\tau/d|\boldsymbol{\theta}| = 0$ gives $|\boldsymbol{\theta}| = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}$, which is the Einstein ring. The minimum of τ is no longer an isolated point but a circle of stationary points: the Einstein ring is a degenerate minimum of the arrival-time surface.

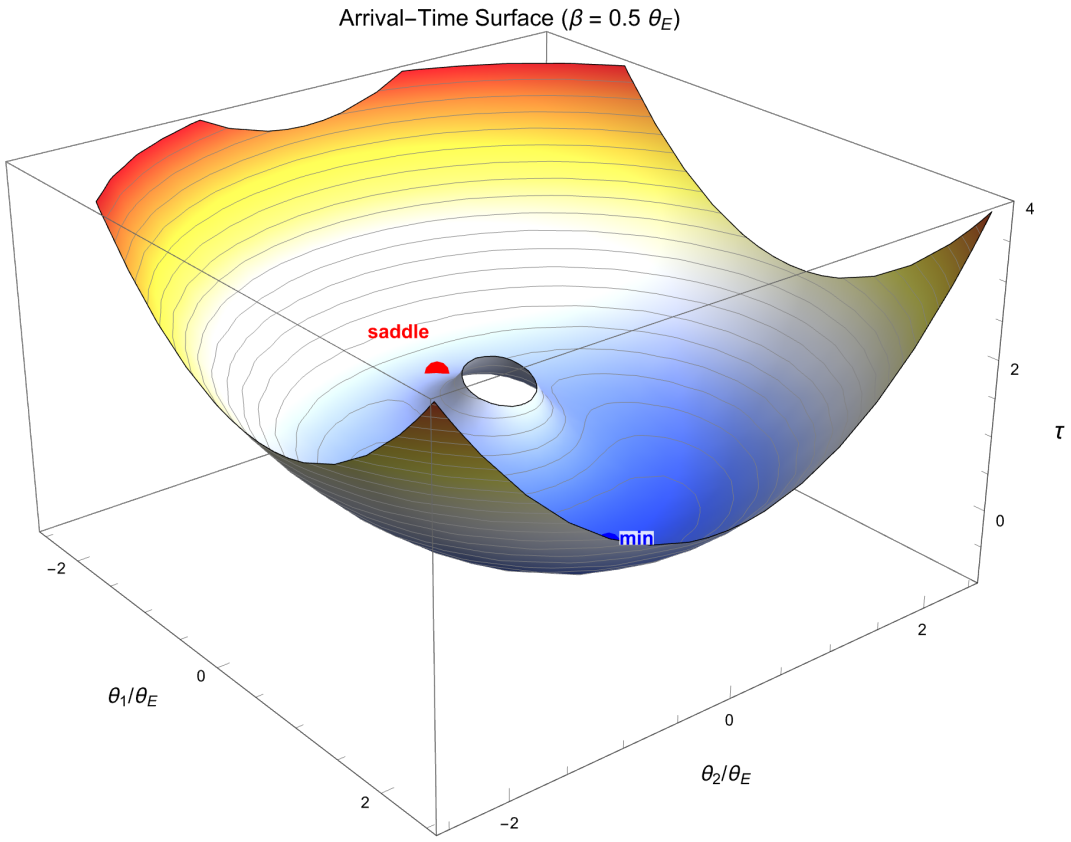


Figure 10.1: The arrival-time surface $\tau(\theta_1, \theta_2)$ for a point mass lens with source at $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.5, 0)\,\theta_{\rm E}$. The surface shows a minimum (Type I image, blue dot) and a saddle point (Type II image, red dot). The minimum has the smaller arrival time and corresponds to the image that is observed first. The difference in τ between the two stationary points gives the dimensionless time delay. Generated by `time_delay_function.wl`.

10.6 Observable Time Delays

The arrival time at each image $\boldsymbol{\theta}_i$ is given by eq. (10.1). The *time delay* between two images i and j is the difference in their arrival times:

$$\boxed{\Delta t_{ij} = t(\boldsymbol{\theta}_i) - t(\boldsymbol{\theta}_j) = \frac{(1+z_d)}{c}\,\frac{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm ds}}\,\left[\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta}_i, \boldsymbol{\beta}) - \tau(\boldsymbol{\theta}_j, \boldsymbol{\beta})\right]} \tag{10.13}$$

This quantity is directly observable: if the source is variable (as quasars are), the light curves measured at the two image positions will show the same variability pattern, but shifted by Δt_{ij}. By cross-correlating the light curves, one can extract Δt_{ij} to high precision.

Remark 10.6.1. The time delay Δt_{ij} depends on three ingredients:

1. The cosmological distances $(1+z_d)\,D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}/D_{\rm ds}$, which encode the expansion history of the universe.
2. The image positions $\boldsymbol{\theta}_i$, $\boldsymbol{\theta}_j$, which are directly observed.

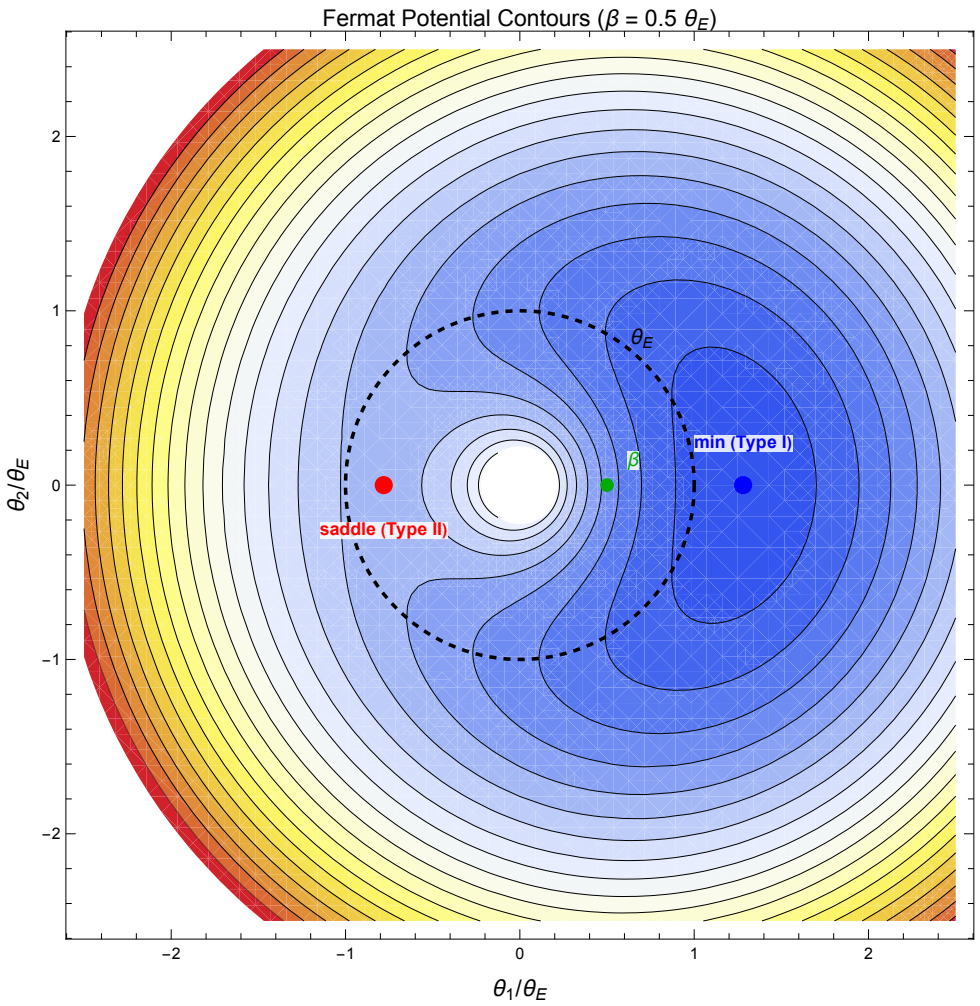


Figure 10.2: Contour plot of the Fermat potential $\tau(\theta_1, \theta_2)$ for a point mass lens with $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.5, 0)\,\theta_{\rm E}$. The two stationary points (minimum and saddle) are marked. The critical curve (Einstein ring, dashed circle) is overlaid. Generated by `time_delay_function.wl`.

3. The lensing potential $\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, which must be modeled from the observed lens properties (mass distribution, image positions, fluxes, etc.).

Given items (2) and (3), a measurement of Δt_{ij} constrains the distance combination in item (1), and hence the cosmological parameters.

10.7 Time Delay and the Hubble Constant

The principal cosmological application of time delays is the measurement of the Hubble constant H_0. The distance combination $D_{\rm d}\, D_{\rm s}/D_{\rm ds}$ is an angular diameter distance ratio that scales inversely with the Hubble constant:

$$\frac{D_{\rm d}\, D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm ds}} \propto \frac{1}{H_0}\,. \tag{10.14}$$

This follows from the definition of angular diameter distances in Chapter 7: all comoving distances scale as c/H_0 times a dimensionless integral over the expansion history.

Therefore, the time delay between images scales as:

$$\boxed{\Delta t \propto H_0^{-1}} \tag{10.15}$$

This is the basis of *time-delay cosmography*: by measuring Δt from monitoring campaigns and modeling the lens potential ψ, one can determine H_0 independently of the cosmic distance ladder. The method is sometimes called "one-step" distance measurement, because it converts an observed time delay directly into a physical distance.

Remark 10.7.1. To extract H_0 from a time delay measurement, one needs:

1. A precise measurement of Δt (from light curve monitoring of a multiply-imaged variable source).
2. The lens and source redshifts z_d, z_s.
3. A model for the lens mass distribution $\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, constrained by the observed image positions, fluxes, and extended image structure.
4. A cosmological model (usually flat ΛCDM with Ω_m fixed) to convert the distance ratio into H_0.

The main systematic uncertainty is the lens model degeneracy (the "mass-sheet degeneracy"), which we will encounter in later chapters.

10.7.1 Observational Milestones

Time-delay cosmography has been applied to a growing number of multiply-imaged quasars. Q0957+561 (Walsh, Carswell & Weymann 1979), the first gravitational lens discovered, has a time delay ($\Delta t \approx 417$ days) that was measured after years of photometric monitoring. B1608+656 is a four-image lens system with three independent time delays, which provide strong constraints. H0LiCOW (2017–present) is a systematic program combining precise time delays from COSMOGRAIL monitoring with detailed lens models and line-of-sight structure analysis. The H0LiCOW XIII result (Wong et al. 2020; six lenses) gives $H_0 = 73.3^{+1.7}_{-1.8}\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$, in agreement with local distance ladder measurements and in some tension with the CMB value ($H_0 \approx 67\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$ from Planck). The successor TDCOSMO programme (Birrer et al. 2020) performed an independent analysis that explicitly marginalises over the mass-sheet degeneracy and obtained a less precise but consistent result ($H_0 = 74.5^{+5.6}_{-6.1}\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$).

10.8 Example: Point Mass Time Delay

We now compute the time delay for a point mass lens explicitly. This calculation illustrates the method and the physical scales involved.

10.8.1 Fermat Potential for the Point Mass

Using the lensing potential $\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \theta_\mathrm{E}^2 \ln|\boldsymbol{\theta}|$ and working in units of θ_E (i.e., defining $x = \theta/\theta_\mathrm{E}$ and $y = \beta/\theta_\mathrm{E}$), the Fermat potential along the symmetry axis (where both images lie for a

point mass) is:

$$\tau(x) = \tfrac{1}{2}(x-y)^2 - \ln|x|\,, \tag{10.16}$$

where we have set $\theta_{\rm E} = 1$ in the logarithmic term.

The two image positions are $x_\pm = (y \pm \sqrt{y^2+4})/2$.

10.8.2 Time Delay Computation

The Fermat potential at the two images is:

$$\tau(x_+) = \tfrac{1}{2}(x_+ - y)^2 - \ln x_+\,, \tag{10.17}$$
$$\tau(x_-) = \tfrac{1}{2}(x_- - y)^2 - \ln|x_-|\,. \tag{10.18}$$

The dimensionless time delay is $\Delta\tau = \tau(x_-) - \tau(x_+)$ (since $\tau(x_-) > \tau(x_+)$, the saddle image arrives later).

After algebraic simplification (verified in `time_delay_function.wl`), the result is:

$$\boxed{\Delta\tau = \frac{y\sqrt{y^2+4}}{2} + \ln\left(\frac{\sqrt{y^2+4}+y}{\sqrt{y^2+4}-y}\right)} \tag{10.19}$$

where $y = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$ is the dimensionless source position.

The physical time delay is:

$$\Delta t = \frac{(1+z_d)}{c}\,\frac{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm ds}}\,\theta_{\rm E}^2\,\Delta\tau\,. \tag{10.20}$$

Using $\theta_{\rm E}^2 = 4GM/(c^2)\cdot D_{\rm ds}/(D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s})$:

$$\Delta t = \frac{4GM}{c^3}\,(1+z_d)\,\Delta\tau = \frac{2R_{\rm S}}{c}\,(1+z_d)\,\Delta\tau\,, \tag{10.21}$$

where $R_{\rm S} = 2GM/c^2$ is the Schwarzschild radius.[2]

Example 10.8.1. Numerical time delay for a galaxy-mass point lens.

Consider a lens mass $M = 10^{12}\,M_\odot$ at $z_d = 0.3$ with a source at $\beta = 0.5\,\theta_{\rm E}$ ($y = 0.5$). The Schwarzschild radius is:

$$R_{\rm S} = \frac{2\times 6.674\times10^{-11}\times10^{12}\times1.989\times10^{30}}{(2.998\times10^{8})^2} \approx 2.95\times10^{15}\ \text{m} \approx 0.096\ \text{pc}\,.$$

For $y = 0.5$: $\sqrt{y^2+4} = \sqrt{4.25} \approx 2.0616$.

$$\begin{aligned}\Delta\tau &= \frac{0.5\times2.0616}{2} + \ln\left(\frac{2.0616+0.5}{2.0616-0.5}\right)\\ &= 0.5154 + \ln(1.6404) = 0.5154 + 0.4949 = 1.0103\,.\end{aligned}$$

[2]The factor 2 in the second equality follows from $4GM/c^3 = 2R_{\rm S}/c$. Earlier versions of these notes wrote $R_{\rm S}/c$ here and in Example 10.8.1, which halved the delay.

The time delay is:

$$\Delta t = \frac{2 \times 2.95 \times 10^{15}}{2.998 \times 10^{8}} \times 1.3 \times 1.0103 \approx 2.59 \times 10^{7}\ \text{s} \approx 300\ \text{days}\,.$$

This is a realistic order of magnitude: observed time delays in galaxy-scale lens systems range from days to a year or so. Computed and verified in `time_delay_function.wl`.

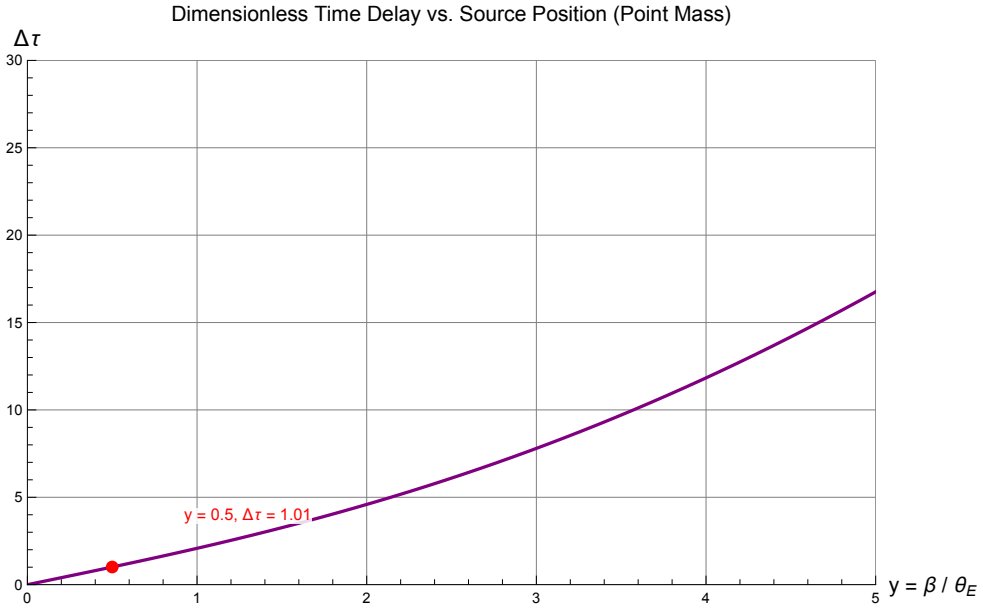


Figure 10.3: Dimensionless time delay $\Delta\tau$ between the two images of a point mass lens as a function of the source position $y = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$. The time delay increases with the source offset. For $y \to 0$ (Einstein ring limit), $\Delta\tau \to 0$ because the two images become symmetric. Generated by `time_delay_function.wl`.

10.9 Example: SIS Time Delay

As a preview for Chapter 11 (axially symmetric lens models), we state the time delay for the singular isothermal sphere (SIS). The SIS is characterized by its velocity dispersion σ_v, and its Einstein radius is $\theta_{\rm E} = 4\pi\,(\sigma_v/c)^2\,D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}$.

For a source inside the Einstein ring ($\beta < \theta_{\rm E}$), the SIS produces two images at positions $\theta_\pm = \beta \pm \theta_{\rm E}$ (both on the same side of the lens for θ_+, opposite for θ_-). The lensing potential is $\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \theta_{\rm E}\,|\boldsymbol{\theta}|$, and the time delay between the two images is:

$$\boxed{\Delta t_{\rm SIS} = \frac{(1+z_d)}{c}\,\frac{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm ds}}\,\frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{2}\left(\frac{\theta_+^2 - \theta_-^2}{\theta_{\rm E}^2}\right) = \frac{(1+z_d)}{2c}\,\frac{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm ds}}\,\left(\theta_+^2 - \theta_-^2\right)} \tag{10.22}$$

Since $\theta_+^2 - \theta_-^2 = (\theta_+ + \theta_-)(\theta_+ - \theta_-) = 2\beta \cdot 2\theta_{\rm E} = 4\beta\,\theta_{\rm E}$, this simplifies to:

$$\Delta t_{\rm SIS} = \frac{2(1+z_d)}{c}\,\frac{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm ds}}\,\beta\,\theta_{\rm E}\,. \tag{10.23}$$

For the SIS the time delay is proportional to the source position: the farther the source from the optical axis, the larger the time delay. This relation makes the SIS a useful first approximation for time-delay estimates.

10.10 Summary

The time delay function $t(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \propto \tau(\boldsymbol{\theta}, \boldsymbol{\beta})$ gives the arrival time of a photon passing through the lens plane at $\boldsymbol{\theta}$. The Fermat potential $\tau = \frac{1}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\beta}|^2 - \psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ combines the geometric delay (extra path length) and the Shapiro delay (gravitational time delay from the lensing potential). Fermat's principle states that images form at stationary points of $\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta})$; the condition $\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}\tau = 0$ recovers the lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \nabla\psi = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}$. Images are classified by Morse theory: Type I (minimum, positive parity, arrives first), Type II (saddle, negative parity), Type III (maximum, positive parity, arrives last). Burke's theorem states that the number of images is always odd for a transparent lens. The arrival-time surface $\tau(\theta_1, \theta_2)$ visualizes the image-forming process; for a point mass lens it has a minimum and a saddle point (plus a singular maximum at the lens center).

The time delay between images $\Delta t_{ij} \propto (1 + z_d)\, D_{\rm d} D_{\rm s}/D_{\rm ds} \times [\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta}_i) - \tau(\boldsymbol{\theta}_j)]$ is directly observable by monitoring variable sources, and $\Delta t \propto H_0^{-1}$: measuring time delays and modeling the lens potential gives H_0 independently of the distance ladder. This is time-delay cosmography, implemented by programs such as H0LiCOW/TDCOSMO. For a point mass lens the dimensionless time delay is $\Delta\tau = y\sqrt{y^2+4}/2 + \ln[(\sqrt{y^2+4}+y)/(\sqrt{y^2+4}-y)]$, where $y = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$, and the physical time delay for a galaxy-mass lens is of order days to a year or so. For the SIS, $\Delta t_{\rm SIS} \propto \beta\,\theta_{\rm E}$, a linear dependence on the source position.

10.11 Problems

Exercise 10.11.1. (Deriving the lens equation from Fermat's principle.) Starting from the Fermat potential $\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = \frac{1}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\beta}|^2 - \psi(\boldsymbol{\theta})$:

(a) Compute the gradient $\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}\,\tau$.

(b) Set $\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}\,\tau = 0$ and show that this gives the lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \nabla\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$.

(c) Explain physically why images form at stationary points of the arrival time.

Verify with `problems_06.wl`.

Exercise 10.11.2. (Arrival times for a point mass lens.) Consider a point mass lens with Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$ and a source at $\beta = 0.5\,\theta_{\rm E}$.

(a) Find the two image positions θ_+ and θ_-.

(b) Compute the Fermat potential τ at each image position using $\tau(x) = \frac{1}{2}(x - y)^2 - \ln|x|$ with $y = 0.5$, where $x = \theta/\theta_{\rm E}$.

(c) Compute the dimensionless time delay $\Delta\tau = \tau(x_-) - \tau(x_+)$.

(d) For a lens mass $M = 10^{12}\,M_\odot$ at $z_d = 0.3$, compute the physical time delay Δt in days.

Verify with `problems_06.wl`.

Exercise 10.11.3. (Type I image arrives first.) For a point mass lens with source at $\beta > 0$:

(a) Show that $\tau(\theta_+) < \tau(\theta_-)$, i.e., the minimum-image (Type I) has a smaller value of τ than the saddle-image (Type II).

(b) Verify this by computing $\tau(\theta_\pm)$ for $\beta = 0.1, 0.5, 1.0, 2.0$ (in units of θ_E) and checking that $\tau(\theta_+) < \tau(\theta_-)$ in all cases.

(c) Explain why this implies the Type I image arrives *before* the Type II image.

Verify with `problems_06.wl`.

Exercise 10.11.4. (Measuring H_0 from time delays.) A multiply-imaged quasar has a measured time delay $\Delta t = 100$ days between two images. The lens model gives a dimensionless Fermat potential difference of $\tau_1 - \tau_2 = 2.0$ arcsec^2. The lens is at $z_d = 0.3$ and the source is at $z_s = 1.0$.

(a) Using the relation $\Delta t = (1 + z_d)/c \times D_\mathrm{d} D_\mathrm{s}/D_\mathrm{ds} \times (\tau_1 - \tau_2)$, solve for $D_\mathrm{d} D_\mathrm{s}/D_\mathrm{ds}$.

(b) For a flat ΛCDM cosmology with $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$, show that $D_\mathrm{d} D_\mathrm{s}/D_\mathrm{ds} \propto 1/H_0$ and compute the proportionality constant (hint: use the dimensionless distance ratios from Chapter 7).

(c) Determine H_0 in km s^{-1} Mpc^{-1}. Compare with the H0LiCOW result and the Planck value.

This is a simplified version of the analysis performed in real time-delay cosmography. Verify with `problems_06.wl`.

Exercise 10.11.5. (Plotting the arrival-time surface.) Using Mathematica (or your preferred software):

(a) Plot the arrival-time surface $\tau(\theta_1, \theta_2)$ for a point mass lens with source at $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.3, 0)\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$. Use $\theta_\mathrm{E} = 1$.

(b) Identify the two stationary points on the surface. Label them as "minimum" and "saddle."

(c) Make a contour plot of τ and overlay the critical curve (the Einstein ring $|\boldsymbol{\theta}| = \theta_\mathrm{E}$).

(d) Verify that the stationary points agree with the analytical image positions $\theta_\pm$ from the lens equation.

See `arrival_time_surface.nb` and `problems_06.wl`.

Part III

Lens Models and Applications

Chapter 11

Axisymmetric Lens Models

> *In the special case of a circularly symmetric lens, we can shift the coordinate origin to the center of symmetry and reduce light deflection to a one-dimensional problem.* — Narayan & Bartelmann (1997), Sect. 2.1.2

In Chapters 8 and 9 we developed the general framework of gravitational lensing: the lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, the convergence κ, the shear γ, and the magnification $\mu = 1/[(1-\kappa)^2 - |\gamma|^2]$. We applied these to the point mass lens and briefly previewed the singular isothermal sphere (SIS).

We now turn from formalism to *modeling*. Real gravitational lenses, galaxies and galaxy clusters, have extended mass distributions, and to interpret observations one needs specific, physically motivated models. This chapter treats the circularly symmetric (axisymmetric) lens models in most common use: the point mass (recalled from Chapter 8), the singular isothermal sphere (SIS), the nonsingular isothermal sphere (NIS), and the Navarro–Frenk–White (NFW) profile. These models are the building blocks for the non-circular lens models of Chapter 12 and for the lens modeling applications of Chapters 13–14.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `axisymmetric_models.wl` contains the symbolic derivation of the SIS, NIS, and NFW lensing quantities, numerical examples with realistic parameters, and the comparison figures exported to `Figures/07_Axisymmetric_Models/`.
- `sis_nis_nfw.nb` is an interactive notebook with `Manipulate` widgets for the SIS, NIS, and NFW models, in which the velocity dispersion, core radius, concentration, and source position can be varied.

11.1 Introduction: From Formalism to Models

The general formalism of Chapter 9 provides the machinery for computing lensing observables, but to apply it one must specify a mass distribution. In practice the choice of mass model is guided by the physics of the lens. Stars and compact objects are described by a point mass (§11.3). In elliptical galaxies the combined stellar and dark matter mass distribution is approximately isothermal, with $\rho \propto r^{-2}$ (§11.4–11.5). For dark matter haloes, N-body

simulations show that the radial density profile is well described by the universal NFW profile (§11.6).

In this chapter we restrict ourselves to circularly symmetric models, for which all lensing quantities depend only on the angular radius $\theta = |\boldsymbol{\theta}|$. This restriction allows analytic progress and prepares the ground for the elliptical models of Chapter 12.

11.2 General Formalism for Circularly Symmetric Lenses

For a lens with circular symmetry about the optical axis, the surface mass density Σ, the convergence κ, the deflection angle $\boldsymbol{\alpha}$, and the shear γ all depend only on the angular radius $\theta = |\boldsymbol{\theta}|$. The vector deflection is purely radial:

$$\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \alpha(\theta)\,\frac{\boldsymbol{\theta}}{\theta}\,, \tag{11.1}$$

and the lens equation reduces to a single dimension (Narayan & Bartelmann eq. 14):

$$\boxed{\beta = \theta - \alpha(\theta)} \tag{11.2}$$

where $\beta = |\boldsymbol{\beta}|$ (by symmetry, source and image are collinear with the lens center).

11.2.1 Deflection Angle from Enclosed Mass

For a circularly symmetric mass distribution, the deflection angle at radius θ depends only on the mass enclosed within that radius (just as in Newtonian gravity, by the circular analog of Newton's shell theorem). The projected mass within angular radius θ is:

$$M(\theta) = 2\pi \int_0^{D_\mathrm{d}\,\theta} \Sigma(\xi)\,\xi\,d\xi = 2\pi D_\mathrm{d}^2 \int_0^{\theta} \Sigma(D_\mathrm{d}\,\theta')\,\theta'\,d\theta'\,, \tag{11.3}$$

and the reduced deflection angle is (Congdon & Keeton Sec. 2.2.1):

$$\boxed{\alpha(\theta) = \frac{M(\theta)}{\pi\,\Sigma_\mathrm{cr}\,D_\mathrm{d}^2\,\theta}} \tag{11.4}$$

11.2.2 Mean Convergence

It is useful to define the *mean convergence* within radius θ:

$$\bar{\kappa}(\theta) = \frac{1}{\pi\theta^2}\int_0^{\theta} \kappa(\theta')\,2\pi\theta'\,d\theta' = \frac{2}{\theta^2}\int_0^{\theta} \kappa(\theta')\,\theta'\,d\theta'\,. \tag{11.5}$$

Since $M(\theta) = \pi D_\mathrm{d}^2 \Sigma_\mathrm{cr}\,\theta^2\,\bar{\kappa}(\theta)$, the deflection angle (11.4) can be written as:

$$\alpha(\theta) = \bar{\kappa}(\theta)\,\theta\,. \tag{11.6}$$

11.2.3 Shear for Circular Symmetry

For a circularly symmetric lens, the shear magnitude takes a simple form (cf. Narayan & Bartelmann Sec. 3.4):

$$\boxed{|\gamma(\theta)| = \bar{\kappa}(\theta) - \kappa(\theta)} \tag{11.7}$$

The shear is the difference between the mean convergence inside θ and the local convergence at θ: it arises from the differential focusing between interior and exterior mass.

11.2.4 Magnification for Circular Symmetry

From Chapter 8 (eq. 8.31), the magnification of a circularly symmetric lens is:

$$\mu = \frac{\theta}{\beta}\frac{d\theta}{d\beta} = \frac{1}{\left(1 - \frac{\alpha}{\theta}\right)\left(1 - \frac{d\alpha}{d\theta}\right)}\,. \tag{11.8}$$

The two factors correspond to the tangential and radial eigenvalues of the Jacobian:

$$\lambda_t = 1 - \frac{\alpha(\theta)}{\theta} = 1 - \bar{\kappa}(\theta)\,, \qquad \lambda_r = 1 - \frac{d\alpha}{d\theta} = 1 - 2\kappa(\theta) + \bar{\kappa}(\theta)\,. \tag{11.9}$$

The *tangential critical curve* occurs where $\lambda_t = 0$ (i.e., $\bar{\kappa} = 1$), and the *radial critical curve* occurs where $\lambda_r = 0$ (i.e., $2\kappa = 1 + \bar{\kappa}$).

11.3 Point Mass Lens (Recap)

We briefly collect the point mass results from Chapters 8 and 9 for comparison with the extended models.

For a point mass M at the origin:

$$\Sigma(\theta) = M\,\delta^{(2)}(D_{\rm d}\,\boldsymbol{\theta})/D_{\rm d}^2\,, \qquad \kappa(\theta) = 0 \quad (\theta \neq 0)\,, \tag{11.10}$$

$$\alpha(\theta) = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\theta}\,, \tag{11.11}$$

$$|\gamma(\theta)| = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\theta^2} = \bar{\kappa}(\theta)\,, \tag{11.12}$$

where $\theta_{\rm E} = \sqrt{4GMD_{\rm ds}/(c^2 D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm s})}$ is the Einstein radius (eq. 8.17).

The lens equation $\beta = \theta - \theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta$ yields two images at $\theta_\pm = (\beta \pm \sqrt{\beta^2 + 4\theta_{\rm E}^2})/2$, with magnifications

$$\mu_\pm = \frac{u^2 + 2}{2u\sqrt{u^2 + 4}} \pm \frac{1}{2}\,, \qquad u = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}\,. \tag{11.13}$$

Remark 11.3.1. The point mass has no radial critical curve (the convergence is a delta function, so $\lambda_r = 1 + \bar{\kappa} > 0$ everywhere away from the origin). It has only a tangential critical curve at $\theta = \theta_{\rm E}$ (the Einstein ring), whose corresponding caustic is the degenerate point $\beta = 0$.

11.4 Singular Isothermal Sphere (SIS)

The *singular isothermal sphere* is the simplest realistic model for a galaxy lens. It describes a self-gravitating system of particles with a Maxwellian velocity distribution and one-dimensional velocity dispersion σ_v. Despite its simplicity, the SIS reproduces many of the features of observed galaxy lenses.

11.4.1 Three-Dimensional Density Profile

The SIS density profile is (Congdon & Keeton eq. 2.42):

$$\boxed{\rho(r) = \frac{\sigma_v^2}{2\pi G\, r^2}} \tag{11.14}$$

where r is the three-dimensional (spherical) radius and σ_v is the one-dimensional velocity dispersion. This profile is "isothermal" because it corresponds to a self-gravitating gas at constant temperature $T \propto \sigma_v^2$, and "singular" because $\rho \to \infty$ as $r \to 0$.

Remark 11.4.1. The $\rho \propto r^{-2}$ profile gives a flat rotation curve: $v_c(r) = \sqrt{2}\,\sigma_v = \text{const}$. This is consistent with observations of spiral galaxies, which show approximately flat rotation curves out to large radii. For elliptical galaxies, the velocity dispersion σ_v plays the analogous role.

11.4.2 Surface Mass Density

Projecting along the line of sight (taking ξ as the impact parameter in the lens plane):

$$\Sigma(\xi) = \int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} \rho\Big(\sqrt{\xi^2 + z^2}\Big)\, dz = \frac{\sigma_v^2}{2G\,\xi}\,. \tag{11.15}$$

The surface mass density diverges as $\xi \to 0$ and falls off as ξ^{-1}.

11.4.3 Einstein Radius of the SIS

The physical deflection angle of the SIS is its most characteristic property. The enclosed projected mass $M_{2\mathrm{D}}(\xi) = \pi\sigma_v^2\xi/G$ follows from the SIS surface density $\Sigma(\xi) = \sigma_v^2/(2G\xi)$ by a one-line integral,

$$M_{2\mathrm{D}}(\xi) \;=\; 2\pi\int_0^{\xi} \Sigma(\xi')\,\xi'\,d\xi' \;=\; 2\pi\cdot\frac{\sigma_v^2}{2G}\int_0^{\xi} d\xi' \;=\; \frac{\pi\sigma_v^2\xi}{G}\,,$$

and $\Sigma(\xi)$ itself follows from $\int_{-\infty}^{\infty}(\sigma_v^2/(2\pi G))/(\xi^2+z^2)\,dz = \sigma_v^2/(2G\xi)$. Substituting into the axisymmetric deflection formula (eq. 5.18 from Chapter 8):

$$\boxed{\hat{\alpha} = \frac{4\pi\sigma_v^2}{c^2}} \tag{11.16}$$

This is constant, independent of the impact parameter: every light ray is deflected by the same angle, regardless of how close it passes to the lens center. The reason is that the SIS has $\rho \propto r^{-2}$, so the projected (surface) mass enclosed within a cylinder of radius ξ grows linearly, $M(\xi) = \pi\sigma_v^2\xi/G \propto \xi$ (eq. 11.3 and Exercise 11.9.1). Since the deflection angle is $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM(\xi)/(c^2\,\xi)$, the ξ in numerator and denominator cancel exactly, leaving $\hat{\alpha}$ independent of ξ. The $\rho \propto r^{-2}$ profile is the unique power law for which this cancellation occurs; any steeper or shallower profile gives a deflection that varies with impact parameter. For the same reason the velocity dispersion σ_v, rather than a mass scale, is the natural parameter of the SIS (Congdon & Keeton Sec. 6.1; Narayan & Bartelmann Sec. 3.4; verified in `axisymmetric_models.wl`).

The reduced deflection angle is:

$$\alpha = \frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}}\,\hat{\alpha} = \frac{4\pi\sigma_v^2}{c^2}\,\frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}} = \theta_{\rm E}\,, \tag{11.17}$$

where the Einstein radius of the SIS is:

$$\boxed{\theta_{\rm E} = 4\pi\left(\frac{\sigma_v}{c}\right)^2\frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}}} \tag{11.18}$$

Example 11.4.1. SIS Einstein radius for a typical galaxy lens. For $\sigma_v = 250$ km s^{-1}, $z_d = 0.3$, $z_s = 1$ ($D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s} \approx 1055/1652 \approx 0.638$):

$$\theta_{\rm E} = 4\pi\left(\frac{250\times10^3}{3\times10^8}\right)^2 \times 0.638 \approx 5.6\times10^{-6}\ \text{rad} \approx 1.15''\,. \tag{11.19}$$

This is typical of galaxy-scale strong lenses. The value is computed and verified in `axisymmetric_models.wl`.

11.4.4 Convergence and Shear of the SIS

The convergence is (previewed in Chapter 9, eq. 9.37):

$$\kappa(\theta) = \frac{\Sigma(D_{\rm d}\,\theta)}{\Sigma_{\rm cr}} = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{2\theta}\,. \tag{11.20}$$

The mean convergence within θ is:

$$\bar{\kappa}(\theta) = \frac{2}{\theta^2}\int_0^\theta \frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{2\theta'}\,\theta'\,d\theta' = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta}\,. \tag{11.21}$$

The shear magnitude is (from eq. 11.7):

$$\boxed{|\gamma(\theta)| = \bar{\kappa} - \kappa = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta} - \frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{2\theta} = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{2\theta} = \kappa(\theta)} \tag{11.22}$$

Remark 11.4.2. The equality $|\gamma| = \kappa$ at every point is a special property of the SIS. It does *not* hold for general lens models. For the point mass, $\kappa = 0$ (away from the origin) while $|\gamma| = \theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta^2 \neq 0$. For the NIS and NFW models below, $|\gamma| \neq \kappa$ in general.

11.4.5 SIS Lens Equation and Images

Take θ as a signed coordinate along the line through the lens and the source ($\beta \geq 0$; $\theta > 0$ on the source's side). The SIS deflection has constant magnitude $\theta_{\rm E}$ and points along $\theta/|\theta|$, so the 1D lens equation is

$$\beta = \theta - \theta_{\rm E} \frac{\theta}{|\theta|} \,. \tag{11.23}$$

This is *piecewise linear* in θ (unlike the point mass lens equation, which is quadratic). The analysis depends on whether the source lies inside or outside the Einstein radius:

Case 1: $\beta < \theta_{\rm E}$ (source inside the caustic). There are two images:

$$\theta_+ = \beta + \theta_{\rm E} \,, \qquad \theta_- = -(\theta_{\rm E} - \beta) = \beta - \theta_{\rm E} \,, \tag{11.24}$$

where $\theta_- < 0$ indicates the image is on the opposite side of the lens from the source. (For $\theta > 0$, eq. (11.23) reads $\beta = \theta - \theta_{\rm E}$, giving θ_+; for $\theta < 0$ it reads $\beta = \theta + \theta_{\rm E}$, giving θ_-, which is indeed negative when $\beta < \theta_{\rm E}$.)

Case 2: $\beta > \theta_{\rm E}$ (source outside the caustic). There is only one image:

$$\theta = \beta + \theta_{\rm E} \,. \tag{11.25}$$

The $\theta < 0$ branch would give $\theta = \beta - \theta_{\rm E} > 0$, which contradicts $\theta < 0$, so there is no second image.

Case 3: $\beta = 0$ (source on the optical axis). The image is a complete Einstein ring at $\theta = \theta_{\rm E}$.

11.4.6 SIS Magnification

The magnification of the SIS images is:

$$\mu_\pm = \frac{\theta_\pm}{\beta} \frac{d\theta}{d\beta} = \frac{\theta_\pm}{\beta} = 1 \pm \frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\beta} \,, \tag{11.26}$$

where we used $d\theta/d\beta = 1$ (the SIS lens equation is linear). The total magnification for a doubly-imaged source ($\beta < \theta_{\rm E}$) is:

$$|\mu_+| + |\mu_-| = \left(1 + \frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\beta}\right) + \left(\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\beta} - 1\right) = \frac{2\theta_{\rm E}}{\beta} \,. \tag{11.27}$$

11.4.7 Critical Curves and Caustics of the SIS

The critical curve structure of the SIS is simple. The tangential critical curve, $\lambda_t = 0$, requires $\bar{\kappa}(\theta) = 1$, i.e., $\theta_{\rm E}/\theta = 1$, giving $\theta_{\rm crit} = \theta_{\rm E}$: the critical curve is the Einstein ring. Mapping it to the source plane gives the tangential caustic, $\beta = \theta_{\rm E} - \theta_{\rm E} = 0$, which degenerates to a

single point at the origin. A radial critical curve, $\lambda_r = 0$, would require $2\kappa = 1 + \bar{\kappa}$; for the SIS, $2\kappa = \theta_{\rm E}/\theta$ and $1 + \bar{\kappa} = 1 + \theta_{\rm E}/\theta$, so the condition becomes $\theta_{\rm E}/\theta = 1 + \theta_{\rm E}/\theta$, i.e., $0 = 1$. There is therefore no radial critical curve for the SIS; the singularity at the center prevents its formation.

Remark 11.4.3. The absence of a radial critical curve is a consequence of the central singularity. As we will see in Section 11.5, introducing a finite core radius (NIS) creates a radial critical curve and changes the image configuration.

11.5 Nonsingular Isothermal Sphere (NIS)

The SIS has an unphysical singularity at $r = 0$: the density and surface mass density diverge. A more realistic model introduces a finite *core radius* θ_c that softens the central density cusp.

11.5.1 Surface Mass Density

The NIS surface mass density is (Congdon & Keeton Sec. 2.3.3):

$$\boxed{\Sigma(\theta) = \frac{\sigma_v^2}{2G\, D_{\rm d}\, \sqrt{\theta^2 + \theta_c^2}}} \tag{11.28}$$

where θ_c is the angular core radius. For $\theta \gg \theta_c$, $\Sigma \to \sigma_v^2/(2G\, D_{\rm d}\, \theta)$, recovering the SIS. For $\theta \to 0$, $\Sigma(0) = \sigma_v^2/(2G\, D_{\rm d}\, \theta_c)$ is finite. This is the projection of the 3D density (Congdon & Keeton eq. 2.53)

$$\rho(r) = \frac{\sigma_v^2}{2\pi G\, (r^2 + r_c^2)}\,, \tag{11.29}$$

with physical core radius $r_c = D_{\rm d}\, \theta_c$: since $\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} dz/(\xi^2 + r_c^2 + z^2) = \pi/\sqrt{\xi^2 + r_c^2}$, integrating along the line of sight at $\xi = D_{\rm d}\theta$ gives eq. (11.28).

11.5.2 Convergence of the NIS

$$\kappa(\theta) = \frac{\Sigma(\theta)}{\Sigma_{\rm cr}} = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{2\sqrt{\theta^2 + \theta_c^2}} \tag{11.30}$$

where $\theta_{\rm E}$ is the SIS Einstein radius (eq. 11.18). The central convergence is:

$$\kappa(0) = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{2\theta_c}\,. \tag{11.31}$$

For strong lensing to occur, we need $\kappa(0) > 1$, requiring $\theta_c < \theta_{\rm E}/2$.

11.5.3 Deflection Angle of the NIS

The axisymmetric formula $\alpha(\theta) = (2/\theta)\int_0^\theta \kappa(\theta')\,\theta'\,d\theta'$ reduces to an elementary integral once we substitute eq. (11.30):

$$\alpha(\theta) \;=\; \frac{2}{\theta}\int_0^\theta \frac{\theta_\mathrm{E}}{2\sqrt{\theta'^2+\theta_c^2}}\,\theta'\,d\theta' \;=\; \frac{\theta_\mathrm{E}}{\theta}\Big[\sqrt{\theta'^2+\theta_c^2}\Big]_0^\theta,$$

where the antiderivative follows from $d/d\theta'\sqrt{\theta'^2+\theta_c^2} = \theta'/\sqrt{\theta'^2+\theta_c^2}$. Evaluating the limits,

$$\alpha(\theta) = \theta_\mathrm{E}\,\frac{\sqrt{\theta^2+\theta_c^2}-\theta_c}{\theta}\,. \tag{11.32}$$

In the limit $\theta_c \to 0$:

$$\alpha(\theta) \;\to\; \theta_\mathrm{E}\,\frac{\theta-0}{\theta} \;=\; \theta_\mathrm{E}\,, \tag{11.33}$$

recovering the constant SIS deflection angle. The integral and the SIS limit are checked symbolically in `axisymmetric_models.wl`.

11.5.4 Effect of the Core Radius on Image Multiplicity

The NIS lens equation is:

$$\beta = \theta - \theta_\mathrm{E}\,\frac{\sqrt{\theta^2+\theta_c^2}-\theta_c}{\theta}\,. \tag{11.34}$$

The core radius controls the critical curve structure. For $\theta_c < \theta_\mathrm{E}/2$ (a supercritical core) the central convergence exceeds unity, and there exist both a tangential and a radial critical curve; a source near the center can then produce three images, compared with two for the SIS. For $\theta_c = \theta_\mathrm{E}/2$ the central convergence is exactly unity and the radial critical curve contracts to a point at the center. For $\theta_c > \theta_\mathrm{E}/2$ (a subcritical core), $\kappa < 1$ everywhere, and the lens cannot produce multiple images; there is only a single image for any source position.

The radial critical curve of the NIS creates a *radial caustic* in the source plane: a circle of radius $\beta_r > 0$. Because the tangential caustic of an axisymmetric lens is the single point $\beta = 0$, the image count depends only on $|\beta|$: sources with $0 < |\beta| < \beta_r$ produce three images, sources with $|\beta| > \beta_r$ produce one, and a source at $\beta = 0$ produces an Einstein ring plus a central image.[1]

Remark 11.5.1. The transition from SIS to NIS illustrates a general principle: the *central density profile* of a lens model determines whether a radial critical curve (and hence a third image) can form. Observed lens systems rarely show a detectable central (third) image, which constrains the core radius to be very small or zero and so supports cuspy density profiles.

[1] An earlier version said that sources *between* the radial and tangential caustics produce one image. For the NIS the tangential caustic is the point $\beta = 0$, inside the radial caustic, so that region is the three-image region; one image forms outside β_r (e.g. for $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$, $\beta_r = 0.427\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$).

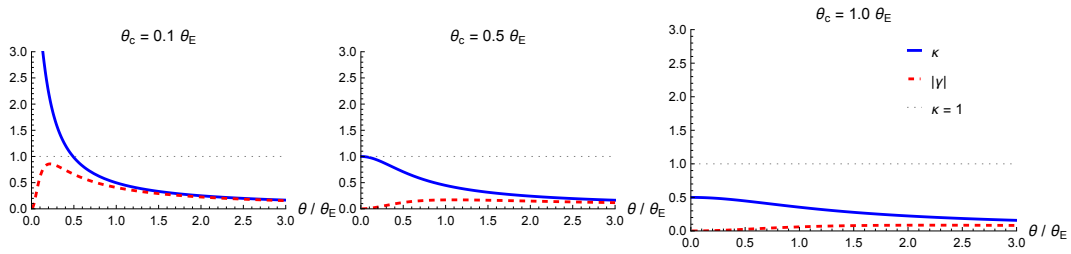


Figure 11.1: Effect of the core radius on the NIS convergence and shear, shown for three regimes that control the critical-curve topology. **Left:** for $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E} < \theta_{\rm E}/2$, the central convergence $\kappa(0) > 1$, so both tangential and radial critical curves exist and three images can form. **Center:** at the critical value $\theta_c = 0.5\,\theta_{\rm E} = \theta_{\rm E}/2$, $\kappa(0) = 1$ exactly and the radial critical curve collapses to a point. **Right:** for $\theta_c = 1.0\,\theta_{\rm E} > \theta_{\rm E}/2$, $\kappa(0) < 1$ everywhere; no critical curves exist and only one image forms. Generated by `axisymmetric_models.wl`.

11.6 NFW Profile

The *Navarro–Frenk–White* (NFW) profile is the "universal" dark matter halo density profile found in cosmological N-body simulations (Navarro, Frenk & White 1996, 1997). It is the standard model for the mass distribution of galaxy clusters and underlies the treatment of cluster lensing in Chapter 14.

11.6.1 Three-Dimensional Density Profile

$$\boxed{\rho(r) = \frac{\rho_s}{\left(\dfrac{r}{r_s}\right)\left(1 + \dfrac{r}{r_s}\right)^2}} \tag{11.35}$$

where r_s is the *scale radius* and ρ_s is a characteristic density. The profile has two regimes: for $r \ll r_s$, $\rho \propto r^{-1}$, a cusp shallower than isothermal, and for $r \gg r_s$, $\rho \propto r^{-3}$, steeper than isothermal, so that the total mass within a virial radius is finite.

11.6.2 NFW Parameters: Concentration and Virial Mass

The NFW profile is usually parametrized by two quantities. The *virial mass* M_{200} is the mass enclosed within the virial radius r_{200}, defined as the radius within which the mean density is 200 times the critical density of the universe. The *concentration parameter* $c = r_{200}/r_s$ is the ratio of virial to scale radius; typical values are $c \sim 5$ for massive clusters ($M_{200} \sim 10^{15}\,M_\odot$) and $c \sim 10$ for galaxy-mass haloes ($M_{200} \sim 10^{12}\,M_\odot$) [43, Part 2, p. 128].

The characteristic density is related to c by:

$$\rho_s = \frac{200}{3}\,\rho_{\rm crit}\,\frac{c^3}{\ln(1+c) - c/(1+c)}\,. \tag{11.36}$$

11.6.3 Surface Mass Density of the NFW

The line-of-sight projection of the NFW density gives the surface mass density

$$\Sigma(\xi) \;=\; \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \rho\Big(\sqrt{\xi^2+z^2}\Big)\, dz\,, \tag{11.37}$$

where ξ is the physical impact parameter in the lens plane and z is the line-of-sight coordinate. We now evaluate this integral explicitly; the computation separates into three steps and is the first place where the NFW branch structure (arccosh vs. arctan) appears. The full derivation is verified symbolically in `nfw_projection.wl`.

Step 1: dimensionless variables. Let $x = \xi/r_s$ and $u = z/r_s$, so that $r/r_s = \sqrt{x^2+u^2}$ and $dz = r_s\, du$. The NFW density (eq. 11.35) becomes

$$\rho = \frac{\rho_s}{\sqrt{x^2+u^2}\,\big(1+\sqrt{x^2+u^2}\big)^2}\,.$$

Using the symmetry $z \leftrightarrow -z$,

$$\Sigma(\xi) \;=\; 2\,\rho_s\, r_s\, I(x)\,, \qquad I(x) = \int_0^{\infty} \frac{du}{\sqrt{x^2+u^2}\,\big(1+\sqrt{x^2+u^2}\big)^2}\,. \tag{11.38}$$

Step 2: change of variable $w = \sqrt{x^2+u^2}$. Then $u\,du = w\,dw$ and $du = w\,dw/\sqrt{w^2-x^2}$. The limits $u\!:0\to\infty$ map to $w\!:x\to\infty$, and

$$I(x) \;=\; \int_x^{\infty} \frac{dw}{(1+w)^2\,\sqrt{w^2-x^2}}\,. \tag{11.39}$$

Step 3: reduce to a simpler integral. A short calculation gives the identity

$$\frac{d}{dw}\left[\frac{\sqrt{w^2-x^2}}{1+w}\right] \;=\; \frac{w+x^2}{(1+w)^2\sqrt{w^2-x^2}}\,. \tag{11.40}$$

Writing $w + x^2 = (1+w) + (x^2-1)$ splits the right side into a piece involving one power of $(1+w)$ in the denominator and the target integrand $\big[(1+w)^2\sqrt{w^2-x^2}\big]^{-1}$ multiplied by (x^2-1). Integrating eq. (11.40) from $w = x$ to $w = \infty$ and using $\sqrt{w^2-x^2}/(1+w) \to 1$ at infinity and 0 at $w = x$:

$$1 \;=\; K(x) \;+\; (x^2-1)\, I(x)\,, \qquad K(x) \equiv \int_x^{\infty} \frac{dw}{(1+w)\sqrt{w^2-x^2}}\,, \tag{11.41}$$

so

$$I(x) \;=\; \frac{1-K(x)}{x^2-1}\,. \tag{11.42}$$

Step 4: evaluate $K(x)$. The substitution $w = x\cosh\tau$ (with $\sqrt{w^2-x^2} = x\sinh\tau$, $dw = x\sinh\tau\, d\tau$) turns K into

$$K(x) \;=\; \int_0^\infty \frac{d\tau}{1 + x\cosh\tau}\,, \tag{11.43}$$

which is elementary. Using the Weierstrass half-angle substitution $t = \tanh(\tau/2)$ and the standard result $\int_0^1 2\,dt/(a - b\,t^2) = (2/\sqrt{ab})\,\operatorname{arctanh}\sqrt{b/a}$ (and its arctan analog when the signs flip), one finds

$$\boxed{K(x) = \begin{cases} \dfrac{\operatorname{arccosh}(1/x)}{\sqrt{1-x^2}}, & 0 < x < 1, \\ 1, & x = 1, \\ \dfrac{\arctan\sqrt{x^2-1}}{\sqrt{x^2-1}}, & x > 1. \end{cases}} \tag{11.44}$$

The two branches are related by the identity $\operatorname{arccosh}(1/x) \leftrightarrow \arccos(1/x)$ (analytic continuation through $x = 1$), and the $x = 1$ value follows from a Taylor expansion of either branch.

Collected result. Substituting eq. (11.44) into eq. (11.42), and then eq. (11.38),

$$\boxed{\Sigma(x) = 2\,\rho_s\, r_s\, f(x)\,, \qquad f(x) = \frac{1 - K(x)}{x^2 - 1}\,,} \tag{11.45}$$

where $x = \xi/r_s = \theta/\theta_s$ and $\theta_s = r_s/D_\mathrm{d}$. Writing out the three branches explicitly,

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} \dfrac{1}{x^2-1}\left(1 - \dfrac{\operatorname{arccosh}(1/x)}{\sqrt{1-x^2}}\right) & 0 < x < 1, \\ \dfrac{1}{3} & x = 1, \\ \dfrac{1}{x^2-1}\left(1 - \dfrac{\arctan\sqrt{x^2-1}}{\sqrt{x^2-1}}\right) & x > 1. \end{cases} \tag{11.46}$$

This recovers the standard result of Bartelmann [3] and Wright and Brainerd [51].

Remark 11.6.1. The apparent singularity at $x = 1$ in eq. (11.46) cancels between numerator and denominator. A Taylor expansion of $1 - K(x)$ about $x = 1$ (for either branch) gives $1 - K(x) = \frac{1}{3}(x^2-1) + \mathcal{O}((x^2-1)^2)$, leaving $f(1) = 1/3$, a smooth function of x.

11.6.4 Convergence of the NFW

Dividing eq. (11.45) by the critical surface density,

$$\boxed{\kappa(x) \;=\; \frac{\Sigma(x)}{\Sigma_\mathrm{cr}} \;=\; \frac{2\,\rho_s\, r_s}{\Sigma_\mathrm{cr}}\, f(x) \;\equiv\; \kappa_s\, f(x)\,, \qquad \kappa_s \equiv \frac{2\rho_s r_s}{\Sigma_\mathrm{cr}}.} \tag{11.47}$$

The characteristic convergence κ_s collects every dimensionful quantity from the density profile and the distance configuration, leaving $f(x)$ purely dimensionless.

Remark 11.6.2. Unlike the SIS (where $\kappa \propto \theta^{-1}$), the NFW convergence has a *logarithmic* divergence as $x \to 0$. This follows from the small-x expansion of eq. (11.44), $\operatorname{arccosh}(1/x) = \ln(2/x) + \mathcal{O}(x^2)$, which gives $K(x) \to \ln(2/x)$ and hence $f(x) \sim \ln(2/x)$ as $x \to 0$. The NFW cusp ($\rho \propto r^{-1}$) is shallower than the isothermal cusp ($\rho \propto r^{-2}$), which has consequences for central image formation.

11.6.5 Deflection Angle and Shear of the NFW

For any axisymmetric profile, the reduced deflection angle satisfies eqs. (11.5) and (11.6),

$$\alpha(\theta) \;=\; \theta\,\bar{\kappa}(\theta)\,, \qquad \bar{\kappa}(\theta) = \frac{2}{\theta^2}\int_0^{\theta} \kappa(\theta')\,\theta'\,d\theta'. \tag{11.48}$$

Switching to $x = \theta/\theta_s$ and using $\kappa = \kappa_s f(x)$ (eq. 11.47) turns the integral into

$$\bar{\kappa}(x) = \frac{2\kappa_s}{x^2}\,h(x)\,, \qquad h(x) \equiv \int_0^{x} f(x')\,x'\,dx'. \tag{11.49}$$

Evaluation of $h(x)$. From eq. (11.42), $f(x) = [1 - K(x)]/(x^2-1)$, where $K(x)$ is given by eq. (11.44). A direct calculation shows

$$\frac{d}{dx}\Big[\ln\tfrac{x}{2} + K(x)\Big] \;=\; x\,f(x) \quad \text{for } 0 < x \neq 1, \tag{11.50}$$

and, using $\operatorname{arccosh}(1/x) = \ln(2/x) + \mathcal{O}(x^2)$ as $x \to 0$,

$$\lim_{x\to 0^+}\Big[\ln(x/2) + K(x)\Big] = 0\,.$$

Hence

$$h(x) \;=\; \ln\frac{x}{2} + g(x)\,, \qquad g(x) \equiv K(x), \tag{11.51}$$

with

$$g(x) = \begin{cases} \dfrac{\operatorname{arccosh}(1/x)}{\sqrt{1-x^2}}, & 0 < x < 1, \\[2mm] 1, & x = 1, \\[2mm] \dfrac{\arctan\sqrt{x^2-1}}{\sqrt{x^2-1}}, & x > 1. \end{cases} \tag{11.52}$$

Deflection angle and shear. Substituting eq. (11.51) into eqs. (11.48)–(11.49) and using $\theta = x\,\theta_s$:

$$\boxed{\alpha(x) = \frac{2\kappa_s\,\theta_s}{x}\left[\ln\frac{x}{2} + g(x)\right], \qquad \bar{\kappa}(x) = \frac{2\kappa_s}{x^2}\left[\ln\frac{x}{2} + g(x)\right].} \tag{11.53}$$

The tangential shear of any axisymmetric profile is $|\gamma(x)| = \bar{\kappa}(x) - \kappa(x)$ (cf. eq. 11.7):

$$|\gamma(x)| \;=\; \frac{2\kappa_s}{x^2}\left[\ln\frac{x}{2} + g(x)\right] \;-\; \kappa_s\,f(x)\,. \tag{11.54}$$

Every identity in this subsection (the antiderivative eq. (11.50), the $x \to 0$ limit, and the numerical consistency of eq. (11.53) with direct integration of κ) is verified symbolically and numerically in `nfw_projection.wl`.

11.6.6 Role of Concentration in NFW Lensing

The concentration parameter c has a strong effect on the lensing strength of an NFW halo. Higher c means more centrally concentrated mass, which raises the central convergence $\kappa(0)$ and makes strong lensing more likely. For a fixed virial mass, increasing c increases κ_s and decreases θ_s, concentrating the lensing signal in a smaller angular region. Typical galaxy clusters ($c \sim 4$–5) are strong lenses for background sources at $z_s \gtrsim 1$, producing giant arcs with radii of $\sim 10''$–$30''$. The NFW model is applied extensively to cluster lensing in Chapter 14.

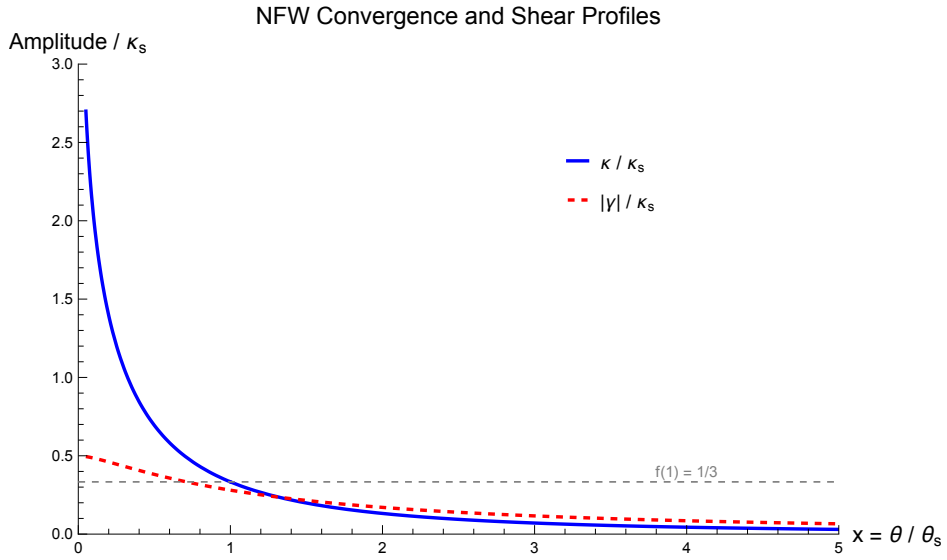


Figure 11.2: NFW convergence $\kappa(x)/\kappa_s = f(x)$ (solid) and shear $|\gamma(x)|/\kappa_s = \bar{\kappa}(x)/\kappa_s - f(x)$ (dashed) as functions of the dimensionless radius $x = \theta/\theta_s$. Both curves are normalized to κ_s and are universal functions of x (independent of concentration); the horizontal grey line marks $f(1) = 1/3$. The concentration c enters only through the overall scale κ_s and the angular scale θ_s, both of which absorb the dependence on c and on the cosmological distances. Generated by `axisymmetric_models.wl`.

11.7 Comparison of Models

Table 11.1 summarizes the properties of the four axisymmetric lens models treated in this chapter.

The qualitative differences between the models are as follows. The point mass and SIS have singular central densities, whereas the NIS and NFW have finite or logarithmically divergent central densities; the central density determines whether a radial critical curve can form. The point mass deflection $\alpha \propto 1/\theta$ diverges at the center and falls off with distance, the SIS deflection is constant, and the NIS and NFW deflections are intermediate. Models with a radial critical curve (NIS, NFW) can produce a third, central image, while the SIS and point mass produce at most two images. Finally, the SIS has $\Sigma \propto \theta^{-1}$ and infinite total mass, whereas the NFW has $\Sigma \propto \theta^{-2}$ (for $\theta \gg \theta_s$) and a well-defined virial mass.

Table 11.1: Comparison of axisymmetric lens models. Here θ is the angular radius from the lens center in units of the appropriate scale ($\theta_{\rm E}$ for point mass and SIS, θ_s for NFW).

Property	Point Mass	SIS	NIS	NFW
$\rho(r)$	$\delta^{(3)}$	$\propto r^{-2}$	$\propto (r^2+r_c^2)^{-1}$	eq. (11.35)
$\kappa(\theta)$	0 $(\theta \neq 0)$	$\theta_{\rm E}/2\theta$	$\theta_{\rm E}/2\sqrt{\theta^2+\theta_c^2}$	$\kappa_s\, f(x)$
$\alpha(\theta)$	$\theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta$	$\theta_{\rm E}$	eq. (11.32)	eq. (11.53)
$\kappa = \lvert\gamma\rvert$?	No $(\kappa = 0)$	Yes	No	No
Tangential CC	$\theta = \theta_{\rm E}$	$\theta = \theta_{\rm E}$	Yes	Yes
Radial CC	No	No	Yes $(\theta_c < \theta_{\rm E}/2)$	Yes
Max images	2	2	3	3
Caustic	Point	Point	Point + circle	Point + circle

11.8 Summary

For a circularly symmetric lens all quantities depend only on $\theta = |\boldsymbol{\theta}|$; the deflection angle is $\alpha(\theta) = \bar{\kappa}(\theta)\,\theta$, and the shear is $|\gamma| = \bar{\kappa} - \kappa$. The point mass lens has $\alpha = \theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta$, $\kappa = 0$ (away from origin), and always produces two images. The SIS has $\rho \propto r^{-2}$, a constant physical deflection angle $\hat{\alpha} = 4\pi\sigma_v^2/c^2$, Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E} = 4\pi(\sigma_v/c)^2\, D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}$, and $\kappa = |\gamma| = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta)$ everywhere. It produces two images for $\beta < \theta_{\rm E}$ and one image for $\beta > \theta_{\rm E}$, with magnifications $\mu_\pm = 1 \pm \theta_{\rm E}/\beta$; it has a tangential critical curve (the Einstein ring) but no radial critical curve.

The NIS introduces a core radius θ_c that removes the central singularity. For $\theta_c < \theta_{\rm E}/2$ a radial critical curve appears, which allows a third, central image; the NIS reduces to the SIS for $\theta_c \to 0$. The NFW profile $\rho = \rho_s/[(r/r_s)(1+r/r_s)^2]$ is the universal dark matter halo profile, parametrized by the virial mass M_{200} and concentration c; higher concentration increases the lensing strength. Models with finite central density (NIS, NFW) possess a radial critical curve and can produce three images, whereas the SIS and point mass cannot.

11.9 Problems

Exercise 11.9.1. (Derivation of the SIS deflection angle.) Starting from the SIS density profile $\rho(r) = \sigma_v^2/(2\pi G r^2)$:

(a) Compute the surface mass density $\Sigma(\xi) = \int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} \rho(\sqrt{\xi^2+z^2})\, dz$ and show that $\Sigma(\xi) = \sigma_v^2/(2G\,\xi)$. *Hint:* Use the substitution $z = \xi \tan\phi$.

(b) Compute the projected enclosed mass $M(\xi) = 2\pi \int_0^\xi \Sigma(\xi')\, \xi'\, d\xi'$.

(c) Using $\hat{\alpha}(\xi) = 4GM(\xi)/(c^2\,\xi)$, show that $\hat{\alpha} = 4\pi\sigma_v^2/c^2$, independent of ξ.

(d) Derive the SIS Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$.

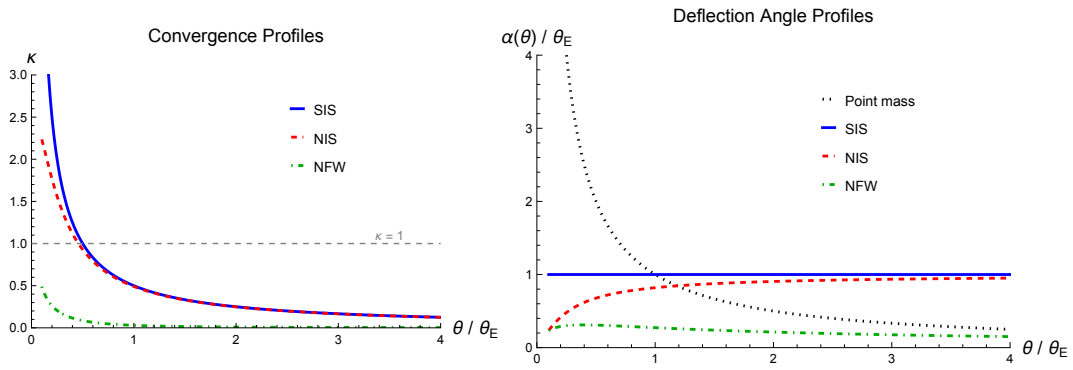


Figure 11.3: Comparison of convergence profiles (left) and deflection angles (right) for the four axisymmetric models. All curves use the SIS Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$ as the unit of length on the horizontal axis; the SIS, NIS and NFW amplitudes are set so that the profiles can be compared on the same panel (specifically NIS with $\theta_c = 0.2\,\theta_{\rm E}$ and NFW with $\theta_s = 0.3\,\theta_{\rm E}$, $\kappa_s = 0.5$). Only the SIS and NIS are normalized to reproduce $\bar{\kappa}(\theta_{\rm E}) = 1$; the NFW deflection therefore does not pass through $\alpha = \theta_{\rm E}$ at $\theta = \theta_{\rm E}$ on this plot. The point mass convergence is a delta function and is not shown. Generated by `axisymmetric_models.wl`.

Verify with `problems_07.wl`.

Exercise 11.9.2. (SIS: $\kappa = |\gamma|$ everywhere.)

(a) For the SIS with $\kappa(\theta) = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta)$, compute the mean convergence $\bar{\kappa}(\theta)$ using eq. (11.5).

(b) Show that $|\gamma(\theta)| = \bar{\kappa}(\theta) - \kappa(\theta) = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta) = \kappa(\theta)$.

(c) Explain physically why $\kappa = |\gamma|$ for the SIS but $\kappa = 0 \neq |\gamma|$ for the point mass. *Hint:* Consider the mass distribution — where is the mass located for each model?

(d) Show that for *any* power-law profile $\kappa(\theta) \propto \theta^{-n}$ with $n > 0$, the ratio $|\gamma|/\kappa$ is constant, and find the value of n for which $|\gamma| = \kappa$.

Verify with `problems_07.wl`.

Exercise 11.9.3. (SIS numerical example.) Consider an SIS lens with $\sigma_v = 250$ km s^{-1} at $z_d = 0.3$ lensing a source at $z_s = 1$. Use $D_{\rm d} \approx 920$ Mpc, $D_{\rm s} \approx 1650$ Mpc, $D_{\rm ds} \approx 1055$ Mpc.

(a) Compute the Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$ in arcseconds.

(b) For a source at $\beta = 0.5''$:

(i) Is the source inside or outside the caustic?

(ii) Find the image positions θ_+ and θ_-.

(iii) Compute the magnifications μ_+ and μ_-.

(iv) Compute the total magnification.

(c) For what source position β does the SIS produce images with equal absolute magnification? Is this physically realizable?

(d) Compare the SIS Einstein radius with the point mass Einstein radius for $M = 10^{12}\,M_\odot$ at the same redshifts. Comment on the difference.

Verify with `problems_07.wl`.

Exercise 11.9.4. (NIS convergence and SIS limit.)

(a) Starting from the NIS surface mass density $\Sigma(\theta) = \sigma_v^2/[2G\,D_{\rm d}\,\sqrt{\theta^2+\theta_c^2}]$, derive the NIS convergence $\kappa(\theta) = \theta_{\rm E}/[2\sqrt{\theta^2+\theta_c^2}]$.

(b) Show that the NIS convergence reduces to the SIS convergence $\kappa = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta)$ in the limit $\theta_c \to 0$.

(c) Find the critical value of θ_c (in terms of $\theta_{\rm E}$) above which the NIS cannot produce multiple images. *Hint:* multiple images require $\kappa(0) > 1$.

(d) For the NIS with $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$, compute $\kappa(0)$, $\kappa(\theta_{\rm E})$, and $\kappa(2\,\theta_{\rm E})$.

(e) Sketch (or plot) the NIS convergence profile for $\theta_c = 0$ (SIS), $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$, $\theta_c = 0.3\,\theta_{\rm E}$, and $\theta_c = 0.5\,\theta_{\rm E}$ on the same axes.

Verify with `problems_07.wl`.

Exercise 11.9.5. (NFW concentration and lensing strength.)

(a) Using the NFW convergence formula $\kappa(x) = \kappa_s\,f(x)$ (eq. 11.47), plot $\kappa(x)/\kappa_s$ as a function of $x = \theta/\theta_s$ for $0.01 \le x \le 10$.

(b) For a cluster at $z_d = 0.3$ with $M_{200} = 10^{15}\,M_\odot$ and source at $z_s = 1$, compute κ_s and θ_s for $c = 5$, $c = 10$, and $c = 20$.

(c) Plot the convergence profiles $\kappa(\theta)$ (in arcsec) for the three concentrations on the same axes. At what angular radius does $\kappa = 1$ for each case?

(d) Discuss how the concentration parameter affects: (i) the Einstein radius, (ii) the size of the region where $\kappa > 1$, and (iii) the lensing cross-section for producing giant arcs.

Use Mathematica to generate the plots. See `axisymmetric_models.wl` and `problems_07.wl`.

Chapter 12

Non-Axisymmetric Models and Critical Curves

> *A circularly symmetric lens model is much too idealized and is unlikely to describe real galaxies. Therefore, considerable work has gone into developing non-circularly symmetric models. The breaking of the symmetry leads to qualitatively new image configurations [. . .]* — Narayan & Bartelmann (1997), Sect. 3.5

In Chapters 9 and 11 we developed the Jacobian formalism for magnification and applied it to axisymmetric lens models: the point mass and the singular isothermal sphere (SIS). These models have a continuous rotational symmetry that makes the mathematics tractable but the phenomenology limited. The SIS, for instance, can produce at most two images of a point source, and its critical curve is a perfect circle.

Real galaxies, however, are elliptical. Their mass distributions have axis ratios $q \sim 0.5$–0.9, and they live in environments that contribute external tidal shear. Breaking circular symmetry introduces qualitatively new phenomena. Critical curves deform from circles into ellipses and ovals; caustics develop a diamond (astroid) shape with cusps and folds; sources can be quadruply as well as doubly imaged, producing Einstein crosses and arcs; and the topology of the image configuration (how many images exist, their parities, and their magnifications) is governed entirely by the position of the source relative to the caustics.

This chapter introduces the two standard non-axisymmetric models, the SIS with external shear and the singular isothermal ellipsoid, and then develops the theory of critical curves, caustics, and image topology on which the rest of strong lensing theory rests.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `critical_curves_caustics.wl` contains the symbolic and numerical computation of critical curves and caustics for the SIS+shear and SIE models, an image position solver, and the generation of all the figures of this chapter.
- `image_configurations.nb` is an interactive notebook in which a source is placed on the source plane and the images appear, colored by parity; caustic crossings can be animated and the ellipticity and shear varied with sliders.

12.1 Introduction: Why Non-Axisymmetric Models Matter

The singular isothermal sphere (Chapter 11) is a useful starting point for galaxy-scale lensing. Its velocity dispersion σ_v maps directly onto observable galaxy kinematics, and its Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E} = 4\pi\sigma_v^2 D_{\rm ds}/(c^2 D_{\rm s})$ sets the angular scale of lensing. The SIS has one basic limitation, its perfect circular symmetry.

Observations of strong lens systems show three things that an SIS cannot account for. Quadruple images are common: about 20–30% of known galaxy-scale lens systems are quads (four bright images plus a faint central image), which an SIS cannot produce. Giant luminous arcs in galaxy clusters are tangentially stretched images that trace out the critical curves of the cluster potential, and these arcs are not perfect circles, so the mass distribution is not axisymmetric. Finally, astrometric anomalies in lens models require ellipticity and/or external shear to achieve acceptable fits.

The simplest way to break axial symmetry is to add a constant *external shear* to the SIS potential. The resulting SIS + shear model already produces diamond caustics, quad images, and fold/cusp configurations. The more physically motivated *singular isothermal ellipsoid* (SIE) achieves the same through an intrinsically elliptical mass distribution and is the model used in modern lens-modeling codes such as `lenstronomy` and `PyAutoLens`.

12.2 SIS + External Shear

The simplest non-axisymmetric lens model augments the SIS potential with a constant external tidal shear $\gamma_{\rm ext}$. This shear arises from the tidal gravitational field of neighboring galaxies or the cluster environment in which the lens galaxy resides.

12.2.1 Lensing Potential

The lensing potential is (Congdon & Keeton eqs. 6.1–6.2):

$$\boxed{\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \theta_{\rm E}\,|\boldsymbol{\theta}| + \frac{1}{2}\,\gamma_{\rm ext}\,(\theta_1^2 - \theta_2^2)} \tag{12.1}$$

where $|\boldsymbol{\theta}| = \sqrt{\theta_1^2 + \theta_2^2}$ and we have chosen the shear to be aligned with the θ_1-axis (the general case involves a rotation by the shear angle ϕ_γ). The first term is the SIS potential; the second is the external shear contribution.

12.2.2 Deflection Angle

The deflection angle components are:

$$\alpha_1 = \frac{\partial\psi}{\partial\theta_1} = \theta_{\rm E}\,\frac{\theta_1}{|\boldsymbol{\theta}|} + \gamma_{\rm ext}\,\theta_1\,, \qquad \alpha_2 = \frac{\partial\psi}{\partial\theta_2} = \theta_{\rm E}\,\frac{\theta_2}{|\boldsymbol{\theta}|} - \gamma_{\rm ext}\,\theta_2\,. \tag{12.2}$$

The SIS contribution deflects radially inward; the shear contribution stretches along θ_1 and compresses along θ_2 (for $\gamma_{\rm ext} > 0$).

12.2.3 Convergence and Shear

The convergence of the SIS + shear model is the same as the pure SIS (the external shear does not add mass):

$$\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{\theta_{\mathrm{E}}}{2\,|\boldsymbol{\theta}|}\,. \tag{12.3}$$

The total shear now has contributions from both the SIS and the external shear. For the SIS alone, $|\gamma_{\mathrm{SIS}}| = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}/(2|\boldsymbol{\theta}|) = \kappa$. The external shear adds γ_{ext} aligned with the coordinate axes, so the total shear field is anisotropic and position-dependent.

12.2.4 Critical Curves

The critical curves are defined by $\det \mathcal{A} = 0$. Start from the Hessian of the SIS+shear potential $\psi = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}|\boldsymbol{\theta}| + \frac{1}{2}\gamma_{\mathrm{ext}}(\theta_1^2 - \theta_2^2)$ and let $u = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}/|\boldsymbol{\theta}|$, $g = \gamma_{\mathrm{ext}}$. In polar coordinates $(\theta_1, \theta_2) = (|\boldsymbol{\theta}|\cos\phi, |\boldsymbol{\theta}|\sin\phi)$ the Jacobian entries are

$$\mathcal{A}_{11} = 1 - g - u\sin^2\phi, \quad \mathcal{A}_{22} = 1 + g - u\cos^2\phi, \quad \mathcal{A}_{12} = \mathcal{A}_{21} = u\sin\phi\cos\phi,$$

and a short expansion gives

$$\det \mathcal{A} \;=\; (1 - g^2) - u\,(1 - g\cos 2\phi).$$

Setting $\det \mathcal{A} = 0$ yields the critical curve:

$$\boxed{\theta_{\mathrm{crit}}(\phi) \;=\; \theta_{\mathrm{E}}\,\frac{1 - \gamma_{\mathrm{ext}}\cos 2\phi}{1 - \gamma_{\mathrm{ext}}^2}\,.} \tag{12.4}$$

The derivation is verified symbolically in `critical_curves_caustics.wl`. For $\gamma_{\mathrm{ext}} = 0$ this reduces to $\theta = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}$ (the SIS critical circle). For $\gamma_{\mathrm{ext}} > 0$, the critical curve is an oval: elongated along the θ_2-axis (perpendicular to the shear direction) and compressed along θ_1 (approximately elliptical for small γ_{ext}; the deviation from a true ellipse reaches $\sim$1.5% at $\gamma_{\mathrm{ext}} = 0.1$).

Remark 12.2.1. The critical curve is elongated perpendicular to the shear direction. The reason is that the shear stretches images along θ_1, so that the magnification diverges at smaller θ in that direction, pushing the critical curve inward along θ_1 and outward along θ_2.

12.2.5 Caustics: The Diamond (Astroid)

The caustics are obtained by mapping the critical curves through the lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta}_{\mathrm{crit}} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}_{\mathrm{crit}})$. For the SIS + shear model, the tangential caustic takes the shape of a *diamond* or *astroid*, a four-cusped curve.

In parametric form, the caustic is:

$$\beta_1(\phi) = \theta_{\mathrm{crit}}(\phi)\cos\phi - \theta_{\mathrm{E}}\cos\phi - \gamma_{\mathrm{ext}}\,\theta_{\mathrm{crit}}(\phi)\cos\phi\,, \tag{12.5}$$

$$\beta_2(\phi) = \theta_{\mathrm{crit}}(\phi)\sin\phi - \theta_{\mathrm{E}}\sin\phi + \gamma_{\mathrm{ext}}\,\theta_{\mathrm{crit}}(\phi)\sin\phi\,. \tag{12.6}$$

This curve has four cusps (at $\phi = 0, \pi/2, \pi, 3\pi/2$) and four fold segments connecting them. The size of the diamond is proportional to γ_{ext}: for $\gamma_{\mathrm{ext}} = 0$, the caustic degenerates to a point (the SIS point caustic), and for larger shear values, the diamond grows.

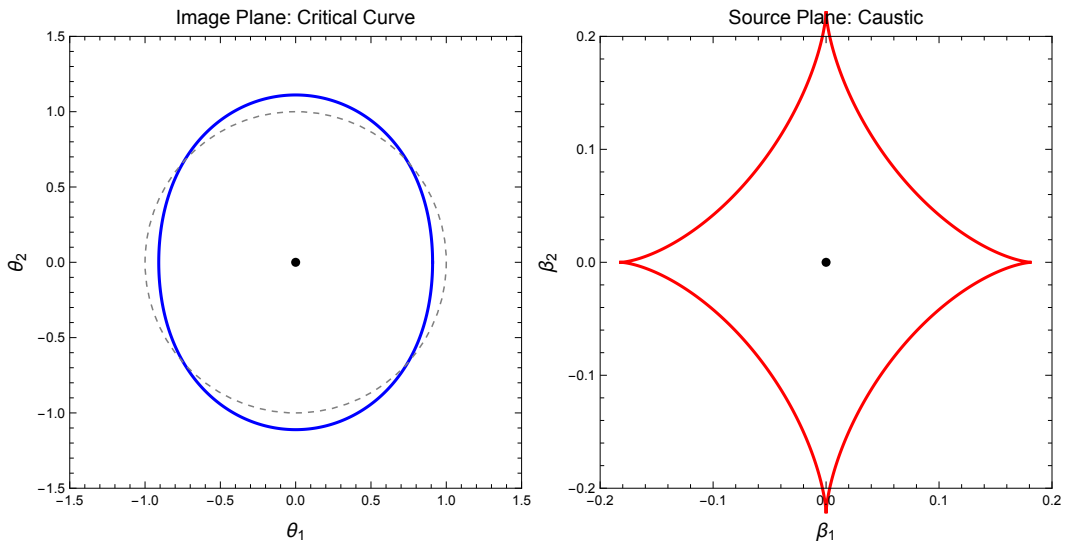


Figure 12.1: Critical curves (left, image plane) and caustics (right, source plane) for the SIS + external shear model with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$ and $\gamma_{\rm ext} = 0.1$. The critical curve is an oval (approximately elliptical for small shear); the caustic is a diamond (astroid) with four cusps. The shear axis is horizontal. Generated by `critical_curves_caustics.wl`.

12.2.6 Image Configurations

The image configuration for the SIS + shear model depends on the source position relative to the diamond caustic. A source outside the diamond has two images (a double): one outside the critical curve (Type I, positive parity) and one inside (Type II, negative parity, demagnified). A source inside the diamond has four images (a quad), two outside the critical curve with positive parity and two inside with negative parity. A source on a fold has three images, two of which merge on the critical curve and are highly magnified, and a source on a cusp has three images, with the merging triplet producing the characteristic cusp configuration.

Remark 12.2.2. The SIS is singular, so there is no separate radial critical curve or radial caustic. The SIS + shear model therefore has only a tangential caustic (the diamond). A non-singular model (e.g., a softened isothermal sphere + shear) would also have a radial caustic enclosing the tangential one.

12.3 The Singular Isothermal Ellipsoid (SIE)

The singular isothermal ellipsoid (SIE) is the standard model for galaxy-scale strong lensing. Rather than adding shear externally, the SIE builds ellipticity directly into the mass distribution.

12.3.1 Surface Mass Density

The SIE surface mass density is (Kormann, Schneider & Bartelmann 1994; Congdon & Keeton eq. 6.13):

$$\boxed{\Sigma(\xi_1,\xi_2) = \frac{\sigma_v^2}{2G}\,\frac{\sqrt{q}}{\sqrt{q^2\,\xi_1^2+\xi_2^2}}} \tag{12.7}$$

where $q \le 1$ is the axis ratio ($q = b/a$, with a the semi-major axis aligned along ξ_1), σ_v is the velocity dispersion, and (ξ_1,ξ_2) are physical coordinates in the lens plane. The iso-density contours $q^2\xi_1^2+\xi_2^2 = \text{const}$ are ellipses of axis ratio q with the major axis along ξ_1. For $q = 1$ this reduces to the SIS surface mass density $\Sigma = \sigma_v^2/(2G\xi)$.

The factor $\sqrt{q}$ ensures that the total mass enclosed within a given elliptical radius is consistent with the isothermal profile.

Converting to angular coordinates via $\boldsymbol{\xi} = D_{\rm d}\boldsymbol{\theta}$ and dividing by the critical surface density gives the dimensionless convergence

$$\kappa(\theta_1,\theta_2) \;=\; \frac{\Sigma}{\Sigma_{\rm cr}} \;=\; \frac{\theta_{\rm E}\sqrt{q}}{2\sqrt{q^2\theta_1^2+\theta_2^2}}\,, \tag{12.8}$$

where $\theta_{\rm E} = 4\pi\sigma_v^2 D_{\rm ds}/(c^2 D_{\rm s})$ is the SIS-equivalent Einstein radius (the Einstein radius of the circular isothermal sphere with the same σ_v).

12.3.2 Deflection Angle

The deflection angle for the SIE, first given in closed form by Kormann, Schneider & Bartelmann (1994, hereafter KSB94), is

$$\boxed{\alpha_1 = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}\,\sqrt{q}}{\sqrt{1-q^2}}\,\arctan\!\left(\frac{\theta_1\sqrt{1-q^2}}{\sqrt{q^2\theta_1^2+\theta_2^2}}\right), \qquad \alpha_2 = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}\,\sqrt{q}}{\sqrt{1-q^2}}\,\operatorname{arctanh}\!\left(\frac{\theta_2\sqrt{1-q^2}}{\sqrt{q^2\theta_1^2+\theta_2^2}}\right).} \tag{12.9}$$

The asymmetry (arctan along the major axis, arctanh along the minor) is intrinsic to the elliptical geometry. Rather than reproducing the long convolution integral that leads to these forms (a contour-integral computation spanning several pages of KSB94), we give a shorter derivation that shows eq. (12.9) is consistent with the SIE convergence (12.8) by using the scale-invariance of the lens. Every step is verified symbolically in `sie_deflection.wl`.

Step 1: scale invariance and the lensing potential. The SIE convergence (12.8) is homogeneous of degree -1 in $\boldsymbol{\theta}$,

$$\kappa(\lambda\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \lambda^{-1}\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \qquad (\lambda > 0).$$

Since $\alpha_i = \partial\psi/\partial\theta_i$ and $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \kappa * \boldsymbol{\theta}/\pi$ is a convolution with a homogeneous-of-degree--1 kernel, the deflection is homogeneous of degree 0 and the potential ψ is homogeneous of degree 1. Euler's theorem for homogeneous functions then gives

$$\psi(\theta_1,\theta_2) \;=\; \theta_1\,\alpha_1(\theta_1,\theta_2) + \theta_2\,\alpha_2(\theta_1,\theta_2)\,. \tag{12.10}$$

Step 2: ansatz and its structure. For the SIE, any deflection consistent with the elliptical symmetry must involve only θ_1, θ_2, and the elliptical radius $F(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \equiv \sqrt{q^2\theta_1^2 + \theta_2^2}$. Dimensional and homogeneity requirements force the argument of the inverse trig/hyperbolic function to be dimensionless and of degree 0. Natural choices are $\theta_1\sqrt{1-q^2}/F$ and $\theta_2\sqrt{1-q^2}/F$; the coefficients $\sqrt{1-q^2}$ are fixed uniquely (up to sign) by the requirement that $\alpha_i \to \theta_{\rm E}\theta_i/|\boldsymbol{\theta}|$ in the SIS limit $q \to 1$. This motivates the KSB94 ansatz (12.9).

Step 3: verify the gradient condition $\alpha_i = \partial_i\psi$. Combining (12.10) and (12.9) and differentiating gives

$$\frac{\partial\psi}{\partial\theta_i} \;=\; \alpha_i + \theta_j\,\frac{\partial\alpha_j}{\partial\theta_i}\,,$$

so the gradient condition is equivalent to $\theta_j(\partial\alpha_j/\partial\theta_i) = 0$. Direct differentiation of (12.9) shows that all cross terms cancel after using the identity $\partial_i(1/F) = -q^{2(1-\delta_{i2})}\theta_i/F^3$ and the derivative of arctan/arctanh. The detailed cancellation is carried out symbolically in `sie_deflection.wl`; the result is

$$\frac{\partial\psi}{\partial\theta_1} = \alpha_1, \qquad \frac{\partial\psi}{\partial\theta_2} = \alpha_2. \tag{12.11}$$

Step 4: verify $\nabla^2\psi = 2\kappa$. Computing $\nabla^2\psi = \partial_1\alpha_1 + \partial_2\alpha_2$ from (12.9):

$$\begin{aligned}
\partial_1\alpha_1 &= \frac{\theta_{\rm E}\sqrt{q}}{\sqrt{1-q^2}}\,\frac{\partial}{\partial\theta_1}\arctan\!\left(\frac{\theta_1\sqrt{1-q^2}}{F}\right) = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}\sqrt{q}}{\sqrt{1-q^2}}\cdot\frac{F^2}{\theta^2}\cdot\frac{\sqrt{1-q^2}\,\theta_2^2}{F^3} \\
&= \frac{\theta_{\rm E}\sqrt{q}\,\theta_2^2}{\theta^2 F}, \\
\partial_2\alpha_2 &= \frac{\theta_{\rm E}\sqrt{q}\,\theta_1^2}{\theta^2 F},
\end{aligned}$$

after applying the chain rule to $\partial_i F = q^{2(1-\delta_{i2})}\theta_i/F$ and simplifying, with $\theta^2 = \theta_1^2 + \theta_2^2$. Adding:

$$\nabla^2\psi \;=\; \frac{\theta_{\rm E}\sqrt{q}\,(\theta_1^2+\theta_2^2)}{\theta^2 F} \;=\; \frac{\theta_{\rm E}\sqrt{q}}{F} \;=\; 2\,\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}), \tag{12.12}$$

matching (12.8). This completes the verification.

Step 5: the SIS limit $q \to 1$. As $q \to 1^-$, $\sqrt{1-q^2} \to 0$ and the arguments of the inverse functions vanish; using $\arctan x/x \to 1$ and $\operatorname{arctanh} x/x \to 1$,

$$\alpha_i \;\to\; \theta_{\rm E}\,\sqrt{q}\,\frac{\theta_i}{\sqrt{q^2\theta_1^2+\theta_2^2}} \;\to\; \theta_{\rm E}\,\frac{\theta_i}{|\boldsymbol{\theta}|}\,,$$

which is the SIS deflection. The limit is taken symbolically in `sie_deflection.wl`.

12.3.3 Critical Curves and Caustics of the SIE

The critical curves of the SIE are found by solving $\det \mathcal{A}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = 0$. Unlike the SIS (where the critical curve is a circle), the SIE tangential critical curve is an ellipse, $q^2\theta_1^2 + \theta_2^2 = q\theta_{\rm E}^2$, with the same axis ratio q as the mass (it is the contour $2\kappa = 1$ of eq. (12.8)). Its shape depends on q.

For axis ratios $q \lesssim 0.9$ the SIE has a tangential critical curve that is an ellipse close to the Einstein radius, elongated *along* the major axis of the mass distribution: with $q < 1$ and mass elongated along θ_1, the critical curve crosses the θ_1-axis at $\pm\theta_{\rm E}/\sqrt{q}$ and the θ_2-axis at $\pm\theta_{\rm E}\sqrt{q}$, so it stretches farther along θ_1 than along θ_2. Its tangential caustic is a diamond (astroid) similar to that of the SIS + shear case, with four cusps; for $q < 1$ the diamond is also wider along the mass major axis β_1.

The SIE, being singular at the origin, does not have a radial critical curve (just as the SIS does not). A non-singular isothermal ellipsoid would also have a radial critical curve mapping to a radial caustic.

The cross-section for quad lensing (the area enclosed by the tangential caustic) increases with ellipticity. For $q = 0.7$, the caustic area is roughly $0.066\,\theta_{\rm E}^2$, while for $q = 0.5$ it can be several times larger. More elliptical galaxies are therefore more likely to produce quad lens systems.

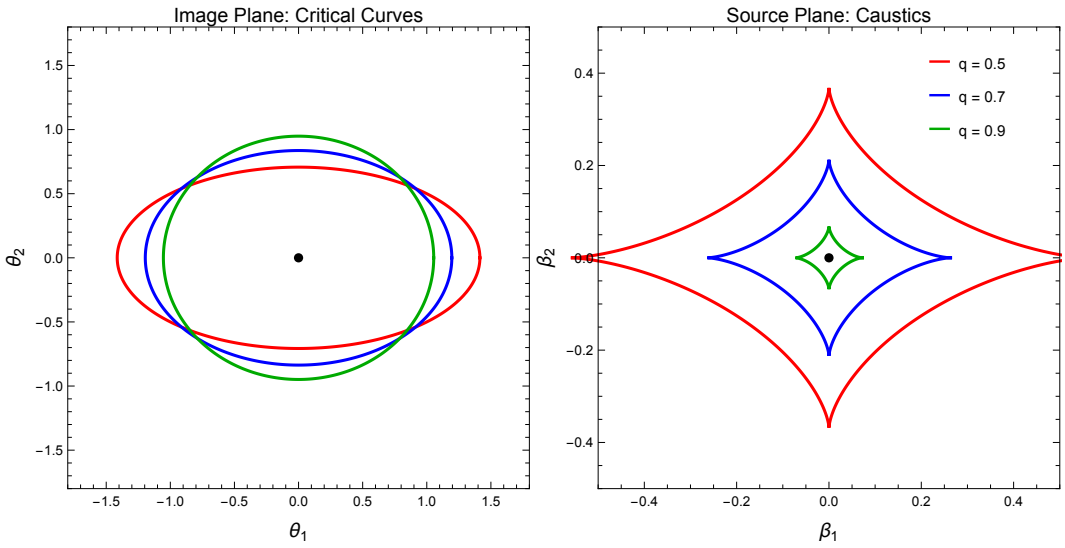


Figure 12.2: Critical curves (left) and caustics (right) for the SIE model with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$ and axis ratios $q = 0.5$, 0.7, and 0.9. As q decreases (more elliptical), the diamond caustic grows larger, increasing the cross-section for quad imaging. Generated by `critical_curves_caustics.wl`.

12.4 The Angular Structure of Lenses: Multipole Expansion

The SIE and the SIS + shear model are two *specific* ways of breaking circular symmetry. A more systematic view treats any lens potential as a circularly symmetric *monopole* plus a series of *angular multipoles*. This is the natural language for asking *which* deviations from circular symmetry a set of images can constrain, a question that, as Schneider et al. [43] emphasize (Part 2, §4.4–4.5, Kochanek), gravitational lensing answers better than any other probe of galaxy potentials.

12.4.1 The Multipole Series

Expand the lensing potential in azimuthal harmonics of the polar angle φ (with $\boldsymbol{\theta} = \theta(\cos\varphi, \sin\varphi)$):

$$\psi(\theta, \varphi) = \psi_0(\theta) + \sum_{m=1}^{\infty} \psi_m(\theta)\, \cos\big[m(\varphi - \varphi_m)\big], \tag{12.13}$$

where ψ_0 is the monopole (the axisymmetric part of Chapter 11) and each $m \geq 1$ term has its own orientation φ_m. The convergence of a single multipole follows from the two-dimensional Poisson equation $\nabla^2\psi = 2\kappa$ (Chapter 9), with the Laplacian in polar coordinates $\nabla^2 = \partial_\theta^2 + \theta^{-1}\partial_\theta + \theta^{-2}\partial_\varphi^2$.

For the *isothermal-scaling* multipole $\psi_m = a_m\,\theta\,\cos[m(\varphi - \varphi_m)]$ (radial dependence $\propto \theta$, matching the flat rotation curve of the SIS), a direct computation gives

$$\boxed{\kappa_m(\theta, \varphi) = \frac{a_m\,(1 - m^2)}{2\,\theta}\, \cos\big[m(\varphi - \varphi_m)\big]} \tag{12.14}$$

(verified symbolically in the companion script; cf. the equivalent relation in Schneider et al. [43], Part 2, eq. 77). Two cases anchor this result. For $m = 0$, $\kappa_0 = a_0/(2\theta)$ is the SIS profile $\kappa = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta)$ with $a_0 = \theta_{\rm E}$. For $m = 2$, $\kappa_2 = -(3a_2/2\theta)\cos[2(\varphi - \varphi_2)]$ is the leading *quadrupole*, the elliptical distortion of an isothermal galaxy.

12.4.2 Internal vs. External Multipoles

Each angular harmonic m admits two radial "flavours" that are solutions of Laplace's equation away from the mass: an *internal* part sourced by mass *interior* to θ (decaying outward) and an *external* part sourced by mass *exterior* to θ (growing outward). The quadrupole makes this concrete. The external shear of §12.2 is the massless external quadrupole, $\psi = \frac{1}{2}\gamma\,\theta^2\cos[2(\varphi - \varphi_\gamma)]$, with $\kappa = 0$ but nonzero γ: a pure tidal field from the environment. The isothermal quadrupole $\psi_2 \propto \theta$ of Eq. (12.14) is the internal quadrupole carried by the lens's own elliptical mass. For a singular isothermal ellipsoid the internal and external quadrupole amplitudes are locked in the ratio $\psi_{2,\rm int}/\psi_{2,\rm ext} = (m-1)/(m+1) = 1/3$, so the internal fraction of the total quadrupole is $f_{\rm int} = 1/4$: *three-quarters of an SIE's quadrupole is generated by mass outside any given radius* [43, Part 2, eq. 74]. For lenses embedded in flat-rotation-curve dark haloes, most of the quadrupole therefore comes from the halo

beyond the Einstein ring, which is why an *external* shear term is an adequate stand-in for the environment in most models.

12.4.3 Which Multipoles Matter

The amplitude of successive poles falls steeply with ellipticity, $\psi_m \propto \epsilon^{m/2}$ (with $q = 1-\epsilon$). For a typical lens with $\theta_{\rm E} \sim 1''$ the quadrupole ($m = 2$) produces angular deflections $\sim 0.46''\,\epsilon$, which matter for any ellipticity given milliarcsecond astrometry; the $m = 4$ pole (boxy/discy isophotes) contributes $\sim 0.09''\,\epsilon^2$ and matters only for $q \lesssim 0.75$; and the dipole ($m = 1$, lopsidedness) is nearly degenerate with the source position and rarely matters. The practical conclusion, a recurring theme of the applications in Chapter 13, is that a monopole plus an external shear (a single quadrupole) accounts for most of the constrainable angular structure, with the $m = 4$ term becoming relevant only for markedly flattened lenses.

12.5 Critical Curves

We now develop the general theory of critical curves, building on the preview in Chapter 9 (Section 9.10).

Definition 12.5.1. The *critical curves* are the loci in the image plane where the Jacobian determinant vanishes:

$$\boxed{\det \mathcal{A}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = 0 \qquad \Longleftrightarrow \qquad (1-\kappa)^2 - |\gamma|^2 = 0} \tag{12.15}$$

Equivalently, $\mu(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \to \infty$ on critical curves.

12.5.1 Two Families of Critical Curves

Using the eigenvalues $\lambda_\pm = 1 - \kappa \pm |\gamma|$ of the Jacobian (Chapter 9, eq. 9.17), the condition $\det \mathcal{A} = \lambda_+\,\lambda_- = 0$ is satisfied when either eigenvalue vanishes, and there are accordingly two families. The *tangential critical curve* is where $\lambda_- = 0$,

$$1 - \kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = |\gamma(\boldsymbol{\theta})| \tag{12.16}$$

Images near this curve are stretched tangentially (along the curve), because the eigenvalue corresponding to the tangential direction vanishes; giant arcs in clusters trace the tangential critical curve. The *radial critical curve* is where $\lambda_+ = 0$,

$$1 - \kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = -|\gamma(\boldsymbol{\theta})| \tag{12.17}$$

Images near this curve are stretched radially (perpendicular to the curve). Radial arcs, pointing toward the lens center, form near radial critical curves, though they are rarer and fainter than tangential arcs.

12.5.2 Critical Curves for Axisymmetric vs. Elliptical Lenses

For axisymmetric lenses the critical curves are circles centered on the lens: for the SIS there is only a tangential critical curve at $\theta = \theta_{\rm E}$, and for the point mass the critical curve is the Einstein ring. For elliptical lenses the critical curves become ellipses or ovals. For the SIE (mass elongated along θ_1, $q < 1$) the tangential critical curve is elongated *along* the mass major axis, crossing θ_1 at $\pm\theta_{\rm E}/\sqrt{q}$ and θ_2 at $\pm\theta_{\rm E}\sqrt{q}$. In general the shapes are computed numerically by solving $\det \mathcal{A} = 0$ on a grid or parametrically.

12.5.3 Physical Meaning

Critical curves are the sites of maximum magnification. Images that form near a critical curve are highly magnified, $|\mu| \gg 1$, because $\det \mathcal{A} \approx 0$. They are also highly stretched: along one direction (tangential or radial) the magnification diverges while it remains finite in the orthogonal direction, which produces the elongated arc morphology. Finally, critical curves are parity boundaries: as we cross one, $\det \mathcal{A}$ changes sign, so the image parity flips, with positive parity (Type I) on one side and negative parity (Type II) on the other. The practical significance is considerable, since critical curves are where the most highly magnified background sources are to be found; cluster lensing surveys map out critical curves to find magnified galaxies at very high redshift.

12.6 Caustics

Definition 12.6.1. The *caustics* are the images of the critical curves under the lens mapping. That is, the caustics are the curves in the source plane obtained by applying the lens equation to each point on a critical curve:

$$\boxed{\boldsymbol{\beta}_{\rm caustic} = \boldsymbol{\theta}_{\rm crit} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}_{\rm crit})} \tag{12.18}$$

12.6.1 Types of Caustics

Corresponding to the two families of critical curves there are two types of caustics. The *tangential caustic* is the mapping of the tangential critical curve; for elliptical lenses it is typically a diamond (astroid) with four cusps, and sources inside it are quadruply imaged. The *radial caustic* is the mapping of the radial critical curve; it is typically a smooth, roughly elliptical curve that encloses the tangential caustic. Sources inside the radial caustic but outside the tangential caustic are doubly imaged, and sources outside both caustics have a single image.

12.6.2 Caustics for Specific Models

For the point mass, the tangential critical curve (the Einstein ring $\theta = \theta_{\rm E}$) maps to a single point ($\beta = 0$), a degenerate point caustic; a source at $\beta = 0$ produces the Einstein ring, and any source at $\beta > 0$ produces exactly two images. The SIS behaves in the same way: the critical curve $\theta = \theta_{\rm E}$ maps to $\beta = 0$, and there is no radial caustic, so sources with

$\beta < \theta_{\rm E}$ produce two images and sources with $\beta > \theta_{\rm E}$ produce one image. For the SIS + shear the tangential caustic opens up into a diamond (astroid) with four cusps whose size is proportional to $\gamma_{\rm ext}$, and the SIE has the same diamond structure, with the size controlled by the ellipticity $(1-q)$. Non-singular models (NIS, NFW) have both tangential and radial caustics; the radial caustic encloses the tangential one, creating regions with 1, 3, and 5 images.

12.7 Image Topology

This section explains why images appear and disappear as a source moves, why they always come in pairs, and how the full image configuration (positions, parities, magnifications) is determined by the location of the source relative to the caustic structure. Caustics are the boundaries between regions of different image multiplicity, and critical curves are the boundaries between regions of different image parity; together they provide a complete topological description of the lens mapping.

12.7.1 Critical Curves as Parity Boundaries

Recall from Chapter 9 that the magnification is $\mu = 1/\det \mathcal{A}$ and that the sign of μ determines the image parity: $\det \mathcal{A} > 0 \;\Rightarrow\; \mu > 0$ gives positive parity (a Type I image, with the same orientation as the source), and $\det \mathcal{A} < 0 \;\Rightarrow\; \mu < 0$ gives negative parity (a Type II image, mirror-reflected relative to the source). Since $\det \mathcal{A}$ is a continuous function of position that passes through zero on critical curves, the sign of $\det \mathcal{A}$ must change across a critical curve. Therefore:

Proposition 12.7.1. ***Critical curves are parity boundaries.*** *Images on opposite sides of a critical curve have opposite parities. If a critical curve separates region R_+ ($\det \mathcal{A} > 0$) from region R_- ($\det \mathcal{A} < 0$), then images in R_+ have positive parity (Type I, minima of the arrival time surface) and images in R_- have negative parity (Type II, saddle points of the arrival time surface).*

For a typical galaxy lens with an elliptical mass distribution, the region outside the tangential critical curve has $\det \mathcal{A} > 0$, so images there are Type I (positive parity, time-delay minima); the region between the tangential and radial critical curves has $\det \mathcal{A} < 0$, so images there are Type II (negative parity, saddle points); and the region inside the radial critical curve has $\det \mathcal{A} > 0$ again, so images there are Type I or Type III (positive parity, but corresponding to time-delay maxima for Type III, as discussed in Chapter 10).

Remark 12.7.1. The connection to Morse theory (Chapter 10) is direct. The three image types correspond to the three types of stationary points of the Fermat potential: Type I is a minimum, Type II a saddle, and Type III a maximum. The magnification parity determines the Morse index.

12.7.2 Caustic Crossings and Image Creation/Destruction

The most important property of caustics is the following.

Proposition 12.7.2. ***Image creation/destruction at caustics.*** *When a source crosses a caustic, the number of images changes by exactly two. A pair of images either appears (as the source enters a higher-multiplicity region) or disappears (as it exits).*

This happens because, as a source approaches a caustic from the side with fewer images, two of the "potential" image positions on opposite sides of the corresponding critical curve converge toward the critical curve. At the moment the source is exactly on the caustic, the two images merge *on* the critical curve (where $\det \mathcal{A} = 0$ and the magnification diverges). As the source crosses the caustic, the two images separate and become distinct.

The two images that appear or disappear are located on opposite sides of the critical curve, have opposite parities (one Type I, one Type II), are both highly magnified near the caustic (their magnifications diverge as they approach the critical curve), and have nearly equal magnifications in absolute value.

Remark 12.7.2. The fact that images always appear or disappear in pairs with opposite parities is a topological necessity. It preserves Burke's odd-number theorem (Chapter 10): the total number of images is always odd (for a non-singular, transparent lens with a source inside the outermost caustic). Since images are created and destroyed in pairs, the parity of the count (odd or even) never changes.

12.7.3 Walking a Source Across Caustics: A Worked Example

To make the image creation/destruction process concrete, we walk through a complete example using an SIE lens with axis ratio $q = 0.7$ and Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$. The SIE has a tangential caustic (diamond shape) in the source plane. For a non-singular model there would also be a radial caustic enclosing the diamond, but for the SIE (which is singular at the center) we focus on the tangential caustic.

Consider a source that starts far from the lens and moves inward, crossing the caustics:

Stage 1: Source outside the tangential caustic. For the singular SIE the outermost boundary in the source plane is not a radial caustic but the *cut* (pseudo-caustic): the closed curve onto which an infinitesimal circle about the singular centre is mapped. If the source is beyond the cut (for $q = 0.7$, $|\beta_1| > 0.932\,\theta_{\rm E}$ on the β_1 axis and $|\beta_2| > 1.049\,\theta_{\rm E}$ on the β_2 axis) the SIE forms a single Type I image, the elliptical version of the SIS rule that $\beta > \theta_{\rm E}$ gives one image. Once the source is inside the cut but still outside the diamond, there are two images (one Type I outside the critical curve, near the true source position, and one Type II inside the critical curve on the opposite side of the lens). In a non-singular model a third, Type III image appears near the lens center once the source is inside the radial caustic, but for the SIE that central image is suppressed because Σ is singular at the origin. The two observable images are a Type I image (positive parity, a minimum of the arrival time) outside the tangential critical curve near the true source position, weakly magnified ($|\mu| \approx 1$), and a Type II image (negative parity, a saddle of the arrival time) inside the critical curve on the far side of the lens, also weakly magnified.

Stage 2: Source crosses the tangential caustic (outside → inside). As the source reaches the tangential (diamond) caustic, two new images appear simultaneously, straddling

the tangential critical curve. The total count goes from 2 to 4 images. The original Type I image (positive parity, outside the tangential critical curve) persists, moving slightly. A new Type II image (negative parity) appears just inside the tangential critical curve; it is a saddle point of the arrival time surface, highly magnified and tangentially stretched. A new Type I image (positive parity) appears just outside the tangential critical curve, close to the Type II image; it is a minimum of the arrival time surface and is also highly magnified.

The two new images are born as a highly magnified, closely spaced pair straddling the critical curve. They have opposite parities (one positive, one negative) and nearly equal $|\mu|$. As the source moves further inside the caustic, they separate and their magnifications decrease.

Stage 3: Source inside the tangential caustic (quad configuration). With the source well inside the diamond caustic, four bright images surround the lens (plus a faint, highly demagnified central image in non-singular models). The typical configuration is an Einstein cross: two Type I images (positive parity) outside the tangential critical curve and two Type II images (negative parity) inside it. The four images form a roughly cross-shaped pattern around the lens. The magnification depends on the source's proximity to the caustic folds and cusps.

Stage 4: Source crosses the tangential caustic again (inside $\rightarrow$ outside). As the source exits the diamond caustic, two images converge on the critical curve, merge, and disappear. The count drops from 4 back to 2. The two images that disappear are a Type I/Type II pair, just as in the creation event.

For a non-singular lens model (e.g., a softened isothermal ellipsoid), there is also a radial caustic enclosing the tangential one. As the source crosses the radial caustic inward, two additional images appear (a Type II near the radial critical curve and the Type III central image), bringing the total from 1 to 3; crossing the tangential caustic then adds two more, giving 5. This gives the complete sequence:

Region	Image count	Types
Outside radial caustic	1	I
Between radial & tangential	3	I, II, III
Inside tangential caustic	5	I, I, II, II, III

Here Type III is a maximum of the arrival time (the highly demagnified central image).

12.7.4 The Fold and Cusp Catastrophes

The caustic curves of a generic smooth lens consist of two types of points: *folds* (smooth segments) and *cusps* (pointed corners). These are the only two generic singularities of smooth two-dimensional mappings, a result from catastrophe theory (or singularity theory; see Petters, Levine & Wambsganss 2001 for a thorough treatment).

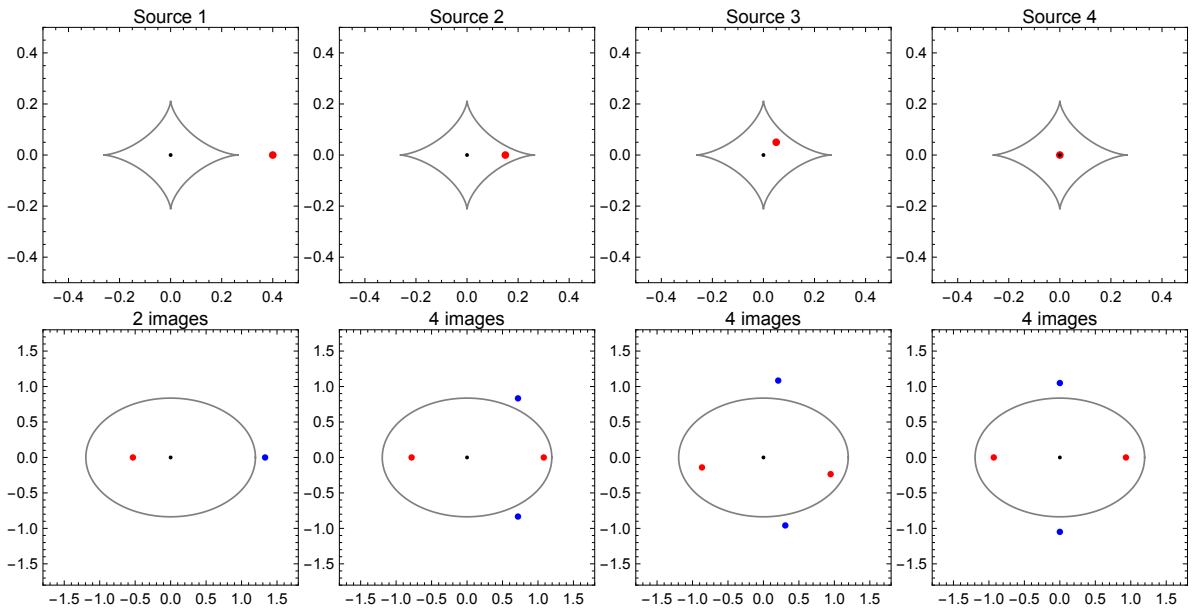


Figure 12.3: A source walks across the caustic of an SIE lens ($q = 0.7$). **Top row:** Source positions (red star) in the source plane, with the diamond caustic shown. **Bottom row:** Corresponding image configurations in the image plane, with the critical curve shown. Blue dots = Type I images (positive parity); red dots = Type II images (negative parity). As the source crosses the caustic, images appear/disappear in pairs. Generated by `critical_curves_caustics.wl`.

Fold Caustics

Near a fold (a smooth segment of the caustic) two images merge: as a source crosses a fold caustic, two images appear or disappear, straddling the critical curve with one on each side. The magnification of each of the two merging images scales as

$$\boxed{|\mu| \propto \frac{1}{\sqrt{d_\perp}}} \tag{12.19}$$

where $d_\perp$ is the perpendicular distance of the source from the caustic. The magnification diverges as $d_\perp \to 0$ (source on the caustic), but only as an inverse square root, a relatively mild divergence. The two merging images have magnifications that approach $+|\mu_0|$ and $-|\mu_0|$ (equal absolute values, opposite signs), so their total signed magnification approaches zero, while the unsigned total $2|\mu_0| \propto 1/\sqrt{d_\perp}$ diverges. The merging images are highly elongated tangentially (along the critical curve) and compressed radially, which is the origin of the "arc" morphology.

Cusp Caustics

Near a cusp (a pointed corner of the caustic) the behavior is richer. Three images merge: as a source approaches a cusp from inside the caustic, three images converge toward a single point on the critical curve, forming the characteristic *cusp triplet*. The magnification divergence is

stronger than at a fold, since the sum of the (unsigned) image magnifications diverges as

$$|\mu_A| + |\mu_B| + |\mu_C| \propto d_\perp^{-1} \tag{12.20}$$

(compared to $d_\perp^{-1/2}$ for a fold). The *signed* magnifications of the three cusp images satisfy a different relation,

$$\mu_A + \mu_B + \mu_C \;\to\; 0 \quad (\text{in the limit } d_\perp \to 0)\,, \tag{12.21}$$

where A, B, C are the three images of the cusp triplet (with signed magnifications). That is, the sum of the signed magnifications of the three brightest images in a cusp configuration should vanish; violations of this relation indicate substructure (e.g., dark matter subhalos) perturbing the images. The three cusp images are closely spaced along the critical curve, and one is on the opposite side of the critical curve from the other two, ensuring opposite parities.

Remark 12.7.3. The fold and cusp are the only stable (generic) singularities of smooth two-dimensional maps. Higher-order singularities (swallowtails, lips, etc.) require special symmetries or fine-tuning and are not generically present in gravitational lens models. This follows from Whitney's theorem in singularity theory (Petters et al. 2001, Ch. 7, Sec. 7.5).

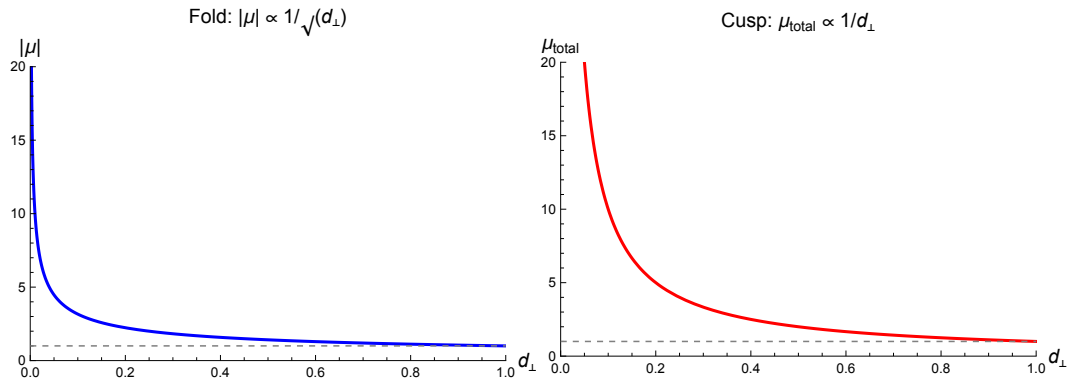


Figure 12.4: Magnification behavior near fold and cusp caustics. **Left:** Near a fold, two images straddle the critical curve with magnifications scaling as $|\mu| \propto 1/\sqrt{d_\perp}$. **Right:** Near a cusp, three images merge, with stronger divergence. The cusp relation $\mu_A + \mu_B + \mu_C \approx 0$ holds for the signed magnifications. Generated by `critical_curves_caustics.wl`.

12.7.5 Image Configuration Taxonomy

The caustic structure of a lens determines all possible image configurations. For an elliptical galaxy lens (SIE or similar model), the following taxonomy applies:

Doubles

When the source is outside the tangential caustic, two images form (or effectively one bright image plus one highly demagnified image near the lens center for singular models): one Type I image (positive parity, outside the critical curve), the dominant, brighter image, and one

Type II image (negative parity, inside the critical curve), typically fainter and on the opposite side of the lens from the source. Doubles account for ∼70–80% of known galaxy-scale lens systems.

Quads / Einstein Crosses

When the source is inside the tangential caustic, four bright images form (plus a faint central image): two Type I images (positive parity), roughly on the side of the lens closer to the source, and two Type II images (negative parity) on the opposite side. The four images form a roughly cross-shaped (Einstein cross) or diamond-shaped pattern around the lens. Quads account for ∼20–30% of galaxy-scale systems and are especially valuable for cosmography because they provide three independent time delays.

Cusp Configurations

When the source is near a cusp of the tangential caustic, three of the four images in a quad merge into a closely spaced triplet near one point on the critical curve. This produces the *naked cusp* or *cusp triplet* configuration: three closely spaced images near the cusp of the critical curve, with the cusp relation $\mu_A + \mu_B + \mu_C \approx 0$, and one isolated image on the opposite side of the lens.

Why Most Observed Quads Have a Diamond Caustic

The tangential caustic of an elliptical galaxy lens is generically a diamond (astroid). The dominant perturbation from circular symmetry is quadrupolar (ellipticity or shear), which produces exactly four cusps, and higher-order multipoles (hexapole, octupole) are typically subdominant and do not change the topology of the caustic. The diamond caustic produces Einstein crosses (quads with roughly equal magnifications) when the source is near the center, and fold or cusp configurations when the source is near a fold or cusp of the diamond.

12.7.6 Why Giant Arcs Form

The formation of giant luminous arcs in galaxy clusters follows from the theory of critical curves and caustics.

Step 1: Sources near the tangential caustic. Giant arcs form when a background galaxy lies very close to (but just inside or outside) the tangential caustic. At this location, one or two of its images lie very close to the tangential critical curve.

Step 2: Tangential stretching near the critical curve. The tangential critical curve is where $\lambda_- = 0$ (the eigenvalue corresponding to the tangential direction vanishes). Near this curve, images are stretched strongly in the tangential direction (along the critical curve) while remaining relatively unstretched in the radial direction.

Quantitatively, if the source is at perpendicular distance $d_\perp$ from the tangential caustic, the tangential magnification scales as:

$$\mu_{\rm tan} \propto \frac{1}{\sqrt{d_\perp}} \tag{12.22}$$

while the radial magnification remains of order unity. The result is an image that is stretched by a factor of $\mu_{\rm tan}$ along the critical curve but not radially: an arc.

Step 3: Arc length and curvature. Since the arc follows the tangential critical curve, its curvature matches that of the critical curve. For a galaxy cluster, the tangential critical curve has a radius of ∼10–30 arcsec, so giant arcs appear as curved features with large opening angles. The length-to-width ratio of the arc is approximately $\mu_{\rm tan} \sim 1/\sqrt{d_\perp}$, which can reach 10:1 or more for sources very close to the caustic.

Step 4: Multiple arcs. A source just inside the tangential caustic produces two highly magnified images on opposite sides of the tangential critical curve (a fold pair). Both images are arcs. If the source is also near a cusp, three images merge into a very long arc (a "cusp arc").

Remark 12.7.4. The largest known arcs in galaxy clusters have length-to-width ratios exceeding 10:1 and total magnifications of $\mu \sim 20$–50. These extreme magnifications are used to study intrinsically faint galaxies at high redshift ("cosmic telescopes").

12.8 Image Configurations: Doubles, Quads, and Einstein Crosses

We now illustrate the different image configurations with explicit examples for an SIE lens.

12.8.1 Double Configuration

For a source at $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.5, 0.0)''$ lensed by an SIE with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$, $q = 0.7$, the source is outside the tangential caustic and two images form: image A at $\boldsymbol{\theta}_A \approx (1.43, 0.0)''$, Type I with positive parity and $\mu_A \approx 6.1$, and image B at $\boldsymbol{\theta}_B \approx (-0.43, 0.0)''$, Type II with negative parity and $\mu_B \approx -0.6$. The brighter image (A) is on the same side as the source; the fainter image (B) is on the opposite side.

12.8.2 Quad / Einstein Cross Configuration

For a source at $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.05, 0.05)''$ (inside the tangential caustic): Four bright images form, arranged in a cross pattern. The two Type I images tend to be on the side closer to the source; the two Type II images are on the opposite side. The magnifications of the four images are comparable, with the images nearer the critical curve being brighter.

12.8.3 Cusp Configuration

For a source near a cusp of the tangential caustic (e.g., near $\boldsymbol{\beta} \approx (0.25, 0.0)''$ for an SIE with $q = 0.7$, where the cusp on the β_1-axis sits at $|\beta_1| \approx 0.263\,\theta_{\rm E}$): Three images cluster together near the corresponding point on the critical curve, forming a cusp triplet. The fourth image is isolated on the opposite side.

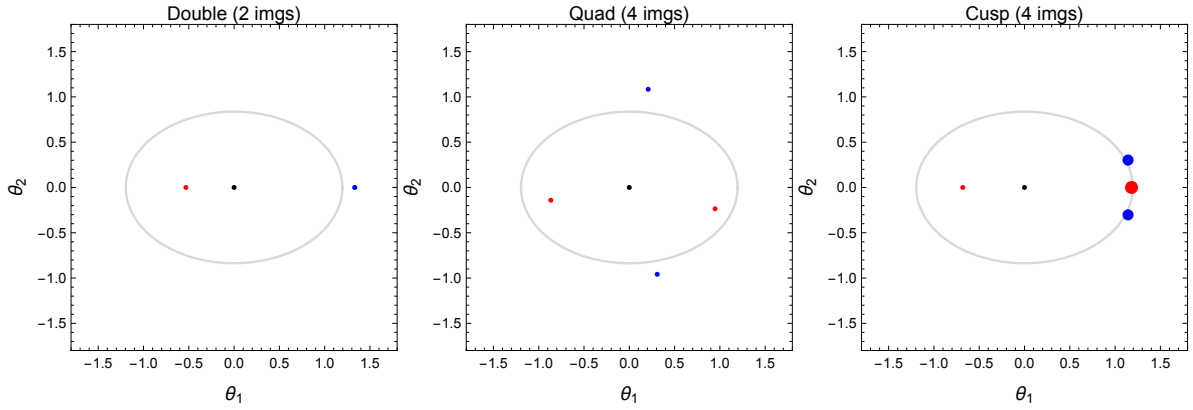


Figure 12.5: Image configurations for an SIE lens with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$ and $q = 0.7$. **Left:** Double (source outside caustic). **Center:** Quad / Einstein cross (source inside caustic). **Right:** Cusp configuration (source near a cusp). Blue = Type I (positive parity); red = Type II (negative parity). The critical curve and caustic are shown as gray curves. Generated by `critical_curves_caustics.wl`.

12.9 Summary

The SIS with external shear is the simplest non-axisymmetric model. The external shear $\gamma_{\rm ext}$ deforms the critical curve into an oval and opens the point caustic into a diamond (astroid) with four cusps. The singular isothermal ellipsoid (SIE) builds ellipticity directly into the mass distribution; its deflection angle involves arctan and arctanh functions (Kormann et al. 1994), and it is the standard model for galaxy-scale lens modeling. Critical curves ($\det \mathcal{A} = 0$) are parity boundaries in the image plane: the tangential critical curve ($1 - \kappa = |\gamma|$) is the site of giant arcs, and the radial critical curve ($1 - \kappa = -|\gamma|$) is the site of radial arcs. Caustics are the mappings of critical curves to the source plane and divide it into regions of different image multiplicity.

As a source crosses a caustic, two images appear or disappear on opposite sides of the critical curve, with opposite parities, which preserves Burke's odd-number theorem. At a fold two images merge, with magnification $|\mu| \propto 1/\sqrt{d_\perp}$; this produces giant arcs. At a cusp three images merge and the cusp relation $\mu_A + \mu_B + \mu_C \approx 0$ holds. Doubles (source outside the caustic), quads or Einstein crosses (source inside the caustic), and cusp triplets (source near a cusp) account for the observed morphologies of strong lens systems. Giant arcs form when extended sources lie near the tangential caustic: images are tangentially stretched by factors of $\mu_{\rm tan} \propto 1/\sqrt{d_\perp}$ along the tangential critical curve.

12.10 Problems

Exercise 12.10.1. (SIS + shear: critical curves and caustics.) Consider an SIS + external shear model with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$ and $\gamma_{\rm ext} = 0.1$.

(a) Starting from the lensing potential (eq. 12.1), compute the Jacobian matrix $\mathcal{A}$ and the determinant $\det \mathcal{A}$ as functions of (θ_1, θ_2).

(b) Solve $\det \mathcal{A} = 0$ to find the critical curve. Express the result in polar coordinates $\theta_{\rm crit}(\phi)$. Plot the critical curve.

(c) Map the critical curve through the lens equation to obtain the caustic. Plot the caustic in the source plane. Verify that it has four cusps and the shape of an astroid.

(d) Estimate the area enclosed by the caustic (the quad cross-section).

Verify with `problems_08.wl`.

Exercise 12.10.2. (SIE tangential caustic.) For an SIE with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$ and axis ratio $q = 0.7$:

(a) Write down the deflection angle components α_1 and α_2 from eq. (12.9).

(b) Compute the tangential caustic numerically by: (i) finding the critical curve from $\det \mathcal{A} = 0$, and (ii) mapping it through the lens equation. Plot the caustic.

(c) Compute the area of the tangential caustic (the quad cross-section) numerically. How does it compare to the SIS + shear model with the same effective ellipticity?

Verify with `problems_08.wl`.

Exercise 12.10.3. (Fold magnification scaling.) Show that images appear or disappear in pairs at caustic crossings by analyzing $\det \mathcal{A}$ near a fold:

(a) Near a fold caustic, the lens mapping in the direction perpendicular to the fold can be approximated as $\beta_\perp \approx a\,\theta_\perp^2$, where $\theta_\perp$ is the signed distance from the critical curve and a is a constant. Show that for $\beta_\perp > 0$, there are two solutions $\theta_\perp = \pm\sqrt{\beta_\perp / a}$ (one on each side of the critical curve), while for $\beta_\perp < 0$ there are no solutions.

(b) Compute the Jacobian of the simplified mapping and show that the magnification scales as $|\mu| \propto 1/\sqrt{\beta_\perp}$ for each image.

(c) Show that the two images have opposite parities (opposite signs of $\det \mathcal{A}$).

Verify with `problems_08.wl`.

Exercise 12.10.4. (SIE image positions.) For a source at $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.1, 0.2)''$ lensed by an SIE with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$ and $q = 0.8$:

(a) Determine whether the source is inside or outside the tangential caustic. How many images do you expect?

(b) Find all image positions $\boldsymbol{\theta}_i$ numerically by solving the lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$.

(c) For each image, compute the magnification μ_i and determine the parity (Type I or Type II).

(d) Compute the signed magnification sum $\sum_i \mu_i$ and discuss whether it is consistent with the expected value (considering the missing central image for the singular SIE).

Verify with `problems_08.wl`.

Exercise 12.10.5. (Burke's odd-number theorem for the SIE.) Verify Burke's odd-number theorem for an SIE with $\theta_{\mathrm{E}} = 1''$ and $q = 0.7$:

(a) For a source outside the tangential caustic (e.g., $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.5, 0.0)''$), find all image positions. Count the images (including any faint central image) and verify the count is odd.

(b) For a source inside the tangential caustic (e.g., $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.05, 0.05)''$), find all image positions. Verify the count is odd.

(c) For each case, classify each image by parity and verify that the number of positive-parity images exceeds the number of negative-parity images by one.

(d) Discuss why the SIE (being singular at the origin) requires care in applying Burke's theorem. What role does the central image play?

Verify with `problems_08.wl`.

Chapter 13

Strong Lensing by Galaxies: Applications

> *The Einstein radius is a most useful quantity to express the lensing strength of an object, and it is usually very robustly determined via strong lens models [...]. As a consequence, the mass enclosed in the cylinder of radius equal to the Einstein radius can be measured to within 1–2%, including all random and systematic uncertainties.* — T. Treu, *Ann. Rev. Astron. Astrophys.* **48**, 87 (2010)

In Chapters 11 and 12 we developed the theory and the lens models: the SIS, SIE, critical curves, caustics, and image configurations. These are the tools; we now apply them.

Galaxy-scale strong lensing addresses several basic questions of modern astrophysics: the total mass of a galaxy, since lensing measures the projected mass within the Einstein radius, including dark matter; the distribution of that mass, since combining lensing with stellar kinematics constrains the density profile slope; the expansion rate of the universe, since time delays between multiple images, combined with a lens model, yield H_0 independently of the cosmic distance ladder; and the limits of what lensing can tell us, since degeneracies, most notably the mass-sheet degeneracy, limit the information that lensing alone can provide. This chapter connects the lens modeling formalism to these applications. Understanding the degeneracies is as important as understanding the models themselves.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `galaxy_lensing.wl` computes the mass from the Einstein radius, demonstrates the mass-sheet degeneracy, analyses the power-law profile, derives H_0 from time delays, and generates all the figures of this chapter.
- `mass_sheet_demo.nb` is an interactive notebook with an MSD visualizer (slider for λ), a power-law profile explorer, and an H_0 estimator from time delays.

13.1 Lens Modeling Overview

Before applying lensing to astrophysics, we must understand what goes into building a lens model and what data constrain it.

13.1.1 Parametric Models: SIE + External Shear

The standard approach to modeling galaxy-scale strong lenses uses a *parametric* mass model. The standard choice is the singular isothermal ellipsoid (SIE, Chapter 12) plus external shear:

$$\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}\,\sqrt{q}}{2\sqrt{q^2\theta_1^2 + \theta_2^2}} \tag{13.1}$$

with an external shear $\gamma_{\rm ext}$ at position angle ϕ_γ. The model parameters are:

Parameter	Physical meaning
$\theta_{\rm E}$	Einstein radius (sets the mass scale)
q	Axis ratio (b/a, sets the ellipticity)
$\theta_{1,c}$, $\theta_{2,c}$	Lens center position
ϕ_q	Position angle of the mass distribution
$\gamma_{\rm ext}$	External shear magnitude
ϕ_γ	External shear position angle

This gives 7 lens parameters (or 5 if the center is fixed to the observed galaxy light). The source position $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (\beta_1, \beta_2)$ adds 2 more unknowns, for a total of 9 (or 7) free parameters.

13.1.2 What Data Constrain the Model

The observational constraints for a strong lens system are of four kinds. Each image position gives 2 constraints ($\theta_{1,i}$, $\theta_{2,i}$), so a quad system with 4 images gives 8 constraints. Each flux ratio gives 1 constraint (the ratio of magnifications), three independent ones for a quad. Each time delay gives 1 constraint, again three independent delays for a quad. Finally, if the source is extended (a galaxy rather than a quasar), the arc morphology provides many more constraints, effectively constraining the lens potential on a grid.

13.1.3 Degrees of Freedom

For a quad lens modeled with SIE + shear, the image positions alone give $4 \times 2 = 8$ constraints, the free parameters (with center fixed) number 7, and the degrees of freedom are $8 - 7 = 1$: the model is marginally constrained. Quad lenses are valuable for this reason; they provide just enough constraints to determine the SIE + shear model from astrometry alone. Double lenses ($2 \times 2 = 4$ constraints) are under-constrained for SIE + shear. Extended arcs provide many more constraints and can support more complex models.

13.1.4 Free-Form Models

An alternative to parametric models is *free-form* or *pixelated* modeling, where the lens potential is reconstructed on a grid without assuming a specific functional form. Programs like `PixeLens` (Saha & Williams 2004) and `GLASS` (Coles et al. 2014) take this approach. Free-form models are less biased by the assumed mass profile but have more degrees of freedom and thus require regularization or priors.

13.2 The Einstein Radius as a Mass Estimator

13.2.1 The Model-Independent Mass Measurement

The most important result in galaxy-scale strong lensing is that the Einstein radius directly gives the enclosed projected mass. For *any* circularly symmetric lens, the projected mass enclosed within the Einstein radius is (Congdon & Keeton eq. 7.9):

$$\boxed{M(\leq \theta_{\rm E}) = \pi\, \theta_{\rm E}^2\, D_{\rm d}^2\, \Sigma_{\rm cr}} \tag{13.2}$$

This follows from the definition of the Einstein radius as the angular radius where $\kappa_{\rm mean} = 1$, i.e., where the mean convergence within that radius equals unity. Recall that $\kappa = \Sigma/\Sigma_{\rm cr}$, so $\kappa_{\rm mean} = 1$ means the mean surface mass density within $\theta_{\rm E}$ equals the critical surface mass density. The enclosed mass is then the critical density times the area:

$$M_{\rm E} = \Sigma_{\rm cr} \times \pi (D_{\rm d}\, \theta_{\rm E})^2 = \pi\, \theta_{\rm E}^2\, D_{\rm d}^2\, \Sigma_{\rm cr}\,. \tag{13.3}$$

The critical surface mass density is (Chapter 8):

$$\Sigma_{\rm cr} = \frac{c^2}{4\pi G}\,\frac{D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm d}\, D_{\rm ds}}\,. \tag{13.4}$$

Substituting:

$$\boxed{M_{\rm E} = \frac{c^2}{4G}\,\theta_{\rm E}^2\,\frac{D_{\rm d}\, D_{\rm s}}{D_{\rm ds}}} \tag{13.5}$$

Remark 13.2.1. Equation (13.5) is model-independent for any circularly symmetric lens. It depends only on the observed Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$ and the angular diameter distances (which require knowing the redshifts z_d and z_s and adopting a cosmology). It does not depend on the radial mass profile, which is what makes strong lensing a reliable mass measurement tool.

13.2.2 The SIE Einstein Radius and Velocity Dispersion

For the SIE model, the Einstein radius is related to the velocity dispersion by (Chapter 11):

$$\boxed{\theta_{\rm E} = 4\pi\,\frac{\sigma_v^2}{c^2}\,\frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}}} \tag{13.6}$$

For a typical massive elliptical galaxy with $\sigma_v = 250$ km/s at $z_d = 0.3$ lensing a source at $z_s = 1.0$:

$$\theta_{\rm E} \approx 4\pi \left(\frac{250}{3\times 10^5}\right)^2 \frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}} \approx 4\pi \left(\frac{250}{3\times 10^5}\right)^2 \times 0.64 \approx 1.15''\,. \tag{13.7}$$

The enclosed mass is then $M_{\rm E} \sim 2$–$4 \times 10^{11}\, M_\odot$, comparable to the total stellar mass of the galaxy. The fact that $M_{\rm E}$ typically exceeds the stellar mass is direct evidence for dark matter within the Einstein radius.

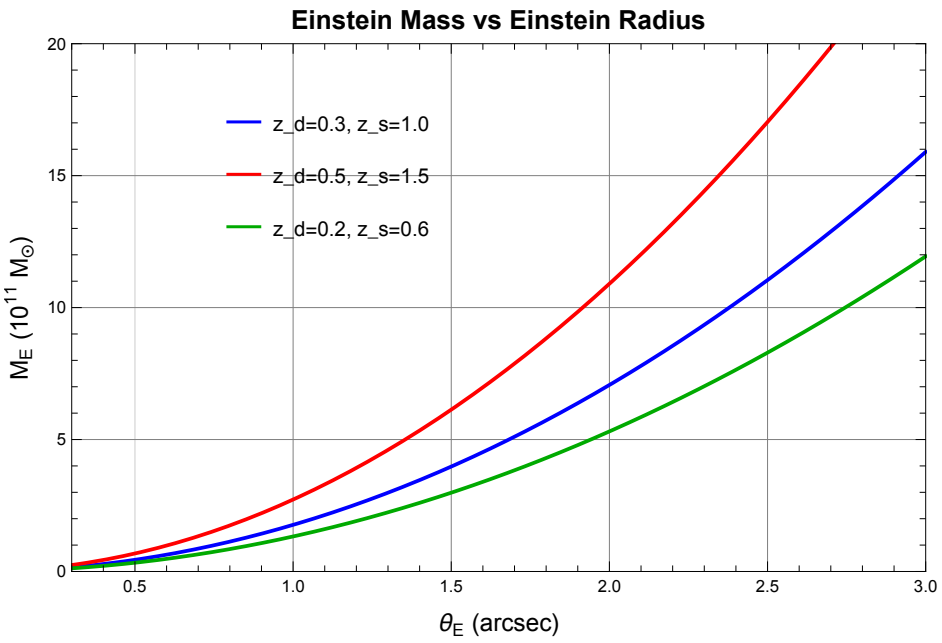


Figure 13.1: Enclosed Einstein mass M_{E} as a function of Einstein radius θ_{E} for three lens–source redshift configurations (flat ΛCDM, $H_0 = 70$ km/s/Mpc, $\Omega_{\mathrm{m}} = 0.3$). Higher redshift lenses enclose more mass for the same angular Einstein radius. Generated by `galaxy_lensing.wl`.

13.2.3 Numerical Examples with Real Systems

Figure 13.1 shows the enclosed mass as a function of Einstein radius for different lens–source redshift configurations.

Table 13.1 lists the Einstein radii and enclosed masses for several well-known lens systems:

System	z_d	z_s	θ_{E} (arcsec)	M_{E} ($10^{11}\,M_\odot$)	**Type**
Q0957+561	0.36	1.41	1.0	~ 1.9	Double
Q2237+0305	0.04	1.69	0.9	~ 0.2	Quad
B1608+656	0.63	1.39	1.0	~ 3.9	Quad

Table 13.1: Einstein radii and enclosed masses for three well-known lens systems. Masses computed using eq. (13.5) with a flat ΛCDM cosmology ($H_0 = 70$ km/s/Mpc, $\Omega_{\mathrm{m}} = 0.3$). Computed by `galaxy_lensing.wl`.

Remark 13.2.2. Q2237+0305 (the Einstein Cross) has an unusually small enclosed mass because the lens galaxy is very nearby ($z_d = 0.04$), so the physical Einstein radius is small even though the angular Einstein radius is nearly $1''$.

13.3 The Mass-Sheet Degeneracy

The *mass-sheet degeneracy* (MSD) is the most important systematic limitation of strong gravitational lensing. It cannot be broken by lensing data alone (image positions, flux ratios, or arc morphology).

13.3.1 The Mass-Sheet Transform

Consider a lens with convergence $\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta})$. The *mass-sheet transform* (MST) replaces this convergence with:

$$\boxed{\kappa_\lambda(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \lambda\,\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) + (1-\lambda)} \tag{13.8}$$

and simultaneously rescales the source plane:

$$\boxed{\boldsymbol{\beta}_\lambda = \lambda\,\boldsymbol{\beta}} \tag{13.9}$$

where λ is a free parameter.

The MST adds a uniform sheet of convergence $(1-\lambda)$ to the lens (hence the name "mass sheet") and rescales both the original convergence and the source plane by λ.

13.3.2 Image Positions Are Invariant

The defining property of the MST is that it preserves all image positions. To see this, recall the lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$. For the original lens, the deflection angle is related to the convergence via $\nabla \cdot \boldsymbol{\alpha} = 2\kappa$. Under the MST:

$$\boldsymbol{\alpha}_\lambda(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \lambda\,\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) + (1-\lambda)\,\boldsymbol{\theta}\,. \tag{13.10}$$

The new lens equation becomes:

$$\begin{aligned}
\boldsymbol{\beta}_\lambda &= \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}_\lambda(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \\
&= \boldsymbol{\theta} - \lambda\,\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) - (1-\lambda)\,\boldsymbol{\theta} \\
&= \lambda\,[\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})] \\
&= \lambda\,\boldsymbol{\beta}\,.
\end{aligned} \tag{13.11}$$

So if $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ satisfies the original lens equation for source position $\boldsymbol{\beta}$, it also satisfies the transformed lens equation for source position $\boldsymbol{\beta}_\lambda = \lambda\boldsymbol{\beta}$. The image positions are unchanged.

13.3.3 What the MST Changes

Although image positions are preserved, the MST changes other observables:

Magnifications. Under the MST the transformed convergence and deflection are

$$\kappa_\lambda(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \lambda\,\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) + (1-\lambda), \qquad \boldsymbol{\alpha}_\lambda(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \lambda\,\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) + (1-\lambda)\,\boldsymbol{\theta},$$

the second of which follows from the first via $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \nabla\psi$ and $\nabla^2\psi = 2\kappa$ (the $(1-\lambda)\boldsymbol{\theta}$ piece is the deflection of a uniform sheet of convergence $1-\lambda$, since $\nabla\cdot[(1-\lambda)\boldsymbol{\theta}] = 2(1-\lambda)$). The Jacobian then transforms componentwise:

$$(\mathcal{A}_\lambda)_{ij} \;=\; \delta_{ij} - \frac{\partial\alpha_{\lambda,i}}{\partial\theta_j} \;=\; \delta_{ij} - \lambda\,\frac{\partial\alpha_i}{\partial\theta_j} - (1-\lambda)\,\delta_{ij} \;=\; \lambda\left(\delta_{ij} - \frac{\partial\alpha_i}{\partial\theta_j}\right) \;=\; \lambda\,\mathcal{A}_{ij}\,.$$

That is, every entry of $\mathcal{A}$ scales by λ:

$$\mathcal{A}_\lambda = \lambda\,\mathcal{A}, \qquad \det\mathcal{A}_\lambda = \lambda^2\,\det\mathcal{A}, \tag{13.12}$$

so the magnification $\mu = 1/\det\mathcal{A}$ scales as

$$\boxed{\mu_\lambda = \frac{1}{\lambda^2}\,\mu\,.} \tag{13.13}$$

Individual magnifications change, but magnification ratios $\mu_i/\mu_j = \mu_{\lambda,i}/\mu_{\lambda,j}$ are preserved. Flux ratios therefore cannot distinguish between the original model and the MST-transformed model. Both steps are verified symbolically in `galaxy_lensing.wl`.

Time delays. The Fermat-potential difference between images, and therefore the model-predicted time delay for a given H_0, scales as:

$$\boxed{\Delta t_\lambda = \lambda\,\Delta t} \tag{13.14}$$

That is, an MST-transformed model with parameter λ produces a time delay λ times that of the original ($\lambda = 1$) model at the same H_0. But the observed Δt is fixed; to match that observation under the transformed model, the inferred H_0^{naive} that one computes from a $\lambda = 1$ (no-sheet) fit and the underlying "true" H_0^{true} that accounts for an actual sheet of parameter λ differ by:

$$\boxed{H_0^{\text{true}} \;=\; \lambda\,H_0^{\text{naive}} \quad\Longleftrightarrow\quad H_0^{\text{naive}} \;=\; H_0^{\text{true}}/\lambda\,.} \tag{13.15}$$

With an unmodeled positive mass sheet ($\lambda < 1$), the naive analysis therefore *overestimates* H_0, and including the sheet brings the inferred value *downward*. This is the direction in which TDCOSMO has explored [6]: relaxing the lens profile (equivalently, allowing $\lambda < 1$) shifts the time-delay H_0 from the H0LiCOW value $H_0 \approx 73.3\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$ toward the Planck CMB value $H_0 \approx 67.4\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$.

Remark 13.3.1. The MSD bears directly on time-delay cosmography. If we model a lens and infer H_0 from the time delay, the answer is degenerate with λ: any extra convergence (a true mass sheet, or unmodeled line-of-sight structure, or a profile that is *shallower* than assumed near the images) reduces H_0^{true} below H_0^{naive}. Breaking this degeneracy is the central challenge of modern time-delay cosmography.

13.3.4 Physical Interpretation

The mass-sheet transform can be interpreted in two ways. Taken literally, a uniform sheet of matter between the observer and the source (or at the lens redshift) adds convergence without changing image positions; in practice, line-of-sight structure (voids, filaments, galaxy groups along the line of sight) acts as an approximate mass sheet. Alternatively, even without an actual mass sheet, the MST reflects the fact that different radial mass profiles can produce the same image positions: steeper profiles can mimic shallower profiles plus a mass sheet.

Figure 13.2 illustrates the mass-sheet degeneracy: the left panel shows how the convergence profile changes for different λ, and the right panel shows how absolute magnifications scale as $1/\lambda^2$.

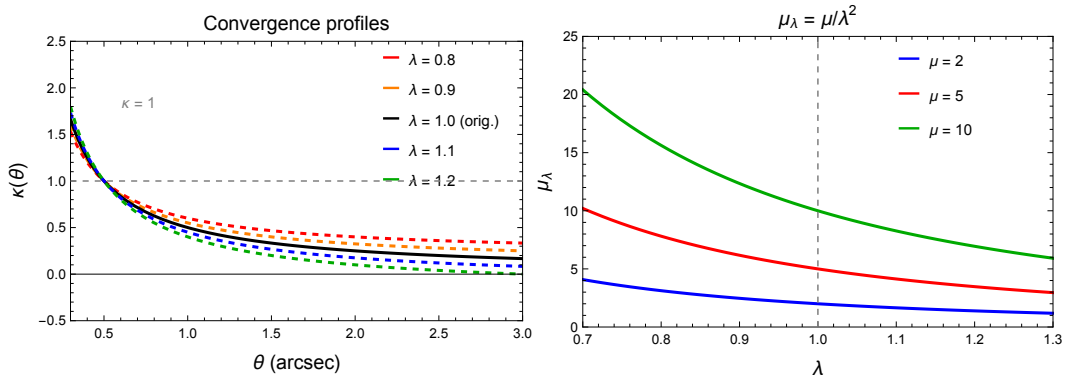


Figure 13.2: The mass-sheet degeneracy. **Left:** Convergence profiles for an SIS lens ($\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$) under the MST with different λ values. The solid curve is the original profile ($\lambda = 1$); dashed curves show the transformed profiles. Curves with $\lambda > 1$ correspond to a negative sheet, e.g. an underdense line of sight ($\kappa_{\rm ext} < 0$ in $\lambda = 1 - \kappa_{\rm ext}$). **Right:** Magnification scaling $\mu_\lambda = \mu/\lambda^2$ for three different original magnifications. Generated by `galaxy_lensing.wl`.

13.3.5 How to Break the MSD

Four kinds of information can break or constrain the mass-sheet degeneracy:

1. stellar kinematics: the velocity dispersion σ_v of the lens galaxy depends on the mass profile slope, not only on the enclosed mass, and a mass-sheet transform changes the predicted σ_v, so a kinematic measurement constrains λ (Section 13.5);

2. standardizable magnifications: if the source has a known intrinsic luminosity (e.g., a Type Ia supernova), the absolute magnification can be measured, which breaks the MSD;

3. multiple source planes: if the same lens produces images of sources at different redshifts, the different $\Sigma_{\rm cr}$ values for each source plane break the degeneracy;

4. extended source reconstruction: detailed modeling of extended arcs constrains the lens potential more tightly and partially (though not completely) breaks the degeneracy.

13.4 The Source Position Transformation

The mass-sheet degeneracy is a special case of a more general class of transformations that preserve image positions.

13.4.1 Definition

The *source position transformation* (SPT), introduced by Schneider & Sluse (2014), is any invertible mapping of the source plane:

$$\boldsymbol{\beta} \to \hat{\boldsymbol{\beta}}(\boldsymbol{\beta}) \tag{13.16}$$

that, when combined with a suitably modified lens equation, preserves all image positions. The modified lens equation is:

$$\hat{\boldsymbol{\beta}}(\boldsymbol{\beta}) = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \tag{13.17}$$

where the new deflection field $\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$ is defined by the requirement that all observed image positions map to the transformed source position $\hat{\boldsymbol{\beta}}$.

The MST is the special case where $\hat{\boldsymbol{\beta}} = \lambda\boldsymbol{\beta}$ (a linear scaling). The SPT generalizes this to arbitrary nonlinear remappings of the source plane.

13.4.2 Implications

The SPT is an active area of research because it defines the full class of degeneracies in strong lensing. Not all SPTs correspond to physically valid lens models, since the transformed deflection field may not come from a non-negative mass distribution. The SPT preserves image positions and flux ratios, as the MST does, but generically changes absolute magnifications and time delays. Breaking it generally requires external information (kinematics, multiple source planes, or standardizable sources), as for the MST.

Remark 13.4.1. The SPT shows that the mass-sheet degeneracy is not a peculiarity of a specific transform but rather the simplest member of a broad family of degeneracies inherent in the lensing inverse problem. Any attempt to measure H_0 from time delays must confront this limitation.

13.5 Strong Lensing and Stellar Kinematics

Combining strong lensing with stellar kinematics is among the most productive approaches to galaxy mass distributions, because the two techniques are complementary.

13.5.1 What Each Technique Measures

Strong lensing: Measures the total projected mass (dark matter + stars + gas) within the Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$. The measurement is model-independent for a circularly symmetric lens (eq. 13.5). For an elliptical model, the enclosed mass depends weakly on the assumed axis ratio but is still robust.

Stellar kinematics: The stellar velocity dispersion σ_v of the lens galaxy, measured from absorption line broadening, probes the gravitational potential. Specifically, under the assumption of dynamical equilibrium (the Jeans equation), the luminosity-weighted line-of-sight velocity dispersion within an aperture $R_{\rm ap}$ depends on the mass profile slope (how mass is distributed radially), on the total mass normalization, and on the orbital anisotropy of the stellar orbits.

13.5.2 The Power-Law Mass Profile

The simplest model with the required freedom is a *spherical power-law* density profile:

$$\boxed{\rho(r) = \rho_0 \left(\frac{r}{r_0}\right)^{-\gamma'}} \tag{13.18}$$

where γ' is the power-law slope. The isothermal case is $\gamma' = 2$ (i.e., $\rho \propto r^{-2}$).

Figure 13.3 shows convergence profiles and enclosed mass scalings for power-law density profiles with different slopes.

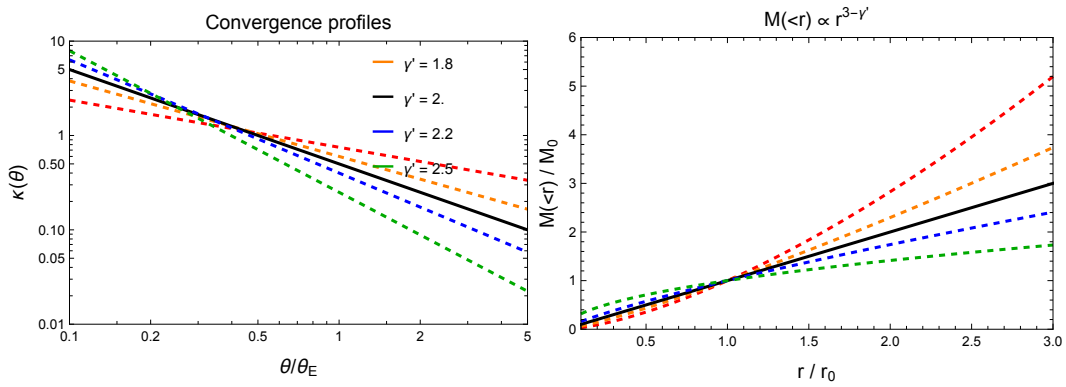


Figure 13.3: Power-law density profiles $\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$. **Left:** Convergence profiles for different slopes (the solid curve is the isothermal case $\gamma' = 2$). **Right:** Enclosed 3D mass $M(\leq r) \propto r^{3-\gamma'}$ for the same slopes. Generated by `galaxy_lensing.wl`.

The convergence follows from the line-of-sight projection. Writing $r = \sqrt{\xi^2 + z^2}$,

$$\Sigma(\xi) \;=\; \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \rho_0 \left(\frac{\sqrt{\xi^2+z^2}}{r_0}\right)^{-\gamma'} dz \;=\; 2\rho_0\, r_0^{\gamma'}\, \xi^{1-\gamma'} \int_0^{\infty} (1+u^2)^{-\gamma'/2}\, du \qquad (u = z/\xi).$$

The remaining integral is a Beta function:

$$\int_0^{\infty} (1+u^2)^{-\gamma'/2}\, du \;=\; \frac{1}{2}\, B\!\left(\frac{1}{2}, \frac{\gamma'-1}{2}\right) \;=\; \frac{\sqrt{\pi}}{2}\, \frac{\Gamma\!\left(\frac{\gamma'-1}{2}\right)}{\Gamma\!\left(\frac{\gamma'}{2}\right)},$$

finite for $\gamma' > 1$. Hence $\Sigma(\xi) \propto \xi^{1-\gamma'}$ and, using $\xi = D_{\rm d}\theta$ and dividing by $\Sigma_{\rm cr}$, the convergence has the same exponent. A short computation that fixes the overall normalization by requiring

the mean convergence inside $\theta_{\rm E}$ to be unity, $\bar{\kappa}(\theta_{\rm E}) = 1$ (which for $\gamma' = 2$ returns the SIS), gives

$$\kappa(\theta) \;=\; \frac{3-\gamma'}{2}\left(\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta}\right)^{\gamma'-1}, \tag{13.19}$$

valid for $1 < \gamma' < 3$ (finite projection, finite enclosed mass). The projection integral and the normalization are verified in `galaxy_lensing.wl`. The Einstein radius is

$$\theta_{\rm E} = 4\pi\,\frac{\sigma_{\rm SIE}^2}{c^2}\,\frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}}\,f(\gamma') \tag{13.20}$$

where $f(\gamma')$ is a function of the slope that equals unity for $\gamma' = 2$ (recovering the SIE result) and $\sigma_{\rm SIE}$ is the SIE-equivalent velocity dispersion.

13.5.3 Breaking the Degeneracy

Lensing and kinematics respond differently to the mass profile slope γ'. Lensing constrains the projected mass within $\theta_{\rm E}$; for a power-law profile the enclosed mass $M_{\rm E}$ depends on the normalization ρ_0 and the slope γ' in a specific way. Kinematics constrains the mass within the spectroscopic aperture (typically a different physical radius than $R_{\rm E}$), and the predicted σ_v^2 depends on γ' differently from how $M_{\rm E}$ does. By measuring both $M_{\rm E}$ (from lensing) and σ_v (from spectroscopy), one can therefore solve for both the mass normalization and the slope γ'. This breaks the mass-sheet degeneracy because the MST changes the effective γ': steepening or shallowing the profile to compensate for the added mass sheet.

13.5.4 The Bulge-Halo Conspiracy

A notable result from combining lensing and kinematics is the *bulge-halo conspiracy*: the total (dark matter + stellar) density profiles of massive elliptical galaxies are close to isothermal over a wide range of radii:

$$\gamma' \approx 2.0 \pm 0.2 \tag{13.21}$$

This result, established by the SLACS survey (Auger et al. 2010) and confirmed by subsequent studies, means that the combined contribution of the stellar bulge (which has a steeper profile, $\gamma' \sim 3$) and the dark matter halo (which has a shallower inner profile, $\gamma' \sim 1$ for NFW) conspire to produce an approximately r^{-2} total density profile.

Figure 13.4 shows how the predicted velocity dispersion varies with γ' for a fixed Einstein mass, illustrating how kinematics breaks the degeneracy.

This "conspiracy" is not fully understood theoretically and remains an active area of research. It implies that the SIE ($\gamma' = 2$) is a good approximation for most galaxy-scale lenses; the small scatter in γ' suggests a universal mass assembly process for massive ellipticals; and it connects directly to the flat rotation curves observed in spiral galaxies, both being consequences of $\rho \propto r^{-2}$.

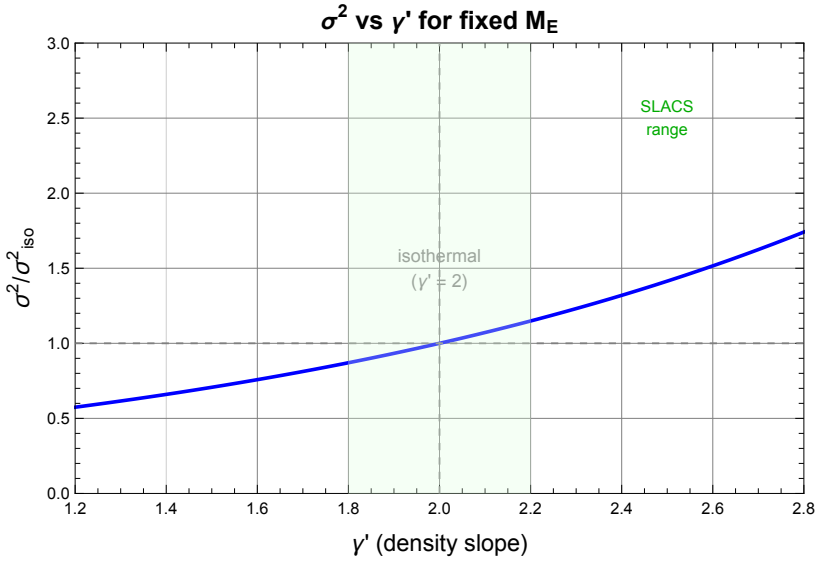


Figure 13.4: Predicted σ_v^2 (normalized to the isothermal value) as a function of the density slope γ', for fixed Einstein mass. The green band shows the range found by the SLACS survey ($\gamma' \approx 2.0 \pm 0.2$). Measuring σ_v constrains γ' and breaks the mass-sheet degeneracy. Generated by `galaxy_lensing.wl`.

13.6 Time-Delay Cosmography

Strong lens time delays offer a one-step measurement of H_0, independent of the cosmic distance ladder.

13.6.1 Recap: Time Delays and H_0

From Chapter 10, the time delay between images A and B of a strongly lensed variable source is:

$$\Delta t_{AB} = \frac{1 + z_d}{c} \frac{D_\mathrm{d}\, D_\mathrm{s}}{D_\mathrm{ds}} \left[\Delta\tau_{AB}\right] \tag{13.22}$$

where $\Delta\tau_{AB}$ is the Fermat potential difference (computed from the lens model) and the combination $(1 + z_d) D_\mathrm{d} D_\mathrm{s} / D_\mathrm{ds}$ is called the *time-delay distance* $D_{\Delta t}$, so that $\Delta t_{AB} = D_{\Delta t}\, \Delta\tau_{AB} / c$. (Some texts call $D_\mathrm{d} D_\mathrm{s} / D_\mathrm{ds}$ alone $D_{\Delta t}$ and write $(1 + z_d)$ separately; the delay is the same either way.) The decisive property is that

$$D_{\Delta t} \propto \frac{1}{H_0} \tag{13.23}$$

so measuring Δt (from monitoring the variable source) and modeling $\Delta\tau$ (from the lens model) gives H_0.

13.6.2 The H0LiCOW / TDCOSMO Program

The most extensive application of this method is the H0LiCOW (H0 Lenses in COSMOGRAIL's Wellspring) program and its successor TDCOSMO, which have analyzed six well-

studied time-delay lenses.

The headline result from Wong et al. (2020), assuming power-law mass profiles:

$$\boxed{H_0 = 73.3^{+1.7}_{-1.8}\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}} \tag{13.24}$$

at 2.4% precision. This value is in 3.1σ tension with the Planck CMB measurement (Planck Collaboration 2020):

$$H_0^{\mathrm{Planck}} = 67.4 \pm 0.5\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}} \tag{13.25}$$

and agrees well with the local distance ladder value from SH0ES (Riess et al. 2022):

$$H_0^{\mathrm{SH0ES}} = 73.0 \pm 1.0\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}\,. \tag{13.26}$$

Figure 13.5 illustrates the effect of the mass-sheet degeneracy on the inferred H_0.

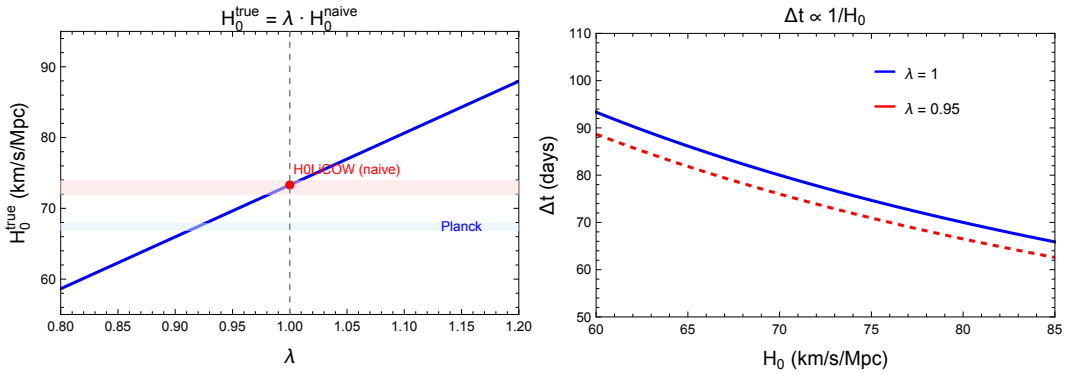


Figure 13.5: Time-delay cosmography and the mass-sheet degeneracy. **Left:** Inferred H_0 as a function of the MST parameter λ, showing the H0LiCOW measurement (red point) and the Planck and SH0ES bands. **Right:** Time delay vs. H_0 for $\lambda = 1$ (solid) and $\lambda = 0.95$ (dashed). Generated by `galaxy_lensing.wl`.

13.6.3 The Role of the Mass-Sheet Degeneracy

The mass-sheet degeneracy is the dominant systematic uncertainty in time-delay cosmography. From eq. (13.15):

$$H_0^{\mathrm{true}} = \lambda\, H_0^{\mathrm{naive}} \tag{13.27}$$

where H_0^{naive} is the H_0 inferred from a no-sheet ($\lambda = 1$) power-law fit and H_0^{true} is the actual cosmological value; since $\lambda < 1$ for an unmodeled positive mass sheet, $H_0^{\mathrm{true}} < H_0^{\mathrm{naive}}$. A 10% mass sheet ($\lambda = 0.9$, i.e., adding $\kappa_s = 0.1$ to the convergence) gives $H_0^{\mathrm{true}} = 0.9\, H_0^{\mathrm{naive}}$: the inferred value moves 10% downward (equivalently, the naive value is 11% too high).

The TDCOSMO collaboration (Birrer et al. 2020) showed that relaxing the assumption of a power-law mass profile (which partially encodes λ) broadens the uncertainty to:

$$H_0 = 74.5^{+5.6}_{-6.1}\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}} \tag{13.28}$$

which is still consistent with the local value but with much larger uncertainty. The increased uncertainty is almost entirely due to the mass-sheet degeneracy.

Constraining λ requires external information, primarily stellar kinematics of the lens galaxies (Section 13.5).

13.6.4 Current State and Future Prospects

The time-delay cosmography method is one of the independent routes in the Hubble tension debate. Upcoming surveys (Rubin Observatory/LSST, Euclid) will discover thousands of new lensed quasars, enabling a statistical approach that can average over individual modeling uncertainties. Combined with improved stellar kinematics from next-generation spectrographs, the method has the potential to reach $\sim$1% precision on H_0.

13.7 Real Lens Systems: Case Studies

13.7.1 Q0957+561: The First Gravitational Lens

Discovered by Walsh, Carswell & Weymann in 1979, Q0957+561 was the first confirmed strong gravitational lens. It is a double, two images of a $z_s = 1.41$ quasar, lensed by a giant elliptical galaxy at $z_d = 0.36$ that sits in a galaxy cluster, with Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E} \approx 1.0''$. The time delay is $\Delta t = 417 \pm 3$ days (optical monitoring; Kundić et al. 1997; see 43, Part 1, p. 12). The system confirmed Einstein's prediction of multiple imaging by galaxies, and its long time delay was the first used for H_0 estimation (Refsdal's method).

13.7.2 Q2237+0305: The Einstein Cross

Q2237+0305 is a quad: four images of a $z_s = 1.69$ quasar arranged in a near-perfect Einstein cross around the nucleus of a nearby, face-on barred spiral galaxy at $z_d = 0.04$ (Huchra's Lens), the nearest known strong lens galaxy, with $\theta_{\rm E} \approx 0.9''$. Because the lens is so nearby, the Einstein radius corresponds to a very small physical radius (~ 0.7 kpc), probing deep into the bulge of the spiral galaxy, and the system shows strong microlensing variability as individual stars in the lens galaxy cross the lines of sight to the quasar images. The time delays are very short ($\lesssim 1$ day) because of the symmetric geometry, which makes the system unsuitable for H_0 measurement but ideal for microlensing studies.

13.7.3 B1608+656: Time-Delay Cosmography

B1608+656 is one of the best-studied time-delay lenses: a quad, four images of a $z_s = 1.39$ radio source, lensed by two interacting galaxies at $z_d = 0.63$, with $\theta_{\rm E} \approx 1.0''$. Three independent delays have been measured with $\sim$1–2% precision from radio monitoring, and the system is one of the six TDCOSMO/H0LiCOW lenses used to constrain H_0; the lens modeling is more complex than usual because of the two-galaxy lens configuration. Deep HST imaging resolves the lensed host galaxy of the radio source, providing extended arc constraints that considerably tighten the lens model.

13.8 Substructure and Flux-Ratio Anomalies

Everything so far has treated the lens as a *smooth* mass distribution. But ΛCDM predicts that galaxy haloes are lumpy: N-body simulations produce far more low-mass subhaloes than the number of luminous satellites we observe (the "missing satellites" problem), with of order a few percent of the projected mass near the images bound in substructure [43, Part 2, §8]. Strong lensing offers a way to weigh this *dark* substructure.

13.8.1 The Flux-Ratio Anomaly

Lens models that fit the image *positions* of a quad to milliarcsecond precision routinely fail to reproduce the image *flux ratios*. For a source straddling a fold or cusp of the caustic, smooth models make sharp predictions (e.g. the cusp relation, that the signed magnifications of the three merging images of a cusp image sum to zero), and real systems (the classic case is the radio quad B1422+231) violate them. Optical flux ratios can be corrupted by microlensing (Chapter 17) and dust; but *radio* flux ratios are largely immune to both, and they are anomalous just the same.

13.8.2 Why Flux Ratios Probe Low-Mass Substructure

What matters is how many derivatives of the potential each observable requires. For virialized objects $M \propto \sigma_v^4$ and $R \propto \sigma_v^2$, so time delays $\propto \psi \propto M \propto \sigma_v^4$ are unaffected by low-mass substructure; deflections $\propto \nabla\psi \propto \sigma_v^2$ are perturbed only by *massive* substructure; and magnifications, $\kappa, \gamma \propto \nabla^2\psi \propto \sigma_v^0$, are perturbed *equally by all mass scales*. Flux ratios (magnifications) are therefore uniquely sensitive to the low-mass end of the substructure spectrum, exactly where CDM and warm dark matter differ. A further diagnostic is that substructure preferentially *demagnifies saddle-point* images relative to minima [43, Part 2, §8]. Applying a Bayesian analysis to a sample of radio quads, Dalal & Kochanek found a substructure mass fraction $f_{\rm sat} \approx 0.02$ (90% confidence 0.006–0.07), consistent with CDM and far above the luminous-satellite fraction. Modern work extends this with *gravitational imaging*, the detection of individual dark subhaloes through their astrometric perturbations of extended arcs, turning flux-ratio and arc anomalies into a probe of the small-scale matter power spectrum.

13.9 Extended Sources and Einstein-Ring Reconstruction

Real sources are extended, and their lensed images, arcs and Einstein rings, carry far more information than a handful of point images. The basic fact is that gravitational lensing conserves surface brightness:

$$f_I(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = f_S(\boldsymbol{\beta}(\boldsymbol{\theta})), \tag{13.29}$$

so what we call "magnification" is only the apparent brightening that follows from the image subtending a larger solid angle than the source; the intrinsic surface brightness is unchanged [43, Part 2, §10].

13.9.1 The Einstein Ring as a Pattern

An Einstein ring is not a set of discrete images but a *pattern*: the locus of peak surface brightness along radial spokes from the lens centre. For an isothermal lens with arbitrary angular structure, $\psi = b\,\theta\,F(\varphi)$ with $\langle F\rangle = 1$, the tangential critical curve sits at

$$\frac{r_{\rm crit}}{b} = F(\varphi) + F''(\varphi), \tag{13.30}$$

while, for a compact source offset by $\boldsymbol{\beta}_0$ from the lens centre, the ring curve is

$$\frac{r_E(\varphi)}{b} = F(\varphi) + \boldsymbol{\beta}_0 \cdot \hat{e}_\theta \tag{13.31}$$

[Kochanek, Keeton & McLeod 2001; see 43, Part 2, eq. 141]. The consequence is that the *angular shape* of the ring directly reads off the multipoles $F(\varphi)$ of the lens potential (§12.4 of Chapter 12): the even multipoles of the ring encode the lens, the odd multipoles the source. Rings thus break the angular degeneracies that a two-image lens cannot constrain, though they pin down the *radial* profile only weakly (the dependence scales as $|\Delta\beta|^4$).

13.9.2 Source Reconstruction

To use every pixel of an arc, one reconstructs the source. Because surface brightness is conserved, every image-plane pixel maps to a source position $\boldsymbol{\beta}(\boldsymbol{\theta}, \mathbf{p})$ for lens parameters $\mathbf{p}$; in a *correct* model all image pixels mapping to the same source pixel share a surface brightness, while an incorrect model scatters them. Minimizing that scatter, the "Ring Cycle" idea, now realized as regularized linear (semilinear) inversion onto a pixel or adaptive grid, underlies modern pipelines such as `PyAutoLens` and the SLaM framework used in surveys like AGEL. This is the practical engine behind galaxy-scale mass measurements and the source-plane reconstructions of high-redshift galaxies.

13.10 External Convergence and Lens Environments

No lens is isolated. Mass in the lens's group or cluster, and uncorrelated structure along the line of sight, contribute an *external convergence* $\kappa_{\rm ext}$ that is nearly uniform across the image region, i.e. a mass sheet. As we saw in §13.3, a uniform sheet leaves the image positions and flux ratios unchanged (it is the physical realization of the mass-sheet transform with $\lambda = 1 - \kappa_{\rm ext}$), but it rescales an inferred Hubble constant,

$$H_0^{\rm true} = (1 - \kappa_{\rm ext})\, H_0^{\rm naive}, \tag{13.32}$$

exactly as in Eq. (13.15). Estimating $\kappa_{\rm ext}$, typically a few percent, from the photometric and spectroscopic weighting of the lens field, calibrated against numerical line-of-sight simulations, is a necessary step in time-delay cosmography [6, 50].

13.10.1 Dust and the Interstellar Medium of the Lens

A more mundane environmental effect is the interstellar medium of the lens galaxy. Differential extinction reddens and dims the optical and near-infrared images that pass through different lines of sight in the lens, corrupting optical flux ratios (and biasing colours) in a strongly wavelength-dependent way [43, Part 2, §9]. This is a principal reason the substructure studies of §13.8 rely on *radio* flux ratios, which are effectively dust-free, and a reminder that a clean lensing measurement must always account for the baryonic astrophysics of the deflector.

13.11 Summary

The Einstein radius provides a model-independent measurement of the enclosed projected mass, $M_{\rm E} = \pi\theta_{\rm E}^2 D_{\rm d}^2 \Sigma_{\rm cr}$; for typical galaxy-scale lenses this mass is 10^{11}–$10^{12}\,M_\odot$. The standard parametric lens model is the SIE with external shear, with 7 parameters; quad lenses provide 8 positional constraints, which marginally determine the model. The mass-sheet degeneracy (MST: $\kappa \to \lambda\kappa + (1-\lambda)$, $\boldsymbol{\beta} \to \lambda\boldsymbol{\beta}$) preserves all image positions but changes magnifications by $1/\lambda^2$ and time delays by λ, and it is the dominant systematic for time-delay cosmography. The source position transformation (Schneider & Sluse 2014) generalizes the MST to arbitrary remappings $\boldsymbol{\beta} \to \hat{\boldsymbol{\beta}}(\boldsymbol{\beta})$ of the source plane.

Lensing combined with kinematics breaks the MSD by constraining the density profile slope γ'; the SLACS survey found $\gamma' \approx 2.0 \pm 0.2$ (the "bulge-halo conspiracy"). Time-delay cosmography measures H_0 via $\Delta t \propto D_{\Delta t} \propto 1/H_0$; the H0LiCOW/TDCOSMO result is $H_0 = 73.3^{+1.7}_{-1.8}$ km/s/Mpc, in tension with Planck. The case studies of this chapter are Q0957+561 (the first lens, 1979), Q2237+0305 (the Einstein Cross, a microlensing laboratory), and B1608+656 (time-delay cosmography).

13.12 Problems

Exercise 13.12.1. (Enclosed mass for an SIE lens.) Consider an SIE lens with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1.5''$, axis ratio $q = 0.8$, lens redshift $z_d = 0.3$, and source redshift $z_s = 1.0$. Assume a flat ΛCDM cosmology with $H_0 = 70$ km/s/Mpc and $\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$.

(a) Compute the angular diameter distances $D_{\rm d}$, $D_{\rm s}$, and $D_{\rm ds}$.

(b) Compute the critical surface mass density $\Sigma_{\rm cr}$.

(c) Compute the enclosed projected mass $M_{\rm E}$ using eq. (13.5). Express the result in solar masses.

(d) Estimate the velocity dispersion σ_v that would correspond to this Einstein radius using eq. (13.6).

Verify with `problems_09.wl`.

Exercise 13.12.2. (Mass-sheet degeneracy: invariance and observables.) Consider a general lens with convergence $\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ and a source at $\boldsymbol{\beta}$.

(a) Apply the mass-sheet transform $\kappa_\lambda = \lambda\kappa + (1-\lambda)$ and $\boldsymbol{\beta}_\lambda = \lambda\boldsymbol{\beta}$. Show explicitly that the lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta}_\lambda = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}_\lambda(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ is satisfied at the same image positions $\boldsymbol{\theta}$.

(b) Show that the Jacobian matrix transforms as $\mathcal{A}_\lambda = \lambda\,\mathcal{A}$ and hence the magnification transforms as $\mu_\lambda = \mu/\lambda^2$.

(c) Show that magnification *ratios* μ_i/μ_j are invariant under the MST.

(d) Using the Fermat potential, show that time delays transform as $\Delta t_\lambda = \lambda\,\Delta t$.

Verify with `problems_09.wl`.

Exercise 13.12.3. (H_0 from a time-delay lens.) A quad lens at $z_d = 0.6$, $z_s = 1.5$ has a measured time delay $\Delta t = 80$ days between two images. The lens model predicts a Fermat potential difference $\Delta\tau = 0.64$ arcsec^2.

(a) Write the time-delay equation (eq. 13.22) and solve for H_0.

(b) Compute H_0 numerically, assuming a flat ΛCDM cosmology with $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$ and using the angular diameter distances at the given redshifts. *(Hint: the time-delay distance $D_{\Delta t} = (1+z_d)D_\mathrm{d}D_\mathrm{s}/D_\mathrm{ds}$ depends on H_0, so you will need to solve self-consistently or use H_0-independent distance ratios.)*

(c) Discuss: if the true lens includes a mass sheet with $\kappa_s = 0.05$ (i.e., $\lambda = 0.95$) that was not accounted for in the model, how would the inferred H_0 change?

Verify with `problems_09.wl`.

Exercise 13.12.4. (Power-law profile: lensing and kinematics.) Consider a spherical power-law density profile $\rho(r) = \rho_0(r/r_0)^{-\gamma'}$.

(a) Compute the projected surface mass density $\Sigma(\theta)$ by integrating ρ along the line of sight. Show that $\kappa(\theta) \propto \theta^{1-\gamma'}$.

(b) For $\gamma' = 2$ (isothermal), verify that you recover $\kappa \propto 1/\theta$ (the SIS).

(c) The luminosity-weighted line-of-sight velocity dispersion for an isotropic power-law profile is (Treu & Koopmans 2004):

$$\sigma_v^2 \propto M(\leq R_\mathrm{ap}) \cdot R_\mathrm{ap}^{-1} \cdot g(\gamma')$$

where $g(\gamma')$ is a known function of the slope. Argue that σ_v depends on γ' differently from M_E, so combining the two measurements constrains γ'.

(d) For a lens at $z_d = 0.3$, $z_s = 1.0$ (flat ΛCDM, $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$) with $\theta_\mathrm{E} = 1.2''$ and $\sigma_v = 230$ km/s, compare σ_v with the isothermal (SIS) prediction for this θ_E. What would it take to turn the ratio into a value of γ'? Discuss whether the result is consistent with the "bulge-halo conspiracy" ($\gamma' \approx 2.0$).

Verify with `problems_09.wl`.

Exercise 13.12.5. (Comparing real lens systems.) Consider the three lens systems in Table 13.1: Q0957+561 ($z_d = 0.36$, $z_s = 1.41$, $\theta_{\rm E} = 1.0''$), Q2237+0305 ($z_d = 0.04$, $z_s = 1.69$, $\theta_{\rm E} = 0.9''$), and B1608+656 ($z_d = 0.63$, $z_s = 1.39$, $\theta_{\rm E} = 1.0''$).

(a) For each system, compute the angular diameter distances $D_{\rm d}$, $D_{\rm s}$, $D_{\rm ds}$ and the critical surface mass density $\Sigma_{\rm cr}$.

(b) Compute the enclosed projected mass $M_{\rm E}$ for each system.

(c) Compute the physical Einstein radius $R_{\rm E} = D_{\rm d}\,\theta_{\rm E}$ in kpc for each system.

(d) Which system has the largest enclosed mass? Which has the largest physical Einstein radius? Discuss why the rankings are different.

Verify with `problems_09.wl`.

Chapter 14

Strong Lensing by Galaxy Clusters

> *In the hierarchical model of structure formation, galaxy clusters are the largest and the youngest structures in the universe. They form through the assembly of smaller-scale structures, and for this reason, they are often observed during mergers.* — M. Meneghetti, *Introduction to Gravitational Lensing* (2021), Sect. 5.7

This chapter, the last of Part III, brings together the entire gravitational lensing framework developed in Chapters 1–13 and applies it to galaxy clusters. Where a single galaxy lens (Chapter 13) typically produces two or four images of a background source with an Einstein radius of $\sim 1''$, a massive galaxy cluster can produce dozens of multiple image systems, giant arcs with length-to-width ratios exceeding 10:1, and Einstein radii of $\sim 10''$–$50''$.

Galaxy clusters have total masses of 10^{14}–$10^{15}\,M_\odot$, with $\sim 85\%$ in dark matter, $\sim 13\%$ in hot intracluster gas, and only $\sim 2\%$ in stars. Their mass distributions are well-described by the NFW profile introduced in Chapter 11, now applied at scales 100–1000 times more massive than individual galaxy halos. The richness of cluster lensing, with many image systems at multiple source redshifts, provides tight constraints on the dark matter distribution and on cosmological parameters.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `cluster_lensing.wl` computes the NFW cluster lensing quantities, the critical curves and caustics at cluster scale, ray-tracing through the cluster potential to generate arcs, and the Einstein radius as a function of cluster mass; the figures are exported to `Figures/10_Cluster_Lensing/`.
- `nfw_cluster.nb` is an interactive notebook with `Manipulate` widgets for the NFW cluster parameters, giant arc formation, magnification maps, and weak lensing shear profiles.

14.1 Introduction: Why Cluster Lensing Is Special

Galaxy clusters occupy a special place in both astrophysics and gravitational lensing. They are the largest objects in the universe whose properties are determined by gravity alone; they sit at the top of the hierarchy of cosmic structure. Their masses make them the

strongest gravitational lenses, and they produce phenomena that are qualitatively different from galaxy-scale lensing.

Extended background galaxies are stretched into giant luminous arcs tens of arcseconds long, tracing out the tangential critical curve of the cluster potential; the first giant arcs were discovered independently by Lynds & Petrosian (1986) and Soucail et al. (1987), and the gravitational lensing interpretation was confirmed spectroscopically by Soucail et al. (1988). A single massive cluster can produce 10–30 or more distinct sets of multiple images, each from a different background galaxy at a different redshift, and each set independently constrains the cluster mass model. Magnification factors of $\mu \sim 10$–100 are common near the critical curves of clusters, which turns them into "gravitational telescopes" that reveal galaxies and even individual stars at redshifts $z > 6$ that would otherwise be undetectable. Because clusters are dark-matter dominated, their lensing signal directly probes the dark matter distribution: its radial profile, substructure, and overall mass. Finally, the abundance and properties of cluster lenses depend on cosmological parameters ($\Omega_{\rm m}$, σ_8, the dark energy equation of state), which makes cluster lensing a tool for precision cosmology.

14.2 NFW Model for Cluster Lensing

In Chapter 11 (Section 11.6) we introduced the NFW density profile as the universal dark matter halo profile. Here we apply it at cluster scale, where the relevant parameters are much larger than for galaxy halos.

14.2.1 Cluster-Scale NFW Parameters

The NFW profile (eq. 11.35) is parametrized by the virial mass M_{200} and concentration $c = r_{200}/r_s$. Typical values for galaxy clusters are:

Parameter	Galaxy halo	Cluster halo
M_{200}	$10^{12}\,M_\odot$	10^{14}–$10^{15}\,M_\odot$
c	10–20	3–8
r_s	15–30 kpc	200–500 kpc
r_{200}	200–300 kpc	1–2 Mpc

The main difference is that clusters are less concentrated ($c \sim 3$–8) than galaxy halos ($c \sim 10$–20), reflecting their later formation epoch in the hierarchical structure formation scenario. Despite the lower concentration, the vastly greater mass more than compensates, producing far stronger lensing.

14.2.2 Lensing Quantities at Cluster Scale

The NFW convergence, deflection angle, and shear from Chapter 11 (eqs. 11.47–11.54) apply directly. We collect the formulae here for reference. Define $x = \theta/\theta_s$, where $\theta_s = r_s/D_{\rm d}$ is the

angular scale radius. Then:

$$\kappa(x) = \kappa_s \, f(x) \,, \tag{14.1}$$

$$\alpha(x) = \frac{2\kappa_s \, \theta_s}{x} \left[\ln \frac{x}{2} + g(x) \right] \,, \tag{14.2}$$

$$\bar{\kappa}(x) = \frac{2\kappa_s}{x^2} \left[\ln \frac{x}{2} + g(x) \right] \,, \qquad |\gamma(x)| = \bar{\kappa}(x) - \kappa(x) \,, \tag{14.3}$$

with the functions $f(x)$ and $g(x)$ defined in eqs. (11.46)–(11.52), and the characteristic convergence:

$$\kappa_s = \frac{2\rho_s \, r_s}{\Sigma_{\rm cr}} \,. \tag{14.4}$$

Example 14.2.1. Characteristic convergence for a massive cluster. For a cluster with $M_{200} = 10^{15} \, M_\odot$, $c = 5$, at $z_d = 0.3$ lensing a source at $z_s = 2$ ($D_{\rm d} \approx 919$ Mpc, $D_{\rm s} \approx 1727$ Mpc, $D_{\rm ds} \approx 1328$ Mpc, from Chapter 7), $r_{200} \approx 1.86$ Mpc and $r_s = r_{200}/c \approx 372$ kpc, so that $\theta_s = r_s / D_{\rm d} \approx 84''$ and $\kappa_s \approx 0.51$. The local convergence $\kappa = \kappa_s f(x)$ exceeds unity for $x \lesssim 0.11$ (i.e., $\theta \lesssim 9''$), and the mean convergence $\bar{\kappa}$ reaches unity at $x \approx 0.18$ ($\theta \approx 15''$), so the cluster has a central region of super-critical convergence and is therefore a strong lens. These values are computed and verified in `cluster_lensing.wl`.

14.2.3 Critical Curves and Caustics for Cluster NFW

For the circularly symmetric NFW profile, the tangential and radial critical curves are circles. The tangential critical curve occurs where $\bar{\kappa}(x) = 1$, i.e.:

$$\frac{2\kappa_s}{x_t^2} \left[\ln \frac{x_t}{2} + g(x_t) \right] = 1 \,, \tag{14.5}$$

and the radial critical curve where $2\kappa(x_r) - \bar{\kappa}(x_r) = 1$, i.e.:

$$2\kappa_s \, f(x_r) - \frac{2\kappa_s}{x_r^2} \left[\ln \frac{x_r}{2} + g(x_r) \right] = 1 \,. \tag{14.6}$$

Both equations must be solved numerically. For the cluster parameters above ($M_{200} = 10^{15} \, M_\odot$, $c = 5$, $z_d = 0.3$, $z_s = 2$), the tangential critical curve lies at $x_t \approx 0.18$, giving $\theta_t \approx 15''$, a physical radius of ~ 66 kpc at the cluster redshift.

Remark 14.2.1. The tangential critical curve radius is often called the Einstein radius of the cluster, $\theta_{\rm E}$. A *spherical* NFW halo with $M_{200} \sim 10^{15} \, M_\odot$ and $c \sim 5$ typically has $\theta_{\rm E} \sim 10''$–$20''$ at these redshifts. Observed clusters (Abell 1689, MACSJ 0717, etc.) frequently display $\theta_{\rm E} \sim 30''$–$50''$; this additional lensing strength comes from ellipticity, substructure, merger boosts, and departures of the true mass distribution from a smooth spherical NFW. For a galaxy lens the Einstein radius is instead $\sim 1''$, and the enclosed projected mass within $\theta_{\rm E}$ ranges from $\sim 10^{11} \, M_\odot$ (galaxies) to $\sim 10^{13}$–$10^{14} \, M_\odot$ (clusters).

14.2.4 Einstein Radius Scaling with Cluster Mass

The Einstein radius of an NFW cluster depends on mass, concentration, and the lens/source redshift configuration. For a fixed concentration and redshift configuration, the scaling is approximately:

$$\theta_{\rm E} \propto M_{200}^{1/3}\,, \tag{14.7}$$

which arises because $\theta_{\rm E} \sim r_{200}/D_{\rm d}$ and $r_{200} \propto M_{200}^{1/3}$ (from the definition $M_{200} = (4\pi/3)\,200\,\rho_{\rm crit}\,r_{200}^3$). The actual relationship is more complex due to the dependence of κ_s on c and the nonlinear solution of eq. (14.5), but the cube-root scaling provides a useful approximation.

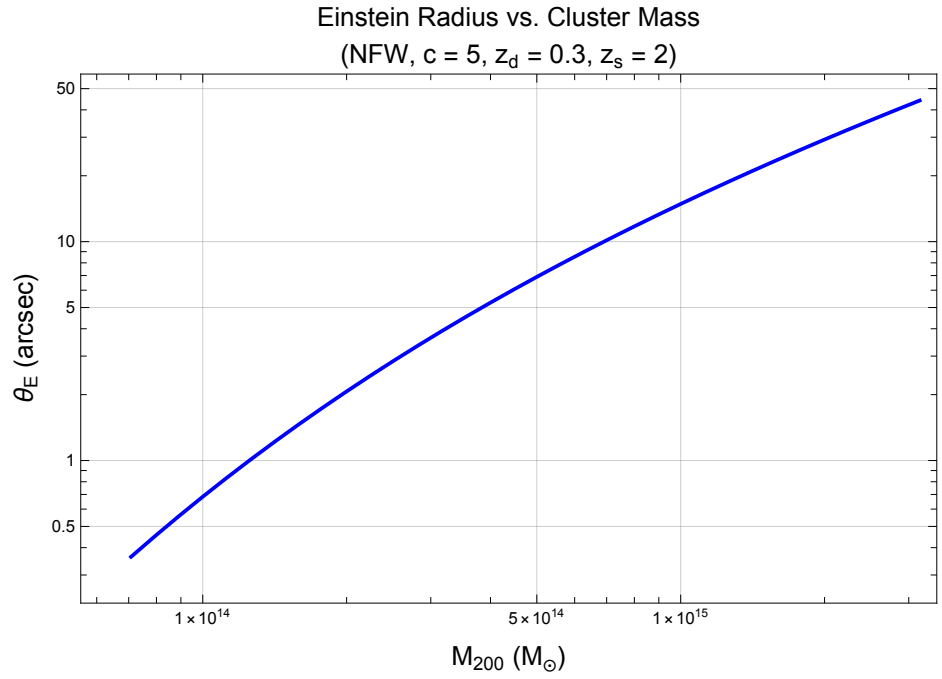


Figure 14.1: Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$ as a function of cluster mass M_{200} for an NFW profile with $c = 5$, $z_d = 0.3$, and $z_s = 2$. The dashed line shows the approximate $M^{1/3}$ scaling. Clusters below $M_{200} \sim 10^{14}\,M_\odot$ have Einstein radii comparable to galaxy-scale lenses. Generated by `cluster_lensing.wl`.

14.3 Giant Arcs

Giant luminous arcs are the most conspicuous signature of cluster strong lensing. They were first discovered by Lynds & Petrosian (1986) and Soucail et al. (1987) in the clusters Abell 370 and Cl 2244-02, and their interpretation as gravitationally lensed images of background galaxies was confirmed spectroscopically by Soucail et al. (1988).

14.3.1 Formation Mechanism

Giant arcs form when an extended background galaxy lies close to the tangential caustic of the cluster. From the theory of critical curves (Chapter 12, Section 14.3), a source galaxy near

(but not exactly on) the tangential caustic in the source plane has images near the tangential critical curve in the image plane, where $\lambda_- \approx 0$. These images are stretched tangentially (along the critical curve) by a large factor $\mu_{\rm tan} \propto 1/\sqrt{d_\perp}$, where $d_\perp$ is the perpendicular distance from the caustic, while the radial magnification remains of order unity, so that each image is a thin, elongated arc that traces the critical curve.

14.3.2 Ray-Tracing Through a Cluster Potential

To visualize arc formation, we ray-trace an extended source through the cluster lens equation. The source is defined as a set of points in the source plane, e.g., a circular disk of angular radius β_0 centered at position $\boldsymbol{\beta}_0$; for each source point $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ the lens equation $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ is solved for all image positions $\boldsymbol{\theta}$, which for a cluster is done numerically on a fine grid; and the union of all image positions is the lensed image of the source.

In practice, it is more efficient to use the *inverse ray-tracing* approach: for each pixel $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ in the image plane, compute $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ and check whether $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ falls within the source. If it does, that pixel is part of a lensed image.

14.3.3 Length-to-Width Ratio

The *length-to-width ratio* (or axis ratio) of an arc is a direct measure of the tangential magnification:

$$\frac{L}{W} \approx \mu_{\rm tan} = \frac{1}{|1 - \bar{\kappa}(\theta)|} \propto \frac{1}{\sqrt{d_\perp}}\,, \tag{14.8}$$

where L and W are the length and width of the arc. Observationally, arcs with $L/W \geq 10$ are classified as "giant arcs", while those with $3 \leq L/W < 10$ are often called "arclets".

14.3.4 Arc Statistics

The probability that a cluster produces a giant arc depends on several factors. More massive clusters have larger Einstein radii and larger tangential caustics, which increase the cross-section for arc production; the arc cross-section scales steeply with mass, roughly as $\sigma_{\rm arc} \propto M_{200}^{2\text{–}3}$. Higher source redshifts increase $D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}$, which increases κ_s and the Einstein radius. Non-axisymmetric mass distributions and merging clusters enhance the arc cross-section considerably, often by a factor of 2–5. Finally, extended sources are more easily stretched into arcs, whereas compact sources are more likely to appear as multiple point-like images.

Remark 14.3.1. Arc statistics have been a source of tension with cosmological models. Bartelmann et al. (1998) found that the observed number of giant arcs exceeded the prediction from ΛCDM by a factor of ∼10. This "arc statistics problem" has been partially resolved by accounting for cluster ellipticity, substructure, and the contribution of baryonic physics (cooling, AGN feedback) to the central mass concentration, but it remains an active area of research.

14.4 Multiple Image Systems in Clusters

A distinctive feature of cluster lensing is that a single cluster lenses many background galaxies simultaneously, producing multiple sets of multiple images. Each set of images (called an "image family" or "image system") comes from a single background source at a particular redshift.

14.4.1 Image Families

A typical strong lensing cluster produces 5–10 secure image families with spectroscopic redshift confirmation in well-studied clusters, and 20–50 candidate image families identified by morphology, color, and photometric redshifts in deep imaging surveys; in extreme cases (e.g., Abell 1689), over 100 candidate images have been identified from more than 30 distinct background sources.

Each image family provides independent constraints on the cluster mass model. The image positions constrain the deflection field $\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ at several points, the magnification ratios (flux ratios between images) constrain the convergence and shear fields, and the redshift of each family provides a distance ratio $D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}$ that weights the lensing signal differently and so breaks degeneracies in the mass model.

14.4.2 Spectroscopic Confirmation

Image families are confirmed by matching the redshifts of candidate images: if multiple images at different positions have the same spectroscopic redshift, they are identified as images of the same source. Modern multi-object spectrographs (VLT/MUSE, Keck/DEIMOS) have changed cluster lensing by enabling redshift measurements of faint, highly magnified background galaxies.

14.4.3 Famous Cluster Lenses

Several galaxy clusters have become benchmarks for strong lensing studies. Abell 370 ($z = 0.375$) is the site of the first discovered giant arc (Soucail et al. 1987), with over 10 multiple image systems identified. Abell 1689 ($z = 0.183$) is one of the strongest known lenses, with over 100 images from ∼30 background sources; its Einstein radius of $\sim 47''$ (for $z_s \sim 2$) is among the largest known. MACSJ0416.1-2403 ($z = 0.396$) is a Hubble Frontier Field cluster with over 60 spectroscopically confirmed multiple images, used for detailed mass reconstruction. Abell 2744 ($z = 0.308$), the "Pandora's Cluster", is a complex merging system with extensive strong and weak lensing constraints.

14.5 Cluster Mass Estimation

Gravitational lensing provides a *direct* measurement of the projected mass distribution of a cluster, independent of assumptions about the dynamical state of the system. This makes

it complementary to X-ray and kinematic mass estimates, which rely on assumptions of hydrostatic or virial equilibrium.

14.5.1 Strong Lensing Mass Estimates

Strong lensing constrains the mass distribution in the inner region of the cluster, typically within ~ 200–300 kpc of the center. The basic approach is to identify multiple image systems and measure their positions and redshifts; to parametrize the mass model, describing the cluster mass by one or more NFW halos (for the smooth dark matter component) plus additional components for cluster member galaxies (typically scaled isothermal profiles); to optimize the model parameters by minimizing the difference between predicted and observed image positions, for which modern codes (e.g., `lenstool`, `glafic`) use Bayesian methods (MCMC) to explore the parameter space; and to derive the mass profile from the best-fit model.

A quick estimate of the enclosed mass within the Einstein radius is provided by:

$$\boxed{M(\theta \leq \theta_{\rm E}) = \pi \, (D_{\rm d} \, \theta_{\rm E})^2 \, \Sigma_{\rm cr}} \tag{14.9}$$

since $\bar{\kappa}(\theta_{\rm E}) = 1$ by definition. For a cluster with $\theta_{\rm E} = 30''$ at $z_d = 0.3$ with $z_s = 2$:

$$M(\theta_{\rm E}) \approx 1.3 \times 10^{14} \, M_\odot \, . \tag{14.10}$$

This is the projected mass within a cylinder of radius ~ 130 kpc, a substantial fraction of the total cluster mass. The exact value is computed in `cluster_lensing.wl`.

14.5.2 Weak Lensing Mass Estimates (Preview)

Strong lensing probes only the inner $\sim$10% of the cluster virial radius. To measure the total cluster mass, one must extend to larger radii using weak lensing (Section 14.7).

14.5.3 Combining Strong and Weak Lensing

The most accurate cluster mass profiles come from combining strong and weak lensing. Strong lensing provides high-resolution constraints on the inner mass profile ($r \lesssim 200$ kpc), including the NFW concentration parameter, while weak lensing provides constraints at larger radii (200 kpc $\lesssim r \lesssim 3$ Mpc) and determines the virial mass M_{200}. The combined profile spans nearly two decades in radius and is well fit by an NFW profile, which supports the universality of the dark matter halo profile.

14.5.4 Comparison with Other Mass Estimators

Cluster masses can also be estimated in other ways. The hot intracluster medium (ICM) emits thermal bremsstrahlung X-rays, and under the assumption of hydrostatic equilibrium the gas temperature and density profiles yield the total mass profile; hydrostatic masses are typically 10–20% lower than lensing masses (the "hydrostatic mass bias"), probably because of non-thermal pressure support from turbulence and bulk motions. The velocities

of cluster member galaxies, combined with the virial theorem, yield a mass estimate, but the method is noisy (it requires many galaxy redshifts) and sensitive to interlopers. Inverse Compton scattering of CMB photons by the hot ICM produces a spectral distortion, the Sunyaev–Zel'dovich (SZ) effect, whose integrated signal is proportional to the total thermal energy and correlates with total mass.

Remark 14.5.1. These methods are complementary. Comparing lensing masses (which are model-independent) with X-ray/SZ masses (which assume hydrostatic equilibrium) calibrates the hydrostatic mass bias, which is an important systematic in using cluster counts for cosmology.

14.6 Magnification and the Cosmic Telescope

A prominent application of cluster lensing in contemporary astrophysics is the use of massive clusters as gravitational telescopes, which amplify the light of distant background galaxies and allow the study of objects that would otherwise be far too faint to detect.

14.6.1 Magnification by Clusters

Near the critical curves of a massive cluster, the magnification can reach $\mu \sim 10$–100 or more. Since the observed flux scales as μ (for sources smaller than the scale over which μ varies), a source at $z \sim 10$ behind a cluster lens can appear as bright as an unmagnified source at $z \sim 3$–4.

The trade-off is that magnification also reduces the effective area in the source plane. A magnification of μ enlarges the image area by μ but surveys a source-plane area that is μ times smaller. The net effect on the number of detected sources depends on the slope of the luminosity function; this is the *magnification bias*.

14.6.2 Magnification Bias

The magnification bias arises because lensing simultaneously amplifies flux, so that sources below the detection threshold are boosted above it and the detected number increases, and dilutes area, since the effective survey area is reduced by $1/\mu$ and the detected number decreases. For a cumulative luminosity function $N(>S) \propto S^{-\alpha}$ (where S is flux and α is the faint-end slope), the net number count behind a lens changes by a factor of $\mu^{\alpha-1}$. For $\alpha > 1$ (steep luminosity function), magnification bias *increases* the number of detected sources; for $\alpha < 1$, it *decreases* the count. At high redshift, the luminosity function is steep ($\alpha \gtrsim 2$), so there is a significant net increase in detected galaxies behind clusters.

14.6.3 The Hubble Frontier Fields

The Hubble Frontier Fields (HFF) program (2013–2017) was a major HST initiative that obtained ultra-deep imaging of six massive galaxy clusters chosen for their strong lensing power:

1. Abell 2744 ($z = 0.308$)

2. MACSJ0416.1-2403 ($z = 0.396$)
3. MACSJ0717.5+3745 ($z = 0.545$)
4. MACSJ1149.5+2223 ($z = 0.543$)
5. Abell S1063 ($z = 0.348$)
6. Abell 370 ($z = 0.375$)

These clusters were used as gravitational telescopes to detect galaxies at $z \sim 6$–10, probing the epoch of reionization. The HFF program discovered some of the most distant galaxies known at the time and provided detailed mass models of the six clusters from their many multiple image systems.

14.6.4 JWST and the New Era of Cluster Lensing

The James Webb Space Telescope (JWST, launched 2021) has transformed cluster lensing with its superior infrared sensitivity and angular resolution. Among the notable results, Earendel (WHL0137-LS) is the most distant individual star known, at $z = 6.2$, magnified by a factor of $\mu \sim 1000$–$40{,}000$ by the cluster WHL 0137-08 [48]; the extreme magnification occurs because the star lies almost exactly on the cluster's critical curve. The Sunrise Arc is a galaxy at $z = 6.2$ lensed into a long arc by the same cluster, in which Earendel was identified as a point source on the arc. Early galaxy candidates at $z > 10$ have also been found: lensed galaxies behind clusters observed with JWST/NIRCam have pushed the redshift frontier beyond $z \sim 13$, with magnifications of $\mu \sim 5$–30 making these detections possible.

Remark 14.6.1. The discovery of Earendel illustrates the reach of cluster lensing. Without magnification, Earendel would have an apparent magnitude of $m \approx 35$–39, far below any detection limit. A magnification of $\mu \sim 1000$–$40{,}000$ corresponds to $\Delta m \approx -7.5$ to -11.5 magnitudes, bringing it to the observed $m \approx 27.2$, within reach of HST and JWST [48]. Such extreme magnification requires the image to lie within a few hundredths of an arcsecond of the critical curve ($\lesssim 0.036''$ in the Welch et al. [48] lens models), making such discoveries exceedingly rare.

14.7 Brief Introduction to Weak Lensing

Throughout Chapters 1–13 and the preceding sections of this chapter, we have focused on strong lensing: the regime where $\kappa \gtrsim 1$ and multiple images or giant arcs are produced. Gravitational lensing does not stop there. At larger radii from the cluster center (and behind foreground mass distributions in general), the lensing effect is weak: too small to produce multiple images, but still measurable statistically. This is the domain of *weak gravitational lensing*.

This section provides a brief introduction to weak lensing, enough to show where the field goes beyond strong lensing and to connect to the literature on the subject. A full treatment of weak lensing is beyond the scope of these tutorials.

14.7.1 The Weak Lensing Regime

In the weak lensing regime, $\kappa \ll 1$ and $|\gamma| \ll 1$. There are no multiple images or giant arcs. Instead, the primary observable effect is a small, coherent distortion (shearing) of the shapes of background galaxies. An intrinsically circular galaxy is sheared into a slightly elliptical shape, with the orientation and magnitude of the induced ellipticity determined by the local shear field.

The difficulty is that individual galaxy shapes are intrinsically elliptical, with typical intrinsic ellipticities of $|\epsilon_{\rm int}| \sim 0.2$–$0.3$. The gravitational shear signal is $|\gamma| \sim 0.01$–0.05 in the weak lensing regime, much smaller than the intrinsic shape noise. Therefore, one must average over many background galaxies to extract the coherent shear signal.

14.7.2 The Reduced Shear

In the weak lensing regime, the observable quantity is the *reduced shear*:

$$\boxed{g = \frac{\gamma}{1-\kappa}} \tag{14.11}$$

This is because the lensing transformation preserves surface brightness, and the observed ellipticity of a lensed galaxy (for $|g| \leq 1$) is:

$$\epsilon^{\rm obs} = \frac{\epsilon^{\rm int} + g}{1 + g^* \, \epsilon^{\rm int}} \approx \epsilon^{\rm int} + g \,, \tag{14.12}$$

where the approximation holds for $|g| \ll 1$. Since intrinsic ellipticities are randomly oriented (in the absence of intrinsic alignments), their average vanishes: $\langle \epsilon^{\rm int} \rangle \approx 0$. Therefore:

$$\langle \epsilon^{\rm obs} \rangle \approx g \approx \gamma \quad (\text{for } \kappa \ll 1) \,. \tag{14.13}$$

The mean observed ellipticity of background galaxies is an unbiased estimator of the shear (in the weak limit).

14.7.3 Tangential Shear Profile Around Clusters

For a circularly symmetric mass distribution, the shear is purely tangential. The *tangential shear* at angular distance θ from the cluster center is:

$$\gamma_t(\theta) = \bar{\kappa}(\theta) - \kappa(\theta) \,, \tag{14.14}$$

which we recognize from eq. (11.7) (Chapter 11). The tangential shear profile $\gamma_t(\theta)$ can be measured by averaging the tangential component of the ellipticities of background galaxies in annular bins around the cluster center.

For an NFW profile, $\gamma_t(\theta)$ has a characteristic shape that rises toward the center (reaching the strong lensing regime) and falls off at large radii. Fitting the observed $\gamma_t(\theta)$ profile to the NFW prediction yields the cluster mass M_{200} and concentration c.

14.7.4 From Clusters to Cosmic Shear

The weak lensing framework extends far beyond individual cluster halos. The *cosmic shear* signal, the coherent shearing of galaxy shapes by the entire large-scale structure of the universe along the line of sight, is one of the primary probes of modern cosmology. Cosmic shear measurements constrain the matter power spectrum, the matter density $\Omega_{\rm m}$, and the amplitude of matter fluctuations σ_8.

Current and upcoming surveys measuring cosmic shear include Euclid (ESA, launched 2023), a space-based imaging survey of $\sim$1.5 billion galaxies over 15,000 deg^2; the Vera C. Rubin Observatory / LSST, a ground-based survey of $\sim$4 billion galaxies over 18,000 deg^2 (first light expected 2025); and the Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope (NASA, expected launch 2027), a space-based survey complementing Euclid. These surveys will measure cosmic shear with percent-level precision, providing tight constraints on dark energy, modified gravity, and the neutrino mass hierarchy.

14.8 The State of the Field and Future Directions

Strong lensing by galaxy clusters is a mature but still developing field, in which new observational facilities and modeling techniques continue to extend what cluster lensing can measure.

14.8.1 Current Observational Facilities

The Hubble Space Telescope has been the mainstay of cluster strong lensing for three decades, with programs such as the Hubble Frontier Fields and RELICS (Reionization Lensing Cluster Survey) producing the deepest cluster lensing data. JWST, with its infrared capabilities, is discovering lensed galaxies at $z > 10$, measuring spectroscopic redshifts of multiple image systems, and resolving detailed structure in giant arcs. The Euclid wide-field survey will discover thousands of new cluster lenses, greatly increasing the statistical power of cluster lensing studies, and the deep, wide Rubin/LSST survey will combine strong and weak lensing for a large sample of clusters, with time-domain capability for detecting lensed transients.

14.8.2 Future Facilities

The Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope will provide high-resolution, wide-field infrared imaging that complements JWST for cluster lensing studies. Radio weak lensing with the Square Kilometre Array (SKA) will provide shape measurements free from many of the systematics that affect optical measurements (atmospheric seeing, PSF modeling). The Extremely Large Telescopes (ELT, TMT, GMT), ground-based 25–39m telescopes with adaptive optics, will resolve sub-arcsecond structure in cluster arcs and obtain spectra of extremely faint lensed sources.

14.8.3 Open Questions

Several questions remain open. CDM predicts a rich hierarchy of subhalos within clusters; the number and mass function of subhalos affect the lensing signal (flux ratio anomalies, perturbations to giant arcs), and comparing predictions to observations constrains alternative dark matter models (warm dark matter, self-interacting dark matter). The inner density profile of clusters (cusp vs. core) is sensitive to dark matter self-interactions, and strong lensing at the center of clusters provides the highest-resolution probe of the dark matter profile. The abundance of massive clusters as a function of mass and redshift is a sensitive cosmological probe, and lensing-calibrated cluster masses are essential for turning cluster counts into cosmological constraints. Light rays from distant sources pass through multiple mass concentrations along the line of sight, and accounting for these "line-of-sight" effects is important for precision mass modeling. Finally, time delays between multiple images of time-varying sources (supernovae, quasars) in clusters constrain H_0; the multiply imaged supernova "Refsdal" in MACSJ1149 (Kelly et al. 2015) was the first such measurement.

14.8.4 Connection to the AGEL Project

The ASTRO 3D Galaxy Evolution with Lensing (AGEL) survey is a spectroscopic survey of galaxy-scale strong lens candidates selected from wide-field imaging surveys. While AGEL focuses on galaxy-scale lenses rather than clusters, many of the techniques and physical principles are the same: NFW profiles and isothermal models describe the lens mass distribution at both galaxy and cluster scales, critical curves and caustics determine the image configurations at all mass scales, and strong lensing mass estimates and comparisons with dynamical masses apply to both galaxy and cluster lenses. The transition from galaxy to cluster lensing is one of scale rather than of physics; the same equations derived in Chapters 1–13 govern both regimes.

14.9 Summary

Galaxy clusters ($M_{200} \sim 10^{14}$–$10^{15}\,M_\odot$) are the strongest gravitational lenses, producing giant arcs, dozens of multiple image systems, and magnification factors of $\mu \sim 10$–100. The NFW profile at cluster scale has $c \sim 3$–8 and $r_s \sim 200$–500 kpc; the Einstein radius is $\theta_{\rm E} \sim 10''$–$50''$, enclosing a projected mass of $\sim 10^{14}\,M_\odot$. Giant arcs form when extended sources lie near the tangential caustic, and their length-to-width ratio $L/W \approx \mu_{\rm tan} \propto 1/\sqrt{d_\perp}$ can exceed 10:1 for sources very close to the caustic. Multiple image systems (10–30+ per cluster) each independently constrain the mass model, and spectroscopic confirmation via redshift matching identifies the image families.

Cluster mass estimation uses strong lensing (inner profile) and weak lensing (outer profile), complemented by X-ray and SZ measurements; strong lensing gives $M(\theta_{\rm E}) = \pi(D_{\rm d}\,\theta_{\rm E})^2\,\Sigma_{\rm cr}$. Clusters serve as gravitational telescopes, magnifying high-redshift galaxies and enabling discoveries such as Earendel ($z = 6.2$, $\mu \sim 10^3$–10^4) and galaxies at $z > 10$. Weak lensing measures the statistical shear $\langle\epsilon\rangle \approx g = \gamma/(1-\kappa)$ of background galaxies, and the tangential shear profile $\gamma_t(\theta)$ yields the cluster mass profile at large radii. Current and future facilities

(JWST, Euclid, Rubin/LSST, Roman, SKA) will transform cluster lensing with larger samples, deeper imaging, and new wavelength regimes.

Where to Go from Here

This chapter concludes Part III. Parts IV and V extend the formalism to statistical, weak and micro lensing, and to compound lenses. We have covered the foundations of general relativity (Chapters 1–5), the theory of gravitational lensing (Chapters 6–10), and the modeling and application of strong lensing (Chapters 11–14). For readers who wish to continue deeper into the field, we suggest the following directions.

Advanced topics not covered in these tutorials include dark matter substructure and flux ratio anomalies; line-of-sight effects and multi-plane lensing; free-form (non-parametric) mass reconstruction; lens modeling with extended source morphology; and microlensing by stars in the lensing galaxy.

Several software packages are available for lens modeling:

- `lenstronomy` (https://github.com/lenstronomy/lenstronomy): a comprehensive Python package for gravitational lens modeling and simulation.
- `PyAutoLens` (https://github.com/Jammy2211/PyAutoLens): automated strong lens modeling with Bayesian inference.
- `glafic` (https://www.slac.stanford.edu/~oguri/glafic/): a fast lens modeling code widely used for cluster lensing.
- `GRALE` (https://research.edm.uhasselt.be/~jlieMDC/): free-form mass reconstruction using a genetic algorithm.

Review articles for further reading are Kneib & Natarajan (2011), "Cluster lenses", A&A Rev.; Treu (2010), "Strong Lensing by Galaxies", ARA&A; Bartelmann & Schneider (2001), "Weak Gravitational Lensing", Phys. Rep.; and Kilbinger (2015), "Cosmology with Cosmic Shear", Rep. Prog. Phys.

The AGEL project (Tran et al. 2022) exemplifies how the techniques developed in these tutorials are applied in practice. Finding, confirming, and modeling galaxy-scale strong lenses in wide-field surveys is an active area of research to which the reader is now well-prepared to contribute.

14.10 Problems

Exercise 14.10.1. (NFW cluster Einstein radius and enclosed mass.) Consider an NFW cluster with $M_{200} = 5 \times 10^{14}\, M_\odot$, $c = 5$, at $z_d = 0.3$ lensing a source at $z_s = 2$. Use $D_\mathrm{d} = 919$ Mpc, $D_\mathrm{s} = 1727$ Mpc, $D_\mathrm{ds} = 1328$ Mpc.

(a) Compute the NFW parameters: r_{200}, r_s, ρ_s, θ_s, and κ_s.

(b) Find the tangential critical curve radius θ_t (the Einstein radius θ_E) by solving $\bar{\kappa}(\theta_t) = 1$ numerically.

(c) Compute the projected mass enclosed within θ_E using eq. (14.9).

(d) Compare this enclosed mass to the total virial mass M_{200}. What fraction of the cluster mass is enclosed within the Einstein radius?

Verify with `problems_10.wl`.

Exercise 14.10.2. (Ray-tracing a source through a cluster potential.) Using the NFW cluster from Exercise 14.10.1:

(a) Set up inverse ray-tracing: for each pixel $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ in the image plane, compute $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ using the NFW deflection angle (eq. 14.2).

(b) Place a circular source of angular radius $0.5''$ at three positions: (i) $\beta = 0$ (on the optical axis), (ii) $\beta = 0.5\,\theta_{\rm E}$ (a source half an Einstein radius off axis), and (iii) $\beta = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$ (close to the tangential caustic, which for a circular lens is the point $\beta = 0$).

(c) Plot the resulting lensed images for each source position. Identify the Einstein ring, giant arc, and counter-image morphologies.

(d) Estimate the length-to-width ratio of the arc in case (iii).

Verify with `problems_10.wl`.

Exercise 14.10.3. (Magnification of a high-redshift galaxy.) Consider a galaxy at $z_s = 9$ lensed by a cluster at $z_d = 0.3$ with $\theta_{\rm E} = 30''$. (For reference, $D_{\rm d} = 919$ Mpc, $D_{\rm s} = 921$ Mpc and $D_{\rm ds} = 802$ Mpc; at $z_s = 9$ the angular-diameter distance has turned over, so $D_{\rm s}$ is barely larger than $D_{\rm d}$. Parts (a)–(c) need only $\theta_{\rm E}$.)

(a) For an SIS model with the same Einstein radius, compute the magnification of a point source at $\beta = 3''$, $1''$, and $0.1''$.

(b) What is the apparent magnitude boost (Δm) for a source at $\beta = 0.1''$ from the lens center? ($\Delta m = -2.5\,\log_{10}\mu$.)

(c) At $z_s = 9$, an L_* galaxy has an apparent magnitude of $m \approx 31$ (AB) in the near-infrared. If the detection limit of JWST is $m \approx 29$, what minimum magnification is needed to detect such a galaxy? At what source position β does this magnification occur (for the SIS model)?

(d) Discuss the implications for surveys of high-redshift galaxies behind clusters.

Verify with `problems_10.wl`.

Exercise 14.10.4. (Einstein radii across mass scales.) Compare the Einstein radii of three lenses at $z_d = 0.3$ with a source at $z_s = 2$, using $D_{\rm d} = 919$ Mpc, $D_{\rm s} = 1727$ Mpc, $D_{\rm ds} = 1328$ Mpc:

(a) A galaxy lens modeled as an SIS with $\sigma_v = 250$ km s^{-1} ($M \approx 10^{12}\,M_\odot$).

(b) A group lens modeled as an SIS with $\sigma_v = 500$ km s^{-1} ($M \approx 10^{13}\,M_\odot$).

(c) A cluster lens modeled as an SIS with $\sigma_v = 1200$ km s^{-1} ($M \approx 10^{15}\,M_\odot$).

(d) Compute $\theta_{\rm E}$ for each case. By what factor does $\theta_{\rm E}$ increase from galaxy to cluster?

(e) Compute the enclosed mass within $\theta_{\rm E}$ for each case. Compare with the total mass of each object.

(f) Discuss why the scaling $\theta_{\rm E} \propto \sigma_v^2$ (from the SIS formula) leads to a qualitative difference in lensing phenomenology between galaxies and clusters.

Verify with `problems_10.wl`.

Exercise 14.10.5. (Weak lensing mass estimate.) A cluster at $z_d = 0.3$ has a measured tangential shear profile $\gamma_t(\theta) = 0.1 \times (\theta/1')^{-0.8}$.

(a) Using the relation $\gamma_t(\theta) = \bar{\kappa}(\theta) - \kappa(\theta)$, and adopting the crude approximation $\gamma_t \approx \bar{\kappa}$ (part (d) asks how good it is), estimate the mean convergence at $\theta = 1'$, $3'$, and $5'$.

(b) Convert $\bar{\kappa}(\theta)$ to the projected mass enclosed within θ: $M(\theta) = \pi\,(D_{\rm d}\,\theta)^2\,\Sigma_{\rm cr}\,\bar{\kappa}(\theta)$. Use $\Sigma_{\rm cr} \approx 2.8 \times 10^{15}\,M_\odot\,{\rm Mpc}^{-2}$ for $z_d = 0.3$, $z_s = 1$ (a typical background redshift for weak lensing), and $D_{\rm d} = 919$ Mpc.

(c) Estimate M within $\theta = 5'$ (corresponding to a physical radius of ~ 1.3 Mpc at $z_d = 0.3$).

(d) Compare your estimated mass with a typical cluster virial mass of $5 \times 10^{14}\,M_\odot$. Discuss whether the result is reasonable and what assumptions may affect the accuracy.

Verify with `problems_10.wl`.

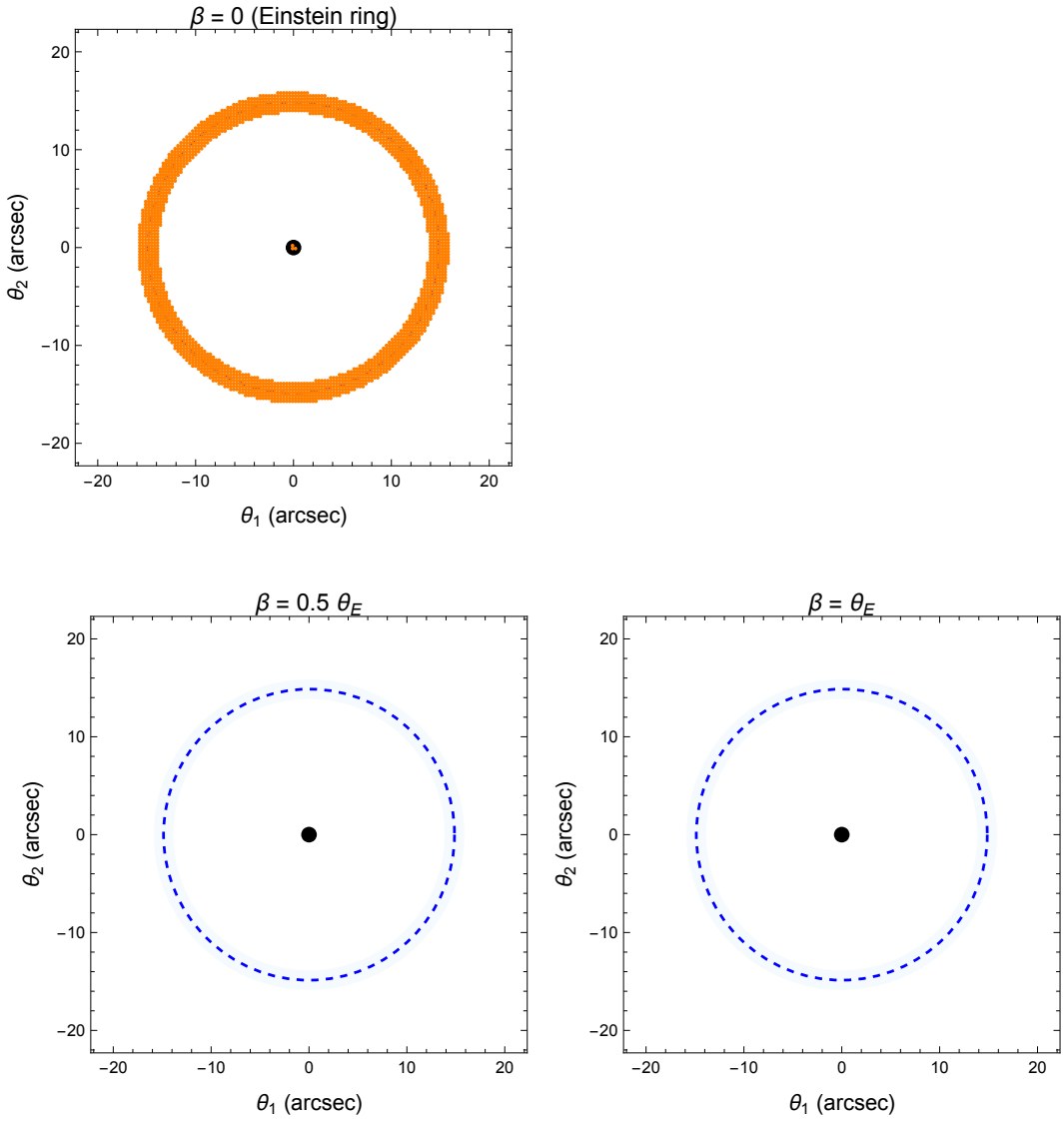


Figure 14.2: Giant arc formation by an NFW cluster ($M_{200} = 10^{15}\,M_\odot$, $c = 5$, $z_d = 0.3$, $z_s = 2$). A circular source of radius $0.5''$ is placed at three positions: $\beta = 0$ (Einstein ring, left), $\beta = 0.5\,\theta_{\rm E}$ (giant arc, center), and $\beta = \theta_{\rm E}$ (near the critical curve, right). The critical curve is shown as a dashed circle. Generated by `cluster_lensing.wl`.

Part IV

Statistical, Weak, and Micro Lensing

Chapter 15

Lensing Statistics and Cross-Sections

> *One is frequently interested in the probability that a specific gravitational lensing event occurs. [. . .] The results of such an investigation depend on the assumed distribution of lens masses and their individual density profiles. A comparison of these results with a statistically well defined sample of observed lens cases can in principle allow one to constrain the lens contents and/or the geometry of the Universe.* — P. Schneider, in Schneider, Kochanek & Wambsganss (2006), Part 1, §5

So far we have studied lenses one at a time. But a survey observes *populations*: many sources seen through many deflectors. The questions then become statistical: what fraction of distant quasars is multiply imaged, how many giant arcs a cluster survey should find, and how lensing distorts the number counts of a flux-limited sample. These questions are answered with three ingredients built in this chapter: the cross-section of a single lens for a given imaging property (§15.1); the optical depth, obtained by summing cross-sections over the lens population along the line of sight (§15.2); and the magnification bias, which reshapes the observed counts of a lensed source population (§15.3). Together these make lens statistics a probe both of the lens population (masses, profiles, abundance) and of cosmology (through the volume element). We build on the point-mass and SIS imaging of Chapters 8 and 11 and the caustic structure of Chapter 12.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `lensing_statistics.wl` contains the symbolic derivation and verification of the point-mass and SIS cross-sections (including the combined SIS threshold cross-section, Eq. (15.6)), the comoving optical-depth integrand and its Ω_Λ dependence, and the magnification-bias factor for power-law counts; the figures are exported to `Figures/11_Lensing_Stati`

15.1 Lensing Cross-Sections

Fix a source and a lens at given distances. For some imaging property Q ("total magnification exceeds μ", "image separation exceeds $\Delta\theta$", "flux ratio below r") there is a region of the *source plane* in which the source must lie for the images to have property Q. The solid angle of that region is the *cross-section* σ_Q [43, Part 1, §5.1]. Everything in lens statistics is built from cross-sections.

15.1.1 The Point-Mass Lens

For a point mass there is a one-to-one relation between the scaled source position $y = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$ and the total magnification $\mu_p(y) = (y^2+2)/\left(y\sqrt{y^2+4}\right)$ (Chapter 8). Inverting it, the source produces a total magnification greater than μ_p whenever it lies within

$$y^2(\mu_p) = 2\left(\frac{\mu_p}{\sqrt{\mu_p^2-1}} - 1\right), \tag{15.1}$$

so the cross-section for magnification $> \mu_p$ is

$$\sigma(\mu_p) = \pi\,\theta_{\rm E}^2\,y^2(\mu_p). \tag{15.2}$$

At high magnification $y^2 \to 1/\mu_p^2$, giving the universal $\sigma \propto \mu_p^{-2}$ (equivalently the differential $p(\mu)\,d\mu \propto -\frac{d\sigma}{d\mu}\,d\mu \propto \mu^{-3}\,d\mu$ that recurs in §15.3). Similarly, the cross-section for the image brightness ratio to be smaller than $r > 1$ is

$$\sigma(r) = \pi\,\theta_{\rm E}^2\left(r^{1/2} + r^{-1/2} - 2\right), \tag{15.3}$$

both verified symbolically in the companion script.

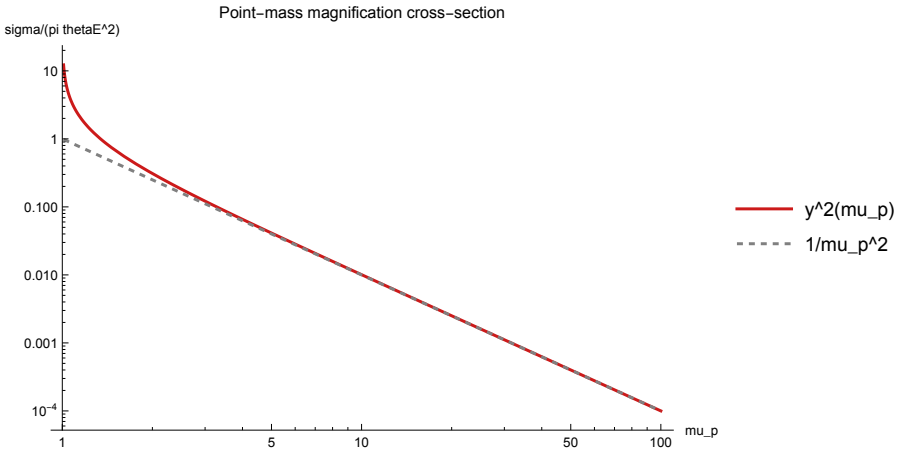


Figure 15.1: The point-mass magnification cross-section $\sigma(\mu_p)/(\pi\theta_{\rm E}^2) = y^2(\mu_p)$ of Eq. (15.1), as a function of the magnification threshold μ_p. At high magnification the cross-section falls as $\sigma \propto \mu_p^{-2}$ (dashed), the universal scaling that produces $p(\mu) \propto \mu^{-3}$ and drives the magnification bias. Generated by `lensing_statistics.wl`.

15.1.2 The Singular Isothermal Sphere

The SIS (Chapter 11) produces two images when $\beta < \theta_{\rm E}$, always separated by $2\theta_{\rm E}$. With $y = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$, the total magnification and flux ratio of the pair are

$$\mu = \frac{2}{y}, \qquad r = \frac{1+y}{1-y}. \tag{15.4}$$

The basic multiple-imaging cross-section is therefore the area of the disk $\beta < \theta_{\rm E}$,

$$\sigma = \pi\,\theta_{\rm E}^2, \tag{15.5}$$

and with the resolution, magnification, and flux-ratio thresholds folded in [43, Part 1, eq. 101],

$$\sigma(\Delta\theta, r, \mu) = \pi\,\theta_{\rm E}^2 \left[\min\!\left(\frac{r-1}{r+1}, \frac{2}{\mu}\right)\right]^2 H(2\theta_{\rm E} - \Delta\theta), \tag{15.6}$$

where H is the Heaviside step function and r is finite, so that $(r-1)/(r+1) < 1$ keeps the source inside the multiple-imaging disk.[1] Because the SIS Einstein radius scales as $\theta_{\rm E} \propto \sigma_v^2$ (Eq. (11.18)), the multiple-imaging cross-section scales as $\sigma \propto \theta_{\rm E}^2 \propto \sigma_v^4$, so lens statistics are dominated by the most massive galaxies.

15.2 Optical Depth

The probability that a random source is lensed with property Q, the *optical depth* τ, is the fraction of the sky covered by the cross-sections of all intervening lenses. Summing the (non-overlapping) cross-sections of lenses with proper number density n along the line of sight,

$$\tau(Q) = \int_0^{z_s} dz_d\; D_{\rm ang}^2(z_d)\,\frac{dr_{\rm prop}}{dz} \int d\chi\; n(z_d,\chi)\,\sigma(Q; z_d, z_s, \chi), \tag{15.7}$$

where χ collects the lens parameters (mass, velocity dispersion, ellipticity) [43, Part 1, §5.2]. Written with the comoving number density $n = (1+z)^3 n_{\rm com}$ and comoving angular diameter distance f_K, this takes the compact form

$$\tau(Q) = \int_0^{w_s} dw\; f_K^2(w) \int d\chi\; n_{\rm com}(w,\chi)\,\sigma(Q; w, w_s, \chi). \tag{15.8}$$

For a population of SIS galaxies with cross-section $\sigma = \pi\theta_{\rm E}^2 \propto \sigma_v^4$, integrating over the observed velocity-dispersion function yields the classic result that the multiple-imaging optical depth scales as $\tau \propto n_{\rm com}\,(\sigma_v/c)^4$ times a cosmological volume factor [47]. Because this volume factor is larger when $\Omega_\Lambda > 0$ (for fixed $n_{\rm com}$ and $z_s = 2$, about three times larger in a flat $\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$ universe than in an Einstein–de Sitter one), lens counts were an early probe of the cosmological constant [43, Part 2, §6]. The same calculation underpins forecasts of $\sim 10^5$ galaxy-scale lenses discoverable in *Euclid* and LSST imaging [14].

15.3 Magnification Bias

A flux-limited sample is not a fair sample of the sky: magnification both brightens sources and spreads them over a larger solid angle. If $p(\mu)$ is the magnification probability distribution

[1] The printed eq. 101 of Schneider et al. [43] carries an extra factor $H(\mu - 2)$. That factor would set $\sigma = 0$ for any magnification threshold $\mu < 2$, yet every SIS image pair has total magnification $2/y \geq 2$, so such a threshold is always met. Direct integration over the source plane confirms the form above for all μ (companion script, Test 6).

and $N_0(>S)$ the unlensed counts, the observed counts are

$$N(>S) = \frac{1}{\langle\mu\rangle}\int d\mu\, p(\mu)\, N_0\!\left(>\frac{S}{\mu}\right), \tag{15.9}$$

with $\int p\, d\mu = 1$ and $\int \mu\, p\, d\mu = \langle\mu\rangle$ [43, Part 1, §5.3]. For power-law counts $N_0(>S) = A\, S^{-\beta}$,

$$N(>S) = N_0(>S)\,\frac{1}{\langle\mu\rangle}\int d\mu\, p(\mu)\,\mu^{\beta}, \tag{15.10}$$

so the counts keep the same slope and are boosted by a factor that depends only on β and $p(\mu)$. For $\beta = 1$ the counts are unchanged: the solid-angle dilution exactly cancels the brightening. Counts steeper than $\beta = 1$ are boosted; flatter ones are depleted.

Because $p(\mu) \propto \mu^{-3}$ at high magnification [8], a consequence of the universal fold magnification law, Eq. (12.19), met for the point mass in §15.1.1, the bias integral grows sharply as $\beta \to 2$: a source population with steep counts, or with an exponential Schechter cutoff, is strongly biased toward including lensed objects. For this reason several of the apparently most luminous objects in the sky, the IRAS galaxy F10214+4724 ($\mu \sim 50$), the Lyman-break galaxy cB58 ($\mu \sim 30$), and the quasar APM 08279+5255, turn out to be strongly magnified. It is also why lensed high-redshift galaxies are found preferentially behind massive clusters, the "cosmic telescope" effect of Chapter 14.

15.4 Summary

A cross-section σ_Q is the source-plane solid angle producing a chosen imaging property Q. For a point mass, $\sigma(\mu_p) = \pi\theta_{\rm E}^2\, y^2(\mu_p)$ with $y^2 = 2(\mu_p/\sqrt{\mu_p^2 - 1} - 1)$; for an SIS the multiple-imaging cross-section is $\pi\theta_{\rm E}^2$. The optical depth sums cross-sections over the lens population along the line of sight, Eq. (15.8); for SIS galaxies $\tau \propto n_{\rm com}(\sigma_v/c)^4$ times a cosmological volume factor sensitive to Ω_Λ. Magnification bias reshapes flux-limited counts, Eq. (15.9); power-law counts are boosted by a β-dependent factor, unchanged at $\beta = 1$, and strongly biased as $\beta \to 2$ because $p(\mu) \propto \mu^{-3}$.

15.5 Problems

Exercise 15.5.1 (Point-mass magnification cross-section)**.** Starting from the total magnification of a point-mass lens, $\mu_p(y) = (y^2+2)/\big(y\sqrt{y^2+4}\big)$:

(a) Show that the source positions with $\mu_p(y) > \mu$ satisfy $y^2 < 2\big(\mu/\sqrt{\mu^2-1} - 1\big)$, giving the cross-section Eq. (15.2).

(b) Show that for $\mu \gg 1$ the cross-section scales as $\sigma \propto \mu^{-2}$, and explain how this yields the universal magnification distribution $p(\mu) \propto \mu^{-3}$.

(c) *Hint:* expand $y^2(\mu)$ for large μ; recall $p(\mu) \propto -\,d\sigma/d\mu$.

problems_11.wl

Exercise 15.5.2 (SIS flux ratio and magnification)**.** For the two images of an SIS with $y = \beta/\theta_{\rm E} < 1$, verify that the total magnification is $\mu = 2/y$ and the flux ratio is $r = (1+y)/(1-y)$, and hence that the cross-section for a flux ratio smaller than r is $\sigma \leq \pi\theta_{\rm E}^2$. problems_11.wl

Exercise 15.5.3 (The $\beta = 1$ null of magnification bias)**.** Using Eq. (15.10) and the normalization $\int \mu\, p(\mu)\, d\mu = \langle\mu\rangle$, show that flux-limited number counts with slope $\beta = 1$ are unchanged by lensing, for *any* magnification distribution $p(\mu)$. Explain physically why the brightening and the solid-angle dilution cancel. problems_11.wl

Chapter 16

Weak Gravitational Lensing and Cosmic Shear

> *One cannot 'see' the effect, nor can it be graphically displayed easily. Only by investigating many faint galaxy images can a signal be extracted from the data, and the human eye is not sufficient to perform this analysis.* — P. Schneider, *Weak Gravitational Lensing* (2006)

Chapters 8–14 were concerned almost entirely with strong lensing: multiple images, giant arcs and Einstein rings, phenomena in which the Jacobian $\mathcal{A} = \partial\boldsymbol{\beta}/\partial\boldsymbol{\theta}$ differs so much from the identity that a single source produces strongly distorted images. This chapter treats the opposite, and far more common, regime. In *weak* gravitational lensing the Jacobian is very close to the unit matrix,

$$\mathcal{A} = \begin{pmatrix} 1-\kappa-\gamma_1 & -\gamma_2 \\ -\gamma_2 & 1-\kappa+\gamma_1 \end{pmatrix} \approx \mathbb{1}, \qquad \kappa \ll 1\,, \quad |\gamma| \ll 1\,,$$

so the distortion and magnification of any individual background galaxy are small and cannot be recognized. The lensing signal is recovered only statistically, by averaging the shapes of many faint galaxies [43].

This is the natural complement to the convergence–shear formalism of Chapter 9. There we defined κ, γ, and the Jacobian; here we ask how they are measured from data and what they tell us. We first show how the shape of a faint galaxy provides a noisy but unbiased estimate of the (reduced) shear (§16.2), and how the tangential shear around a mass concentration measures its projected mass profile (§16.3), which extends the axisymmetric result $|\gamma| = \bar{\kappa} - \kappa$ of Chapter 11 to arbitrary deflectors. The mass-sheet degeneracy of Chapter 13 reappears in this setting (§16.4), and limits the inversion of the shear field into a parameter-free map of the projected mass by the Kaiser–Squires method (§16.5). The coherent distortion imprinted by the large-scale structure, the cosmic shear, probes cosmology (§16.6), and stacking foreground–background galaxy pairs measures the mean mass profile of galaxies (§16.7). The chapter expands the brief weak-lensing sketch of §14.7 in Chapter 14 into a self-contained treatment of the core concepts.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `weak_lensing.wl`: symbolic verification of the Kaiser–Squires kernel and inversion, the tangential-shear relation for the SIS and point mass, reduced-shear invariance under the mass-sheet transform, and the image–ellipticity relations; tangential-shear profile and Kaiser–Squires schematic figures exported to `Figures/12_Weak_Lensing/`

16.1 Introduction: The Weak Regime

In strong lensing a single source suffices: from the positions and fluxes of a handful of multiple images one constrains the deflector. In the weak regime, $\kappa \ll 1$ and $|\gamma| \ll 1$, no individual source carries a recognizable signal. Instead, one exploits the fact that lensing preserves surface brightness while distorting shapes: the observed ellipticity of each faint galaxy is a sum of its (unknown) intrinsic ellipticity and a small, coherent shear. Since intrinsic ellipticities are randomly oriented, they average to zero, and the mean observed ellipticity of a local ensemble of galaxies estimates the shear [43].

The accuracy of any weak-lensing measurement is therefore set by the number of usable background galaxies: the statistical error on the shear scales as $\sigma_\epsilon/\sqrt{N}$, where $\sigma_\epsilon \approx 0.3$ is the intrinsic ellipticity dispersion ("shape noise") and N is the number of galaxies averaged over. Deep imaging, reaching $n \sim 20$–30 galaxies per arcmin^2 in a few hours on a 4-m telescope, is therefore the fundamental observational requirement, and the correction of the atmospheric and telescope point-spread function (which circularizes small images) is the central technical challenge of the field (43, Part 3, Sect. 3; 4).

Throughout this chapter we work in the thin-lens picture of Chapter 8 for individual galaxies and clusters, and generalize to a three-dimensional deflecting mass distribution (the large-scale structure) only in §16.6, where the lensing effect is described by an effective surface mass density.

16.2 Galaxy Shapes and the Shear Estimator

16.2.1 Complex Ellipticity

We first require a quantitative measure of the shape of an image with arbitrary isophotes. Let $I(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ be the surface-brightness distribution of an isolated image. Its centroid is $\bar{\boldsymbol{\theta}} = \int d^2\theta\, I\, q_I[I]\, \boldsymbol{\theta} / \int d^2\theta\, I\, q_I[I]$ for a suitable weight q_I, and the tensor of second brightness moments is (43, Part 3, eq. 6)

$$Q_{ij} = \frac{\int d^2\theta\, I(\boldsymbol{\theta})\, q_I[I]\, (\theta_i - \bar{\theta}_i)(\theta_j - \bar{\theta}_j)}{\int d^2\theta\, I(\boldsymbol{\theta})\, q_I[I]}\,, \qquad i,j \in \{1,2\}\,. \tag{16.1}$$

The trace $Q_{11} + Q_{22}$ measures the size of the image, while the traceless part carries the ellipticity. One defines two complex ellipticities (43, Part 3, eq. 7)

$$\boxed{\chi \equiv \frac{Q_{11} - Q_{22} + 2\mathrm{i}\, Q_{12}}{Q_{11} + Q_{22}}\,, \qquad \epsilon \equiv \frac{Q_{11} - Q_{22} + 2\mathrm{i}\, Q_{12}}{Q_{11} + Q_{22} + 2\,(Q_{11}Q_{22} - Q_{12}^2)^{1/2}}\,.} \tag{16.2}$$

Both share the same phase (that of the traceless part), so both encode the same orientation, but they differ in modulus. For an image with elliptical isophotes of axis ratio $r = b/a \leq 1$ (43, Part 3, eq. 8),

$$|\chi| = \frac{1 - r^2}{1 + r^2}\,, \qquad |\epsilon| = \frac{1 - r}{1 + r}\,, \tag{16.3}$$

and the two are related by

$$\epsilon = \frac{\chi}{1 + \sqrt{1 - |\chi|^2}}\,, \qquad \chi = \frac{2\epsilon}{1 + |\epsilon|^2}\,. \tag{16.4}$$

The phase of χ and ϵ is 2φ, twice the position angle φ of the major axis; the factor of two reflects the fact that an ellipse maps to itself under a rotation by 180°. It is this "spin-2" character that χ and ϵ share with the shear (Chapter 9, eq. 9.10).

16.2.2 From Source to Image, and the Estimator

Under the linearized lens mapping the source and image second-moment tensors are related by $Q^{(s)} = \mathcal{A}\, Q\, \mathcal{A}^{\mathsf{T}}$, which in terms of the complex ellipticity ϵ and the *reduced shear* $g = \gamma/(1-\kappa)$ becomes (43, Part 3, eq. 12)

$$\epsilon^{(s)} = \frac{\epsilon - g}{1 - g^{*}\epsilon} \qquad (|g| \leq 1)\,, \tag{16.5}$$

with the inverse obtained by $\epsilon \leftrightarrow \epsilon^{(s)}$ and $g \to -g$. The statistical assumption on which the method rests is that faint galaxies have no preferred orientation, so that the intrinsic ellipticity averages to zero,

$$\mathrm{E}\big[\epsilon^{(s)}\big] = 0\,. \tag{16.6}$$

Averaging the transformation (16.5) over intrinsic orientations then gives (43, Part 3, eq. 14)

$$\boxed{\mathrm{E}[\epsilon] = g \qquad (|g| \leq 1)\,.} \tag{16.7}$$

Each galaxy ellipticity is therefore an unbiased, though very noisy, estimate of the local reduced shear. The noise is set by the intrinsic dispersion $\sigma_\epsilon = \sqrt{\langle \epsilon^{(s)} \epsilon^{(s)*} \rangle}$: averaging over N galaxies subject to the same g, the 1σ error on the mean is $\approx \sigma_\epsilon / \sqrt{N}$ (43, Part 3, eq. 15).

In the proper weak regime, $\kappa \ll 1$ and $|\gamma| \ll 1$, the reduced shear and shear coincide, and one has the useful chain (43, Part 3, eq. 16)

$$\gamma \approx g \approx \langle \epsilon \rangle \approx \frac{\langle \chi \rangle}{2}\,. \tag{16.8}$$

The factor $\frac{1}{2}$ between $\langle \chi \rangle$ and the shear follows directly from (16.3): for small distortions $|\chi| \approx 2|\epsilon|$.

Remark 16.2.1. Shape noise is irreducible: even with perfect measurements, the finite intrinsic ellipticity dispersion σ_ϵ sets a floor on the achievable accuracy. The only remaining freedom lies in the number density n of usable galaxies and in the survey area. Increasing n requires deeper imaging, which also reaches higher-redshift (more strongly lensed) sources; the two gains together motivate deep, wide imaging surveys.

16.3 Tangential and Cross Shear

16.3.1 Definitions

The shear is not a vector: under a rotation of the coordinate frame by ϕ its complex representation is multiplied by $e^{-2\mathrm{i}\phi}$, not $e^{-\mathrm{i}\phi}$. It is a spin-2 (polar) quantity, like linear polarization. Relative to a chosen direction ϕ one defines the *tangential* and *cross* components (43, Part 3, eq. 17)

$$\boxed{\gamma_{\mathrm{t}} = -\mathrm{Re}\big(\gamma\, e^{-2\mathrm{i}\phi}\big)\,, \qquad \gamma_{\times} = -\mathrm{Im}\big(\gamma\, e^{-2\mathrm{i}\phi}\big)\,,} \tag{16.9}$$

and identically for the ellipticity components $\epsilon_{\mathrm{t}}, \epsilon_{\times}$. Taking ϕ to be the polar angle of the point relative to a chosen center, $\gamma_{\mathrm{t}} > 0$ describes a shear oriented tangentially (an image stretched perpendicular to the line to the center), and $\gamma_{\mathrm{t}} < 0$ a radial stretch. The sign in (16.9) is chosen so that a circular mass concentration, which stretches background images tangentially, produces a positive γ_{t}. For a circularly symmetric deflector the shear is purely tangential at every point, so $\gamma_{\times} = 0$; a non-zero cross component averaged over many pairs is a standard null test for systematics (its expectation vanishes by parity, §16.6).

16.3.2 Mean Tangential Shear and the Projected Mass

For a circularly symmetric lens, Chapter 11 (eq. 11.7) gives $\gamma_{\mathrm{t}}(\theta) = \bar{\kappa}(\theta) - \kappa(\theta)$, the mean convergence interior to θ minus the local convergence. Bartelmann [2] showed that a nearly identical relation holds for the azimuthal average of a completely general, non-symmetric mass distribution. Starting from Gauss's theorem applied to the deflection potential ψ (with $\nabla^2\psi = 2\kappa$) and differentiating the enclosed dimensionless mass $m(\theta) = \pi^{-1}\int_{|\vartheta|\le\theta} d^2\vartheta\,\kappa(\vartheta) = \theta^2\bar{\kappa}(\theta)$ with respect to θ, one obtains (43, Part 3, eq. 24)

$$\boxed{\langle\gamma_{\mathrm{t}}\rangle(\theta) = \bar{\kappa}(\theta) - \langle\kappa\rangle(\theta)\,,} \tag{16.10}$$

where $\langle\cdot\rangle(\theta)$ denotes the average over the circle of radius θ and $\bar{\kappa}(\theta)$ the mean convergence inside it. It follows that the tangential shear averaged on concentric circles gives the azimuthally averaged mass profile of any lens, symmetric or not.

It is customary to write this in physical units. Multiplying by the critical surface mass density Σ_{cr} (Chapter 8) and using $\kappa = \Sigma/\Sigma_{\mathrm{cr}}$,

$$\gamma_{\mathrm{t}}(\theta)\,\Sigma_{\mathrm{cr}} = \bar{\Sigma}(<\theta) - \Sigma(\theta) \equiv \Delta\Sigma(\theta)\,, \tag{16.11}$$

the *excess surface mass density* $\Delta\Sigma$: the mean surface density inside radius θ minus that at θ. Equation (16.11) is the basic relation of cluster and galaxy–galaxy weak lensing: the observable tangential shear translates directly into a projected mass profile.

Example 16.3.1 (Tangential shear of an SIS)**.** For the singular isothermal sphere (Chapter 11, eqs. 11.20–11.21) we have $\kappa = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}/(2\theta)$ and $\bar{\kappa} = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}/\theta$, so

$$\gamma_{\mathrm{t}}(\theta) = \bar{\kappa} - \kappa = \frac{\theta_{\mathrm{E}}}{\theta} - \frac{\theta_{\mathrm{E}}}{2\theta} = \frac{\theta_{\mathrm{E}}}{2\theta}\,. \tag{16.12}$$

The tangential shear falls off as θ^{-1}, exactly tracing the $\Sigma \propto \theta^{-1}$ isothermal profile. For a point mass, $\kappa = 0$ (away from the origin) and $\gamma_{\rm t} = \bar{\kappa} = \theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta^2$. Both are verified in `weak_lensing.wl`.

16.4 Reduced Shear and the Mass-Sheet Degeneracy

Galaxy ellipticities measure not the shear γ but the reduced shear $g = \gamma/(1-\kappa)$ (eq. 16.7). To see the consequence, consider the transformation, for an arbitrary constant λ, (43, Part 3, eq. 51)

$$\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \;\longrightarrow\; \kappa'(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \lambda\,\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) + (1-\lambda)\,, \qquad 1-\kappa' = \lambda\,(1-\kappa)\,. \tag{16.13}$$

Since the shear is the traceless part of the same Hessian that gives the convergence, scaling κ by λ scales the shear by λ, while the added *uniform sheet* $(1-\lambda)$ contributes no shear (its Hessian is isotropic). Hence $\gamma \to \gamma' = \lambda\gamma$, and therefore

$$\boxed{\,g' = \frac{\gamma'}{1-\kappa'} = \frac{\lambda\gamma}{\lambda(1-\kappa)} = \frac{\gamma}{1-\kappa} = g\,.\,} \tag{16.14}$$

The reduced shear, and hence every ellipticity measurement, is invariant under (16.13). This is the weak-lensing form of the *mass-sheet degeneracy* introduced in Chapter 13: from shear data alone the convergence is determined only up to the one-parameter family (16.13). In the Kaiser–Squires inversion below it appears as an undetermined additive constant κ_0.

The degeneracy also rescales the magnification. With $\mu^{-1} = (1-\kappa)^2 - |\gamma|^2$ (Chapter 9, eq. 9.20), the transform (16.13) gives

$$\mu \;\longrightarrow\; \mu' = \lambda^{-2}\,\mu\,, \tag{16.15}$$

so that magnification information can in principle break the degeneracy that shear alone cannot. Such information is available from the lensing-induced change in background number counts, $n(>S)/n_0(>S) \approx 1 + 2(\alpha-1)\kappa$ in the weak limit for unlensed counts $n_0(>S) \propto S^{-\alpha}$ (here α is the count slope, not a deflection angle) (43, Part 3, eq. 27). Both invariances are checked symbolically in `weak_lensing.wl`.

16.5 Cluster Mass Reconstruction

We now turn to the method that made weak lensing quantitative: from a measured shear field one can reconstruct a parameter-free map of the projected mass, with no assumption of symmetry [20].

16.5.1 The Kaiser–Squires Inversion

The convergence and shear are both linear (second-derivative) functionals of the single potential ψ (Chapter 9), so they are related to each other by a non-local convolution. Explicitly (43, Part 3, eq. 41)

$$\gamma(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{1}{\pi}\int_{\mathbb{R}^2} d^2\theta'\; \mathcal{D}(\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}')\,\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}')\,, \qquad \mathcal{D}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \equiv -\frac{\theta_1^2 - \theta_2^2 + 2\mathrm{i}\,\theta_1\theta_2}{|\boldsymbol{\theta}|^4} = \frac{-1}{(\theta_1 - \mathrm{i}\,\theta_2)^2}\,. \tag{16.16}$$

The complex kernel $\mathcal{D}$ is the shear produced by a point mass. In Fourier space the convolution becomes a product, $\hat{\gamma}(\boldsymbol{\ell}) = \pi^{-1}\hat{\mathcal{D}}(\boldsymbol{\ell})\,\hat{\kappa}(\boldsymbol{\ell})$, with (43, Part 3, eq. 43)

$$\hat{\mathcal{D}}(\boldsymbol{\ell}) = \pi\,\frac{\ell_1^2 - \ell_2^2 + 2\mathrm{i}\,\ell_1\ell_2}{|\boldsymbol{\ell}|^2} = \pi\,e^{2\mathrm{i}\beta_\ell}\,, \qquad \hat{\mathcal{D}}\,\hat{\mathcal{D}}^* = \pi^2\,, \tag{16.17}$$

where β_ℓ is the polar angle of $\boldsymbol{\ell}$. Because $|\hat{\mathcal{D}}|^2 = \pi^2$ is a constant, the relation inverts trivially, $\hat{\kappa} = \pi^{-1}\hat{\gamma}\,\hat{\mathcal{D}}^*$ (for $\boldsymbol{\ell} \neq 0$), and transforming back to real space yields the *Kaiser–Squires inversion* (43, Part 3, eq. 44; 20)

$$\boxed{\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) - \kappa_0 = \frac{1}{\pi}\int_{\mathbb{R}^2} d^2\theta'\;\mathrm{Re}[\mathcal{D}^*(\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\theta}')\,\gamma(\boldsymbol{\theta}')]\,.} \tag{16.18}$$

Since the observed shear can be estimated at galaxy positions (via eq. 16.7), (16.18) converts a measured shear map into a mass map.

Remark 16.5.1. Three properties of (16.18) should be kept in mind; all are verified in `weak_lensing.wl`. First, $\hat{\mathcal{D}}$ is undefined at $\boldsymbol{\ell} = 0$, so the mean (DC) mode of κ is unconstrained and the additive constant κ_0 remains free. This is the mass-sheet degeneracy (16.13): a uniform sheet produces no shear. Second, what is measured is the reduced shear g, not γ. In the weak limit $\gamma \approx g$, but in the non-linear inner regions of clusters one must solve the integral equation

$$\kappa - \kappa_0 = \frac{1}{\pi}\int d^2\theta'\;[1 - \kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}')]\,\mathrm{Re}[\mathcal{D}^*(\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\theta}')\,g(\boldsymbol{\theta}')]$$

iteratively (43, Part 3, eq. 50). Third, a naive discrete sum over galaxies has formally infinite variance (the θ^{-2} kernel), so a smoothing kernel is required to obtain a finite-variance mass estimator.

16.5.2 Aperture Mass

The undetermined constant κ_0 motivates a statistic that is insensitive to the mass-sheet degeneracy, the *aperture mass* (43, Part 3, eq. 108)

$$M_{\mathrm{ap}}(\theta) = \int d^2\vartheta\;Q(|\vartheta|)\,\gamma_{\mathrm{t}}(\vartheta)\,, \tag{16.19}$$

a weighted integral of the tangential shear within an aperture of radius θ, with Q a weight function of compact support. If Q is derived from a *compensated* filter U (one with $\int d^2\vartheta\,U = 0$), then M_{ap} can equivalently be written as $\int d^2\vartheta\,U(|\vartheta|)\,\kappa(\vartheta)$: since U integrates to zero, adding a uniform sheet κ_0 contributes nothing, so M_{ap} is invariant under (16.13). Since it is built from the observable γ_{t} directly, it requires no inversion, and, as shown below, it serves also as a cosmic-shear statistic and as a matched filter for detecting mass concentrations by their shear alone.

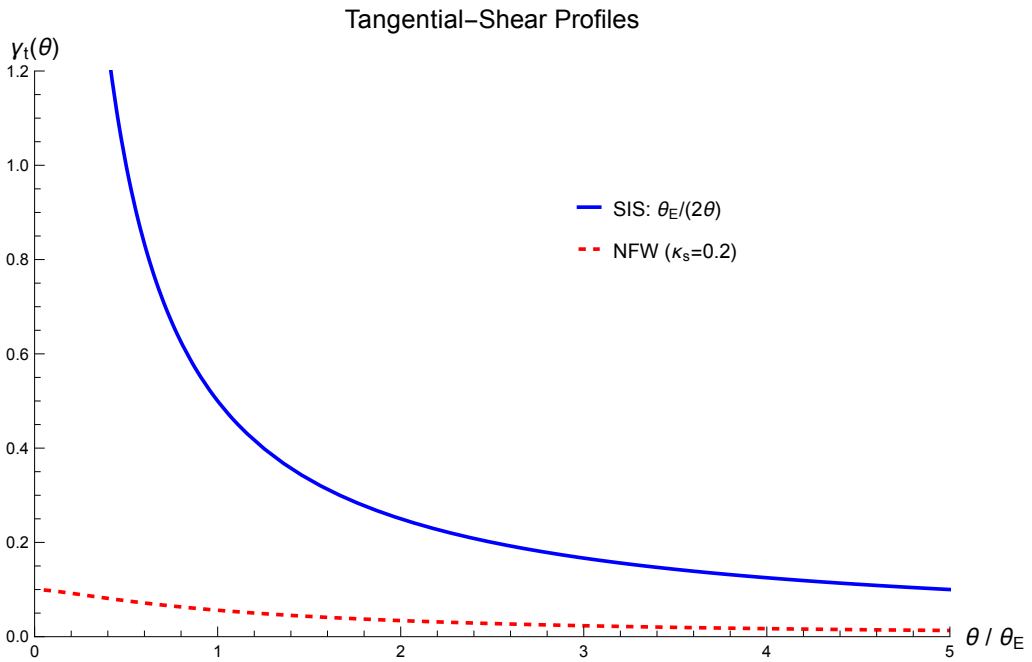


Figure 16.1: Tangential-shear profiles $\gamma_{\rm t}(\theta)$ for two axisymmetric lenses, illustrating eq. (16.10). **Solid:** the singular isothermal sphere, $\gamma_{\rm t} = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta)$ (eq. 16.12), with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1$. **Dashed:** an NFW halo (Chapter 11, eq. 11.54) with $\kappa_s = 0.2$ and scale $\theta_s = 1$. The NFW tangential shear decreases monotonically: it tends to the finite value $\kappa_s/2$ at the centre, is nearly flat inside θ_s, and steepens outside it, whereas the SIS is a single power law. The measurable $\gamma_{\rm t}$ maps directly to the excess surface mass density $\Delta\Sigma$ (eq. 16.11). Generated by `weak_lensing.wl`.

16.6 Cosmic Shear: Lensing by the Large-Scale Structure

So far the deflector has been a single, localized mass (galaxy or cluster) in a thin lens plane. Light bundles from distant galaxies are, however, distorted continuously by all the inhomogeneous matter along the line of sight, the large-scale structure (LSS). This produces a weak, spatially coherent distortion of galaxy shapes across the sky called *cosmic shear*, whose statistics directly probe the matter distribution and hence cosmology [7, 19] (43, Part 3, Sect. 6).

16.6.1 The Effective Convergence

For a three-dimensional deflecting mass distribution, working to first order in the Newtonian potential Φ (the Born approximation, i.e. integrating along the unperturbed ray), the distortion is still described by a Jacobian $\mathcal{A}_{ij} = \delta_{ij} - \psi_{,ij}$ with an *effective* deflection potential. Its convergence is a line-of-sight integral of the fractional density contrast $\delta = \Delta\rho/\bar{\rho}$, weighted by the geometric lensing efficiency (43, Part 3, eq. 93)

$$\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{3H_0^2\,\Omega_{\rm m}}{2c^2} \int_0^{w_h} dw\; g(w)\, f_K(w)\, \frac{\delta(f_K(w)\boldsymbol{\theta},\, w)}{a(w)}\,, \tag{16.20}$$

where w is comoving distance, a the scale factor, f_K the comoving angular-diameter distance, and $g(w) = \int_w^{w_h} dw'\, p_w(w')\, f_K(w'-w)/f_K(w')$ is the source-averaged efficiency factor. Two properties of this expression follow directly: $\kappa \propto \Omega_\mathrm{m}$, because lensing responds to the physical density contrast $\Delta\rho \propto \Omega_\mathrm{m}\,\delta$, not to δ alone; and κ can be negative, since δ can be (unlike the surface density of a real cluster).

16.6.2 The Convergence Power Spectrum

Because δ is a realization of a random field, the observables are statistical. Applying Limber's equation to the projection (16.20) relates the *convergence power spectrum* $P_\kappa(\ell)$ to the three-dimensional matter power spectrum $P_\delta(k)$ (43, Part 3, eq. 99)

$$\boxed{P_\kappa(\ell) = \frac{9H_0^4\,\Omega_\mathrm{m}^2}{4c^4} \int_0^{w_h} dw\, \frac{g^2(w)}{a^2(w)}\, P_\delta\!\left(\frac{\ell}{f_K(w)},\, w\right).} \tag{16.21}$$

The shear power spectrum equals the convergence power spectrum, since $\hat\gamma(\boldsymbol{\ell}) = e^{2\mathrm{i}\beta_\ell}\,\hat\kappa(\boldsymbol{\ell})$ from (16.17) and $|e^{2\mathrm{i}\beta_\ell}| = 1$. The strong prefactor makes the cosmic-shear amplitude scale roughly as $\sigma_8\,\Omega_\mathrm{m}^{0.5}$, much like cluster abundances, so cosmic shear is a leading probe of the clustering amplitude of matter [43, Part 3, Sect. 6.4].

16.6.3 Two-Point Statistics

P_κ is not measured directly; what one estimates from a shear catalogue are real-space two-point functions. Using the tangential and cross components (16.9) defined with respect to the line connecting each galaxy pair, one forms the two *shear correlation functions* (43, Part 3, eqs. 104–105)

$$\xi_\pm(\theta) = \langle\gamma_\mathrm{t}\gamma_\mathrm{t}\rangle(\theta) \pm \langle\gamma_\times\gamma_\times\rangle(\theta) = \int_0^\infty \frac{d\ell\,\ell}{2\pi}\, J_{0,4}(\ell\theta)\, P_\kappa(\ell)\,, \tag{16.22}$$

with J_0 for ξ_+ and J_4 for ξ_-. The mixed correlator $\xi_\times = \langle\gamma_\mathrm{t}\gamma_\times\rangle$ vanishes by parity: under a reflection $\gamma_\mathrm{t} \to \gamma_\mathrm{t}$ but $\gamma_\times \to -\gamma_\times$, so a non-zero $\xi_\times$ (or a "B-mode" signal) flags residual systematics. The correlation functions are the preferred observable because, unlike aperture statistics, they can be evaluated over gaps and masked regions; every galaxy pair at a given separation contributes, whatever the survey geometry. The aperture-mass dispersion $\langle M_\mathrm{ap}^2\rangle(\theta)$ built from the statistic (16.19) is a convenient summary, because its filter is so narrow that it probes P_κ at nearly a single multipole $\ell \approx 4$–$5/\theta$; the filter $J_4^2(\eta)/\eta^4$ peaks at $\eta = \ell\theta \approx 4.1$ (43, Part 3, eq. 109 and Sect. 6.3, who quote $\ell \sim 5/\theta$).

Remark 16.6.1 (Tomography). Splitting the source galaxies into photometric-redshift bins and measuring $\xi_\pm$ within and between bins gives the redshift evolution of the matter power spectrum through the changing efficiency $g(w)$ in (16.21). This "weak-lensing tomography" turns a projected 2-D measurement into a partially 3-D probe, and is central to the dark-energy programs of Stage-IV surveys.

16.7 Galaxy–Galaxy Lensing

A single galaxy is far too weak a lens to be detected individually: the signal-to-noise ratio of an SIS detection scales as $S/N \propto \theta_{\rm E}\sqrt{n}\,/\sigma_\epsilon$, which for a galaxy ($\sigma_v \lesssim 200\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}}$) is far too small (43, Part 3, eq. 19). The signals of many galaxies can, however, be stacked. In the mean, a background galaxy behind a foreground (lens) galaxy is stretched tangentially about it, so the mean tangential ellipticity of background sources, binned by the foreground–background separation θ, measures the mean tangential shear $\gamma_{\rm t}(\theta)$, and hence, through eq. (16.11), the average projected mass profile of the lens galaxies (43, Part 3, Sect. 8.2; first detected by Brainerd et al. [9]).

Since the halo of a single galaxy cannot be mapped, one parametrizes the lens population and fits. A standard choice is a *truncated isothermal sphere*: an isothermal $\rho \propto r^{-2}$ core turning to $\rho \propto r^{-4}$ beyond a truncation radius s, with the velocity dispersion and truncation scaled to luminosity via the Faber–Jackson / Tully–Fisher relations,

$$\sigma = \sigma_* \left(\frac{L}{L_*}\right)^{\beta/2}, \qquad s = s_* \left(\frac{L}{L_*}\right)^{\eta}, \qquad M \propto \sigma^2 s\,. \tag{16.23}$$

Fitting the stacked $\gamma_{\rm t}(\theta)$ constrains $(\sigma_*, s_*, \beta, \eta)$ and thereby the mass, extent, and luminosity scaling of galaxy dark-matter haloes out to radii far beyond the reach of stellar or gas dynamics. The first detection [9] yielded $\sigma_* \approx 160\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}}$ for an L_* galaxy; modern surveys stack millions of lenses and split them by colour, stellar mass, and environment. On larger scales the same measurement transitions into a probe of the galaxy–mass cross-correlation (the "bias" of galaxies relative to the underlying matter).

16.8 Summary

In the weak regime, $\kappa \ll 1$, $|\gamma| \ll 1$, so $\mathcal{A} \approx \mathbb{1}$. No individual source shows a recognizable signal; the shear is recovered only statistically, by averaging galaxy shapes, with error $\sim \sigma_\epsilon/\sqrt{N}$ set by shape noise. The complex ellipticities χ, ϵ (eq. 16.2) are spin-2 shape measures. With randomly oriented intrinsic ellipticities, $\mathrm{E}[\epsilon] = g$, the reduced shear, so that each galaxy is an unbiased, noisy shear estimate; in the weak limit $\gamma \approx g \approx \langle\epsilon\rangle \approx \langle\chi\rangle/2$.

The tangential shear is $\gamma_{\rm t} = -\mathrm{Re}(\gamma e^{-2\mathrm{i}\phi})$. Averaged on circles, $\langle\gamma_{\rm t}\rangle = \bar\kappa - \langle\kappa\rangle$ for any mass distribution (eq. 16.10), so that $\gamma_{\rm t}\Sigma_{\rm cr} = \Delta\Sigma$ measures the projected mass profile; for the SIS, $\gamma_{\rm t} = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta)$. The reduced shear $g = \gamma/(1-\kappa)$ is invariant under $\kappa \to \lambda\kappa + (1-\lambda)$, $\gamma \to \lambda\gamma$ (with $\mu \to \lambda^{-2}\mu$), so shear determines κ only up to an additive constant; this is the mass-sheet degeneracy, which magnification (number counts) can break.

The shear γ and the convergence κ are related by convolution with $\mathcal{D}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = -1/(\theta_1 - \mathrm{i}\theta_2)^2$. Since $|\hat{\mathcal{D}}|^2 = \pi^2$, this inverts to $\kappa - \kappa_0 = \pi^{-1}\int \mathrm{Re}[\mathcal{D}^*\gamma]\, d^2\theta'$ (eq. 16.18), the Kaiser–Squires parameter-free mass map. The aperture mass $M_{\rm ap}$ is a mass-sheet-invariant alternative.

The large-scale structure distorts galaxy shapes coherently. The effective convergence (16.20) has power spectrum $P_\kappa \propto \Omega_{\rm m}^2 \int (g^2/a^2)\, P_\delta$ (eq. 16.21), measured through $\xi_\pm(\theta) = \int (d\ell\,\ell/2\pi) J_{0,4}(\ell\theta) P_\kappa$; the amplitude scales as $\sim \sigma_8\, \Omega_{\rm m}^{0.5}$, and tomography adds redshift information. Finally, stacking foreground–background pairs measures the mean $\gamma_{\rm t}$ and hence the average galaxy mass profile (truncated isothermal, eq. 16.23), extending to a probe of galaxy bias on large scales.

16.9 Problems

Exercise 16.9.1. (Reduced shear and the mass-sheet degeneracy.) The mass-sheet transform is $\kappa \to \kappa' = \lambda\kappa + (1-\lambda)$, $\gamma \to \gamma' = \lambda\gamma$, for constant λ.

(a) Show that the reduced shear $g = \gamma/(1-\kappa)$ is invariant under this transform.

(b) Using $\mu^{-1} = (1-\kappa)^2 - |\gamma|^2$, show that the magnification transforms as $\mu \to \lambda^{-2}\mu$.

(c) Explain why a purely local measurement of galaxy ellipticities cannot break the degeneracy, and name one observable that can.

(d) Why is the transform called a "mass sheet"? Compute the convergence of a uniform sheet $\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = 1 - \lambda$ and its shear.

Verify with `problems_12.wl`.

Exercise 16.9.2. (Tangential shear and the projected mass.)

(a) For the SIS with $\kappa(\theta) = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta)$, compute the mean convergence $\bar\kappa(\theta)$ and show that the tangential shear is $\gamma_{\rm t}(\theta) = \bar\kappa - \kappa = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta)$.

(b) For a point mass, $\kappa = 0$ away from the origin. What is $\gamma_{\rm t}(\theta)$? Contrast the radial fall-off of $\gamma_{\rm t}$ for the point mass and the SIS.

(c) Starting from $\langle\gamma_{\rm t}\rangle = \bar\kappa - \langle\kappa\rangle$ (eq. 16.10), show that in physical units the observable tangential shear equals the excess surface mass density, $\gamma_{\rm t}\Sigma_{\rm cr} = \bar\Sigma(<\theta) - \Sigma(\theta)$.

(d) For an NFW halo, sketch $\gamma_{\rm t}(\theta)$ using Chapter 11 (eq. 11.54). Show that it stays finite at the centre, and explain qualitatively why its logarithmic slope changes near θ_s, unlike the single power law of the SIS.

Verify with `problems_12.wl`.

Exercise 16.9.3. (The Kaiser–Squires kernel.) The forward relation is $\hat\gamma(\boldsymbol{\ell}) = \pi^{-1}\hat{\mathcal{D}}(\boldsymbol{\ell})\,\hat\kappa(\boldsymbol{\ell})$ with $\hat{\mathcal{D}} = \pi(\ell_1^2 - \ell_2^2 + 2{\rm i}\ell_1\ell_2)/|\boldsymbol{\ell}|^2$.

(a) Show that $\hat{\mathcal{D}}(\boldsymbol{\ell})\,\hat{\mathcal{D}}^*(\boldsymbol{\ell}) = \pi^2$ for all $\boldsymbol{\ell} \neq 0$.

(b) Use this to derive the inversion $\hat\kappa = \pi^{-1}\hat\gamma\,\hat{\mathcal{D}}^*$, and hence eq. (16.18).

(c) Explain why the inversion determines κ only up to an additive constant κ_0. Relate this to Exercise 16.9.1.

(d) Writing $\hat{\mathcal{D}} = \pi\, e^{2{\rm i}\beta_\ell}$ (with β_ℓ the polar angle of $\boldsymbol{\ell}$), verify that the shear and convergence have identical power spectra, $P_\gamma(\ell) = P_\kappa(\ell)$.

Verify with `problems_12.wl`.

Exercise 16.9.4. (Complex ellipticity.) An image has elliptical isophotes with semi-axes $a \geq b$ and axis ratio $r = b/a$, aligned with the coordinate axes (so $Q_{12} = 0$, $Q_{11} = a^2/4$, $Q_{22} = b^2/4$ up to a common factor).

(a) Using the definitions (16.2), show $|\chi| = (1 - r^2)/(1 + r^2)$ and $|\epsilon| = (1 - r)/(1 + r)$.

(b) Verify the transformation $\epsilon = \chi/(1 + \sqrt{1 - |\chi|^2})$ and its inverse $\chi = 2\epsilon/(1 + |\epsilon|^2)$.

(c) In the weak-distortion limit ($r \to 1$), show $|\chi| \approx 2|\epsilon|$, and hence that the shear estimators satisfy $\langle\chi\rangle/2 \approx \langle\epsilon\rangle \approx \gamma$.

Verify with `problems_12.wl`.

Exercise 16.9.5. (Cosmic-shear correlation functions.)

(a) Starting from the definitions $\xi_\pm = \langle\gamma_t\gamma_t\rangle \pm \langle\gamma_\times\gamma_\times\rangle$ and the relation (16.22), explain why ξ_+ and ξ_- are *not* independent (both derive from the single field P_κ).

(b) Show, using the parity behaviour $\gamma_t \to \gamma_t$, $\gamma_\times \to -\gamma_\times$ under reflection, that the mixed correlator $\xi_\times = \langle\gamma_t\gamma_\times\rangle$ vanishes. Why is this a useful systematics test?

(c) For a scale-free power spectrum $P_\kappa(\ell) = A\,\ell^{-1}$, use $\int_0^\infty J_n(\ell\theta)\,d\ell = 1/\theta$ (valid for $n = 0$ and $n = 4$) to compute $\xi_+(\theta)$ and $\xi_-(\theta)$. Why would the steeper $P_\kappa \propto \ell^{-2}$ not give a finite ξ_+?

(d) Explain why the aperture-mass dispersion $\langle M_{\rm ap}^2\rangle(\theta)$ gives more *localized* information about P_κ than the shear dispersion $\langle|\bar\gamma|^2\rangle(\theta)$.

Verify with `problems_12.wl`.

Chapter 17

Gravitational Microlensing

> *"Of course, there is no hope of observing this phenomenon directly."* —
> A. Einstein, *Science* **84**, 506 (1936), on star–star lensing

Einstein's pessimism [17] was well founded for the technology of his day, but wrong for ours. The images formed when one star lenses another are split by only $\sim 10^{-3}$ arcsec, far too small to resolve, so the individual images that dominated Chapters 8 through 12 can never be seen. What is observable is the total magnification, and since the lens, source, and observer are all in relative motion, that magnification varies with time. Monitoring millions of stars turns this small, transient brightening into one of the most productive tools in modern astrophysics. This is the regime of *gravitational microlensing*, and it is the subject of this chapter, which follows Part 4 of Schneider et al. [43].

Microlensing reuses the physics already developed: it is the point-mass lens of Chapter 8 and the magnification formalism of Chapter 9, read out in a new observational regime. Since the images are unresolved, the observable is the time-variable total magnification $A(u)$ rather than the image positions. The natural clock is the Einstein-radius crossing time $t_{\rm E}$, and the light curve has a universal, symmetric shape, the Paczyński curve. Ensembles of unseen lenses are characterized statistically through the optical depth τ, and small departures from the point-lens light curve reveal binary companions and planets, through the caustics of Chapter 12 realized at stellar scales. The sub-milliarcsecond motion of the light centroid (astrometric microlensing) and the micro-caustic networks that cross the images of multiply imaged quasars (Chapters 12–13) extend the method to lens masses and quasar sizes.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `microlensing.wl`: symbolic derivation of the point-lens magnification $A(u) = (u^2+2)/(u\sqrt{u^2+4})$ from the two images, its $u \to 0$ and $u \to \infty$ limits, and the symmetry of the Paczyński light curve about the peak; figures exported to `Figures/13_Microlensing/`
- `microlensing_explorer.nb`: interactive notebook with `Manipulate` widgets for the light curve (vary u_0, t_0, $t_{\rm E}$) and for the binary-lens caustic topology (vary mass ratio q and separation d)

17.1 The Microlensing Regime

Consider a foreground star of mass M at distance D_d lensing a background star at distance D_s. The angular Einstein radius is (eq. 8.17, specialized to a point mass)

$$\theta_\mathrm{E} = \sqrt{\frac{4GM}{c^2}\,\frac{D_\mathrm{ds}}{D_\mathrm{d}\,D_\mathrm{s}}}\,, \tag{17.1}$$

which for stellar masses and kiloparsec distances evaluates to $\theta_\mathrm{E} \sim 10^{-3}$ arcsec (a milliarcsecond, far below the arcsecond image splittings of galaxy lensing). The two images produced by a point lens straddle the lens and are separated by $\Delta\theta \approx 2\theta_\mathrm{E} \sim$ mas, far below the resolution of any conventional telescope.

As a result, individual image positions, magnifications, and shapes are not measurable. All the information carried by the image geometry in earlier chapters is lost. What survives is the sum of the image fluxes, the total magnification, which, through the relative motion, sweeps out a light curve [43, Sect. 1]. The remainder of this chapter is largely the study of that light curve and its perturbations.

Remark 17.1.1. Microlensing is defined by the observable, not by the lens mass. The same point-mass physics describes a planet ($10^{-6}\,M_\odot$) perturbing a stellar event and a $30\,M_\odot$ black hole in the Galactic halo. What makes all of these "micro" is that the image splitting is unresolved, so that the total magnification is the only observable.

17.2 Point-Lens Magnification

Scale all angles by θ_E and work with the dimensionless source position $u \equiv \beta/\theta_\mathrm{E}$ and image position $y \equiv \theta/\theta_\mathrm{E}$. The point-mass lens equation (Chapter 8) reduces to the one-dimensional form [43, eq. 1]

$$\boxed{u = y - \frac{1}{y}} \tag{17.2}$$

This is quadratic, $y^2 - u\,y - 1 = 0$, with the two roots

$$y_\pm = \frac{1}{2}\left(u \pm \sqrt{u^2+4}\right)\,. \tag{17.3}$$

The two images always straddle the lens: $y_+ > 0$ lies on the same side as the source (positive parity, brighter, always outside the Einstein ring), while $y_- < 0$ lies on the opposite side (negative parity, fainter, inside the ring). Their separation is $|y_+ - y_-| = \sqrt{u^2+4}$.

17.2.1 Magnification of Each Image

For a circularly symmetric lens the signed magnification of an image at y is $\mu = [\,1 - y^{-4}\,]^{-1}$ (the product of the tangential and radial eigenvalues, eq. 11.9 evaluated for $\alpha = 1/y$). Substituting eq. (17.3) [43, eq. 3],

$$\mu_\pm = \pm\frac{1}{2}\left[\frac{u^2+2}{u\sqrt{u^2+4}} \pm 1\right]\,, \tag{17.4}$$

so that $\mu_+ > 0$, $\mu_- < 0$, and the images obey the sum rule $\mu_+ + \mu_- = 1$. (The leading $\pm$, which carries the image parity, is present in the cited eq. 3; without it the bracket gives only $|\mu_\pm|$, and an earlier version of this equation dropped it.)

17.2.2 Total Magnification

Since only the combined flux is observable, the relevant quantity is the *total magnification* $A(u) = |\mu_+| + |\mu_-| = \mu_+ - \mu_-$:

$$\boxed{A(u) = \frac{u^2 + 2}{u\sqrt{u^2 + 4}}} \tag{17.5}$$

This is the central formula of single-lens microlensing [43, eq. 4]; the derivation by summing the two image magnifications is verified symbolically in `microlensing.wl`. Its two limits are

$$A(u) \longrightarrow \frac{1}{u} \qquad (u \to 0)\,, \tag{17.6}$$

$$A(u) \longrightarrow 1 \qquad (u \to \infty)\,. \tag{17.7}$$

Close alignment ($u \to 0$) gives arbitrarily high magnification (formally infinite for a point source at $u = 0$, where the images merge into an Einstein ring), while a distant source ($u \gg 1$) is lensed only negligibly. At the fiducial separation $u = 1$ the magnification is $A(1) = 3/\sqrt{5} \approx 1.34$, corresponding to a brightening of $\Delta m = 2.5 \log_{10} A \approx 0.32$ mag; the positive-parity image then supplies 87% of the total flux [43, Sect. 1.2]. The value $u = 1$ is the conventional threshold defining a microlensing "event".

17.3 The Light Curve and the Einstein Timescale

A microlensing event is a temporal phenomenon. Over the days-to-months duration of an event the relative motion of lens and source is well approximated as rectilinear, so the separation traces a straight line past the lens. Writing t_0 for the time of closest approach and u_0 for the minimum (impact-parameter) separation, the source–lens separation is [43, eq. 8]

$$\boxed{u(t) = \sqrt{u_0^2 + \left(\frac{t - t_0}{t_\mathrm{E}}\right)^2}} \tag{17.8}$$

where the *Einstein (crossing) timescale*

$$t_\mathrm{E} \equiv \frac{D_\mathrm{d}\,\theta_\mathrm{E}}{v_\perp} = \frac{R_\mathrm{E}}{v_\perp} \tag{17.9}$$

is the time for the lens to traverse one (physical) Einstein radius $R_\mathrm{E} = D_\mathrm{d}\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$ at transverse speed $v_\perp$. Substituting eq. (17.8) into eq. (17.5) gives the observed light curve $F(t) = A(u(t))\,F_s$, where F_s is the unlensed source flux.

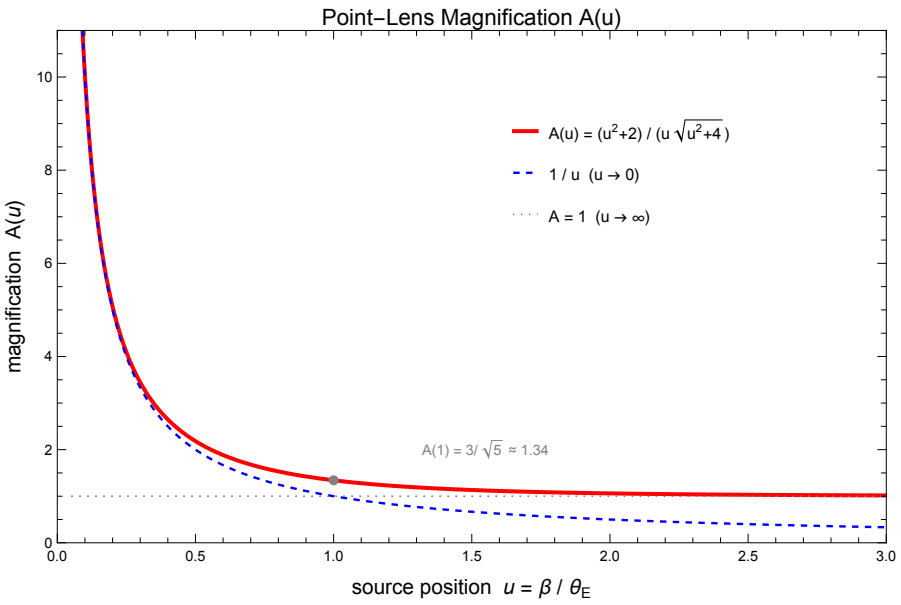


Figure 17.1: The point-lens total magnification $A(u)$ (eq. 17.5, red) as a function of the source–lens separation $u = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$. The high-magnification asymptote $A \to 1/u$ (blue dashed) and the unlensed limit $A \to 1$ (grey dotted) are shown for reference; the marked point is $A(1) = 3/\sqrt{5} \approx 1.34$. Generated by `microlensing.wl`.

17.3.1 The Paczyński Curve

The resulting light curve, the *Paczyński curve* [33], is smooth, achromatic, and symmetric about t_0. Symmetry follows immediately because $u(t)$ depends on time only through $(t-t_0)^2$: $u(t_0+s) = u(t_0-s)$, hence $A(u(t_0+s)) = A(u(t_0-s))$. Since A is a monotonically decreasing function of u (indeed $dA/du = -8/[u^2(u^2+4)^{3/2}] < 0$), the peak magnification occurs at closest approach:

$$A_{\max} = A(u_0) = \frac{u_0^2+2}{u_0\sqrt{u_0^2+4}} \;\approx\; \frac{1}{u_0} \quad (u_0 \ll 1)\,. \tag{17.10}$$

Both the symmetry and the identification $A_{\max} = A(u_0)$ are verified in `microlensing.wl`.

The point-source, point-lens light curve is described by four parameters: the baseline flux F_0, the peak time t_0, the impact parameter u_0, and the timescale $t_{\rm E}$. Of these only $t_{\rm E}$ carries physical information about the lens, and it does so in the degenerate combination $t_{\rm E} = D_{\rm d}\theta_{\rm E}/v_\perp \propto \sqrt{M}$ that mixes the lens mass M, distance $D_{\rm d}$, and transverse velocity $v_\perp$ [43, Sect. 1.2]. To break this degeneracy, and so to determine the lens mass, requires additional information: finite-source effects, parallax, or the astrometric shift of §17.6.

Example 17.3.1 (A typical Galactic event)**.** For a lens of $M = 0.3\,M_\odot$ halfway to a bulge source ($D_{\rm d} = 4$ kpc, $D_{\rm s} = 8$ kpc) moving at $v_\perp = 200\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}}$, eqs. (17.1) and (17.9) give $\theta_{\rm E} \approx 0.55$ mas, $R_{\rm E} \approx 2.2$ AU, and $t_{\rm E} \approx 19$ days, of order weeks, as observed. The numbers are computed in `problems_13.wl`.

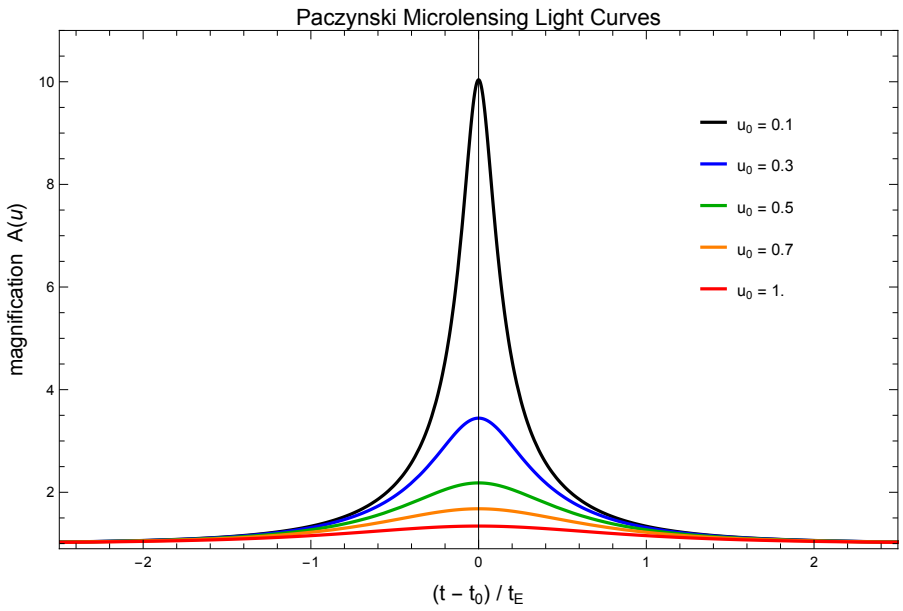


Figure 17.2: Paczyński microlensing light curves (eq. 17.8 substituted into eq. 17.5) for minimum impact parameters $u_0 = 0.1, 0.3, 0.5, 0.7, 1.0$ (top to bottom). Time is in units of the Einstein timescale $t_{\rm E}$; every curve is symmetric about the peak at $(t-t_0)/t_{\rm E} = 0$, and the smaller the impact parameter the higher and narrower the peak ($A_{\max} \approx 1/u_0$). Generated by `microlensing.wl`.

17.4 Optical Depth to Microlensing

A single event is rare, so microlensing is inherently a statistical undertaking: one monitors millions of stars to catch a handful of events. The relevant statistic is the *optical depth* τ, the probability that a random source lies within one Einstein radius of some lens at a given instant; equivalently, it is the fraction of the sky covered by the Einstein disks of all the lenses [43, Sect. 1.4].

For lenses distributed with mass density $\rho(D_{\rm d})$ along the line of sight, Paczynski [33] showed

$$\boxed{\tau = \int_0^{D_{\rm s}} \frac{4\pi G}{c^2}\,\frac{D_{\rm d}\,D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}}\,\rho(D_{\rm d})\,dD_{\rm d}} \tag{17.11}$$

The optical depth is independent of the individual lens masses: it depends only on the total mass density, because the Einstein area $\pi\theta_{\rm E}^2 \propto M$ while the number density $\propto 1/M$, and the two cancel. The equivalence of "fraction of sky in Einstein disks" and $\Sigma/\Sigma_{\rm cr}$ for a thin lens screen is verified in `problems_13.wl`.

17.4.1 The Dark-Matter Test Toward the Magellanic Clouds

Paczyński's motivation was the dark-matter problem: if the dark halo of the Milky Way were made of compact objects (MACHOs, massive compact halo objects), they would microlens background stars in the Large and Small Magellanic Clouds (LMC/SMC). For a standard

isothermal halo he predicted

$$\tau_{\rm halo} \sim 5 \times 10^{-7}\,, \tag{17.12}$$

so that roughly one star in two million is measurably lensed at any time, a small but tractable fraction for large CCD surveys. The MACHO, EROS, and OGLE collaborations carried out the experiment through the 1990s and 2000s. They found that the observed rate toward the LMC, $\tau_{\rm LMC} \approx 1.2^{+0.4}_{-0.3} \times 10^{-7}$ (MACHO, with a further $\sim$20% systematic uncertainty), is far too low for compact objects to constitute the entire halo. EROS limits objects of 2×10^{-7} to $1\,M_\odot$ to less than 25% of the halo, MACHO finds that objects of 0.3–30 $M_\odot$ cannot make up the whole halo, and the surviving events are consistent with ordinary stars in the disk or within the Clouds themselves [43, Sect. 3.5]. This null result rules out compact objects of $\sim 10^{-7}$–$30\,M_\odot$ as the dominant component of the halo dark matter.

17.4.2 Toward the Galactic Bulge

Monitoring the crowded Galactic bulge yields events with near certainty and a much higher optical depth, $\tau_{\rm bulge} \approx (0.9\text{–}4) \times 10^{-6}$ (EROS to MACHO/OGLE), tracing the stellar bar along the line of sight [43, Sect. 3.6]. The bulge is now the principal field for the planetary events of the next section.

17.5 Binary and Planetary Microlensing

A single point lens has only a degenerate point caustic at $u = 0$. As soon as a second mass is added, the lens becomes non-axisymmetric and develops extended caustics in the source plane, the fold-and-cusp curves of Chapter 12, now realized at stellar scales. For a binary lens the deflection is the sum of two point-mass terms [43, eq. 14],

$$\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{4G}{c^2}\left[\frac{M_A(\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}_A)}{|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}_A|^2} + \frac{M_B(\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}_B)}{|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\theta}_B|^2}\right], \tag{17.13}$$

and the system is described by three new parameters: the mass ratio $q = M_B/M_A$, the projected separation d (in units of $\theta_{\rm E}$ of the total mass), and the angle ϕ of the source trajectory relative to the binary axis. The caustic topology changes qualitatively with d. For equal masses: widely separated lenses ($d > 2$) have two small four-cusp (astroid-shaped) caustics; for $2^{-1/2} < d < 2$ these are merged into a single six-cusp caustic; and for $d < 2^{-1/2} \approx 0.707$ the caustic splits into a central four-cusp caustic plus two small triangular ones [35, 37] [43, Part 4, Sect. 2.1].[1]

17.5.1 Caustic Crossings

When the source crosses a caustic, a pair of highly magnified images is created or destroyed, and since these images dominate the (unresolved) total flux, the light curve shows a sharp

[1] Schneider and Weiss [37], reproduced as Fig. 4 of Schneider et al. [43, Part 4], quote these transitions as 1 and $8^{-1/2}$ because they measure the *half*-separation of the two lenses. In the full-separation units used here the transitions are at $d = 2$ and $d = 2^{-1/2}$; both values are checked by counting critical curves in `microlensing.wl`.

spike. A point source would formally be infinitely magnified at the caustic; the finite spike height instead measures the source size, since the magnification is smeared over the time $t_{\rm cross} = R_{\rm source}/v_\perp$ it takes the source to move by its own radius. Caustic-crossing binaries thus break the point-source approximation in a useful way, occasionally even resolving the stellar surface brightness profile.

17.5.2 Detecting Planets

Mao and Paczynski [28] first showed that a planetary companion to the lens star produces the same kind of short, low-amplitude deviation on top of an otherwise ordinary stellar light curve, and estimated that of order 10% of events should show a detectable binary signature. A planet of mass ratio $q = M_{\rm planet}/M_\star$ generates a small caustic whose perturbation is strongest when the projected separation lies in the *lensing zone* $0.6 \lesssim d/\theta_{\rm E} \lesssim 1.6$, where the planetary caustic falls near the Einstein ring of the host star [43, Sect. 4.1]. By coincidence this angular range corresponds to physical separations of order 1 AU for typical Galactic lenses, which overlaps the habitable zone. The planetary deviation is brief (hours to a day) and of small amplitude (a few percent), so dense, continuous monitoring of ongoing stellar events is required. Microlensing is especially sensitive to cool, low-mass planets at $\sim$1–few AU around distant ($\sim$ kpc) stars, a region of parameter space complementary to radial-velocity and transit surveys. The limitation is that each event is a unique, non-repeatable alignment, and only the mass ratio q (not the planet mass directly) is measured from the light curve alone.

17.6 Astrometric Microlensing

Although the two images cannot be resolved, their flux-weighted mean position, the *light centroid*, is displaced from the true source position, and that displacement can in principle be measured to sub-milliarcsecond precision. This is *astrometric microlensing* [43, Sect. 6]. Combining the image positions (17.3) with their magnifications (17.4), the centroid shift relative to the source is

$$\delta(u) = \frac{u}{u^2 + 2}\,\theta_{\rm E}\,. \tag{17.14}$$

Unlike the photometric magnification, the centroid shift vanishes both at perfect alignment ($u \to 0$) and at large separation ($u \to \infty$); it is maximized in between. Setting $d\delta/du = 0$ gives

$$\boxed{\delta_{\max} = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{2}}\,\theta_{\rm E} = 8^{-1/2}\,\theta_{\rm E} \approx 0.354\,\theta_{\rm E} \quad \text{at} \quad u = \sqrt{2}} \tag{17.15}$$

[43, eq. 22], a result due to Paczynski [34]; both the location $u = \sqrt{2}$ and the peak value are verified in `microlensing.wl`.

The astrometric signal is valuable because the centroid traces an ellipse whose angular size is set directly by $\theta_{\rm E} \propto \sqrt{M}$. Measuring it therefore yields $\theta_{\rm E}$, and combined with a parallax measurement it breaks the mass–distance–velocity degeneracy entirely, delivering the lens mass:

$$M = 0.123\,M_\odot\,\frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\pi_{\rm ds}} \tag{17.16}$$

with $\theta_{\rm E}$ and the lens–source relative parallax $\pi_{\rm ds}$ in milliarcseconds [43, eq. 25]. The centroid shift is tens to hundreds of micro-arcseconds, beyond ground-based astrometry of the 2000s but within reach of space astrometry (the numerical coefficient is checked in `problems_13.wl`).

17.7 Quasar Microlensing

Microlensing is not confined to the Milky Way. When a distant quasar is multiply imaged by a foreground galaxy (Chapters 12 and 13), the individual stars of that galaxy microlens each macro-image. This is *quasar microlensing* [43, Sect. 7]. The difference from Galactic microlensing is that at the position of a macro-image the stellar convergence is of order unity, $\kappa \sim 1$, so at any instant a whole ensemble of stars lenses the source coherently, producing a network of micro-caustics in the source plane rather than a single isolated event.

The relevant scales, for typical lens and source redshifts $z_d \approx 0.5$, $z_s \approx 2$, are the Einstein radius projected into the quasar plane and its crossing time [43, Sect. 7.1]. For the concordance cosmology of Chapter 7 ($D_{\rm d} \approx 1260$, $D_{\rm s} \approx 1730$, $D_{\rm ds} \approx 1100$ Mpc),

$$r_{\rm E} = \sqrt{\frac{4GM}{c^2}\,\frac{D_{\rm s}\,D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm d}}} \approx 5\times10^{16}\left(\frac{M}{M_\odot}\right)^{1/2}\ {\rm cm}\,, \tag{17.17}$$

$$t_{\rm E} = \frac{r_{\rm E}}{v_\perp} \approx 28\left(\frac{M}{M_\odot}\right)^{1/2}\left(\frac{v_\perp}{600\ {\rm km\ s^{-1}}}\right)^{-1}\ {\rm yr}\,, \tag{17.18}$$

where $v_\perp$ is the relative transverse velocity projected into the source plane.[2] The full Einstein-crossing time is long, but the observable fluctuations are governed instead by the much shorter caustic-crossing time $t_{\rm cross} = R_{\rm source}/v_\perp \approx 6\,R_{15}\,(v_\perp/600\ {\rm km\ s^{-1}})^{-1}$ months, where the quasar continuum radius R_{15} is in units of 10^{15} cm. The scale estimates and the $\propto\sqrt{M}$ mass scaling are checked in `problems_13.wl`.

The value of quasar microlensing lies in the fact that $t_{\rm cross}$, and hence the sharpness of the microlensing fluctuations, is set by the source size: a compact continuum-emitting region crosses caustics sharply and fluctuates strongly, whereas a large emission region smooths the peaks out. Monitoring the uncorrelated (non-time-delayed) variability between the macro-images therefore constrains the quasar accretion-disk size, independently of the time-delay cosmography of Chapter 13. The best-studied case is the "Einstein Cross" Q2237+0305, whose four images vary independently by up to ~ 1.3 mag; the fits imply a continuum region of order 10^{14} cm [43, Sect. 7.3]. Quasar microlensing also probes the fraction of the lens-galaxy mass in compact objects versus smooth dark matter, complementing the halo constraints of §17.4.

[2] Schneider et al. [43, Part 4, Sect. 7.1] quotes $r_{\rm E} \approx 4\times10^{16}$ cm, which corresponds to an older Einstein–de Sitter-type cosmology (EdS with $H_0 = 70$ gives 3.8×10^{16} cm). It also quotes $t_{\rm E} \approx 15$ yr and $t_{\rm cross} \approx 4$ months. Those two values are consistent with each other but are about $1.5\times$ shorter than r/v for $v = 600\ {\rm km\,s^{-1}}$, which implies a differently defined effective velocity. Here we quote r/v directly; see `problems_13.wl`.

17.8 Summary

In the microlensing regime the two point-lens images are split by only $\sim$ mas and are unresolved, so the sole observable is the time-variable total magnification $A(u) = (u^2 + 2)/(u\sqrt{u^2+4})$, with $u = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$. It tends to $A(u) \to 1/u$ at high magnification ($u \to 0$) and to $A(u) \to 1$ at large separation ($u \to \infty$); the event threshold is $u = 1$, where $A = 3/\sqrt{5} \approx 1.34$. Relative motion turns A into the symmetric Paczyński light curve $A(u(t))$ with $u(t) = \sqrt{u_0^2 + (t - t_0)^2/t_{\rm E}^2}$, peaking at $A_{\max} = A(u_0)$. Only the Einstein timescale $t_{\rm E} = D_{\rm d}\theta_{\rm E}/v_\perp \propto \sqrt{M}$ carries physical information, in a mass–distance–velocity degenerate combination.

The optical depth $\tau = \int (4\pi G/c^2)(D_{\rm d}D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s})\rho\, dD_{\rm d}$ is mass-independent. Toward the LMC the measured $\tau \approx 1.2 \times 10^{-7}$ rules out compact objects of $\sim 10^{-7}$–$30\,M_\odot$ as the dominant halo dark matter (EROS: $< 25\%$ of the halo for 2×10^{-7}–$1\,M_\odot$); toward the bulge $\tau \sim 10^{-6}$.

Binary and planetary lenses add extended caustics. Caustic crossings give sharp, source-size-dependent spikes, and a planet in the lensing zone $0.6 \lesssim d/\theta_{\rm E} \lesssim 1.6$ produces a brief low-amplitude deviation revealing the mass ratio q. Astrometric microlensing measures the light-centroid shift, peaking at $\delta_{\max} = 8^{-1/2}\theta_{\rm E}$ for $u = \sqrt{2}$; with a parallax it yields the lens mass. Quasar microlensing ($\kappa \sim 1$, micro-caustic networks) constrains quasar accretion-disk sizes and the compact-object content of lens galaxies.

17.9 Problems

Exercise 17.9.1. (Total magnification and its limits.) Work in Einstein units, $u = \beta/\theta_{\rm E}$, $y = \theta/\theta_{\rm E}$.

(a) Solve the point-lens equation $u = y - 1/y$ for the two image positions $y_\pm$ and verify the separation $|y_+ - y_-| = \sqrt{u^2+4}$.

(b) Using $\mu = [1 - y^{-4}]^{-1}$, show that the total magnification is $A(u) = |\mu_+| + |\mu_-| = (u^2+2)/(u\sqrt{u^2+4})$.

(c) Verify the limits $A(u) \to 1/u$ as $u \to 0$ and $A(u) \to 1$ as $u \to \infty$.

(d) Compute the peak brightening Δm (in magnitudes) for an event with impact parameter $u_0 = 1$.

Verify with `problems_13.wl`.

Exercise 17.9.2. (Einstein radius and timescale.)

(a) For a lens of $M = 0.3\,M_\odot$ at $D_{\rm d} = 4$ kpc lensing a bulge source at $D_{\rm s} = 8$ kpc, compute the angular Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}$ (in mas) and the physical Einstein radius $R_{\rm E}$ (in AU).

(b) For a transverse speed $v_\perp = 200$ km s^{-1}, compute the Einstein timescale $t_{\rm E}$ in days. Comment on why Galactic events last of order weeks.

(c) Show that at fixed geometry and velocity $t_{\rm E} \propto \sqrt{M}$, and hence that the light curve alone cannot separate M, $D_{\rm d}$, and $v_\perp$. What additional measurements break this degeneracy?

Verify with `problems_13.wl`.

Exercise 17.9.3. (Optical depth and the MACHO test.)

(a) Explain physically why the optical depth τ (eq. 17.11) is independent of the individual lens masses. *Hint:* how do the Einstein area and the number density each scale with M?

(b) For a thin lens screen of surface mass density Σ, show that the fraction of sky covered by Einstein disks equals $\Sigma/\Sigma_{\rm cr}$.

(c) Given the Paczyński halo value $\tau \sim 5 \times 10^{-7}$, how many stars must be monitored to expect of order one lensed star at any instant?

(d) The measured LMC value is $\tau \approx 1.2 \times 10^{-7}$, well below the prediction for a fully compact halo. What does this imply about MACHOs as a dark-matter candidate?

Verify with `problems_13.wl`.

Exercise 17.9.4. (Peak magnification and event width.)

(a) An event reaches peak magnification $A_{\rm max} = 5$. Invert eq. (17.10) to find the impact parameter u_0.

(b) Show that the high-magnification approximation $A_{\rm max} \approx 1/u_0$ is accurate to better than 1% for $u_0 = 0.05$.

(c) Show that the source reaches the event threshold $u = 1$ (where $A = 3/\sqrt{5}$) at times $|t - t_0| = t_{\rm E}\sqrt{1 - u_0^2}$, for $u_0 < 1$.

Verify with `problems_13.wl`.

Exercise 17.9.5. (Astrometric centroid shift.) The light centroid of a point-lens event is displaced from the source by $\delta(u) = u\,\theta_{\rm E}/(u^2 + 2)$.

(a) Show that $\delta(u)$ is maximized at $u = \sqrt{2}$.

(b) Evaluate the maximum shift and show it equals $\delta_{\rm max} = 8^{-1/2}\,\theta_{\rm E} \approx 0.354\,\theta_{\rm E}$.

(c) Explain why the astrometric signal breaks the mass–distance degeneracy that the photometric light curve cannot, and identify the coefficient in the mass relation $M = 0.123\,M_\odot\,\theta_{\rm E}^2/\pi_{\rm ds}$ (with angles in mas).

Verify with `problems_13.wl`.

Exercise 17.9.6. (Quasar microlensing scales.)

(a) For a quasar at $z_s \approx 2$ microlensed by stars in a galaxy at $z_d \approx 0.5$, estimate the Einstein radius projected into the source plane for a solar-mass star, and show it is of order 10^{16} cm.

(b) Show $r_{\rm E} \propto \sqrt{M}$.

(c) Estimate the caustic-crossing time $t_{\rm cross} = R_{\rm source}/v_\perp$ for a continuum region of $R = 10^{15}$ cm and $v_\perp = 600\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}}$, and explain why this (not $t_{\rm E}$) sets the observable variability timescale.

(d) Why does the condition $\kappa \sim 1$ at a quasar macro-image mean that microlensing acts as a *network* of caustics rather than isolated events?

Verify with `problems_13.wl`.

Part V

Compound Lenses, Degeneracies, and Cosmography

Chapter 18

The Multi-Plane Lens Equation and Double-Source-Plane Lenses

Everything so far has used a single deflecting plane: one thin mass sheet between the observer and one source. Real lines of sight are often more complicated. A quasar may be lensed by two galaxies at different redshifts; a lens galaxy may sit in front of two background sources at different redshifts; and the nearer of those sources is itself a galaxy with mass, so it lenses the farther one. This chapter, the first of Part V, builds the formalism for all of these situations and then specialises it to a configuration that is a cosmological tool in its own right: the *double-source-plane lens* (DSPL), one deflector seen against two sources.

We first assemble the recursive multi-plane lens equation for N deflecting planes from straight-line propagation between deflections, and identify the lens–lens coupling it contains. We then specialise to one deflector and two source planes, derive the distance ratio $\mathcal{B}$, and show that it lies in $(0, 1)$ and does not depend on H_0. The ratio $\mathcal{B}$ is connected to what is actually measured, the ratio of the two Einstein radii η: $\mathcal{B} = \eta$ for an isothermal (SIS or SIE) deflector, and $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$ for a power law. We compute $\mathcal{B}(z_l, z_{s1}, z_{s2}; \Omega_\mathrm{m}, w)$ and its sensitivity to w and Ω_m, and finally state what a DSPL fit samples, where the inner density slope enters, and the one shortcut that would make the inference circular.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `multiplane_dspl.wl`: recursive multi-plane equation versus explicit ray tracing (generic deflections and two point-mass planes), the two-plane Jacobian, the distance ratio $\mathcal{B}$ in flat wCDM computed from the comoving-distance integral, the power-law and SIE Einstein-radius identities, $\partial \ln \mathcal{B}/\partial w$ and $\partial \ln \mathcal{B}/\partial \Omega_\mathrm{m}$ by two independent methods, the lens–lens coupling estimate, and Figure 18.1
- `problems_14.wl`: verified solutions to all exercises of this chapter

18.1 Why a Double Source Plane Is a Cosmological Ruler

A single strong lens says a great deal about the mass of the deflector but little that is clean about cosmology. The Einstein radius of a singular isothermal sphere, $\theta_\mathrm{E} = 4\pi(\sigma_v/c)^2\, D_\mathrm{ds}/D_\mathrm{s}$ (eq. (11.18)), multiplies a property of the galaxy (σ_v) by a ratio of distances, and the two cannot be separated without an independent constraint on the mass.

A DSPL uses the same deflector twice. Two sources at redshifts $z_{s1} < z_{s2}$ lie behind one galaxy at z_l. The galaxy's mass distribution is identical for both; only the geometry differs. The ratio of the two Einstein radii therefore cancels the deflector mass, leaving a dimensionless ratio of distances that depends on the shape of the expansion history, $(\Omega_{\rm m}, w)$, but, as we will show, not on the Hubble constant. The use of DSPLs to constrain the dark-energy equation of state was developed by Collett et al. [13]; cosmological constraints from an observed galaxy-scale DSPL were derived by Collett and Auger [15].

18.2 Recap: The Single-Plane Lens Equation and Its Distances

GR reminder — Why light bends twice as much

A ray passing a point mass M at impact parameter b is deflected by $\hat{\alpha} = 4GM/(c^2 b)$, twice the value a Newtonian argument gives, because the photon responds equally to the temporal (g_{tt}) and spatial (g_{ij}) parts of the weak-field metric $\mathrm{d}s^2 = -(1 + 2\Phi/c^2)c^2\mathrm{d}t^2 + (1 - 2\Phi/c^2)\mathrm{d}\ell^2$. A slow massive particle feels only g_{tt} and is deflected half as much (Chapters 5 and 6).

For a thin mass sheet with surface density Σ, the physical deflection at lens-plane position $\boldsymbol{\xi}$ is the superposition

$$\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(\boldsymbol{\xi}) = \frac{4G}{c^2}\int \Sigma(\boldsymbol{\xi}')\,\frac{\boldsymbol{\xi} - \boldsymbol{\xi}'}{|\boldsymbol{\xi} - \boldsymbol{\xi}'|^2}\,\mathrm{d}^2\xi', \tag{18.1}$$

and with $\boldsymbol{\xi} = D_{\rm d}\boldsymbol{\theta}$ the lens equation of Chapter 8 (eqs. (8.8) and (8.9)) reads

$$\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}), \qquad \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \equiv \frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm s}}\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(D_{\rm d}\boldsymbol{\theta}). \tag{18.2}$$

The factor $D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}$ is the *lensing efficiency*: a given mass produces a larger reduced deflection for a more distant source.

All distances are angular-diameter distances. In a spatially flat universe with comoving distance $\chi(z)$,

$$D_A(z_1, z_2) = \frac{\chi(z_2) - \chi(z_1)}{1 + z_2}, \qquad \chi(z) = \frac{c}{H_0}\int_0^z \frac{\mathrm{d}z'}{E(z')}, \qquad E(z) = \sqrt{\Omega_{\rm m}(1+z)^3 + (1-\Omega_{\rm m})\,\zeta(z)}, \tag{18.3}$$

where $\zeta(z) = \exp\!\left[3\int_0^z \frac{1+w(z')}{1+z'}\,\mathrm{d}z'\right]$ carries the dark-energy history. For constant w, $\zeta = (1+z)^{3(1+w)}$, and $\zeta \equiv 1$ for a cosmological constant ($w = -1$). The denominator $1 + z_2$ belongs to the far endpoint.

18.3 The Multi-Plane Lens Equation

18.3.1 Statement

Order the deflecting planes by redshift, $z_1 < z_2 < \cdots < z_N$, and put the source at $z_s > z_N$. Let $\boldsymbol{\theta}_j$ be the angular position, as seen by the observer, at which the ray crosses plane j; $\boldsymbol{\theta}_1$ is the observed image position. Write $D_j \equiv D_A(0, z_j)$ and $D_{ij} \equiv D_A(z_i, z_j)$, and let $\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}_i$ be the physical deflection produced by the mass in plane i, evaluated at the physical impact position $\boldsymbol{\xi}_i = D_i \boldsymbol{\theta}_i$. Then [42, §9.1.1, eqs. 9.2–9.3]

$$\boxed{\boldsymbol{\theta}_j = \boldsymbol{\theta}_1 - \sum_{i=1}^{j-1} \frac{D_{ij}}{D_j}\, \hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}_i\big(D_i \boldsymbol{\theta}_i\big), \qquad j = 2, \ldots, N+1,} \tag{18.4}$$

with $\boldsymbol{\theta}_{N+1} \equiv \boldsymbol{\beta}$ the source position. The equation is *recursive*: $\boldsymbol{\theta}_2$ needs only $\boldsymbol{\theta}_1$; $\boldsymbol{\theta}_3$ needs $\boldsymbol{\theta}_1$ and $\boldsymbol{\theta}_2$; and so on. Schneider et al. [42, §9] attribute the multiple lens-plane formalism in part to Blandford and Narayan [8].

The multi-plane lens equation

A ray observed at $\boldsymbol{\theta}_1$ reaches plane j at $\boldsymbol{\theta}_j = \boldsymbol{\theta}_1 - \sum_{i<j} (D_{ij}/D_j)\, \hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}_i(D_i \boldsymbol{\theta}_i)$. Each earlier plane contributes its physical deflection, weighted by its efficiency D_{ij}/D_j towards plane j and evaluated where the already deflected ray crosses it. For $N = 1$ this is eq. (18.2).

18.3.2 Derivation from straight-line propagation

In a spatially flat FRW universe the spatial metric in comoving coordinates is Euclidean, so between deflections a light ray is a straight line in comoving coordinates. Let $\vec{x}(\chi)$ be the ray's comoving transverse position at comoving distance χ from the observer. It leaves the observer in direction $\boldsymbol{\theta}_1$; at plane i (comoving distance χ_i) its direction changes by $\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}_i$. Because the FRW metric is conformally flat, angles are the same in comoving and proper coordinates, so the local deflection angle can be used directly.

The geometric derivation in SEF §9.1.1 works directly with angular-diameter distances and does not assume flatness, so eq. (18.4) also holds in curved FRW models, with D_{ij} computed from the curved-space formula (eq. (7.47)).

18.3.3 The Congdon–Keeton form and the factors β_{ij}

It is often convenient to use deflections reduced to the final source, $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_i \equiv (D_{is}/D_s)\, \hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}_i$. Substituting into eq. (18.4) gives [16, §4.8, eqs. 4.99a–c]

$$\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta}_1 - \sum_{i=1}^{N} \boldsymbol{\alpha}_i(\boldsymbol{\theta}_i), \qquad \boldsymbol{\theta}_j = \boldsymbol{\theta}_1 - \sum_{i=1}^{j-1} \beta_{ij}\, \boldsymbol{\alpha}_i(\boldsymbol{\theta}_i), \qquad \beta_{ij} \equiv \frac{D_{ij}\, D_s}{D_j\, D_{is}}. \tag{18.5}$$

The factor β_{ij} converts a deflection reduced to the source plane into one reduced to plane j. It reappears in §18.4 as the DSPL distance ratio.

18.3.4 Lens–lens coupling

Equation (18.4) is nonlinear in a way the single-plane equation is not: the deflection at plane i is evaluated at $\boldsymbol{\theta}_i$, which already depends on all earlier deflections. This *lens–lens coupling* leaves a clear signature in the Jacobian. For two planes, let $\Psi_i \equiv \partial\boldsymbol{\alpha}_i/\partial\boldsymbol{\theta}_i$; each is symmetric because each $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_i$ is the gradient of a potential. The chain rule applied to eq. (18.5) gives

$$\mathcal{A} \equiv \frac{\partial\boldsymbol{\beta}}{\partial\boldsymbol{\theta}_1} = I - \Psi_1 - \Psi_2\big(I - \beta_{12}\Psi_1\big). \tag{18.6}$$

Its antisymmetric part is $\frac{1}{2}\beta_{12}\big[\Psi_2\Psi_1 - (\Psi_2\Psi_1)^T\big]$, which vanishes only if the two matrices commute. Hence $\mathcal{A}$ is in general not symmetric: the multi-plane mapping is not a gradient map, and images can be rotated as well as sheared, as SEF point out at the start of their Chapter 9. Setting either mass to zero restores a symmetric Jacobian.

18.3.5 Two limits every implementation should pass

The first limit removes the mass of the first plane. With $\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}_1 = 0$, eq. (18.4) for the source becomes $\boldsymbol{\beta} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - (D_{2s}/D_s)\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}_2(D_2\boldsymbol{\theta})$, the single-plane equation (18.2) for a lens at z_2. The second limit merges the planes. As $z_1 \to z_2$, $D_{12} \to 0$, so $\beta_{12} \to 0$ and $\boldsymbol{\theta}_2 = \boldsymbol{\theta}_1$: by eq. (18.5) the two masses act as one thin lens with the summed deflection. Congdon and Keeton [16, §4.8] make the same remark. `multiplane_dspl.wl` also traces rays through two point masses at $z = 0.3$ and 0.6 (source at $z = 1.5$) in two ways, by explicit sequential tracing in comoving coordinates and by the recursive angular equation, and finds agreement to better than 10^{-12} arcsec.

18.4 One Deflector, Two Source Planes

Now take a single deflector at z_l with physical deflection $\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$, and two sources at $z_{s1} < z_{s2}$. For the moment treat source 1 as massless; its mass is restored in §18.5. There is one deflecting plane, so the sum in eq. (18.4) has one term and there is no coupling. An image at $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ maps to each source plane as

$$\boldsymbol{\beta}_1 = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \frac{D_{l,s1}}{D_{s1}}\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(D_l\boldsymbol{\theta}) \equiv \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}_1(\boldsymbol{\theta}), \tag{18.7}$$

$$\boldsymbol{\beta}_2 = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \frac{D_{l,s2}}{D_{s2}}\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(D_l\boldsymbol{\theta}) \equiv \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}_2(\boldsymbol{\theta}). \tag{18.8}$$

The same physical deflection appears in both; the reduced deflections differ only by their efficiencies. Hence

$$\frac{\boldsymbol{\alpha}_2(\boldsymbol{\theta})}{\boldsymbol{\alpha}_1(\boldsymbol{\theta})} = \frac{D_{l,s2}/D_{s2}}{D_{l,s1}/D_{s1}} = \frac{1}{\mathcal{B}}, \qquad \mathcal{B} \equiv \frac{D_{l,s1}\,D_{s2}}{D_{s1}\,D_{l,s2}}, \tag{18.9}$$

so $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_2(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \boldsymbol{\alpha}_1(\boldsymbol{\theta})/\mathcal{B}$ at every $\boldsymbol{\theta}$, for any mass distribution in the lens plane. Comparing with eq. (18.5), $\mathcal{B}$ is exactly the Congdon–Keeton factor β_{ij} with the lens as plane i, the near source as plane j, and the far source as "the" source.

The DSPL distance ratio

$\mathcal{B} = \dfrac{D_{l,s1}\, D_{s2}}{D_{s1}\, D_{l,s2}}$ is dimensionless, lies strictly between 0 and 1, and $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_2 = \boldsymbol{\alpha}_1/\mathcal{B}$ pointwise. The deflector's mass distribution cancels in the ratio $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_2/\boldsymbol{\alpha}_1 = 1/\mathcal{B}$, which is pure geometry. Turning a measured ratio of Einstein radii into $\mathcal{B}$ still requires the deflector's slope (§18.6).

Why $0 < \mathcal{B} < 1$. Insert eq. (18.3). Every distance carries a factor c/H_0 and a factor $1/(1+z)$ of its far endpoint; all of them cancel (§18.7), leaving

$$\mathcal{B} = \frac{(\chi_{s1} - \chi_l)\,\chi_{s2}}{\chi_{s1}\,(\chi_{s2} - \chi_l)} = \frac{1 - \chi_l/\chi_{s1}}{1 - \chi_l/\chi_{s2}}, \qquad \chi_x \equiv \chi(z_x). \tag{18.10}$$

With $0 < \chi_l < \chi_{s1} < \chi_{s2}$ the numerator is smaller than the denominator, and both are positive. The second form shows the reason: in a flat universe the efficiency is $D_{l,s}/D_s = 1 - \chi_l/\chi_s$, which grows with source distance, so the far source is lensed more strongly and $\mathcal{B} < 1$.

An illustrative geometry. Throughout this chapter we use $(z_l, z_{s1}, z_{s2}) = (0.5,\ 1.0,\ 2.0)$ in flat ΛCDM with $\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$; the choice is generic, made only to make numbers concrete. Equation (18.9) gives

$$\mathcal{B}(0.5,\ 1.0,\ 2.0) = 0.6742. \tag{18.11}$$

Had the lens-to-source distances been built by naive subtraction, $D_{l,s} = D_s - D_l$, one would have found 0.878, a 30% error from a single bookkeeping slip.

18.5 When the Near Source Has Mass: Coupling in a DSPL

Equation (18.8) assumed one deflector. In a real DSPL the near source is a galaxy, and its mass deflects the light of the far source: a genuine second deflecting plane at z_{s1}. Apply eq. (18.4) with planes $\{l,\ s1\}$ and the far source as the final plane. The ray crosses plane $s1$ at $\boldsymbol{\theta}_{s1} = \boldsymbol{\beta}_1$, so

$$\boldsymbol{\beta}_2 = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \frac{1}{\mathcal{B}}\,\boldsymbol{\alpha}_1(\boldsymbol{\theta}) - \frac{D_{s1,s2}}{D_{s2}}\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}_{s1}\big(D_{s1}\boldsymbol{\beta}_1\big), \qquad \boldsymbol{\beta}_1 = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}_1(\boldsymbol{\theta}), \tag{18.12}$$

where $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_1$ is the main lens's deflection reduced to plane $s1$ and $\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}_{s1}$ is the physical deflection of the near source's own mass. The last term is the coupling; it is evaluated at the point $\boldsymbol{\beta}_1$ where the lensed ray crosses the near-source plane. Setting the near source's mass to zero recovers eq. (18.8).

How large is it? Model both galaxies as singular isothermal spheres with velocity dispersions σ_L (main lens) and σ_1 (near source). Each produces a constant physical deflection

$4\pi\sigma^2/c^2$, so the ratio of the coupling deflection to the main lens's deflection, both reduced to the far-source plane, is

$$\frac{\theta_{\rm E}(s1 \to s2)}{\theta_{\rm E}(l \to s2)} = \left(\frac{\sigma_1}{\sigma_L}\right)^2 \frac{D_{s1,s2}}{D_{l,s2}} = \left(\frac{\sigma_1}{\sigma_L}\right)^2 \frac{\chi_{s2} - \chi_{s1}}{\chi_{s2} - \chi_l}. \tag{18.13}$$

At the illustrative geometry $D_{s1,s2}/D_{s2} = 0.3622$ and $D_{l,s2}/D_{s2} = 0.6354$, so the geometric factor is 0.570. A near source with $\sigma_1/\sigma_L = 0.4$ deflects the far source's light by 9.1% of the main lens's deflection; a $\sigma_1 = 100\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}}$ galaxy at $z_{s1} = 1$ has an Einstein radius of $0.10''$ for a source at $z_{s2} = 2$. For galaxy-scale sources this is a first-order term, not a small perturbation.

18.6 From Deflections to Einstein Radii: $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$

We do not measure $\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$; we measure image positions, which for a nearly round deflector are governed by the Einstein radius on each source plane. Define the measured ratio

$$\eta \equiv \frac{\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}}{\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}}. \tag{18.14}$$

Because the far source is lensed more strongly, $\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)} > \theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}$ and $\eta < 1$.

Take a circular power-law deflector with three-dimensional density $\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$. Its convergence on source plane i is $\kappa_i(\theta) = \frac{3-\gamma'}{2}\left(\theta_{\rm E}^{(i)}/\theta\right)^{\gamma'-1}$ (eq. (13.19)), and the circular-lens relation $\alpha = \theta\,\bar{\kappa}(<\theta)$ gives

$$\alpha_i(\theta) = \left(\theta_{\rm E}^{(i)}\right)^{\gamma'-1} \theta^{\,2-\gamma'}. \tag{18.15}$$

Imposing $\alpha_2 = \alpha_1/\mathcal{B}$ at all θ forces $\left(\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}\right)^{\gamma'-1} = \left(\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}\right)^{\gamma'-1}/\mathcal{B}$:

$$\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)} = \theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}\,\mathcal{B}^{-1/(\gamma'-1)} \qquad \Longleftrightarrow \qquad \boxed{\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\,\gamma'-1}} \tag{18.16}$$

Two consequences organise the rest of the chapter. For an isothermal deflector ($\gamma' = 2$) the exponent is one and $\mathcal{B} = \eta$ exactly: the ratio of Einstein radii is the distance ratio. For any other slope, recovering $\mathcal{B}$ from the measured η requires γ'. At fixed η, $\partial \ln \mathcal{B}/\partial\gamma' = \ln\eta$, which is negative and independent of γ', so an error in the inferred slope enters $\mathcal{B}$ through the exponent even if η is perfect.

18.7 The Cosmological Content of $\mathcal{B}$

18.7.1 $\mathcal{B}$ is independent of H_0

Insert eq. (18.3) into eq. (18.9), writing $\chi = (c/H_0)\,\tilde{\chi}$ with $\tilde{\chi}(z) \equiv \int_0^z \mathrm{d}z'/E$:

$$\mathcal{B} = \frac{\dfrac{c}{H_0}\dfrac{\tilde{\chi}_{s1} - \tilde{\chi}_l}{1+z_{s1}} \cdot \dfrac{c}{H_0}\dfrac{\tilde{\chi}_{s2}}{1+z_{s2}}}{\dfrac{c}{H_0}\dfrac{\tilde{\chi}_{s1}}{1+z_{s1}} \cdot \dfrac{c}{H_0}\dfrac{\tilde{\chi}_{s2} - \tilde{\chi}_l}{1+z_{s2}}} = \frac{(\tilde{\chi}_{s1} - \tilde{\chi}_l)\,\tilde{\chi}_{s2}}{\tilde{\chi}_{s1}\,(\tilde{\chi}_{s2} - \tilde{\chi}_l)}. \tag{18.17}$$

Numerator and denominator each contain two factors of c/H_0, one of $(1+z_{s1})^{-1}$ and one of $(1+z_{s2})^{-1}$; all cancel. The lens redshift never appears in a $(1+z)$ prefactor, because no distance in $\mathcal{B}$ ends at the lens.

$\mathcal{B}$ is Hubble-free

$\mathcal{B}$ depends on cosmology only through the shape of the comoving-distance function, i.e. through $E(z) = \sqrt{\Omega_{\rm m}(1+z)^3 + (1-\Omega_{\rm m})\,\zeta(z)}$. It is independent of H_0. DSPLs therefore probe $\Omega_{\rm m}$ and w and say nothing about H_0; they are the complement of time-delay cosmography, which measures an absolute distance scale.

18.7.2 Sensitivity to w and $\Omega_{\rm m}$

Define the logarithmic responses

$$S_w \equiv \frac{\partial \ln \mathcal{B}}{\partial w}, \qquad S_{\Omega_{\rm m}} \equiv \frac{\partial \ln \mathcal{B}}{\partial \Omega_{\rm m}}, \tag{18.18}$$

evaluated at a reference cosmology, each with the other parameter held fixed. A fractional error in the recovered distance ratio maps, to first order and with the other parameter held fixed, to

$$\delta w = \frac{\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}}{S_w}, \qquad \delta\Omega_{\rm m} = \frac{\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}}{S_{\Omega_{\rm m}}}. \tag{18.19}$$

At the illustrative geometry in flat ΛCDM ($\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$, $w = -1$):

$$S_w = -0.0330, \qquad S_{\Omega_{\rm m}} = -0.0357. \tag{18.20}$$

Both are negative: raising w or $\Omega_{\rm m}$ shortens the comoving distances unevenly, in a way that lowers $\mathcal{B}$. Both are small. If $\Omega_{\rm m}$ is held fixed, a 1% error in $\mathcal{B}$ masquerades as $|\delta w| = 0.30$ at this geometry. The linear estimate hides an asymmetry: solving for w exactly at $\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$, a 1% deficit in $\mathcal{B}$ shifts w by $+0.29$ and a 1% excess by -0.36. If $\Omega_{\rm m}$ is free to move as well, the same 1% buys a larger shift: along $\mathrm{d}\Omega_{\rm m} = -\frac{1}{2}\mathrm{d}w$ it takes $|\delta w| = 0.66$, and along the degeneracy curve of §18.9 it is unbounded. A single DSPL therefore gives only a weak w constraint, and populations of DSPLs are needed [13]. For the same reason, percent-level systematics in $\mathcal{B}$ matter (Chapters 21 and 24).

18.8 The Isothermal Ellipsoid: Ratio of Einstein Radii = Distance Ratio

Galaxy lenses are elliptical, not round, so we must verify that the statement $\mathcal{B} = \eta$ survives ellipticity exactly for an isothermal profile.

SIS baseline. For a singular isothermal sphere the physical deflection is the constant $\hat{\alpha} = 4\pi\sigma_v^2/c^2$, so on source plane i

$$\theta_{\rm E}^{(i)} = 4\pi\,\frac{\sigma_v^2}{c^2}\,\frac{D_{l,si}}{D_{si}}. \tag{18.21}$$

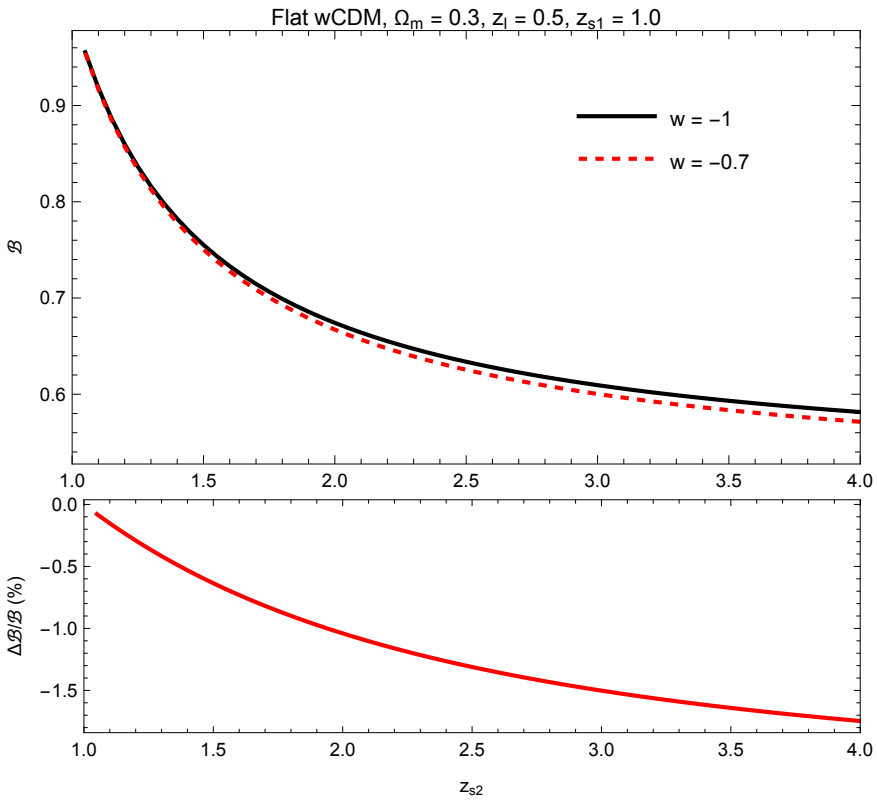


Figure 18.1: The DSPL distance ratio $\mathcal{B}$ as a function of the far source redshift z_{s2} for $z_l = 0.5$, $z_{s1} = 1.0$, in a flat cosmology with $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$, for $w = -1$ (solid) and $w = -0.7$ (dashed). Lower panel: the fractional difference. $\mathcal{B}$ falls monotonically with z_{s2} towards a finite floor; the w signal grows with the separation of the two source planes, reaching -1.75% at $z_{s2} = 4$ ($\mathcal{B} = 0.5815 \to 0.5714$). Generated by `multiplane_dspl.wl`.

The Einstein radius is linear in the efficiency, which is the special property of the isothermal slope.

Adding ellipticity. In the normalisation of Chapter 12 (eq. (12.8)), following Kormann et al. [24], whose eq. (21b) is this form with the axes rotated by 90°), the SIE convergence on source plane i is

$$\kappa_i(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{\theta_\mathrm{E}^{(i)}\sqrt{q}}{2\sqrt{q^2\theta_1^2 + \theta_2^2}}, \qquad \theta_\mathrm{E}^{(i)} = 4\pi\frac{\sigma_v^2}{c^2}\frac{D_{l,si}}{D_{si}}, \tag{18.22}$$

and its deflection (eq. (12.9)) is $\theta_\mathrm{E}^{(i)}$ times a function of (θ_1, θ_2, q) that is homogeneous of degree zero in $\boldsymbol{\theta}$. Two facts follow. First, the plane-2 deflection field is the plane-1 field divided by $\mathcal{B}$, as it must be. Second, every length scale of the lens (the parameter θ_E, the radius of the tangential critical curve along any direction, the radius of the circle with the same area as that curve) is θ_E times a coefficient that depends only on q and the direction.

The cancellation. Put the same physical SIE behind two source planes. σ_v, q and the position angle are properties of the galaxy and identical for both, so

$$\eta = \frac{\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(1)}}{\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(2)}} = \frac{\left[4\pi\sigma_v^2/c^2\right] f(q)\,(D_{l,s1}/D_{s1})}{\left[4\pi\sigma_v^2/c^2\right] f(q)\,(D_{l,s2}/D_{s2})} = \mathcal{B}, \tag{18.23}$$

where $f(q)$ is whatever q-dependent factor a particular Einstein-radius convention introduces ($f = 1$ for the parameter of eq. (18.22)).

The ratio of Einstein radii

For an SIS or SIE the velocity dispersion, axis ratio and position angle all cancel in $\eta = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(1)}/\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(2)}$, leaving $\eta = \mathcal{B}$ exactly, in any Einstein-radius convention. For a power law $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$, and the slope must be known.

18.9 What a DSPL Fit Samples

A DSPL cosmography fit is a Bayesian fit of one lens model to both image systems at once. The deflector-plus-sources parameter vector is

$$\mathbf{p}_{\mathrm{mod}} = \{\, \underbrace{\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(1)},\ \gamma',\ q,\ \varphi,\ \gamma_{\mathrm{ext}},\ \phi_{\mathrm{ext}},\ \boldsymbol{\theta}_c}_{\text{deflector}},\ \underbrace{\boldsymbol{\beta}_1}_{\text{source 1}},\ \underbrace{\boldsymbol{\beta}_2}_{\text{source 2}},\ \ldots \,\}, \tag{18.24}$$

with $\boldsymbol{\theta}_c$ the lens centre, $(\gamma_{\mathrm{ext}}, \phi_{\mathrm{ext}})$ an external shear, and the dots standing for source-light parameters in extended-image fits (and, when the near source is massive, its own mass parameters, §18.5). The two source planes are tied together by one extra number through the plane-2 lens equation

$$\boldsymbol{\beta}_2 = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \frac{1}{\mathcal{B}}\,\boldsymbol{\alpha}_1(\boldsymbol{\theta}; \mathbf{p}_{\mathrm{mod}}), \tag{18.25}$$

the same deflection field that lenses source 1, divided by $\mathcal{B}$. That single rescaling is the only place cosmology enters a position or pixel fit of a one-deflector DSPL.

Two equivalent parametrisations.

(a) With $\mathcal{B}$ free, one appends $\mathcal{B}$ to $\mathbf{p}_{\mathrm{mod}}$ and samples both. The plane-2 data pull on $\mathcal{B}$ through eq. (18.25). The $\mathcal{B}$ posterior is converted to (Ω_{m}, w) afterwards with eq. (18.9). Cosmology never enters the likelihood.

(b) With the cosmology free, one samples $(\mathbf{p}_{\mathrm{mod}}, \Omega_{\mathrm{m}}, w)$ and computes $\mathcal{B}(z_l, z_{s1}, z_{s2}; \Omega_{\mathrm{m}}, w)$ at every step. The likelihood is the same function; only the coordinates on parameter space, and hence the meaning of a "flat" prior, differ.

The likelihood. With Gaussian astrometric errors,

$$\mathcal{L}(\mathrm{data} \mid \mathbf{p}_{\mathrm{mod}}, \mathcal{B}) \propto \exp\Big[-\tfrac{1}{2}\chi^2\Big], \qquad \chi^2 = \sum_{\text{planes } i}\ \sum_{\text{images } k} \frac{\left|\boldsymbol{\theta}_{ik}^{\mathrm{obs}} - \boldsymbol{\theta}_{ik}^{\mathrm{mod}}(\mathbf{p}_{\mathrm{mod}}, \mathcal{B})\right|^2}{\sigma_{ik}^2}, \tag{18.26}$$

summed over both image systems. In position-only fits the source positions $\boldsymbol{\beta}_i$ are nuisance parameters, often optimised or marginalised per plane; in extended-image fits the sum runs over pixels and the source light is reconstructed. Either way $\mathcal{B}$, or the cosmology behind it, is a sampled dimension of the posterior, constrained by requiring that one deflector map both image systems back to consistent sources.

Why one lens gives a curve, not a point. In parametrisation (b), χ^2 depends on (Ω_m, w) only through the composite $\mathcal{B}(\Omega_\mathrm{m}, w)$. Two cosmologies with the same $\mathcal{B}$ give identical model images and identical likelihood. A single DSPL therefore constrains a level curve of $\mathcal{B}$ in the (Ω_m, w) plane, with local slope

$$\left.\frac{\mathrm{d}w}{\mathrm{d}\Omega_\mathrm{m}}\right|_{\mathcal{B}} = -\frac{S_{\Omega_\mathrm{m}}}{S_w}, \tag{18.27}$$

which is -1.08 at the illustrative geometry. Breaking the degeneracy needs several lenses with different redshift triplets, each contributing a differently oriented band [13].

18.10 The $\mathcal{B}$–γ' Degeneracy: Why the Inner Slope Is Load-Bearing

The data constrain the image configuration, hence in effect η and the slope γ' jointly; the cosmological number is the derived combination $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$. Its logarithmic differential is

$$\frac{\delta\mathcal{B}}{\mathcal{B}} = (\gamma' - 1)\,\frac{\delta\eta}{\eta} \;+\; \ln\eta\;\delta\gamma'. \tag{18.28}$$

(Solutions 8a–8d.) Two consequences follow. First, the posterior in $(\mathcal{B}, \gamma')$ is correlated. If the images fix η well but γ' poorly, the marginal $\mathcal{B}$ posterior is broad, and the width of the cosmology constraint is set by how well the slope is pinned. Exercise 18.13.10 gives a worked budget in which the slope channel dominates. Second, the two channels have opposite signs. Since $\eta < 1$, $\ln\eta < 0$, while $\gamma' - 1 > 0$. An upward error in η raises $\mathcal{B}$; an upward error in γ' lowers it. Correlated errors can therefore partly cancel, and an error in the slope can masquerade as a change in cosmology even when η is measured well.

The slope is pinned by data that probe the mass profile away from the tangential arcs or across them, and three such anchors stand on an equal footing. Stellar kinematics measure the mass at a different radius (Chapter 13). The radial thickness of extended arcs measures the local gradient of the deflection: for a power law the radial eigenvalue of the Jacobian at θ_E is $\gamma' - 1$, so the radial magnification there is $1/(\gamma' - 1)$. A radial or central image, when one is detected, probes the inner profile directly (Chapter 20), although Chapter 20 stresses that a central image constrains a combination of inner slope and central mass, not the slope alone. That central region is where an unmodelled compact mass would act, which is why Chapters 19 and 21 study power-law lenses with a central point mass.

18.11 The Circularity Trap

One shortcut invalidates the inference. One might take a reference cosmology, compute $\mathcal{B}_{\rm ref}$, and impose $\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)} = \theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}\,\mathcal{B}_{\rm ref}^{-1/(\gamma'-1)}$ (equivalently $\eta = \mathcal{B}_{\rm ref}^{1/(\gamma'-1)}$) as a constraint in the fit. That builds the answer into the model: the posterior would only reproduce $\mathcal{B}_{\rm ref}$.

Never tie the two planes with a cosmological $\mathcal{B}$

The correct inference leaves the two planes' normalisations free: either $\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}$ and $\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}$ are both sampled, or $\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}$ and $\mathcal{B}$ are. $\mathcal{B}$ is then whatever value lets one deflector fit both image systems, and only then is it a measurement that can agree or disagree with a cosmology. The relation $\eta = \mathcal{B}^{1/(\gamma'-1)}$ is for interpreting a fitted (η, γ'), never for constraining the fit.

18.12 Summary

With N deflecting planes, a ray observed at $\boldsymbol{\theta}_1$ reaches plane j at $\boldsymbol{\theta}_j = \boldsymbol{\theta}_1 - \sum_{i<j}(D_{ij}/D_j)\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}_i(D_i\boldsymbol{\theta}_i)$ (eq. (18.4)), which follows from straight comoving rays between deflections. Each deflection is evaluated at the already deflected ray (lens–lens coupling), and the Jacobian is no longer symmetric. For one deflector and two source planes, $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_2 = \boldsymbol{\alpha}_1/\mathcal{B}$ with $\mathcal{B} = D_{l,s1}D_{s2}/(D_{s1}D_{l,s2}) \in (0,1)$. In a flat universe $\mathcal{B} = (\chi_{s1}-\chi_l)\chi_{s2}/[\chi_{s1}(\chi_{s2}-\chi_l)]$, independent of H_0. Plane-to-plane distances must be built from comoving differences, never as $D_s - D_l$. A massive near source adds a coupling term $-(D_{s1,s2}/D_{s2})\hat{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}_{s1}(D_{s1}\boldsymbol{\beta}_1)$ (eq. (18.12)); for galaxy-scale sources it is a first-order effect and must be modelled.

The measured ratio of Einstein radii is the distance ratio for an isothermal deflector ($\mathcal{B} = \eta$; SIS or SIE, any ellipticity, any Einstein-radius convention) and $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$ for a power law. $\mathcal{B}$ is only weakly sensitive to cosmology: $S_w = -0.0330$ and $S_{\Omega_{\rm m}} = -0.0357$ at $(z_l, z_{s1}, z_{s2}) = (0.5, 1, 2)$, so, with $\Omega_{\rm m}$ held fixed, a 1% error in $\mathcal{B}$ corresponds to $|\delta w| \approx 0.3$. One lens constrains a curve in $(\Omega_{\rm m}, w)$. Lenses at different redshift triplets give differently oriented curves [13], so a sample shrinks the allowed region. A DSPL fit samples the lens model plus $\mathcal{B}$ (or the cosmology behind it). The inner slope controls the width of the $\mathcal{B}$ posterior through $\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B} = (\gamma'-1)\delta\eta/\eta + \ln\eta\,\delta\gamma'$. The ratio $\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}/\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}$ must never be fixed from a reference cosmology.

The chain from data to cosmology is

$$\underbrace{\text{image positions}}_{\text{data}} \longrightarrow \underbrace{(\eta, \gamma')}_{\text{lens fit}} \xrightarrow{\mathcal{B}=\eta^{\gamma'-1}} \underbrace{\mathcal{B}}_{\text{distance ratio}} \xrightarrow{\text{eq. (18.17)}} \underbrace{(\Omega_{\rm m},\, w)}_{\text{cosmology}}.$$

The middle arrow needs the slope; the last arrow is Hubble-free but weak. Chapter 19 develops the power-law lens with a central point mass, and Chapter 21 shows how such a mass, left out of the model, biases both arrows.

18.13 Problems

Exercise 18.13.1. $\mathcal{B}$ is Hubble-free. Write each of the four distances in eq. (18.9) using eq. (18.3) and show explicitly that all factors of c/H_0 and $(1+z)^{-1}$ cancel, so that $\mathcal{B}$ depends only on $\{\chi_l, \chi_{s1}, \chi_{s2}\}$. Why does z_l never appear in a $(1+z)$ prefactor?

Exercise 18.13.2. The isothermal ruler. For an isothermal deflector ($\gamma' = 2$) verify $\mathcal{B} = \eta$ from eq. (18.16), and again directly from the constant SIS deflection. Interpret geometrically why the ratio of Einstein radii equals the ratio of the two efficiencies.

Exercise 18.13.3. The slope lever arm. (a) From eq. (18.16), compute $\partial \ln \mathcal{B}/\partial\gamma'$ at fixed η and show that it does not depend on γ'. (b) At the illustrative geometry ($\mathcal{B} = 0.6742$) a deflector has $\gamma' = 1.9$. What is η, and what slope error $\delta\gamma'$ produces a 1% error in $\mathcal{B}$? (c) Suppose an unmodelled feature of the lens biases the fitted slope by $\delta\gamma' = +0.03$ while η is measured perfectly. What $\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}$ results, and, using S_w from eq. (18.20), what δw would be inferred?

Exercise 18.13.4. The cost of $D_{ds} = D_s - D_d$. (a) Show that $(D_s - D_d) - D_{ds} = \chi_d[1/(1+z_s) - 1/(1+z_d)]$ in a flat universe and that it is nonzero for every $z_s > z_d > 0$. (b) Evaluate D_d, D_s, D_{ds} and $D_s - D_d$ at $z_d = 0.5$, $z_s = 2$ in flat ΛCDM with $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$, $H_0 = 70\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$. (c) Compute the "distance ratio" that results if both lens-to-source distances in eq. (18.9) are built by naive subtraction, at the illustrative geometry, and compare with eq. (18.11).

Exercise 18.13.5. Limits of $\mathcal{B}$. (a) Show that $\mathcal{B} \to 0$ as $z_{s1} \to z_l$ and $\mathcal{B} \to 1$ as $z_{s2} \to z_{s1}$, and interpret both limits. (b) Show that $\partial\mathcal{B}/\partial\chi_{s2} < 0$. (c) For flat ΛCDM with $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$, $\chi(z \to \infty)$ is finite. Compute it in units of c/H_0 and find the floor $\mathcal{B}(0.5,\, 1.0,\, z_{s2} \to \infty)$.

Exercise 18.13.6. How big is lens–lens coupling? (a) Treat both the main lens and the near source as singular isothermal spheres and derive eq. (18.13). (b) Show that the coupling vanishes as $z_{s1} \to z_{s2}$ and tends to $(\sigma_1/\sigma_L)^2$ as $z_{s1} \to z_l$. (c) Evaluate the geometric factor at the illustrative geometry and the coupling fraction for $\sigma_1/\sigma_L = 0.4$ and 0.6.

Exercise 18.13.7. What cancels in η. (a) Carry a general shape factor $f(q, \varphi)$ through eq. (18.23) and confirm it cancels for any f common to both planes. (b) Add an external shear produced by mass at z_l. Show that the whole lens-plane deflection field (SIE plus shear) scales by $1/\mathcal{B}$ between the planes, so a model in which the reduced shear differs between planes by that factor recovers $\eta = \mathcal{B}$ exactly. (Here η is the ratio of the fitted θ_E parameters; with shear present, radii read off the critical curves do not scale by exactly $1/\mathcal{B}$.) (c) Explain why a shear produced by a perturber between the two source planes does not cancel.

Exercise 18.13.8. Two channels. Derive eq. (18.28) by taking the logarithmic differential of $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$, and confirm that for $\eta < 1$ and $\gamma' > 1$ the two channels have opposite signs.

Exercise 18.13.9. The single-lens degeneracy. In parametrisation (b) of §18.9, show that the likelihood is exactly constant along level curves $\mathcal{B}(\Omega_\mathrm{m}, w) = \mathrm{const}$ and that the local slope of such a curve is $-S_{\Omega_\mathrm{m}}/S_w$. Evaluate it at the illustrative geometry, and check numerically that a step along that direction changes $\mathcal{B}$ far less than the same step across it.

Exercise 18.13.10. Where to spend observing time. A fit returns $\eta = 0.72 \pm 0.01$ and $\gamma' = 1.60 \pm 0.05$ with correlation coefficient $\rho = +0.8$. Propagate to $\sigma_{\mathcal{B}}/\mathcal{B}$ with eq. (18.28), including the covariance. Compare the slope-driven and ratio-driven contributions. Which dominates, and what does this say about the relative value of better astrometry and a better constraint on the slope? For a lens whose redshifts give $|S_w| = 0.0330$, what is σ_w?

Chapter 19

Power-Law Lenses with a Central Point Mass

Chapter 11 built the circular-lens formalism and used it on the point mass, the singular and nonsingular isothermal spheres, and the NFW halo. Chapter 13 then introduced the spherical power law $\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$ as the workhorse of galaxy-scale lens modeling. This chapter puts those two threads together and adds one more ingredient: a *central point mass*, such as the supermassive black holes found at the centres of massive galaxies [25].

The questions are concrete. Where are the critical curves of a power law, and when does it have a radial critical curve at all? What does a point mass at the centre do to those curves? The answer to the second question is the main result of the chapter. A point mass has no radial critical curve of its own, and adding one to a profile that does have one pushes the radial eigenvalue upward at exactly the small radii where radial images form, until, above a critical mass fraction, the radial critical curve is destroyed. We derive that critical mass fraction in closed form. We then solve the isothermal-plus-point-mass lens exactly, and finally introduce the *broken power law*, whose inner slope can mimic a central point mass so well that, outside the break radius, the two are identical.

The tools developed here suffice to compute the critical curves and caustics of any axisymmetric profile plus a central point mass, and to decide which observations could and could not distinguish a central point mass from a steeper inner density profile.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `power_law_point_mass.wl`: symbolic derivation of the power-law and point-mass lensing quantities, the critical radii, the annihilation threshold $m_{\rm crit}(\gamma')$, image counts, and the isothermal-plus-point-mass closed form checked against a numerical root solve; exports Figure 19.1
- `broken_power_law.wl`: closed-form deflection of the broken power law, its normalization, the point-mass and isothermal limits, and the outside-the-break identity; exports Figure 19.2
- `problems_15.wl`: worked solutions to the problems in §19.8

19.1 The Circular Toolbox, Revisited

For an axisymmetric convergence $\kappa(\theta)$, with $\theta = |\boldsymbol{\theta}|$, the deflection points radially and depends only on the mass enclosed within θ:

$$\alpha(\theta) = \frac{2}{\theta}\int_0^\theta \kappa(\theta')\,\theta'\,\mathrm{d}\theta' = \bar\kappa(\theta)\,\theta, \qquad \bar\kappa(\theta) \equiv \frac{2}{\theta^2}\int_0^\theta \kappa(\theta')\,\theta'\,\mathrm{d}\theta', \tag{19.1}$$

where $\bar\kappa$ is the mean convergence inside θ. Multiplying by θ and differentiating inverts this relation:

$$\kappa(\theta) = \frac{1}{2\theta}\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}\theta}\big[\theta\,\alpha(\theta)\big]. \tag{19.2}$$

The *Einstein radius* is where the mean interior convergence is unity, $\bar\kappa(\theta_\mathrm{E}) = 1$, equivalently $\alpha(\theta_\mathrm{E}) = \theta_\mathrm{E}$.

The signed one-dimensional lens equation. Source, lens centre, and images all lie on one line through the centre, so we let θ run over the whole real line, negative values denoting the side opposite the source. The deflection is then an odd function, $\alpha(-\theta) = -\alpha(\theta)$, and the lens equation is

$$y = \theta - \alpha(\theta), \tag{19.3}$$

with $y \geq 0$ the source position. This is eq. (11.2) of Chapter 11 written for both sides of the lens at once; we use the letter y for the signed source coordinate, as in the rest of Part V. Every image of a source at y_0 is a root of $y(\theta) = y_0$.

Eigenvalues. The Jacobian of a circular lens is diagonal in polar coordinates, with a tangential and a radial eigenvalue

$$\lambda_t(\theta) = 1 - \frac{\alpha(\theta)}{\theta} = 1 - \bar\kappa(\theta), \qquad \lambda_r(\theta) = 1 - \frac{\mathrm{d}\alpha}{\mathrm{d}\theta} = 1 + \bar\kappa(\theta) - 2\kappa(\theta), \qquad \mu = \frac{1}{\lambda_t\,\lambda_r}. \tag{19.4}$$

The tangential critical curve is $\lambda_t = 0$ (arcs, Einstein rings); the radial critical curve is $\lambda_r = 0$ (radially stretched images). The second form of λ_r uses the identity

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\alpha}{\mathrm{d}\theta} = 2\kappa(\theta) - \bar\kappa(\theta), \tag{19.5}$$

which holds for every axisymmetric profile.

Superposition. Deflections add, so for a composite lens $\alpha = \alpha_1 + \alpha_2$ the departures from unity of the eigenvalues add too:

$$\lambda_t - 1 = (\lambda_{t,1} - 1) + (\lambda_{t,2} - 1), \qquad \lambda_r - 1 = (\lambda_{r,1} - 1) + (\lambda_{r,2} - 1). \tag{19.6}$$

Every critical-curve result below uses it.

Recipe: critical curves of any axisymmetric profile plus a point mass

For a profile with mean convergence $\bar{\kappa}(\theta)$ and local convergence $\kappa(\theta)$, plus a central point mass of Einstein radius $\theta_\bullet$:

$$\lambda_t(\theta) = 1 - \bar{\kappa}(\theta) - \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta^2}, \tag{19.7}$$

$$\lambda_r(\theta) = 1 + \bar{\kappa}(\theta) - 2\kappa(\theta) + \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta^2}. \tag{19.8}$$

The tangential critical curve solves $\lambda_t = 0$ and the radial critical curve(s) solve $\lambda_r = 0$. Each critical radius θ_c maps to a caustic at $y_c = \theta_c - \alpha(\theta_c)$. The point mass lowers λ_t and raises λ_r, by the same amount $\theta_\bullet^2/\theta^2$.

19.2 The Power-Law Lens

19.2.1 Convergence and deflection

Take the spherical power law of §13.5.2, $\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$. Chapter 13 projected it along the line of sight with a Beta-function integral and found $\Sigma \propto R^{1-\gamma'}$ (finite for $\gamma' > 1$), hence a convergence with the same exponent, normalized as in eq. (13.19). We take that result as our starting point and derive the deflection from it. Writing the convergence as

$$\kappa(\theta) = \frac{3-\gamma'}{2}\left(\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta}\right)^{\gamma'-1}, \qquad 1 < \gamma' < 3, \tag{19.9}$$

the enclosed-mass integral (19.1) gives

$$\boxed{\alpha_{\rm PL}(\theta) = \theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma'-1}\,\theta^{\,2-\gamma'}} \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad \bar{\kappa}(\theta) = \left(\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta}\right)^{\gamma'-1}. \tag{19.10}$$

The Einstein condition $\alpha(\theta_{\rm E}) = \theta_{\rm E}$ holds for every γ'; the prefactor $(3-\gamma')/2$ in (19.9) is what makes it so. In the isothermal case $\gamma' = 2$ the deflection is constant, $\alpha = \theta_{\rm E}$, and $\kappa = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta)$: the SIS of §11.4.

Cross-check against the literature. Meneghetti [29] (§5.2, eqs. 5.38–5.40) writes the same lens in units of $\theta_{\rm E}$, $x = \theta/\theta_{\rm E}$, through the dimensionless enclosed mass $m(x) = x^{3-n}$, with n the 3-D slope: $\kappa = m'(x)/(2x) = \frac{3-n}{2}x^{1-n}$ and $\alpha = m/x = x^{2-n}$. With $n \equiv \gamma'$ these are eqs. (19.9) and (19.10) divided by $\theta_{\rm E}$. Keeton [21] (eqs. 26 and 29, "softened power law") uses $\kappa = \frac{1}{2}b^{2-\alpha_{\rm K}}(s^2+\xi^2)^{\alpha_{\rm K}/2-1}$ with $M_{\rm cyl} \propto r^{\alpha_{\rm K}}$ asymptotically. Setting the core $s = 0$, $\alpha_{\rm K} = 3-\gamma'$, and $b^{\gamma'-1} = (3-\gamma')\,\theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma'-1}$ reproduces both of our expressions; Keeton's scale b equals $\theta_{\rm E}$ only for the isothermal case.

19.2.2 Critical curves of the power law

Inserting (19.10) into (19.4),

$$\lambda_t = 1 - \left(\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta}\right)^{\gamma'-1}, \qquad \lambda_r = 1 - (2-\gamma')\left(\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta}\right)^{\gamma'-1}. \tag{19.11}$$

Critical radii of a power law

$$\text{tangential:} \quad \theta_t = \theta_{\rm E}, \tag{19.12}$$

$$\text{radial:} \quad \theta_r = \theta_{\rm E}\,(2-\gamma')^{1/(\gamma'-1)} \qquad (\text{exists only for } 1<\gamma'<2). \tag{19.13}$$

As $\gamma' \to 2$ (isothermal), $\theta_r \to 0$: the singular isothermal sphere has no radial critical curve. Shallower profiles push θ_r outward: $\theta_r/\theta_{\rm E} = 0.0427$ at $\gamma' = 1.95$, 0.217 at $\gamma' = 1.6$, 0.25 at $\gamma' = 1.5$, approaching $1/e$ as $\gamma' \to 1$.

The radial critical curve maps to a radial caustic at

$$y_r = \theta_r - \alpha(\theta_r) = -\frac{\gamma'-1}{2-\gamma'}\,\theta_r = -\theta_{\rm E}\,(\gamma'-1)(2-\gamma')^{(2-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)}, \tag{19.14}$$

which is $-\theta_{\rm E}/4$ at $\gamma' = 1.5$. The negative sign means the critical point lies on the opposite side of the lens from the sources it serves. As $\gamma' \to 2^-$, $|y_r| \to \theta_{\rm E}$: the radial caustic grows even as the radial critical curve shrinks to a point (compare the statement after eq. 5.44 of Meneghetti [29]).

19.2.3 Reading the source-plane map

For $1 < \gamma' < 2$ the curve $y(\theta) = \theta - \alpha_{\rm PL}(\theta)$ on the $\theta > 0$ side starts at $y(0) = 0$ (because $\alpha_{\rm PL} \propto \theta^{2-\gamma'} \to 0$), dips negative to a minimum y_r at θ_r, returns to zero at $\theta = \theta_{\rm E}$, and then rises. The $\theta < 0$ side is the mirror image, $y(-\theta) = -y(\theta)$. A source at $0 < y_0 < |y_r|$ therefore has three images: an outer image at $\theta > \theta_{\rm E}$ (positive parity), a counter-image on the far side between $-\theta_{\rm E}$ and $-\theta_r$, and a radial image on the far side between $-\theta_r$ and the centre. Outside the radial caustic, $y_0 > |y_r|$, only the outer image survives. For $\gamma' = 1.5$ ($|y_r| = \theta_{\rm E}/4$) a source at $y_0 = 0.05\,\theta_{\rm E}$ has three images and one at $0.3\,\theta_{\rm E}$ has one. This is the familiar odd-number count for a nonsingular lens; Chapter 20 returns to it.

19.3 The Point Mass

A point mass $M_\bullet$ at the origin puts all of its convergence into a delta function; away from the centre $\kappa = 0$ and

$$\alpha_\bullet(\theta) = \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta}, \qquad \theta_\bullet^2 = \frac{4GM_\bullet}{c^2}\frac{D_{\rm ds}}{D_{\rm d}D_{\rm s}}, \qquad \lambda_t = 1 - \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta^2}, \qquad \lambda_r = 1 + \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta^2}. \tag{19.15}$$

(This is the potential $\psi = \theta_\bullet^2 \ln\theta$ of Keeton [21], eqs. 23–24.) Two facts matter for the rest of the chapter. First, $\lambda_t = 0$ at $\theta = \theta_\bullet$ (the point mass's own Einstein ring), but $\lambda_r > 0$ everywhere: a point mass has no radial critical curve of its own. Second, $\alpha_\bullet \to \infty$ as $\theta \to 0$, so the point mass dominates the innermost region of any lens it is added to. We measure its strength by

$$m \equiv \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta_\mathrm{E}^2} = \frac{M_\bullet}{M_\mathrm{PL}(<\theta_\mathrm{E})}, \tag{19.16}$$

the point mass as a fraction of the mass of the power law inside θ_E. The second equality uses $\theta_\bullet^2 = M_\bullet/(\pi\Sigma_\mathrm{cr}D_\mathrm{d}^2)$, which follows from eq. (11.4), together with $M_\mathrm{PL}(<\theta_\mathrm{E}) = \pi\Sigma_\mathrm{cr}D_\mathrm{d}^2\theta_\mathrm{E}^2\,\bar\kappa(\theta_\mathrm{E})$ and $\bar\kappa(\theta_\mathrm{E}) = 1$. Throughout this chapter θ_E denotes the Einstein radius of the power law alone; the tangential critical curve of the composite lens sits slightly outside it (Problem 19.8.5). For a black hole in a galaxy, $m \ll 1$.

19.4 Power Law plus Point Mass

19.4.1 Where the point mass acts

Apply the recipe (19.7)–(19.8) to the power law (19.10) plus the point mass (19.15). In units $u = \theta/\theta_\mathrm{E}$,

$$\lambda_r(u) = 1 - (2-\gamma')\,u^{1-\gamma'} + m\,u^{-2}, \qquad \lambda_t(u) = 1 - u^{1-\gamma'} - m\,u^{-2}. \tag{19.17}$$

The point mass enters λ_r with a plus sign: it can only push the radial eigenvalue up, toward and past zero. How hard it pushes, relative to the power law, depends on radius. The ratio of the two terms that compete in $\lambda_r - 1$ is

$$\frac{m\,u^{-2}}{(2-\gamma')\,u^{1-\gamma'}} = \frac{m}{2-\gamma'}\,u^{-(3-\gamma')}. \tag{19.18}$$

Since $3-\gamma' > 0$, the point mass gains on the power law as u decreases. Compared with its weight at the Einstein radius, its weight at the radial critical curve is larger by $(\theta_\mathrm{E}/\theta_r)^{3-\gamma'}$: a factor of $4^{3/2} = 8$ for $\gamma' = 1.5$. At the very centre the point-mass term always dominates, $\lambda_r \to +\infty$, whereas the pure power law has $\lambda_r \to -\infty$ there.

Why a central point mass acts precisely where radial images form

A point mass changes λ_t and λ_r by $\mp\theta_\bullet^2/\theta^2$. At the Einstein ring this is a small correction of size m. The radial critical curve, however, lives deep inside, at $\theta_r < \theta_\mathrm{E}$, where the same term is larger by $(\theta_\mathrm{E}/\theta_r)^2$, and larger relative to the profile's own contribution by $(\theta_\mathrm{E}/\theta_r)^{3-\gamma'}$. For $\gamma' = 1.5$ and $m = 10^{-3}$ the Einstein ring moves by 0.2 per cent, yet any $m > 0.0066$ removes the radial critical curve of every power law (eq. 19.19 below).

19.4.2 The stationary point and the critical mass fraction

With $m > 0$, λ_r is $+\infty$ at the centre and tends to 1 from below at large radius, so it has a minimum in between. A radial critical curve exists if and only if that minimum is ≤ 0.

Annihilation of the radial critical curve

A power law with $1 < \gamma' < 2$ plus a central point mass of fractional mass m has a radial critical curve if and only if $m \leq m_{\rm crit}(\gamma')$, with

$$m_{\rm crit}(\gamma') = \frac{(2-\gamma')(\gamma'-1)}{2}\left[\frac{(2-\gamma')(3-\gamma')}{2}\right]^{(3-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)}. \tag{19.19}$$

At $\gamma' = 3/2$ this is exactly $m_{\rm crit} = 27/4096 \approx 0.0066$, with the merger at $u_c = 9/64$. Over the whole range $1 < \gamma' < 2$ the threshold never exceeds 0.0066 (maximum at $\gamma' \approx 1.48$), and it vanishes at both ends.

A point mass carrying less than one per cent of the projected mass inside the Einstein radius is enough to remove the radial critical curve of any power law. Figure 19.1 shows how it happens. Without the point mass, λ_r rises monotonically from $-\infty$ and crosses zero once, at θ_r. A small point mass bends the curve back up at the centre, so that λ_r crosses zero twice: there are now two radial critical curves, an inner one created by the point mass and an outer one inherited from the power law. As m grows the two approach each other, merge at u_c when $m = m_{\rm crit}$, and disappear together. This is the annihilation of the radial critical curve.

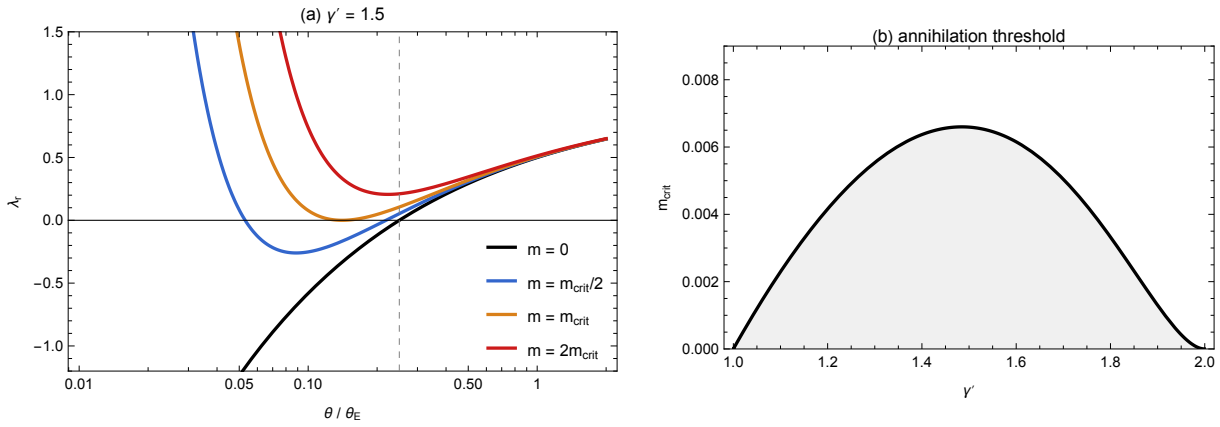


Figure 19.1: Annihilation of the radial critical curve by a central point mass. **(a)** Radial eigenvalue $\lambda_r(\theta)$, eq. (19.17), for a $\gamma' = 1.5$ power law with point masses $m = 0$, $m_{\rm crit}/2$, $m_{\rm crit}$, and $2m_{\rm crit}$ ($m_{\rm crit} = 27/4096$). The dashed line marks the radial critical radius $\theta_r = \theta_{\rm E}/4$ of the bare power law. For $0 < m < m_{\rm crit}$ the curve crosses zero twice (two radial critical curves); at $m_{\rm crit}$ it touches zero; above it $\lambda_r > 0$ everywhere. **(b)** The threshold $m_{\rm crit}(\gamma')$ of eq. (19.19). Below the curve the lens has radial critical curves; above it, none. Generated by `power_law_point_mass.wl`.

19.4.3 Caustics and image counts

Each radial critical curve has its own caustic. Below threshold the inner radial curve maps to a caustic of radius $|y_{\rm in}|$ and the outer one to $|y_{\rm out}|$, with $|y_{\rm in}| < |y_{\rm out}|$ for every slope $1 < \gamma' < 2$: at either radial curve $\lambda_t < \lambda_r = 0$, so both caustic points lie on the $y < 0$ side, and $y(\theta)$ falls from the first to the second. For $\gamma' = 1.5$ and $m = 0.003$ these are $0.234\,\theta_{\rm E}$ and $0.263\,\theta_{\rm E}$. Reading the image diagram (the annotation of §19.1) then gives the image count as a function of source position. For $y_0 < |y_{\rm in}|$ there are two images, the outer image and the counter-image; the radial image is gone. For $|y_{\rm in}| < y_0 < |y_{\rm out}|$ there are four images: the outer image, the counter-image, the radial image, and an additional faint image very close to the point mass. For $y_0 > |y_{\rm out}|$ there are two images, the outer image and a faint image very close to the point mass. Above threshold, $m > m_{\rm crit}$, $y(\theta)$ is monotonic on each side and there are exactly two images for every source position. Because the point mass makes the lens singular, these counts are even, not odd; Chapter 20 explains why. At $m = m_{\rm crit}$ the two caustics coincide (at $|y| = 9\theta_{\rm E}/32$ for $\gamma' = 1.5$) and the four-image annulus closes.

The inner caustic is a *zone of influence*: sources inside it lose their radial image. To leading order in small m the inner radial curve sits where the point-mass and power-law terms of λ_r balance, $u_{\rm in} \simeq [m/(2-\gamma')]^{1/(3-\gamma')}$, and its caustic radius is

$$|y_{\rm in}| \simeq (3-\gamma') \left(\frac{m}{2-\gamma'}\right)^{(2-\gamma')/(3-\gamma')} \theta_{\rm E}. \tag{19.20}$$

For $\gamma' = 1.5$ this scales as $m^{1/3}$: a point mass of $m = 10^{-3}$ already suppresses the radial image for every source within $0.17\,\theta_{\rm E}$ of the axis (the leading-order formula gives 0.19). Mao et al. [27] found the same behaviour for a cored isothermal ellipsoid with a central black hole: above a critical black-hole mass the central images are suppressed for all source positions, while below it they are suppressed only inside a zone of influence, and the black hole can create an additional image. Chapter 21 takes up what happens when such a point mass is present but left out of the model.

19.4.4 The tangential critical curve

The point mass also moves the tangential critical curve, but only slightly. From (19.17), $\lambda_t = 0$ now requires $u^{1-\gamma'} + mu^{-2} = 1$, whose root lies just outside $u = 1$:

$$\theta_t \simeq \theta_{\rm E} \left(1 + \frac{m}{\gamma' - 1}\right). \tag{19.21}$$

For $m \sim 10^{-3}$ this is a per-mille effect, compared with the order-unity effect on the radial curve. The derivation is Problem 19.8.5.

19.5 The Singular Isothermal Sphere plus a Point Mass

The case $\gamma' = 2$ with a central point mass is the one composite lens that solves in elementary closed form. The signed lens equation (19.3) is

$$y = \theta - \theta_{\rm E}\,\mathrm{sgn}(\theta) - \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta}. \tag{19.22}$$

On the $\theta > 0$ branch, multiplying by θ gives a quadratic whose positive root is the outer image:

$$\theta^2 - (y + \theta_{\rm E})\,\theta - \theta_\bullet^2 = 0 \implies \theta_+ = \tfrac{1}{2}\Big[(y + \theta_{\rm E}) + \sqrt{(y + \theta_{\rm E})^2 + 4\theta_\bullet^2}\Big]. \tag{19.23}$$

On the $\theta < 0$ branch, writing $\theta = -s$ with $s > 0$,

$$s^2 + (y - \theta_{\rm E})\,s - \theta_\bullet^2 = 0 \implies \theta_- = -\tfrac{1}{2}\Big[(\theta_{\rm E} - y) + \sqrt{(\theta_{\rm E} - y)^2 + 4\theta_\bullet^2}\Big]. \tag{19.24}$$

As $\theta_\bullet \to 0$ these reduce to the SIS images $y \pm \theta_{\rm E}$ of eq. (11.24) (for $y < \theta_{\rm E}$). Both closed forms agree with a brute-force numerical root solve of (19.22) to better than 10^{-9} for $\theta_{\rm E} = 1$, $\theta_\bullet = 0.08$ and $y = 0.3$ or 1.4.

SIS plus point mass: always exactly two images

Each quadratic has root product $-\theta_\bullet^2 < 0$, so each has exactly one positive root: one image per side, two in total, for every source position. For $y < \theta_{\rm E}$ these are the SIS pair, each pushed slightly away from the centre. For $y > \theta_{\rm E}$, where the bare SIS has a single image, the point mass keeps a second, faint image on the far side at $|\theta_-| \simeq \theta_\bullet^2/(y - \theta_{\rm E})$. There is no radial critical curve, since $\lambda_r = 1 + \theta_\bullet^2/\theta^2 > 0$, so the SIS plus point mass has no radial image for any m.

To first order in m, both images move away from the centre by $\delta\theta_\pm = \theta_\bullet^2/\theta_\pm^{(0)}$, where $\theta_\pm^{(0)} = y \pm \theta_{\rm E}$ are the SIS positions (Problem 19.8.4). This small, linear astrometric shift is the starting point of the bias calculations in Chapters 21 and 25.

19.6 Broken Power Laws

A single power law forces one slope on the whole galaxy. The simplest generalization lets the inner slope differ from the outer one. We now show that this extra freedom is closely related to a central point mass: the point mass is a limiting case of the broken power law, and outside the break the two are indistinguishable.

19.6.1 Definition and slope convention

Define the broken power law directly in the convergence,

$$\kappa(\theta) = \begin{cases} \kappa_B\,(\theta_B/\theta)^{t_1}, & \theta \le \theta_B, \\ \kappa_B\,(\theta_B/\theta)^{t_2}, & \theta > \theta_B, \end{cases} \tag{19.25}$$

continuous at the *break radius* θ_B, with inner slope t_1 and outer slope t_2. These are convergence slopes: for a 3-D density $\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$ the convergence falls as $\theta^{-(\gamma'-1)}$, so

$$t = \gamma' - 1. \tag{19.26}$$

The isothermal case is $t = 1$; a $\gamma' = 1.5$ profile has $t = 0.5$. A finite projected mass at the centre needs $t < 2$ (i.e. $\gamma' < 3$), and the radial images of §19.2 need $t < 1$.

19.6.2 Deflection in closed form

Integrating (19.25) piecewise in (19.1),

$$\theta \le \theta_B : \qquad \alpha(\theta) = \frac{2\kappa_B\,\theta_B^2}{(2-t_1)\,\theta}\left(\frac{\theta}{\theta_B}\right)^{2-t_1}, \tag{19.27}$$

$$\theta > \theta_B : \qquad \alpha(\theta) = \frac{2\kappa_B\,\theta_B^2}{\theta}\left[\frac{1}{2-t_1} + \frac{(\theta/\theta_B)^{2-t_2}-1}{2-t_2}\right]. \tag{19.28}$$

Normalization. Define $\theta_{\rm E}$ by $\alpha(\theta_{\rm E}) = \theta_{\rm E}$ and write $\nu \equiv \theta_B/\theta_{\rm E} < 1$. Then (19.28) fixes the break convergence:

$$\kappa_B = \frac{2-t_1}{2\nu^2\left[1+\Delta t\left(\nu^{\,t_2-2}-1\right)\right]}, \qquad \Delta t \equiv \frac{2-t_1}{2-t_2}. \tag{19.29}$$

For $t_1 = t_2 = t$ this reduces to $\kappa_B = \frac{2-t}{2}\nu^{-t}$, i.e. $\kappa(\theta_{\rm E}) = \kappa_B\nu^t = (2-t)/2 = (3-\gamma')/2$: the annotation check of §19.2 again.

19.6.3 The point mass as the corner $t_1 \to 2$

The inner slope cannot reach $t_1 = 2$, where the enclosed mass diverges logarithmically. But it can approach it while the inner mass is held fixed. Fix the projected mass inside the break, $m_{\rm 2D}(\theta_B) = 2\pi\kappa_B\theta_B^2/(2-t_1) \equiv \pi\theta_\bullet^2$, i.e. $\kappa_B = (2-t_1)\theta_\bullet^2/(2\theta_B^2)$. Then the inner branch (19.27) is

$$\alpha(\theta) = \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta}\left(\frac{\theta}{\theta_B}\right)^{2-t_1} \xrightarrow{\;t_1\to 2\;} \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta} \qquad (\theta \le \theta_B) : \tag{19.30}$$

all of the inner mass collapses onto the centre and the inner branch becomes the point-mass deflection. The same statement in Meneghetti's language (Remark 5.3 of Meneghetti [29]): the power law with 3-D slope $n = 3$ (here $t = 2$) has constant enclosed mass and is the point mass.

There is a subtlety. If θ_B is held fixed, $\kappa_B \to 0$ takes the outer power law down with it, and the whole lens collapses to a point mass. To obtain a galaxy plus a point mass one must also hold the outer power law fixed, $K \equiv \kappa_B\theta_B^{t_2}$ constant. Together with the fixed inner mass this forces

$$\theta_B = \left[\frac{(2-t_1)\,\theta_\bullet^2}{2K}\right]^{1/(2-t_2)} \xrightarrow{\;t_1\to 2\;} 0, \tag{19.31}$$

and in that joint limit the deflection at every fixed $\theta > 0$ tends to $2K\theta^{1-t_2}/(2-t_2) + \theta_\bullet^2/\theta$: an outer power law plus a point mass. So the power-law-plus-point-mass model of §19.4 is a boundary point of the broken-power-law family, reached by sending the inner slope to 2 and the break radius to 0 together.

19.6.4 Outside the break: a power law plus an effective point mass

Compare the broken power law with the single power law of the same outer slope t_2 and the same prefactor $\kappa_B\theta_B^{t_2}$, i.e. the outer branch continued all the way to the centre. For $\theta > \theta_B$

the two enclosed masses differ by a constant,

$$\Delta m_{2\mathrm{D}} = 2\pi\kappa_B\theta_B^2\left[\frac{1}{2-t_1}-\frac{1}{2-t_2}\right] = 2\pi\kappa_B\theta_B^2\,\frac{t_1-t_2}{(2-t_1)(2-t_2)},$$

and a constant enclosed mass is exactly what a point mass is.

Outside the break, broken power law = power law + point mass

For every $\theta > \theta_B$, exactly,

$$\alpha_{\mathrm{bPL}}(\theta) = \frac{2\kappa_B\theta_B^{t_2}}{2-t_2}\,\theta^{1-t_2} + \frac{\theta_{\mathrm{eff}}^2}{\theta}, \qquad \theta_{\mathrm{eff}}^2 = 2\kappa_B\theta_B^2\,\frac{t_1-t_2}{(2-t_1)(2-t_2)}. \tag{19.32}$$

Consequently, by the superposition rule (19.6), outside the break λ_r and λ_t are those of a power law plus a point mass θ_{eff}, and everything in §19.4 (the weight ratio, the stationary point, the annihilation threshold with $m \to \theta_{\mathrm{eff}}^2/\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2$) applies unchanged to any critical curve that lies outside θ_B.

This is an identity, not an approximation. Two properties of θ_{eff} deserve separate statement. Its sign is the sign of $t_1 - t_2$: an inner cusp steeper than the outer slope ($t_1 > t_2$) acts as a positive point mass, whereas a shallower inner profile, a core ($t_1 < t_2$), acts as a negative one, a mass deficit relative to the continued power law. It is not the total inner mass: with $\pi\theta_\bullet^2 \equiv 2\pi\kappa_B\theta_B^2/(2-t_1)$ the mass inside the break,

$$\frac{\theta_{\mathrm{eff}}^2}{\theta_\bullet^2} = \frac{t_1-t_2}{2-t_2}, \tag{19.33}$$

which reaches 1 only as $t_1 \to 2$. The effective point mass is what the inner cusp adds over and above what the continued outer power law already puts there.

19.6.5 Inside the break: a resolved break is necessary, not sufficient

Equation (19.32) settles the outside. Inside the break, compare the broken power law with a point mass carrying the same total inner mass $\pi\theta_\bullet^2$. From (19.30),

$$\frac{\alpha_{\mathrm{bPL}}(\theta)}{\alpha_\bullet(\theta)} = \left(\frac{\theta}{\theta_B}\right)^{2-t_1}, \qquad \theta \le \theta_B. \tag{19.34}$$

The two agree at θ_B by construction and separate inward. As $t_1 \to 2^-$ at fixed inner mass the ratio tends to 1 at every radius ($t_1 = 2$ itself has a divergent inner mass, §19.6.3); for any $t_1 < 2$ the fractional difference is

$$1 - \left(\frac{\theta}{\theta_B}\right)^{2-t_1} = (2-t_1)\ln\frac{\theta_B}{\theta} + \mathcal{O}\big((2-t_1)^2\big), \tag{19.35}$$

to first order linear in the slope deficit $2-t_1$ and logarithmic in radius. The logarithmic form holds only while $(2-t_1)\ln(\theta_B/\theta) \ll 1$: for $2-t_1 = 1$ the exact deviation is $1-\theta/\theta_B$, linear

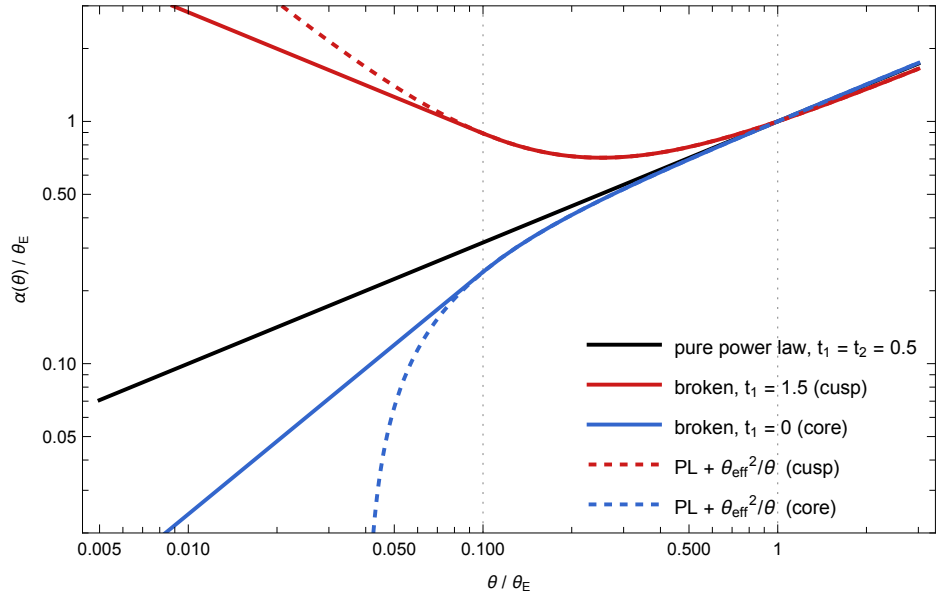


Figure 19.2: Deflection of a broken power law versus a single power law. All three solid curves have outer slope $t_2 = 0.5$ ($\gamma' = 1.5$) and Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E} = 1$ (vertical dotted line at 1); the broken models have $\theta_B = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$ (dotted line at 0.1) and inner slope $t_1 = 1.5$ (a steep cusp, red) or $t_1 = 0$ (a flat core, blue). The dashed curves are eq. (19.32): the continued outer power law plus $\theta_{\rm eff}^2/\theta$. Outside the break they lie exactly on the broken-power-law curves; inside, they separate. For the core, $\theta_{\rm eff}^2 < 0$ and the dashed curve plunges to zero. Generated by `broken_power_law.wl`.

in θ, and the logarithmic form exceeds 1 inside θ_B/e (at $\theta_B/10$ it gives 2.3 against the exact 0.9).

This has a practical meaning. Data that never reach inside θ_B cannot tell a broken power law from a power law plus a point mass, by eq. (19.32), so the break must be resolved. Resolving it does not settle the question, because inside the break the models part company only as the power $(\theta/\theta_B)^{2-t_1}$, slowly when the cusp is steep. A fractional difference δ is reached at

$$\frac{\theta}{\theta_B} = (1-\delta)^{1/(2-t_1)}, \tag{19.36}$$

so a 10 per cent difference appears at $0.9\,\theta_B$ for a mild cusp ($2 - t_1 = 1$) but only at $0.35\,\theta_B$ for a steep one ($2 - t_1 = 0.1$). The observational requirement is to resolve the radius where the deflections differ by more than the astrometric precision, which can be much smaller than θ_B itself.

19.7 Summary

For any axisymmetric lens, $\lambda_t = 1 - \bar\kappa$ and $\lambda_r = 1 + \bar\kappa - 2\kappa$; the departures from unity add under superposition. A central point mass adds $\mp\theta_\bullet^2/\theta^2$ to $\lambda_{t,r}$ (eqs. 19.7–19.8). The power law $\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$ has $\alpha = \theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma'-1}\theta^{2-\gamma'}$, $\kappa = \frac{3-\gamma'}{2}(\theta_{\rm E}/\theta)^{\gamma'-1}$, and $\kappa(\theta_{\rm E}) = (3-\gamma')/2$. Its convergence

slope is $t = \gamma' - 1$, and the two conventions must be kept apart. Its tangential critical curve is the Einstein ring; its radial critical curve, $\theta_r = \theta_{\rm E}(2-\gamma')^{1/(\gamma'-1)}$, exists only for $1 < \gamma' < 2$ and shrinks to the centre as $\gamma' \to 2$.

A point mass has $\lambda_r = 1 + \theta_\bullet^2/\theta^2 > 0$ and no radial critical curve. Added to a power law, its influence relative to the profile grows inward as $\theta^{-(3-\gamma')}$, so it acts exactly where radial images form. Below $m_{\rm crit}(\gamma')$ (eq. 19.19) the composite has two radial critical curves; at threshold they merge and annihilate. $m_{\rm crit} \leq 0.0066$ for every γ'; at $\gamma' = 1.5$ it is $27/4096$. Below threshold the inner caustic is a zone of influence of radius $\propto m^{(2-\gamma')/(3-\gamma')}$ inside which the radial image is suppressed. The SIS plus point mass solves in closed form and has exactly two images for every source position, and no radial image.

The broken power law has closed-form deflections. A power law plus a point mass is its corner $t_1 \to 2$, $\theta_B \to 0$, reached with the inner mass and the outer power law both held fixed; at fixed θ_B the same limit leaves a bare point mass. Outside the break the broken power law is exactly a power law plus an effective point mass, $\theta_{\rm eff}^2 \propto (t_1 - t_2)$. Inside the break the two separate only as $(\theta/\theta_B)^{2-t_1}$, slowly when the cusp is steep, so a resolved break alone may not distinguish a cusp from a point mass.

19.8 Problems

Exercise 19.8.1. (Power-law convergence by inversion.) Starting from $\alpha_{\rm PL} = \theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma'-1}\theta^{2-\gamma'}$, use eq. (19.2) to derive eq. (19.9). Then rebuild α from κ with eq. (19.1), state where the integral converges, and verify $\bar\kappa(\theta_{\rm E}) = 1$ for every γ'.

Exercise 19.8.2. (Point-mass magnification.) Show that a point mass has magnification $\mu = \theta^4/(\theta^4 - \theta_\bullet^4)$ at image position θ. Show that its two images, at $\theta_\pm$, have total magnification $|\mu_+| + |\mu_-| = (u^2+2)/(u\sqrt{u^2+4})$ with $u = y/\theta_\bullet$, that this always exceeds 1, and that the signed magnifications sum to exactly 1.

Exercise 19.8.3. (Radial critical radius.) Derive $\theta_r = \theta_{\rm E}(2-\gamma')^{1/(\gamma'-1)}$ from $\lambda_r = 0$. Show that $\theta_r \to 0$ as $\gamma' \to 2$ and that there is no radial critical curve for $\gamma' > 2$. Evaluate $\theta_r/\theta_{\rm E}$ at $\gamma' = 1.6$.

Exercise 19.8.4. (SIS plus point mass: first-order shifts.) Expand the closed-form images (19.23) and (19.24) to first order in $m = \theta_\bullet^2/\theta_{\rm E}^2$ and show that both images move away from the centre by $\delta\theta_\pm = \theta_\bullet^2/\theta_\pm^{(0)}$, with $\theta_\pm^{(0)} = y \pm \theta_{\rm E}$. Evaluate exact and linearized positions for $\theta_{\rm E} = 1$, $\theta_\bullet = 0.08$, $y = 0.3$.

Exercise 19.8.5. (Tangential critical curve with a point mass.) For a power law plus a point mass, show that the tangential critical curve lies at $\theta_t \simeq \theta_{\rm E}[1 + m/(\gamma'-1)]$ to first order in m, eq. (19.21). Find the exact result for the SIS and compare. Evaluate θ_t numerically for $\gamma' = 1.5$, $m = 0.01$.

Exercise 19.8.6. (Annihilation at $\gamma' = 3/2$ by hand.) For $\gamma' = 3/2$ substitute $u = s^2$ in eq. (19.17) and show that $u^2\lambda_r = s^4 - \frac{1}{2}s^3 + m$. A double root marks the merger of the two radial critical curves; use this to derive $u_c = 9/64$ and $m_{\rm crit} = 27/4096$ without the general formula (19.19). Find the radius of the merged radial caustic.

Exercise 19.8.7. (Broken power law outside the break.)

(a) Compute the projected mass inside θ_B and in the annulus $\theta_B < \theta' < \theta$ for the profile (19.25), and hence derive eq. (19.28).

(b) Show that it is continuous with eq. (19.27) at θ_B.

(c) Rewrite it as eq. (19.32) and identify $\theta_{\rm eff}^2$.

Exercise 19.8.8. (The point-mass limit.) Hold the projected mass inside the break fixed at $\pi\theta_\bullet^2$. Show that the inner branch becomes $\alpha = (\theta_\bullet^2/\theta)(\theta/\theta_B)^{2-t_1}$ and tends to the point-mass deflection as $t_1 \to 2$, even though the central convergence becomes more singular. What happens to κ_B, and to $\theta_{\rm eff}^2$, in the same limit? If θ_B is held fixed, what happens to the outer branch?

Exercise 19.8.9. (Isothermal limits.)

(a) Show that $t_1 = t_2 = 1$ gives a constant deflection on both branches: a SIS with $\theta_{\rm E} = 2\kappa_B\theta_B$.

(b) For $t_2 = 1$ and $1 < t_1 < 2$, show that outside the break the lens is *exactly* a SIS plus a point mass, and use eq. (19.23) to write the outer image of a source at y in closed form. Evaluate it for $\theta_B = 0.1$, $\kappa_B = 5$, $t_1 = 3/2$, $y = 0.3$, and confirm the image lies outside the break.

(c) What does $t_1 < 1$ correspond to?

Chapter 20

Odd Images, Central Images, and Their Suppression

Chapter 10 showed that every image is a stationary point of the arrival-time surface and stated Burke's theorem: a smooth, transparent lens produces an odd number of images. Chapter 12 then walked a source across the caustics of an elliptical lens and found that the image count changes by two at each crossing. Yet the lenses we actually observe are doubles and quads. For a single galaxy the missing odd image is the *central image*, the maximum of the arrival-time surface, and this chapter is about where it lives, how faint it is, and what destroys it.

Whether a central image exists, and how bright it is, depends on the region inside the radial critical curve, which for the cored lenses of this chapter lies at a quarter to a third of the deflector's Einstein radius: on the size of a core, on the steepness of a cusp, and on the mass of a central black hole. The same topology that removes the central image also removes the radial critical curve, and the moment at which this happens, the *annihilation boundary*, is the organising idea of Chapter 21. The degeneracy between a steep inner slope and a central point mass, both of which suppress the central image, is one reason the inner mass profile has to be pinned down by other means, the theme of Chapter 22.

The chapter provides the means to sketch the arrival-time surface of a cored lens and locate its central maximum; to state exactly which hypothesis of Burke's theorem a point mass violates, and what replaces the theorem when it does; to compute the demagnification of the central image and explain why observed lenses rarely show one; and to see why a central point mass and a steep inner slope both suppress it.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `odd_images.wl`: symbolic and numerical verification of every result in this chapter (Fermat gradient and Hessian, index counting on source grids, central-image magnification, point-mass puncture, critical black-hole mass); exports the three figures to `Figures/16_Odd_Images_Central/`
- `problems_16.wl`: verified solutions to the Problems

20.1 The Arrival-Time Surface, Revisited

We work throughout with the dimensionless Fermat potential of eq. (10.2),

$$\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta};\boldsymbol{\beta}) = \tfrac{1}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\beta}|^2 - \psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}), \qquad \boldsymbol{\alpha} = \nabla\psi, \qquad \kappa = \tfrac{1}{2}\nabla^2\psi. \tag{20.1}$$

Its gradient is $\nabla\tau = (\boldsymbol{\theta}-\boldsymbol{\beta}) - \boldsymbol{\alpha}$, so $\nabla\tau = 0$ is the lens equation (eq. 10.7), and its Hessian is the Jacobian matrix, $\partial_a\partial_b\tau = \mathcal{A}_{ab}$ (eq. 10.8). Both facts are re-verified for an arbitrary potential in checks A.1–A.4 of `odd_images.wl`.

20.1.1 Where can a maximum sit?

With the shear components γ_1, γ_2 and $|\gamma| = (\gamma_1^2+\gamma_2^2)^{1/2}$, the Jacobian $\mathcal{A} = \begin{pmatrix} 1-\kappa-\gamma_1 & -\gamma_2 \\ -\gamma_2 & 1-\kappa+\gamma_1 \end{pmatrix}$ has eigenvalues

$$\lambda_\pm = 1 - \kappa \pm |\gamma|. \tag{20.2}$$

A maximum of τ needs both eigenvalues negative, i.e. the larger one, $1-\kappa+|\gamma|$, must be negative:

$$\boxed{\text{maximum of } \tau \iff \kappa > 1 + |\gamma|} \tag{20.3}$$

. A Type III image can therefore only sit where the lens is locally supercritical by more than the shear. In a galaxy this happens only near the centre, which is why the third image is called the central image. By the same algebra a minimum needs $\kappa < 1 - |\gamma|$, and a saddle needs $|1-\kappa| < |\gamma|$.

20.1.2 The one-dimensional cut

For an axisymmetric lens every image lies on the line through the lens centre and the source. Put the source at $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (y, 0)$ with $y \geq 0$ and let θ be a signed coordinate along that line, so that images on the far side of the lens have $\theta < 0$. The deflection $\alpha(\theta)$ is then an odd function, and the cut through the arrival-time surface is

$$\tau(\theta) = \tfrac{1}{2}(\theta - y)^2 - \psi(|\theta|), \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}\tau}{\mathrm{d}\theta} = \theta - y - \alpha(\theta). \tag{20.4}$$

The Hessian does not depend on y (apart from a constant, the source enters τ only through the linear term $-\boldsymbol{\beta}\cdot\boldsymbol{\theta}$), so at any point its eigenvalues are those of Chapter 11, eq. (11.9):

$$\lambda_r = \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}\theta} = 1 - \frac{\mathrm{d}\alpha}{\mathrm{d}\theta}, \qquad \lambda_t = 1 - \frac{\alpha(\theta)}{\theta}, \tag{20.5}$$

where $y(\theta) = \theta - \alpha(\theta)$ is the one-dimensional lens map. λ_r is the curvature of τ along the cut and λ_t its curvature across the cut. Reading off the type of an image is therefore a two-step exercise: find where $y(\theta)$ crosses the source value (the image), and ask whether $y(\theta)$ is rising ($\lambda_r > 0$) or falling ($\lambda_r < 0$) there and whether the image is outside ($\lambda_t > 0$) or inside ($\lambda_t < 0$) the tangential critical circle.

20.2 Counting Images with the Index Theorem

Chapter 10 quoted the Morse relation $n_{\min} - n_{\text{sad}} + n_{\max} = 1$. To see what happens when the lens is not smooth we need the proof, and the most direct one is the index argument of Schneider et al. [42, Sect. 5.4.1]. It uses only the vector field $\mathbf{X}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \nabla\tau$. (The Morse-theoretic version, with Euler characteristics and the Morse inequalities, is developed in Petters et al. 35, Sect. 7.4 and Chs. 10–11.)

The index of a stationary point. Let $\mathbf{X}$ be a continuous planar vector field and c a closed curve on which $\mathbf{X} \neq 0$. As we traverse c once counter-clockwise, the direction angle of $\mathbf{X}$ turns by 2π times an integer, the *winding number* of $\mathbf{X}$ around c. It cannot change while c is deformed without crossing a zero of $\mathbf{X}$; the winding number around a small curve enclosing one isolated zero is the *index* of that zero, and the winding number around any curve is the sum of the indices of the zeros it encloses.

For $\mathbf{X} = \nabla\tau$ near an image, $\mathbf{X} \approx \mathcal{A}\,\delta\boldsymbol{\theta}$. In the eigenbasis of $\mathcal{A}$ this is $(\lambda_1\,\delta\theta_1, \lambda_2\,\delta\theta_2)$, and

$$\text{index(image)} = \operatorname{sgn}(\lambda_1\lambda_2) = \operatorname{sgn}\det\mathcal{A} = \operatorname{sgn}\mu = \begin{cases} +1 & \text{minimum or maximum,} \\ -1 & \text{saddle.} \end{cases} \tag{20.6}$$

The winding at infinity. On a circle of radius $R \to \infty$, $\mathbf{X} = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\beta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$. If $|\boldsymbol{\alpha}|$ is bounded, the term $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ dominates and $\mathbf{X}$ points radially outward: its winding number is $+1$. If, in addition, $\mathbf{X}$ is continuous everywhere, the only zeros inside the circle are the images, so

$$\sum_{\text{images}} \operatorname{sgn}\mu_i = n_+ - n_- = 1, \qquad n_+ = n_{\min} + n_{\max}, \quad n_- = n_{\text{sad}}. \tag{20.7}$$

The total number of images is then

$$N = n_+ + n_- = 1 + 2\,n_- \qquad \text{(odd)}. \tag{20.8}$$

This is Burke's odd-number theorem [10], in the form of Theorem 1 of Schneider et al. [42, Sect. 5.4.1]. The same theorem adds two facts we will use: the global minimum of τ always exists and is an image, so $n_{\min} \geq 1$; and a source far enough from the lens has a single image.

The counting rule and its hypotheses

For a lens whose deflection $\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ is (S1) continuous everywhere and (S2) bounded, and a source (S3) not on a caustic,

$$n_+ - n_- = 1, \qquad N = 1 + 2n_-.$$

The proof is purely topological: images are the zeros of $\nabla\tau$, each carries index $\operatorname{sgn}\mu = \pm 1$, and the indices must add up to the winding of $\nabla\tau$ at infinity. Hypothesis (S1) is what a "smooth, bounded Σ" buys in Theorem 10.4.1.

20.2.1 What the hypotheses exclude

Every step above is sound except the claim that the images are the only zeros of $\mathbf{X}$ inside the large circle. That claim needs (S1). If $\boldsymbol{\alpha}$ fails to be continuous at some point, the field $\mathbf{X}$ is undefined there, and that point can carry a winding of its own even though it is not an image. Table 20.1 lists the three axisymmetric centres we need.

Table 20.1: The centre of three axisymmetric lenses, seen by the index theorem. "Centre index" is the winding number of $\nabla\tau$ around a small circle about a *singular* centre (one that is not an image). Verified in `odd_images.wl`, checks C.5, E.5–E.7, F.1–F.4.

Lens	$\boldsymbol{\alpha}$ near 0	τ near 0	Centre index	$n_+ - n_-$
NIS (core θ_c)	$\kappa_0\,\boldsymbol{\theta}$, continuous	smooth summit	none (not singular)	1
SIS	$\theta_{\mathrm{E}}\,\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$, jumps	conical tip	1 if $\lvert\boldsymbol{\beta}\rvert < \theta_{\mathrm{E}}$, else 0	0 or 1
point mass	$\theta_\bullet^2\,\boldsymbol{\theta}/\theta^2$, unbounded	spike, $\tau \to +\infty$	1 always	0

The point mass. For a point mass $\psi = \theta_\bullet^2 \ln\theta$, so $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \theta_\bullet^2\boldsymbol{\theta}/\theta^2$ diverges at the origin and $\tau \to +\infty$ there: the summit of the potential hill has become an infinitely tall spike. The surface density is a Dirac delta: it is not bounded, the deflection is neither continuous nor bounded at the origin, and (S1)–(S2) fail there (they still hold far away, so the winding at infinity is still +1). Near the origin $\mathbf{X} \approx -\theta_\bullet^2\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}/\theta$ points straight inward, like the field around a maximum, so the puncture carries index +1. The index sum therefore reads

$$n_+ - n_- + g = 1, \qquad N = 2n_- + 1 - g, \tag{20.9}$$

for a lens containing g point masses. Schneider et al. [42, Sect. 5.4.1] put it in words: each point mass turns what would have been a local maximum of τ into a logarithmic spike, so the number of positive-parity images plus the number of point masses exceeds the number of negative-parity images by one. The same counting formula, written as $N = 2n_+ + g - 1$, is Theorem 11.4 of Petters et al. [35], who also show that as the source moves far away there are g saddle images, each approaching one of the point masses. For a single point mass ($g = 1$) the image count is even.

The SIS. For the singular isothermal sphere, $\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ has constant length but its direction jumps at the origin: (S1) fails, (S2) holds. The surface τ has a conical tip with no tangent plane (a local maximum when $\lvert\boldsymbol{\beta}\rvert < \theta_{\mathrm{E}}$), so it is not a stationary point and produces no image. Its index depends on the source: near the origin $\mathbf{X} \approx -\boldsymbol{\beta} - \theta_{\mathrm{E}}\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$, which winds once if $\lvert\boldsymbol{\beta}\rvert < \theta_{\mathrm{E}}$ and not at all if $\lvert\boldsymbol{\beta}\rvert > \theta_{\mathrm{E}}$. This is the index-theorem reading of the SIS "cut": two images ($n_+ - n_- = 0$) inside it, one image ($n_+ - n_- = 1$) outside. The computation is Exercise 20.8.5.

Cusps that are not singular enough. A power-law profile $\kappa \propto \theta^{1-\gamma'}$ with $1 < \gamma' < 2$ has an infinite central convergence, so its surface density is not bounded. However, $\alpha \propto \theta^{2-\gamma'} \to 0$ continuously at the origin, so (S1) holds. The untruncated power law does violate (S2), since

$\alpha \propto \theta^{2-\gamma'}$ grows without bound at large θ, but $|\boldsymbol{\alpha}|/\theta \propto \theta^{1-\gamma'} \to 0$, so $\nabla\tau$ still winds once at infinity. This is the generalisation noted by Schneider et al. [42, p. 174]: the theorem holds for any gradient map asymptotic to the identity at infinity (a real galaxy is, in any case, truncated at large radius). The index argument goes through, and the lens produces an odd number of images: it has a central image (Section 20.4). The counting rule needs a continuous deflection with $|\boldsymbol{\alpha}|/\theta \to 0$ at infinity. A finite central density is not required.

20.3 The Central Image of a Cored Lens

The non-singular isothermal sphere (NIS) of Chapter 11, Section 11.5, is the simplest lens with a genuine central image. Its convergence and deflection are (eqs. 11.30 and 11.32)

$$\kappa(\theta) = \frac{\theta_{\mathrm{E}}}{2\sqrt{\theta^2+\theta_c^2}}, \qquad \alpha(\theta) = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}\,\frac{\sqrt{\theta^2+\theta_c^2}-\theta_c}{\theta}, \tag{20.10}$$

with central convergence $\kappa_0 = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}/(2\theta_c)$ (eq. 11.31). The potential, needed to draw τ, is

$$\psi(\theta) = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}\Big[s - \theta_c \ln\big(\theta_c + s\big)\Big], \qquad s \equiv \sqrt{\theta^2+\theta_c^2}, \tag{20.11}$$

up to an irrelevant constant.

20.3.1 Three images, at most

Multiplying the NIS lens equation $y = \theta - \alpha(\theta)$ by θ and isolating the square root gives $\theta_{\mathrm{E}}\, s = \theta^2 - y\,\theta + \theta_{\mathrm{E}}\theta_c$; squaring and discarding the spurious root $\theta = 0$ leaves a cubic,

$$\theta^3 - 2y\,\theta^2 + \big(y^2 + 2\theta_{\mathrm{E}}\theta_c - \theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2\big)\theta - 2y\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}\theta_c = 0 \tag{20.12}$$

, so the NIS has at most three images. The radial critical curve is where $\lambda_r = 0$; by eq. (20.19) below (at $\theta_\bullet = 0$) it is the positive root of $s^2 + \theta_c s - \theta_{\mathrm{E}}\theta_c = 0$:

$$s_r = \frac{-\theta_c + \sqrt{\theta_c^2 + 4\theta_{\mathrm{E}}\theta_c}}{2}, \qquad \theta_r = \sqrt{s_r^2 - \theta_c^2}, \qquad y_r = \big|\theta_r - \alpha(\theta_r)\big|. \tag{20.13}$$

For $\theta_c = 0.2\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}$ this gives $\theta_r = 0.297\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}$ and a radial caustic of radius $y_r = 0.235\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}$; for $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}$, $\theta_r = 0.251\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}$ and $y_r = 0.427\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}$.

The census. On a grid of 149 source positions $0.01 \le y/\theta_{\mathrm{E}} \le 1.5$, the script finds every root of eq. (20.12) and classifies it with eq. (20.5). For $y > y_r$ there is one image, a minimum. For $y < y_r$ there are three images: the minimum, a saddle on the far side outside the radial critical circle ($\theta < -\theta_r$), and a maximum on the far side inside it ($-\theta_r < \theta < 0$). In every case $n_+ - n_- = 1$. At $y = 0.1\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}$ the arrival order is $\tau_{\min} < \tau_{\mathrm{sad}} < \tau_{\max}$: the central image arrives last, as Table 10.1 leads us to expect for a Type III image. As $y \to y_r$ from below, the saddle and the maximum merge on the radial critical circle and disappear together. The left column of Figure 20.1 shows the contours of τ. The contour through the saddle is a figure eight: one lobe encloses the central maximum, the other the minimum.

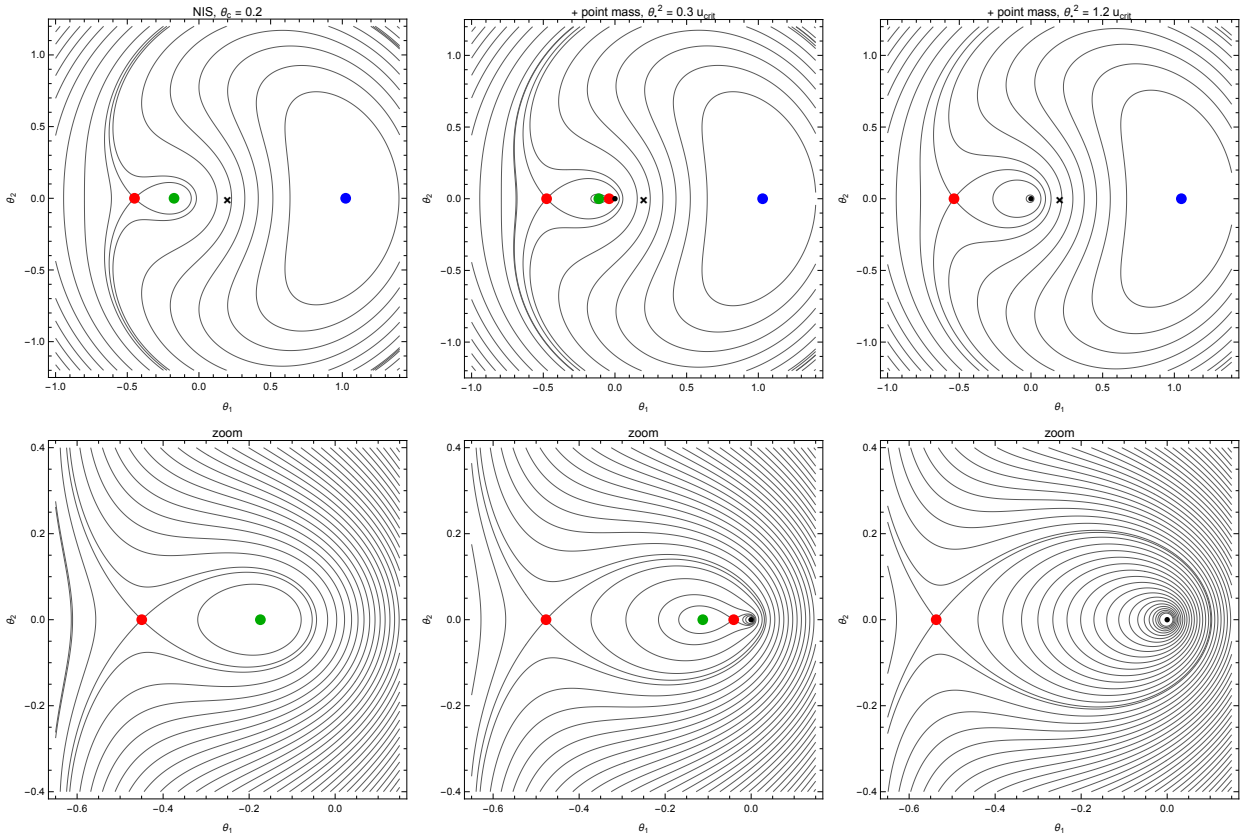


Figure 20.1: Contours of the arrival-time surface $\tau(\theta_1, \theta_2)$ for an NIS with $\theta_c = 0.2\,\theta_{\rm E}$ and a source at $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.2, 0)\,\theta_{\rm E}$ (black cross); top row full view, bottom row zoom on the centre; axes in units of $\theta_{\rm E}$. **Left:** NIS alone — minimum (blue), saddle (red), central maximum (green). **Centre:** NIS plus a central point mass with $\theta_\bullet^2 = 0.3\,\theta_{\bullet,\rm crit}^2$ — the summit is punctured (black dot) and a second saddle appears next to the puncture; four images. **Right:** $\theta_\bullet^2 = 1.2\,\theta_{\bullet,\rm crit}^2$ — the maximum and the inner saddle are gone; two images. Generated by `odd_images.wl`.

20.3.2 How faint is the central image?

Put the source on the axis, $y = 0$. The central image is then at $\theta = 0$, where $\alpha(\theta) \simeq \kappa_0\theta$, so both eigenvalues equal $1 - \kappa_0$ (the shear vanishes at the centre of an axisymmetric lens):

$$\boxed{\mu_c = \frac{1}{(1-\kappa_0)^2} = \frac{4\theta_c^2}{(\theta_{\rm E} - 2\theta_c)^2} = \frac{4\theta_c^2}{\theta_{\rm E}^2}\left[1 + \frac{4\theta_c}{\theta_{\rm E}} + \mathcal{O}\!\left(\frac{\theta_c^2}{\theta_{\rm E}^2}\right)\right]} \tag{20.14}$$

. For a source slightly off axis, linearising $y \simeq (1-\kappa_0)\theta$ puts the central image at $\theta \simeq -y/(\kappa_0 - 1)$, on the far side and $\kappa_0 - 1$ times closer to the centre than the source, with the same magnification to leading order. The magnification falls as the square of the core radius: a core one hundred times smaller than the Einstein radius makes the central image $\mu_c = 1/2401$ times as bright as the unlensed source, 8.5 magnitudes fainter; even a generous core, $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$, gives $\mu_c = 1/16$, 3.0 magnitudes fainter. Figure 20.2 shows eq. (20.14) against a direct numerical solution at $y = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$.

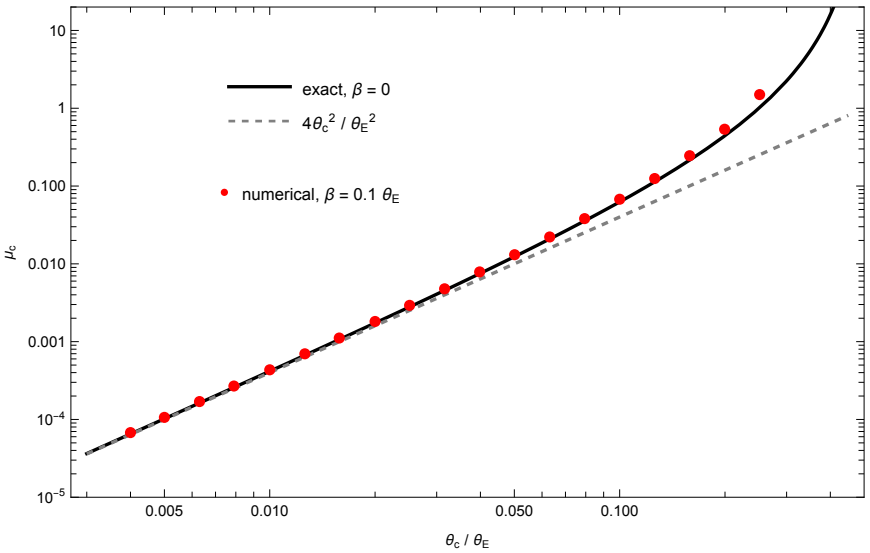


Figure 20.2: Magnification of the central image of an NIS as a function of core radius. Solid: the on-axis closed form, eq. (20.14); dashed: its small-core limit $4\theta_c^2/\theta_{\rm E}^2$; points: numerical roots of the lens equation for $y = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$, which lie within 6% of the closed form for $\theta_c \le 0.05\,\theta_{\rm E}$. The divergence as $\theta_c \to \theta_{\rm E}/2$ is the radial critical circle shrinking onto the centre. Generated by `odd_images.wl`.

Why central images are rarely seen. Three effects hide it. First, the demagnification of eq. (20.14) for any realistically small core. Second, the central image sits on top of the lens galaxy's own bright nucleus, so at optical wavelengths it is swamped; searches are done in the radio, where the lens galaxy is usually faint. Third, real galaxies are cuspier than a cored isothermal sphere and host central black holes, both of which suppress the image further (the next two sections). Congdon and Keeton [16, Sect. 6.2.2] summarise model-based expectations of typical central-image magnifications around 10^{-3}, with values as large as 0.1 possible (an estimate they take from Keeton 22), and note that at the time of writing a central image had been detected in only one galaxy-scale lens, the radio quasar lens PMN J1632−0033. Conversely, a measured upper limit on the central image's flux is a *lower* limit on how cuspy the centre is.

The central image of a cored lens

A supercritical core ($\kappa_0 > 1$) makes a third image, a maximum of τ on the far side inside the radial critical curve, that exists only for sources inside the radial caustic and has

$$\mu_c \simeq \frac{1}{(\kappa_0 - 1)^2} \simeq \frac{4\theta_c^2}{\theta_{\rm E}^2} \quad (\theta_c \ll \theta_{\rm E}).$$

It is demagnified by the curvature of the summit of τ.

20.4 Steep Cusps Suppress the Central Image

A core is not the only way to keep the central image alive. Consider the power-law lens with $\theta_{\rm E}$ as unit,

$$\kappa(\theta) = \frac{3-\gamma'}{2}\,\theta^{1-\gamma'}, \qquad \alpha(\theta) = \operatorname{sgn}(\theta)\,|\theta|^{2-\gamma'}, \qquad 1 < \gamma' < 2, \tag{20.15}$$

where γ' is the slope of the three-dimensional density, $\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$ ($\gamma' = 2$ is isothermal; check G.1 verifies that κ and α are consistent). The density diverges at the centre, but, as noted in Section 20.2.1, the deflection is continuous, so there is a central image.

On the far side write $\theta = -x$ with $x > 0$. The lens equation reads $y = x^{2-\gamma'} - x$, and for a small source offset the central root has $x \ll 1$, so $y \simeq x^{2-\gamma'}$, i.e. $x \simeq y^{1/(2-\gamma')}$. From eq. (20.5), $\lambda_t = 1 - x^{1-\gamma'}$ and $\lambda_r = 1 - (2-\gamma')\,x^{1-\gamma'}$; both are large and negative for $x \to 0$ (the image is a maximum), and $\lambda_t\lambda_r \simeq (2-\gamma')\,x^{2(1-\gamma')}$. Therefore

$$\boxed{\mu_c \simeq \frac{1}{2-\gamma'}\left(\frac{y}{\theta_{\rm E}}\right)^{2(\gamma'-1)/(2-\gamma')}} \qquad (y \to 0). \tag{20.16}$$

The exponent $2(\gamma'-1)/(2-\gamma')$ grows without bound as $\gamma' \to 2$: steepening the cusp toward isothermal drives the central image to zero flux for every source inside the radial caustic. At $y = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$ the exact (numerical) values are $\mu_c = 0.037$ for $\gamma' = 1.5$, 3.1×10^{-3} for $\gamma' = 1.6$, 7.5×10^{-5} for $\gamma' = 1.7$, and below 10^{-7} for $\gamma' = 1.8$. At $\gamma' = 1.2$ a source at $0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$ is already outside the radial caustic and has no central image at all.

The physical reading is the same as for the core: the steeper the cusp, the more sharply peaked the summit of $-\psi$, the more curved the maximum of τ, and the fainter the image. A core and a shallow cusp are two ways of rounding the summit; isothermal ($\gamma' = 2$) is the borderline at which the summit becomes a cone.

20.5 A Central Point Mass Punctures the Surface

20.5.1 The bare point mass: exactly two images

For a point mass, $\alpha(\theta) = \theta_\bullet^2/\theta$ and eq. (20.5) gives

$$\lambda_r = 1 + \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta^2} > 0, \qquad \lambda_t = 1 - \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta^2} \tag{20.17}$$

. Since λ_r is positive everywhere, no point of the lens plane can host a maximum of τ, and since $y(\theta)$ is strictly increasing on each half-line, each side of the lens has exactly one image. These are the two roots $\theta_\pm = \left(y \pm \sqrt{y^2 + 4\theta_\bullet^2}\right)/2$ of Chapter 8, eq. (8.21): a minimum at $\theta_+ > \theta_\bullet$ and a saddle at $\theta_- < 0$ inside the Einstein ring, with $n_+ - n_- = 0$, exactly as eq. (20.9) demands for $g = 1$.

20.5.2 A point mass inside a cored lens

Now put a point mass at the centre of an NIS, a supermassive black hole at the centre of a galaxy. The one-dimensional map becomes

$$y(\theta) = \theta - \theta_{\rm E}\,\frac{\sqrt{\theta^2+\theta_c^2}-\theta_c}{\theta} - \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta}. \tag{20.18}$$

Multiplying by θ and squaring as before gives a quartic, so there are at most four images, and by eq. (20.9) with $g=1$ their number is even. The radial eigenvalue is the decisive quantity. Using $\theta^2 = s^2 - \theta_c^2$ it factorises:

$$\theta^2\lambda_r = h(s) + \theta_\bullet^2, \qquad h(s) \equiv (s-\theta_c)\left(s+\theta_c - \frac{\theta_{\rm E}\theta_c}{s}\right), \qquad s=\sqrt{\theta^2+\theta_c^2} \tag{20.19}$$

.

Two radial critical circles. The function $h(s)$ vanishes at $s=\theta_c$ (the centre), dips to a negative minimum, and rises again. Adding $\theta_\bullet^2 > 0$ lifts the whole curve. For a small black hole $h+\theta_\bullet^2$ still dips below zero, so it has two zeros: an inner critical circle r_1 created by the black hole and the (slightly displaced) radial critical circle r_2 of the NIS. On the far side, the map $y(\theta)$ therefore rises from $-\infty$, reaches a local maximum $y_{\rm out}$ at $\theta=-r_2$ (the radial caustic), falls to a local minimum $y_{\rm in}$ at $\theta=-r_1$ (a new, inner caustic), and then rises to $+\infty$ as $\theta\to 0^-$. On the near side there is a single image, the minimum. Counting crossings of a source value y:

Source	N	Images
$y < y_{\rm in}$	2	minimum; far-side saddle outside r_2
$y_{\rm in} < y < y_{\rm out}$	4	minimum; saddle; **central maximum**; saddle next to the black hole
$y > y_{\rm out}$	2	minimum; saddle next to the black hole

The census is verified on source grids in checks H.10–H.13, with $n_+ - n_- = 0$ throughout. The central maximum survives only in the middle band, and next to it the black hole has created a second faint image, a saddle close to the puncture, visible in the middle column of Figure 20.1. This matches the picture of Mao et al. [27] as summarised in Sect. 6.2.2 of Congdon and Keeton [16]: above a threshold black-hole mass an NIS cannot form a central image at all; below it the central image may become unobservably faint, or a second central image may form.

A small black hole already matters. For $\theta_\bullet \to 0$ the inner critical circle sits where $(\kappa_0-1)\theta^2 \simeq \theta_\bullet^2$, and the inner caustic has radius

$$y_{\rm in} \simeq 2\,\theta_\bullet\sqrt{\kappa_0-1} \tag{20.20}$$

. It grows linearly in $\theta_\bullet$, i.e. as the square root of the black-hole mass, so even a small black hole removes the central image for every source closer to the axis than $y_{\rm in}$. For $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$ ($\kappa_0 = 5$), a point mass with $\theta_\bullet = 0.082\,\theta_{\rm E}$ already removes it for every source within $0.3\,\theta_{\rm E}$ of the axis.

20.5.3 The critical black-hole mass

As $\theta_\bullet$ grows, the dip of $h(s)+\theta_\bullet^2$ becomes shallower, the two critical circles approach each other, and at a critical mass they merge and disappear. Beyond it $\lambda_r > 0$ everywhere, $y(\theta)$ is monotonic on each side, and every source has exactly two images, a minimum and a saddle, with no maximum anywhere. The boundary is $\theta_\bullet^2 = -\min_s h(s)$. Setting $h'(s) = 2s - \theta_\mathrm{E}\theta_c^2/s^2 = 0$ gives $s_\star^3 = \theta_\mathrm{E}\theta_c^2/2$ (which lies at $\theta > 0$ exactly when the core is supercritical, $\theta_c < \theta_\mathrm{E}/2$; checks H.2–H.3), and $h(s_\star) = 3s_\star^2 - \theta_c^2 - \theta_\mathrm{E}\theta_c$, so

$$\boxed{\theta_{\bullet,\mathrm{crit}}^2 = \theta_c(\theta_\mathrm{E}+\theta_c) - 3\left(\frac{\theta_\mathrm{E}\theta_c^2}{2}\right)^{2/3}} \tag{20.21}$$

. It vanishes as $\theta_c \to \theta_\mathrm{E}/2$, where the NIS radial critical curve itself shrinks to the centre, and tends to $\theta_\mathrm{E}\theta_c$ as $\theta_c/\theta_\mathrm{E} \to 0$. For $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$ it gives $\theta_{\bullet,\mathrm{crit}}^2 = 0.0223\,\theta_\mathrm{E}^2$ ($\theta_{\bullet,\mathrm{crit}} = 0.149\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$), and for $\theta_c = 0.2\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$, $0.0190\,\theta_\mathrm{E}^2$ ($0.138\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$). The closed form agrees with a direct numerical minimisation of $\theta^2\lambda_r$, and the minimum of λ_r changes sign across it.

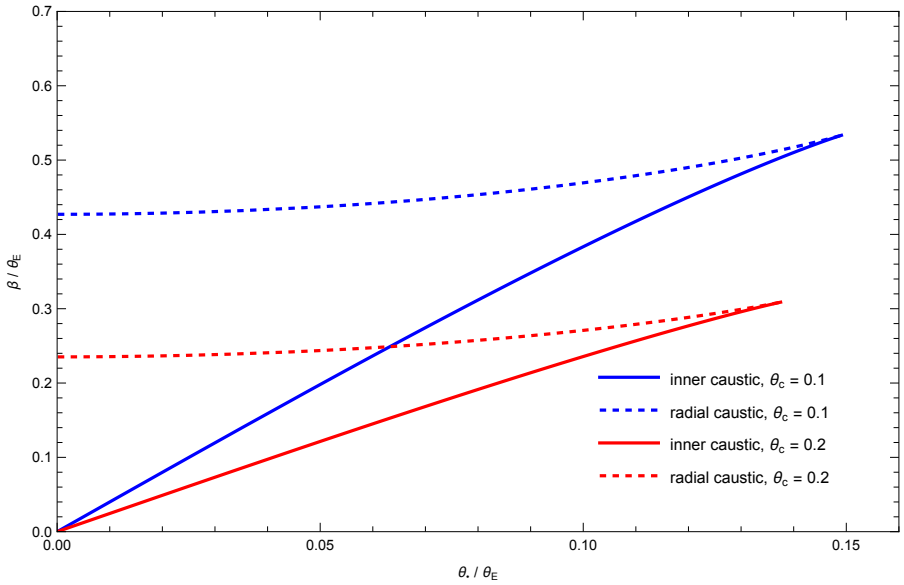


Figure 20.3: Where a central image can exist, for an NIS with a central point mass. For each black-hole Einstein radius $\theta_\bullet$ the central image exists only for sources between the inner caustic (solid; eq. 20.20 at small $\theta_\bullet$) and the radial caustic (dashed). The two curves meet and end at $\theta_{\bullet,\mathrm{crit}}$, eq. (20.21); above it no source has a central image. Blue: $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$; red: $\theta_c = 0.2\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$. Generated by `odd_images.wl`.

The annihilation boundary

A central point mass of Einstein radius $\theta_\bullet$ in a cored lens creates an inner critical circle around itself. As $\theta_\bullet$ grows, this circle and the lens's own radial critical circle approach, and at $\theta_\bullet = \theta_{\bullet,\mathrm{crit}}$ (eq. 20.21 for the NIS) they merge and annihilate. Below the boundary a source can have four images (minimum, saddle, central maximum,

black-hole saddle) or two; above it every source has exactly two (minimum and saddle), and the radial caustic, with every image associated with it, no longer exists. For any fixed source, the central maximum disappears earlier, by merging with the black-hole saddle when the inner caustic sweeps past the source.

20.6 A Degeneracy: Inner Slope versus Central Mass

Sections 20.3–20.5 identified three properties of the deflector that control the central image. A core rounds the summit of τ and makes a central image with $\mu_c \propto \theta_c^2$; a steep cusp sharpens the summit and suppresses the image as $\gamma' \to 2$, eq. (20.16); and a central point mass punctures the summit, creates an inner caustic of radius $\propto \theta_\bullet$, and above a critical mass removes the central image altogether. The last two act in the same direction. A faint or absent central image can be produced by a steep inner profile, by a black hole in a shallower profile, or by a combination; the central-image flux alone does not separate them. Congdon and Keeton [16, Sect. 6.2.2] make the same point: central images are demagnified by black holes, so a given central-image magnification is to some extent degenerate between black-hole mass and inner density profile.

The degeneracy also reaches the images that are seen. The radial critical curve, whose existence is decided by the same inner mass distribution, controls whether a radial arc or a radial image of an extended source can form. Chapter 21 quantifies how a black hole that is left out of the model biases the inferred lens parameters, and Chapter 22 turns to the mass-sheet degeneracy and to stellar kinematics, the independent constraint on the mass profile that is needed when lensing alone cannot fix it.

20.7 Summary

Images are the zeros of $\nabla\tau$; each carries index $\operatorname{sgn}\mu = \pm 1$. A maximum of τ requires $\kappa > 1 + |\gamma|$, so it can only sit near the centre of the lens. If the deflection is continuous and bounded (or, more generally, $|\boldsymbol{\alpha}|/\theta \to 0$ at infinity), the indices sum to the winding at infinity: $n_+ - n_- = 1$ and $N = 1 + 2n_-$ (Burke). What matters is continuity of $\boldsymbol{\alpha}$: a power-law cusp with $1 < \gamma' < 2$ has infinite central density and unbounded α at large θ, yet still obeys the theorem. A point mass violates continuity and boundedness of $\boldsymbol{\alpha}$ at one point. The puncture carries index $+1$, so $n_+ - n_- + g = 1$: one point mass makes the image count even. A bare point mass has $\lambda_r = 1 + \theta_\bullet^2/\theta^2 > 0$ everywhere and exactly two images.

The central image of an NIS is a maximum on the far side inside the radial critical curve, arrives last, and has $\mu_c = (1-\kappa_0)^{-2} \simeq 4\theta_c^2/\theta_{\rm E}^2$. Small cores make it many magnitudes fainter than the source, and it sits on the bright galaxy nucleus. Steepening a power-law cusp suppresses the central image as $\mu_c \propto (y/\theta_{\rm E})^{2(\gamma'-1)/(2-\gamma')}$, which vanishes as $\gamma' \to 2$. A central point mass in a cored lens creates an inner caustic of radius $\simeq 2\theta_\bullet\sqrt{\kappa_0 - 1}$ inside which the central image is destroyed, and above $\theta^2_{\bullet,\rm crit} = \theta_c(\theta_{\rm E} + \theta_c) - 3(\theta_{\rm E}\theta_c^2/2)^{2/3}$ it removes the radial critical curve and every central image. This is the annihilation boundary of Chapter 21. A steep cusp and a central black hole both suppress the central image: its flux constrains a

combination of the two.

20.8 Problems

Exercise 20.8.1 (Fermat gradient and Hessian)**.** For an arbitrary smooth potential $\psi(\theta_1, \theta_2)$:

(a) Show that $\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}\tau = 0$ is the lens equation.

(b) Show that $\nabla\nabla\tau = \mathcal{A}$, and that $\operatorname{tr}\mathcal{A} = 2(1-\kappa)$.

(c) Using eq. (20.2), show that the image type is fixed by the signs of $\det\mathcal{A}$ and $\operatorname{tr}\mathcal{A}$.

Exercise 20.8.2 (Five images of a cored elliptical lens)**.** Use eq. (20.7) to show that a source inside both the tangential and the radial caustic of a smooth cored elliptical lens, which sees four bright images, must have a fifth, and identify the type and parity of each. Then verify your answer numerically with the softened elliptical potential $\psi = \sqrt{s^2 + (1-e)\theta_1^2 + (1+e)\theta_2^2}$, $s = 0.25$, $e = 0.3$, and source $\boldsymbol{\beta} = (0.05, 0.03)$.

Exercise 20.8.3 (The NIS central image)**.** For the NIS, eq. (20.10):

(a) Show that $\lambda_t(0) = \lambda_r(0) = 1 - \kappa_0$, and hence that the centre is a maximum of τ if and only if $0 < \theta_c < \theta_{\mathrm{E}}/2$.

(b) Derive eq. (20.14) and its small-core limit.

(c) For a small source offset, show that the central image lies at $\theta \simeq -y/(\kappa_0 - 1)$. Evaluate for $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}$, $y = 0.01\,\theta_{\mathrm{E}}$.

(d) Show that as $\theta_c \to 0$ the deflection tends to the SIS value and the central image's magnification tends to zero.

Exercise 20.8.4 (Point masses change the parity of the count)**.** (a) Show that the winding number of $\nabla\tau$ around a small circle centred on a point mass is $+1$, whatever the source position.

(b) Deduce eq. (20.9) for g point masses embedded in a smooth lens, and show that each added point mass changes the parity of the image count, while $N + g$ stays odd.

(c) Check this against the NIS-plus-point-mass census of Section 20.5: compare the image counts with and without the black hole for the same source.

Exercise 20.8.5 (The tip of the SIS)**.** For the SIS, $\nabla\tau = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\beta} - \theta_{\mathrm{E}}\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$.

(a) Show that on a circle of radius $\epsilon \to 0$ around the origin the field winds once if $|\boldsymbol{\beta}| < \theta_{\mathrm{E}}$ and not at all if $|\boldsymbol{\beta}| > \theta_{\mathrm{E}}$.

(b) Combine with the SIS image parities to show that the sum of the image indices and the tip index equals 1 in both cases. Which circle in the source plane plays the role of a caustic?

Exercise 20.8.6 (The critical black-hole mass)**.** (a) Show that eq. (20.21) can be written exactly as $\theta^2_{\bullet,\mathrm{crit}} = \theta_\mathrm{E}\theta_c - 3\cdot 2^{-2/3}\theta_\mathrm{E}^{2/3}\theta_c^{4/3} + \theta_c^2$, and that $\theta^2_{\bullet,\mathrm{crit}}/(\theta_\mathrm{E}\theta_c) \to 1$ as $\theta_c/\theta_\mathrm{E} \to 0$.

(b) Evaluate $\theta_{\bullet,\mathrm{crit}}$ for $\theta_c = 0.05\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$.

(c) The black hole's mass relative to the NIS mass inside θ_E is $m = \theta^2_\bullet/[\theta_\mathrm{E}\,\alpha(\theta_\mathrm{E})]$. Evaluate the critical m for $\theta_c = 0.1\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$.

Exercise 20.8.7 (A shallow cusp)**.** For the power-law lens, eq. (20.15), with $\gamma' = 1.5$:

(a) Solve the far-side lens equation exactly (substitute $x = w^2$) and show that a source at $y < \theta_\mathrm{E}/4$ has three images.

(b) Compute the exact central-image magnification at $y = 0.1\,\theta_\mathrm{E}$ and compare with eq. (20.16).

(c) Repeat (b) numerically for $\gamma' = 1.8$ and comment.

Chapter 21

How an Unmodelled Central Mass Biases a Compound Lens

A compound lens, one deflector with two background sources at different redshifts, measures the distance ratio $\mathcal{B} = D_{ds_1} D_{s_2} / (D_{s_1} D_{ds_2})$ through the ratio of its two Einstein radii (Chapter 18). Because $\mathcal{B}$ depends on the expansion history but not on H_0, it can be used to constrain the dark-energy equation of state [13]. That depends on the lens model being right. If the deflector contains a mass component the model cannot represent, the fit makes up for it by shifting the parameters it does have, and the shift propagates into $\mathcal{B}$.

This chapter works through the simplest case. Massive galaxies generally host central supermassive black holes. A radial image, which is the observable that constrains the inner slope of a power-law model (Chapter 19), forms close to the centre, where a black hole's deflection is largest. The question is therefore how wrong the recovered $\mathcal{B}$ is when a power law plus a central point mass is fit with a power law alone.

We first define the Einstein radius unambiguously when a point mass is present (§21.2), and then show that the point mass is a different fractional perturbation on the two source planes, so that its effect does not cancel in the ratio (§21.3). The bias in $\mathcal{B}$ is then split into a ratio channel and a slope channel, and a fixed-slope estimate of the ratio channel is derived (§21.4). The general linear-response formula for the parameter bias is written down and tested against an exact power-law-only fit (§21.5), and the central mass at which the radial image disappears is derived in closed form (§21.6). Finally we separate the hidden and detected regimes (§21.7) and propagate the bias to the equation of state w (§21.8). All numbers in this chapter come from generic illustrative configurations; how large the bias is for a particular system is left to the Problems.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `central_mass_bias.wl`, which verifies the plane-scaling identities, the total-mass Einstein radius and its expansion, the two-channel decomposition, the closed-form annihilation boundary (against two independent numerical routes), and the linear-response bias against an exact power-law-only fit; exports the two figures of this chapter
- `problems_17.wl`, the worked solutions to the Problems

21.1 A Power Law with a Central Point Mass, Seen from Two Source Planes

Throughout, the deflector is axisymmetric, so the lens equation is one-dimensional (Chapter 11, eq. (11.2)). We use a *signed* image coordinate $\theta \in \mathbb{R}$, so that images on opposite sides of the centre have opposite signs. The signed source position is

$$y_i(\theta) = \theta - \alpha_i(\theta), \tag{21.1}$$

with α_i an odd function of θ. The index $i \in \{1, 2\}$ labels the near ($i = 1$) and far ($i = 2$) source planes. The deflector is a power law of three-dimensional slope γ' ($\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$) plus a central point mass. For $\theta > 0$,

$$\boxed{\alpha_i(\theta) = \underbrace{\left(\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(i)}\right)^{\gamma'-1}\theta^{\,2-\gamma'}}_{\alpha_{\mathrm{PL},i}} + \underbrace{\frac{\left(\theta_{\bullet}^{(i)}\right)^2}{\theta}}_{\alpha_{\bullet,i}}} \tag{21.2}$$

Here $\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(i)}$ is the *normalisation of the power law* on plane i, the ring radius the power law would have on its own, and $\theta_{\bullet}^{(i)}$ is the point mass's own Einstein radius (eq. (8.16)). The power-law term follows from the convergence $\kappa(\theta) = \frac{3-\gamma'}{2}(\theta_{\mathrm{E}}/\theta)^{\gamma'-1}$ through the mean-convergence relation $\alpha = \bar{\kappa}\,\theta$ (eq. (11.6)). The projection of $\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$ to $\kappa \propto \theta^{1-\gamma'}$ is Exercise 13.12.4.

GR reminder — Why both terms scale the same way between planes

In the weak-field metric, the physical deflection of a ray is set by the deflector's potential along the line of sight (Chapter 6). It does not depend on where the ray started. The source distance enters only when the physical deflection $\hat{\alpha}$ is converted to the reduced deflection, $\alpha = (D_{\mathrm{ds}}/D_{\mathrm{s}})\,\hat{\alpha}$ (Chapter 8). A power law and a black hole in the same deflector therefore pick up the same factor $D_{\mathrm{ds}}/D_{\mathrm{s}}$ on each source plane, whatever their mass profiles.

Define the distance ratio

$$\mathcal{B} \equiv \frac{D_{ds_1}\,D_{\mathrm{s}_2}}{D_{\mathrm{s}_1}\,D_{ds_2}} = \frac{D_{ds_1}/D_{\mathrm{s}_1}}{D_{ds_2}/D_{\mathrm{s}_2}} \;<\; 1. \tag{21.3}$$

It is below unity because the far source has the larger distance factor $D_{\mathrm{ds}}/D_{\mathrm{s}}$, which at fixed z_{d} is proportional to the lensing efficiency of §7.16. The aside then gives

$$\alpha_2(\theta) = \frac{\alpha_1(\theta)}{\mathcal{B}} \quad\Longleftrightarrow\quad \left(\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(2)}\right)^{\gamma'-1} = \frac{\left(\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(1)}\right)^{\gamma'-1}}{\mathcal{B}}, \qquad \left(\theta_{\bullet}^{(2)}\right)^2 = \frac{\left(\theta_{\bullet}^{(1)}\right)^2}{\mathcal{B}}. \tag{21.4}$$

Solving the first relation for the power-law normalisations,

$$\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(2)} = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(1)}\,\mathcal{B}^{-1/(\gamma'-1)}, \qquad \eta \equiv \frac{\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(1)}}{\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(2)}} = \mathcal{B}^{1/(\gamma'-1)} \quad\Longleftrightarrow\quad \boxed{\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\,\gamma'-1}} \tag{21.5}$$

This is the compound-lens identity of Chapter 18, specialised to a power law: the ratio of Einstein radii, raised to the slope-dependent power $\gamma' - 1$, gives the cosmological observable. For an isothermal deflector ($\gamma' = 2$) it reduces to $\mathcal{B} = \eta$. For $\mathcal{B} < 1$ and $\gamma' > 1$ we have $\eta < 1$, so $\ln \eta < 0$, which matters in §21.4.

We make two simplifications. First, the near source is treated as massless. In reality it also deflects the light of the far source; the multi-plane treatment is the subject of Chapter 18. Second, axisymmetry isolates the mechanism. Ellipticity and external shear add parameters, but the effect comes from the radial profile of the deflection.

21.2 What "the Einstein Radius" Means When a Central Mass Is Present

With a point mass present, "the Einstein radius" could mean two different numbers: the power-law normalisation $\theta_{\rm E}^{(i)}$, or the radius of the ring the full lens actually forms. We measure the central mass on plane i by the dimensionless fraction

$$m_i \equiv \frac{\left(\theta_\bullet^{(i)}\right)^2}{\left(\theta_{\rm E}^{(i)}\right)^2}. \tag{21.6}$$

The projected mass inside radius θ is $\pi \Sigma_{\rm cr} D_{\rm d}^2 \theta^2 \bar{\kappa}(\theta)$ (Chapter 11), and the power law alone has $\bar{\kappa}(\theta_{\rm E}) = 1$. So m_i is the black-hole mass divided by the power-law mass inside the power-law Einstein radius.

Convention: the total-mass Einstein radius

The physical Einstein radius on plane i is the positive solution $\theta_{\rm E,tot}^{(i)}$ of

$$\theta = \alpha_{{\rm PL},i}(\theta) + \alpha_{\bullet,i}(\theta), \tag{21.7}$$

that is, the ring radius of the full lens, inside which the mean convergence of power law plus point mass equals one. The true Einstein-radius ratio $\eta_{\rm true}$ is formed from these total-mass radii. The bias that propagates to cosmology is measured by

$$\frac{\delta \mathcal{B}}{\mathcal{B}} \equiv \frac{\eta_{\rm fit}^{\gamma'_{\rm fit}-1}}{\mathcal{B}_{\rm true}} - 1, \tag{21.8}$$

where $\eta_{\rm fit}$ and $\gamma'_{\rm fit}$ come from a power-law-only fit and $\mathcal{B}_{\rm true}$ is the true distance ratio. Eq. (21.8) folds the error in the ratio and the error in the slope into one number.

The total-mass radius is the appropriate definition because a ring, or a pair of images close to it, measures the mass enclosed by the ring. By eq. (11.6), $\theta = \alpha(\theta)$ is the same statement as $\bar{\kappa}(\theta) = 1$, whatever the profile inside. A power-law-only fit to images near the ring will therefore return a normalisation close to $\theta_{\rm E,tot}$, not the true power-law normalisation $\theta_{\rm E}$. The total-mass radius is what an observer with no model in mind would call the Einstein radius.

To see how far apart the two radii are, divide eq. (21.7) by $\theta^{2-\gamma'}$ and work in units of $\theta_{\rm E}$:

$$\left(\frac{\theta}{\theta_{\rm E}}\right)^{\gamma'-1} = 1 + m\left(\frac{\theta}{\theta_{\rm E}}\right)^{\gamma'-3} \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \boxed{\frac{\theta_{\rm E,tot}}{\theta_{\rm E}} = 1 + \frac{m}{\gamma'-1} + \frac{\gamma'-4}{2(\gamma'-1)^2}\,m^2 + \mathcal{O}(m^3)} \tag{21.9}$$

For $\gamma' = 1.9$ and $m = 0.01$, the exact root of eq. (21.7) is $\theta_{\rm E,tot} = 1.010984\,\theta_{\rm E}$, against $1.011111\,\theta_{\rm E}$ from the first-order term. The point mass enlarges the ring by about 1%. For comparison, changing w by 0.3 changes $\mathcal{B}$ by only about 1% (§21.8).

21.3 The Central Mass Is a Different Perturbation on Each Plane

The black hole and the power law scale the same way between planes (eq. (21.4)), so one might expect the black hole to drop out of the ratio. It does not, because the two Einstein radii scale with different powers of $\mathcal{B}$. From eqs. (21.4)–(21.5),

$$m_2 = \frac{\left(\theta_\bullet^{(1)}\right)^2/\mathcal{B}}{\left(\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}\right)^2\mathcal{B}^{-2/(\gamma'-1)}} = m_1\,\mathcal{B}^{-1+2/(\gamma'-1)} \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \boxed{m_2 = m_1\,\mathcal{B}^{(3-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)} < m_1} \tag{21.10}$$

The inequality holds for all $0 < \mathcal{B} < 1$ and $1 < \gamma' < 3$, where the exponent is positive. The black hole is a smaller fractional perturbation on the far plane. For $\mathcal{B} = 0.8$, $m_2/m_1 = 0.594$ at $\gamma' = 1.6$ and 0.761 at $\gamma' = 1.9$.

The bias is differential

By eq. (21.9), the black hole moves each total-mass Einstein radius outward by the fraction $m_i/(\gamma'-1)$. Since $m_1 > m_2$, the near ring moves further than the far one, and the ratio η changes. For the total-mass radii, equal fractional perturbations ($m_2 = m_1$) would leave η unchanged. A fit does not return the total-mass radii, though. The two planes have different image configurations (here only the far plane has a radial image), so they respond differently even to the same fractional perturbation. In the worked example of §21.5.1 at $m_1 = 10^{-4}$, forcing $m_2 = m_1$ makes the fitted bias 1.87 times larger, not zero.

There is a second reason the black hole matters more than its mass fraction suggests. The radial critical curve of the pure power law lies where the radial eigenvalue $\lambda_r = 1 - \frac{{\rm d}\alpha}{{\rm d}\theta}$ vanishes. (This is the eigenvalue $\lambda_+ = 1 - \kappa + |\gamma|$ of eq. (9.17), written for an axisymmetric lens.) For the power law $\lambda_r = 1 - (2-\gamma')(\theta_{\rm E}/\theta)^{\gamma'-1}$, so

$$\theta_r = \theta_{\rm E}\,(2-\gamma')^{1/(\gamma'-1)}. \tag{21.11}$$

At $\gamma' = 1.9$, $\theta_r = 0.077\,\theta_{\rm E}$. A black hole with $m = 0.01$ has $\theta_\bullet = \sqrt{m}\,\theta_{\rm E} = 0.1\,\theta_{\rm E}$, which is larger than θ_r. A 1% perturbation in mass is a perturbation of order unity in deflection at the place where the radial image forms. (For $\gamma' = 1.6$, $\theta_r = 0.217\,\theta_{\rm E}$.)

21.4 Two Channels for the Bias in $\mathcal{B}$

A power-law-only fit returns some $\eta_{\rm fit}$ and $\gamma'_{\rm fit}$, from which the observer computes $\mathcal{B}_{\rm fit} = \eta_{\rm fit}^{\gamma'_{\rm fit}-1}$. Take the logarithm of eq. (21.5) and form its total differential with respect to the two fitted quantities:

$$\ln \mathcal{B} = (\gamma' - 1)\ln\eta \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \boxed{\frac{\delta\mathcal{B}}{\mathcal{B}} = \underbrace{(\gamma'-1)\,\frac{\delta\eta}{\eta}}_{\text{ratio channel}} + \underbrace{\ln\eta\;\delta\gamma'}_{\text{slope-drag channel}}} \tag{21.12}$$

The two terms have different physical origins. The first, $(\gamma'-1)\,\delta\eta/\eta$, is the *ratio channel*: the black hole moves the two Einstein radii by different fractions (§21.3), so the ratio itself changes. Since the near ring moves out more, this channel tends to increase η and therefore $\mathcal{B}$. The second, $\ln\eta\,\delta\gamma'$, is the *slope-drag channel*. The fitted slope is set mainly by the radial image (Chapter 19), which forms where the black hole's deflection is comparable to the power law's. With the black hole missing from the model, the fit accounts for the extra central deflection by changing γ'. The map $\eta \mapsto \mathcal{B}$ depends on the slope, so that error passes straight into $\mathcal{B}$. Because $\ln\eta < 0$, a steeper fitted slope ($\delta\gamma' > 0$) lowers $\mathcal{B}$. The two channels can have opposite signs. Which one wins depends on the configuration, in particular on how far η is from unity: the slope channel carries the factor $\ln\eta$, which vanishes when the two planes coincide (Exercise 21.10.1).

21.4.1 A fixed-slope, on-ring estimate

Suppose the slope is known, for example from independent information, so that only the ratio channel acts. Suppose also that the images lie close enough to the rings for the fit to return the total-mass radii. Applying eq. (21.9) on each plane then gives

$$\left.\frac{\delta\eta}{\eta}\right|_{\gamma'\ \text{fixed}} \simeq \frac{1+m_1/(\gamma'-1)}{1+m_2/(\gamma'-1)} - 1 \simeq \frac{m_1-m_2}{\gamma'-1} = \frac{m_1\big(1-\mathcal{B}^{(3-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)}\big)}{\gamma'-1}, \tag{21.13}$$

and so $\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}|_{\gamma'\ \text{fixed}} \simeq m_1\big(1-\mathcal{B}^{(3-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)}\big)$. For the illustrative values $\gamma' = 1.9$, $m_1 = 0.01$, $\mathcal{B} = 0.8$:

$$\frac{\delta\eta}{\eta} \simeq 2.65\times10^{-3}, \qquad \left.\frac{\delta\mathcal{B}}{\mathcal{B}}\right|_{\gamma'\ \text{fixed}} \simeq 2.39\times10^{-3}.$$

Solving eq. (21.7) exactly on both planes gives $\delta\eta/\eta = 2.58\times10^{-3}$ for the total-mass radii, so here the linearisation in m is accurate to 3%.

Limits of the fixed-slope estimate

Eq. (21.13) gives the ratio channel for images on the rings. It does not predict the bias of a real fit, and need not even give its order of magnitude, for three reasons. First, it contains only the ratio channel; when the slope is free and constrained by a radial image, the slope-drag channel can be larger and of opposite sign (§21.5). Second, it assumes the fit recovers the total-mass radii, which is exactly true only for images on the ring.

For the lens of the worked example in §21.5.1, a fixed-slope fit to the tangential image pairs agrees with eq. (21.13) to 0.3% when each source is 0.02 of its plane's $\theta_{\rm E}$ off axis. The disagreement grows steadily with the offset and reaches a factor of 1.75 at $0.3\,\theta_{\rm E}$. When the two sources sit at different fractional offsets, the per-plane shifts can nearly cancel: at the offsets of the worked example (0.15 and 0.3), a fixed-slope fit returns only 0.084 of eq. (21.13). Third, it is first order in m; near the annihilation boundary of §21.6 the response is strongly nonlinear. A systematic treatment of first-order estimators and their range of validity is the subject of Chapter 25.

21.5 Linear Response: the Bias of a Fit That Cannot Represent the Truth

The general tool for working out what a misspecified model does is linear response. Collect the observed image positions in a vector $\mathbf{o}$, and all the parameters of the power-law-only model, including the unobserved source positions, in $\mathbf{p}$. For our axisymmetric compound lens the data vector is $\mathbf{o} = (\theta_{A1}, \theta_{B1}, \theta_{A2}, \theta_{B2}, \theta_{R2})$, the main image and counter-image on each plane together with the radial image on the far plane, and the parameter vector is $\mathbf{p} = (\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}, \theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}, \gamma', y_1, y_2)$. The central image produced by the black hole is assumed too faint to detect (§21.7).

Expand the true image positions to first order in the near-plane mass fraction:

$$\mathbf{o}(m_1) = \mathbf{o}(0) + \mathbf{s}\, m_1 + \mathcal{O}\big(m_1^2\big)\,, \qquad \mathbf{s} \equiv \left.\frac{\partial \mathbf{o}}{\partial m_1}\right|_{m_1=0}. \tag{21.14}$$

The vector $\mathbf{s}$ is the response of each image to the black hole with all other parameters held fixed. The power-law-only model predicts $\mathbf{o}_{\rm PL}(\mathbf{p})$, and the fit chooses $\mathbf{p}_0 + \delta\mathbf{p}$ so that $\mathbf{o}_{\rm PL}(\mathbf{p}_0 + \delta\mathbf{p}) = \mathbf{o}(m_1)$. Since $\mathbf{o}_{\rm PL}(\mathbf{p}_0) = \mathbf{o}(0)$, linearising both sides gives

$$\boxed{\delta\mathbf{p} = \mathsf{J}^{-1}\,\mathbf{s}\; m_1 + \mathcal{O}\big(m_1^2\big)\,, \qquad \mathsf{J} \equiv \left.\frac{\partial \mathbf{o}_{\rm PL}}{\partial \mathbf{p}}\right|_{\mathbf{p}_0}} \tag{21.15}$$

The parameter bias is thus the inverse of the model's Jacobian applied to the part of the signal the model cannot produce. Putting the $(\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}, \theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}, \gamma')$ components of $\delta\mathbf{p}$ into eq. (21.12) gives $\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}$ to first order.

Counting constraints. The power-law-only model has five parameters, and there are five observed positions. The fit is therefore *exactly determined*: whatever the true lens, a power law reproduces the data perfectly, as long as a solution exists. The residuals carry no information about the missing black hole. This is the sense in which the bias is *hidden*. More images, or extended arcs, make the problem overdetermined. Whether the residuals then reveal the missing mass depends on how well a change of slope can mimic the extra $1/\theta$ deflection over the radial range the data cover.

21.5.1 Worked example: exact fit versus linear response

Take $\gamma' = 1.6$, $\mathcal{B} = 0.8$, and units $\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)} = 1$. Put the sources at $y_1 = 0.15\,\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}$ and $y_2 = 0.3\,\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}$. Generate the five image positions with the black hole included. Then find the power law that reproduces them by minimising the source-plane mismatch

$$\chi^2(\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}, \theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}, \gamma') = \big[y_{\rm PL}(\theta_{A1}) - y_{\rm PL}(\theta_{B1})\big]^2 + \big[y_{\rm PL}(\theta_{A2}) - y_{\rm PL}(\theta_{B2})\big]^2 + \big[y_{\rm PL}(\theta_{A2}) - y_{\rm PL}(\theta_{R2})\big]^2$$

with `FindMinimum`. In every case the minimum is zero to working precision, as the counting argument requires. Table 21.1 compares the result with eq. (21.15).

Table 21.1: Exact power-law-only fit versus linear response for $\gamma' = 1.6$, $\mathcal{B} = 0.8$, $y_1 = 0.15\,\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}$, $y_2 = 0.3\,\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}$. The linear-response coefficients are $\frac{{\rm d}(\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B})}{{\rm d}m_1} = -4.26$ (ratio channel $+1.53$, slope channel -5.79) and $\frac{{\rm d}\gamma'}{{\rm d}m_1} = +15.6$.

m_1	10^{-4}	3×10^{-4}	10^{-3}	3×10^{-3}
$\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}$ (exact fit)	-0.043%	-0.130%	-0.449%	-1.59%
$\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}$ (linear)	-0.043%	-0.128%	-0.426%	-1.28%
$\delta\gamma'$ (exact fit)	0.0016	0.0048	0.0166	0.0600

The table shows, first, that the formula is right to the order claimed. At $m_1 = 10^{-4}$ the exact and linear biases agree to 0.5%. The difference grows as m_1^2: tripling m_1 multiplies it by about nine. The coefficient $\mathsf{J}^{-1}\mathbf{s}$ also agrees with a finite-difference derivative of the exact fit to better than one part in 10^5.

Second, in this configuration the fitted slope steepens ($\delta\gamma' > 0$). The ratio channel is positive, as §21.4.1 anticipated. The slope channel is negative and nearly four times larger, so it sets the sign: $\mathcal{B}$ is biased low. The two channels add up exactly to the linear total.

Third, the bias depends on the image geometry, not only on m_1. Moving the far source to $y_2 = 0.2\,\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}$ changes the coefficient from -4.26 to -17.8. Nothing in the lens has changed; the radial image has moved closer to the centre, where the black hole's deflection is relatively larger.

Fourth, the bias is much larger than the fixed-slope estimate. Eq. (21.13) gives $\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B} = +0.041\%$ at $m_1 = 10^{-3}$: the opposite sign, and an order of magnitude smaller than the exact -0.449%. What makes the black hole dangerous is a free slope constrained by a radial image.

21.6 When the Central Mass Destroys the Radial Image

The radial image exists only while the far plane still has a radial critical curve, that is, while $\lambda_r = y'(\theta) = 0$ has a positive root. Work in units of that plane's power-law Einstein radius

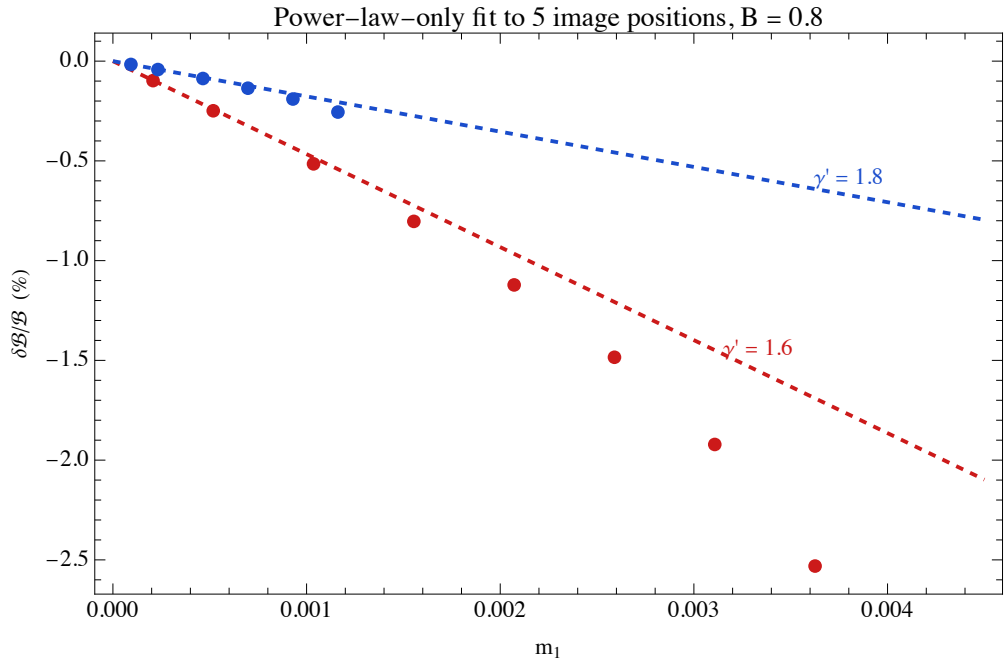


Figure 21.1: Bias in $\mathcal{B}$ from a power-law-only fit to five image positions generated with a central point mass, for $\mathcal{B} = 0.8$ and two slopes. Points: exact fit (zero residual). Dashed: linear response, eq. (21.15). The far source is at 0.9 times the radius of the power law's radial caustic ($y_2 = 0.293\,\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}$ for $\gamma' = 1.6$ and $0.481\,\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}$ for $\gamma' = 1.8$), giving linear coefficients -4.66 and -1.77. The points run from 2% of the annihilation value $m_{1,\rm crit}$ (§21.6) to 0.35 ($\gamma' = 1.6$) and 0.25 ($\gamma' = 1.8$) of it, just below the masses at which this source loses its radial image (0.38 and $0.29\,m_{1,\rm crit}$). At the last $\gamma' = 1.6$ point the exact bias exceeds the linear one by 50%; at the last $\gamma' = 1.8$ point, by 24%. Generated by `central_mass_bias.wl`.

($\theta_{\rm E} = 1$) and write $u \equiv m$ for its central mass fraction. For $\theta > 0$,

$$y(\theta) = \theta - \theta^{2-\gamma'} - \frac{u}{\theta},$$
$$y'(\theta) = 1 - (2-\gamma')\,\theta^{1-\gamma'} + \frac{u}{\theta^2}, \tag{21.16}$$
$$y''(\theta) = (2-\gamma')(\gamma'-1)\,\theta^{-\gamma'} - \frac{2u}{\theta^3}. \tag{21.17}$$

Without the black hole ($u = 0$), $y' \to -\infty$ as $\theta \to 0$ and $y' \to 1$ at large θ, so y' vanishes at θ_r (eq. (21.11)). With $u > 0$ the term u/θ^2 dominates at small θ and sends $y' \to +\infty$. Now y' is positive at both ends and dips in between. For small u the dip goes below zero and y' has two zeros: the (shifted) radial critical curve, and an inner radial critical curve. A point mass alone has none ($\lambda_r = 1 + u/\theta^2 > 0$); the black hole creates the inner curve by cutting off the power law's $\lambda_r < 0$ region from inside. As u grows the dip rises. At a critical value $u_{\rm crit}$ its minimum just touches zero; the two critical curves merge and disappear. Beyond that, $y' > 0$ everywhere, and there is no radial critical curve, no radial caustic and no radial image.

The boundary is therefore a *double root*, a point where both λ_r and its derivative vanish:

$$y'(\theta_\star) = 0 \qquad \text{and} \qquad y''(\theta_\star) = 0. \tag{21.18}$$

Multiplying eq. (21.17) by θ^3 shows that $y''=0$ is linear in $\theta^{3-\gamma'}$:

$$\theta_\star^{3-\gamma'} = \frac{2u}{(2-\gamma')(\gamma'-1)}. \tag{21.19}$$

Now substitute $u = \frac{1}{2}(2-\gamma')(\gamma'-1)\theta_\star^{3-\gamma'}$ into $y'(\theta_\star)=0$. The term $u/\theta_\star^2$ becomes $\frac{1}{2}(2-\gamma')(\gamma'-1)\theta_\star^{1-\gamma'}$, the same power of $\theta_\star$ as the middle term, and the two combine:

$$1-(2-\gamma')\Big[1-\frac{\gamma'-1}{2}\Big]\theta_\star^{1-\gamma'}=0 \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \boxed{\theta_\star = \left[\frac{(2-\gamma')(3-\gamma')}{2}\right]^{1/(\gamma'-1)}} \tag{21.20}$$

Then, from eq. (21.19),

$$\boxed{m_{\rm crit}(\gamma') = \frac{(2-\gamma')(\gamma'-1)}{2}\left[\frac{(2-\gamma')(3-\gamma')}{2}\right]^{(3-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)}} \tag{21.21}$$

This is the mass fraction on the plane where the radial image forms, measured against that plane's own $\theta_{\rm E}$. Converting to the near-plane fraction with eq. (21.10),

$$m_{1,\rm crit}(\gamma',\mathcal{B}) = m_{\rm crit}(\gamma')\,\mathcal{B}^{(\gamma'-3)/(\gamma'-1)}. \tag{21.22}$$

Table 21.2: Annihilation boundary of the radial image. $\theta_\star$ and $m_{\rm crit}$ refer to the radial-image plane, in units of its $\theta_{\rm E}$; $m_{1,\rm crit}$ is the corresponding near-plane fraction for $\mathcal{B}=0.8$.

γ'	1.4	1.5	1.6	1.7	1.8	1.9
$\theta_\star/\theta_{\rm E}$	0.160	0.141	0.120	0.097	0.071	0.040
$m_{\rm crit}$	0.00637	0.00659	0.00615	0.00504	0.00333	0.00130
$m_{1,\rm crit}(\mathcal{B}=0.8)$	0.0156	0.0129	0.0104	0.0076	0.0046	0.0017

Table 21.2 and Figure 21.2 show the consequences. (At $\gamma'=3/2$ everything is rational: $\theta_\star = 9/64$ and $m_{\rm crit} = 27/4096$.) We have $m_{\rm crit}\to 0$ both as $\gamma'\to 2$ (an isothermal profile has no radial critical curve to destroy) and as $\gamma'\to 1$. In between it has a single maximum, $m_{\rm crit}=0.0066$ at $\gamma'\approx 1.48$. For an axisymmetric lens, therefore, no slope tolerates a central mass above 0.66% of the power-law mass inside $\theta_{\rm E}$ on the radial-image plane. External shear raises the boundary. Along the axis of a shear $\gamma_{\rm e}$ on the radial-image plane, $\lambda_r = 1-\gamma_{\rm e}-\frac{{\rm d}\alpha}{{\rm d}\theta}$, and rescaling θ maps this onto the axisymmetric problem with $m_{\rm crit}$ multiplied by $(1-\gamma_{\rm e})^{-(3-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)}$, a factor 1.28 for $\gamma_{\rm e}=0.1$ at $\gamma'=1.6$.

Near-isothermal deflectors are fragile. At $\gamma'=1.9$ and $\mathcal{B}=0.8$, a near-plane fraction of only 0.0017 removes the far-plane radial image. The illustrative $m_1=0.01$ of §21.4.1 is far above the boundary: that lens has no radial image, the slope-drag channel has no radial image to act through, and only the ratio channel remains. Below the boundary y' has two zeros on $\theta>0$; above it, none.

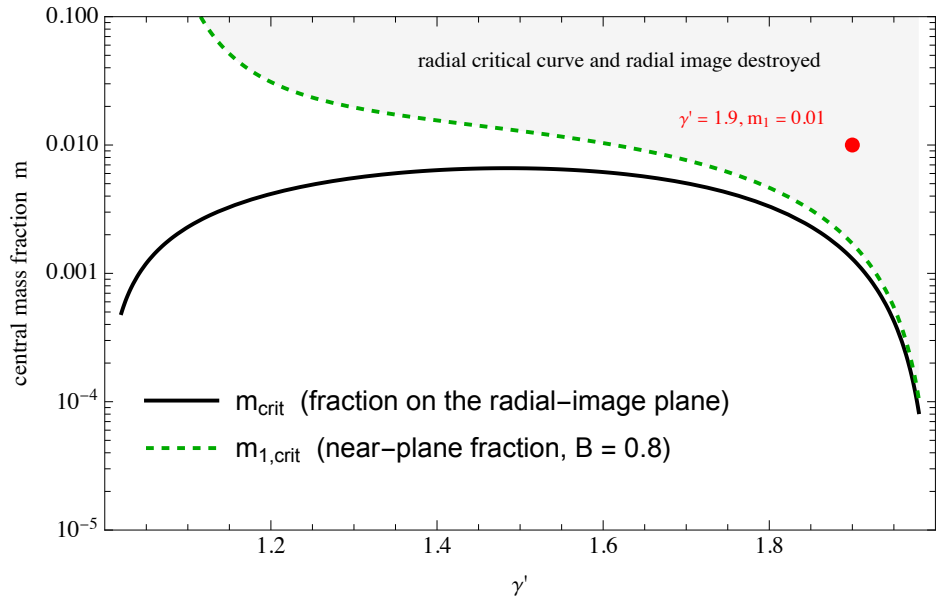


Figure 21.2: Annihilation boundary of the radial image in the (γ', m) plane. Solid: $m_{\rm crit}(\gamma')$, eq. (21.21), the fraction on the radial-image plane. Dashed: the near-plane fraction $m_{1,\rm crit}$ for $\mathcal{B} = 0.8$, eq. (21.22); above it (shaded) the far plane has no radial critical curve. The dot marks the illustrative lens of §21.4.1 ($\gamma' = 1.9$, $m_1 = 0.01$). Generated by `central_mass_bias.wl`.

Remark 21.6.1 (Two edges of the same effect). The influence of central black holes on the central images of galaxy lenses was studied by Mao et al. [27]. For compound-lens cosmography the effect cuts both ways. It limits which systems can show a radial image at all: at fixed near-plane fraction and $\mathcal{B}$, the dashed curve of Figure 21.2 favours shallower inner slopes. A system whose radial image is observed, on the other hand, lies below the boundary, possibly close to it, where Figure 21.1 shows the bias growing faster than linearly.

21.7 Hidden and Detected Central Masses

Besides moving the radial image, the point mass produces its own faint image very close to the centre (Chapter 20). How bright that image is decides which of two regimes the observer is in. In the *hidden regime* the central image is below the detection limit. The observer sees the tangential images and the radial image, fits a power law, gets a perfect fit (§21.5), and obtains a biased $\mathcal{B}$ with no warning. This is the regime that matters for cosmology. In the *detected regime* the black hole's own critical structure is large enough to produce detectable extra images. The observer is then forced to add a central mass to the model, and if that model is correct the bias disappears. This is one way a central black hole can be detected through lensing. A black hole that measurably deforms an existing image can also force a central mass into the model without any extra image; the Abell 1201 analysis of Nightingale et al. [31] is a case in point.

The point mass stands for any unmodelled central excess. Nothing in this chapter used the fact that the extra central mass is a black hole, only that the model leaves it out. Seen from outside its own radius, any axisymmetric central excess looks exactly like a point mass. (An off-centre excess also adds higher multipoles: a unit mass displaced by 0.1 from the centre deflects a ray at $\theta = 1$ by 11% more than a central one.) Take a deflector that follows the power law outside a radius θ_b and has a steeper inner slope $\gamma_{\rm in} > \gamma'$ inside it, joined continuously. For $\theta > \theta_b$ the deflection depends only on the enclosed mass, so

$$\alpha(\theta) = \alpha_{\rm PL}(\theta) + \frac{m_{\rm eff}\,\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\theta}, \qquad m_{\rm eff} = \frac{2}{\theta_{\rm E}^2}\int_0^{\theta_b} \big[\kappa_{\rm in}(\theta') - \kappa_{\rm PL}(\theta')\big]\theta'\,{\rm d}\theta', \tag{21.23}$$

exactly, and $m_{\rm eff} > 0$ for a steeper cusp (Exercise 21.10.7). A nuclear star cluster, a steepened stellar cusp and a black hole all bias a rigid power law in the same way, provided the images lie outside the region containing the excess. The converse is the practical lesson: a model with one extra degree of freedom in the inner profile can absorb such an excess. The bias derived in this chapter is the bias of a rigid power law, and its size measures how much that rigidity costs.

21.8 From a Bias in $\mathcal{B}$ to a Bias in w

A fractional error in $\mathcal{B}$ turns into an error in any cosmological parameter through the logarithmic sensitivity of $\mathcal{B}$ to that parameter. For a constant equation of state w,

$$\delta w = \frac{\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}}{S_w}, \qquad S_w \equiv \frac{\partial \ln \mathcal{B}}{\partial w}. \tag{21.24}$$

As an illustration, take a flat universe with $\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$, $w = -1$ and redshifts $(z_{\rm d}, z_{\rm s_1}, z_{\rm s_2}) = (0.5, 1, 2)$. The flat-universe expression from the bridge in §21.1 gives $\mathcal{B} = 0.674$ and $S_w = -0.033$. $\mathcal{B}$ responds only weakly to w, which is why sub-percent biases matter: a bias of $\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B} = -0.5\%$ becomes $\delta w = +0.15$. In this configuration $S_w < 0$, so a $\mathcal{B}$ biased low pushes w up (less negative). The full sensitivity analysis, including how it depends on the redshifts, is in Chapter 24.

A coherent systematic

The bias is not random from lens to lens. For a population of similar deflectors, each hosting a central black hole and observed in similar configurations, it tends to have the same sign, because every black hole adds positive central mass, although the size, and in some geometries the sign, of the slope response varies (§21.5.1). Averaging over N lenses reduces the statistical error as $N^{-1/2}$ but leaves the mean bias unchanged, so beyond a modest sample size the unmodelled central mass dominates the error budget (Exercise 21.10.4). It has to be modelled, or bounded with independent information on the inner mass; it cannot be averaged away.

21.9 Summary

A power law plus a central point mass deflects light on two source planes with the same distance factor, so $\alpha_2 = \alpha_1/\mathcal{B}$, $\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)} = \theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}\mathcal{B}^{-1/(\gamma'-1)}$ and $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$. With a central mass present, the Einstein radius is defined from the total enclosed mass, $\theta = \alpha_{\rm PL} + \alpha_\bullet$. At first order it exceeds the power-law normalisation by the fraction $m/(\gamma'-1)$, where $m = \theta_\bullet^2/\theta_{\rm E}^2$. On the far plane the black hole is a smaller fractional perturbation, $m_2 = m_1\mathcal{B}^{(3-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)}$, which is less than m_1. This asymmetry is one reason the bias does not cancel in the ratio; the other is that the two planes' images respond differently to the fit.

The bias splits as $\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B} = (\gamma'-1)\delta\eta/\eta + \ln\eta\,\delta\gamma'$. With the slope fixed and the images on the rings, the ratio channel gives $m_1(1-\mathcal{B}^{(3-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)})$; away from the rings a fixed-slope fit can differ from this by a large factor. With a free slope constrained by a radial image, the slope-drag channel can be larger and of the opposite sign. The linear-response formula $\delta\mathbf{p} = \mathsf{J}^{-1}\mathbf{s}\,m_1$ agrees with an exact power-law-only fit up to corrections of order m_1^2. The fit residual is zero, so the bias is hidden. The radial image disappears at the double root of λ_r, which has a closed form, $\theta_\star = [(2-\gamma')(3-\gamma')/2]^{1/(\gamma'-1)}$ and $m_{\rm crit} = \frac{1}{2}(2-\gamma')(\gamma'-1)\theta_\star^{3-\gamma'}$, never more than 0.0066. The bias propagates to w through $\delta w = (\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B})/S_w$. Its mean is coherent across a sample and does not average down.

21.10 Problems

Exercise 21.10.1. (The two channels.)

(a) Derive eq. (21.12) from $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$.

(b) Evaluate the two channels separately for $\gamma' = 1.6$, $\eta = 0.79$, $\delta\eta/\eta = +0.5\%$ and $\delta\gamma' = +0.03$. Which dominates, and what is the net $\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}$?

(c) Show that the slope channel vanishes as $\eta \to 1$, while the ratio channel at fixed fractional shift does not depend on η. At what η would the two channels of part (b) have equal magnitude?

Exercise 21.10.2. (The annihilation boundary.)

(a) Starting from eqs. (21.16)–(21.17), eliminate u between $y' = 0$ and $y'' = 0$ and derive eqs. (21.20) and (21.21).

(b) Evaluate $\theta_\star$ and $m_{\rm crit}$ at $\gamma' = 1.6$, and convert to the near-plane fraction for $\mathcal{B} = 0.8$.

(c) Find the slope at which $m_{\rm crit}$ is largest, and its value there. Interpret the result.

Exercise 21.10.3. (Why the ratio is biased.) Using eq. (21.10), show that the fixed-slope ratio shift $(m_1 - m_2)/(\gamma'-1)$ is strictly positive for $0 < \mathcal{B} < 1$ and $1 < \gamma' < 3$, and that it vanishes if and only if the black hole is equally important on both planes. Identify the two limits in which this happens and explain each physically.

Exercise 21.10.4. (A coherent systematic.)

(a) Show that if every lens in a sample of N has the same bias b in $\mathcal{B}$, the bias of the sample mean is b, independent of N, whereas a per-lens statistical error σ_1 averages down to $\sigma_1/\sqrt{N}$.

(b) Find the N beyond which the systematic dominates, for $\sigma_1 = 2\%$ and $b = 0.5\%$.

(c) Using the flat-universe expression from the bridge in §21.1, compute S_w for $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$, $w = -1$ and $(z_\mathrm{d}, z_{\mathrm{s}_1}, z_{\mathrm{s}_2}) = (0.5, 1, 2)$, and the δw produced by $b = -0.5\%$.

Exercise 21.10.5. (How large is it for a real lens?) A deflector has a projected mass of $2 \times 10^{11}\, M_\odot$ inside its near-plane Einstein radius and a central black hole of $10^9\, M_\odot$. Take $\mathcal{B} = 0.8$.

(a) Compute m_1.

(b) For $\gamma' = 1.6$ and for $\gamma' = 1.9$, decide whether the far plane can still have a radial image.

(c) For both slopes, evaluate the fixed-slope estimate eq. (21.13) for $\delta\eta/\eta$ and $\delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}$. For $\gamma' = 1.9$, convert the result to δw using the S_w of Exercise 21.10.4.

(d) Explain why, for $\gamma' = 1.6$, the linear coefficient of the worked example (§21.5.1) *cannot* simply be multiplied by m_1 to predict the bias of a real fit. List what you would need to know about the system to do better.

Exercise 21.10.6. (Isothermal sphere plus point mass.)

(a) For $\gamma' = 2$, solve eq. (21.7) in closed form and expand to $\mathcal{O}(m^2)$. Check the result against eq. (21.9).

(b) Show that an SIS plus a point mass never has a radial critical curve. What does this imply for the slope-drag channel in a near-isothermal lens?

(c) Evaluate $\theta_{\mathrm{E,tot}}/\theta_\mathrm{E}$ for $m = 0.01$.

Exercise 21.10.7. (A cusp is a point mass from outside.) A deflector follows the power law $\kappa_\mathrm{PL} = \frac{3-\gamma'}{2}\theta^{1-\gamma'}$ (units $\theta_\mathrm{E} = 1$) for $\theta > \theta_b$, and the steeper profile $\kappa_\mathrm{in} = \kappa_\mathrm{PL}(\theta_b)(\theta_b/\theta)^{\gamma_\mathrm{in}-1}$ for $\theta < \theta_b$.

(a) Show that for $\theta > \theta_b$ the deflection is exactly eq. (21.23), with $m_\mathrm{eff} = (3-\gamma')\,\theta_b^{3-\gamma'}\left[1/(3-\gamma_\mathrm{in}) - 1/(3-\gamma')\right]$.

(b) Let this deflector describe the far (radial-image) plane, in units of that plane's θ_E. Evaluate m_eff for $\gamma' = 1.9$, $\gamma_\mathrm{in} = 2.1$ and $\theta_b = 0.02$, and compare it with $m_\mathrm{crit}(1.9)$ of Table 21.2. Why does the comparison require $\theta_b < \theta_\star$?

(c) What does this imply for the statement that a central black hole "biases" a compound lens?

Chapter 22

The Mass-Sheet Degeneracy in Multi-Plane Lenses and Kinematic Breaking

Chapter 13 introduced the mass-sheet transformation (MST), $\kappa \to \lambda\kappa + (1-\lambda)$, proved that it leaves image positions and flux ratios untouched (§13.3), placed it inside the wider family of source-position transformations (§13.4), and showed that it propagates one-for-one into a time-delay Hubble constant (Eq. 13.15). Chapter 16 met the same transformation as the reason a shear map determines κ only up to a constant (§16.4). This chapter treats the two questions that matter once lenses have more than one source plane, and once one wants to do something about the degeneracy. The first is whether a second source plane behind the same deflector breaks the MST; it does so only if the distance ratio between the planes is known in advance, which in double-source-plane cosmography is exactly what one is trying to measure. The second is how a stellar velocity dispersion fixes λ, and which systematic errors it brings with it. Along the way we show that a change of the power-law slope γ' is, to first order near the Einstein radius, an MST in disguise. That "local MST" is the mechanism through which an unmodelled central mass biases both a time-delay H_0 and a double-source-plane distance ratio (Chapter 21).

Companion Mathematica files:

- `msd_multiplane.wl`, the symbolic verification of every result in this chapter: the single-plane MST (SIS and power law + sheet), the two-source-plane and two-lens-plane transformations, the local MST, and the spherical Jeans solution for a power-law lens; exports Fig. 22.1
- `problems_18.wl`, the worked solutions to the problems of §22.7

22.1 The Mass-Sheet Transformation in Three Lines

Let $\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ be any lens that reproduces a set of images. The MST (18; Eq. 13.8) replaces it by

$$\kappa_\lambda(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \lambda\,\kappa(\boldsymbol{\theta}) + (1-\lambda), \qquad \lambda \neq 0. \tag{22.1}$$

Three facts carry the whole argument. (i) The deflection is linear in κ, and a uniform sheet $\kappa = 1$ deflects as $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_{\rm sheet} = \boldsymbol{\theta}$ (for an axisymmetric distribution $\alpha = \bar{\kappa}\,\theta$, Eq. 11.6, and here $\bar{\kappa} = 1$). Hence

$$\boldsymbol{\alpha}_\lambda(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \lambda\,\boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) + (1-\lambda)\,\boldsymbol{\theta}. \tag{22.2}$$

(ii) Inserting this into the lens equation,

$$\boxed{\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}_\lambda(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \lambda\boldsymbol{\alpha} - (1-\lambda)\boldsymbol{\theta} = \lambda\left[\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}(\boldsymbol{\theta})\right] = \lambda\,\boldsymbol{\beta},} \tag{22.3}$$

so every $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ that solved the original lens equation for a source at $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ solves the transformed one for a source at $\lambda\boldsymbol{\beta}$. (iii) Differentiating Eq. (22.2) gives $\mathcal{A}_\lambda = \lambda\mathcal{A}$ (Eq. 13.12), and the Fermat potential (Eq. 10.2) transforms as

$$\tau_\lambda(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \tfrac{1}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta} - \lambda\boldsymbol{\beta}|^2 - \lambda\psi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) - \tfrac{1-\lambda}{2}|\boldsymbol{\theta}|^2 = \lambda\,\tau(\boldsymbol{\theta}) + \tfrac{\lambda(\lambda-1)}{2}|\boldsymbol{\beta}|^2. \tag{22.4}$$

The last term is the same for every image, so it cancels from any difference: $\Delta\tau_\lambda = \lambda\,\Delta\tau$.

What the MST preserves and what it changes

Under Eq. (22.1) with $\boldsymbol{\beta} \to \lambda\boldsymbol{\beta}$, the image positions, the image shapes ($\mathcal{A}_\lambda \propto \mathcal{A}$), the flux ratios, the critical curves (both eigenvalues $1 - \kappa \pm \gamma$ scale by λ, so their zeros stay put), the Einstein radius (where $\bar{\kappa}_\lambda = \lambda\bar{\kappa} + 1 - \lambda = 1$ iff $\bar{\kappa} = 1$) and the reduced shear are all unchanged. What changes are the absolute magnifications, $\mu \to \mu/\lambda^2$, the time delays, $\Delta t \to \lambda\,\Delta t$, hence $H_0^{\rm true} = \lambda\,H_0^{\rm naive}$ (Eq. 13.15), and the mass of the deflector itself.

22.1.1 Two explicit examples

Two explicit profiles show Eq. (22.3) at work. For an SIS (Chapter 11), on the axis through the source, $\alpha(\theta) = \theta_{\rm E}\,\mathrm{sgn}(\theta)$ and the images of a source at $0 < \beta < \theta_{\rm E}$ sit at $\theta_\pm = \beta \pm \theta_{\rm E}$. With a sheet, $\theta - \alpha_\lambda = \lambda(\theta - \theta_{\rm E}\,\mathrm{sgn}\,\theta)$, which equals $\lambda\beta$ at exactly the same $\theta_\pm$. For a power law (Eq. 13.19),

$$\kappa(\theta) = \frac{3-\gamma'}{2}\left(\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta}\right)^{\gamma'-1}, \qquad \alpha(\theta) = \theta_{\rm E}\,\mathrm{sgn}(\theta)\left(\frac{|\theta|}{\theta_{\rm E}}\right)^{2-\gamma'}, \tag{22.5}$$

the identity $\theta - \alpha_\lambda(\theta) - \lambda\beta = \lambda[\theta - \alpha(\theta) - \beta]$ holds for every θ, so the roots are shared; for $\gamma' = 2.2$ and $\beta = 0.2\,\theta_{\rm E}$ they are $\theta_A = 1.1692\,\theta_{\rm E}$ and $\theta_B = -0.8364\,\theta_{\rm E}$ for every λ. Figure 22.1 shows three such profiles and the shared roots.

22.2 What the Sheet Is: External, Internal, and the SPT

The parameter λ has two physically different readings, and different data break them. For an *external sheet*, line-of-sight structure adds a nearly uniform convergence $\kappa_{\rm ext}$ across the image region; it is an MST with $\lambda = 1 - \kappa_{\rm ext}$ (§13.10, Eq. 13.32). The deflector's own mass is untouched; the sheet is real matter elsewhere, estimated from galaxy counts and weak lensing

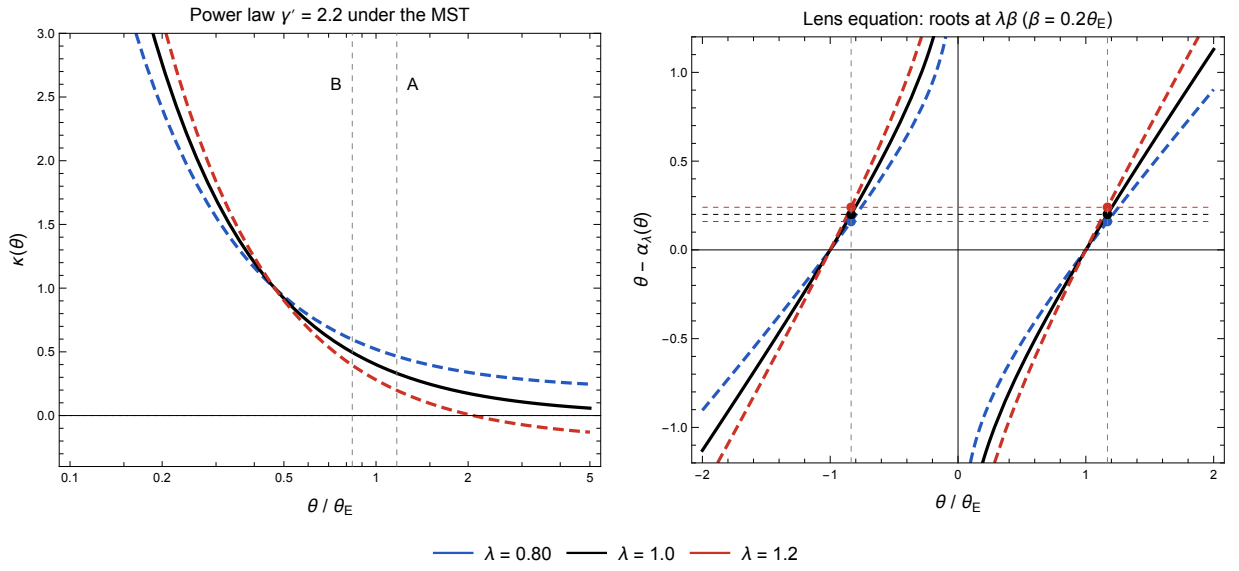


Figure 22.1: The MST of a power law with $\gamma' = 2.2$. **Left:** convergence for $\lambda = 0.8$ (positive sheet), 1, and 1.2 (negative sheet; this profile crosses $\kappa = 0$ near $2\,\theta_{\rm E}$). All three profiles cross where $\kappa = 1$ (the fixed point of $\kappa \to \lambda\kappa + 1 - \lambda$), not at $\theta_{\rm E}$. The dashed verticals mark the two images A and B of a source at $\beta = 0.2\,\theta_{\rm E}$; they are the same for all three profiles. **Right:** the lens map $\theta - \alpha_\lambda(\theta)$. Each curve meets its own source line $\lambda\beta$ (horizontal dashes) at the same two image positions. Generated by `msd_multiplane.wl`.

of the field rather than from the lens. For an *internal sheet* no extra matter exists; instead the deflector's own profile is $\lambda\kappa + (1-\lambda)\kappa_{\rm c}$, where $\kappa_{\rm c}$ is a very extended, cored component that is nearly constant over the image region. This is a re-profiling of the galaxy that imaging cannot see, and field counts cannot touch it. Schneider and Sluse [40] argue that the formal precision of time-delay H_0 rests on assuming that the profile is an exact power law, which suppresses exactly this freedom. The MST is itself the exactly-degenerate, profile-independent member of the *source-position transformations* (SPT; 41; §13.4), which remap the source plane non-linearly and keep the images invariant only approximately. Everything in this chapter concerns the exact, linear member.

22.3 One Deflector, Two Source Planes

Now place two sources behind the same deflector at redshift z_d: a nearer one (plane 1, z_{s1}) and a farther one (plane 2, $z_{s2} > z_{s1}$). For the moment the nearer source is massless, so a single plane deflects both. The deflector has one physical surface density $\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ but two convergences,

$$\kappa_i(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{\Sigma(\boldsymbol{\theta})}{\Sigma_{{\rm cr},i}}, \qquad \kappa_1 = \mathcal{B}\,\kappa_2, \qquad \mathcal{B} \equiv \frac{\Sigma_{\rm cr,2}}{\Sigma_{\rm cr,1}} = \frac{D_{ds1}\,D_{s2}}{D_{s1}\,D_{ds2}} < 1, \tag{22.6}$$

with $\Sigma_{{\rm cr},i} = c^2 D_{si}/(4\pi G D_{\rm d} D_{dsi})$ (Eq. 13.4). The ratio $\mathcal{B}$ depends only on redshifts and on the expansion history; measuring it is the point of double-source-plane (DSPL) cosmography

(Chapter 18; 13, 15). Its observable proxy is the ratio of the two Einstein radii,

$$\eta \equiv \frac{\theta_{\rm E1}}{\theta_{\rm E2}}, \qquad \mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1} \quad \text{(power law)}, \tag{22.7}$$

which follows from $\bar\kappa_2(\theta) = (\theta_{\rm E2}/\theta)^{\gamma'-1}$ and $\bar\kappa_1 = \mathcal{B}\,\bar\kappa_2 = 1$ at $\theta_{\rm E1}$. Throughout this chapter plane 1 is the nearer source, so that $\mathcal{B} < 1$ and $\eta < 1$; η always denotes the ratio of Einstein radii and $\mathcal{B}$ the distance ratio (papers that number the planes the other way quote $\mathcal{B}^{-1}$).

22.3.1 Known distances: the second plane breaks the MST

Suppose $\mathcal{B}$ is known. Is there still an MST? Transform the physical density as $\Sigma \to \lambda_m\Sigma + \Sigma_s$. Plane by plane, $\kappa_i \to \lambda_m\kappa_i + \Sigma_s/\Sigma_{{\rm cr},i}$, and this is an MST of plane i only if $\Sigma_s/\Sigma_{{\rm cr},i} = 1-\lambda_m$. Both conditions can hold only if $\lambda_m = 1$ and $\Sigma_s = 0$, because $\Sigma_{{\rm cr},1} \neq \Sigma_{{\rm cr},2}$. Concretely, apply an MST λ_2 to the far plane. The near plane then receives

$$\kappa_1' = \lambda_2\,\kappa_1 + \mathcal{B}\,(1-\lambda_2), \qquad \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}_1' = \big[1 - \mathcal{B}(1-\lambda_2)\big]\boldsymbol{\theta} - \lambda_2\boldsymbol{\alpha}_1, \tag{22.8}$$

which is not proportional to $\boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}_1$ unless $\lambda_2 = 1$: the near-plane images move. For the power law the near Einstein radius shifts to

$$\left(\frac{\theta_{\rm E1}'}{\theta_{\rm E1}}\right)^{\gamma'-1} = \frac{\lambda_2}{1-\mathcal{B}(1-\lambda_2)}, \tag{22.9}$$

so for $\gamma' = 2$, $\mathcal{B} = 0.7$, $\lambda_2 = 0.9$, η falls by 3.2%. This is the sense in which "multiple source planes break the MSD" (§13.3, item 3; 36, §3.7): the sheet is one physical object, and its convergence scales as $1/\Sigma_{{\rm cr},i}$, differently on each plane.

22.3.2 Free distance ratio: the second plane does not

In DSPL cosmography $\mathcal{B}$ is not known; it is the measurement. We therefore let the model carry its own ratio $\mathcal{B}'$ and ask whether a pair of per-plane MSTs (λ_1, λ_2) can reproduce both image sets. The far plane is transformed with λ_2, and the model's near-plane convergence is $\mathcal{B}'$ times the transformed far-plane one. Demanding that this be an exact MST of the true near plane, $\mathcal{B}'\big[\lambda_2\kappa_2 + 1 - \lambda_2\big] = \lambda_1\mathcal{B}\kappa_2 + (1-\lambda_1)$ for every κ_2, gives two linear conditions with the unique solution

$$\boxed{\mathcal{B}' = \frac{1}{1-\lambda_2+\lambda_2/\mathcal{B}}, \qquad \lambda_1 = \frac{\lambda_2}{\mathcal{B}(1-\lambda_2)+\lambda_2}, \qquad \frac{1-\lambda_1}{1-\lambda_2} = \mathcal{B}'.} \tag{22.10}$$

Three features of Eq. (22.10) carry the physics. First, the two planes carry different mass-sheet parameters: $\lambda_1 - \lambda_2 = \lambda_2(1-\lambda_2)(1-\mathcal{B})/[\mathcal{B}(1-\lambda_2)+\lambda_2]$, non-zero unless $\lambda_2 = 1$. Second, the two sheets are one physical sheet at the deflector: $(1-\lambda_1)/(1-\lambda_2) = \mathcal{B}'$ is exactly the ratio that a uniform Σ_s at z_d produces between the two planes, read through the model's distance ratio. The λ_i differ because the sheet sits physically at the lens plane. Third, each plane's Einstein radius is fixed by its own exact MST, so both $\theta_{{\rm E}i}$ and η are unchanged,

while the inferred distance ratio moves. For $\mathcal{B} = 0.7$, $\lambda_2 = 0.9$: $\mathcal{B}' = 70/97 = 0.7216$ and $\lambda_1 = 90/97 = 0.9278$. To first order,

$$\mathcal{B}' \simeq \mathcal{B}\left[1 + (1-\mathcal{B})(1-\lambda_2)\right], \tag{22.11}$$

so a positive sheet ($\lambda_2 < 1$) is mistaken for a larger distance ratio.

A second source plane trades λ for $\mathcal{B}$

For a single deflector with sources on two planes, a mass sheet at the lens redshift acts on each plane as an exact MST with its own λ_i, provided the distance ratio is allowed to change according to Eq. (22.10). All images on both planes and the Einstein-radius ratio η are invariant. If $\mathcal{B}$ is known (cosmology fixed), the second plane breaks the MST; if $\mathcal{B}$ is the target, the MST and the cosmology are degenerate, and an independent handle on λ is required.

22.3.3 How the MST reaches a power-law distance ratio

With a power-law model, $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$ contains no mass normalisation at all: $\partial\mathcal{B}/\partial\lambda = 0$ at fixed (η, γ'), whereas $\partial\mathcal{B}/\partial\gamma' = \mathcal{B}\ln\eta \neq 0$. Since η is invariant, a power-law fit can follow the shift $\mathcal{B} \to \mathcal{B}'$ of Eq. (22.10) only by changing its slope, $\gamma'' - 1 = (\gamma' - 1)\ln\mathcal{B}'/\ln\mathcal{B}$. For the DSPL ratio the MST is therefore demoted from a normalisation systematic (as it is for H_0) to a profile-shape systematic. Anything that drags the fitted γ' (a sheet, a core, a central point mass) moves $\mathcal{B}$ by $\delta\ln\mathcal{B} = \ln\eta\,\delta\gamma'$. Section 22.4 makes the link between "sheet" and "slope" precise.

22.3.4 When the nearer source has mass: two lens planes

In many DSPLs the first source is itself a galaxy massive enough to deflect light from the second. Schneider [38] showed that the MST survives this too. With $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ the image-plane position, $\mathcal{B}$ his β, and deflections scaled to the last plane, the lens equations are

$$\boldsymbol{\theta}_2 = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \mathcal{B}\,\boldsymbol{\alpha}_1(\boldsymbol{\theta}), \qquad \boldsymbol{\theta}_3 = \boldsymbol{\theta} - \boldsymbol{\alpha}_1(\boldsymbol{\theta}) - \boldsymbol{\alpha}_2(\boldsymbol{\theta}_2), \tag{22.12}$$

and the transformation

$$\boldsymbol{\alpha}_1' = \lambda\boldsymbol{\alpha}_1 + \frac{1-\lambda}{\mathcal{B}}\boldsymbol{\theta}, \qquad \boldsymbol{\alpha}_2'(\boldsymbol{\theta}_2') = \boldsymbol{\alpha}_2(\boldsymbol{\theta}_2'/\lambda) + \frac{\lambda-1}{\lambda\mathcal{B}}\,\boldsymbol{\theta}_2' \tag{22.13}$$

gives $\boldsymbol{\theta}_2' = \lambda\boldsymbol{\theta}_2$ and $\boldsymbol{\theta}_3' = \boldsymbol{\theta}_3$ (38, Eqs. 6–11; checks t4a–t4b).

Three consequences follow. (i) The sheets alternate in sign: plane 1 receives $K_1 = (1-\lambda)/\mathcal{B}$ and plane 2 receives $K_2 = (\lambda-1)/(\lambda\mathcal{B})$, with $K_1/K_2 = -\lambda$. (ii) The second lens is rescaled in amplitude and in scale: $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_2(\boldsymbol{\theta}_2'/\lambda)$ is the deflection of $\lambda^{-1}\kappa_2(\boldsymbol{\theta}/\lambda)$ (Schneider's Eq. 13; check t4d for a power law). (iii) All time delays, from sources on both planes, scale by the same λ, so time-delay ratios cannot break the transformation [38]. The same paper shows that a change of cosmology, $\mathcal{B} \to \mathcal{B}'$, can be absorbed by a transformation of the same form (his Eqs. 18–20; checks t4e–t4f2); with the first source made massless this reduces to our Eq. (22.10). For an arbitrary number of planes the isotropic scaling alternates between λ and 1 from plane to plane, and every time delay still scales by λ [39].

22.4 The Power-Law Slope as a Local MST

Strong lensing probes κ only in an annulus around $\theta_{\rm E}$, so the transformation need only hold there; its main effect is to change the local slope of the profile near the Einstein radius [38]. To see how, expand the deflection of a power law and of its MST about $\theta = \theta_{\rm E} + \delta$ ($\theta > 0$):

$$\alpha_{\gamma'}(\theta_{\rm E}+\delta) = \theta_{\rm E} + (2-\gamma')\,\delta + \frac{(2-\gamma')(1-\gamma')}{2\theta_{\rm E}}\,\delta^2 + \mathcal{O}\big(\delta^3\big)\,, \tag{22.14}$$

$$\alpha_{\lambda}(\theta_{\rm E}+\delta) = \theta_{\rm E} + \big[1-\lambda(\gamma'-1)\big]\delta + \lambda\,\frac{(2-\gamma')(1-\gamma')}{2\theta_{\rm E}}\,\delta^2 + \mathcal{O}\big(\delta^3\big)\,. \tag{22.15}$$

The zeroth orders agree (the Einstein radius is MST-invariant). The first orders agree if and only if the power law has slope

$$\boxed{\gamma'_{\rm eff} - 1 = \lambda\,(\gamma'-1)} \tag{22.16}$$

, and then $\theta - \alpha_{\gamma'_{\rm eff}} = \lambda(\theta - \alpha_{\gamma'}) + \mathcal{O}(\delta^2)$: the steeper or shallower power law reproduces the images to first order with the source rescaled by λ. Near $\theta_{\rm E}$, therefore, a change of slope is an MST.

The local equivalence also explains the slope dependence of time delays. For a power law, at fixed image positions,

$$\Delta\tau \simeq (\gamma'-1)\,\frac{\theta_A^2 - \theta_B^2}{2}, \tag{22.17}$$

to better than 10^{-4} for $\beta = 0.005\,\theta_{\rm E}$ and $\gamma' \in \{1.6, 2, 2.4\}$. At fixed images, then, delays scale as $\gamma' - 1$, and two power laws whose slopes are related by Eq. (22.16) have delays in the ratio λ, which is the MST rule again. Expressed instead in terms of the unobservable source position, $\Delta\tau \simeq 2\beta\theta_{\rm E}$ for every slope: the source position absorbs the slope.

The local MST

To first order about the Einstein radius, an MST with parameter λ applied to a power law of slope γ' is indistinguishable from a power law of slope $\gamma'_{\rm eff} = 1 + \lambda(\gamma'-1)$ with the source rescaled by λ. The radial eigenvalue at $\theta_{\rm E}$, $1 - \alpha'(\theta_{\rm E}) = \gamma' - 1$, and $1 - \kappa(\theta_{\rm E}) = (\gamma'-1)/2$ both scale by λ, and time delays at fixed images scale as $\gamma' - 1$. Anything that drags a fitted slope therefore acts on H_0 and on $\mathcal{B}$ like a sheet.

22.5 Breaking the MST with Stellar Kinematics

Imaging fixes the total projected mass inside the Einstein radius, $M_{\rm E} = \pi\Sigma_{\rm cr}R_{\rm E}^2$ with $R_{\rm E} = D_{\rm d}\theta_{\rm E}$ (Eq. 13.2), and this mass is MST-invariant. For an external sheet the galaxy's own convergence is $\lambda\kappa$, so the galaxy's own mass inside any radius is λ times that of the $\lambda = 1$ model. Stars orbit in the galaxy's potential, not in the sheet's, so their velocity dispersion measures that λ. We make this exact in two steps.

22.5.1 The isothermal case, exactly

For an SIS of dispersion σ_v, $\theta_{\rm E} = 4\pi(\sigma_v^2/c^2)D_{\rm ds}/D_{\rm s}$ (Eq. 11.18) and $\kappa = \theta_{\rm E}/(2\theta)$. The galaxy part of the transformed model is $\lambda\kappa = (\lambda\theta_{\rm E})/(2\theta)$: an SIS with Einstein radius $\lambda\theta_{\rm E}$, hence

$$\sigma_v'^2 = \lambda\,\sigma_v^2, \qquad \lambda = \left(\frac{\sigma_{\rm obs}}{\sigma_{\rm SIS}(\theta_{\rm E})}\right)^2 \tag{22.18}$$

, where $\sigma_{\rm SIS}(\theta_{\rm E})$ is the dispersion predicted from the measured Einstein radius. For isothermal stars in an SIS the line-of-sight dispersion is the same at every projected radius, so in this case the aperture does not matter.

22.5.2 Power-law mass, power-law tracer: the spherical Jeans equation

Let the total density be $\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$ (Eq. 13.18), the stellar tracer $\rho_* \propto r^{-\nu}$, and the orbital anisotropy $\beta_a = 1 - \sigma_t^2/\sigma_r^2$ constant. The spherical Jeans equation,

$$\frac{{\rm d}(\rho_*\sigma_r^2)}{{\rm d}r} + \frac{2\beta_a}{r}\rho_*\sigma_r^2 = -\rho_*\frac{GM(r)}{r^2}, \tag{22.19}$$

has the power-law solution

$$\sigma_r^2(r) = \frac{GM(r)}{r}\,\frac{1}{\nu+\gamma'-2-2\beta_a} \tag{22.20}$$

. What a spectrograph measures is the luminosity-weighted line-of-sight dispersion inside an aperture $R_{\rm ap}$. Projecting and averaging (box below), and normalising $M(r)$ by the lensing condition $\bar\kappa(\theta_{\rm E}) = 1$ applied to the galaxy part $\lambda\kappa$, one finds

$$\boxed{\sigma_{\rm ap}^2 = \lambda\,\frac{GM_{\rm E}}{R_{\rm E}}\left(\frac{R_{\rm ap}}{R_{\rm E}}\right)^{2-\gamma'} F(\gamma',\nu,\beta_a),} \tag{22.21}$$

$$F = \frac{3-\nu}{5-\nu-\gamma'}\,\frac{\nu+\gamma'-2-\beta_a(\nu+\gamma'-3)}{\nu+\gamma'-2-2\beta_a}\,\frac{\Gamma(\frac{\gamma'}{2})\,\Gamma(\frac{\nu}{2})\,\Gamma(\frac{\nu+\gamma'-3}{2})}{\sqrt{\pi}\,\Gamma(\frac{\gamma'-1}{2})\,\Gamma(\frac{\nu-1}{2})\,\Gamma(\frac{\nu+\gamma'}{2})}, \tag{22.22}$$

valid for $1 < \nu < 3$, $\gamma' > 1$, $3 < \nu+\gamma' < 5$ and $\nu+\gamma'-2-2\beta_a > 0$ (convergence of the line-of-sight projections of ρ_* and of ρ, of the aperture integral at small radius, and of the Jeans integral at large radius, which also keeps $\sigma_r^2 > 0$ in Eq. 22.20). With $GM_{\rm E}/R_{\rm E} = (c^2/4)\theta_{\rm E}D_{\rm s}/D_{\rm ds}$ and $F(2,2,0) = 1/\pi$ this reduces to λ times the SIS result; more generally $F(2,\nu,0) = 2/(\nu\pi)$.

One dispersion fixes λ

Equation (22.21) is strictly linear in λ. For given (γ', ν, β_a) a single measured aperture dispersion gives

$$\lambda = \frac{\sigma^2_{\rm obs}}{\sigma^2_{\rm ap}(\lambda = 1)}, \qquad \frac{\Delta\lambda}{\lambda} = 2\,\frac{\Delta\sigma}{\sigma}. \tag{22.23}$$

A 4% dispersion therefore gives an 8% λ, and 1% in λ needs 0.5% in σ (Problem 22.7.5). The error budget is usually dominated not by this statistical term but by what Eq. (22.21) assumes: β_a, ν, and γ'.

22.5.3 The systematics that come with σ

Anisotropy. Only the middle factor of Eq. (22.22) depends on β_a:

$$\frac{F(\beta_a)}{F(0)} = \frac{\nu + \gamma' - 2 - \beta_a(\nu + \gamma' - 3)}{\nu + \gamma' - 2 - 2\beta_a}, \tag{22.24}$$

independent of $R_{\rm ap}$. For an isothermal mass and tracer ($\gamma' = \nu = 2$) it is $(1 - \beta_a/2)/(1 - \beta_a)$: a true $\beta_a = +0.2$ analysed as isotropic raises the inferred λ by 12.5%, and $\beta_a = -0.2$ lowers it by 8.3%. For $\nu = 2.5$ the factors are 22/21 and 28/29. A single aperture number cannot separate a change of λ from a change of β_a: this is the *mass–anisotropy degeneracy*. A spatially resolved $\sigma(R)$ helps because the anisotropy and the mass profile change the shape of $\sigma_{\rm los}(R)$ differently once β_a is allowed to vary with radius.

Aperture and slope. At fixed $\sigma_{\rm ap}$, Eq. (22.21) gives

$$\left.\frac{\partial \ln\lambda}{\partial\gamma'}\right|_{\sigma_{\rm ap}} = \ln\frac{R_{\rm ap}}{R_{\rm E}} - \frac{\partial \ln F}{\partial\gamma'} \tag{22.25}$$

. The crude "projected-mass proxy" $M_{\rm 2D,gal}(< R) = \lambda M_{\rm E}(R/R_{\rm E})^{3-\gamma'}$ keeps only the first term, which vanishes at $R_{\rm ap} = R_{\rm E}$: there, the proxy says, σ measures λ independently of the slope. The Jeans solution adds the second term. For $\gamma' = \nu = 2$ and $\beta_a = 0$, $\partial \ln F/\partial\gamma' = 1/2$ exactly, so the decoupling radius is $R_{\rm ap} = e^{1/2}R_{\rm E} \approx 1.65\,R_{\rm E}$. Inside it, an error in γ' leaks into λ. The decoupling radius $R_{\rm E}\exp(\partial \ln F/\partial\gamma')$ depends on both slopes. For an isotropic $\nu = 2$ tracer it is 0.91, 1.09, 1.32, 1.47 and 1.65 $R_{\rm E}$ for $\gamma' = 1.4$, 1.6, 1.8, 1.9 and 2.0, so for shallow mass profiles it falls inside $R_{\rm E}$; for $\nu = 2.5$ it lies between 3.6 and 6.4 $R_{\rm E}$ over the same range of γ'. It has to be computed for the model at hand, not assumed.

Internal versus external sheet. For an external sheet the galaxy is $\lambda\kappa$ and Eq. (22.21) is exact. For an internal sheet the galaxy also contains the cored component $(1 - \lambda)\kappa_{\rm c}$. Model it as a uniform sphere of radius $r_c \gg R_{\rm E}$: its central column is $2\rho_c r_c$, so $\rho_c = (1 - \lambda)\Sigma_{\rm cr}/(2r_c)$. Its own Jeans solution with $\rho_*\sigma_r^2 \to 0$ at infinity is, at $r \ll r_c$, $\sigma_r^2 \simeq (4\pi/3)G\rho_c r^2/(\nu - 2 - 2\beta_a)$ for $\nu > 2 + 2\beta_a$; for the isothermal tracer ($\nu = 2$, $\beta_a = 0$) a logarithm appears, and the exact result is $\sigma_r^2 = (4\pi/3)G\rho_c r^2[\ln(r_c/r) + 1/3]$. Either way the core contributes a fraction of order $R^2_{\rm ap}/(R_{\rm E}r_c)$ (times $\ln(r_c/R_{\rm ap})$ at $\nu = 2$), which vanishes as $r_c \to \infty$. In

that limit the kinematics measures $\lambda_{\rm int}$ just as it measures λ for an external sheet; at finite r_c the core's own dispersion must be modelled. A power law scaled by $\lambda_{\rm int}$, plus a large core, is the parameterisation used in the TDCOSMO hierarchical analysis. With $\lambda_{\rm int}$ constrained only by the kinematics of seven time-delay lenses, Birrer et al. [6] found $H_0 = 74.5^{+5.6}_{-6.1}\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$; adding imaging and spectroscopy of 33 SLACS lenses (nine with resolved kinematics used to constrain the anisotropy), under the assumption that both samples share a parent population, gave $H_0 = 67.4^{+4.1}_{-3.2}\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$. Freeing $\lambda_{\rm int}$ widens the H_0 interval to about $\pm 6\ \mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$, and that width is set by the kinematics.

22.5.4 Two internal directions: a core and a central point mass

The internal MST is one direction in the space of image-preserving re-profilings. A central point mass is another, and it pushes the opposite way. A point mass adds a compact excess that a power-law fit, in the configurations of Chapter 21, absorbs by steepening γ'; a core removes mass from the centre and is absorbed by flattening γ'. Their dynamical signatures differ in the same way: a point mass gives $\sigma_r^2 = GM_\bullet/[r(\nu + 1 - 2\beta_a)]$, rising inward as $1/r$, while a uniform core gives $\sigma_r^2 \propto r^2$ (times $\ln(r_c/r)$ at $\nu = 2$), falling inward (Problem 22.7.8). A single aperture number averages over both and can be matched by either. The radial run $\sigma(R)$, whose central rise is the black hole's signature, and the radial image, which samples κ at small θ (Chapter 20), are the two pieces of information that separate them.

22.6 Summary

The MST $\kappa \to \lambda\kappa + (1-\lambda)$, $\boldsymbol{\beta} \to \lambda\boldsymbol{\beta}$ preserves image positions, shapes, flux ratios, critical curves and $\theta_{\rm E}$; it scales magnifications by λ^{-2} and time delays by λ, so $H_0^{\rm true} = \lambda H_0^{\rm naive}$. The proof is Eq. (22.3). With one deflector and two source planes, a sheet at the lens acts on each plane as an MST with its own λ_i, linked by Eq. (22.10). The second plane breaks the MST only if the distance ratio $\mathcal{B}$ is known; if $\mathcal{B}$ is fitted, the MST becomes a bias on $\mathcal{B}$ while η and all images stay fixed. With a massive first source the MST survives with an unscaled far plane and sheets of alternating sign, and all time delays scale by the same λ [38, 39].

Near $\theta_{\rm E}$ a change of slope is an MST, $\gamma'_{\rm eff} - 1 = \lambda(\gamma' - 1)$, and only second-order information (ξ) tells them apart. This is how slope drag from a central mass becomes an H_0 or $\mathcal{B}$ bias. Stellar kinematics measures the galaxy's own mass: $\sigma^2_{\rm ap} \propto \lambda$ exactly (Eq. 22.21), so $\Delta\lambda/\lambda = 2\Delta\sigma/\sigma$. The anisotropy factor (Eq. 22.24), the tracer slope, and the aperture–slope covariance (Eq. 22.25) are the systematics, and resolved $\sigma(R)$ is what reduces them.

22.7 Problems

Exercise 22.7.1. (The MST in three lines.) Starting from $\kappa_\lambda = \lambda\kappa + (1-\lambda)$, show that $\boldsymbol{\beta} \to \lambda\boldsymbol{\beta}$ leaves image positions invariant, that $\mathcal{A}_\lambda = \lambda\mathcal{A}$, that $\det\mathcal{A}_\lambda = \lambda^2 \det\mathcal{A}$, and that flux ratios are invariant while absolute magnifications scale as λ^{-2}. Show that both eigenvalues of $\mathcal{A}$ scale by λ, and conclude that the tangential critical curve is unchanged.

Exercise 22.7.2. (Delays and H_0.) (a) Show that $\tau_\lambda - \lambda\tau$ is independent of $\boldsymbol{\theta}$, and hence that $\Delta t \to \lambda \Delta t$. (b) Using $H_0 \propto \Delta\tau/\Delta t_{\rm obs}$, derive $H_0^{\rm true} = \lambda H_0^{\rm naive}$ and state by how much a naive analysis overestimates H_0 when $\lambda = 0.9$. (c) Show that for a power-law DSPL, $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$ has no λ dependence at fixed (η, γ'), and compute $\partial\mathcal{B}/\partial\gamma'$. Why is the MST a normalisation systematic for H_0 but a shape systematic for $\mathcal{B}$?

Exercise 22.7.3. (One deflector, two source planes.) (a) For a power-law deflector with known $\mathcal{B}$, derive Eq. (22.9) and evaluate the shift of η for $\gamma' = 2$, $\mathcal{B} = 0.7$, $\lambda_2 = 0.9$. (b) Now let $\mathcal{B}$ be free. Derive Eq. (22.10) and evaluate $\mathcal{B}'$ and λ_1 for the same numbers. (c) With η held fixed, what slope must a power-law fit adopt to reproduce $\mathcal{B}'$? Explain in two sentences why the second plane does not break the MST.

Exercise 22.7.4. (Two lens planes.) Verify that Eq. (22.13) maps $\boldsymbol{\theta}_2 \to \lambda\boldsymbol{\theta}_2$ and leaves $\boldsymbol{\theta}_3$ unchanged. Show that $K_1/K_2 = -\lambda$, evaluate both sheets for $\lambda = 0.95$ and $\mathcal{B} = 0.7$, and show that no MST acts on the second lens plane alone.

Exercise 22.7.5. (The kinematic error budget.) A lens has $\sigma_{\rm ap} = 250 \pm 10\ {\rm km\,s^{-1}}$. (a) What is $\Delta\lambda/\lambda$? (b) What dispersion precision would give 1% in λ? (c) For an isothermal mass and tracer, by how much is λ biased if the true anisotropy is $\beta_a = \pm 0.2$ and the analysis assumes $\beta_a = 0$? Compare the anisotropy range with the statistical error of (a).

Exercise 22.7.6. (The local MST.) Expand α_λ and $\alpha_{\gamma'_{\rm eff}}$ to second order about $\theta_{\rm E}$. Show that the first orders agree if and only if $\gamma'_{\rm eff} - 1 = \lambda(\gamma' - 1)$, and find the second-order mismatch. For $\gamma' = 2$, $\lambda = 0.9$, give $\gamma'_{\rm eff}$, the ratio of time delays at fixed images, and the invariant ξ of both models.

Exercise 22.7.7. (Where to put the aperture.) Using the projected-mass proxy, show that $\partial \ln\lambda/\partial\gamma'$ at fixed σ is $\ln(R_{\rm ap}/R_{\rm E})$. Using the Jeans result with $\partial \ln F/\partial\gamma' = 1/2$ (isothermal mass and tracer, isotropic), evaluate it at $R_{\rm ap} = 0.5\,R_{\rm E}$, the bias in λ from a slope error $\delta\gamma' = +0.1$, and the radius at which the covariance vanishes.

Exercise 22.7.8. (Core or black hole?) Show that a central point mass and a uniform core give Jeans solutions $\sigma_r^2 \propto r^{-1}$ and, at radii well inside the core and for $\nu > 2 + 2\beta_a$, $\propto r^2$ respectively (at $\nu = 2$, $\beta_a = 0$: r^2 up to a logarithm). Argue why the two are different internal directions of the MST/SPT family, and why a single aperture dispersion cannot distinguish them while a resolved $\sigma(R)$ or a radial image can.

Chapter 23

Azimuthal Multipoles and the Central-Mass Confusion

Every lens model we have built so far has had either circular (Chapter 11) or elliptical (Chapter 12) isodensity contours, which is a modelling convenience. Lens galaxies carry angular structure beyond the ellipse at the per-cent level in their mass: O'Riordan and Vegetti [32] model mass multipoles of 1 and 3 per cent, consistent with the departures seen in galaxy isophotes, and Stacey et al. [46] measure $m = 3$ and $m = 4$ multipoles of about 1% of the convergence in three lenses observed at high resolution with ALMA. The classic shape is the $m = 4$ Fourier mode ("boxy" versus "discy"); odd modes ($m = 1$ lopsidedness, $m = 3$) are the other low orders.

This chapter treats such structure quantitatively, as a single azimuthal multipole on a power-law radial base. We derive its lensing potential and deflection in closed form, pin down the bookkeeping that connects the amplitude conventions in use, and then prove the result the rest of the chapter uses: *a multipole of order $m \geq 1$ encloses zero mass at every radius*. It is therefore exactly orthogonal to a central point mass in the space of convergence fields, and yet the two can be confused in a fit, because a likelihood is not an integral over a full circle. We close with the residual diagnostic that tells them apart: an omitted central mass misfits the inner image region, an omitted multipole misfits the outer arcs.

The chapter builds on the multipole series of Chapter 12 (§12.4), on the Poisson equation and Jacobian of Chapter 9, and on the power-law convergence of Chapter 13. Its diagnostic feeds forward into the discussion of central-mass inferences in Chapter 21.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `multipoles_power_law.wl`, the symbolic verification of every new equation of this chapter (potential, deflection, amplitude bookkeeping, zero-enclosed-mass theorem for general m, critical-curve shift, residual demonstration); exports the two figures to `Figures/19_Multipoles/`
- `problems_19.wl`, the worked solutions to the Problems

23.1 Notation and Set-up

We use polar image-plane coordinates (θ, φ) centred on the deflector, exactly as in §12.4. Two notational collisions must be settled at the outset. First, the integer m is the azimuthal multipole order, whereas elsewhere in Part V the symbol m denotes the central point-mass fraction. To avoid a clash, in this chapter we write the central point-mass fraction as

$$f_\bullet \;\equiv\; \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta_{\rm E}^2}, \tag{23.1}$$

where $\theta_\bullet$ is the Einstein radius the point mass would have on its own (so its deflection is $\theta_\bullet^2/\theta$, Chapter 11). Second, the symbol a_m needs care: in §12.4.1 a_m was the amplitude of an isothermal potential multipole, $\psi_m = a_m \theta \cos[m(\varphi - \varphi_m)]$. Here a_m is the *fractional convergence* amplitude defined in Eq. (23.5) below. The two are related in §23.3.2. The total three-dimensional density slope is γ' ($\rho \propto r^{-\gamma'}$, with $\gamma' = 2$ isothermal), as in §13.5.2.

23.2 The Multipole Expansion of the Convergence

Any convergence field can be expanded in a Fourier series in the azimuth,

$$\kappa(\theta, \varphi) \;=\; \kappa_0(\theta) \;+\; \sum_{m \geq 1} \kappa_m(\theta) \cos\!\big[m(\varphi - \varphi_m)\big], \tag{23.2}$$

where κ_0 is the circularly averaged (monopole) profile and each $m \geq 1$ term is a pure angular redistribution of mass with its own orientation φ_m. This is the convergence-space counterpart of the potential-space series Eq. (12.13).

23.2.1 The power-law base

We put the multipoles on the circular power law of Chapter 13, Eq. (13.19):

$$\kappa_0(\theta) \;=\; \frac{3 - \gamma'}{2} \left(\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta}\right)^{\gamma' - 1}, \qquad \psi_0(\theta) \;=\; \frac{\theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma' - 1}\, \theta^{3 - \gamma'}}{3 - \gamma'}, \qquad \alpha_0(\theta) \;=\; \theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma' - 1}\, \theta^{2 - \gamma'}, \tag{23.3}$$

valid for $1 < \gamma' < 3$. One checks directly that $\nabla^2 \psi_0 = 2\kappa_0$, that $\alpha_0 = \psi_0'$, and that $\alpha_0(\theta_{\rm E}) = \theta_{\rm E}$, so $\theta_{\rm E}$ is the Einstein radius. The deflection also follows from the enclosed-mass formula of Chapter 11, $\alpha_0 = (2/\theta) \int_0^\theta \kappa_0\, \theta'\, {\rm d}\theta'$ (Eq. (11.4) in dimensionless form).

23.2.2 A single multipole on the power-law base

The simplest non-circular extension multiplies the monopole by a small angular modulation. A single order m with the same radial run as the base is

$$\kappa_m(\theta, \varphi) \;=\; \frac{k_m}{2} \left(\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta}\right)^{\gamma' - 1} \cos\!\big[m(\varphi - \varphi_m)\big], \tag{23.4}$$

where the multipole shares the centre, $\theta_{\rm E}$ and γ' of the monopole. The physically meaningful amplitude is the *peak fractional convergence perturbation*,

$$\boxed{a_m \;\equiv\; \frac{\max_\varphi |\kappa_m|}{\kappa_0} \;=\; \frac{k_m}{3-\gamma'}} \tag{23.5}$$

which is independent of radius, because κ_m and κ_0 both scale as $\theta^{-(\gamma'-1)}$. The total convergence is therefore $\kappa = \kappa_0(\theta)\,\{1 + a_m \cos[m(\varphi-\varphi_m)]\}$: $a_m = 0.01$ means a 1% azimuthal modulation of the surface density at every radius. This is an intrinsic departure from the base shape, not the $m=4$ content that an ellipse itself carries; the latter is what §12.4.3 estimated to matter only for markedly flattened lenses ($q \lesssim 0.75$).

23.3 Potential and Deflection in Closed Form

23.3.1 Solving the Poisson equation mode by mode

Because the polar Laplacian does not mix different azimuthal orders, we can solve $\nabla^2\psi_m = 2\kappa_m$ one order at a time with the separable ansatz $\psi_m = A\,\theta^p \cos m\Delta\varphi$, $\Delta\varphi \equiv \varphi - \varphi_m$. The identity needed is

$$\nabla^2(\theta^p \cos m\Delta\varphi) \;=\; (p^2 - m^2)\,\theta^{p-2}\cos m\Delta\varphi. \tag{23.6}$$

The result is the closed-form multipole potential on a power-law base:

$$\boxed{\psi_m(\theta,\varphi) \;=\; -\,\frac{k_m\,\theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma'-1}}{m^2-(3-\gamma')^2}\;\theta^{3-\gamma'}\cos\big[m(\varphi-\varphi_m)\big].} \tag{23.7}$$

Its gradient gives the deflection in the polar frame, $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_m = (\partial_\theta\psi_m,\ \theta^{-1}\partial_\varphi\psi_m)$:

$$\alpha_{m,\theta} = -\,\frac{(3-\gamma')\,k_m\,\theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma'-1}\,\theta^{2-\gamma'}}{m^2-(3-\gamma')^2}\;\cos\big[m(\varphi-\varphi_m)\big], \tag{23.8}$$

$$\alpha_{m,\varphi} = +\,\frac{m\,k_m\,\theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma'-1}\,\theta^{2-\gamma'}}{m^2-(3-\gamma')^2}\;\sin\big[m(\varphi-\varphi_m)\big]. \tag{23.9}$$

Only the radial component carries the factor $(3-\gamma')$, only the tangential one the factor m; at high m the perturbation is predominantly tangential. As a check, setting $m=0$ and $k_0 = 3-\gamma'$ in Eq. (23.7) returns the monopole potential ψ_0 of Eq. (23.3).

23.3.2 The isothermal limit and Chapter 12

At $\gamma' = 2$, Eq. (23.7) becomes $\psi_m = A\,\theta\cos[m(\varphi-\varphi_m)]$ with $A = -k_m\theta_{\rm E}/(m^2-1)$. This is precisely the isothermal-scaling potential multipole of §12.4.1; inserting this A into Eq. (12.14) gives $\kappa = A(1-m^2)/(2\theta)\cos[\ldots] = \tfrac{1}{2}k_m(\theta_{\rm E}/\theta)\cos[\ldots]$, which is Eq. (23.4) at $\gamma'=2$. Since $k_m = a_m$ at $\gamma'=2$, the isothermal potential amplitude of Chapter 12 (call it A_m to avoid the clash) and the fractional convergence amplitude of this chapter are related by

$$A_m \;=\; -\,\frac{\theta_{\rm E}\,a_m}{m^2-1} \qquad (\gamma'=2). \tag{23.10}$$

23.3.3 A radius-independent perturbation

Dividing the magnitude $|\boldsymbol{\alpha}_m| = (\alpha_{m,\theta}^2 + \alpha_{m,\varphi}^2)^{1/2}$ by the monopole deflection, the common factor $\theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma'-1}\theta^{2-\gamma'}$ cancels:

$$\frac{|\boldsymbol{\alpha}_m|}{\alpha_0} = \frac{k_m\sqrt{(3-\gamma')^2\cos^2 m\Delta\varphi + m^2\sin^2 m\Delta\varphi}}{|m^2-(3-\gamma')^2|}, \qquad \max_{\varphi}\frac{|\boldsymbol{\alpha}_m|}{\alpha_0} = \frac{m\,k_m}{m^2-(3-\gamma')^2} \quad (m>3{-}\gamma'). \tag{23.11}$$

The fractional deflection perturbation is the same at every radius; the absolute perturbation grows outward as $\theta^{2-\gamma'}$ for the shallow slopes $\gamma' < 2$. This will matter in §23.8. For $a_m = 0.01$ on a $\gamma' = 1.5$ base, Eq. (23.11) gives a peak of 0.67% ($m = 3$) and 0.44% ($m = 4$) of the monopole deflection, about 6.7 and 4.4 milliarcseconds for $\theta_{\rm E} = 1''$.

23.4 Amplitude Bookkeeping

23.4.1 The convention trap: k_m is not a_m

Inverting Eq. (23.5),

$$\boxed{k_m \;=\; a_m\,(3-\gamma')} \tag{23.12}$$

A multipole can be stored as two Cartesian-like components (ϵ_1, ϵ_2) with

$$(\epsilon_1,\epsilon_2) \;=\; k_m\,\big(\cos m\varphi_m,\ \sin m\varphi_m\big), \qquad k_m = \sqrt{\epsilon_1^2+\epsilon_2^2}, \qquad \varphi_m = \tfrac{1}{m}\,\mathrm{atan2}(\epsilon_2,\epsilon_1), \tag{23.13}$$

so that $\epsilon_1\cos m\varphi + \epsilon_2\sin m\varphi = k_m\cos[m(\varphi-\varphi_m)]$ is linear in the sampled parameters. Two factors hide here: the magnitude is k_m, not a_m; and the angle carries a factor $1/m$, so φ_m is defined only modulo $2\pi/m$ (and a shift by π/m is equivalent to flipping the sign of k_m).

Amplitude conventions are not interchangeable

The fractional density amplitude must always be derived from the code's own definition before it is compared to a published value or a "1% multipole" is injected; Eqs. (23.4), (23.5) and (23.13) are one convention among several. The angle needs the same care: if a code orders the components the other way, $(\epsilon_1,\epsilon_2) = k_m(\sin m\varphi_m, \cos m\varphi_m)$, the same two numbers put the mode at $90°/m - \varphi_m$ instead of φ_m. The safe procedure is to evaluate the code's own convergence and locate its peak. For the circular power-law form used here, $k_m = a_m(3-\gamma')$; taking a component magnitude of 0.01 to mean $a_m = 0.01$ actually injects $a_m = 0.01/(3-\gamma')$, which is 33% low at $\gamma' = 1.5$ and 37.5% low at $\gamma' = 1.4$.

23.4.2 From fractional amplitude to isophotal deviation

The geometric meaning of a_m follows from supposing that the isodensity contours are perturbed circles,

$$\theta_{\rm iso}(\varphi) \;=\; \theta_0\big[1+\varepsilon_m\cos m\Delta\varphi\big], \tag{23.14}$$

with ε_m the fractional contour deviation (for isophotes, the quantity a photometric fit of Fourier modes to the contour radius returns). A convergence that is constant along these contours and has the power-law radial run is a function of the "shape radius" $\theta/[1+\varepsilon_m\cos m\Delta\varphi]$:

$$\kappa(\theta,\varphi) = C\left[\frac{\theta}{1+\varepsilon_m\cos m\Delta\varphi}\right]^{-(\gamma'-1)} = \kappa_0(\theta)\big[1+\varepsilon_m\cos m\Delta\varphi\big]^{\gamma'-1} \simeq \kappa_0(\theta)\big[1+(\gamma'-1)\,\varepsilon_m\cos m\Delta\varphi\big], \tag{23.15}$$

to first order in ε_m (binomial expansion of $(1+x)^{\gamma'-1}$; the first neglected term is $\frac{1}{2}(\gamma'-1)(\gamma'-2)\varepsilon_m^2\cos^2 m\Delta\varphi$). Comparing with Eq. (23.5):

$$\boxed{a_m \;=\; (\gamma'-1)\,\varepsilon_m} \qquad\Longleftrightarrow\qquad \varepsilon_m = \frac{a_m}{\gamma'-1}. \tag{23.16}$$

At isothermal $\gamma'=2$ the two coincide. At shallow slopes a given convergence multipole demands a larger contour distortion: $a_m=0.01$ needs $\varepsilon_m=2.5\%$ at $\gamma'=1.4$ and 2.0% at $\gamma'=1.5$. Equation (23.16) is the ellipticity-equivalent translator: it says how "boxy" a lens must look for a given lensing amplitude. It is first order, for circular base contours and a radially constant amplitude; real multipole amplitudes vary with radius and sit on elliptical contours, so it serves as an order-of-magnitude translator, not a calibration.

23.5 The Structural Fact: a Multipole Encloses No Mass

Theorem 23.5.1 (Zero enclosed mass)**.** *For every integer $m\geq 1$, every orientation φ_m and every radius θ, the multipole Eq. (23.4) contributes nothing to the projected mass enclosed within θ:*

$$\delta M_m(<\theta) \;\propto\; \int_0^{\theta}\!\!\int_0^{2\pi} \kappa_m(\theta',\varphi)\,\mathrm{d}\varphi\;\theta'\,\mathrm{d}\theta' \;=\; 0. \tag{23.17}$$

Equivalently, the azimuthal average of its radial deflection vanishes on every circle, $\oint \alpha_{m,\theta}\,\theta\,\mathrm{d}\varphi = 0$.

Proof. Do the φ-integral first: $\int_0^{2\pi}\cos[m(\varphi-\varphi_m)]\,\mathrm{d}\varphi = \frac{1}{m}\big[\sin m(\varphi-\varphi_m)\big]_0^{2\pi} = 0$, because 2π is an integer multiple of the period $2\pi/m$. The radial integral that remains, $\int_0^{\theta}\theta'^{\,2-\gamma'}\,\mathrm{d}\theta'$, is finite for $\gamma'<3$, so the product is zero. For the second form, apply the two-dimensional divergence theorem to $\boldsymbol{\alpha}=\nabla\psi$ on the disc of radius θ: $\oint\boldsymbol{\alpha}\cdot\hat{\boldsymbol{n}}\,\theta\,\mathrm{d}\varphi = \int\nabla^2\psi\,\mathrm{d}A = 2\int\kappa\,\mathrm{d}A$; the right-hand side is proportional to δM_m. □

A central point mass is the opposite extreme. Its deflection $\theta_\bullet^2/\theta$ is independent of φ, so all its Fourier content is in $m=0$; it changes $M(<\theta)$ by the same amount at every radius and changes nothing else. Distinct multipole orders are also mutually orthogonal, for any orientations:

$$\int_0^{2\pi}\cos[m(\varphi-\varphi_m)]\cos[n(\varphi-\varphi_n)]\,\mathrm{d}\varphi \;=\; \pi\,\delta_{mn}\cos[m(\varphi_m-\varphi_n)] \qquad (m,n\geq 1). \tag{23.18}$$

Orthogonal sectors of the convergence

A multipole of order $m \geq 1$ carries zero enclosed mass at every radius (Theorem 23.5.1); a central point mass is a pure monopole. The two are exactly orthogonal in the space of convergence fields, and so are different multipole orders. A multipole leaves the mass inside the Einstein ring unchanged, and a central point mass leaves the contour shapes unchanged.

23.6 Degenerate in the Likelihood, not in κ

Orthogonality holds under an integral over the full circle. A likelihood is a sum over the pixels that actually contain lensed light, and those occupy a few localised arcs. Over a partial arc, two orthogonal functions generally have a nonzero overlap.

In the simplest model of the effect, suppose the data contain a residual $A\cos m\varphi$ (from an omitted multipole) over an arc $|\varphi| < \Delta$, and the model has only a φ-independent template available (as any monopole perturbation is). The least-squares amplitude the fit assigns to the template is

$$\hat{A}_0 \;=\; \frac{\int_{-\Delta}^{\Delta} A\cos m\varphi \,\mathrm{d}\varphi}{\int_{-\Delta}^{\Delta} \mathrm{d}\varphi} \;=\; A\,\frac{\sin m\Delta}{m\Delta}, \tag{23.19}$$

which vanishes for the full circle ($\Delta = \pi$) but is of order unity for short arcs: $2/\pi \simeq 0.64$ for an $m = 4$ residual seen over a 45° arc ($\Delta = \pi/8$), and 0.41 over 60°. A model with no angular freedom will therefore buy whatever χ^2 reduction its available parameters can deliver, and a central point mass is one such parameter. That is a *specification error*, not a physical degeneracy. Conversely, because the two perturbations are orthogonal in κ, once the multipole orders actually present are in the model the angular signal has a legitimate home: one expects free multipoles neither to absorb a genuine central mass nor to leave room for a spurious one. An evidence ratio for a central mass should therefore not be quoted as a detection unless the winning model fits the data to the noise level.

23.7 Response of the Tangential Critical Curve

The tangential critical curve is the most directly observed feature of a lens, since the Einstein ring traces it, and we now ask how a small multipole deforms it. For the circular base the tangential eigenvalue of the Jacobian (Eq. (9.17)) is $\lambda_t = 1 - \alpha_0/\theta$, which vanishes at θ_{E}; the radial eigenvalue there is $\lambda_r = 1 - \alpha_0' = \gamma' - 1 > 0$. Write the critical curve as $\theta_c(\varphi) = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}[1 + \delta(\varphi)]$ and expand $\det \mathcal{A} = 0$ to first order in a_m.

The result is

$$\frac{\delta\theta_c}{\theta_{\mathrm{E}}} \;=\; \frac{k_m\,[m^2 - (3-\gamma')]}{(\gamma'-1)\,[m^2-(3-\gamma')^2]}\,\cos m\Delta\varphi \;=\; a_m\,\frac{(3-\gamma')\,(m^2-3+\gamma')}{(\gamma'-1)\,[m^2-(3-\gamma')^2]}\,\cos m\Delta\varphi. \tag{23.20}$$

Three readings follow. At $\gamma' = 2$ the coefficient is exactly 1 for every m: $\delta\theta_c = a_m\theta_{\mathrm{E}}\cos m\Delta\varphi = \varepsilon_m\theta_{\mathrm{E}}\cos m\Delta\varphi$. For an isothermal lens the tangential critical curve is the $\kappa = \frac{1}{2}$ isodensity

contour, so it inherits the contour shape exactly (compare Eq. (23.16) at $\gamma' = 2$). Shallow slopes amplify the response, since the factor $1/(\gamma' - 1)$ is the inverse of the radial eigenvalue: a shallow profile has a slowly varying λ_t near the ring, so a given perturbation moves its zero further. For $m = 4$ at $\gamma' = 1.5$ the coefficient is 3.16; a 1% multipole moves the critical curve by $\pm 3.2\%$ of $\theta_{\rm E}$. Finally, the shift averages to zero over φ, so the area inside the critical curve is unchanged at first order, by the same integral $\oint \cos m\Delta\varphi \, \mathrm{d}\varphi = 0$ that proves Theorem 23.5.1. A central point mass added to a fixed base does the opposite: it expands the critical curve uniformly, $\delta\theta_c/\theta_{\rm E} = f_\bullet/(\gamma' - 1)$, with no angular dependence. If instead the base normalisation is reduced so that the Einstein ring stays where the data put it, the tangential critical curve does not move at all. Figure 23.1 shows the $m = 4$ convergence pattern and the corresponding first-order critical curve.

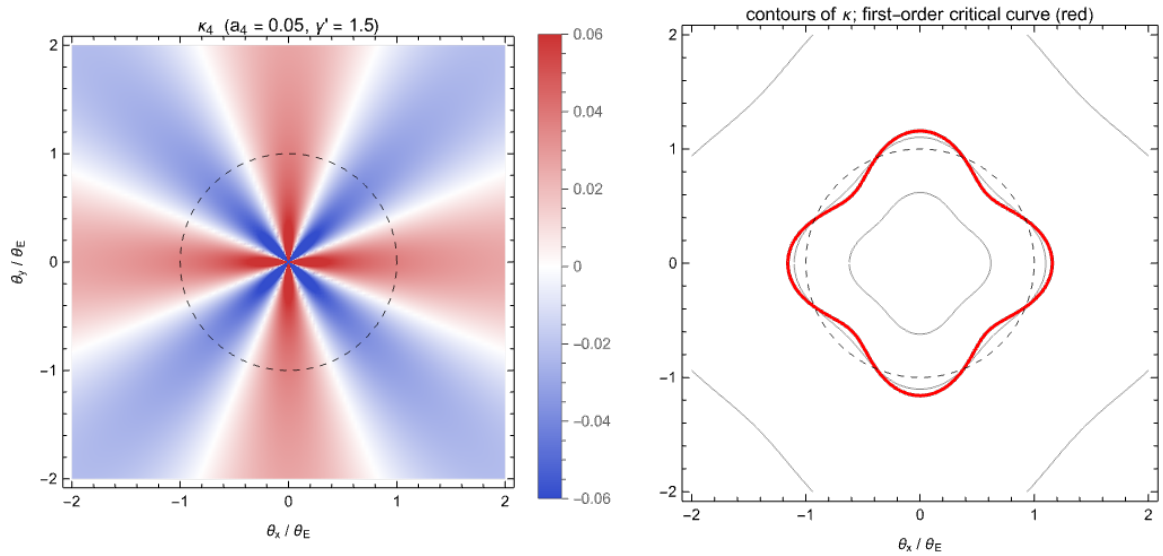


Figure 23.1: **Left:** the $m = 4$ convergence multipole κ_4 of Eq. (23.4) on a $\gamma' = 1.5$ power-law base, with an exaggerated $a_4 = 0.05$ for visibility (the colour scale is clipped near the centre, where $\kappa_4 \propto \theta^{-1/2}$). The dashed circle is the unperturbed Einstein ring. Red regions gain mass and blue regions lose the same amount: the pattern averages to zero on every circle. **Right:** contours of the total convergence (grey) and the first-order tangential critical curve, Eq. (23.20) (red), compared with the unperturbed ring (dashed). Generated by `multipoles_power_law.wl`.

23.8 The Residual Diagnostic: Inner versus Outer

We can now say where in the image plane each perturbation shows up. The data fix the Einstein ring very precisely, so any viable model must reproduce it; a fair comparison holds $\theta_{\rm E}$ fixed.

23.8.1 The central point mass

Add a point mass of fraction $f_\bullet$ and reduce the base normalisation by the factor $(1 - f_\bullet)$ so that the total deflection at $\theta_{\rm E}$ is still $\theta_{\rm E}$. The change in deflection is

$$\delta\alpha_\bullet(\theta) = f_\bullet\,\theta_{\rm E}\left[\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta} - \left(\frac{\theta}{\theta_{\rm E}}\right)^{2-\gamma'}\right], \qquad \frac{\delta\alpha_\bullet}{\alpha_0} = f_\bullet\left[\left(\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta}\right)^{3-\gamma'} - 1\right]. \tag{23.21}$$

It vanishes on the ring, is positive inside and negative outside, and grows inward as $(\theta_{\rm E}/\theta)^{3-\gamma'}$. Near the ring, though, it is linear in $\ln(\theta/\theta_{\rm E})$: $\delta\alpha_\bullet/\alpha_0 \simeq -f_\bullet(3-\gamma')\ln(\theta/\theta_{\rm E})$. A change of the slope at fixed $\theta_{\rm E}$ produces exactly this shape, $\partial\alpha_0/\partial\gamma' = -\alpha_0\ln(\theta/\theta_{\rm E})$. Any realistic fit lets the slope float, so re-fit it with $\delta\gamma' = -f_\bullet(3-\gamma')$ (the base becomes slightly shallower to compensate for the added central concentration). What remains is

$$\left.\frac{\delta\alpha_\bullet}{\alpha_0}\right|_{\rm ring+slope} = f_\bullet\big[u^p - 1 - p\ln u\big], \qquad u \equiv \frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{\theta}, \quad p \equiv 3-\gamma', \tag{23.22}$$

which is second order in $\ln(\theta/\theta_{\rm E})$ near the ring (it starts as $\frac{1}{2}f_\bullet p^2\ln^2 u$) and grows as $f_\bullet u^p$ inside. The point-mass signature that survives a reasonable fit is concentrated in the inner region. A convenient reference radius is the radial critical curve of the base,

$$\theta_r = \theta_{\rm E}\,(2-\gamma')^{1/(\gamma'-1)} \qquad (1<\gamma'<2), \tag{23.23}$$

where $1-\alpha_0' = 0$ and near which radial and central images form; $\theta_r = 0.25\,\theta_{\rm E}$ for $\gamma' = 1.5$. A point mass can remove this curve altogether: at $\gamma' = 1.5$ any $f_\bullet > 27/4096 \approx 0.0066$ does so (Chapter 19, Eq. (19.19)), and the inner residual then falls on the central and point-mass-induced images instead. The radial ordering below does not depend on which.

23.8.2 The multipole

In κ, the multipole cannot be absorbed by $\theta_{\rm E}$, γ' or any other monopole parameter, because it averages to zero on every circle (Theorem 23.5.1). A fit sees only the arcs, so the absorption is limited to the partial-arc overlap of Eq. (23.19), and it disappears once the multipole is modelled. Its fractional deflection is radius-independent (Eq. (23.11)), so its absolute deflection is $\propto \theta^{2-\gamma'}$ and is largest where the tangential arcs are, near and outside $\theta_{\rm E}$. Its ratio between two radii is $(\theta_{\rm in}/\theta_{\rm out})^{2-\gamma'}$.

23.8.3 A worked comparison

Take $\gamma' = 1.5$, a central point mass with $f_\bullet = 0.01$ (ring and slope matched) and an $m = 4$ multipole with $a_4 = 0.01$ (peak over φ). Evaluate $|\delta\alpha|/\theta_{\rm E}$ at the base's radial critical curve $\theta_r = 0.25\,\theta_{\rm E}$ (this $f_\bullet$ exceeds $27/4096$, so the composite lens itself has no radial critical curve) and in the arc region at $1.2\,\theta_{\rm E}$. This is a linearised toy (source fixed, first order in $f_\bullet$ and a_m); the numbers illustrate the radial ordering, not any particular lens.

	$\theta = \theta_r = 0.25\,\theta_{\rm E}$ (base)	$\theta = 1.2\,\theta_{\rm E}$	inner/outer
point mass, $f_\bullet = 0.01$ (ring + slope matched)	0.0246	3.75×10^{-4}	65.7
$m = 4$ multipole, $a_4 = 0.01$	0.00218	0.00478	0.456
point mass / multipole	11.3	0.078	

The two perturbations have opposite radial orderings. The multipole dominates for $0.58 \lesssim \theta/\theta_{\rm E} \lesssim 2.1$, which is where tangential arcs live; the point mass dominates inside, where the radial images live. Figure 23.2 shows the full radial profiles. (Far outside the ring the point-mass curve rises again; that is a smooth monopole term which any model with more radial freedom than a single power-law slope would absorb, and few lensed pixels sit there.)

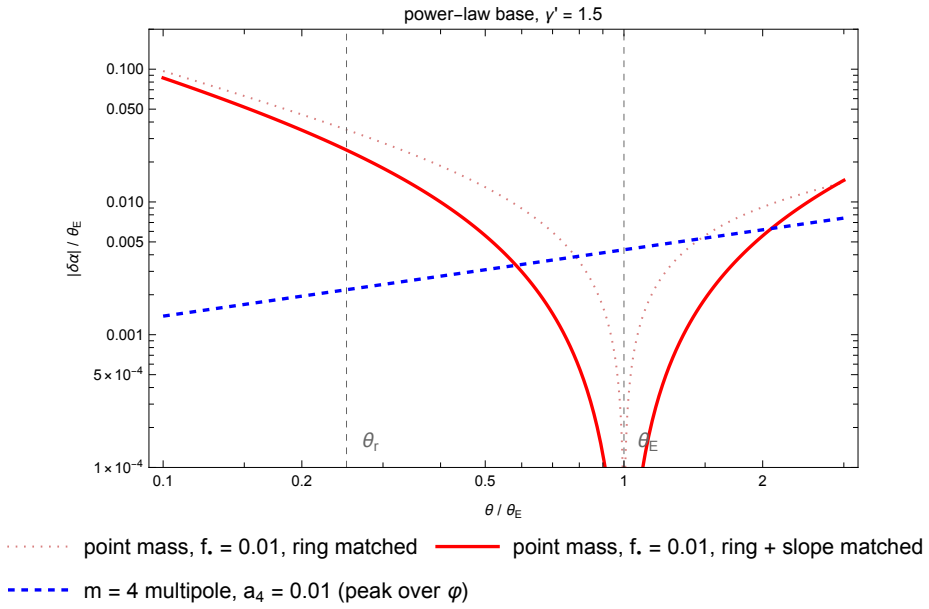


Figure 23.2: Deflection perturbation $|\delta\alpha|/\theta_{\rm E}$ versus radius on a $\gamma' = 1.5$ power-law base. Dotted: central point mass with $f_\bullet = 0.01$, base renormalised to keep the Einstein ring fixed (Eq. (23.21)). Solid red: the same after the slope is also re-fitted (Eq. (23.22)); the residual is now second order at $\theta_{\rm E}$ and concentrated inside. Dashed blue: an $m = 4$ multipole with $a_4 = 0.01$, peak over φ (Eq. (23.11)), rising outward as $\theta^{1/2}$. Vertical lines mark the radial critical curve θ_r of the base and the Einstein radius. Generated by `multipoles_power_law.wl`.

The residual-map discriminator

The two hypotheses misfit in opposite places and with opposite angular structure. An omitted central mass leaves an inner, azimuthally uniform ($m = 0$) residual, in the inner image region (at the radial critical curve if the lens still has one, otherwise at the central images), whereas omitted azimuthal structure leaves an outer residual with a $\cos m\varphi$ pattern and zero azimuthal mean, in the tangential arcs. A global χ^2 cannot

tell the two apart; the residual map, split at a radius between θ_r and $\theta_{\rm E}$ and examined for its angular pattern, can. A "central mass" whose inclusion mainly improves the outer residual is not a central-mass signal.

23.9 The Dipole Resonance

The denominator $m^2-(3-\gamma')^2$ in Eqs. (23.7)–(23.9) vanishes when $m=3-\gamma'$. For integer m and $1<\gamma'<3$ the only case is $m=1$, $\gamma'=2$ (isothermal). There the trial function $\theta^{3-\gamma'}\cos\Delta\varphi = \theta\cos\Delta\varphi$ is a linear function of position, hence harmonic ($\nabla^2=0$, zero convergence), and its gradient is a uniform deflection. A uniform deflection translates the source plane and is unobservable [16, §4.1.3]. The divergent amplitude is the usual signature of driving a homogeneous solution: no finite potential of this power-law form produces an $m=1$ convergence at $\gamma'=2$.

Remark 23.9.1 (The dipole is poorly conditioned). For $\gamma'<2$ the $m=1$ mode is finite, but its potential has the opposite sign to the $m\geq 2$ modes and its response is large: $m^2-(3-\gamma')^2=-1.25$ at $\gamma'=1.5$ and -0.21 at $\gamma'=1.9$. Much of that response is a nearly uniform deflection, i.e. nearly a source shift. Lopsidedness is therefore weakly constrained for near-isothermal lenses, in line with the remark in §12.4.3 that the dipole is nearly degenerate with the source position. A fit that includes $m=1$ should expect strong correlations with the source position.

23.10 Summary

A single multipole on a power-law base, $\kappa_m=\frac{1}{2}k_m(\theta_{\rm E}/\theta)^{\gamma'-1}\cos[m(\varphi-\varphi_m)]$, has the closed-form potential $\psi_m=-k_m\theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma'-1}\theta^{3-\gamma'}\cos m\Delta\varphi/[m^2-(3-\gamma')^2]$ (Eq. (23.7)); its deflection is Eqs. (23.8)–(23.9), and its fractional deflection is independent of radius. The fractional density amplitude is $a_m=k_m/(3-\gamma')$ and the isophotal deviation is $\varepsilon_m=a_m/(\gamma'-1)$; a_m must always be derived from a code's own amplitude definition.

A multipole with $m\geq 1$ encloses zero mass at every radius, whereas a central point mass is a pure monopole. They are orthogonal in κ but not in a likelihood evaluated on partial arcs (overlap $\sin m\Delta/(m\Delta)$), so an omitted multipole can masquerade as a central mass, a specification error that disappears when the multipole is modelled. To first order the tangential critical curve moves by Eq. (23.20): $\delta\theta_c=a_m\theta_{\rm E}\cos m\Delta\varphi$ at $\gamma'=2$, amplified by $\sim 1/(\gamma'-1)$ at shallow slopes, with zero azimuthal mean. The residual diagnostic is that an omitted central mass misfits the inner region with an azimuthally uniform residual, while an omitted multipole misfits the outer arcs with a $\cos m\varphi$ residual. The $m=1$, $\gamma'=2$ case is a resonance with the source translation, and the dipole is poorly constrained near isothermal.

23.11 Problems

Exercise 23.11.1. (Potential, deflection and response.) Verify that ψ_m of Eq. (23.7) satisfies $\nabla^2\psi_m = 2\kappa_m$ with κ_m from Eq. (23.4), and that its gradient reproduces Eqs. (23.8)–(23.9). Show that $|\boldsymbol{\alpha}_m|/\alpha_0$ is independent of θ and evaluate its maximum, Eq. (23.11), for $m = 3$ and $m = 4$ at $\gamma' = 1.40$ and 1.50 with $a_m = 0.01$. Which order perturbs the deflection more at fixed a_m, and how does the response scale with m at large m?

Exercise 23.11.2. (Isophotal translation.) Derive $a_m = (\gamma' - 1)\varepsilon_m$, Eq. (23.16), for contours $\theta_{\rm iso} = \theta_0[1 + \varepsilon_m \cos m\Delta\varphi]$, stating where you linearise and giving the first neglected term. Evaluate ε_m for $a_m \in \{0.01, 0.03\}$ at $\gamma' \in \{1.40, 1.50, 2.00\}$. Which regime demands the larger geometric distortion for the same lensing signal?

Exercise 23.11.3. (Zero enclosed mass and partial arcs.) (a) Prove Theorem 23.5.1 and the orthogonality relation Eq. (23.18). (b) Show that the point-mass deflection has no Fourier content at $m \geq 1$. (c) Derive Eq. (23.19) and evaluate the absorbed fraction for an $m = 4$ residual over arcs of half-width $\Delta = \pi/8$, $\pi/6$, $\pi/4$ and π. Use the result to explain how a model without angular freedom can "detect" a central mass that is not there.

Exercise 23.11.4. (Critical-curve shift.) (a) Show that for the power-law base the eigenvalues at $\theta_{\rm E}$ are $\lambda_t = 0$ and $\lambda_r = \gamma' - 1$, and that $\partial_\theta \lambda_t|_{\theta_{\rm E}} = (\gamma' - 1)/\theta_{\rm E}$. (b) Derive Eq. (23.20). (c) Evaluate its coefficient for $m = 3, 4$ at $\gamma' = 1.5$ and 2. (d) Show that the area enclosed by the critical curve is unchanged at first order. (e) Repeat for a central point mass on a fixed base and show $\delta\theta_c/\theta_{\rm E} = f_\bullet/(\gamma' - 1)$.

Exercise 23.11.5. (The inner/outer discriminator.) (a) Derive Eq. (23.21). (b) Show that near the ring it has the same shape as a slope change at fixed $\theta_{\rm E}$ and that $\delta\gamma' = -f_\bullet(3-\gamma')$ cancels the linear term, leaving Eq. (23.22). (c) Reproduce the numbers in the table of §23.8. (d) Describe the azimuthal structure of each residual and say how you would use a residual map to tell the two apart.

Exercise 23.11.6. (Bookkeeping.) A code parameterises a multipole by the components of Eq. (23.13). (a) A paper reports $a_4 = 0.01$ at $\varphi_4 = 30°$ for a $\gamma' = 1.5$ lens. What (ϵ_1, ϵ_2) should you set? Invert your answer to check it. (b) A colleague sets $|\boldsymbol{\epsilon}| = 0.01$ believing that to be "a 1% multipole". What a_4 did they inject at $\gamma' = 1.5$ and at $\gamma' = 1.4$, and by what fraction is it low? (c) Show that φ_m is defined only modulo $2\pi/m$ and that $\varphi_m \to \varphi_m + \pi/m$ is equivalent to $k_m \to -k_m$.

Exercise 23.11.7. (The dipole resonance.) (a) Show that $m^2 = (3 - \gamma')^2$ has the single solution $m = 1$, $\gamma' = 2$ for integer $m \geq 1$ and $1 < \gamma' < 3$, and that $\theta\cos(\varphi - \varphi_1)$ is harmonic with a uniform gradient. (b) Evaluate $m^2 - (3 - \gamma')^2$ for $m = 1$ at $\gamma' = 1.4$, 1.5 and 1.9. (c) For $m < 3 - \gamma'$ the maximum of Eq. (23.11) is at $\cos m\Delta\varphi = \pm 1$; evaluate the peak $|\boldsymbol{\alpha}_1|/\alpha_0$ for $a_1 = 0.01$ at $\gamma' = 1.5$ and 1.9, and comment on what most of that deflection does to the images.

Chapter 24

Cosmological Sensitivity of Compound-Lens Ratios

A double-source-plane lens (DSPL) turns the image geometry of a single deflector into one number, the distance ratio $\mathcal{B}$ of Chapter 18. That number depends on cosmology only through angular-diameter distances, and it does not depend on the Hubble constant at all [13]. Chapter 21 showed how a mass-model error, such as an unmodelled central mass, shifts the inferred ratio by a fractional amount $\Delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}$. This chapter takes the next step and asks what such a shift does to the inferred cosmological parameters.

The obvious answer is to divide by a sensitivity, $\Delta w = (\Delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B})/S_w$. That is a one-dimensional projection of a multi-dimensional problem. A single DSPL constrains one combination of $(\Omega_\mathrm{m}, w_0, w_a)$, so a bias is a direction in parameter space, and the number one quotes for Δw depends on which other parameters were held fixed. Compound lenses with more than two source planes add a second subtlety: one inner-profile error enters every plane at once, so the per-plane biases are coherent and do not average down like noise. Finally, a bias has to be told apart from a degeneracy. Removing a datum from the fit does not shift the answer; it gives up part of the constraint, and it must not be propagated as if it were a small shift.

The chapter therefore shows how to compute $\mathcal{B}$ and its Jacobian for any flat dark-energy cosmology, why one DSPL constrains a direction in $(\Omega_\mathrm{m}, w_0, w_a)$ and what that implies for quoted single-parameter biases, how coherent systematics across planes and lenses differ from independent ones, and how a degeneracy is told from a bias.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `cosmological_sensitivity.wl`, with in-script flat CPL distances; $\mathcal{B}$ and its H_0 independence; the Jacobian by two independent routes; rank, blind direction and projections; the N-plane coherence identity; dynamic range of $\mathcal{B}$; exports both figures
- `problems_20.wl`, the worked solutions to the Problems, with an independent implementation of the distances

24.1 Why a Scalar Is Not Enough

The inference chain of a galaxy-scale DSPL analysis (Chapters 18 and 19) is

$$\text{image positions} \;\longrightarrow\; \eta = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}^{(1)}}{\theta_{\rm E}^{(2)}} \;\longrightarrow\; \mathcal{B} = \eta^{\,\gamma'-1} \;\longrightarrow\; (\Omega_{\rm m}, w_0, w_a), \tag{24.1}$$

where $\theta_{\rm E}^{(i)}$ is the Einstein radius for source plane i and γ' the three-dimensional density slope of a power-law deflector. The last arrow is usually closed with a single number,

$$S_w \equiv \left.\frac{\partial \ln \mathcal{B}}{\partial w}\right|_{\Omega_{\rm m}} \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad \Delta w = \frac{\Delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}}{S_w}. \tag{24.2}$$

Equation (24.2) is correct, but it answers a narrower question than the one we want. It presumes (i) a single distance ratio, (ii) all other cosmological parameters held fixed, and (iii) a bias small enough that a first-order expansion holds. A real compound-lens cosmography can violate all three: it may use several source planes, it marginalises over $\Omega_{\rm m}$ (and possibly over a time-varying dark-energy equation of state), and some mass-model failures produce excursions much larger than a linear expansion tolerates.

What we need is the map from a vector of per-plane ratio errors to a displacement in parameter space, together with the direction along which that displacement is unconstrained.

Notation for this chapter

$\boldsymbol{p} = (p_1, p_2, p_3) = (\Omega_{\rm m}, w_0, w_a)$ is the cosmological parameter vector; the universe is spatially flat. The deflector is at z_d and the sources at $z_1 < z_2 < \cdots < z_N$. Index $i = 2, \ldots, N$ labels the ratio $\mathcal{B}_i$ of plane 1 to plane i. The quantity $\delta_i \equiv \Delta \ln \mathcal{B}_i \simeq \Delta\mathcal{B}_i/\mathcal{B}_i$ is the fractional error in $\mathcal{B}_i$ induced by the mass model. It is a systematic offset, not a measurement uncertainty.

24.2 The Ratio $\mathcal{B}$ in a Dark-Energy Cosmology

24.2.1 The CPL equation of state

Chapter 7 treated dark energy with a constant equation of state w, for which the fluid equation gives $\rho \propto a^{-3(1+w)}$ (eq. 7.33). To test whether dark energy evolves, the standard two-parameter extension is the Chevallier–Polarski–Linder (CPL) form [12, 26]

$$w(a) = w_0 + w_a\,(1-a) \qquad \Longleftrightarrow \qquad w(z) = w_0 + w_a\,\frac{z}{1+z}, \tag{24.3}$$

using $a = 1/(1+z)$ (eq. 7.37). Here w_0 is the present-day value and w_a controls the evolution: $w \to w_0 + w_a$ at high redshift. The cosmological constant is $(w_0, w_a) = (-1, 0)$.

With a time-dependent w the fluid equation $\mathrm{d}\ln\rho/\mathrm{d}\ln a = -3[1 + w(a)]$ no longer integrates to a single power. Writing $\rho_{\rm DE}(z) = \rho_{\rm DE,0}\,\zeta(z)$,

$$\zeta(z) = \exp\left[3\int_0^z \frac{1+w(z')}{1+z'}\,\mathrm{d}z'\right] = (1+z)^{3(1+w_0+w_a)}\exp\left(-\frac{3w_a z}{1+z}\right). \tag{24.4}$$

In a flat universe the expansion rate is then

$$E^2(z) \equiv \frac{H^2(z)}{H_0^2} = \Omega_{\rm m}(1+z)^3 + (1-\Omega_{\rm m})\,\zeta(z), \tag{24.5}$$

which reduces to the concordance form, eq. (7.39), for $\Omega_{\rm m} = 0.3$ and $\zeta \equiv 1$, and satisfies $E(0) = 1$ for every $(\Omega_{\rm m}, w_0, w_a)$.

24.2.2 $\mathcal{B}$ is a ratio of comoving distances

Following Chapter 18,

$$\mathcal{B} \equiv \frac{D_{{\rm d}s_1}\, D_{s_2}}{D_{s_1}\, D_{{\rm d}s_2}} = \frac{D_{{\rm d}s_1}/D_{s_1}}{D_{{\rm d}s_2}/D_{s_2}} \;<\; 1, \tag{24.6}$$

the ratio of the lensing efficiencies of the nearer and farther source planes. Every distance in eq. (24.6) is a flat-universe angular-diameter distance, eqs. (7.43) and (7.46): $D_s = \chi_s/(1+z_s)$ and $D_{\rm ds} = (\chi_s - \chi_d)/(1+z_s)$, with

$$\chi(z) = \frac{c}{H_0}\int_0^z \frac{{\rm d}z'}{E(z')}. \tag{24.7}$$

Substituting, the $(1+z)$ factors cancel pairwise and

$$\boxed{\mathcal{B} = \frac{1-\chi_d/\chi_1}{1-\chi_d/\chi_2}} \tag{24.8}$$

Two properties follow at once. First, $\mathcal{B}$ involves only ratios of comoving distances, so the Hubble distance c/H_0 cancels: $\mathcal{B}$ is independent of H_0. Second, $\mathcal{B} \to 1$ as $z_2 \to z_1$, so the cosmological signal vanishes when the two source planes approach each other.

GR reminder — Computing $\mathcal{B}$ in practice

A fitting formula for $\mathcal{B}$ should not be used. The cosmology is written as a callable function, $1/E$ is integrated numerically, and eq. (24.8) is formed directly. The companion script does this in a few lines, checks it against an independent ΛCDM implementation, and proves symbolically that c/H_0 drops out.

24.3 The Sensitivity Jacobian

24.3.1 Definition

For a fixed geometry $\{z_d; z_1, \ldots, z_N\}$ define the *sensitivity Jacobian*

$$J_{ij}(\boldsymbol{p}) \equiv \left.\frac{\partial \ln \mathcal{B}_i}{\partial p_j}\right|_{\boldsymbol{p}}, \qquad i = 2, \ldots, N, \quad j = 1, 2, 3. \tag{24.9}$$

Each row is the response of one observable to cosmology; each column is the imprint of one parameter across the planes. For a single DSPL, J is the row vector $(S_{\Omega_{\rm m}}, S_{w_0}, S_{w_a})$, and S_w of eq. (24.2) is its middle entry.

24.3.2 Two ways to compute it

Finite differences. Evaluate $\ln\mathcal{B}$ at $p_j \pm h$ with the other parameters fixed and take $[\ln\mathcal{B}(p_j+h) - \ln\mathcal{B}(p_j-h)]/2h$. The truncation error is $\mathcal{O}(h^2)$; combining steps h and $h/2$ (Richardson extrapolation) removes the leading term.

Differentiating under the integral. From eq. (24.7),

$$\frac{\partial\chi(z)}{\partial p_j} = -\frac{c}{2H_0}\int_0^z \frac{1}{E^3(z')}\,\frac{\partial E^2(z')}{\partial p_j}\,\mathrm{d}z', \tag{24.10}$$

and from eq. (24.8), $\ln\mathcal{B} = \ln(\chi_1-\chi_d) - \ln\chi_1 + \ln\chi_2 - \ln(\chi_2-\chi_d)$, so

$$\frac{\partial\ln\mathcal{B}}{\partial p_j} = \frac{\chi_1'-\chi_d'}{\chi_1-\chi_d} - \frac{\chi_1'}{\chi_1} + \frac{\chi_2'}{\chi_2} - \frac{\chi_2'-\chi_d'}{\chi_2-\chi_d}, \qquad \chi' \equiv \frac{\partial\chi}{\partial p_j}. \tag{24.11}$$

The derivatives of E^2 needed in eq. (24.10) are elementary: $\partial E^2/\partial\Omega_\mathrm{m} = (1+z)^3 - \zeta$, $\partial E^2/\partial w_0 = 3(1-\Omega_\mathrm{m})\zeta\ln(1+z)$ and $\partial E^2/\partial w_a = 3(1-\Omega_\mathrm{m})\zeta[\ln(1+z) - z/(1+z)]$.

The two routes share nothing but $E(z)$, so their agreement is a real check. The companion script finds agreement to better than 10^{-10} after Richardson extrapolation.

24.3.3 An illustrative geometry

Throughout this chapter we use the illustrative configuration

$$z_d = 0.5, \qquad z_1 = 1.0, \qquad z_2 = 2.0, \qquad \boldsymbol{p}_0 = (\Omega_\mathrm{m}, w_0, w_a) = (0.3, -1, 0),$$

which is not meant to represent any particular observed system. There $\mathcal{B} = 0.674156$ and

$$J = (S_{\Omega_\mathrm{m}},\, S_{w_0},\, S_{w_a}) = (-0.03569,\ -0.03301,\ -0.007255), \qquad 1/S_{w_0} = -30.29. \tag{24.12}$$

All three entries are negative: raising Ω_m, w_0 or w_a lowers $\mathcal{B}$. The scalar formula (24.2) would therefore convert a 1% ratio error into $|\Delta w_0| = 0.30$ at fixed Ω_m and w_a. The rest of the chapter is about what that number does and does not mean.

24.4 From a Model Error to a Parameter Displacement

Suppose the mass model biases the inferred log-ratios by δ_i. To first order the inferred parameters move by whatever $\Delta\boldsymbol{p}$ reproduces those offsets:

$$J\,\Delta\boldsymbol{p} = \boldsymbol{\delta}. \tag{24.13}$$

If the analysis carries a covariance C on the $\ln\mathcal{B}_i$, the fit minimises $\chi^2 = (J\Delta\boldsymbol{p}-\boldsymbol{\delta})^\mathsf{T} C^{-1}(J\Delta\boldsymbol{p}-\boldsymbol{\delta})$. Setting its gradient to zero gives the generalised least-squares solution, and hence the induced bias

$$\boxed{\Delta\boldsymbol{p} = \left(J^\mathsf{T}C^{-1}J\right)^{-1}J^\mathsf{T}C^{-1}\,\boldsymbol{\delta}} \tag{24.14}$$

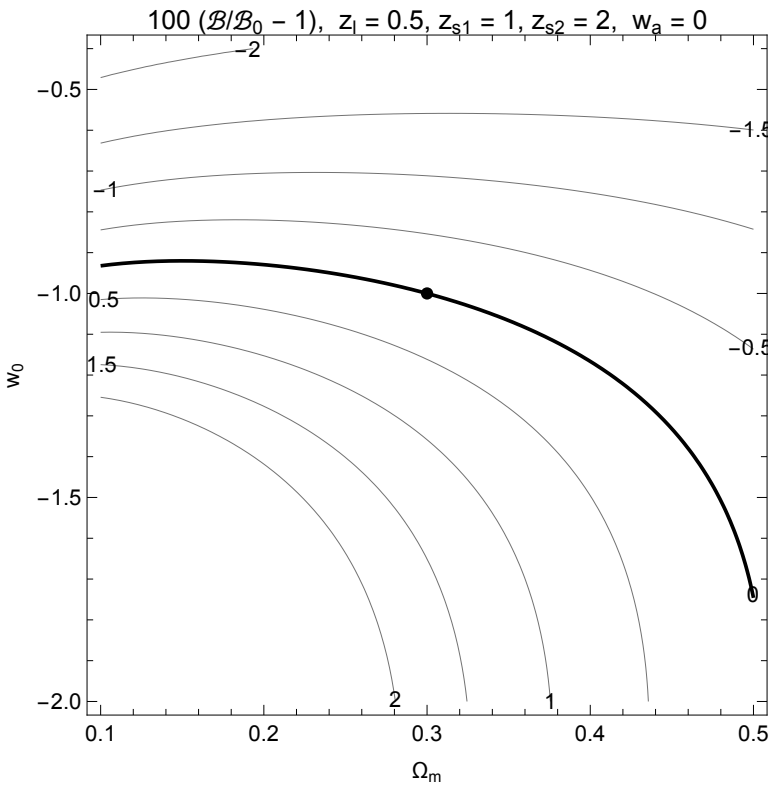


Figure 24.1: Contours of $100\,(\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}_0 - 1)$, the percentage change of $\mathcal{B}$ relative to its value at $(\Omega_{\rm m}, w_0) = (0.3, -1)$ (black dot), for the illustrative geometry $z_d = 0.5$, $z_1 = 1$, $z_2 = 2$ with $w_a = 0$. The thick contour is $\mathcal{B} = \mathcal{B}_0$: every cosmology on it reproduces the same ratio. Note the small dynamic range (a few per cent over the whole panel) and the curvature of the contours, which makes $\mathcal{B}$ non-monotonic in w_0 (§24.7). Generated by `cosmological_sensitivity.wl`.

The matrix $F = J^{\mathsf{T}} C^{-1} J$ is the Fisher matrix of the measurement, and F^{-1} is the covariance of the statistical errors. Equation (24.14) says that the same F^{-1} also converts a systematic offset into a parameter shift. When J is square and invertible, eq. (24.14) reduces to $\Delta\boldsymbol{p} = J^{-1}\boldsymbol{\delta}$ and C drops out.

Two consequences deserve explicit statement. First, direction matters as much as magnitude: $\Delta\boldsymbol{p}$ inherits the orientation of the poorly constrained eigendirections of F, so a systematic that projects onto a well-constrained direction is comparatively harmless, while the same magnitude along a degenerate direction is not. Second, rank governs everything: if J has fewer rows than there are parameters (one DSPL, three parameters), F is singular and eq. (24.14) has no unique solution, and the bias is then a ray, not a point.

24.5 One Source-Plane Pair: The Answer Is a Direction

24.5.1 Rank and the blind direction

With one DSPL, J is a single row and $F = \sigma^{-2} J^{\mathsf{T}} J$ is the outer product of one vector with itself. Its rank is 1 whatever σ is. In the full $(\Omega_{\rm m}, w_0, w_a)$ space the null space is

two-dimensional, and in the $(\Omega_{\rm m}, w_0)$ plane it is the single direction

$$\boldsymbol{n} \propto (S_{w_0},\, -S_{\Omega_{\rm m}}), \qquad J \cdot \boldsymbol{n} = 0. \tag{24.15}$$

Moving the cosmology along $\boldsymbol{n}$ does not change $\mathcal{B}$ to first order: $\boldsymbol{n}$ is the tangent to the contour $\mathcal{B} = \mathcal{B}_0$ in Figure 24.1. Parametrising directions in the $(\Omega_{\rm m}, w_0)$ plane as $\mathrm{d}\Omega_{\rm m} = c\,\mathrm{d}w_0$, the null direction corresponds to

$$c_\star = -\frac{S_{w_0}}{S_{\Omega_{\rm m}}}, \tag{24.16}$$

which is $c_\star = -0.925$ at the illustrative geometry. We call $(c_\star, 1)$ the *blind direction* of the system. The companion script confirms numerically that a step along it changes $\ln \mathcal{B}$ only at second order: for a step of 0.01 the response is about 4% of the response to the same step along w_0, and it halves when the step is halved.

24.5.2 The bias ray

With one equation $J \cdot \Delta\boldsymbol{p} = \delta$ and two or three unknowns, any direction $\hat{\boldsymbol{u}}$ with $J \cdot \hat{\boldsymbol{u}} \neq 0$ provides a solution:

$$\Delta\boldsymbol{p} = \frac{\delta}{J \cdot \hat{\boldsymbol{u}}}\, \hat{\boldsymbol{u}}. \tag{24.17}$$

Choosing $\hat{\boldsymbol{u}}$ is a modelling assumption. Taking $\hat{\boldsymbol{u}} = \hat{\boldsymbol{e}}_{w_0}$, which amounts to declaring $\Omega_{\rm m}$ (and w_a) known, recovers eq. (24.2) exactly: $\Delta w_0 = \delta / S_{w_0}$.

In a real analysis $\hat{\boldsymbol{u}}$ is usually decided by another probe. Suppose an external data set (supernovae, baryon acoustic oscillations, the CMB) constrains the combination $\Omega_{\rm m} - c\,w_0$ and is itself blind along $\mathrm{d}\Omega_{\rm m} = c\,\mathrm{d}w_0$. Minimising the joint χ^2 of the DSPL and the external probe, both centred on the truth, gives

$$\boxed{\Delta w_0 = \frac{\delta}{S_{w_0} + c\, S_{\Omega_{\rm m}}}, \qquad \Delta\Omega_{\rm m} = c\,\Delta w_0} \tag{24.18}$$

independent of how precise the external probe is. The case $c = 0$, an $\Omega_{\rm m}$ prior centred on the truth, gives back δ / S_{w_0} and $\Delta\Omega_{\rm m} = 0$.

24.5.3 Is the fixed-$\Omega_{\rm m}$ number a bound?

Equation (24.18) is a function of c with a pole at $c = c_\star$, where the external probe and the DSPL are blind along the same line. Relative to the fixed-$\Omega_{\rm m}$ value it is larger by the *amplification factor*

$$\mathcal{A}(c) = \left| \frac{S_{w_0}}{S_{w_0} + c\, S_{\Omega_{\rm m}}} \right|. \tag{24.19}$$

At the illustrative geometry $\mathcal{A}(-\tfrac{1}{2}) = 2.18$ and $\mathcal{A}(+\tfrac{1}{2}) = 0.649$. For a 1% ratio error this means $|\Delta w_0| = 0.659$ at $c = -\tfrac{1}{2}$, 0.303 at $c = 0$ and 0.197 at $c = +\tfrac{1}{2}$. Since $\mathcal{A} \geq 1$ exactly when $|S_{w_0} + c S_{\Omega_{\rm m}}| \leq |S_{w_0}|$, the fixed-$\Omega_{\rm m}$ number is a lower bound on the bias only for

$$c \in [\,2c_\star,\ 0\,] \qquad (= [-1.850,\ 0] \text{ here}), \tag{24.20}$$

that is, only when the external degeneracy tilts toward the DSPL's own blind direction. Outside that interval, marginalising reduces the bias. As $c \to c_\star$ the bias grows without limit: at $c = 0.99\,c_\star$ it is already more than fifty times the fixed-Ω_m value.

What the fixed-Ω_m number is, and is not

$\Delta w_0 = \delta/S_{w_0}$ is the bias projected onto w_0 under a perfect Ω_m prior. It is not a bound on the bias of a marginalised analysis in either direction: it is the single point $c = 0$ on a curve with a pole at the blind direction $c_\star$. It is a lower bound only when the other probes' degeneracy lies in $c \in [2c_\star, 0]$. The bias vector (eq. 24.14) should be reported together with the blind direction, and any single-parameter number labelled with the assumption that produced it.

There is a genuine bound, but it concerns statistical errors, not biases. For any Fisher matrix the variance of w_0 with Ω_m fixed, $1/F_{w_0w_0}$, never exceeds the marginalised variance $(F^{-1})_{w_0w_0}$. This is a property of every positive-definite matrix, not a statement about estimators. (The Cramér–Rao bound is the separate result that an unbiased estimator of w_0 has variance at least $(F^{-1})_{w_0w_0}$.) With an Ω_m prior of width σ_X the difference of the two variances is exactly $\sigma_X^2 S_{\Omega_\mathrm{m}}^2/S_{w_0}^2 \geq 0$. It is a common slip to carry the intuition that "fixing parameters always underestimates" from errors over to biases, where it does not hold.

24.5.4 Linear is only linear

Equation (24.18) is first order. Near the blind direction the first-order response $S_{w_0} + cS_{\Omega_\mathrm{m}}$ is small, so the second-order terms that bend the contours of Figure 24.1 take over sooner. Figure 24.2 makes this concrete for $\delta = +0.5\%$. Along $c = 0$ and $c = +\frac{1}{2}$ the exact solutions of $\mathcal{B}(\boldsymbol{p}_0 + t\,(c, 1)) = 1.005\,\mathcal{B}_0$ are $\Delta w_0 = -0.162$ and -0.091, close to the linear values -0.151 and -0.098. Along $c = -\frac{1}{2}$ the linear formula predicts $\Delta w_0 = -0.330$. In fact $\mathcal{B}$ rises by at most 0.09% along that ray before falling again, so no point on the ray absorbs a 0.5% error. There the linear formula returns a point that is not a solution of $\mathcal{B} = 1.005\,\mathcal{B}_0$.

24.5.5 Raising the rank

The rank can only be raised by an observable whose row of J is not parallel to the DSPL row. There are three options: a time delay in the same system, which measures the time-delay distance $D_{\Delta t} = (1 + z_d)D_\mathrm{d}D_\mathrm{s}/D_\mathrm{ds}$ (eq. 13.22), a different combination of the same distances that also depends on H_0; an external probe in the same likelihood, as above; or a second lens at a different z_d, or a third source plane, each of which adds a row (but see §24.6 for how much it helps). More images of the same source planes do not raise the rank: they sharpen σ but leave J unchanged.

One further caution applies to every option. $\mathcal{B}$ is never observed directly; it is inferred through a mass model, and a multi-plane generalisation of the mass-sheet transformation can trade a change in the mass model for a change in the inferred cosmology [38]. Raising the rank of J does not by itself break that second degeneracy.

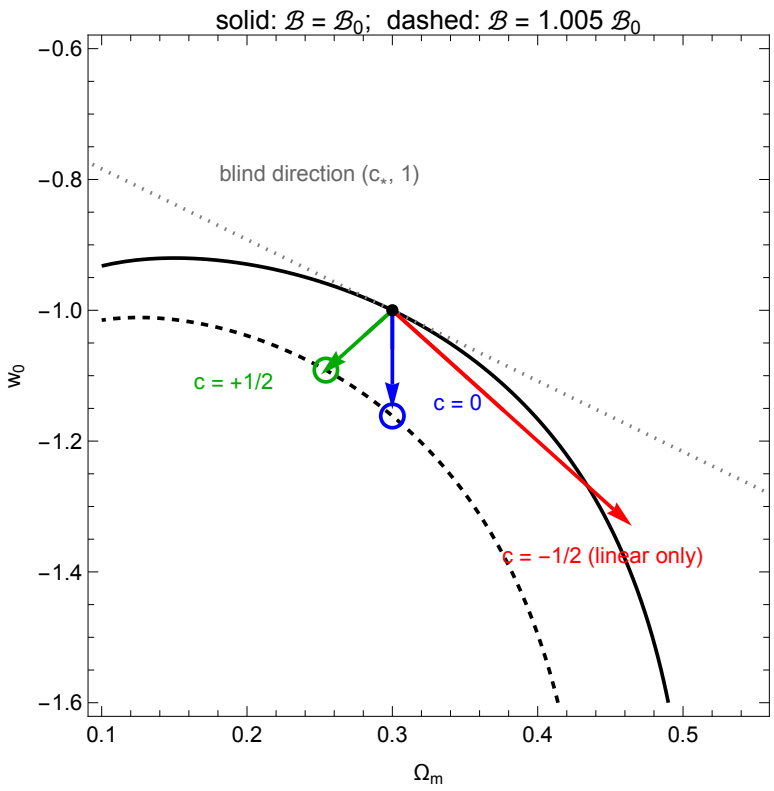


Figure 24.2: The bias as a direction. Solid: the contour $\mathcal{B} = \mathcal{B}_0$ through the reference cosmology (dot) at the illustrative geometry ($w_a = 0$). Dashed: $\mathcal{B} = 1.005\,\mathcal{B}_0$, the locus to which a +0.5% ratio error moves the fit. Dotted: the blind direction $(c_\star, 1)$, tangent to the solid curve. Arrows: the linear bias vectors of eq. (24.18) for external degeneracies $c = 0$ (fixed Ω_m, blue), $c = +\frac{1}{2}$ (green) and $c = -\frac{1}{2}$ (red). Open circles: the exact solutions on the first two rays. The red ray never reaches the dashed curve. Generated by `cosmological_sensitivity.wl`.

24.6 Many Planes: Coherence, Not Averaging

A compound lens with $N > 2$ source planes yields $N - 1$ ratios. It is tempting to treat them as $N - 1$ independent measurements whose errors average down. Two facts make that wrong, and both push the same way.

24.6.1 The rows of J are nearly parallel

All $\mathcal{B}_i$ share the deflector redshift and the distance–redshift relation; their responses to Ω_m and w_0 differ only through the lever arm in z_i. Add a third source at $z_3 = 3$ to the illustrative system. The ratio of plane 1 to plane 3 has $\mathcal{B}_3 = 0.6095$ and row $(-0.0600,\ -0.0456,\ -0.0114)$, with the same sign pattern as the first row. In the (Ω_m, w_0) plane the two rows are only 5.5° apart, and the 2×2 Jacobian has condition number 22.7. Nearly parallel rows make F ill-conditioned. The extra plane does raise the rank, but it constrains the old blind direction only weakly, and a systematic that points along that direction is amplified by the large eigenvalue of F^{-1}.

24.6.2 The model error is one error

A single deflector with an incorrectly modelled interior produces one physical error, one wrong inner profile, which propagates into every source plane. Take the case of Chapter 21: a power-law deflector plus a central point mass, characterised on plane i by the central-mass fraction $m_i = \theta_\bullet^{(i)\,2}/\theta_{\rm E}^{(i)\,2}$. The per-plane fractions obey

$$\boxed{m_i = m_1\,\mathcal{B}_i^{(3-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)}} \tag{24.21}$$

for every i, where $\mathcal{B}_i$ is the ratio of plane 1 to plane i.

For $1 < \gamma' < 3$ the exponent is positive, and $0 < \mathcal{B}_i < 1$, so $0 < m_i < m_1$: farther planes feel a weaker but same-signed perturbation. The δ_i are therefore not independent draws; they form a deterministic family driven by one amplitude. Write $\delta_i = m_1 r_i$ with response vector $r_i \equiv \partial \ln \mathcal{B}_i/\partial m_1$. The m_i share a sign, but the δ_i share a sign only if the r_i do. Chapter 25 derives r_i and shows that the responses share a sign in the baseline where the images on every plane respond equally strongly to the central mass; a plane whose image lies close enough to the centre can reverse the sign of its r_i. Then eq. (24.14) becomes

$$\Delta\boldsymbol{p} = m_1\big(J^{\mathsf{T}}C^{-1}J\big)^{-1}J^{\mathsf{T}}C^{-1}\boldsymbol{r}. \tag{24.22}$$

Whether the planes reinforce or partially cancel is decided by how $\boldsymbol{r}$ lines up with the poorly constrained eigendirections of F, which can be computed from the geometry.

24.6.3 Why coherent errors do not average as $1/\sqrt{n}$

The cleanest way to see the difference is a one-parameter fit (say w_0 with everything else fixed) to n ratios with equal variances. The estimator is $\Delta w_0 = \sum_i J_i\delta_i/\sum_i J_i^2$. Define the *per-plane bias* $b_i \equiv \delta_i/J_i$, the shift each ratio would produce on its own. Then

$$\Delta w_0 = \sum_i \omega_i\, b_i, \qquad \omega_i = \frac{J_i^2}{\sum_k J_k^2} > 0, \qquad \sum_i \omega_i = 1. \tag{24.23}$$

The combined bias is a weighted mean of the per-plane biases, so it lies between the smallest and the largest of them, for every n. When the b_i share a sign, as they do for a coherent error whenever the r_i and the J_i share a sign, adding planes cannot push the bias toward zero.

Compare independent errors of size δ on each ratio. The rms bias is then $\delta/\|J\|$. With equal $J_i = J$ this is $\delta/(J\sqrt{n})$, while a coherent error $\delta_i = \delta$ gives δ/J for every n. For unequal same-sign J_i the ratio of coherent to independent is $\sum_i J_i/\|J\|$, which lies between 1 and $\sqrt{n}$. Coherent errors never benefit from the $1/\sqrt{n}$.

The weighted-mean property belongs to the one-parameter fit. With $\Omega_{\rm m}$ free as well, the planes at $z = 2$ and $z = 3$ of the illustrative system give a square 2×2 Jacobian in $(\Omega_{\rm m}, w_0)$, and the bias is $J^{-1}\boldsymbol{\delta}$ (the covariance drops out). For an illustrative $\delta_i = 1\%$ on both ratios this gives $\Delta w_0 = -0.687$, more than twice the per-plane fixed-$\Omega_{\rm m}$ biases -0.303 and -0.219. The nearly parallel rows (5.5° apart) that make the system ill-conditioned also amplify the coherent bias.

Coherent systematics

In an N-plane compound lens a single inner-profile error enters all $N-1$ ratios through $m_i = m_1 \mathcal{B}_i^{(3-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)}$, with one sign. In a one-parameter fit the induced bias is a weighted mean of the per-plane biases (eq. 24.23), so it does not shrink as $1/\sqrt{N}$. With several free parameters it can be larger than any single-plane bias, because nearly parallel rows of J amplify it. A many-plane system is not automatically safer than a two-plane one: it is more precise, and therefore more exposed to a systematic that does not average away.

24.7 Degeneracy Versus Bias

24.7.1 Three things an analyst can do with the radial image

Chapters 20 and 21 discuss how a radial (central) image constrains the inner profile of the deflector. For cosmography the useful classification is by what the analyst does with that image, rather than by which mass profile is true:

1. *Masked*: the radial image is removed from the data vector.

2. *Included, rigid inner profile*: it is fitted with a single power law (no central mass, no break in slope).

3. *Included, flexible inner profile*: it is fitted with a model that lets the inner slope differ from the outer one.

Cases 2 and 3 produce biases: a definite offset δ that the linear machinery of §§24.4–24.6 can propagate (with the caveat of Figure 24.2). Case 3 is expected to have the smaller bias, because the extra freedom can absorb the inner structure that case 2 forces into the slope. Case 1 is different in kind.

24.7.2 Masking surrenders a constraint

With the radial image removed, the data no longer determine the inner slope, and $\mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}$ inherits that indeterminacy: a range of $(\gamma', \mathcal{B})$ pairs fits the remaining images equally well. Within that range $\mathcal{B}$ is not shifted by the data; it is not determined by them at all. The value an analyst reports is set by where their prior on γ' sits. Calling the width of that range a "bias" and pushing it through eq. (24.2) confuses two different objects.

That is the exact, noise-free limit. With noise, ellipticity and a finite prior, the remaining images usually still exclude part of the range, so the slope becomes prior-dominated rather than completely undetermined. In a quad the surviving images can keep γ' constrained but biased, which turns the masked case back into a bias of the kind in case 2.

A degeneracy is not a bias

A *bias* is a displacement: the data determine a value, and the value is wrong by δ. A *degeneracy* is a surrendered constraint: the data determine a set, or nearly so, and the reported point within it is chosen by a prior. Masking a feature that carried information creates a degeneracy. It is reported as the span of $\mathcal{B}$ allowed by the data, with the prior that selects within it named, and propagated non-linearly as a region in parameter space; it is never converted into a linearised Δw.

24.7.3 The model manifold is thin

There is a second, blunter reason not to linearise large offsets: no cosmology can absorb them. Figure 24.1 shows how little $\mathcal{B}$ moves. At the illustrative geometry, with $w_a = 0$, along $\Omega_\mathrm{m} = 0.3$ the ratio $\mathcal{B}$ is not monotonic in w_0: it peaks 1.81% above $\mathcal{B}_0$ near $w_0 = -2.2$ and falls on both sides. Over the box $\Omega_\mathrm{m} \in [0.2, 0.4]$, $w_0 \in [-2.5, -0.5]$ the fractional change stays within $[-1.7\%, +3.3\%]$ (grid evaluation). A fractional error of, say, 25% is therefore not a "large Δw". It lies far off the manifold of predictions, and no member of the model family reproduces it. A naive linearisation would return $|0.25/S_{w_0}| = 7.6$, a number with no meaning: it extrapolates a local derivative across an excursion over which $\mathcal{B}$ is not even monotonic. The correct statement is that the inferred $\mathcal{B}$ is inconsistent with the stated model family over the stated box. Freeing w_a keeps flat CPL far from 25%: over $\Omega_\mathrm{m} \in [0.20, 0.42]$, $w_0 \in [-8, -0.1]$, $w_a \in [-3, 3]$ the change stays within $[-3.4\%, +8.9\%]$ (grid evaluation). Both qualifiers still matter, because a more flexible $E(z)$ can reach larger excursions. A flat model with $w = -1$ below $z = 0.5$ and $w = +4$ above it, physically contrived but admissible as an $E(z)$, moves $\mathcal{B}$ by +30.5% at the illustrative geometry. "No cosmology fits" is a statement about a named family and a named box.

24.8 A Practical Recipe

For a given compound-lens system and a candidate mass-model systematic:

1. Write the cosmology as a callable $E(z; \boldsymbol{p})$ (eq. 24.5) and compute every $\mathcal{B}_i$ from eq. (24.8).

2. Compute J by finite differences and check it against eqs. (24.10)–(24.11). J belongs to the geometry; do not transport it to another system.

3. Find the blind direction(s): the null space of J, or the smallest-eigenvalue directions of F when $N > 2$.

4. Decide whether the systematic is a bias (case 2 or 3) or a degeneracy (case 1). Only biases go further.

5. Check that $|\delta|$ is well inside the dynamic range of $\mathcal{B}$, and that the probe combination being used is not close to the blind direction. If either check fails, solve $\mathcal{B}(\boldsymbol{p}) = \mathcal{B}_\mathrm{obs}$ non-linearly.

6. For coherent multi-plane errors, build $\boldsymbol{\delta}$ from the single amplitude via eq. (24.21) and propagate with eq. (24.22). Do not divide by $\sqrt{N}$.

7. Report $\Delta\boldsymbol{p}$ as a vector with the degeneracy direction shown, and give any single-parameter number with its projection labelled.

DSPL cosmography has gone from a forecast [13] to a first measurement on an observed system [15]. Every step from δ to $\Delta\boldsymbol{p}$ carries an assumption about directions in parameter space, and those assumptions need to be stated alongside the result.

24.9 Summary

With CPL dark energy, $w(a) = w_0 + w_a(1-a)$, the density factor is $\zeta(z) = (1+z)^{3(1+w_0+w_a)} e^{-3w_a z/(1+z)}$ and $E^2 = \Omega_\mathrm{m}(1+z)^3 + (1-\Omega_\mathrm{m})\zeta$. In a flat universe $\mathcal{B} = (1-\chi_d/\chi_1)/(1-\chi_d/\chi_2)$, a ratio of comoving distances, independent of H_0. The sensitivity Jacobian $J_{ij} = \partial \ln \mathcal{B}_i / \partial p_j$ can be computed by finite differences or by differentiating under the integral; at the illustrative geometry all entries are negative and S_{w_a} is several times smaller than S_{w_0}.

A ratio error $\boldsymbol{\delta}$ maps to $\Delta\boldsymbol{p} = F^{-1} J^\mathsf{T} C^{-1} \boldsymbol{\delta}$. With one DSPL F has rank 1, so the bias is a ray, fixed only by a choice of direction. With an external probe blind along $(c, 1)$, $\Delta w_0 = \delta/(S_{w_0} + c S_{\Omega_\mathrm{m}})$, which diverges at the blind direction $c_\star = -S_{w_0}/S_{\Omega_\mathrm{m}}$. The fixed-$\Omega_\mathrm{m}$ value is a lower bound only for $c \in [2c_\star, 0]$; for statistical errors, by contrast, fixing parameters always gives a lower bound. Near the blind direction the linear formula fails early, and can describe a solution that does not exist.

In an N-plane lens one inner-profile error enters every ratio through $m_i = m_1 \mathcal{B}_i^{(3-\gamma')/(\gamma'-1)}$. In a one-parameter fit the resulting bias is a weighted mean of per-plane biases and does not average as $1/\sqrt{N}$; with several free parameters it can exceed every single-plane bias. Masking a constraining feature creates a degeneracy, not a bias, and is reported as a span and the prior, not a linearised Δw. Offsets larger than the dynamic range of $\mathcal{B}$ mean that no cosmology in the stated family and box fits.

24.10 Problems

Exercise 24.10.1. (The CPL density.) (a) Starting from $\mathrm{d}\ln\rho/\mathrm{d}\ln a = -3[1 + w(a)]$ with $w(a) = w_0 + w_a(1-a)$, derive eq. (24.4). (b) Show that $\zeta(z) \to e^{-3w_a}(1+z)^{3(1+w_0+w_a)}$ as $z \to \infty$, and interpret the exponent. (c) Evaluate $\zeta(1)$ for $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.9, -0.3)$. (d) Explain why $|S_{w_a}|$ is much smaller than $|S_{w_0}|$ for galaxy-scale DSPLs.

Exercise 24.10.2. (Projection.) Show that eq. (24.17) with $\hat{\boldsymbol{u}} = \hat{\boldsymbol{e}}_{w_0}$ reproduces $\Delta w_0 = \delta/S_{w_0}$, and derive the expression when Ω_m moves along a fixed direction $\mathrm{d}\Omega_\mathrm{m} = c\,\mathrm{d}w_0$. At the illustrative geometry, compare $|\Delta w_0|$ for $\delta = 1\%$ at $c = 0, \pm\frac{1}{2}$. For which c is the fixed-Ω_m value a lower bound? Why is "marginalising always makes it worse" the wrong intuition here?

Exercise 24.10.3. (Rank.) For a single DSPL, show that $J^\mathsf{T} C^{-1} J$ has rank 1 and give its null direction in the (Ω_m, w_0) plane at the illustrative geometry. Name an observable that

raises the rank *without* adding a source plane, and check that its row is not parallel to the DSPL row.

Exercise 24.10.4. (Coherence.) Using eq. (24.21) with $\gamma' = 1.6$ and $\mathcal{B}_2 = 0.7$, compute m_2/m_1. If a third plane has $\mathcal{B}_3 = 0.5$ relative to plane 1, do the three central-mass fractions have the same sign? Use eq. (24.23) to argue whether the per-plane biases reinforce.

Exercise 24.10.5. (Non-linearity.) An analysis that masked the radial image reports that $\mathcal{B}$ could lie anywhere in a 25% span. Explain why quoting $|\Delta w_0| = 0.25/|S_{w_0}|$ is not meaningful, using both the degeneracy argument and the dynamic range of $\mathcal{B}$, and state what should be reported instead.

Exercise 24.10.6. (Design.) Would you rather have one DSPL with an exquisitely modelled radial image, or three DSPLs whose radial images are all masked and which are analysed with the same rigid profile and the same γ' prior? Justify your answer with the rank and coherence arguments of this chapter, not with intuition about $\sqrt{N}$.

Exercise 24.10.7. (A second geometry.) Compute $\mathcal{B}$, the Jacobian $(S_{\Omega_\mathrm{m}}, S_{w_0}, S_{w_a})$ and $c_\star$ for $z_d = 0.3$, $z_1 = 0.8$, $z_2 = 3.0$ at $(\Omega_\mathrm{m}, w_0, w_a) = (0.3, -1, 0)$, and compare with the illustrative geometry. What does the comparison tell you about transporting S_w from one system to another?

Chapter 25

First-Order Estimators and Multi-Plane Coherence

Every lens model is wrong in some small way. A power law has no black hole at its centre, no core, no transition from stellar to dark matter; a single-plane model has no line-of-sight structure. When such a model is fitted to real image positions it does not fail loudly. It returns parameters that are *biased*: the fit absorbs the omitted component by moving whatever parameters it has. The usual way to find out by how much is numerical: one simulates data with the extra component, refits, and compares. That answers "how much" for one configuration at a time, but it does not say why, and it cannot tell in advance which images, which parameters or which configurations are the dangerous ones.

This chapter develops the analytic counterpart: a *first-order estimator* that predicts, in closed form, the bias of a least-squares fit when the omitted component is small. The idea is general (any omitted nuisance component, any parametric model) and the recipe fits in one box (§25.1). We work it out in full for one physically important case: a pure power law fitted to a lens that also contains a small central point mass, such as a supermassive black hole (Chapter 19 develops that lens; Chapter 21 catalogues the bias channels it opens). The example shows every feature of the method: a nuisance parameter that must not be fixed, a single image, the radial image, that in a source-plane fit carries almost all the leverage (and in an image-plane fit much less), an exact closed form for a canonical configuration, a sign change, and, once several source planes look through the same deflector, a coherent error that does not average down.

Companion Mathematica files:

- `response_coefficient.wl`, with first-order image positions; weighted normal equations; the closed form of the response coefficient and its limits; brute-force `FindMinimum` fits against the linear estimator (with and without the radial image, source- and image-plane χ^2, fixed and free slope); double-source-plane bias and sign change; N-plane coherence; exports the two figures of this chapter to `Figures/21_Perturbative_Estimators/`
- `problems_21.wl`, the verified solutions to all exercises

25.1 The General Idea: Bias as Linear Response

Suppose a model with parameters $\mathbf{p}$ predicts data $d_j(\mathbf{p})$, and the truth is the model plus a small extra piece,

$$d_j^{\rm true} = d_j(\mathbf{p}_0) + m\, g_j, \tag{25.1}$$

where $m \ll 1$ is a dimensionless amplitude and g_j is the *shape* of the omitted component evaluated at datum j. A fit minimises $\chi^2(\mathbf{p}) = \sum_j w_j \,[d_j^{\rm true} - d_j(\mathbf{p})]^2$ with weights w_j. Expanding the model about the truth, $d_j(\mathbf{p}_0+\delta\mathbf{p}) \simeq d_j(\mathbf{p}_0)+\sum_k X_{jk}\,\delta p_k$ with $X_{jk} = \partial d_j/\partial p_k$, the residuals become $m\,g_j - \sum_k X_{jk}\delta p_k$: a linear least-squares problem in $\delta\mathbf{p}$. Its solution is

$$\boxed{\delta\mathbf{p} \;=\; m\left(X^{\mathsf T}WX\right)^{-1}X^{\mathsf T}W\,\mathbf{g} \;+\; \mathcal{O}\!\left(m^2\right), \qquad W = \mathrm{diag}(w_j).} \tag{25.2}$$

Equation (25.2) is the estimator. The bias is linear in the amplitude m, and its coefficient is the regression of the omitted shape $\mathbf{g}$ onto the columns of X, the directions in which the model is free to move. Three consequences are immediate. If $\mathbf{g}$ lies in the span of the columns of X, the model absorbs the omitted component exactly: the fit is perfect, the component is invisible, and yet the parameters are biased. If $\mathbf{g}$ is orthogonal (in the metric W) to every column, the parameters are unbiased and the component shows up only in the residuals. Everything in between is decided by the *data geometry*, that is, by which data exist, where they sit, and how they are weighted; this is why the same omitted mass produces very different biases in lenses with different image configurations.

The first-order recipe

1. Write the truth as model plus small component, with an explicit amplitude m and shape g_j.
2. Linearise the residuals at the observed data in all small quantities: m and the parameter shifts δp_k.
3. Include every unobservable nuisance parameter (source position, overall offsets) as a free column of X. Fixing a nuisance that the data do not determine changes the answer.
4. Solve the normal equations, Eq. (25.2). The bias is m times a response coefficient that depends only on the data geometry and the weights.

25.2 Worked Example: A Power Law with a Hidden Central Mass

25.2.1 The lens

Take an axisymmetric lens and work along the line through the lens centre and the source, so that image and source positions are signed one-dimensional angles θ and y. The true

deflection is a power law plus a central point mass,

$$\alpha(\theta) \;=\; \underbrace{\theta_{\rm E}^{\gamma'-1}\,|\theta|^{2-\gamma'}\,\operatorname{sgn}\theta}_{\alpha_{\rm PL}(\theta)} \;+\; \underbrace{m\,\frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\theta}}_{\text{point mass}}\,, \qquad 1<\gamma'<2, \tag{25.3}$$

where γ' is the slope of the three-dimensional density $\rho\propto r^{-\gamma'}$ and $\theta_{\rm E}$ is the Einstein radius of the power-law component. The first term is the deflection produced by the power-law convergence of Eq. (13.19); the second is the point-mass deflection of Eq. (11.11), with the point mass's own Einstein radius written as $\theta_\bullet^2 = m\,\theta_{\rm E}^2$. The amplitude

$$m \;=\; \frac{\theta_\bullet^2}{\theta_{\rm E}^2} \;=\; \frac{M_\bullet}{M_{\rm PL}(<\theta_{\rm E})} \tag{25.4}$$

is the central mass as a fraction of the power-law mass inside the Einstein radius. The second equality holds because the mass inside any Einstein radius is $\pi\theta_{\rm E}^2 D_{\rm d}^2\Sigma_{\rm cr}$ (Eq. (13.2)), for the power law and for the point mass alike.

The observer, unaware of the point mass, fits a pure power law with the slope held fixed (we free it in §25.5). The free parameters are the Einstein radius and the source position, which is never observed.

25.2.2 Image configuration

For the pure power law ($m=0$) and a source at $0<y$ inside the radial caustic, the lens equation $y=\theta-\alpha_{\rm PL}(\theta)$ has three solutions: an image $\theta_A>\theta_{\rm E}$ on the source side, a counter-image θ_B with $\theta_r<|\theta_B|<\theta_{\rm E}$, and a faint *radial image* θ_C with $|\theta_C|<\theta_r$. The divide between the last two is the radial critical radius, where the radial eigenvalue of the Jacobian,

$$\lambda_r(\theta) \;=\; 1-\frac{{\rm d}\alpha_{\rm PL}}{{\rm d}\theta} \;=\; 1-(2-\gamma')\left|\frac{\theta}{\theta_{\rm E}}\right|^{1-\gamma'} \;=\; 1-\left|\frac{\theta}{\theta_r}\right|^{1-\gamma'}, \qquad \theta_r=(2-\gamma')^{1/(\gamma'-1)}\,\theta_{\rm E}, \tag{25.5}$$

vanishes. Since $1-\gamma'<0$, $\lambda_r<0$ inside θ_r (the radial image has negative radial parity) and $\lambda_r>0$ outside; at the Einstein radius $\lambda_r(\theta_{\rm E})=\gamma'-1$. With $m>0$ a fourth, extremely faint image appears very close to the point mass; it plays no role at first order and is the subject of Chapter 20.

A running example. Throughout we use $\gamma'=1.6$ and a source at $y=0.2\,\theta_{\rm E}$. Then $\theta_r=0.217\,\theta_{\rm E}$ and the three power-law images sit at

$$\theta_A=+1.316\,\theta_{\rm E}, \qquad \theta_B=-0.633\,\theta_{\rm E}, \qquad \theta_C=-0.0237\,\theta_{\rm E},$$

with radial eigenvalues $\lambda_r=0.66$, 0.47 and -2.78.

25.2.3 First-order image positions

Switch on the point mass at fixed source position. Differentiating the lens equation $y=\theta-\alpha_{\rm PL}(\theta)-m\theta_{\rm E}^2/\theta$ implicitly with respect to m at $m=0$ gives

$$\boxed{\delta\theta_j \;=\; m\,\frac{a_j}{\lambda_r(\theta_j)}+\mathcal{O}\big(m^2\big)\,, \qquad a_j\equiv\frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\theta_j}.} \tag{25.6}$$

In the running example the shifts per unit m are 1.15, -3.34 and 15.2 (in units of $\theta_{\rm E}$) for A, B and C, and an exact numerical solve of the perturbed lens equation reproduces them to better than 10^{-4}. The radial image moves by far the most, because the point-mass deflection $a_j \propto 1/\theta_j$ is largest there.

25.3 Residuals and the Least-Squares Fit

25.3.1 The first-order residual

A position-only fit asks whether there is one source position $y_{\rm fit}$ and one Einstein radius $\theta_{\rm E}e^{\epsilon}$ such that the model maps every observed image back to that source. Its residual at image j is $r_j = \theta_j - \alpha_{\rm PL}(\theta_j;\theta_{\rm E}e^{\epsilon}) - y_{\rm fit}$. The true lens maps the same image to the true source, $y = \theta_j - \alpha_{\rm PL}(\theta_j;\theta_{\rm E}) - m a_j$. Subtracting and writing $y_{\rm fit} = y + \delta y$,

$$\boxed{r_j \;=\; m\,a_j \;-\; \epsilon\,b_j \;-\; \delta y, \qquad a_j = \frac{\theta_{\rm E}^2}{\theta_j}, \qquad b_j = \left.\frac{\partial \alpha_{\rm PL}}{\partial \ln \theta_{\rm E}}\right|_{\theta_j} = (\gamma' - 1)\,\alpha_{\rm PL}(\theta_j)} \tag{25.7}$$

to first order in the small quantities $(m, \epsilon, \delta y)$. Here a_j is the shape of the omitted component and b_j is the one direction in which the fit can move its deflection. This is Eq. (25.1) with $\mathbf{g} = \mathbf{a}$ and two columns, $X = [\,\mathbf{b},\ \mathbf{1}\,]$; the column of ones is the source shift.

25.3.2 Which χ^2? Source plane versus image plane

Minimising $\sum_j r_j^2$ is a *source-plane* fit. An *image-plane* fit compares predicted and observed image positions instead. To first order the model's predicted image j is displaced from the observed one by $-r_j/\lambda_r(\theta_j)$ (the same implicit-differentiation argument as for Eq. (25.6)), so an image-plane χ^2 with equal astrometric errors σ is again a sum over the same residuals:

$$\chi^2 \;=\; \sum_j w_j\, r_j^2, \qquad w_j = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{source plane,} \\ \dfrac{1}{\sigma^2 \lambda_r(\theta_j)^2} & \text{image plane.} \end{cases} \tag{25.8}$$

Both are weighted linear regressions; they differ only in the weights. We keep w_j general.

25.3.3 The normal equations and the response coefficient

Setting $\partial\chi^2/\partial\epsilon = \partial\chi^2/\partial\delta y = 0$ gives two linear equations,

$$\sum_j w_j\, b_j\,(m a_j - \epsilon b_j - \delta y) = 0, \qquad \sum_j w_j\,(m a_j - \epsilon b_j - \delta y) = 0, \tag{25.9}$$

whose solution is

$$\boxed{\epsilon = m\,c, \qquad c = \frac{\sum_j w_j\,(a_j - \bar a)(b_j - \bar b)}{\sum_j w_j\,(b_j - \bar b)^2} \equiv \frac{\mathrm{Cov}_w(a,b)}{\mathrm{Var}_w(b)}, \qquad \delta y = m\,(\bar a - c\,\bar b),} \tag{25.10}$$

with weighted means $\bar{a} = \sum_j w_j a_j / \sum_j w_j$ and $\bar{b} = \sum_j w_j b_j / \sum_j w_j$. The response coefficient is the slope of a weighted linear regression of the omitted shape a on the model's direction b with an intercept, and the intercept is the source shift.

Three properties follow directly from Eq. (25.10). First, two images give an exact fit: with two images there are two equations and two unknowns, both residuals can be made zero, and $c = (a_1 - a_2)/(b_1 - b_2)$ for any weights. A source plane with only two images cannot detect the central mass; it can only be biased by it. Second, the source shift absorbs any constant: replacing $a_j \to a_j + \kappa$ shifts $\bar{a}$ by κ and leaves every centred difference, and hence c, unchanged; only δy moves. Third, c is scale free: under $\theta \to \lambda\theta$, $\theta_{\rm E} \to \lambda\theta_{\rm E}$ both a_j and b_j scale by λ, so c depends only on the dimensionless positions $\theta_j/\theta_{\rm E}$. We set $\theta_{\rm E} = 1$ from now on.

The free intercept is not a technicality

The source position is not observed, so δy must be fitted. Dropping it, i.e. regressing a on b through the origin, is equivalent to claiming the source position is known, and gives a different, wrong, c. The invariance of c under $a_j \to a_j + \kappa$ is exactly the statement that a uniform shift of the source is unobservable. In the general recipe this is step 3: every unobservable nuisance parameter is a free column.

25.4 The Radial Image's Leverage

25.4.1 The tangential pair alone measures enclosed mass

Start with only the two bright images, idealised as a symmetric pair at $\theta = \pm 1$. Then $a = (1, -1)$ and $b = (\gamma' - 1)(1, -1)$, so $a = b/(\gamma' - 1)$ exactly: on these two images the point-mass shape is indistinguishable from a rescaling of the Einstein radius, and

$$c_{\rm pair} = \frac{1}{\gamma' - 1}. \tag{25.11}$$

This number has a clean meaning. Solving the lens equation of the total lens for its Einstein radius to first order in m gives

$$\theta_{\rm E}^{\rm tot} = \theta_{\rm E}\Big(1 + \frac{m}{\gamma' - 1}\Big) + \mathcal{O}\big(m^2\big)\,, \tag{25.12}$$

so a fit to a symmetric tangential pair returns the Einstein radius of the total enclosed mass, as it should.

25.4.2 Why the radial image dominates

Now add a radial image at $\theta = \rho$, $0 < \rho < 1$. Its two shapes behave oppositely:

$$a_C = \frac{1}{\rho} \;\to\; \infty, \qquad b_C = (\gamma' - 1)\rho^{2-\gamma'} \;\to\; 0 \qquad (\rho \to 0,\ 1 < \gamma' < 2).$$

Near the centre the point-mass deflection diverges while the power law's response to a change of Einstein radius vanishes. This is where the two shapes are most different, so this is the datum that breaks the degeneracy of the pair and, by the same token, the datum that drags the fitted Einstein radius furthest when the point mass is ignored, provided it carries the same weight as the other images (a source-plane fit). How strongly it pulls in an image-plane fit is a different matter (§25.4.5).

25.4.3 The exact closed form for the canonical triple

For the *canonical triple*, a symmetric pair at ± 1 and a radial image at ρ, the regression can be done exactly. With unit weights, i.e. for the source-plane χ^2 of Eq. (25.8),

$$a = \Big(1,\, -1,\, \frac{1}{\rho}\Big), \qquad b = (\gamma' - 1)\big(1,\, -1,\, \rho^{2-\gamma'}\big), \tag{25.13}$$

and

$$\mathrm{Cov}(a,b) = 2(\gamma'-1)\Big[1 + \tfrac{1}{3}\rho^{1-\gamma'}\Big], \qquad \mathrm{Var}(b) = 2(\gamma'-1)^2\Big[1 + \tfrac{1}{3}\rho^{4-2\gamma'}\Big], \tag{25.14}$$

so that

$$\boxed{c(\rho,\gamma') = \frac{3 + \rho^{1-\gamma'}}{(\gamma'-1)\big(3 + \rho^{4-2\gamma'}\big)}} \tag{25.15}$$

This is exact, not an expansion in ρ: three data and two free parameters leave one residual degree of freedom, and the normal equations close.

Limits. Figure 25.1 shows Eq. (25.15); its limits carry the physics of the source-plane fit. As $\rho \to 1$, $c \to 4/[4(\gamma'-1)] = 1/(\gamma'-1)$, the floor of Eq. (25.11): the "radial" image has merged with a tangential one and the configuration has lost its extra datum, so for the canonical triple the masked and unmasked cases are one function evaluated at the two ends of ρ. As $\rho \to 0$, $\rho^{1-\gamma'} \to \infty$ dominates the numerator while $\rho^{4-2\gamma'} \to 0$ in the denominator, so

$$c \;\simeq\; c_{\mathrm{asym}} \equiv \frac{\rho^{1-\gamma'}}{3(\gamma'-1)} \;\longrightarrow\; \infty. \tag{25.16}$$

In a source-plane fit, therefore, the deeper the radial image, the larger the leverage of an unmodelled central mass. The divergence is a warning, not a prediction: the linear estimate fails well before mc becomes large (§25.9). It is also specific to unit weights: under image-plane weights c tends to the floor instead (§25.4.5). In between, c decreases strictly with ρ for every $1 < \gamma' < 2$, since the numerator of $\mathrm{d}c/\mathrm{d}\rho$ is a sum of three terms with negative coefficients.

25.4.4 How good is the asymptote?

Dividing Eq. (25.15) by Eq. (25.16) gives an exact correction factor (Fig. 25.2),

$$\frac{c}{c_{\mathrm{asym}}} = \frac{1+3u}{1+v/3}, \qquad u \equiv \rho^{\gamma'-1}, \qquad v \equiv \rho^{4-2\gamma'}. \tag{25.17}$$

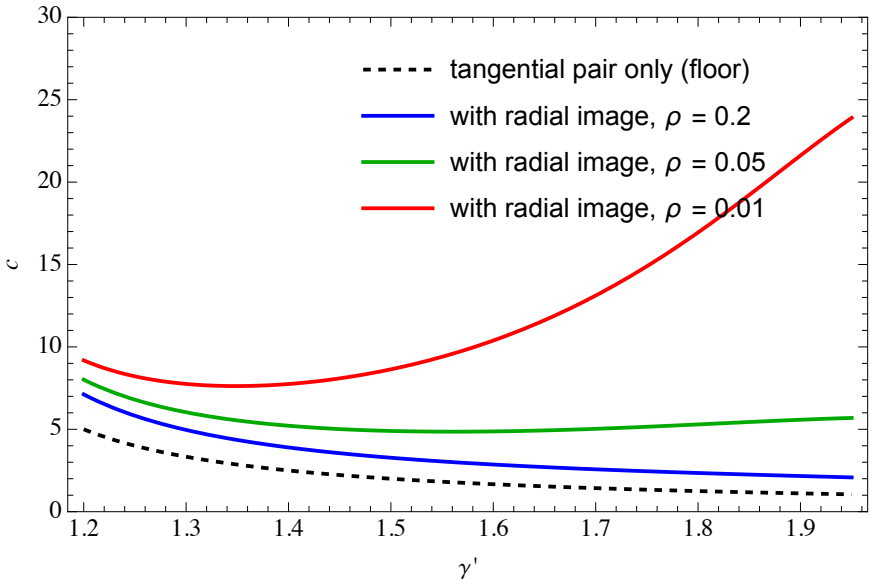


Figure 25.1: Response coefficient c of a fixed-slope, source-plane (unit-weight) power-law fit to a lens with an omitted central point mass, as a function of the density slope γ', for the canonical configuration: tangential pair only (dashed; the floor $1/(\gamma'-1)$ of Eq. (25.11)) and with a radial image at $\rho = 0.2$, 0.05 and 0.01 (Eq. (25.15)). The radial image raises c above the floor, the more so the deeper it sits. This depth dependence is a property of the unit weights; an image-plane fit behaves differently (§25.4.5). From `response_coefficient.wl`.

Here u is the tangential pair's contribution to the covariance and v is the radial image's contribution to the variance, precisely the two terms the $\rho \to 0$ limit discards. Both exponents are positive for $1 < \gamma' < 2$, so both corrections vanish as $\rho \to 0$, but at different rates. Expanding to first order in each,

$$c \simeq \frac{\rho^{1-\gamma'} + 3 - \frac{1}{3}\rho^{5-3\gamma'}}{3(\gamma'-1)}, \tag{25.18}$$

a form that displays the structure; Eq. (25.15) is the form to use.

$\gamma' = 5/3$ is a structural boundary

Which correction in Eq. (25.17) leads is decided by the slope alone: $\gamma' - 1 < 4 - 2\gamma'$ if and only if $\gamma' < 5/3$. Below $\gamma' = 5/3$ the $+3u$ term rules and c approaches the asymptote from above; above 5/3 the $v/3$ term rules at small ρ and c dips below it. The two cross where $\rho^{5-3\gamma'} = 9$, i.e. at

$$\rho_\times = 9^{1/(5-3\gamma')},$$

which lies inside $0 < \rho < 1$ only for $\gamma' > 5/3$ (for example $\rho_\times = 1/243 \approx 4.1 \times 10^{-3}$ at $\gamma' = 1.8$ and 4.3×10^{-2} at $\gamma' = 1.9$). A table of $c/c_{\rm asym}$ that dips slightly below one at steep slopes is therefore not a numerical glitch; it is this crossing.

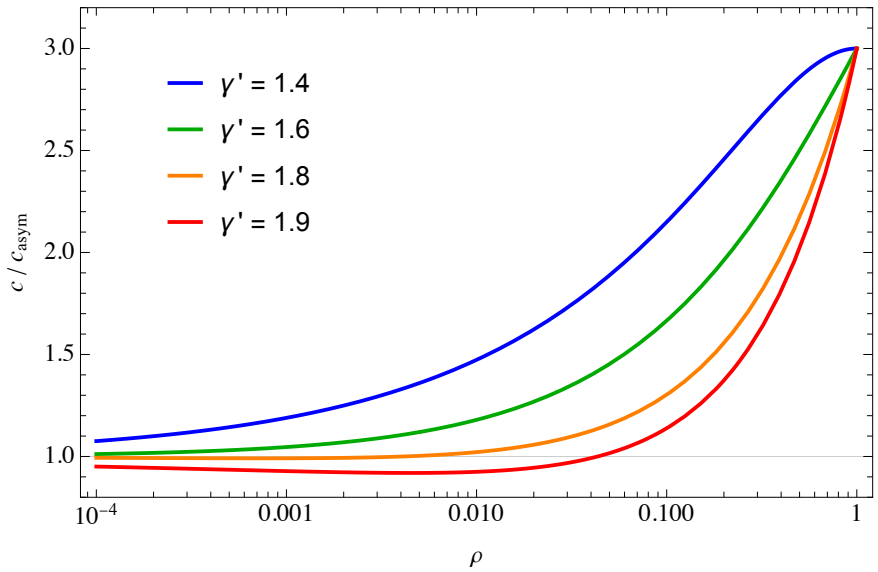


Figure 25.2: The exact correction factor $c/c_{\rm asym}$ of Eq. (25.17) against the radial-image position ρ. For $\gamma' < 5/3$ the asymptote is approached from above and can be badly low at moderate ρ; for $\gamma' > 5/3$ the curve dips below unity before converging. All curves reach 3 at $\rho = 1$, where c has returned to the floor while $c_{\rm asym}$ has not. From `response_coefficient.wl`.

25.4.5 Beyond the canonical triple

Real tangential pairs are not symmetric. In the running example ($\gamma' = 1.6$, $y = 0.2$) the source-plane regression of Eq. (25.10), with $w_j = 1$ on the three images listed in §25.2, gives $c = 10.46$, whereas the canonical formula evaluated at $\rho = |\theta_C| = 0.0237$ gives 6.81: the asymmetric pair raises c by about half. With the radial image masked, the same regression gives $c = 2.00$ rather than the canonical floor $1/(\gamma' - 1) = 1.67$. The closed form is the tool for understanding structure and limits; for a specific lens one evaluates Eq. (25.10) on the actual images.

The estimator itself is confirmed by brute force in `response_coefficient.wl`: generating the images of the power-law-plus-point-mass lens for $m = 10^{-6}$ and fitting a pure power law with `FindMinimum` returns ϵ/m equal to the linear c evaluated on the same perturbed images to better than 10^{-4}, both with and without the radial image. (On those images $c = 10.466$. Evaluating a_j and b_j on the perturbed rather than the unperturbed images changes c only at $\mathcal{O}(m)$, here by a relative 4×10^{-4} at $m = 10^{-6}$, large because the radial image is so sensitive; see §25.9.)

The weights matter. An image-plane fit of the same three images, Eq. (25.8) with $w_j \propto 1/\lambda_r^2$, gives $c = 2.08$, again confirmed by a brute-force image-plane fit. The radial image is demagnified, $|\lambda_r(\theta_C)| = 2.78 > 1$, so a given source-plane residual corresponds to a small image-plane displacement and the image-plane χ^2 down-weights it. The radial image's leverage is therefore a property of the estimator as well as of the lens: which χ^2 is minimised, and with which astrometric errors, is part of the data geometry in Eq. (25.2).

The weights change the dependence on ρ as well as the value of c. Apply Eq. (25.8)

with equal σ to the canonical triple: the pair has weight $1/(\gamma'-1)^2$, and the radial image has weight $1/\lambda_r(\rho)^2$. Since $|\lambda_r(\rho)|$ grows like $\rho^{1-\gamma'}$, that weight falls like $\rho^{2(\gamma'-1)}$, and the deep radial image is switched off rather than given unlimited leverage. At $\gamma' = 1.6$ the image-plane c does not diverge but tends to the floor $1/(\gamma'-1) = 5/3$ as $\rho \to 0$, and it is not monotonic: 1.70, 1.83, 2.48, 3.72, 4.76 and 4.70 at $\rho = 0.001$, 0.01, 0.05, 0.1, 0.15 and 0.2, where the source-plane values are 36.7, 10.4, 4.87, 3.68, 3.17 and 2.86. The $\rho \to 0$ divergence of Eq. (25.16), Fig. 25.1 and the sign-change example of §25.6.3 are therefore source-plane (unit-weight) results.

25.5 Freeing the Slope: Where the Leverage Goes

So far the slope was fixed. Freeing it adds a third column to X,

$$h_j = \left.\frac{\partial \alpha_{\rm PL}}{\partial \gamma'}\right|_{\theta_j} = \alpha_{\rm PL}(\theta_j)\,\ln\frac{\theta_{\rm E}}{|\theta_j|}, \tag{25.19}$$

which vanishes at $|\theta| = \theta_{\rm E}$: the power-law deflection at the Einstein radius equals $\theta_{\rm E}$ for every slope, so the slope pivots there. On the canonical triple there are now three equations for three unknowns $(\epsilon, \delta\gamma', \delta y)$, and the exact solution is

$$\boxed{\epsilon = \frac{m}{\gamma'-1}, \qquad \delta\gamma' = m\,\frac{\rho^{\gamma'-3}-1}{\ln(1/\rho)} > 0, \qquad \delta y = 0,} \tag{25.20}$$

with all three residuals exactly zero.

Equation (25.20) makes the role of the radial image explicit. For the canonical triple with the slope free, the Einstein radius falls back to the total-mass value of Eq. (25.12), and all of the radial image's information goes into the slope: the fitted profile steepens to mimic the central mass, the fit is perfect, and the central mass is undetectable from these three positions. Without the radial image the free-slope normal matrix is singular (rank 2 for three parameters): two tangential images at the pivot cannot constrain the slope at all, so the radial image is what fixes the slope, and an unmodelled central mass biases the slope through it. For the asymmetric running example the same calculation gives $\delta\gamma'/m = 86.4$ and $\epsilon/m = -3.51$, again confirmed by a three-parameter `FindMinimum` fit: the fit is still exact and the slope still steepens, but the Einstein radius no longer returns to the total-mass value $1/(\gamma'-1) = 1.67$. How this slope bias propagates into other observables is one of the channels of Chapter 21.

25.6 Two Source Planes: Bias of the Distance Ratio

25.6.1 Setup

In a double-source-plane lens (Chapter 18) the same deflector images two sources at different redshifts. Let $d_i = D_{{\rm ds}_i}/D_{s_i}$ be the distance factor of plane i, with plane 1 the nearer source, and

$$\mathcal{B} = \frac{d_1}{d_2} < 1 \tag{25.21}$$

their ratio, the cosmological observable of a double-source-plane lens [13]. We treat each plane as lensed by the main deflector only: any extra deflection of the far source by the nearer source's own mass is assumed to be modelled correctly (Chapter 18 gives the full multi-plane treatment). Because every reduced deflection scales with d_i,

$$\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(i)\,\gamma'-1} \propto d_i, \qquad \theta_{\bullet}^{(i)\,2} \propto d_i \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \mathcal{B} = \eta^{\gamma'-1}, \quad m_2 = m_1 \mathcal{B}^k, \quad k = \frac{3-\gamma'}{\gamma'-1} > 0, \tag{25.22}$$

where $\eta = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(1)}/\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(2)}$.

At fixed γ' the two planes share no fitted parameter (each has its own Einstein radius and its own source position), so the planes decouple: each is a separate regression with its own response coefficient c_i, and $\epsilon_i = m_i c_i$.

25.6.2 The bias

Linearising $\ln \mathcal{B} = (\gamma'-1)\ln\!\left(\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(1)}/\theta_{\mathrm{E}}^{(2)}\right)$ gives $\delta \ln \mathcal{B} = (\gamma'-1)(\epsilon_1 - \epsilon_2)$, and with Eq. (25.22),

$$\boxed{\frac{\Delta\mathcal{B}}{\mathcal{B}} = (\gamma'-1)\, m_1 \left[c_1 - \mathcal{B}^k c_2\right] + \mathcal{O}\!\left(m^2\right).} \tag{25.23}$$

The bias is a difference: it would vanish if both planes responded alike, and it survives because $\mathcal{B}^k < 1$ suppresses plane 2's response. Each c_i depends on where that plane's images sit, so the bias depends on the source positions, above all through the depth of each plane's radial image.

The total-mass shortcut. If both planes are put at the floor, $c_1 = c_2 = 1/(\gamma'-1)$, Eq. (25.23) reduces to

$$\left.\frac{\Delta\mathcal{B}}{\mathcal{B}}\right|_{\text{floor}} = m_1\left(1 - \mathcal{B}^k\right), \tag{25.24}$$

which is the difference between the total-mass Einstein radii of Eq. (25.12) on the two planes. It is a correct answer to a different question, how two definitions of the Einstein radius differ, and contains no image positions, no source marginalisation and no fit. In particular it is positive for every $0 < \mathcal{B} < 1$.

25.6.3 The sign change

Equation (25.23) changes sign where the bracket vanishes:

$$\boxed{\frac{c_2}{c_1} = \mathcal{B}^{-k} > 1.} \tag{25.25}$$

The bias is positive while plane 2 responds less than $\mathcal{B}^{-k}$ times as strongly as plane 1, and negative beyond. In a source-plane fit a deep radial image raises c without bound, so a plane-2 radial image close enough to the centre always flips the sign. For example, with $\gamma' = 1.6$, $\mathcal{B} = 0.8$, plane 1 at its floor and plane 2 a canonical triple, the source-plane bias is negative

for $\rho_2 < 0.212$ and positive above. (A root always exists in $0 < \rho_2 < 1$: the source-plane $c_2(\gamma' - 1)$ runs from 1 at $\rho_2 = 1$ to ∞ as $\rho_2 \to 0$, while $\mathcal{B}^{-k} > 1$.) An image-plane fit of the same configuration reverses the pattern: since its c_2 returns to the floor as $\rho_2 \to 0$ (§25.4.5), the bias is positive for a very deep radial image and negative only for $0.065 < \rho_2 < \theta_r$. The shortcut Eq. (25.24) has a fixed sign and cannot reproduce either pattern. The sign of the cosmological bias is set by the image geometry together with the choice of χ^2.

25.7 Multi-Plane Coherence

With N source planes, form the ratios $\mathcal{B}_i = d_1/d_i$ against the nearest plane ($i = 2, \ldots, N$). The derivation is unchanged, so the response of each ratio to the central mass is

$$\boxed{r_i \equiv \frac{\partial \ln \mathcal{B}_i}{\partial m_1} = (\gamma' - 1)\big[c_1 - \mathcal{B}_i^k c_i\big].} \tag{25.26}$$

Three structural facts follow (checked symbolically for $N = 5$ planes). First, every r_i contains the same c_1, with the same coefficient $\gamma' - 1$. All ratios share the reference plane and look through one deflector, so their errors share a cause: the r_i form a deterministic family, not independent draws. Second, there is a common non-zero limit: as $\mathcal{B}_i^k \to 0$, $r_i \to (\gamma' - 1)c_1$ whatever c_i is. In that limit plane i sees a negligible central-mass fraction ($m_i = m_1\mathcal{B}_i^k \to 0$) and acts as a clean reference against which plane 1's contamination is measured in full; the response tends to a constant, never to zero. Third, there is no cancellation: for equal $c_i = c > 0$, $r_i = (\gamma' - 1)c\,(1 - \mathcal{B}_i^k)$ lies strictly between 0 and $(\gamma' - 1)c$ and grows monotonically as $\mathcal{B}_i$ decreases, so all ratios are biased in the same direction.

25.8 The Consequence: Significance, Not Amplitude

Whether the bias stacks across planes is best asked not of the raw size of the bias but of its size in units of the statistical error,

$$\mathcal{S} = \frac{|\text{systematic shift of a parameter}|}{\text{statistical error of that parameter}}, \tag{25.27}$$

because that is what decides whether a published result is wrong. Two generic facts about linear least squares settle how $\mathcal{S}$ scales.

First, the bias does not know the noise level. For data with covariance $C = \sigma^2 I$ and Jacobian J, the bias of a linear fit to a data shift $\boldsymbol{\delta}$ is $(J^\mathsf{T} C^{-1} J)^{-1} J^\mathsf{T} C^{-1} \boldsymbol{\delta}$, in which σ^2 cancels, while the parameter covariance $(J^\mathsf{T} C^{-1} J)^{-1}$ scales as σ^2. Better data shrink the error bar but not the bias, so $\mathcal{S} \propto 1/\sigma$.

Second, coherent biases do not average down. In the simplest toy (N ratios with equal sensitivity to one parameter, each shifted by the same mr) the averaged parameter carries the full bias mr while its error falls as $\sigma/\sqrt{N}$, so $\mathcal{S}_N = \sqrt{N}\,\mathcal{S}_1$. Had the shifts random signs, the root-mean-square bias would fall as $1/\sqrt{N}$ along with the error and $\mathcal{S}$ would not grow. Equation (25.26) says the central-mass bias is of the first, coherent, kind.

The design consequence

A compound lens with more source planes is more exposed to a coherent modelling systematic, not less. Extra planes buy statistical precision, which the systematic does not share. Intuition of the form "N planes, so errors average down like $\sqrt{N}$" presumes independent draws, and here there is one physical cause; when the planes' response coefficients are comparable it also pushes every ratio the same way (unequal c_i can give opposite signs, §25.6.3). The only lever that lowers $\mathcal{S}$ is the modelling one: giving the deflector's inner profile the freedom to represent the central mass, or measuring the radial image well enough to constrain it. How per-ratio biases map into cosmological parameters through a full Fisher matrix is the subject of Chapter 24.

25.9 When the Linear Estimate Fails

Equation (25.2) is a first-order expansion. It fails, and the numerics must be used, in the following situations.

1. The fitted shift is not small. The step $e^{(\gamma'-1)\epsilon} \simeq 1 + (\gamma'-1)\epsilon$ requires $|\epsilon| = m|c| \ll 1$. That is necessary but not sufficient. The image positions of Eq. (25.6) were also linearised, which requires each image to move by a small fraction of its distance from the centre, $|m a_j/(\lambda_r(\theta_j)\,\theta_j)| \ll 1$. For a deep radial image this is the stricter condition: in the running example it reads $640\,m \ll 1$, against $mc \simeq 10\,m$. The brute-force ϵ/m there departs from c by 0.4% at $m = 10^{-5}$ and by 4.5% at $m = 10^{-4}$, and by $m = 10^{-3}$ the radial image has disappeared altogether (item 3). In a source-plane fit c also grows as $\rho^{1-\gamma'}$, so a deep radial image breaks the expansion at a smaller m on both counts.

2. An image is near a critical curve. The image shift $m a_j/\lambda_r(\theta_j)$ of Eq. (25.6) diverges as $\lambda_r \to 0$, i.e. as the source approaches the radial caustic.

3. The image count changes. A finite central mass can make the radial image merge with the extra central image and disappear. That is a change of topology, not a small perturbation, and no linear theory captures it (Chapters 20 and 21).

A fourth limitation is not a failure of linearity but of scope: the closed form Eq. (25.15) applies only to the symmetric triple, and for any other configuration Eq. (25.10) must be evaluated on the actual images (§25.4.5).

Inside its domain, the error of the linear estimate is second order. In the running example, the departure of the brute-force ϵ/m from c doubles (to within 1%) when m is doubled from 10^{-5} to 2×10^{-5}, as an $\mathcal{O}(m^2)$ error in ϵ must.

25.10 Summary

To first order, the bias of a least-squares fit caused by a small omitted component of amplitude m and shape $\mathbf{g}$ is $\delta\mathbf{p} = m\,(X^{\mathsf{T}}WX)^{-1}X^{\mathsf{T}}W\mathbf{g}$, the regression of the omitted shape on the model's free directions, Eq. (25.2). Every unobservable nuisance parameter (here the

source position) must be a free column; it enters as an intercept, and fixing it changes the answer. For a fixed-slope power law fitted to a lens with a central point mass, $\epsilon = mc$ with $c = \mathrm{Cov}_w(a, b)/\mathrm{Var}_w(b)$, $a = \theta_{\mathrm{E}}^2/\theta$, $b = (\gamma' - 1)\alpha_{\mathrm{PL}}$ (Eq. (25.10)), and the weights distinguish source-plane from image-plane fits.

A symmetric tangential pair alone gives $c = 1/(\gamma' - 1)$: it measures the total enclosed mass. The radial image, where the point-mass and power-law shapes differ most, supplies the leverage in a source-plane fit. For the canonical triple with unit (source-plane) weights $c = (3 + \rho^{1-\gamma'})/[(\gamma' - 1)(3 + \rho^{4-2\gamma'})]$ exactly, with asymptote $\rho^{1-\gamma'}/[3(\gamma' - 1)]$, a crossing at $\rho_\times = 9^{1/(5-3\gamma')}$ for $\gamma' > 5/3$, and the floor at $\rho = 1$. Under image-plane weights the deep radial image is down-weighted and c returns to the floor as $\rho \to 0$. With the slope free, the radial image's leverage goes into the slope: the fit steepens and absorbs the central mass exactly, and for the canonical triple the Einstein radius returns to its total-mass value.

For two source planes, $\Delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B} = (\gamma' - 1)m_1[c_1 - \mathcal{B}^k c_2]$ with $k = (3 - \gamma')/(\gamma' - 1)$, which changes sign at $c_2/c_1 = \mathcal{B}^{-k}$; the total-mass shortcut $m_1(1 - \mathcal{B}^k)$ cannot. Where the sign changes depends on the weights: in a source-plane fit a deep enough plane-2 radial image always makes the bias negative, in an image-plane fit it does not. For N planes all responses share the plane-1 term and tend to $(\gamma' - 1)c_1$: the error is coherent, so adding planes makes the systematic more significant. The estimate fails when mc is not small, when a deep radial image's fractional shift $ma_j/(\lambda_r\theta_j)$ is not small (about 640 m in the running example), near critical curves, and when images are created or destroyed.

25.11 Problems

Exercise 25.11.1. (Two images.) Derive $c = (a_1 - a_2)/(b_1 - b_2)$ directly by solving $r_1 = r_2 = 0$, with r_j from Eq. (25.7), and explain why the residual is exactly zero for two images but not, in general, for three. What does a non-zero three-image residual tell you about the lens?

Exercise 25.11.2. (Why the intercept matters.) Show that replacing $a_j \to a_j + \kappa$ for a constant κ leaves the weighted c of Eq. (25.10) unchanged, and find how δy changes. State the physical content of this invariance, and show with the canonical triple that fixing $\delta y = 0$ changes c.

Exercise 25.11.3. (The radial image's leverage.) Consider the canonical triple of Eq. (25.13) with unit (source-plane) weights.

(a) Show that the radial image dominates $\mathrm{Cov}(a, b)$ as $\rho \to 0$ while $\mathrm{Var}(b) \to 2(\gamma' - 1)^2$, and deduce $c \simeq \rho^{1-\gamma'}/[3(\gamma' - 1)]$.

(b) Evaluate $\mathrm{Cov}(a, b)$ and $\mathrm{Var}(b)$ *without* expanding and obtain Eq. (25.15).

(c) In the correction factor $(1+3u)/(1+v/3)$, identify which term belongs to the tangential pair and which to the radial image, and show that they exchange dominance at $\gamma' = 5/3$.

(d) Check that $\rho \to 1$ returns the two-image floor.

(e) For $\rho = 0.03$, $\gamma' = 1.4$, evaluate c from the asymptote, from the one-term form Eq. (25.18), and from Eq. (25.15). Which would you carry into a systematic error budget?

Exercise 25.11.4. (Sign change.) Using Eq. (25.23), find the condition on c_2/c_1 at which $\Delta\mathcal{B}/\mathcal{B}$ changes sign, show that the threshold always exceeds one, and explain why the total-mass shortcut Eq. (25.24) can never reproduce it.

Exercise 25.11.5. (Coherence limit.) Verify that $r_i \to (\gamma' - 1)c_1$ as $\mathcal{B}_i \to 0$ in Eq. (25.26), and interpret the limit physically: what is the distant-plane limit *measuring*? Show that $\mathcal{B}_i > d_1$ for every plane and say what this implies for how closely the limit can be approached.

Exercise 25.11.6. (Design.) A survey can either add a fourth source plane to an existing three-plane lens or halve the per-ratio statistical error on the existing three. Using §25.8 and its equal-sensitivity toy model, argue which does more for the *accuracy* (as opposed to the precision) of a cosmological parameter, and identify the only effective lever.

Exercise 25.11.7. (A different omitted component.) Apply the recipe of §25.1 to an omitted uniform mass sheet of convergence κ instead of a point mass, still fitting a fixed-slope power law with free source position.

(a) Show that the omitted shape is $a_j = \theta_j$ (with $\theta_{\rm E} = 1$), so that the residual keeps the form of Eq. (25.7) with $m \to \kappa$.

(b) For the canonical triple, show that $c_{\rm sheet} = (3 + \rho^{3-\gamma'})/[(\gamma' - 1)(3 + \rho^{4-2\gamma'})]$.

(c) Show that $c_{\rm sheet} \to 1/(\gamma' - 1)$ both as $\rho \to 0$ and for the tangential pair alone, and that this equals the first-order shift of the total-mass Einstein radius. Compare $c_{\rm sheet}$ with the point-mass c at $\rho = 0.05$, $\gamma' = 1.6$, and explain why the radial image, so powerful against a point mass, gives almost no leverage against a sheet.

References

[1] James M. Bardeen, William H. Press, and Saul A. Teukolsky. Rotating black holes: Locally nonrotating frames, energy extraction, and scalar synchrotron radiation. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 178:347, 1972. doi: 10.1086/151796.

[2] Matthias Bartelmann. Cluster mass estimates from weak lensing. *Astronomy and Astrophysics*, 303:643, 1995. ADS 1995A&A...303..643B.

[3] Matthias Bartelmann. Arcs from a universal dark-matter halo profile. *Astronomy & Astrophysics*, 313:697–702, 1996.

[4] Matthias Bartelmann and Peter Schneider. Weak gravitational lensing. *Physics Reports*, 340(4-5):291–472, 2001. doi: 10.1016/S0370-1573(00)00082-X.

[5] B. Bertotti, L. Iess, and P. Tortora. A test of general relativity using radio links with the Cassini spacecraft. *Nature*, 425(6956):374–376, 2003. doi: 10.1038/nature01997.

[6] S. Birrer, A. J. Shajib, A. Galan, M. Millon, T. Treu, A. Agnello, M. Auger, G. C.-F. Chen, L. Christensen, T. Collett, F. Courbin, C. D. Fassnacht, L. V. E. Koopmans, P. J. Marshall, J.-W. Park, C. E. Rusu, D. Sluse, C. Spiniello, S. H. Suyu, S. Wagner-Carena, K. C. Wong, M. Barnabè, A. S. Bolton, O. Czoske, X. Ding, J. A. Frieman, and L. Van de Vyvere. TDCOSMO. IV. hierarchical time-delay cosmography – joint inference of the Hubble constant and galaxy density profiles. *Astronomy & Astrophysics*, 643:A165, 2020. doi: 10.1051/0004-6361/202038861.

[7] R. D. Blandford, A. B. Saust, T. G. Brainerd, and J. V. Villumsen. The distortion of distant galaxy images by large-scale structure. *Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society*, 251(4):600–627, 1991. doi: 10.1093/mnras/251.4.600.

[8] Roger Blandford and Ramesh Narayan. Fermat's principle, caustics, and the classification of gravitational lens images. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 310:568, 1986. doi: 10.1086/164709.

[9] Tereasa G. Brainerd, Roger D. Blandford, and Ian Smail. Weak gravitational lensing by galaxies. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 466:623, 1996. doi: 10.1086/177537.

[10] W. L. Burke. Multiple gravitational imaging by distributed masses. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 244:L1, 1981. doi: 10.1086/183466.

[11] Sean M. Carroll. *Spacetime and Geometry: An Introduction to General Relativity*. Addison Wesley, San Francisco, 2004. ISBN 978-0-8053-8732-2. Reissued by Cambridge University Press (2019).

[12] Michel Chevallier and David Polarski. Accelerating universes with scaling dark matter. *International Journal of Modern Physics D*, 10(02):213–223, 2001. doi: 10.1142/S0218271801000822.

[13] T. E. Collett, M. W. Auger, V. Belokurov, P. J. Marshall, and A. C. Hall. Constraining the dark energy equation of state with double-source plane strong lenses. *Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society*, 424(4):2864–2875, 2012. doi: 10.1111/j.1365-2966.2012.21424.x.

[14] Thomas E. Collett. The population of galaxy–galaxy strong lenses in forthcoming optical imaging surveys. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 811(1):20, 2015. doi: 10.1088/0004-637X/811/1/20.

[15] Thomas E. Collett and Matthew W. Auger. Cosmological constraints from the double source plane lens SDSSJ0946+1006. *Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society*, 443(2):969–976, 2014. doi: 10.1093/mnras/stu1190.

[16] Arthur B. Congdon and Charles R. Keeton. *Principles of Gravitational Lensing: Light Deflection as a Probe of Astrophysics and Cosmology*. Springer International Publishing, Cham, 2018. ISBN 978-3-030-02121-4. doi: 10.1007/978-3-030-02122-1.

[17] Albert Einstein. Lens-like action of a star by the deviation of light in the gravitational field. *Science*, 84(2188):506–507, 1936. doi: 10.1126/science.84.2188.506.

[18] E. E. Falco, M. V. Gorenstein, and I. I. Shapiro. On model-dependent bounds on H(0) from gravitational images: Application of Q0957+561A,B. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 289:L1, 1985. doi: 10.1086/184422.

[19] James E. Gunn. On the propagation of light in inhomogeneous cosmologies. I. mean effects. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 150:737, 1967. doi: 10.1086/149378.

[20] Nick Kaiser and Gordon Squires. Mapping the dark matter with weak gravitational lensing. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 404:441, 1993. doi: 10.1086/172297.

[21] Charles R. Keeton. A catalog of mass models for gravitational lensing. arXiv:astro-ph/0102341, 2001.

[22] Charles R. Keeton. Lensing and the centers of distant early-type galaxies. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 582(1):17–29, 2003. doi: 10.1086/344539.

[23] C. S. Kochanek. Overconstrained gravitational lens models and the Hubble constant. *Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society*, 493(2):1725–1735, 2020. doi: 10.1093/mnras/staa344.

[24] R. Kormann, P. Schneider, and M. Bartelmann. Isothermal elliptical gravitational lens models. *Astronomy and Astrophysics*, 284:285–299, 1994. ADS bibcode 1994A&A...284..285K.

[25] John Kormendy and Luis C. Ho. Coevolution (or not) of supermassive black holes and host galaxies. *Annual Review of Astronomy and Astrophysics*, 51(1):511–653, 2013. doi: 10.1146/annurev-astro-082708-101811.

[26] Eric V. Linder. Exploring the expansion history of the universe. *Physical Review Letters*, 90(9):091301, 2003. doi: 10.1103/PhysRevLett.90.091301.

[27] S. Mao, H. J. Witt, and L. V. E. Koopmans. The influence of central black holes on gravitational lenses. *Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society*, 323(2):301–307, 2001. doi: 10.1046/j.1365-8711.2001.04143.x.

[28] Shude Mao and Bohdan Paczynski. Gravitational microlensing by double stars and planetary systems. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 374:L37, 1991. doi: 10.1086/186066.

[29] Massimo Meneghetti. *Introduction to Gravitational Lensing: With Python Examples*, volume 956 of *Lecture Notes in Physics*. Springer International Publishing, Cham, 2021. ISBN 978-3-030-73581-4. doi: 10.1007/978-3-030-73582-1.

[30] Ramesh Narayan and Matthias Bartelmann. Lectures on gravitational lensing, 1997. arXiv:astro-ph/9606001.

[31] J. W. Nightingale, Russell J. Smith, Qiuhan He, Conor M. O'Riordan, Jacob A. Kegerreis, Aristeidis Amvrosiadis, Alastair C. Edge, Amy Etherington, Richard G. Hayes, Ash Kelly, John R. Lucey, and Richard J. Massey. Abell 1201: detection of an ultramassive black hole in a strong gravitational lens. *Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society*, 521(3):3298–3322, 2023. doi: 10.1093/mnras/stad587.

[32] Conor M. O'Riordan and Simona Vegetti. Angular complexity in strong lens substructure detection. *Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society*, 528(2):1757–1768, 2024. doi: 10.1093/mnras/stae153.

[33] Bohdan Paczynski. Gravitational microlensing by the galactic halo. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 304:1, 1986. doi: 10.1086/164140.

[34] Bohdan Paczynski. Gravitational microlensing with the space interferometry mission. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 494(1):L23, 1998. doi: 10.1086/311153.

[35] Arlie O. Petters, Harold Levine, and Joachim Wambsganss. *Singularity Theory and Gravitational Lensing*, volume 21 of *Progress in Mathematical Physics*. Birkhäuser, Boston, 2001. ISBN 978-0-8176-3668-5.

[36] Prasenjit Saha, Dominique Sluse, Jenny Wagner, and Liliya L. R. Williams. Essentials of strong gravitational lensing. *Space Science Reviews*, 220(1):12, 2024. doi: 10.1007/s11214-024-01041-w.

[37] P. Schneider and A. Weiss. The two-point-mass lens: Detailed investigation of a special asymmetric gravitational lens. *Astronomy and Astrophysics*, 164:237, 1986. ADS 1986A&A...164..237S.

[38] Peter Schneider. Can one determine cosmological parameters from multi-plane strong lens systems? *Astronomy & Astrophysics*, 568:L2, 2014. doi: 10.1051/0004-6361/201424450.

[39] Peter Schneider. Generalized multi-plane gravitational lensing: time delays, recursive lens equation, and the mass-sheet transformation. *Astronomy & Astrophysics*, 624:A54, 2019. doi: 10.1051/0004-6361/201424881.

[40] Peter Schneider and Dominique Sluse. Mass-sheet degeneracy, power-law models and external convergence: Impact on the determination of the Hubble constant from gravitational lensing. *Astronomy & Astrophysics*, 559:A37, 2013. doi: 10.1051/0004-6361/201321882.

[41] Peter Schneider and Dominique Sluse. Source-position transformation: an approximate invariance in strong gravitational lensing. *Astronomy & Astrophysics*, 564:A103, 2014. doi: 10.1051/0004-6361/201322106.

[42] Peter Schneider, Jürgen Ehlers, and Emilio E. Falco. *Gravitational Lenses*. Astronomy and Astrophysics Library. Springer-Verlag, Berlin, 1992. ISBN 978-0-387-97070-7. doi: 10.1007/978-3-662-03758-4.

[43] Peter Schneider, Christopher S. Kochanek, and Joachim Wambsganss. *Gravitational Lensing: Strong, Weak and Micro*. Saas-Fee Advanced Course 33. Swiss Society for Astronomy and Astrophysics. Springer, Berlin, Heidelberg, 2006. ISBN 978-3-540-30309-1. G. Meylan, P. Jetzer & P. North (eds.).

[44] Irwin I. Shapiro. Fourth test of general relativity. *Physical Review Letters*, 13(26): 789–791, 1964. doi: 10.1103/PhysRevLett.13.789.

[45] Irwin I. Shapiro, Gordon H. Pettengill, Michael E. Ash, Melvin L. Stone, William B. Smith, Richard P. Ingalls, and Richard A. Brockelman. Fourth test of general relativity: Preliminary results. *Physical Review Letters*, 20(22):1265–1269, 1968. doi: 10.1103/PhysRevLett.20.1265.

[46] H. R. Stacey, D. M. Powell, S. Vegetti, J. P. McKean, C. D. Fassnacht, D. Wen, and C. M. O'Riordan. Complex angular structure of three elliptical galaxies from high-resolution ALMA observations of strong gravitational lenses. *Astronomy & Astrophysics*, 688:A110, 2024. doi: 10.1051/0004-6361/202449710.

[47] Edwin L. Turner, Jeremiah P. Ostriker, and J. Richard Gott, III. The statistics of gravitational lenses: the distributions of image angular separations and lens redshifts. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 284:1, 1984. doi: 10.1086/162379.

[48] Brian Welch, Dan Coe, Jose M. Diego, et al. A highly magnified star at redshift 6.2. *Nature*, 603(7903):815–818, 2022. doi: 10.1038/s41586-022-04449-y.

[49] Clifford M. Will. The confrontation between general relativity and experiment. *Living Reviews in Relativity*, 17(1):4, 2014. doi: 10.12942/lrr-2014-4.

[50] Kenneth C. Wong, Sherry H. Suyu, Geoff C.-F. Chen, Cristian E. Rusu, Martin Millon, Dominique Sluse, Vivien Bonvin, Christopher D. Fassnacht, Stefan Taubenberger, Matthew W. Auger, Simon Birrer, et al. H0LiCOW. XIII. a 2.4 per cent measurement of H_0 from lensed quasars: 5.3σ tension between early- and late-universe probes. *Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society*, 498(1):1420–1439, 2020. doi: 10.1093/mnras/stz3094.

[51] Candace Oaxaca Wright and Tereasa G. Brainerd. Gravitational lensing by NFW halos. *The Astrophysical Journal*, 534(1):34–40, 2000. doi: 10.1086/308744.